Blake (Chapter 76)

Friday, January 16, 2026 19:59

There is only one thing I want to do. Find David, and then kick the shit out of him. What kind of a shadow strategist is he, not telling me about any of the stuff he was up to. As I fly in the cold sky towards Dr. Drews house, I began thinking of slurs I was sure to say to him. Once we got the message I told others to put a lid on it before I get confirmation. Nathan was the only who seem to enjoy the situation. I had to make sure he wouldn't tell anyone. He just laughed and said there is no point. There is no evidence and besides that, there no reason to betray David. He was right about that. He was allowed on the island based on various conditions.

Tessa remained neutral, saying even if David was the behind this incident, its not a problem. Though she wants to know why David remained anonymous. On the other hand, Vanessa didn't agree with anything. She was already mad at David and didn't promise that she would be quiet about him. I was concerned about her the most. Even if its not personal, which she claims its not, I know she can't hide this from her crew without good reason. And I did agree with her.

And that’s why I am approaching to Dr. Drews place. I assumed he would meet her there since its easier to go to her rather than bringing her to him. I spot her house and descend down to the field. I caught some aura's nearby and land there. As I came closer I realized Drew and two another person were already outside, standing at a corner in field. She was with Marina and Catherine. Damn, Catherine also figured it out then. I scoff thinking they also couldn't stay away from this huh. They saw me coming down and pause their discussion.

As my feet land on the field, Marina asks, you came. I thought things were very crazy at work. I shook my head, you have no idea. All of them had changed to their casual dress, save me. I was so busy after the meetings, I didn't get time to go change into the spare clothes in my office. I walk to Drew, sorry to intrude on this. I wasn't expecting people to be here. Marina says, come on. You think I would stay away from this. Catherine agreed with her, David had been unreasonable to me, but doesn't mean I have to be too.

If Catherine is also here, then she must have explained how she found about Drew. He look at her with my intense gaze. She shot a look back of zero qualms about intruding like this. She asks, what. I say, I asked you to leave alone David yesterday. But what did you do instead, you not only stalked Drew but spied on her. I don't know if I can let that slide. I didn't get time to talk to her the entire day. So I wanted an answer from her now. Now she felt a little cornered.

Drew defends her, its fine Blake. She already apologized. I wasn't happy about it, buts there no harm done. I can't believe she wasn't bothered by this. But I wasn't letting it go this easily. It possible I was still agitated a little after my little tussle with Peter. I say, even if Drew is fine with it, I am not Catherine. I can tell she wasn't proud of her actions. She must have understood that it wasn't just about tailing Drew. She rarely does things so impulsive, so it might be also why I couldn't let it go.

She says with a apologetic expression, I couldn't help it Blake. You know how he is. Unless I force things out of him, he won't tell me. I can imagine that, but you could have waited. You being late this morning isn't a big deal. But I can't have friends going rouge on critical times. There are so many things me and Marina wanted to know. But do you see us hounding him. You need to be patient. I might be taking it more personal than I thought. Marina steps to me, whoa, Blake. Look, she said she was sorry. It was a just a small judgment miss. No need to make this bigger than it actually is.

I was ready to rebuke her too. But then I stop myself, because she was right. I was making it way too out of proportion. Turns out I was talking my anger about the whole ordeal on her. I sigh thinking how rude I might have been to her. But Catherine didn't see it that way. She says, you don't need to cover for me Marina. She turns to me, I know what I did was impulsive. I just wanted answers from David. We had been in an argument lately, so I couldn't take it anymore when you told about his condition.

She then becomes a bit somber, if it makes you feel any better. I am regretting it now. David told me things I shouldn't have known. She said something like this earlier. I calmed my nerves before asking, what do you mean by that. She turns to Drew, you know about it too. Don't you. As his therapist, she knew things about him the most. But she wasn't going to indulge in revealing anything. She says, like I told you earlier, it’s a privileged. She was a very good at being impartial, her aura remained consistent. I can't tell if she knew about it or not.

Marina asks curious, he told you things. What things. Catherine faces her, stuff about me in Medrine. That surprised both of us. David said he never met most of us. I ask, he met you back when you were kids. How. I am very certain David didn't have many friends outside Shadows. Catherine shook her head, not me. I meant my family. Now I get what she meant. Marina ask, you didn't like what he said about your family. He didn't like, trash talk about them. Did he? Because he did mine few times. I mean, he isn't completely wrong, but. She stops her herself before going on a monologue, forget that. What did he say to you.

Catherine seemed reluctant to share that. I say, lets not force her, Marina. I apologies Catherine. I wasn't accusing of anything. Its been a long day for me, and with the recent mess, I wasn't thinking clearly. I sigh a little, I know we are all adjusting the new life here now. I wasn't even sure until now if Drew would make a complaint against you, if she ever found about you spying. Catherine nods at me, you aren't wrong. I was also afraid of that, so I came here to explain my myself. She looks at a stoic Drew, who turns out she is a very understanding person. She probably knows what David told me and what other things he didn't.

Drew didn't even flinch for a second, not giving even a small change in aura. Damn, she is really good. She says, I don't know what he said to you. That’s between you two. I just hope you both can work things out. Marina says, hey, wait. Does that mean he has revealed everything to you. She got a little anxious for a moment. I realized what she was going on about. We both assumed Drew knows David's shadow past, but we aren't certain of it. Not surprising, Drew's poker expression didn't change. She locks gazes between me and Marina. After thinking for a while she says, don't worry. I am not going to share his past or his secrets to anyone. And even if I wanted, David has put counter measures.

Marina looks at me a tense expression. We both knew at that moment that she knows. She could have said nothing, but she reassured us not to worry. I can't believe David, so overly cautious, would entrust her with so many secrets. Catherine asks, is it something bad. Should I be worried too. I clear my thought, its nothing. No, not nothing. You don't need to worry about it. Just that Marina and I can't believe you got David to open up. Drew finally shows an expression of a light chuckle, therapy can't work without honesty and transparency. He is smart enough to know this is the only true and efficient way to mitigate his symptoms. I just didn't realize that would involve you high profile people.

Marina says, we are just worried about him. She says, I understand Marina. Like I told earlier, David already warned me about people founding about our arrangement. I would have preferred it remain hidden, but I can't deny its good that he opening up at least to some people. Bottling it up inside is not healthy, no matter how good you are, it takes a toll. Quite a change in perspective, considering she refused to hear Marina yesterday. She turns to me, I wasn't expecting you though. I heard some sort of fight broke out involving some warriors. My whole family was on edge when we saw the news. Aren't you busy with that.

Since the topic shits to that, Marina asks, I heard Citradel people were involved. I don't know what to say here. David basically broadcasted his message to us after hiding his involvement in this matter. Its a little confusing what his intent is. What I know is that I can't tell to Marina or Catherine in front of Drew. Drew caught me staring at her for a moment. That was enough for her to make her realize my intension, you don't want to say in front of me. I got it, its not my business.

She was quick to understand my dilemma. Marina looks at Catherine who shrugs. I reply, thanks for understanding. Its just too early to tell. We need time. The investigation just started, and there are things we can't share until all the facts are known. Drew nods, I completely understand. Once I confirm David's condition, you guys are free to discuss. Catherin says to me, how sure are you of David condition improving. Isn't it a little too much to have him resolve his issues in a day ?

Marina become a little forlorn about it, he was very depressed in the morning. She turns to Drew, that interview he gave was a performance. Drew takes that information like she was reading us. She nods, I figured that was the case. A form of self defense mechanism. Personally, I am ninety nine percent sure he won't overcome it in a day. I haven't talked to Drew much, but I come to understand she is good at her job. Her low expectation was considering that she could judge him the best.

Other two became very nervous hearing such a claim from the said person's therapist. But I knew more than them in this matter. I scoff, don't worry guys. I am very certain that he got over his issues, at least the panic attacks he was getting today. Drew inspects me trying to figure out how I can be so confident. Catherine asks, you spoke to him? Marina says, weren't you in the officers building whole day. Did David visit you at work. I could tell them how I know. But I wasn't completely sure about it. Would it be possible for him to beat down those warriors without using his Kuret. Seems incredibly unlikely. But now I have seen his robots and security, he could have used them instead.

My moneys on him using his Kuret. Peter said he saw people fighting each other. He must have done that trick where I could use others Kuret. I reply, I didn't seem him since morning. Its just a hunch. Marina nods, yeah. Well, that’s all good. But doesn't he has only 5 minutes left. You said he messaged you a while ago, why is he so late. Drew says, can't imagine what's keeping him if he actually controlled his Kuret. That’s also why I think he couldn't do it within the time limit.

Catherine asks, what if he did overcome it, but like hours from now, or tomorrow. Would you still help him? Marina says, yeah, how does few more yours makes a difference. Drew thinks about it for a moment and then shook her head, its not just about the time. I am testing other things too. I can't say what without giving up some things about him. He did ask me the same thing when I didn't even give him whole day. If it weren't for those things, I would have been okay to wait till tomorrow or a week. And besides that, there's the match with Charles in the future. I can't deny that external factors wasn't part of the reason. All I can hope is that he makes it here regardless of the situation.

She made sense, as her therapist. But we were all having mixed feeling about this. Time past by and two minute remained. All of us here becoming frantic. Marina, I am just going to call him. Catherine says, don't bother. He isn't picking up. I tried it a while ago. He might be on his way here. I put down my own phone that I was myself going to use. Now even Drew couldn't remain calm. She was rolling her eyes around the field towards the in road.

Then one minute remained. I ask, did he really bailed. Did something happen after leaving the water treatment. Suddenly Marina says, what's that. I thought she finally found him on the road, but she was pointing to the sky. Everyone's eyes gaze up to the sky. I didn't see anything in the dark, but I could also see a figure coming in. Catherine says, I don't see anything. Is that him. In the next moment a large beam of dark Kuret hits the ground in front of us. The Kuret was pouring in like a burst of large water, pushing the grass sideways an away from the air its pushing out.

Marina says, wow. Look at this entry. Like stepping out of an elevator, David comes out of his Kuret that begins to thin out behind him. I am not going to lie, he looked beat up. He had bandages wrapped around his chest and few stiches on the side his face. This is what he gets when he recklessly attacks a group of warriors all alone. He was a little out of breath, what are you all doing here. Wait, before that, tell me if I made it in time. He was huffing and restless as he approached us.

Marina asks confused, what the hell happened to you. Were you in a fight again. David turns to all of us and then to Drew, I'll explain in a moment guys. I need to finish my business with Drew first. I wanted to ask so many things, but he had his own priorities. A while ago I would have just smacked him, but I have calmed down since. We turn to Drew. For the first time, she was genuinely surprised. He aura showed her momentarily shocked expression.

Drew says, you actually did it. I don't believe this. She then smiles and chuckles. David feels a little relieved then, that was close. I thought I was late. Why was he so late, he should have left the plant hours ago. Was he getting his injuries treated. He turns to us, I wasn't expecting a welcoming committee here. He then singularly focuses on Catherine. They both just have a staring contest trying to figure out something. Then he finally turns to me, I know you are in a rush to talk about incident. Just give me few minutes with Drew. Okay.

At least he knows why I am here. I nod, yeah, I can wait. Marina clicks her tongue and slaps on David's back, you had us worried dude. David chokes a little on that and coughs slightly with pain. He winces while saying, easy there. Marina got anxious, hold on. You look worse than yesterday. What happened. David answers, would you believe if I say injuries look worse on the second day. Marina and Catherine both say in unison, no. David straightens himself, well, things happened tonight. But first.

Drew says to him, no need for keep on the theatrics. You did this on purpose didn't you. You got your Kuret back several hours ago, didn't you. All eyes fell on David. David asks with an innocent look, why do you think that. Drew smiles, I'll be honest. I thought you were going to ask for an extension when you sent your message earlier. But you have made me wait in anticipation this long and make a show like this. You were just messing with me, didn't you.

David can be petty sometimes unexpectedly. He just went out of his way to one up Nathan a while ago too. David smiles, all right. You caught me. No matter how calm you appear, you must have been worried at least a little, right. He wasn't even going to deny it and accepted so fast. That’s probably even more surprising than his antics to keep us in suspense. Drew didn't say anything, but I know she was worried for a moment there. She remained silent to not give David that satisfaction.

Marina asks, jeez dude. Don't antagonize your own therapist. David scoffs, don't worry. This isn't even close enough to rattle her. Drew breaks her silence, its quite all right Marina. He is feeling smug that he did it in time. David says, and justifiably so. Drew replies, maybe. But what if this was a trick you have just shown. I am sure you must have thought about it at least once whole day. David chuckles being called out like this. Catherine asks, ah, you can't believe that wasn't his Kuret.

Drew says, who knows. He is extremely skilled in deception. I won't rule out anything. Did she really thought this a trick from David. Maybe she hasn't seen his Kuret up close enough to know its real. All of us were sure of it though. David says, that’s fair. So how about I prove it to you. Lets. Marina cuts him off, I'll prove it Doctor. Even David was surprised by her sudden enthusiasm. Marina prepares a bunch of her Kuret charms and prepares to launch on David.

My eyes widen at that sudden outburst from her. David yells with his palm raised at her, wait. This is not what I meant. Marina already threw her Kuret on him. She threw couple of circuit charms that do a little bit of physical damage. Not good, she doesn't know how David is hurt. He must be weak right now. With my quick reflexes, I pull out my own Kuret and block two of them in the air. But one went around it my Kuret. David stumbles down on the ground not able to maintain his balance when trying to dodge it. Just before the last Kuret charm could hit him, David pulls out his Kuret in front of him and cancels it out before it physically hits him.

The impact still had force that he got dragged away a distance though. Marina had her jaw open seeing David couldn't defend himself. I immediately wrap my Kuret on her extended arm to ensure she doesn't attack him again. David grunts in pain, what the hell Marina. Catherine shrieks while running to him, what did you do that for. Marina yells shocked, what was that David. You could have easily cancelled it with your Kuret. I remove my Kuret from her arm once she backs down, didn't you saw his injuries.

With Catherine's help David stands back up. He was already panting hard. He is even in worse shape that I imagined. Marina was the most surprised among us, I saw. But this is nothing for him. Didn't you see the amount of Kuret he used when he came here. Why didn't you block it. David was glaring at her, woman, I get you are annoyed at me for keeping stuff from you, but this is not how you get even with me. Catherine holds him tightly he almost slipped out from her grip.

Marina broke into a sweat, no. That’s not. Dammit. Sorry David. She steps to him. David was reeling a little from it waves his palm at her, believing she might attack her again. He sighs, just. Give me a second. He raises his watch, any stiches open M. Hi watch opens with the hologram, a small stitch opened in your chest, boss. Its underneath the cast, we will need to cut it open to handle it. David grits his teeth, I felt that one. Well, next stop is the nano bot tank.

Catherine asks, wait, are you wearing a cast underneath. Marina turns panicked hearing that with anxious eyes all over his body. David nods, yeah. I have on in my left foot too. Marina asks, what the hell happened to you. He sighs, price of getting my Kuret back. Two of them didn't really get what he meant. Daivd says, I am fine Catherine. Thanks. She lets go of her and walks towards Drew, who was a little puzzled by Marina's rash behavior. She says, you know, you might also benefit with a bit of therapy for that explosive impulsivity.

Marina ignores her after a mocking expression, what about that Kuret you showed a minute ago. David says, I was late because it took time to build up that. I wasn't totally faking being late, I didn't realize it took so long to pull that off. That little show was the limit. Its funny to see David flustered enough that he didn't even try to hide the pain. David turns to Marina, I was going to propose just a talk with Drew alone for a minute. She knows how to prove I can use my Kuret without triggering a panic attack.

Marina turns to Drew who nods in agreement. With a scorn look from David, he and Drew went a little farther for a brief private discussion. I poke Marina's arm who was in a daze, its fine Marina. He will be fine. He just took a beating from couple of tough people. That pulled her out of her thoughts, what do you know. Catherine also joins in, he definitely looks worse than morning. I guess I could tell them now that Drew was not listening in. But David kept a lid on his involvement. There must be a reason. So I want him to tell us.

I say, all I know he was involved in the fight that broke out in the treatment plant tonight. Marina shrieks, what. Involved how. Catherine turns to David's back, he got beat up there? But no one mentioned him. Did he escape from there. I laugh, more like the mastermind. I am not sure completely myself. The bastard didn't tell anyone about until 20 minutes ago, and, it was with a two line message. No explanation. I rushed here immediately to get details for him. And that’s how I knew he probably resolved his mental block.

Marina tilts her head confused, hold on. I heard Quintin was involved too. Did they fought. I shrug, no clue. We will have to hear it from him. Catherine scoffs, no wonder he is so banged up. Its not just Quintin, Marina, you remember the dual Kuret user Polly, she was there too. I added, and Cory too. Marina eyes widen, I remember those people. They are pretty strong too. Did he fought them there. Who was with him. I shrug not knowing the whole picture.

We waited for their discussion to end. We couldn't hear them, but from their body postures its pretty clear she was asking him bunch of questions. After being is suspense for a while, they finally walk back to us. Drew spoke first, I confirmed it, she eyes at Marina, with words. Sounds almost ridiculous that he actually pushed through in a bizarre manner. Catherine asks, so your symptoms are gone. David replies, it doesn't work like that. Drew answers for him, its not a switch that will turn off in on go. But he took a very big step in recovery. I am a little conflicted about it though. Because that means I have to held up my side the deal.

David nods, yeah. To quote you, a radical experimental treatment. She nods, exactly. She takes a moment to think about it, maybe I was exaggerating the radical part to maybe scare you from actually being able to do this. I can't believe she would do mind games like this on her patient. But then I look at him nod at her. No, actually she is perfect for him. She says, I can't back down now. Its not everyday I get to observe a case like you. So I'll help you.

David replies excited, thanks Drew. She says, as I told earlier, give me a week. When I am ready, I will contact you. She then looks around to us, I suppose that’s all I can do now. I am sure you all are eagerly waiting to hear an explanation for this current injuries. So I will you all some time to discuss. But please do me a favor and do it somewhere else. I don't have too many neighbors, but someone might see you all here. I understood her concern, thank you Drew. We will get out of your hair.

She waves good night to us and leaves us. I proposed, David, can you move. He says, I will manage. Lets move to my place for a while. I'll explain what I can. I can't wait to hear that explanation. Marina hesitantly asks, do we move to your. David shots her down, no. Not ART. I told you, it can't handle all of us. My place. Its the closest. We all agreed to that and started walking towards the road. A car runs down the road towards us. I ask, is that for us.

David nods, yes. I hadn't seen this car before. What's more that it was a driverless car. This must be part of the underwater house. We all get in and it drove us to his house. While we drove, David asks me, what did you tell them. I replied, not much. Just what I know. He leans back on the driver seat, well then. Before I explain what happened I want to confirm something. He turns to Catherine seating with me in the behind, I know I am being rude, but I am not in favor of telling you.

That’s shocked everyone. I face a irritated Catherine. She asks, what do you mean by that. Why. David replies, I found out things. Things about who tried to poison Marina and Blake. Marina yells, what. You know who it is. Give me their name right now. She was a down with guilty from pushing David earlier, but now she was distracted by the prospect of finding the people who poisoned her. David says, I will tell you. However, Catherine. You are in a position where being in charge of managing the social affairs of the island makes you a target.

Now I was flabbergasted, hold on. Target for whom. You mean the people we have in custody. He shook his head, they are nothing but criminals. They don't pose a threat. But there is someone pulling strings behind them. My worry is that if I share this to you Catherine, you might act or do stuff that will attract their attention. That’s what I mean by becoming a target. Its safer for you to not know this. I got a little annoyed, that’s not fair to her man. You can't held what she did in the morning against her.

As soon as that left my mouth, I felt hypocritical. Didn't I just chewed her a little about it minutes ago. David didn't rebuke that. Catherine become quite, her aura showing bit of confusion and anger. But their were hints of resentment too. Marina asks, is it that dangerous for her. David nods, it is. More than us. I was coming up a way to defend her. But I couldn't. If David was being so concerned, he must have a good reason. Catherine asks, is it because of what you told me in the morning.

David closes his eyes, like it pained him for some reason. He replies, maybe. Maybe not. I don't want to lie by saying its not. So instead I'll say this, I trust you. I just don't trust the people around you at work. And after today, anyone around me will be in target. I don't know how, but it’s a very strong possibility. Marina and Blake are shadows, they know how to be covert. He then thinks for a moment, no. Actually you are even better than them. And that’s why this is dangerous for you. They already have a target on them. Can you handle one on you as well ?

He was being very cryptic, but he made sense. We were targeted in the tournament. No one else. It might not be fair to Catherine, but I was beginning to think she should stay out of it too. Catherine turns to me, I don't understand what he is saying. You seem to know the most. Tell me honestly, am I a liability here. I didn't like her being so dejected. I answer, you aren't a liability Catherine. Don't think like that. I am at a loss of words to comfort her. I understood both their concerns, but it was hard to weigh which one is more important.

David says, Catherine, how about this as a compromise. You can do what you excel at without me stopping you. Figure things out for yourself. You are excellent at it. Catherine turns to him, what's that supposed to mean. He answers, I know its not fair to keep in the dark. So how about instead of me asking you to stay out of it, you do your own investigation. Follow the trail and if that somehow leads back to us, I will gladly show our cards. David was meeting her half way here.

This cheered up Catherine a little, you mean I can figure out how or why you were involved today, and keep perusing it on my own. He nods, exactly. I shook my head, I don't like this David. You are using her as a bait. Aren't you. Marina slaps David on his shoulder who grunts in pain, the hell David. You are the worst. David shots Marina with another glare and then back to me, to be clear, she is only a target if she is helping me. But if she investigates it on her own, she won't have to worry about it. The entire IDF is doing it as well.

He didn't deny it. But apparently, that was the jolt Catherine needed to get out her sour mood, you sure. I may not be good at deceiving like you, but I am damn good at spying and gathering intel. What if I found about things that you don't know. I might not share that to you. That brought a smile to his face, that’s fine. That just means I will ask your help in that case. Besides, this is the perfect chance to prove certain people wrong about you. I turn to her with a confused look. She finally grins, hmm. Really, you think I have to prove myself. No thanks, I may not be happy with them, but I don't need justify myself to them too.

Earlier Catherine said David told things about her family. They must be talking about someone of her relatives. David says, I knew that. Just wanted to know if you know that too. Catherine clicks her tongue, you think you are so clever, don't you. You still lied. David says, I didn't. So lets just leave it at that. Whatever conversation they had, it made sense only to them. I ask her, are you really okay with this. Being out of the loop. She nods, yeah. I don't know what this is all about, but I will figure it out.

She was resolved to do, so I guess I didn't have to make a decision for her. Marina asks, Blake is right, Catherine. David might want be using you as bait despite all what he said. David smiles now not denying the accusation. Catherine says, its fine. I might use him as well. Just you know, to keep things fair. Okay, she is beginning to be her usual self. David says, thanks for understanding. Because I programmed M to drop you at your house first. I didn't realize we were going through section 1.

Catherine says, damn you. Apparently, David already knew how this conversation would turn out. In a minute we were at her house's driveway. Catherine gets out of the car and says, I see you all tomorrow. Then she sneers at David, I will see you real soon. David waves her, looking forward to it. We say our byes and the car drives us to Davids place next. Marina ask, so what's with all the sudden dangerous mission.

Once we were on the road again, David says, the one behind the sabotages and behind tonight's event is someone close to us, an officer from the island.

Blake (Chapter 77)

Sunday, January 18, 2026 17:11

It took another 15 minutes to David's house. He kept us in suspense and didn't explain why he thought one of the officers was behind the scenes. Marina and I kept asking him why he believes that. To make sense of this, he started from beginning. He was a little hesitant to explain how he came to be at the treatment plant. He wanted us to focus more on the criminals than how he found them. But after continuous pestering from Marina, he relented. He pushes a chair, taking a sofa seat, fine. Fine. I'll tell you everything. So far he told us bits about his day.

Me and Marina each take the couch. I opened my unforms jacket and laid it on the back to get comfortable. David offered us some coffee explaining it will be a long night. Honestly, I needed it. Marina sits on the couch with on knee crossed in her seat, this is so good. Much better than what we have in our office. I didn't like that tone, what do you mean. We have good stuff too. Marina says, nope. This is much better. Honestly, you should install same machines there too. She blows off the steam and takes a sip.

I was annoyed at her blatant disregard for the office coffee. Then I tasted it myself. My throat tasted so good that I actually grinned while drinking. Marina smiles with a light foam on her lips, told you. David laughs too. I ask, dude. What the hell. I thought you said you added the latest machines in our cafeteria. You are keeping the good stuff to yourself. David answers, its my own concoction. I have been experimenting with some imported south Columbian beans. I don't have a large enough supply. So unfortunately, you will have to stick with your usual stuff.

Both of us groaned at him hogging it the good stuff. After setting down, I break the ice, as much I want to chat our life styles, lets get down to business. David agrees, are you fine though. Its been a very long day for you. I scoff, I could say the same of you. I wasn't the one who had to fight off 3 warriors. David leans back on his sofa and stares at the ceiling, like something ominous is about to come next. He says, M, begin the umbrella protocol. Lock down the house.

We hear a little mechanical noise and I hear the shades down on the windows and doors locking. M's voice looms, all done boss. Whatever you say will not leave this room. David says, you too M. Unfortunately, I can't have you listen on this too. Manual shutdown for an hour, bypass authorization with voice authentication. A moment later M says, authentication completed. I will be in my lowest passive monitoring mode. Then all the displays in his house goes dark.

Marina asks, you really are serious now. David turn to face us, I am going to reveal everything to you both now. Not just about tonight, but about shadows and my PTSD. I wasn't expecting complete transparency from him. Did he really got over his issues now. Marina asks, look, I know I have been the most vocal about you not sharing, but seriously. If you don't want to, then. David stops hers, appreciate it Marina. I think its time to come clean. Even if you did broke my ribs again.

She jerks, that was an accident. David laughs, yeah, yeah. I know. Just promise you won't do it again now. Marina nods without hesitation, trust me, if you are okay with sharing with us, I promise not to hurt you. Then she murmurs, only if you deserve it. I think only I heard that. I ask, what changed that made you decide this. David says, honestly, I have been grappling about this is for some time now. You remember our talk yesterday morning, just before the match. I told you were going to be the first person who I will explain my changes in behavior.

He did say that back then. Somehow he is honoring that deal. David says, so much to tell. Where to start. He looked unsure where to start. We both remained patient while drinking our coffee while David prepares himself. He says, lets talk about my PTSD. Its not a typical one, you might have heard it from Drew or known about it yourself. If it were normal, I would be cripped with nervous breakdown for years. Instead I have been slowly effected just few years ago, when I was out for revenge against Nathan.

I could feel the pain in his voice. I recalled that year. He was struggling with his guilt over his first human murder and his obsession with getting justice for Sophies father. So it started from then huh. Marina, who wasn't there, asks, but what about the war with Echo last year. You didn't struggle then. Isn't like PTSD worsens in a war. David nods, you could say I avoided then because I was lucky. My memories was only beginning to resurface. What I told you all last year was the truth, at least what I remembered until then.

I ask, you remember more since then. He says, that’s right. Repressed memories is not like a door, not everything comes back immediately. I was already feeling the effects when we were back in the island after the war. That first night terror. His face contorts with slight pain, was excruciating. I thought it was just a one time thing. Then it happened thrice in the next week. I knew then I was screwed up mentally. I tried to fix it myself. Then came the panic attacks. My conditioned had worsened much more than I thought.

Marina ask, why did you hide from us. David answers, I wanted to tell you all. But I was embarrassed and didn't want to be seen weak. Call it arrogance, or egotistical or just plain being a jerk. I wanted to fix myself without people knowing about me. Not a whole lot of people trusted me back then. Giving them an excuse that I had such a base human problems would be like giving them an ammo. Hiding my condition, even to you all seemed the best course of action.

I don't like it that he was giving a mildly rational explanation. I ask, we could have found a way to help you. He asks, how exactly. Its not like there are people here who are skilled in helping complex things related to mind. If it was a physical, mental or medical issue, there could have been ways. But not a phycological case like mine. I needed help from knowledgeable therapist who can understand my unique situation. A human one. Marina asks, so you sought out Drew instead. David nods, luckily I found her a while later. 2 weeks living with the symptoms made me realize I can't do it myself. I needed to get treatment from human professionals. I may be vain about hiding my condition, but I wasn't stupid. Seeking therapy for my mental healthcare was paramount to get better.

I recalled something about this, several months ago, right after we came back. You were asking about going on a long assignment outside. He says, that was the first plan. But luckily I found about Drew. She was the perfect person to help me. She had the right skills, experience and knowledge of both Human and Medrones. Finding her was nothing short of miracle. Since you talk to her, you already know she had to face difficulties due to her choices while living among humans. It took a while to convince her. In the end she agreed and we started doing sessions every week for 8 whole months.

Marina says, David, I can't believe you had to struggle so much. Seriously, you could have told us, at least for moral support. I agreed with her. We have been through so many things together. David says, you aren't wrong. I was probably jealous that I was the only shadow alive who is struggling to get past the horrors of Medrine. You both already went through your trauma alone while growing up in a foreign planet. He turns to me, Oriana died, but that didn't stop you. He turns to Marina, you built Citradel on all your own, despite not knowing anything about Earth.

Oriana's name brought bitter memories. He may think I lost her recently, but we both know I lost her way before when she decided to betray us for Nathan. He continues, I guess I wanted to prove to myself that I could get through the trauma's on my own too. If that makes sense. Marina and I were silent hearing his reasons. He must have felt pressured. Especially when he was part of the shadows, who were chose to have strong mental fortitude. I say, look, I can't imagine the duress you were in, so I understand the need to hide it. I think I can understand that part at least, if not everything.

Marina keeps her cup on the side table, ditto. I may look like this, but I was a mess too in the beginning. I added, yeah, same. David pulls a weak smile, I know, but I was too late in the game. And the worse part is that its my own fault to be in this position. His mood becomes anxious, I told you before that I lost my memories when I came to Earth due to an accident. He takes a long breadth, that’s not true. My memories were fumbled back then, but I remember them now.

I leaned in a bit closer to him. He claps his hands on his knees, I did that to myself. I repressed my own memories. I didn't fully know what he meant, you mean from the trauma. He says with a grim tone, I mean a serum that erases memories. My jaw shook loose hearing that. Marina puts her hand on her mouth shocked. He continues, the last day on Medrine broke me completely. You know that I wanted to leave Medrine and live on Earth believing it that will save me. It had another side to it. Erasing my own memories so that I get live a normal life.

I shout, you are kidding right. You wanted to live here without your memories. This was before Echo attacked Medrine. That’s the most ridiculous plan I have heard from you. Marina says, why would you do something so extreme. David puts his hand on his head. His face screamed guilt and resentment. He says, I don't know how to explain. Unlike most, I didn't have anyone. I was on my own for a time before joining the university. Struggling to eat, breathe, even a basic live. Every day was a struggle, no one could help me or understand me. Maybe things would have been different I knew about the MARS project when I was a child.

He shakes head, regardless. When I learned of Earth, it was a dream and salvation for me. And it became a reality once I got into Shadows. I had a plan then, once I found a way to get off the planet, I would quit Shadows and leave Medrine. I can't believe this. I ask, are you for real. You thought of escaping to Earth without your memories. Marina shook her head, you think Shadows would even allow it. David sighs, it was a crazy and desperate plan. I don't deny it. But it was what all I had that time. I just wanted to live a different life.

He then laughs mockingly, you knows what's even crazier. It was never going to work. I told you before that I was suffering through malnutrition. I later found out on here on Earth, that I wasn't going to make it till even my 20s. Once I hit puberty, my body wouldn't developed, nor my brain. It would eventually lead to some terminal illness. I am not sure what it could have been, it could have been simple as allergies, or something severe like cancer. And most likely, I would be dead before even I could amass resources to leave Medrine.

I never imagined he was going through of all this as a child. I knew he lived a harsh life, but this made it impossible to even fathom how worse it was. Marina asks, was there really no cure. He replies, the only cure came with the destruction of Medrine. One of the things I was struggling in therapy was the survivals guilt. No, actually there is not even a phycological term to describe a situation where I not just survived, but got to live beyond the time I thought I had. All at the expense of everyone and everything dying.

I could only offer some solace now, but that’s not your fault. He makes a weak smile, don't I know that. Just because its true, didn't make it easier for me to accept it. Like I said, one the challenges I had to accept. Marina says, gosh. David. I can't believe it. I can imagine now why you didn't want to tell anyone about it. David says, the story is not over. When I arrived on Earth, I didn't know at that time that I was spared and got to live. I was consumed by the horrors I saw that last day.

He put downs his cup on the side table. His mood becomes serious again, to understand what led me to erase my memories, I need to tell you about someone. A girl I was very close with. She was the who actually came up this crazy plan of erasing memories and was going to come with me to Earth. What the freak, someone else also part of this. Marina asks, that’s nuts. I can understand if its you, but why would someone normal would chose to do it. David says, depends on what people believe is normal.

He leans forward, I am going to reveal things about Shadows as well, so do not disclose this to anyone under any circumstances. I ask, huh. Ah, okay. Marina nods with hesitation too. He continues, I was close with our generations Shadow retrievalist. Her name was, Zakerine, the next in line in alpha to the Utabine bloodline. Do you know who they are. I gulp hard finally learning of another Shadow member. But I had a hard time recalling this bloodline. Marina jerks a bit on her couch.

She shrieks, no way in hell. Someone from their bloodline joined us. Freak. I ask, you know who they are. Because I don't. Marina waited for David, but he waves his arm for her to explain, by my guest. She explains, they are super

powerful bloodline Blake. They can physically teleport. I hands tremble a little hearing that, say that again. She scoffs, I didn't believe when mom told me about them. Buts its true, there is a Kuret that allows space to fold, and make it possible to open, something like a gate ? She asks David. He says, yeah. A mini wormhole. I don't know if you heard about spooky action theory by Einstein. Its basically instantaneous teleportation in a limited space.

My god, I say, that's some ridiculous ability. Having such a ability makes it perfect for a Shadow retrievalist. But how come I never heard of them. Marina says, that's probably because they rarely ever get to use this ability. I was confused why that was the case. David clarifies, unlike most bloodline, only five or six people could do it. And that includes the alpha, so in reality, its even less. Their Kuret has such a massive physical attribute, but most of their house people can't open a wormhole.

I say, jeez. You know, once I learned of Heraknus, I thought I wasn't going to be surprised anymore. But Medrine is the gift that keeps coming. Marina says, yeah. But where Heraknus hid, Utabine ran. They are impossible to find, mom had a theory that royals were protecting them. But I guess not. I shrug, maybe I just wasn't told about them. David adds, no. Not even the royals didn't know. Zakerine told me she was bounced around with her mother, the current alpha of that time. Marina is right, they are sought after. But not to join their house via marriage or team up. They wanted to study and create Kuritines with their DNA. So even if they didn't have he ability to teleport, they can be studied.

Now I understood why Marina was freaked out we had someone like that in Shadows. Its a sad, but predictable tale, when you mean studied, you mean. He sighs, yeah. In a lab, as a controlled subject. Getting your hands on one was like finding a holy grail. Getting an alpha would be divine miracle. The applications are endless, even humans are searching for ways beyond lightspeed. Imagine what Medrones can do with such technology. The potential are boundless, he was right about that.

Marina says, how did she came to join us. We may not abuse or mishandle powers, but still, we do use it. David says, I don't know. She never shared the details on how. I only know why, she, like me wanted to run away to Earth. Her mother left her at the university under the alias of some other bloodline. Some Shadow recruiter found about her true heritage and gave her the choice. After passing the trails, she became our member. She said she was just hiding, biding time in Shadows until her mother came. But after joining a year, she got her bloodline marker and became an alpha. She didn't receive it normally, so their was only one way it would have happened.

We have come to know about this all too familiar, her mother died. David says, that's when she formed that plan. I wasn't aware of it, but once I knew who she was, I found about it accidently one day. Normally she wouldn't have let it slip, but it was her mothers death anniversary, was depressed and I happen to be nearby as she was speaking to herself in her room. She was initially denying it, saying its not possible to create a potion. But I revealed that I was also in Shadow, and we can find a way if we worked together. She took several days to consider, but then she agreed. From then on, I perfected our plan. With my network of people with access growing in time, we were able to make the serum.

I was enthralled listing to this. Not in a good way. I ask, this is when you were both nine or ten. What kind of children think of a plan like this. Marina says, only you could come up with such a dangerous thing. David says, I know that now. But back then, I wasn't aware of the repercussions. No, I did know but didn't care. I was dying, thinking I won't get to become even an adult. And she was being hunted. She didn't care about her bloodline, she just didn't want to die like her mother. Both of had different reasons, but same goal. To live. Something to strive for. My brains and her ability were the best combination to break into any place.

He leans back and takes a moment to himself, like he is reliving those days. After a long silence, he says, she wasn't like me. But I never met anyone who was dedicated to achieve something. Other kids, no offence, were boring compared to her. I can imagine that. When you are born genius, especially on Medrine, you don't mix well with kid of your caliber. He continuous, as we studied and worked together, over time. I found her to be my only true friend. A guide.

He then croaks a little, and eventually I became infatuated with her. Ah, I see now. I can already begin to understand what happened now. Marina was less tact and said, you fell in love with her. When you were kids. David felt uneasy taking about it. I silently signal Marina to not push it. I am very certain this is very sore topic for him. David says, I did. Yeah. Sounds ridiculous, I know. Marina completely ignores my plea and asks, and her, did she also felt the same.

I wished she wouldn't be so inconsiderate of David. David saw me eyeing Marina, its fine Blake. I want to tell. Its just hard to tell reveal this to you. Not even Drew knows the whole story. He then turns to Marina, I think so. Though I always wondered if I pressured her in some way. I can't be sure that I didn't manipulate her. I did that a lot when I didn't care about anything back then. But I was happy. And she was happy. I never told her this, but I was beginning to want to not erase our memories when we go to Earth. At least I didn't want to. I thought I could be with her, even if she lost her memories.

I have seen him rarely this vulnerable, he was even talking without his usual demeanor. Opening up to us like this must be too much for him. Now even Marina understood and patiently waited for him to speak when he got the courage. He takes a moment and says, but that didn't happen. Echo's attacked. She died. And the serum I almost discarded, I used it on myself. Unable to process my grief and unable to forget the memories all the people dying. I couldn't take it anymore. That's also one of my issues I had to grapple with in therapy. I erased my memories for selfish reasons, and lost time when Medrones were hiding or dying, when I could have helped them.

This is painful to just hear, I can't imagine what he must have been going through. He says, I never once imagined Echo would be following us to Earth. In my own selfish way, wanted to keep the plain a live, thinking she would want me to do it too. He had teary eyes now. But before he could shed any tear, he wipes his eyes and closes them. He smiles, damn, I didn't know telling the truth would be this hard. It was much earlier with Drew. It was hard for him, no doubt.

We all have troubled history, each have to bear the burden however they can. David wasn't different, just was really unlucky. Marina asks, you don't have explain to us. I shouldn't have pressured you all this time. David laughs, chocking a little, thanks. But I told you all, I am about to clear the air. That's doesn't mean just the happy stuff. But the gritty stuff too. As he tries to calm down, I went to fetch him a glass of water. He thanks me while drinking it all in one sip.

He then says, but just last night, I unlocked the very last moment of my time on Medrine. I ask, you still hadn't recovered all your memories. He nods, I thought I did. I thought Zakerine died from a bombardment from Echo ships just before we were about to board the ship. But turns that it was the whole story. He then explained to us how she survived that initial attack, but people died to save them, including Branden and John. This is how he knew about Catherines family. But then Zakerine died anyway trying to save John.

This is getting worse by the minute. I am in shock David was able to go on with the day, come to the pier to meet Charles and give the interview. I was depressed for days when Oriana died. This freaking guy had to tough it out and come to accept it in a day. Marina asks, I can't believe she died like that. Why she go this far for John. David replies, a million dollar question. I have no idea. All day I have been trying to figure that out, thinking it was key to resolve my mental block. The best I can think is she didn't want to lose anyone, like she did her mother.

With the messy history he telling, I almost forgot why I came to him. I was curious what made him get past his trauma. But for now, I wanted him to lead his story that way he wants to. Marina says in a muffled tone, I can't believe Utabine bloodline ended like this. I am not trying to disregard her effort, but it was so. She couldn't find the words. Neither could I. David offers, needless. I didn't expect him to be this callous about it. Its not like I wasn't thinking that. I just didn't want to say it.

He says, there's no need to sugarcoat it. It was a pointless death. He sad expression turns to an angry one, Drew told me that I might have always remembered this memory, and influenced my emotions subconsciously. By how much is anyone's guess. But this completely broke me. My lowest point, as Drew calls it, rock bottom. What if could have stopped her, made her see reason. What if I was able to use my Kuret then. All these questions, and no way to answer them.

I gulp hard before asking, she made her choice. I know its easy to but, it really wasn't your fault. He says, I couldn't accept that. Not until tonight. Saving Elina, felt like I was redeeming myself. Marina asks, who is that. I tell her, the victim last night. She was gravely wounded. Marina says, that's her. I nodded. I was very curious how he knew her, but I had to wait for him to tell me that in his own time. I felt it I need to switch topic so David doesn't feel pressured into explain his issues with us. I had a question for him that was good way to turn things a bit, how did you know John and why was he and Branden with you both there.

David puts his palm on his face for some reason, like he didn't want to tell us that. A while later he says, I guess I have come clean about that too. He turns to us, what do you know about the last member, Shadow spy. I looked at Marina who shook her head, same as me. David says, its John. He was also in our generation. Holy shit. I ask, Catherine's brother was in the shadows. Marina says, no way. You know, now that I think about it, its perfect for them. Their Kuret is basically made for this.

I was still stuck at that reveal. I ask, does she know. David says, what do you think? His question gave me the answer. Marina asks, that's so bizarre. Normally you expect Shadows to have distinct people, but we have many so many people for famous and strong bloodline in the same generation. She had a point. Aside from David and Zakerine, all three of us are chosen from powerful bloodline. David chuckles hearing that. Marina asks, what. Am I wrong. David waves his hand, not at all. Just amused how close you are.

I ask, close to what. David says, me and Zakerine learned about something crazy about Shadows. Its probably not so crazy, just a propaganda they spread. I was so confused by this. David says, it's a sham. Well, not a total one. But they still lied big time. Shadows aren't recruited from a very big pool of candidates. Three of roles are almost always filled predetermined from certain bloodlines. Only one or two, maybe three in extreme case, are actually selected from the rest of general population. Marina waves both her hand around David, what does that mean.

Hold on, does he mean what I think he means. David says, Shadows was originally created by your three ancestors. Yours and Catherines. Naturally they would want to keep their power and have their bloodline member in the shadows each generation. Its being going on for centuries. David wasn't just revealing his secrets now, he was telling all of ours. I ask, is this for real. Marina yells nervously, someone from my family was a Shadow too. I ask, but why wouldn't they tell us.

David says, for many reasons I am sure. Like if they told you, it might make you feel undeserved. Because of how they sell the idea that Shadows are selected based on skills and morals. You all would feel cheated and maybe even feel too much privileged. But don't worry, they definitely chose you all for the right reasons. I said earlier the candidates for your roles is less, not gone. You still had to beat your other bloodline members. I don't know if you realized this, but Nathan was a candidate too. He lost in the trials to you, Blake.

I immediately jerked in my seat, who in their right mind would try to induct him. David smiles, its not based on personality, but their skills and judgement. I had to learn the hard way about this in the Shadows. I can't believe I faced off Nathan when were child. We were given individual trails, so its obvious I didn't knew. Marina asks excited, hey what about me. Did I also fought get to fought someone I knew. David thinks for a bit, Ozarek is a little mystery to me, even now. Zakerine said your older sister have been a candidate one time, but we didn't know for sure. But I personally always believed your 4 cousins were candidates too.

She slams her fist on the side of the couch, I should have known. They were so obnoxiously proud of being my aunts children. Those girls in Shadows would have been a disaster. David says, like I said, that just my assumption. Marina says, still. Its amazing though. Shadows kept us always in dark about this. I say, probably didn't want us to know our history and be influenced in any way. David nods, most likely the truth, I believe it too. I ask, but how in the hell did you figure this out. Even if you knew about us, you couldn't conclude about our history with just that alone.

David smirks, every year, there is a summit. All past generations Shadows come together, at least all the ones who are alive. The location is so well guarded, you probably have a better luck searching for pitta Kuretine in the

ocean. I will spare you the arduous details on how we got their location. After failed attempts three times in row, two years before Echo attacked, we finally found their summit location. We successfully infiltrated it too. Never in entire Shadows history they ever recruited people like me and Zakerine. My presence can't be detected by Kuretine devices. And she could basically wrap into anywhere. Even if they had managed to stop Zakerine, I was a different story.

I smile thinking how two kids were able to do it. Marina says, hold on. Are you telling me you know the previous generation Shadows were. I was eager to know too. David says, are you sure you want to know. Some of these are people you know intimately, outside your training. Knowing them will most definitely change your perspective of them. They trained you from a small age, while you didn't know them. I didn't tell Catherine for this very reason. Once you know, you can't go back. So, do you still me to tell you. His concern was legitimate. I don't know how would I feel about them. Marina wasn't grappling with the same as me.

She says, oh come on. I am dying to know. I might not like it, but its always better to know. David says, not always. Even Marina had to agree that. She says, can't deny that. But I'll think I still want to know. Even if its changes my opinion about them. David laughs, that’s so you. Well, maybe you won't have a problem. But I didn't want to find out that out with Catherine. So I never told her. I ask, then why was she upset then. David thinks for a moment, you have to talk to Catherine about that. I'll leave it up to her if she wants to share it.

Probably for the best. At least it helped me make my decision too, I want to know too. Whatever happens, it already has happened. Besides, like you said. It might not be as bad as you think. David tilts his head a bit, that's what everyone says before regretting it. He then sighs, well, since you both have made up your mind, I might as well tell you then. The previous generation of shadows were Brandon, Wagner, Istra, Hansen and a women whose identity I don't know.

As soon as I heard those names, my mind went racing into all directions. Some good, and some very bad.

David (Chapter 78)

Monday, January 19, 2026 19:47

This is so embarrassing. One by one I am telling them my deepest and darkest secrets. Some that I not even told Drew. I had been wavering back and forth about telling them about many things. But I ended up spilling all the beans. I felt someone plunged a cold abyss in my guts when I told about my biggest regret. The most selfish decision to erase my memories. Even when I told my relationship with Zakerine, I couldn't bring out everything. I wanted to tell them so many things. The things we both did, places we visited, and the missions.

I knew I was being cold and detached when I told them her death was pointless. Because I still can't myself to forgive Zakerine. I can accept to some extent, but never forgive her and myself. She might have lost her mind back then, but I didn't help her. The regret hasn't gone, only dimmed by the acceptance of her death. I was glad when Blake asked me something else to not pressure me into telling them everything. I apricate that very much, because I wanted somethings to be just between Zakerine and me.

I decided that it was time to reveal things about Shadows I had learnt over the years on Medrine. Their family being in the Shadows was no doubt a shock to them. I just hope it doesn't dishonor their memories in any way. There was only person that I was reluctant to name in the previous Shadows. But I am tired of hiding his identity now. The two of them were stunned to hear the four people I named. Marina is bewildered, mom was shadow member. What, no way. I think I would recognize my own mom when she was training me in our headquarters.

Her reluctance to believe that was expected. I answer, she was there in the summit. There's no mistaking it. Marina leans back in the couch, damn mom. She was so different when she trained me as Shadow keeper. To think she coddled me so much at home, while was a strict instructor in Shadow. I never imagine it was her. I nod, its perfectly fine. If you think about it, each Shadow generation of your 3 bloodlines go through similar transition. Only once you turn from an apprentice to full fledged member, you learn the truth. I never saw your grandmother in the summit. But if you think about it.

Marina understood my thinking, she was the alone sibling of her generation and her cousins were all male. She was the Shadow before my mom. I nod, most likely. Blake asks, Wagner and Branden were one too. I guess that makes sense for Catherine's father. Marina ask, who is Hansen. I don't recall the name. Before I could answer, Blake says, I think I know, he was the chief advisor to the council right. I nod, you know your politics. Its him. He was a very intelligent. To this day, I haven't met anyone smarter than him. Maybe that’s just how I remember him, but he was certainly very cunning. The quality you need to be strategist.

Blake says, high praise from you means he was a great person. But I can't believe Wagner was one too. I can't believe the crown was a member too. My expression harden a little bit. I know I have tell him, but I was still harboring doubts. He asks, I am guessing you didn't tell Vanessa also. He raised an eyebrow, maybe already knowing the answer.

I sigh, no. She doesn't. To her, her brother is very important, so much so that she blindly idolizes her unconditionally. She will not accept anyone bad mouthing him. You saw yourself when Melinda told that story about him endangering the kids. Blake asks, wait, so that’s actually true. He infiltrated the Heraknus home and causes problems. Its hard to believe that. I shrug, I don't the slightest clue if he did that or not. But honestly, I don't find his actions surprising.

That even brought Marina from her daze, why do you say that. He might have made a mistake that time. He was the golden boy. I immediately make a scowl, he was a menace to the society and should have died way before the Echo killed him. I couldn't hold back now. I used to control myself and holding back, but my veins were popping on my head now. My venomous derogatory comment about him left them both stunned. I need to explain it properly, Blake. Didn't you notice something weird about the lineup of the previous Shadows.

He had already noticed it, you didn't mention anyone from my family. Maybe it was the women you don't know. I shook my head dismissing that. He turns nervous realizing the cruel truth, no. That wasn't Wagner, tell me it wasn't him. I scoff, who else would it be if not him. He was the previous Shadow attacker, there's no doubt. When I laid it out, Blake runs his hands on his hair trying to calm down. Marina was confused, is he like secretly bad. Blake looks at her anxiously, if David's right, then he was a nightmare. This is bizarre, no one should have him as a mentor. Its like Jekel and Hyde, his personality is flipped from a cool and dependable to someone with no qualms brutalizing me.

I am glad at least someone else beside me is able to understand Wagners true nature now. It felt like a big rock lifted from my shoulder hearing that. It was burden I didn't know would release me so much from that guys grip. I smirk, glad you believe that too. Ever since I got my memories, whenever I heard praises of him from Vanessa, I would almost lose it. I could never reveal this to her, without telling them what I know and how I know. Blake shook his head, still in denial, freak this. No wonder you hate Wagner so much. I am so bloody confused right now.

Marina asks hesitantly, really. But why is he like this. I have seen few times personally. She pauses a little before saying in a hushed tone, he was so handsome and charming. I had a massive crush on him. As soon I heard that, my breathing cuts off and I began chocking on myself. I raised my hand to her to stop saying anything more. I could just throw up listening to this utter nonsense. Blake asks me, dude. You good. I nod while I settle down, please Marina. I can handle other women talking about him like this, but not you. Please, never say that in my presence again. I didn't have a panic attack, but I felt even worse than that.

Marina was stunned by my adverse reaction and says, ah, okay. Clearly she was conflicted about it too. I go and grab another glass of water to calm my enraged nervous. I know how Vanessa talks about Wagner, but I know why she believes that. I had gulp down two more glasses to cool myself. Blake says, Marina, he was bad. I mean, there is a strict teacher and then there's him, completely unreasonable. I used to believe that it was a mistake to bring him into Shadows. That guy was deranged. He would beat me up every time I mess up. He didn't even bother to teach me anything. Out sessions were nothing but me getting hurt. I had to rely on David to learn.

I am sure by now Marina now understand what Wagner was truly like. I add, I have no idea why he was like this, Marina. Once I saw their real identities, me and Zakerine spent months digging into everyone's history and tried to understand some weird inconsistences. But even after all that research, I couldn't find his background other than what's public knowledge. But I do one thing, he wasn't like this when he joined. I take sat back on the sofa chair as Blake asks, what makes you say that.

I answer, because he was chosen by the previous Shadow member, Slater. Yours dad Blake. Blake stops rummaging on his hair and looks straight at me, holy shit. My dad was one too. Marina chuckles amused, of course he was. My mom, Catherine's Dad and now yours. Dude, our parents were master in deception. For the love of. She trails off mumbling to herself. Blake clasps his hand and rests his head on it, deep in thoughts. I offered them some advice, look. They had their reasons. I am sure their relatives made them go through the same. If Echo hadn't attacked, I am sure you all be doing the same. I know it’s a lot, but like I said before, don't let this change your perception of them. Its important you don't forget that.

I was really afraid of that they would be angry with them. They should not blame them their families for any reason. Blakes says, I am not angry. Just, hum. I need some time to process this. Marina puts her hand on her cheeks, Its a lot. I nod, it is. But that’s why I know Slater wouldn't have picked Wagner if he was like this from the beginning. You dad gave up alpha power to his brother, just to marry your mother. So I really don't think a selfless guy like him would chose such a poor successor.

Blake nods, that’s true. Dad was very careful about everything he does. But then what happened to Wagner. Something went really bad while he was in Shadows. Marina asks, maybe a mission gone wrong. I say, probably. But its futile to even think about it. No matter what happened, or what his reasons were to change so much. Nothing justifies brutalizing me or Blake like this. Blake asks me, I know what he did to me. But what did he do to you. I close my eyes recalling all times of our encounters. I shook my head, I rather not say. Just trust me, it was bad.

Marina says, jeez. What the hell he did to you. Unfortunately, I had maxed out my quota of terrible memories of Wagner and didn't offer any answer. Instead she asks, okay. You don't have to. You said something about inconsistency among Shadow members. What did you mean by that. I gave it some thought, me and Zakerine found something strange when you compare the ages and lineup of the previous Shadows. Blake caught on what I said, yeah. You are right. There wasn't anyone from the my bloodline, instead Wagner came in as an attacker. Marina says, hold on. I just realized, my mom's even older than Slater. So why would still be in the shadow when younger people were in her generation.

I said, we had the same question. We spent a lot of time trying to figure that out. We have some theories, but no evidence. All I could say is that like any organization, Shadows has politics involved at some level. It had to be. Hansen was older than others too, but I know that the guy before me was killed in a mission. So he had to remain in Shadow even longer until I was recruited. I didn't find any evidence that Istra tried to find any candidate before Marina. Why she wait so long to find a successor. Meanwhile, Slater chose not to include someone from the royal bloodline and instead brought in Wagner. This reeks of politics maneuvers rather than just not finding the right people for the job.

Blake says, that is so weird. I thought Shadows were free from it. Guess that was just wishful thinking. Marina says, I never imagined it was like this. I never gave this so much thought to it except for the training. I am still confused that Slater would choose someone outside from royal bloodline, something going for centuries like you said. I say, I wish I knew. I didn't I know everything even after finding their identities. They were very good at keeping secrets. I myself would love to know why Wagner was brought in. He was nothing but a walking disaster.

Marina asks, is he the reason for your PTSD ? Is that why you had a panic attack yesterday in the match. I knew this would eventually come up. I had unconsciously I grip the sides of the chair tightly. My PTSD is not completely gone. I never know I might regress to some of my previous symptoms. I take few deep breathes before explaining this, before my mentor, Hansen, brought me to the ship. I was in the other side of the continent the previous day. I don't know I got from there to the ship. Anyways, I was helping out with issuing command in place of Hansen, who left with other Shadows to defend against the hive king and his army from crossing the ocean.

They both lean in closer to me. I continue, we were in the middle of the city when we were attacked by Echo ships. I somehow was able to take the underground train and escape with few people. But Echo kept pursuing us and I told we had to split up. I gave them directions on how to remain safe and find the second ship. I and two other people took a different route though. I wanted to check on the Shadows, with whom we lost contact. Hansen didn't want me to come, but I wanted to find him.

I tremble a little recalling that horrid journey. Air filled with dust and bloodied bodies everywhere. I continue to take deep breathe to keep myself calm. Marina asks concerned, are you okay. I nod frantically, just trying to forget that part of the day. It was horrifying and scary. It was a tough decision for me. I don't know how many actually made to the ship or to my two companions. Once we reached close to the battlefront, we got separated. Most likely they died when we ran from the ground troops.

I shook my head, I shouldn't have gone there. I thought I could be of help. I still can't believe the sheer arrogance of thinking that I was better than Hansen. I often think about what would have changed if was there. Maybe I would have just died, or maybe saved someone. Or maybe nothing would change. The shear carnage of being surrounded by the dead soldiers. All alone, its when my mind started to break down. The beginning of my psyche breaking that eventually lead to so many other paths, ending with my erasing my memories.

Blake asks anxious, what did you find. My breathing was hard, I think I was sweating a little too. But I pushed through the irrational fear gripping me, I found the dead bodies of your parents. I saw Istra dead first. She was beside the river. Marina turns horrified, but doesn't interrupt me, then I found your dad and mom, Blake. I don't know why your mother was with him. Blake turns slightly pale next. I could still see their corpses, all bloodied and mangled. I say, I looked around to find anyone alive. But I didn't find anyone. Then I found Wagner and the last shadow women dead too.

My heart beats faster and heavy. I don't know if this a precursor to a panic attack. It could just be my nerves acting up. I managed to bring up some more courage, Wagner was dead with a Kuretine dagger in his heart. This past year, I have been having nightmares of him, more than anyone else. I keep wondering why he died like that, Echo didn't like to use our weapons. Actually, they couldn't use it back then. I have run multiple scenarios, someone betrayed him, or some Echo broke it off from a bigger weapon, or he just freaking killed himself.

My hand turns into a fist, but his death hits me harder than anyone else. I don't know why. Even with so much time in therapy, I can't get him out of my mind. I had once foolishly promised myself that I will kill him, no one else. I know it makes no sense and its completely bonkers, but it feels like my one real purpose was stolen from me. How could he have died like this, not by my hands. Its the regret and anger over my own strange desire, that is one of the core issues for my PTSD. Drew agrees with me. Its just that we haven't broken through the crux of it. Not yet.

As I explained the whole thing, it was dead silent in the room. It was just our breathings in the room. No, actually it was just mine alone. They both stopped a while ago and didn't need the air. What felt a long time in painful silence, Marina broke it, mom died fighting huh. She was one tough lady. I always wondered how it happened. She grabs her arm and stares to the floor. Blakes says, I knew my father was fighting the hive kings army. But mother was there too?

I nod. Blake shook his head dishearten, dammit mom. You couldn't stay away from the fight too, could you. After more silence of mourning I say, I am sorry. I should have told you both this earlier. I thought I was just sparing you unnecessary pain, but I was just hiding stuff for selfish reason. I didn't even told Drew about any of the identities of the Shadow members. Just aliases using their bloodline family name for enough context for the sessions. But it became a bad habit of mine to keep stuff from people, just because I judged it selfishly.

Marina says, don't be. I am glad you told me now. It was a relief to hear that from her. After a while Blake says, I am not sure if its better to know or not. Weirdly I understand what Catherine said about maybe not knowing was better. He sighs, time will tell I suppose. But I apricate you for telling the truth. I may find some closure in it. I was hoping that would happen for them. Marina asks, damn. Its so messed up. Sheesh. I need to think about something else, otherwise I might cry.

I know the feeling. She hurriedly closed her red eyes before any tears formed and opened them in a furry, distract me with something else. Anything. Blakes asks, I got one. Why not tell Vanessa the truth about Wagner. You are keeping way too much from her. I think this is why she was mad at you this morning. This can't be just about breaking her heart about Wagner, is it? He was right on the money. I had take a moment to be sure I was making the right call. I say, I haven't told this to anyone. Not Drew, not Vanessa and not even Siera. You both also are not going to say a word about it to anyone.

I have had them promise not to tell so many times. I just hope they wouldn't be annoyed by it. Thankfully they agree to it. I continue, I have a strong suspicion that Vanessa has been displacing her brothers memories with something else. I said it aloud, for the first time ever. It feels weird and guilty talking about this. Marina sat up, what. You mean she is faking it. I answer, something like that, yeah. But on subconscious level. I have tried talking to her about it few times before. Gently prodding and trying to find a way to tell her. But every time, I was shot down by her.

Blake says, same thing happened a while ago too. I asked her if the tournament winner would be the new crown. She glared at me like I was stealing it from Wagner and said no one can replace him. I didn't think much of it at that time. Marina says, oh yeah. Now that I think about it, she has been weirdly obsessive about him. She got angry with Melinda too when she told that story. But how do you conclude it from just this. I say, over the few months. I have been researching a lot more about memories and psyche. How they break during traumas and its side effects. I was doing it for me, but I could relate it with Vanessa.

They were listening intently as I continue, memory displacement disorder. Its a term when a person in trauma replaces or fabricates an entirely new memories of a person. Now, I don't think she fabricated memories of Wagner, but instead replaced happy memories from, like their parents, or friends or someone else and put Wagner face into them. This is just a theory, but I suspect this really happened. Marina, you said she was obsessive. That’s a classic symptom. I can understand if Vanessa was trying to preserve his memories, or maybe even just admiring his good qualities. But she has blind devotion and finds no flaws in him. That’s not natural, nor realistic. That’s beyond obsession or being starstruck.

I was terrified of what I was saying since I never said this out aloud. Maybe they say I was insane or would be skeptical about this. Blake asks, you really believe this. I nod, think it this way. Imagine how he treated you, and then try to imagine how he would treat others. Do you really think it was only you or me and not be at least rude to her, not even once. I don't buy that. Blake couldn't rebuke that. Because he knew I made sense. Marina says, dude. You cannot tell this to her. She will rip your head off.

I didn't have to think to reply, why do I think I never bring his name in front her anymore. I have my own issues with him, and I am pissed that can't tell any of this to her. I asked Siera a little bit about it, but I got the impression from her that there was nothing wrong with Vanessa. So I have stayed quiet. Trusting that in time Vanessa either begins to accept Wagner isn't a god or at least try to leave the past. Blake says, you have been keeping too much from people. Drew was right earlier, its talking a toll on you.

I can hardly deny it now. We stayed silent a bit contemplating so many things coming out. Blake says, I don't know if its true or not. But I understand why didn't tell anyone about any of this. But she is mad at you. What are you going to do about it. Honestly, I have no clue. So much has been happening that I can't even spare any thoughts on how to mend that relationship. I say, I don't know. For now, I can't keep being depressed about it. We got a lot of work to do in the meantime.

That jarred them both out of the heavy atmosphere we had for a while. I had calmed my nerves now that I revealed all that I had to say. Marina says, I sure hope you don't lie again to her. Because that would suck a lot. Yeah, that would be really bad. I say, lets keep this on the down low. I know I keep repeating myself, but do not reveal the identities of the Shadows or anything else we talked now. There are still many people who hold grudges on us. Adding these names to that list, even if they are gone, will break moral and sow distrust among people.

Blake nods, true enough. I don't know how people will react if they ever found about 3 bloodlines forming the shadows. Marina adds, or how their crown wasn't the person they thought he was. I nod, I would also appreciate if no one finds out that I erased my own memories. People wouldn't have cared about it before. But now I am getting the attention from the entire world. It will eventually get out, but I hope it happened after our city is united. I am glad that they expressed agreement for that request.

I got up and walk to the wall display, lets stop this depressing topic. As much as you all want to know more, lets table it for later. I tap the bottom screen and punch in the code to reactive M, we need to discuss about the mess I made tonight. Blake comes out of his brooding mood, agreed. Marina says, I guess. But I want to know more about my mom, okay. I nod, and I will. For now, I finish the code and M boots back up, M resume your system directives.

M's hologram shines in the display back, resuming all paused tasks. I get to my chair and face them, let me first tell that I didn't want to do the way it happened tonight. I tried calling you multiple times tonight. You both never picked up your phone. That made them agitated and pulled their phones out. Blake says first, seriously, but I don't see. He pauses as he scrolls down all the way down. Marina taps her phone to her temple, shit. I switched it off when I was surveying the land in section 4. I had some of the officers with me, so I must have turned it off to not be disturbed.

I scoff, just want kind of shadows are you both. At least you could have called me back later. I shook my head unimpressed by their lack of sense of alert. They both look guilty as hell. Blake was even more so, I can't believe this. I didn't even see your missed call among the ones from Vanessa and Tessa. Shit, I missed it completely. I figured they both were very busy, but at least they should pick up when one of calls the other. I say to M, install your alert software on their devices. I can't have us be not available when in deep shit.

Marina says, hey. Wait, what is this. She becomes confused when her phone begins to run something on the screen. I wave my hand, its fine. Just a patch that will bypass your phone setting, weather its turned off or silent. It will also reserve some battery for an emergency priority alert from any one of us. Blake keeps his phone on the table until the program completes, shit. I can't believe I was so careless. I should have asked something like this from the beginning.

Marina followed suit and kept hers on the table, but you could have reached out to someone else. I scoff, the patrol officers wouldn't be able to handle those 3 people. I even tried Vanessa. Hoping she or Tessa or some of the IDF crews would stand a chance. But she didn't pick up too. There is a small chance she basically ignored my call. I had wasted enough time for any backup. So I had to forget about calling anyone else and so I just went on my own. It was a reckless move when I couldn't use my Kuret, but I am glad I did that. If had waited for backup, Elina would have died. I barely made it in time myself.

I am sure they understood now that I did it because I had no other option. Blake shook his head, you know I was a furious with you for not telling me about this. But now I am mad at myself. Marina helps him out, don't take it yourself alone Blake. I was reckless too. I never imagined an emergency like this would have happened. We should really had someone keep on eye on David, like we talked about in the morning. That didn't help out the frustration Blake was feeling.

I sigh, lets not dwell on this. We just have to be more prepared. Blake makes a subtle nod, yeah. Sorry man. We should have been there to help you out. I raise my head at him, yeah. It would have made things easier. But anyways, it wasn't all bad. I somehow got over the mental block. Marina whistles, only you would use any situation to your benefit. But how in the hell did you get mixed up in this. Does danger comes to you naturally or you keep looking for it.

I laugh towards Marina's irritated expression, I have asked that myself so many times. Let me start from beginning. After a day spending time alone, I was tired and decided to visit a place I usually go to relax.

David (Chapter 79)

Tuesday, January 20, 2026 12:57

I explained how I have been disguising myself and been visiting public places all over the city at night. And lately, that place was frequently Elina's bar. I was not going to actually tell them that I was there for Elina. So instead I tell them half truth. Marina says shocked, scotch. You visit her because she sells the best scotch in the entire place. Don't you have your own stock at your house. And even if you don't, you can get it for yourself. Why go to her.

I could tell my weak accuse was not going to fly under a woman's intuition. I answered the half truth version, I also like talking to people there. You know, inebriated people, who are drunk with loose lips and open up easily to me. They are normal people, who aren't going to be intimated or bothered by my history. Blake chuckles, you sure that’s the reason. He was thinking the same. I shrug, I won't deny Elina was a friend, but yeah. Nothing ever happened between us. I was just a frequent customer of her. You can ask her yourself about a guy name Mack who was an IT guy.

Marina laughs, that’s what you went with. And she never figured you were a fake. I say, I can be very convincing when I want to. That made her dismiss any thoughts of my ulterior motive. To make sure they really don't get any more ideas I explained it was a process and Drew encouraged to do it. I only chose to do it under a different identity. After making sure they understood that we were just friends, I told them how Peter barged in and took off with them.

From here, I told them exactly what I did. I found his actions suspicious, no GPS on his car hinted at something very criminal. As I explained, they questioned me like I was witness to the event. Which I was, in a way. Then M played the recording from the conversation. Blake had a serious expression downed, probably trying to see if the events match from the interrogations he did with others. Marina looks at me suspiciously when the recording begins to show my intervention.

I think she just was skeptical about its authenticity. I don't blame her. Thankfully, from her on out, M had probably starting taking video too. M had a surveillance camera on me all the time once I smashed the EMF Kuritine. They both kept questioning my decisions and fighting style, for the time being I told them I had a reason. They eyes widen at my reckless assault on the three people. I actually hadn't seen this myself yet. I was amused at my own struggles. I kept making mental notes about the fight itself. My Kuret control was shoddy and inefficient. I was critiquing my own mistakes.

The little show ends when I see myself come out of the building, half carrying by the ART bot and drove off. I say, that’s enough M. I turn to face the two of them, they expression was a little nervous, like they saw some like of movie. Blake puts his hand on his chin, you tricked the hell out of them. Is this the whole video. I was confused, this is everything man. What's the point in hiding anything now. Marina laughs, this is even crazier when you manipulated the entire flag capture game.

I say, I won't deny nor confirm that. But, sure. I'll accept the praise from both if you want. Marina pouts at me for teasing. Blake says, Nathan was right. Only you be pull something like this. You know Cory was reluctant to talk to us. Even when Rose infected her with her Kuret. Now I can see why he was so emotional about this. This is first time hearing of this, you are talking about the same woman who tried to control us years back. I moment later something clicked, I see. Nathan and Rose were both there. They were assisting you with the questioning. That’s a good idea. But I am surprised you allowed them.

Blake sneers, I had no choice. I was desperate for some answers. I didn't invite them though, they barged in. Vanessa was ready to throw them out. I managed to make them agree to some terms and allowed them in. Marina asks, is she the one who can seduce men and control them with her Kuret. Blake and I both had a scowl now. I answer, to be clear, she can influence peoples actions. Not control. Blake answers, and not just men. Everyone. She just has better effect on men. Marina backs down by our sudden clarification. She knows little of our history with the Valley.

She says, I was just asking. Calm down guys. I didn't mean like that. Blake scoffs, anyways. Yeah, we got Cory talking. He pretty much told us what you showed. But shouldn't you already know all this. Seeing as you bugged IDF. Marina jerks up, you did what. Not cool man. And you think why Vanessa is mad at you. I cut in, hold on. Don't just assume things. I didn't bug IDF. What's the point when I can get the details from our own officers in IDF. Blake asks, don't lie dude. You sent a message to us exactly when Nathan called you out.

I nod, I said I didn't bug IDF. I bugged Peter. That made him back off. I say, I told you. I made a plan. I decided to tag Peter and let him go. I thought he would go somewhere, maybe to other members of the criminal smugglers, or maybe the people responsible for stealing the drug. I was certain he stole it at that time. His behaviors made sense, using his siblings as a cover. I put a GPS tracker on the bug too. I was constantly monitoring his every movement. But that plan went to shit when he just surrendered himself.

Blake was in deep thoughts and then speaks up, that was, he thinks for a moment, clever. Marina smiles, gosh. I wished if really led anywhere. I just want to kill the person who poison me. You sure he didn't contact anyone before he got arrested. I shook my, I was monitoring his every move. He just hid in a construction site all the time, not even the slightest hint of contact or any kind of message. It was a good plan, but I am annoyed that I didn't get the result I wanted.

Blake says, I interrogated Elina and Peter myself. I am very sure they are have nothing to do. I was interested in this and I asked him to tell what he learned from Elina and Cory. He told the two of us about Elina's injuries and the accounts of the story from her perspective. Turns out before I arrived the scene, they had been arguing the same thing repeatedly. I clench my teeth a little when he told she was crying at her guilt by not protecting Ryan. It wasn't her fault. I poorly handled the situation with Ryan. Blake believes she is innocent in this. And want I to believe that too. But I had a nagging feeling I couldn't put it behind me. Why was Wyan so sure she stole it from them.

Once he finished explaining Cory's interrogation I say, I also believe they were not behind the theft. They were just hired muscles. Marina becomes mad, let me have a go with them. They might not be behind it, but they must know who did it. Blake thinks for moment, I don't know if it’s a good idea. Marina stomps her fist on the couch, come on. I have been keeping it in for while, but I haven't forgotten about it when David told me in the car. One of them must have seen this client.

I say, you aren't wrong. While I have a strong believe none of them stole it for themselves, they might know something about the person who made them smuggle in the drugs. Marina nods, yeah. Exactly. You allowed Catherine to do her own investigation. Let me in too. Blake pulls a weak smile, I knew you would say that. He sighs, I couldn't stop her. Definitely don't have any right to stop you too. Just give me a day. Okay. I will bring you in once we get everyone's story straight.

I ask M, did anyone wake up in the detention center M. M says, 3 people have been woken up boss. Lance, Wyan and Jade had the least injuries had woke up ten minutes ago. I don't have the latest update on them however. Blake grabs his phone, which was done updating with the software patch. After a minute checking the network messages he says, they all are being interrogated now. And looks like Rose and Nathan are back at it again with Cory.

Marina asks, I am guessing you can't speed up the investigation by telling the whole story we just saw. Blake smiles at me, unfortunately no. As much as it pains for me to let us go through unnecessary witness questioning, we have to make it happens properly. Especially once we bring in Citradel in the loop. I think I know what you are trying to achieve my hiding your involvement. I got curious, lets hear it then. Marina and I listen to his theory, I bet you want to make it look like they had an internal struggle and basically self destructed. All the people, including the warriors, believe they were fighting each other. So even the people who brought the drugs would think that. Not realizing that we are on to them, following their trail.

He hit the mark. Marina asks, so is that it. I nod, yup. Its simple in theory, but it was pain in the ass to actually do it. You saw it yourself, I couldn't fight normally against them. All 3 were very strong. I remained skeptical about the plan until you just told what Cory thought happened. Blake laughs, I believe you. Talking on all three of them was definitely reckless. Marina nods, you got lucky dude. Don't get a big head just because you took the down. She was trying to make it look it wasn't a big deal, but I saw hesitation from her. I smile, thanks for your consideration. I know I was lucky.

Blake asks, anyways. What else you planned. It can't be just this, right. He was right again. I answer, you already know I took their phones. But I will return it to you. Once I have hacked into them and copied their contents, I will drop them someplace outside, inside a water pipe. The same pipe I broke the hatch from inside. Hopefully your team thinks it was the rouge bodyguard of Wyan that took it away, but had to leave behind for some reason. I will make it look like he had no choice but to leave it.

Blake scoffs, covering your own tracks in the process huh. Seems doable to make them believe it. I shook my head, no. Keep your hands clear of it. Don't steer the investigation in anyway that is not based on the facts. Marina snaps her finger, right, we don't want the people behind to know we know about this too. I say, exactly. You need to handle this like the mess it was earlier, before Nathan rudely opened his mouth. Blake giggles, he got you good huh. I wished Nathan would think before calling me out openly. I guess that’s the risk I have to take when dealing with him.

Blake says, I won't cause unnecessary intervention. I understand everything now, but you need to tell why you think the client who used them to smuggle the drugs, are the ones who stole it from them too. I say, M, open the information you found about the drugs. All eyes turn to the hologram forming in the middle of the table. M says, hers are the 3 drugs stolen, MCTL, Hetrox and Pesphinate. M showed the drug compound and its effects for them to read.

Blake says, Pesphinate was also one. But Peter didn't mention that one. I nod, I know. I heard your questioning. I think he just forgot about the last one. He was scared out of his mind in the hanger when I attacked them. Its best to think he is an unrealizable witness for anything related to the fight. Blake says, that lines up. His story didn't align perfectly with what really happened. Guess he was in shock. They both resume reading the details of the third compound.

Marina ask, Low boiling point. Would evaporate on contact to air. Is that why we didn't find this in the residue of the poison. I reply, exactly. We missed it. But read the rest. See for yourself something contradictory. She gets anxious reading the rest of it. Once they read, they caught on the subtle difference of the effectiveness of the drug. Blake says, this makes no sense. If this is correct, Pesphinate would have a positive effect on a Medrone. A mix of steroids, adrenaline and some other stuff that promotes energy consumption. Isn't this the opposite of what it did to Marina.

I point my index finger at him, that’s the contradictory part. Why would it cause a negative reaction to you Marina. Maybe a basic biological compatibility issue, could be. But a more realistic explanation is. I waited for her to come to that conclusion, the poison I got didn't have this. What does that mean. I explained, M had a digital sample of both your poisons. So she was able to find a find very faint traces of Pesphinate on the second poison. The one meant for Blake.

Blake looks to me, the poison for me was different. I nod, yes it was. Its virtually undetectable, unless you look for Pesphinate specifically. Actually, calling it a poison is wrong. This specific compound when mixed in the correct combination will produce a reaction that promotes Kuret production in Medrones cells. Of course, there will some damage by forcing your body to go beyond your natural Kuret limit. But it isn't life threating, at least not to you. So Isn't this strange. Poisoning Marina to make her lose, but forcing to max out your Kuret reserve to make you win. What's the objective from this weird outcomes.

They both are completely baffled now. Marin tugs on her hair ends, what's the point in doing this. I thought they wanted just take out me and Blake from the finals. But now it looks like they wanted to keep Vanessa and Blake in and me out. Blake realizes something, no. That can't be. He made the connection. Marina asks, what. I answer, it makes sense if the people behind this is not Citradel, but someone from the island. Its the only thing that makes

sense. They should believe that too now.

I laid it out to them in simple terms, I never told this before, but I had initially hypothesized that they didn't want the Citradel champion to fight at all in the finals. And that means, taking out strong contenders. Marina, you were a wild card. Since you were outspoken about joining us here, its very possible they thought you would switch side any time. So to make sure that never happened, they poisoned you for extra measure. Blake was a real threat to them, so he was targeted. Me and Vanessa were apparently not deemed a threat, so they us left us alone. Derek was connected to Kafar and couldn't switch sides. This is what I thought had happened. Until today.

Marina says, that’s rude. I wouldn't do that. I scoff, didn't you do something similar this morning. Marina rebukes, that's different. I didn't think it was that different. Blake says, but that’s not true anymore. If Citradel was behind this, they wouldn't want me to beat you and instead fight Charles. I nod, yeah. So that means Citradel can't be behind this. Someone carefully crafted the narrative that looked like we were being targeted and wanted Citradel to win. They almost got away too. If I hadn't heard about the drugs myself, I would still be looking into Kafar or Citradel.

Marina waves her hand, but even if that’s true. Why do you think its one of the officers who stole the drugs. It could be literally anyone. Blake answers, it could be anyone. But more than likely, its one of us. If you think about it, covering up crimes at this scale is impossible without help from the inside. Marina says, you mean they are hiding evidence. He nods, we recovered a stash of hidden weapons few months back. We still have no clue who got it. Now I don't know if it was bought from the same people, but something feels wrong here. How come no one saw anything suspicious. Not a single report. Marina says, when you put it like that it does makes sense that someone is inside. Do you think the boss works with him.

I say, doubt it. Otherwise they would be there too. And even if he has someone among us, why keep questioning Peter and his siblings about the stolen drugs. Its more plausible that they are not together. I didn't make the connection from the weapons found months ago. It may or may not be related. But I agree that someone should have seen something. They were giving smuggled stuff to their clients in public spots. And besides that, the water treatment plant wasn't just a perfect location. They held the meeting exactly when the patrols would be away. A literal blind spot in the city.

Marina says, I learned today that officers shits and patrols are scheduled and predictable. Couldn't they have just observed and figured it out from that. Blake answers, that’s what even more suspicious. The routes are scheduled. But we have a set of officers blended in the crowed, regular clothes and cars. You haven't been told about them yet. So to avoid even them, it means they know who they are and where they are at all times. Marina scoffs, you guys don't mess around with the security here. Whose idea was this ? She turns to me.

I wave my hand, I had no idea about this. Blake raises his eyebrows to me, I really didn't know. I left a lot of the internal mechanics of the city to others. Its a good idea though. He smiles, it was Vanessa's idea. She wanted make this place more secure than the Valley. If even you didn't know about it, that means it works. But then his smile drops, or maybe not since it got leaked to those smugglers. Marina asks, it still doesn't mean one of the officers is behind it. Blake answers, it still doesn't mean its impossible.

I add, either way, I believe that someone used Wyan to deliver them the drugs, but didn't want to pay or keep a trail. So they stole it from them to cover their involvement. We have their phones and the records will soon be in our hands, but that only gets us the people who smuggled in other stuff. Not the one we want our hands on. Blake says, so you think we won't find them on that data. I says, maybe something will be there. Who knows. Maybe even Wyan knows something. But someone went great lengths to remain hidden while poisoning Marina, juicing you, and using a secret criminal group as a patsy. I don't think they leave behind obvious evidence.

Marina asks, jeez. Sounds like it could be you when you say it like this. I smirk noticing the similarities. Wyan was good at this. But I can't believe he is good enough to do all of this. She asks, so what's the game plan now. They both turn to me for this. I shrug, I don't have one. Remember, I was banking on Peter to lead me somewhere. That was a bust. It was a spur of the moment decision, but I was betting on something to pan out from it. Blake says, what about the people we are holding then. They could be in danger. If someone knows something, they could be poisoned. We know they have the ways to make it happen.

That is real possibility, I concurred. Marina makes a depressing expression, so we need to guard these people. I rather see them dead. Her aversion this action was evident because it was personal for her. I added, best you get as much as information from them as soon as possible. The longer this drags on, the more danger it is for anyone. Those people behind this might retaliate in unexpected ways. Blake nods, that’s troubling to even think about. He looks to the floor thinking about his next moves.

Marina asks me, what about getting help from others. Surely we can trust some people to help us. I thought about her suggestion. It wasn't a bad one. If we were free to act on our own, we would be out there searching ourselves. However, we all have others work to do. We have responsibility and can't exactly move freely enough to do our Shadow work. And like Marina said, I did put Catherine as a distraction and bait. I said I won't stop her, didn't mean I wasn't going to keep an eye on her moves from afar.

I answer, we do need help. I can't deny it. If I didn't have a massive match coming up, I would have time to this myself. None of us are really available to undertake a untangling an internal conspiracy right now. Blake says, we should have people who we trust. I gave a better suggestion, better to find people who have zero benefit in sabotaging the tournament. Trust is a fickle thing, being on the receiving end from many people, I can assure you of that. Blake thinks for a moment, you mean getting someone from the Citradel. I nod, yes. If an officer is behind it, the safest bet is to look in other communities for help. Naturally, Citradel is good ally for this. They are merging with us soon, no reason to betray us now.

Marina says, if that’s who you want. You can leave that me. I know some decent people who we can actually trust. But what if they have people in Citradel too. She made another good point. Blake asks, we just have to pick people we really can count on then. Have very limited people involve in this. I add, just don't tell anyone of my involvement. I want to keep it hidden at all cost. Blake asks, seriously. Didn't you just talk about trust. I countered, didn't I tell Catherine that anyone beside us, more specifically me, might be a big target. I wasn't talking about just trust, I am worried to involve people who aren't trained like us. You involved Catherine, so I had no choice but to take her help, but asking others to get involved with me isn't exactly fair. I am always someone's target. Better me than others.

I hope this was good enough to make them believe my intention. Marina says, yeah. He is right, Blake. We are trained for this, and we can take care of our own. We both are already outed as Shadows, keeping David acting separately works in our favor. Blake wasn't convinced. I could the conflicting thoughts in his face. Speaking of people to trust, I think its time I tell them. I sigh, if you want some trustworthy people, why don't you have involve your new Shadow recruits. They seem to be skilled enough to work as a team.

Marina nods, yeah. Blake, we should use them. I have been thinking about it too. They are. She pauses and turns to me immediately with her jaw slightly opened. They both freeze up, their faces blank with utter confusion. Blake's hand slipped from his position. That made me laugh, what. Did I say something wrong. Blake asks, you knew? I say, that you both were already formed a new Shadow team behind my back. Yeah, I figured it out a while ago. Marina a gulps hard, what. Why didn't you tell us. I reply, I didn't want to interfere in it. I trusted you both were good enough to train them in our Shadow ways.

Blake asks, for real. Do you not know anything. I smile, if you are asking if I know who they are. Then I do. If I could infiltrate a Shadow summit as a kid, I can find their identities too. Marina shook her head, I should have known. We didn't tell you because you said you wanted time. I thought it was just because you just got your memories, but now I know it was more than that. I don't want you to feel like we excluded you or anything like that. She was panicking a little.

Blake supports her, with the past you did tell us about, I thought you didn't want to be involved in Shadows anymore. Neither of them were wrong. I say, appreciate it guys. Honestly, I do needed some time to figure things out. You know what's funny, since I always planned to quit, I never panned to groom a next Shadow. And I am the worst kind of teacher one could hope for. I am not oblivious to my own thinking. I know that I would demand high standards from someone I want to replace me. Plus you two must been shaping them for quite some time. I wasn't going to change that in any way. But I don't know how long you have been training them.

Marina answers, its been about two years now. Once I met Blake in Citradel, he proposed this to me then. Blakes says, I just didn't want our tradition to end like this. So we started to look for people during the year you were missing. In a perfect world, we would have recruited kids, but situation has changed. It's much better to recruit experienced adults instead. Marina leans back, you should have told us you knew dude. It would have helped with their training. Blake agrees with the her sentiment.

I say, I will now. I wasn't in the stable enough mindset before. I am still not completely. But once my match with Charles is over, I will help out in anyway I can. Blake asks, does that mean you will look for your successor too. I smile, that I will put on hold. I don't think I am ready for that yet. He says, fair enough. It took us a while too. Marina then gets excited, so. You know who they are. What do you think of them. I gave her my honest opinion, since you didn't know our Shadow history, you did what you thought was right. And I gotta say, they aren't your typical Shadow candidates. There is still room for improvement in their individual capabilities, but they do form a pretty good team.

They both sat up straight, they were proud of it. Marina asks curious, how do you know they are good though. I say, how else. I tested them during the tournament. If I were the mastermind behind that event, I would also see how good they work as a team. Marina scoffs, give it a rest will you. Everyone knows that was all you. I smile while Blake says, leave it. Its like a sickness with him. Just how long will he keep denying that.

I ignore their gazes, I observed their matches. Two of them have moves that were definitely straight from Shadow manual. It must have been tough to train in disciplines you aren't an expert in. Blake sighs, more like impossible. We know the theory, but not the actual practical training. We only guided them, the rest was on their own effort. I nod, they are good. I can help out them out too from now on. I have pretty good grasp on all different Shadow training. Hansen used to show me the sessions with all Shadows.

I turn to Marina, your successor. You pretty much chose someone whose Kuret was similar to yours. She nods, yeah. Funny how without knowing, I still stuck to the same tradition. Blake says, its obvious it would happen. If our family trained us, we would naturally gravitate towards Kuret that behave like ours. I nod, that did happen in a way. I don't have any qualms with your choice, Marina. He is skilled and adaptable. He does lack the power though, but its not his fault. Its not a fair comparison since very few can compete with you.

Marina flashes her teeth with a smug face, I am so relieved you said that. You know Blake has had doubts since beginning. Blake cuts in, hey. Don't say that. I was just concerned. He might be skilled, but he seems even more unpredictable than you. She replies, he is perfect for me to train. Blake denies it, oh come on. Not that again. You are unleashing another one of you. She says, excuse me. That’s is hella rude. I am guessing its not first time they debated like this. I say, must have been hard to do this on all your own huh.

Blake turns to me, it has been rough. Hopefully your involvement will make it easier. I say, but I am not sold on your successor, Blake. Marina slaps her hand on his shoulder, See, I told you. He wouldn't be fine with yours. Blake shoves her hand, of course you have an opinion on my decision. I ask, did you really thought I wouldn't say anything. Blake sighs, no, I guess not. It wasn't a something I did lightly. I needed someone who has the potential to have what it takes to be Shadow attacker. Means raw strength. You saw for yourself. Do you deny it.

I answer, skill wise, I don't have any issues. I am concerned is loyalty. You know who is constantly around us. What happens when there is a choice between Shadow mission and personal affairs. What will be prioritized more. Blake says, believe me, I had the same anxiety. But didn't you said yourself, Shadows need people with correct skills and judgement. Not their personality and ties to people. He got me there. I couldn't refute that reasoning. I sigh, I am not asking you to choose someone else. I just don't want history to repeat yourself. Even if you didn't know, your dad picked Wagner. Whatever his intensions were, it caused internal strife among us. I hope you know what you are doing.

He remained silent, trying to contemplate his actions with this new information. Marina says, since everything is the open now. Shall we bring them into the fold. I nod, I know their skills and effectiveness as a team. But not personally. But if you trust them, then I don't have a problem. They would be a valuable asset. Marina raises her fist and cheers. Blake was little bit excited too. I guess this is their first official mission now. Weird how in just one year I remember being a Shadow to training new generation of Shadow. Its a little strange to think about it. But it wasn't like I was doing nothing last few years. I might not have known I as a Shadow, but I was certainly behaving like one. However, the prospect of teaching someone is not in my forte. Don't know how good I can be.

I looked at the time and decided this is enough. I say, I think its enough for one night. I turn to the side, M, are the tickets booked. M says, I got you the first flight at 8 AM from Beijing. I say, that gives me around 6 hours of sleep. Well, I'll take what I can get. Blake asks, what was that. Marina asks, you going somewhere. I say, we are involving others because we are busy. You think I wasn't. I need to go and contact people to gather the construction materials Marina asked for. She becomes anxious, shit. I totally forgot about that. Do you have to leave today for that.

I lean back into the chair, its not as easy as you think. I need to meet my contacts and get help from them in person. Blake says, can't you do it from here? I shook my head, if it weren't for those bulk amounts, I could have managed. But getting everything in time means in need to move them fast myself. I don't like leaving things like this on you both, but I have to priorities this first. Blake says, can't complain since I had to dump this one on you first. I will authorize your travel for tomorrow morning. When will you be back.

I had a rough estimate, give me two days. I need to make 3 stops in 2 continents. I turn to Marina, I will get around 95 % of the total stuff you want. Is that be enough to get you started for a few days until the remaining comes in. Marina thinks about it for a moment, if you can get all of Platinum, then yeah. We get started while we wait for rest of the other materials. I say to M, adjust the quantities to priorities for Platinum first. M says, adjusting the algorithm. I turn to Blake, if you need anything from me, contact M on your phone. The software patch installed just now can also connect to her server. Blake picks his phone from the table and puts it in his pocket, got it. I will handle the investigation my side.

There was one last thing I wanted to ask them, before we call it a night, one more thing. I got from the chair and they both did the same from the couch, its more like a favor. Once I return, I will have to start my focus on my training. The last fight showed me that I am lacking severely in Kuret control and techniques. Marina asks, isn't that because you haven't recovered. I answer, that’s true, but its not just that. I have relied on physical techniques assisted by my Kuret. But now, I have hit the limit I can improve in this aspect.

Blake says, I think I get what you mean. You want to now learn Kuret techniques assisted by physical strength. The normal way Medrones train. He caught on pretty quick, I was able to turn my Kuret nature a little bit. When I fought Charles, it was the pressure of the match that made me unconsciously pull out new techniques. Tonight I tried them again, and I barely attained the Kuret form. It was a fluke during my fight with Charles. To get to that state again, I need to train like you guys from now on.

Blake turns confused, you want me to train you. I nod. Marina laughs, really? But isn't Shadow techniques are not based on Kuret. I say, I am not asking to learn Shadow tricks. I am asking for a sparring partner. I have always learned from others how to use Kuret. That hasn't changed. I think if you help me out, I can improve a lot faster than on my own. Blake takes a second to answer, this is unexpected. I can understand how it may seem to him, but I have roughly 28 days only. I have to get help to reach the level I need to fight an overdrive user.

I turn to Marina, I need your help too. Marina shocked shook her head, me? What can I do to help you. I say, I can use others Kuret because of you. I analyzed your overdrive from your matches. Using your charms, the markers of the Kuret bloodline I know, as a basis, I was able to pull off both gathering and firing off different Kurets. Marin eye widened and scoffs, you are joking right. That is not possible. I nod, normally it shouldn't be. But did made it work.

Blake turns to Marina, please tell me he is joking. Or did you help him cheat by using some Kuretine. Marina is bamboozled at this, I didn't do anything. Certainly did not him cheat. She faces me, show me. I smile, I would like to. But right now Kuret is burnt out. You saw earlier how weak I am right now. I will show it when I come back. Marina says, all right fine. But what help do you need from me if you already can do this. I say, I need to figure out a way to reduce the time to prepare it. I will explain everything later, but I know that once I show you how I do it, you can help me to optimize it.

Marina puts her index finer on her chin and scratches it thinking about it. I asked something ridiculous of her. No, both of them. They take few seconds to think about it. Blake asks, you want both of us to train you. In less than a month. Are you sure you will be able to handle such arduous regimen? Marina adds, we are talking about two different school of training. I answer, this is a lot. I can understand, but I need to improve on both fronts. I need to learn my new Kuret form, from you Blake. And from you Marina, how to improve my Kuret storm. So, how about it. While I am asking for your help, you might benefit too.

Blake chuckles, that’s actually enticing. I always wondered what it looks like to be, well you and train. Marina says, that is not good enough for me. I was one time a total naïve and beaten down many times when I was with James. She needed more incentive to join in, you know about your mom's charms book. I can. Marina cuts in realizing my intention, yeah, that’s already done deal. I used my Averna charm during the match. You will help me unlock those restricted pages, no matter what. Her piercing gaze is sharp and points to me, you can't offer that again. I smirk, let me finish. I will help you unlock those pages. But did you know there are hidden pages too. That caught her off guard. She closes in towards me and becomes grim, what do you know about it.

That’s a surprise, I didn't know she already had found them. Based on her reaction, she knows about it, not actually found them. I grab her shoulders and lightly push her back, chill. I know there are few forbidden pages. I don't know how many. Marina locks her eyes on me with ferocious intent. She blurts out, how do you know about them. I say, how do you think. Istra told me herself. I remembered a memory of her few months back. I was just a semi temporary apprentice at your home, but for some reason she told me about it.

Marina gasps, she showed it you. Why. I shook my head, she only talked about it. I have no clue why she shared it with me. Maybe she thought I would forget it. Or she was just messing with me. I didn't know at that point that she was in Shadows, but she knew who I was. That’s the best guess I can think of why she tell me about it. Marina punches me in the arm, why in the hell is she sharing family secrets you. I say, I know, right. I have no freaking clue. Marina face contorts in anger, first authorizing you to be in the ship. Now this. She crooks her head to the ceiling, Mom. You better have a good reason for doing this, otherwise I am going to tear that book in half.

I wish I knew why Istra did all of this. I can't think of any reason other than me being a Shadow strategist. Marina faces me back, huh. You win again. You are the worst. Taking advantage of me only when it suits you. You could have told me anytime during the match, but no. You waited this long instead. I wasn't going to let this one slide, hold on. I would have told you, eventually. But part of the challenge is for you to figure it out yourself. That in it self your training. Didn't you said so yourself. You wanted to do the challenge yourself. I was always going to be a guide.

That calmed her down a little. She then says, you think that makes it okay. I can't help it. I feel cheated by own mother. She sighs, so I guess you will only give me hints then. I nod, you guess right. Even though she told me about the 2 pages hidden, all I know is the location. She scoffs, that is already a big clue. Blake had been quite for a while, letting us hash it out. He asks, ah, just asking, how big is this book. Marina says, 1024 pages. And each page has a 10 sections.

Since Blake never saw it himself, he couldn't understand what this all really meant. But he still could understand that if Marina couldn't figure it out all this time, it was well hidden. He asks, is it safe though. The forbidden seems pretty dangerous. Marina waves her hand to him, that’s just a silly term to scare of my other members. I am very certain she has seen it herself. Though, it's probably only for people in my family who can overdrive. Isn't that right.

I shrug, don't know about that. She mocks, of course you don't. I ask her to confirm, so, can I count on you. She laughs, I guess so. You are just taking advantage of me though. She teases me about it, but I know she was very happy inside. I turn to Blake. He sighs, like I will back down now. I am in too.

This is good, I am sure I can figure out way to defeat Charles in his overdrive form now.

Vanessa (Chapter 80)

Wednesday, January 21, 2026 15:07

This is the latest reports of the latest interrogation, I have sent a recording to you as well, a few page note drops on the table in front of me. Ruther says, we got 5 statements now. I stared at it as it was added to the rest of the pile. Deni asks, let me guess, they claim to the same thing. He nods, same as others. Nothing new. I remained silent and looked away through my office window. The sun is setting down already. But the day is not over yet. Not until we mope up the mess that David as left us.

Last night, Blake asked us to keep his involvement a secret. Others were in agreement with him, but I wasn't. Blake was also frustrated that David didn't tell any of us. But then this morning, he told me and Tessa to forget about it. Obviously I couldn't accept this. I rebelled a little against his order because I was done with Davids' antics. He really is the worst kind of person. Knows everything about others, but keeps his own things private. I am not going to help him lie anymore.

My stance on this had made Blake uneasy, so he personally told me the situation. David had no choice when he raided the plant. I never once realized until Blake told me, but David actually had tried to reach out us. I confirmed it when I saw his miss call on my phone when I was busy. Turns out he wanted our backup before his one man army assault. He hadn't recovered fully, but since there were warriors involved and the patrol officers couldn't fight them, he had go in alone. I was too angry and so I just told Blake I will need time to think. As the day went on, I realized I was being childish. David is apparently hunting the guys who poisoned Marina and attempted on Blake.

With heavy reluctance, I decided this plan, to make the real culprits behind think they self destructed, was actually very clever. As much I hate David right now, he wasn't wrong. I was mad at myself, at Blake and Marina who got manipulated again by David. What's worse is that I know that David didn't lie, but I can't feel it this way. He can't keep getting away with this, lying when it suits him. Not trusting me when it suits him. After seeing Wyan's interrogation, all the little objections I had was gone.

Wyan tried to plead he was not involved and tried to blame on Grover who attacked him. At the same time, Grover blamed the entire thing on Wyan trying to cover his ass. We had enough evidence once others woke up. Their Kuret signature was all over the smuggled goods. Wyan had to knew he was going to cop to this sooner or later. It took a while, but he broke under Tessa's interrogation few hours back. He admitted to being the leader of their smuggling operation. But he is trying to get out from harsher punishment by making a deal by giving us access to the data. He was sure that no one can get to it, apart from him. Jade has the data, but he claims only he can access it.

No way we were going to play ball with him. So I had confined to his prison cell while we get to the records holding all the clients information. The reports I got from all the people say different views, but the same story. They were attacked by traitors amongst them. Few people claim that they were attacked by the warriors. But the most ridiculous part is that no one saw their faces. They are so scared and confused that they believed the Kuret attacking them were from them.

Nathan and Rose have been working on Cory this morning. They somehow broke through his mental resistance and fessed up everything. He told us how he and Polly were in close combat. I didn't believe him until then, but now. fully infected by Rose, he confirmed he was in fact fighting Polly. In the end Polly took him out. Until his confession, rumors going around some outsider involvement died down slowly. They are current working on Polly now to corroborate the story. Rose said she was today much more prepared and assured me she will crack Polly much faster.

I didn't even care about her ego, but I didn't stop her. The faster she works, the better for us. Now most of us focusing our effort on gathering evidence and catching everyone involved in this. This all his doing all right. That freaking guy made everyone believe people were fighting each other. Not just that, but if Polly and Quintin say the same story, people will slowly begin to think it was a internal struggle that resulted in mutual destruction. I had no choice after listening to people blaming each other and messaged Blake that I agreed to the ridiculous plan of theirs.

I thought nothing would make me madder when I had to accept David getting away with this. But then my mood turned even worse. Ned finally contacted me after lunch, with a voice message on the phone. I immediately deleted it. If has something to say, he better come to me and say it to my face. I didn't want others to see me distracted with personal things, so I have been focusing on this case. I don't know if I am making it worse by doing ignoring it, all I know is that Ned is too stubborn by keeping his distance. I am trying hard to see his side, but I just can't think why he is behaving this way. I know I was in the wrong first, but he is not blameless too.

Somers asks me, are you listening Vanessa? This pulled me out of my mind. I ask, sorry. What. Sommer was standing with Denu and Ruther behind the table. Sommers asks, I was asking if you listened to the reports I sent about the searches we did of their houses and their work places. I pushed those meddling thoughts and got my game face back on, yeah. I listened to them. We recovered nothing that lies to any other smuggled stuff. But Jades apartment was booby trapped, is that right.

He nods, clearly she thought it would be destroyed if it was anyone but her, but we got to the floor safe before it activated the trap and disintegrated the whole floor. Ruther says, these guys are very resourceful. They used and electrical jamming Kuritines earlier, and now its Corys rotting Kuretine. They have some serious backing from if they are able to create such unregulated Kuritines. I lean back on the chair, they are no doubt the biggest group of criminals we caught. Deni asks, did we though. I know I have been asking this many times, but are you sure we shouldn't have a team looking into who beat them all up.

Since I promised not to mention David here, I have to switch everyone's focus instead. I didn't want to lie to them, so I been telling them that Blake and Marina have been looking into it. I say, do you doubt the Shadow team can't figure it out. She clamps up, no. I don't mean that. I am sure they are good. But they are busy themselves. I just wanted to end this thing quickly. Even during my lunch, my friends keep asking about this. She wasn't alone, the entire IDF has been swarming with reporters and concerned citizens.

Blake had addressed them all in front of a camera in the morning. Explaining the facts, and ensuring that this is an isolated event which is already contained. People don't have to be worried about it since we have everyone already in custody. He didn't give any specifics, like what they were smuggling, or why were they found unconscious. I proposed Peter as the fall guy. Blake said no since we can't exactly say how Peter remained unscraped when warriors were gravely injured.

It wouldn't be difficult to frame him. No, actually. He is really the root cause of all this mayhem. He may not have stolen the drugs, but he got his siblings involved. I am very sure David had to step in to save their lives. I tell her, I know its frustrating. But we have no proof that anyone was involved. Yesterday, that was me and Blake just guessing as we got info from Peter. Once we found the mini safe with their phones in the site, I decided it wasn't worth the effort to look into it now.

David must have took it with him, copied then contents and then dumped in the water pipe in the middle of the night. He meticulously placed it inside a water pipe part of an elaborate escape attempt. Roland told us how he found it. There was some destruction in one of the control rooms. It looked like someone tried to escape, which we know now, it was Kiera. She was fighting Polly at the time, or so she claims. Roland thought that like her, people might be using similar escape routes and investigates all the water pipes. That’s how they recovered all the phones.

Somers says, true. But its very suspicious. Roland team found the broken hatch, signs of a struggle and the safe box inside. But seriously, why would anyone leave it there. Isn't it important. Ruther says, someone tried to leave with it and failed. We have a guy saying he broke open the door and got dragged back in by Quintin. It wouldn't surprise if those three initially beat all the people and then fought each other. Deni cuts in, I don't believe that. Cory says he didn't attack any other person.

Somers says, I don't think he is reliable. He lied about Wyan ordering him to hunt the traitors. Wyan says he didn't. All I know its very strange about the inconsistences in the story. I sigh. David really created a big mess by confusing everyone, not just those criminals. People have been speculating now that we have listened to many of the people in custody. What's incredible is how he wiped his fingerprints off this completely. Even I come out and explain this, how am I going to refute that Cory and Polly fought for real.

While they were arguing over a little, I cut in, that’s enough guys. They all stop their chattering and face me. I got up from my chair and say, the bottle line is, until we get some evidence or at least some kind of clue that someone else is involved, I don't want to waste time on this. So, is there any shred of evidence apart from the circumstance itself. I knew there was none, but I laid it out so that they leave it alone. Three heads shaking confirmed it.

Honestly, I really want to find one. So that once I prove it that it was David, I will publicly lash him out. I know it goes against David's plan, but if he left evidence for me to find, then his plan was never going to work. Plus, I only agreed to not reveal David's involvement, I didn't agree to suppressing or hindering the investigation itself. That might teach David to not mess with me again. I ask, all right then. Lets get to cracking their phones and the records. Where are we on that.

Ruther says, everyone's phones are heavily encrypted. Its taking time to get in without triggering any failsafe. We are requesting for some additional servers from the other departments. With additional computing power, I have got an estimate of 12 to 18 hours. I rest my hands on my waist, its going to take that long huh. I guess it’s a waiting game for now. And what about the hard drive we recovered. Sommers says, that is even worse. X rays shows that there is physical traps, like an acid kill box inside it. We make a wrong move and it will destroy everything.

I click my tongue, so that’s why Wyan is so smug about this and making it look like he is holding all the cards. Deni says, we can't take any deals from him. I agreed, and no one will. What are the options. Sommers says, we are exploring none Kuret options for now. By using human tech, he has made sure we have very slim chance with any Kuret being effective. But still, I have asked everyone here to look for any personal who knows any Kuritines or a Kuret user that can do this.

I ask, are you searching for any civilians too ? Somers says, I wanted to ask for your permission first. Right now I am looking only for officers and others in the administration. I began to weigh the options and say, do it. But don't approach anyone if you think someone can help. Just tell me first. I will talk to Luther and then involve others. Sommers pulls out his tablet and types in the order to his team. I turn to Deni, where are we in finding others who are involved.

Deni opens her tablet and says, apart from the 11 people involved, we are suspecting 8 more. We got 3 of them and brought them in an hour ago. I scoff, let me guess, the five others are in the wind. She says, for now. We know their names and checking with their friends and families. They got nowhere to run. I am sure we will find them tomorrow. I say, we shouldn't take any chances though. Inform our border team to have double shifts. Some are guaranteed to try and break though the barrier we setup.

Ruther chuckles, good luck with that. No ones ever escaped through it. 14 people have tried in the past 9 months, and all of them failed. I say, I know. But we never know. I am not going to take any chance. Just pull in more people for few more days until we catch all of them. Deni taps her tablet, all right. I will inform the team. Sommers says, you know, this is no doubt very bad for our reputation. Not knowing about such a smuggling operation going on. But I think we will turn it around soon, seeing as we caught every single person involved in one swoop. We can turn this into a very good win and make Citradel see our worth.

I smile. Blake is planning to do this exactly. Our effort to rush this faster before people start coming let to possible advantage. Ruther says, yeah. That’s good. But don't forget we still have a lose end. One the client used the

drugs to poison Marina. And someone stole it too. Deni says, I bet one them did It are still hiding it. Why don't we have Rose interrogate them. I stop her, hell no. I am going to use her only on the warriors. No one else. Her presence is already bad enough and I am tolerating it for now. She and Nathan may be good at this, but they completely unpredictable.

They couldn't deny that. They have only heard stories about the Valley, but if they had seen what I had, they wouldn't want them here too. Sommers says, I figure you wanted to keep it that way. Nathan had asked earlier to Dan about the same thing and I to not allow him. I answer, keep it that way. If one of them did it, they will soon give up. We still have 4 more people unconscious, lets see what they say first. Sommers says, I think its Elina who stole it. Wyan is still claiming she stole from them. I don't see a reason for him to lie when he is already caught.

Elina and Ryan have also been detained. Blake said they are victims, but we couldn't let them go. He think David theory is very convincing, but its possible Elina is still involved and maybe even working with the people who stole the drugs. I didn't find anything strange about her or her story. Regardless, they both are still associated with Peter, so we can't let them go. I ask, what's Elina's condition now. Sommers says, her injuries are healed completely once we called Janathan. She has minor internal sourness, but we have confined both her and Ryan to a safe room. Are you going to question them.

I have been thinking for a while now. But because I had a different agenda. Blake said David tailed the criminals because he was following Peter. I didn't believe it when he told he knows Elina and has been visiting her all this time incognito. Just what kind of bizarre coincidence it that he happens to know the sister of a smuggler. I don't know if this was just a coincidence or David is playing at some angle. So I have waiting for an opportunity to visit her. I have finished most of my work, so this is the best time to ask her some questions.

I nod, yeah. I want to be alone with her a some time. She might respond better if I am talking to her alone. He nods, all right. I'll set it up. You want to go in now. I tell him, in 30 minutes. I have an meeting with Luther right now. So go head and inform her I am coming. He asks, just her or Ryna too. I gave it some thoughts, is he responding to us. He shook his head, he is barely talking to Elina. He refuses to leave her side. Ruther says, poor kid is terrified out of his mind.

I say, okay. Lets not agitate him. I will talk to him too. Sommers nods and we all disperse from my office. They all head back to the IDF, while I takes the stairs to the 3rd floor to Luther's office. As I reached his door I hear voices from inside. I knock on the door, he calls me in. Tessa and Roland were here also sitting in the couch. Luther stand up from his seat, thanks for coming in Vanessa. I wave at others and take the space beside Tessa, sorry if I am late.

Luther slides his chairs to us, not to worry. They were giving me a report before our meeting. Tessa asks, any luck with the hard drive you guys recovered. I say, like everyone suspected, it his not only encrypted, but also has fail safe with acid. So, its going to take a lot of time. Rolan puts his hand on his head, damn. That’s hard core. Luther asks, are you sure you don't want to even entertain the idea of using Rose and Nathan on Wyan or Jade. So this what they probably called me for.

I refuse it, I already told I am not going to allow it. I already hate it that I owe them for doing this much. I don't want their help. If I did take it, and it somehow worked, they would just mean I owe them more. That’s infinitely worse. Luther makes a slight scowl, you too huh. I was hoping you would help change Blake mind too. He also doesn't want to involve them more. Just what kind of history you all have that makes them so untrustworthy. I say, trust me, if I went on, it would take hours.

Tessa backs me, she is not kidding. I was with them only for a little time before coming her, but they barely were a team. I say we are lucky Nathan is on the island, let alone inside the building. Her impartiality make Luther even less confident and raise his hands in defeat, fine. I had to try once. We will try with Rose's other bloodline members. I was okay with that. Roland says, could you send some of them my way too. I am finding hard to get information from two people in particular.

Tessa asks, let me guess, you are still stuck with Grover and Perry. He nods, yeah. We got details about the fight, but I know they know more about the people who are on the run. It would help if I could them to reveal it. Luther turns to me for confirmation. I say, yeah, no issues here. Luther nods, all right. I will ask for some volunteers. Tessa says, Roland, lend them too me too. I'll take a stab at Wyan too and try to get him to open the hard drive. He makes an okay gesture with his fingers.

Luther asks, lets move on to the next topic, tomorrow we are going to have conference call with Citradel at 10 AM. They know some of the details of this incident, but we haven't officially told them anything. Vanessa, can you get all the reports Blake asked before then. I was expecting this to happen, yeah. I can get it done by then. Luther asks, what is left on your plate. I answer, we already discussed about the people on the run and the hard disk. If you guys can handle it before morning, then that’s taken care of.

Tessa says, I will try my best. Roland says, I will catch them, I promise. I say, then the only thing is left getting statement from the 4 people still unconscious. I have asked to wake up the one woman from the Citradel first, so that we will have her involvement confirmed. Luther says, good idea. Citradel can't remain blameless for this miss too, he forms a small smirk saying that. I figured we want to make sure they don't blame us solely for this. Well, they can't exactly do that since Quintin is directly involved in this. But this just hammers in the nail on the entire criminals from Citradel.

I say, next, about the warriors. We are haven't Quintin to also admit his role in this. I believe Nathan and Rose are on Polly, but they should be finished soon. I am allowing them both to remain in IDF the entire night. Tessa says, they are okay with it. I shrug, they also know its important we get the warriors talking before we talk to Citradel. Nathan said he liked the challenge and Rose, well, she just wants to show off. I'll have two people watch them all night. I don’t care there reasons, as long as they keep Quintin talking.

Luther nods, all right. We need those 3’s complete testaments. Its essential to prove they were doing this for their own gains and not someone else. I continue, and for the last report. Unfortunately, we are nowhere close to finding who ordered those drugs involved in poisoning Marina. I know that’s very important, but aside from the hard disk with the records, we have no other lead. No one in their gang knows the identities of their client. Luther says, damn. I was hoping there was something else by now. Marina was this close to breaking into the prison cell and beating the crap out of them. She was so mad, that I thought she punch me when I told her to give me some more time.

I smile, best to her meet them. I start with Peter. Roland shook his head with a small laugh, don't. The guy almost pissed his pants when Blake grabbed him. If Marina gets his her hands on him too, he might jut shit himself. Tessa says, I say let her. Wyan too. That would get them talking. I was so glad that they were on board and pressured Luther. He says with a smirk, thankfully I am not going to decide that. She is a spit fire, and I am going to let Blake make the decision.

He made the right call. Keeping her away from this when its so personal to her would be a mistake. She and Blake are Shadows, both together in same room would scare every one of them. I ask, what about the request Sommers made a while ago. Luther says, oh. Right. He pulls out his laptop from the desk and opens it. He types on the keys while reading on the display. A while later he says, done. We are going to get all the servers we can to IDF right now. Hopefully that will speed up the hacking the devices.

Tessa says to me, I want to take a stab at Elina again. I say, actually, I am going to see her soon. I have some question of my own. Let me know what you want to ask her. She says, that’s great. I can focus back on Wyan again then. She then clears her throat, I got the list of all her shipments and their dimensions. I need to how much of them is really hers. If we can't get the smuggled items from the hard disk, at least we will get some clues on the size and amounts of the smuggled goods. Who knows, we might lucky with some item that stands out and cross reference with other people owning them.

This was actually a very good strategy. She says, admittedly, it’s a long shot. But its better to try this than just wait. I want to use this as a leverage at Wyan. If I get even one of the smuggled items, we will make him believe we hacked into the hard disk and his corporation is not needed. That will shut that smug face of his he has kept all day. I smile. Tessa doesn't get worked up often, but even she was hitting that limit when dealing with Wyan. I nod, all right. I will have Elina look at the list.

Tessa offers me some advice, I already showed her the list before to confirm the shipments, but have her view it differently this time. Also, see if you can keep Ryan away from her. I feel for the kid, but he keeps interrupting Elina. I answer, I heard he isn't talking. She sighs, he has not. Roland says, I would like to know how he got out of there. Peter said he found a door broken open to escape, but how did Ryan get out. I am very sure he is suspecting something so I ask, you think something happened.

He nods, not just me. Tessa here also thinks someone helped him. Peter didn't help him, Elina was bleeding out and everyone were fighting each other. No one said they tried to help Elina or him. He is in complete shock now, but I bet he was too when back then too. I know you said that we didn't find any evidence someone else is involvement. I am guessing he knows more. Luther asks, you still believe a group of people went in attacked the place. He says, I refuse to believe it was internal conflict ending in mutual destruction. Its too neat and tidy.

I am a little conflicted here. Blake didn't tell me everything, but it’s a good guess that David was the one who helped Ryan get out of there. If that’s true, then Ryan might know it was him. I wanted to avoid taking to the kid, because then it will be official that someone was really involved. Despite that, I made a decision after thinking a bit more. If he calls out David, fine. Let him. I don't care if this messes up David's plan. He doesn't trust me, well touché. I don't trust you too.

I say, want to tag along with me then. You can try to talk to Ryan while I speak to Elina. Roland became interested in this. He looks at Tessa who says, sure. But try to be gentle with him. He says, yeah all right. But you know, we have tried the carrot for long enough. We need try stick now. Don't worry, I am not going to force him. But its bloody time he understands the situation he is in if he doesn't talk. I add, just don't accuse him of anything. We all might suspect Elina, but I hardly believe he is involved too.

Luther says, I agree. Don't push the kid. It would be bad we cause any distress on him and Elina stops cooperating. She has complained us enough times to leave Ryan alone. Roland nods, I am only going to ask the hard questions everyone else are resisting to ask him. He was right. Its one thing to sympathizes with him, but at a certain point that has to end and answers are needed. I don't know if I made the right call. Maybe Blake will get angry with me on this. But I am already prepared if this somehow leads me to piss on David's plan if he gets outed now.

I say, if that’s all. I will get ready to meet Elina. I got up from the couch, Roland follows me. Luther says, just one last thing. Blake is giving you a deadline with the hard disk. If we can't get it open by tonight, we need to hand it over to him. I asked confused, what. Why. Tessa stands beside me saying, I am guessing he wants to open it before talking to Citradel. He tells with a defeated look, that’s right. We really can't go in without knowing who all the people are involved in this. We don't know if there are 100 people or only 10 people who have used this smuggling service.

I understood the impatience. But I was a little confused what would Blake do with it. Then I realized something I really don't like, does he plan to give it to David. My teeth grit a little with a sudden anger. I am not giving this to him in a silver patter. We do the hard work he gets to swoop in like he is so great. Did he not get it himself because he knew we would ask for his help. I won't give him the satisfaction of this. Luther says, not David. He wants try opening it with Marina.

My anger left as fast it came in. I am relieved to hear that. Tessa says, how would they get it open if we can't. Luther says, how else. They are freaking Shadows. If they can't do it, then who will. Luther has always been a little infatuated with Shadows. Its not like they are magicians. But they do have the best chance, okay. That’s fair. So we have about 6 hours then. I get some more people to help out. Roland says, hey now. This isn't a competition. I rebuke him, I know. But it wouldn't look good on us if we weren't able to do it, but they somehow did it.

Even Tessa understood that, you know what, I kind of agree with her. We should not be complacent just because they are here. Now even Roland could see the bigger picture, that would suck. All right, we better hustle then. Luther says, honestly, I did want David also helping us. But he left this morning. I turn to him in confusion, huh. He isn't in the city. Where he run off too. My retort made him pause for a second before saying, he has gone to collect the materials for the expansion. Apparently, the Citradel requirement is quite high and we don't have much of it here. He is the only one among us who has a vast human network. I guess this task is difficult for him too, so he had to go himself.

I murmur to myself, so he bailed on us while letting us handle his mess. Luther asks, what was that. I says, nothing. Just wondering if he took anyone with him. Luther says, we authorized his sole travel. Are you by any chance worried about his safety? Because I was. He may look fine, but I bet he hasn't recovered fully. I opposed him leaving alone, but Blake said David didn't want anyone. I wished he would take someone with him for some extra protection. A lot is riding on him with his match with Charles.

Tessa says, its fine. He is more in his element out their than here. He can take care of himself. Tessa knew he was involved yesterday. Did she think that if he can take out 3 warriors all on his own, he is fine. I wasn't sold on it. No way he remained untouched from that. Even he would have struggled a lot. Luther says, lets hope so. He is supposed to come back day after tomorrow. I ask mocking him, and what about the materials. He is going to carry them.

Luther says, no idea. I am supposed to get some sort of import schedule from him by tonight. I have asked Tina to handle that. I know its not fair, but I was hoping he stayed away for more days. It felt good knowing he isn't here. Like everything I do now is somehow not under the palm of his hands. After that we all go our separate ways. Roland says he will join me a while later after he prepares a little. While I takes the stairs back to my office, Tessa comes behind me.

She says, don't think I don't know what you are doing. I ask her blatantly, what do you mean. She scoffs, you want to expose David's involvement. Don't you. She guesses right. But I wasn't going to show that on my face, what do you mean. I am doing what Blake said. She shook her head, you know. Being mad at him won't do you any good. You want Roland to question Ryan hoping to get him reveal it. I say without any hesitation, I did that because we want to what happened to Ryan during the time.

She shook her head, fine. Lets go with that excuse. What's the point in keeping a lid on this, if you let others do it. I got a little irritated, I agreed not to tell others about him. But I am not going to hinder the investigation just because of Davids name. If Ryan says his name, so be it. Not like anyone would believe him, right. I was blatantly mocking David now. She sighs, I was wrong earlier. You are way too emotional about this. Maybe you should take a break. I laugh, please. Now that David is not here, I feel a more relaxed. I was worried that he might leave us with another mess. Not anymore.

I know I was being totally unfair and ridiculous. But I didn't care. I was now going to openly state my thoughts a bit, he always has some convenient excuse and gets away with this. He just left after creating so much chaos. I understand the plan is to find out who is behind the curtains, but he decides everything by himself. I am not going to do anything to hinder the plan, but I sure as hell won't trust David to handle this alone. Tessa doesn't say much more and just leaves to her office.

Was I being too harsh. Maybe. Was I wrong though, not even a bit.

Vanessa (Chapter 81)

Wednesday, January 21, 2026 21:42

I knew I shouldn't have made Tessa tense when I said the things on my mind. Because she most definitely warned Blake, who was coming to IDF now. Me and Rolan were waiting for him before entering the safe room. Roland says, do you know why he is coming to observe me. I thought he had other work going on, you know with the Citradel meeting tomorrow. I didn't have answer for him. What can I tell him, he is probably going to convince us not to pressure Ryan into revealing David.

I know I scared Blake, and he probably is going to reprimand here. But I was enjoying a little. If he is coming personally, that means Ryan definitely knows something. I tell him, maybe he wants to see if Ryan lies or hides anything. He is kid after all. I gave him a plausible answer which he mulled over it. We waited for few more minutes and then he walks in through the door. Beside him came Ruther, shall I get you a coffee too. Same kind. I thought he would looked panicked, but he seemed calm. Must be just giving us a poker face.

He laughs, thanks. But no. I recently got a taste of something earlier, and can't get enough of it. Ruther says, I knew it. You have a different machine in your floor, right. Can we also get it. He says, that's not what I meant. He turns to us now, hey Roland. Vanessa. Thanks for waiting. Ruther looks a little sad he didn't get his answer, but he left us alone anyways, let me know if you guys need anything. And Roland, don't pressure the kid too much. He sometimes makes a tantrum until Elina calms his down.

Roland says, yeah. Yeah. I know. Jeez, he has made everyone so on edge. He taps his palm on face, gotta get into a character now. Blake says something that makes me remove my cross arms, good luck. Hope you get some valuable information from him. Roland takes a moment, oh. I thought you were for Ryan. Blake raises his eyebrow, must be a mistake. I came to observe Elina. I got a good read on Ryan before. Sorry if you thought it was him. I am more interested if Elina can help locate any client with a smuggled stuff.

Roland smiles, yeah. Makes more sense. That's actually a relief, I was under a little pressure thinking you wanted to find out who was involved. I couldn't believe what I was hearing. Is he really going to not stop or obstruct Roland from this. Blake nods, really. Am I that intimidating. Roland says, dude. You got aura man. I am not talking the Kuret kind. They both chuckle like there was no tension. Blake says, we have no evidence that someone was involved. If you can get Ryan talking, it will be great.

Roland becomes relaxed knowing Blake wasn't here for him. He says, I got some tips from a friend on to approach him. With that he leaves to the room first and to get Ryan out. I look at Blake with a confused look. Blake eye twitches, why are you looking at me like that. Did I say something wrong to him. I ask, what did she tell you. He behaves clueless, who told me what. I don't believe this. Is he behaving like this on purpose. I ask, aren't you worried that Ryan might identify David.

Blake understands something, oh. You mean that. Don't worry about it. Ryan doesn't know anything. Did you really think David would go to such lengths to hide his presence and forget about Ryan. There's nothing to worry. I am speechless. My rebellious and anger emotions gets replaced with something even more. Embarrassment. I was so sure about this and acting so haughty with Tessa. I ask him, um, how sure are you. He looks around the empty hallway and whispers to me, pretty damn sure. David had the whole thing recorded. So me and Marina got to see everything. Honestly, it was quite a show.

All my hopes were crushed in an instant. Then came even more shame. I was looking for some revenge against David that never existed. I want to kick myself now. I ask, then why you came here. He answers, I was always going to come here. I thought Tessa wanted to question Elina, but she later she message me you are coming instead. This is so not a good reflection of me. Here I was enjoying showing my personal rebellion. I don't think Tessa even warned I brought Rolland to try and get David exposed. What was I even trying to achieve here.

He asks, what did you want to ask her though. I let out a sigh to clear out my messed up emotion. I shouldn't let him see my petty nature. I wasn't expecting this, so I didn't have any clever lie. I had to tell him the truth, honestly. I was going to ask about David to her. That put a damper on his face, you what. I say, not as David. But as a poser. I want to make sure if it was really a coincidence if David happened to at her bar, and at the right time. He asks, as opposed to what. You suspect David has ulterior motives with her.

I wasn't really expecting Blake to be here. I couldn't just say that I was just scratching a curiosity. He sighs, Vanessa, I know you aren't happy with him. But it wasn't his fault. It was a freak coincidence. He told he visits other places as well. You can blame his bad luck that danger follows him around. I say, But don't you want to know why he keeps coming here. Maybe he already had suspicion about the place. Maybe he was onto Peter from the beginning and hide it because he was ashamed he didn't do anything about it until now.

I blurted out some excuse from the top of my head. I hope Blake would be convinced enough with this. He then looks at me for a moment. Like he was observing me. It then went for a lot longer. It was my turn to ask, what is it. He finally says, this may sound weird. But are you feeling all right. That was a strange question out of nowhere. Did he caught on to my rambling. Or did he saw something in my aura. I played clueless, just tired. You and Marina agreeing with David is making me worried a bit.

He says, so it has nothing to do with your brother and David's reasons to accept Charles deal? I ask him immediately, what did he say about my brother. Tell me now. My sudden switch in voice caught him off guard. He clears his throat, sorry. I was just curious. He didn't tell me much about his reasons about that. I just thought to ask If you knew more and that's why you are mad at him. I reigned back my eagerness and back down. I say, nothing useful. That's what makes it me furious. He doesn't trust me at all. Not like how he does you all.

He remained silent. I think I have made the atmosphere awkward. But he was the one who broached the topic about Wagner. Blake says, I am not going to make excuse for him. But just do me a favor and keep an open mind when he does tell you about it. I feel like he is defending him. I sigh thinking David got to him real good. Just want kind of trick he did to make Blake understand his actions. I ask, you still haven't told me what all David said. I bet he told you more than just yesterday attack.

He asks, what makes you say that. I say, you and Marina seem a little different. You seem fine now, but in the morning you and Marina had a face that was like it was burdened. You were distracted for while. I am sure others did too a little. Blake simply says, we were tried and slept late. Try grilling David for answers and you will feel the same. That's all. I ask, really. Even Marina was behaving strange. He asks, she is always like that. It was hard to point out. It was Marina, her mood is very hard to say. I shrug, that's all.

He smiles, I think she is just trying to contain herself. Imagine if I could lose control on Peter, how hard it is for her to keep her hands away from him. I am just glad you allowed it finally. I am going next to her and try to make sure she doesn't kill Peter accidently. I thought that was the case. But maybe something was bothering her too. I set it aside for now. I say, I guess. Well, lets forget about that and focus on Elina. He says, all right. Though how are you going to ask about David, while not asking about him. I say, let me handle that. He nods.

We waited for Roland to message me that he took Ryan to the adjoining room. After I got the message I say, you coming in too. He says, I already questioned her. Best not to pressure her. I will listen in from the monitor here. There was still some part of me that thought he would try and stop me exposing David from Elina. But he wasn't fazed at all. I am really making a fool out of myself now. I enter the room and see Elina siting on the chair.

She was fearing much better since the last time I saw her this morning. She had a jacket on her. We got their clothes from home a while ago. Thought that would help them feel more comfortable. She stands on her feet seeing me, Vanessa. I reply, hey Elina. Don't push yourself. Stay seated. She says, I am good. I promise. Jonathan helped more than enough. I feel fine now. She did seem in good health. All things considered she is better, even though she almost died yesterday.

I nod while checking out the bed with a bad with her clothes in it. I say, I know its not ideal, I hope you know we have to be thorough. We will have to keep you here more longer. I thought she would argue over it. But seems like after hours of interrogation, she has understood the gravity of the situation. She says with a sad face, I know. Your officer, Ruther, kept saying its procedure. Honestly, I was furious before. But I had time to think. I guess I was being over protective of Ryan.

I say, glad you understand. There's nothing more I want than to end this investigation. We are still in the middle of it all. So just bear us some more time. She sits on the bed looking tired, Peter really freaked us. Didn't he. I was seeing a different side to her now. I ask her, how is Ryan. I take it's a good sign that he went with Rolland. She says, barely. He is still terrified. I have tried best to calm him down. Are you sure you can't send him to my neighbors. They have babysit him before and I am sure they can help out again.

She is still persistent. I am a little reminiscent of their bond. Wagner would get worried about me too. I say, I wish we could. But him not talking has made it difficult. She asks, its not his fault. I reply, I never said it was. But like Ruther told you, its procedure. Besides, even if we did send him. He would just throw a fit being separated from you. She sighs, I don't want him to see my pathetic side. So that's also a reason for her. I guess its not all that unrealistic.

I ask, has he told anything to you. She turn forlorn, he has asked a bit about Peter. I didn't know what to do, so I just told him that Peter is fine. She looks to me, he is fine, not that I care. I nod, for now. Have you decided if you want to see him yet. She grabs her arms like she is guarding herself, I don't know. I think it would just mess me up more. And confuse Ryan. I say, he did surrender himself. She spats out, only because he knew he screwed up big time and has no where to go. No love lost for her older sibling here. Her anger was justified. I didn't want to agitate her more, so I got straight into the task at hand.

I ask, Elina, I have to ask some questions. She was in a slightly better mood than I thought. She unfolds her arms and lets them rests on the bed, I know its important. So fire away. I gave her my tablet that had the list of her shipments on the display. She took it and gazes at it, I know this list. This is all the times I ordered my liquors. I nod, that's true. But now I am asking you to go through it again. This time try and remember if there is any shipment that is bigger than it actually was. Maybe we can track that to the smuggled goods and hopefully to the people who bought it.

Elina says, I see. That's smart. Get something that more than necessary volume. Give me a minute to check. She is eager to help out. She must really want to help us get her and Ryan out of her. She went through the list multiple times. But it didn't look she was getting anywhere. I ask, is there a problem. She says, no. I don't remember all of my orders, just trying to figure out which one Peter could have forged. I ask, we tried to match Peter's forged hand righting with yours, but he got it pretty good.

She hesitates a little saying, I should be able to tell which one was my own, but he copied mine well. I am having time figuring out my own handwriting. I say, take your time. Its a long shot anyway. You might not remember all your orders. I hear a small laugh from her, believe me. I am trying to recall all of them. I am meticulous about it. And being here has just amped me up more. That's why its me making mad that I still can't figure it out. She is taking this a little harder. I offer some advice, look. I have some experience in being betrayed by people I know. Its not your fault.

First Nathan and now I am trusting less and less David every day. I don't know if its fair to say he betrayed me, but I feel like it was. He puts her tablet down in frustration, damn him. Its not just betrayal. I wasn't keeping on eye on my own business. He was bringing in profit, so I feel like a turned a blind eye to everything because of that. I feel such a fool. I wanted to assure her she wasn't wrong, it's just men are devious. They do whatever you can to manipulate you.

I was laying a little bit thick now. Hope no one picks my own bias in this matter. She says, its still unreal that this happened. I hate Peter for roping us in to that group of people. Just what was he thinking bring us to a dangerous place like that. I was almost killed and Ryan could have been hurt. And the coward just ran off, leaving him alone. I am glad he is fine, because he want to kill him myself. Her anger was boiling more now.

I turn towards the camera and signal not to note that remark. She panicking seeing me gesture, wait, that was just me being mad. I wasn't being serious. I don't know why she would think we serious about her casual remark. I say, don't worry. Everyone knows you would be justified to feel like this towards him. Actually, many people are waiting in line to get their chance with him. That was just so that they scrub off some of the remark before we send the transcripts it to Citradel. She looks confused, so I explain, there are Citradel people involved. So want to have complete transparency about this situation. That means handing over all our investigation and reports.

She was still nervous, don't worry. It was just a precaution. I am sure they won't held you accountable for your brother's actions. She relaxes a bit and settles down. She says, let me take a look again. He resumes her search. Few minutes went by and then she shrieks, wait. This one. I remember now. It was just before the semi's started. I ask, you got something. She nods excited, this one. I think I only ordered 3 dozen bottles, but I think I saw more than that. Peter has marked it as 5 dozen to cover it, but I know feel their was one more crate.

I can't believe this actually worked. I ask, you sure that’s Peter's and not yours hand righting. She nods, I remember it now. I definitely wrote 3 dozen in 2 crates. I would never go overboard on that that day. I remember that. She pauses for a moment and stares at me. I ask, what. She says, ahm. She was fidgeting a little bit before coming clean, it was the day you and others lost in the tournament. I remember serving only 3 dozens of those particular brand on that day.

I smiled a little bit, though there was a little sting, don't worry about it. It was a match. Someone had to lose. She says, sorry. I remember it clearly that I anticipated a lot of people coming in that day and prepare it with this amount specifically. She seems confident, so did we really catch a break here. She says, look here, it clearly says 5 dozen. She brough the screen to my view. But I look away, great, just mark the date and crate details for me. She pulls it back to her, shit. Sorry. You are dyslexic, aren't you. I totally forget.

I turn back to her, don't worry about it. I am used to it by now. You are struggling much more than me medically. She pulls out a weak smile as she taps the screen, I still can't believe I am alive. Even a paper cut causes me a lot of trouble. While she scribbles on the tablet. Then she looks at me for a second, you know. I was rooting for you to win. You gave a tough time to Marina. If only she didn't use that overdrive, you would have own. She was clearing trying to cover her previous blunder. But regardless if what she thought was really true, I say, thanks. But I was outclassed by her. Everyone saw it. That makes her smile a bit and releases the tension she had.

I thought asking something. I know Blake is looming at me, but I had to know. I ask, do you remember anything when you blacked out. With her eyes glued to the screen says, sorry. I have don't recall anything. I remember Ryan voice near me, but nothing else. She finished marking it and hands over the tablet to me, here you go. Sorry, I only found this one. I am not sure about others.

I say, this is good enough. We have a lead. But in case you remember anything else, let Ruther know immediately. She replies, I will definitely try to recall more. I continue, great. If this helps us catch a break, it would help to you get of out of here. A wave of relief washes over her. She had been waiting for long to hear this. I ask, coming back to my question. Doctors were amazed you survived. Do you know if anyone helped you. I was poking the bear lightly. I can't believe I am prodding for something myself so blatantly. She was already prepared, likely due to beings asked about it already.

She says, I heard about it. Honestly, it’s a miracle. I was surprised myself. If Ryan hadn't gotten me help in time, I would be dead right now. There wasn't any sign of hesitation or lie. Not like I can be sure by seeing her aura. But it doesn't feel like she is hiding it. I had to let this one go. I say, you were lucky no doubt. You got help, just in time. Just not from the person you think, I said internally. She smiles weakly, I try not to think to much about it. I have never been in a fight. It is sucks hard that the first one was so terrifying. For Ryan as well.

Everyone first time is bad. She was really unlucky to have almost died. She then says, I got some checkup from the doctor this morning about my psych eval. I didn't hear the results. Am I showing any severe symptoms. Its amazing she is cognizant of being aware of her own state. I ask, for someone who hasn't seen much violence, you seem more together. I have seen people crumble under the trauma. She says, trust me. I will have a major freakout later. I am just toughing it out for Ryans sake.

That is actually commendable from her. I answer, I think the doctor just forgot about it. I'll let them know to tell you later. She says, thanks. Also, you don't need to tip toe around me. I know you are just trying to keep me calm. I told you, I am good. I can answer any other question you have. Her attitude is also good. I guess a days worth of rest helped her. I say, just a second. I walk to the door and open it. Blake turns to me and I hand him the tablet, mind giving it to Tessa. Best we get on this immediately.

He takes it from me, sure. Also, try be a little inconspicuous when you ask about him. I rather not ruin the plan on the first day itself. I still can't tell what his angle is here. Does he make me to expose David or not. Did he really thought David is untouchable even without his help. I was even more determined to squeeze out truth from Elina. I say, I got this. I don't know if he believe that, but he walks to the other door. I have a few minutes before he comes back. With him gone, I won't be pressured to not ask things I want to ask.

I head back in to her patiently waiting. I ask her, I am sure people have asked you. But has any suspicious person approached you. She says, if you are asking about Peter's criminal friends, then no. I was shown their photos earlier. I never seen them before. I ask, okay. Does no one else pops out. She was shaking her head. I prodded a little more, maybe some customer who was keeping on eye you. She asks, why would they do that. I answer, maybe to make sure their orders don't go missing.

She says, but if that were the case Peter wouldn't have brought me to them. They would know I didn't steal from them. Damn, she is quick to grasp things. I feel like a fool making such excuses. I say, true. But covering my basis here. Could be that whoever keeps an eye on you is one of the people on the run and didn't vouch for you in time. I made a better and plausible argument now. She understood this one, I see. Yeah. That makes a lot of sense. I guess its possible. Lot of people come in and go. I don't have camera in my bar. I never thought this would happen.

Its probably why David chose her place. No surveillance. She thought my silence meant I was suspecting her. She anxiously says, I know I should I have gotten one. A couple of my friends of mine insisted it many times. I should have listened to them. Stupid of me. She blamed herself. But I saw an opening now. I ask, yeah. It could be one of your friends also. Do you suspect anyone. No matter how innocent they seem, they could be one of them. She thinks hard at this question.

She answers, I don't think they would be involved in this. I am a very good judge of character. Her eyes drop a little, I guess that’s not true anymore. I couldn't tell my own brother was a smuggler. I was getting a little impatient, focus Elina. Dig deep and search for the guy who is still lying to you. My intense glare cause her to be nervous, you really think one of my friends were faking it. It could be. Good, she is getting closer. She asks, but aren't you looking into everyone I talk to.

She is good. She had enough wits about her. I say, we are. But you have a lot of customers. It's not going to be easy track all of them down. I dropped even a bigger hint to her now. She picked up on that, one of them. Nah, I don't think so. How would they know about my orders. I say, maybe not directly. But they could have bugged you or something like that. She becomes even more nervous now. I need to stop gaslighting her. I am only terrifying the poor woman even more and making her paranoid.

What the hell was I trying to do to her. I grit my teeth in anger. At myself. How much longer will I do this farse. She mistook my anger as impatience, Vanessa, I am sorry. But I really can't think of anyone. I wish I could. That was my limit now. I say, don't apologies. I was just looking for something suspicious. I didn't want to rattle you. This is my fault. I can't believe I let go this for just for being curious. She sighs, I can't believe how my life turned like this. I have to wonder who I shouldn't have trusted.

I decided to just leave now. I am only stressing her out by my pestering. I say, don't think like that. You are not being treated like a suspect right now. She nods, some of all must be wondering it. And I don't blame you. I was so blinded by the cash Peter was bringing in. I should have just took my friends offer and made him an investor in my bar. He would have found out my mistake for sure. This was unexpected opportunity. Do I dare push ahead. My curiosity got better of me, you wanted someone to be your partner.

She looks at me confused, oh no. That's nothing. Its just something we both joke about. He is my friend, from before Peter told me about his side business. He isn't involved in this, I can guarantee. Oh, is she now talking about him. If so, how is she so confident when he is lying to her. I ask, I see. So he might not be involved, but its best not to overlook anything. What's your friend name. She becomes a nervous for some reason. Now this is suspicious, what is it. You said he isn't involved, right.

She bits her lip, I don't to get trouble him into any trouble. He is a really good guy. I was almost beginning to think she must be taking about someone else. She says hesitantly, I like him a lot. I don't think he would be involved in this. What is this, did she have a crush on this guy. Is it David or not. I curse at him. He didn't tell Blake his name he was using. So even I don't know if she is talking about him. I ask, I can see you care about him. I am not going to accuse him without any proof. You are not going to get him into trouble.

She was still concerned. I tried a different approach, you said he wanted to invest into your bar. So he as money right. Maybe he made if off the smuggling. Maybe he is guilty for using you and giving some back to you. I gave her enough reason to doubt. She would definitely have some sort of doubt in her mind. I hope Blake is not back already, because I am definitely goading her towards David. This accusation puts her at even more uneasiness. She finally says, not him. I know him. We flirt around and tease each other all the time. I know how he makes his money, and he definitely doesn't spend for guilt. He just uses it as an excuse to be around me.

I am so confused now. Is she talking about David or not. She says, sorry. I am just rambling. You don't want to hear my personal life. I swear I could see her embarrassed now. Its killing me not being to not openly ask if its him. I ask, just give his name. We won't even question him. We will go through his profile and see if anything is suspicious. I didn't want to dangle this in front of her, but I was becoming desperate.

I point to the other room, if you can help us out, we can get you and Ryan out of here much faster. That dirty emotional push made her give up. She nods, okay. Anything for Ryan. But you will see, he is a really decent guy. His name is Mack. Don't know his bloodline family. He works in the tech support. All I heard was Mack. It is him. I am know it for sure it now. David said to me during the flag capture game that if had an option to change his name, he would pick Mack.

I finally got him. But then my heart dropped. What the hell did he say to her to make her so faithful to him. I wish I had my tablet with to me to do a search. I will do that later. First I need to learn what they are to each other. Am I really going to expose David here? When I just promised Blake that I won't. I didn't care about it now. I ask, thanks. We will do a background search on him. Hopefully he turns to be how you say his is. She responds, he is. I have no doubt.

This is sad. He has wrapped her on his finger. I ask, you seem too much attached to him. I am not saying that’s suspicious, but what if he turns out to be someone he is not. I am border lining this question so that people don't assume I am hard pressing her. She unexpectedly smiles, oh I know he is keeping stuff from me. It wouldn't be surprising if it turns out if his name isn't Mack. This bamboozled me. What. I don't understand this. I ask, are you serious. You trust such a dubious guy. She smiles, I know. Its weird. I told you before, I have decent grasp on people's character. He told he is private person and may be using an alias. I chewed him out for being so cautious, but I learned he doesn't do it because he was to hiding something out of ill will.

I waited for her to explain. She says, but why do you want to know. I am telling you, he wouldn't betray me like this. He might lie and laugh, but he is good at heart. He always has a reason for whatever he says. A new raw pure emotion evoke from within me. Jealously and hatred. On David. And on her. What he hell is going on here. What kind of wool has he put over her. I had to control myself from shouting out her. She is being manipulated by him.

He is toying with her.

But how exactly. She herself admits he is lying to her. How in the bloody hell is she okay with this. I had a nagging feeling how. Should I ask her. But that’s not appropriate. I will definitely be crossing a line, if I ask her this. I can't be ask her about her private life so suddenly. I am so conflicted that I might my fists tighten in frustration. I ask, you seem so close. You sure he isn't your boyfriend. I asked this instead. She looks at me with strange look. I bet she must be thinking I was being too forceful.

She opened her mouth to say something. Then suddenly the door opens. I turn behind and Ruther rushes in, hey. Sorry to barge in. Blake just pulled me in, saying you wanted me to run background on some guy. He came with a tablet in hand. Damit. Blake was here. He read my aura and figured I was going too far with this. I nod, yeah. Search for a Mack from tech. Ruther looks to me and then to Elina, that’s it. No family name? Elina says, he said he doesn't know his bloodline and doesn't want to. He has a condition that makes him unable to use Kuret. I kept asking him to at least get his Kuret tested, but he didn't want to. Said it doesn't matter, as long as he gets the job done.

You know what frustrating, he didn't lie anything about this to her. He mislead her big time, not a blatant lie. She really has a crush on him. Or Mack. Its hard to figure out if David was playing a character. Ruther says, whoa. Not able to use Kuret, guys got issues no doubt. Lets see. He begins to look for him the database. After a while he says, that’s weird, no Mack here. Are you sure his name is Mack. For the first time there was crack in that confidence. I knew it. She was blind to Peter, and now she was being blinded by David.

She shook her head, I told you. He might not be using his real name. Can you search again please. I nod to Ruther and he tried once more. As more time passed by, Elina became more anxious. To the point her palm turned to a fist and grab the cloth over the bed in anticipation. Hold on. Is this right. I might expose David, but I would also make her even more miserable. She is already suffering due to Peter. Am I so vain that I am going to break her, just to prove a point. And for what.

Just then Ruther says, got it him. Turns out Mack was a nickname. I turn to him shocked, you found him. It had be a fake identity. Nothing else makes sense. Ruther says, yeah I did a broader search and got a hit on Macklerington. Says he joined the island around a year and half ago. So he has been here among the first citizens. No criminal actions. Single, lives in section 5. Works in software, building his own apps sealing it to people. Nothing wrong with his income too. He smiles, the dude is not in debt, but he isn't raking in too much money too. I don't see any recent suspicious transactions, not like we found with others.

David crafted this whole fake identity. Elina says, wow. I see now why he wouldn't tell me his full name. It’s a mouthful. This is not happening. She is falling for someone fake. I grab the tablet from Ruther and raise it in front of Elina, is this him? Elina leans in closer and says, yeah. That’s him. I put a bit of pressure, you sure. She says, we are friends for months now. I think I can recognize him well. She was being witty with me. I think even she is getting irritated my continuous pestering.

I gave the tablet to Ruther, call him. He asks, excuse me. What. Elina stands up, wait. You promised you wouldn't accuse him. He just said there is nothing suspicious. Can't we keep him out of this. I really don't want to get him tangled in my mess. I was painfully aware my own selfish behavior. But I have gone to far to back down now. I say, I know what I said. But he sounds too suspicious for some reason. I turn to Ruther, just call him and but don't tell him you are from IDF.

He was caught in the middle of something. He looks flustered and asks, ah, fine. But what should I say. I ask, say anything. Say you are a friend of Elina and asking to see if he has seen her. Ruther was so confused by my rush. I was doing it purposefully, because any second Blake is going to barge in and shut this down. Elina was beginning to me a annoyed look. I deserved her enraged eyes, I am not denying it. Ruther sighs, fine. I guess no harm in checking him out.

He opens his phone and types in the contact number. Two things will happen, either it goes to David, or the line is dead. I tell him, on speaker phone. Ruther puts he phone in front of me as it rings. Every ring was like my heart beat. But then it connects. It has to be David then. Ruther asks, hey, is this Mack. A very familiar voice speaks, yeah. Its not David. The voice was different, but very similar to David. I am so lost right now. Ruther says, hey man. I am one of the temps Elin hired few days back. I was just wondering if you know where Elina is.

He says, Elina? Why. Is something wrong. Elina slumps back into her bed. Ruther says, oh man. You know. She didn't open the bar today. She and Peter went somewhere in a hurry, and feel he is involved in some shady stuff. So I am beginning to get worried about her. Apparently Mack is angry, you mean they are still not back. I knew her brother was no good. I should have warned Elina. I haven't heard from either of them. Okay, this had to be fake. Or David hired someone to pretend to be him.

At this point I wasn't going to rule out anything. I gesture Ruther to say something. He understood my intent, where are you now. I feel we should go to some officer and report it. Mack says, for sure. I like visiting her bar, be shame if something happened to her. Where do you want to meet. I just thought to have dinner at section 2. We can meet there. This had be a decoy. David must have someone pretend to be Mack now. Ruther was little clueless since I was speechless.

Then another person enters. It was Blake. I had taken it far enough. He whispers something to Ruther. Then he says, thanks man. Just let me try to get out of this shift. I will try to contact you. He says, you sure. Okay. Hit me up whenever you can. He ends the call. Blake asks, is this Mack. Elina nods, he sounds a little different, but yeah. Ruther says, his phone GPS says he is at home. Everything checks out Vanessa. I don't see any connection to Peter or anyone.

I am so quiet, I could cut myself with it. Blake takes over me, we can eliminate one potential suspect now. Elina, thanks for the your help today. I am going to try to get you and Ryan out of here soon. Elina says, thanks Blake. I promise if I remember anything, I will tell you all. He nods and signals us to leave. I follow him out with a lump in my throat. This is nuts, did he really hire an actor with a real job. Once we got out Ruther asks, do we bring in him for questioning.

Blake says, good question. What do you think Vanessa. He was obviously calling me out here. I am so damn confused and angry. I managed to say, just send officers to his place. Do a routine check on him, nothing too intrusive. I can't help but think this guy is hiding something. Ruther says, really. This guy. He looks at his photo in the screen, I don't see it. Looks like a regular guy. Just because he is friends with Elina, doesn't means he is involved is he ? We have talked to the rest of her friends. Blake corrects him, he is more of a customer.

Ruther says, right. But still, what is it that you don't feel right about him. I had no answer. No justification. No reason. Just petty revenge. Blake says, just do it. And quietly. Maybe she isn't sure herself. Ruther scratches her checks, ahm. Okay. Then I guess I will go myself with some patrol officers. You want me look for something specific. I shook my head. He says, all right. I might as well have dinner there too. With that he walks away. As soon as he left, Blake grabs me by the arm.

What the hell is wrong with you. I get you don't want to lie for us, but this, you didn't have to do this. He was angry. He was every right to be. I couldn't even shake off his hand off me. I am so mortified by my actions. He says, you know. I wasn't going to say this. But you are messed up. Angry at David, at me, at Elina. You are angry at Ned too. Don't think I haven't noticed that. I was now feeling more guilt. He let goes of me, what exactly was your plan. Keeping digging until you prove that Mack is fake? That David is using her ? Or you wanted to hurt Elina ? Tell me.

I managed to blurt out, sorry. I got carried away. He spats, damn right you did. He sighs, you don’t trust us. Well, now I can't trust you. I look at his furious eyes. He was being impartial earlier. But now he was berating me. He continues, you know what. Just finish the reports for tomorrow and take tomorrow off. I'll others that you are exhausted too much or something like that. Take a break to get your shit together and then come back. I couldn't believe he was asking me this, are you benching me. Really. When things are so dire.

He says, you leave me no choice. I didn't think you would try to use Ryan like a leverage to use her. It was harmless, but I shutter to think what you might do next. I close my eyes in shame. He says, besides, your work is almost done. After tomorrow, it will be mostly cleanup. Might as well take some time to cool off. Between Wagner's rumor and your behavior now, you might just go ballistic on the next person. I open my eyes trying hard to not let them get moist. He was right. I am thinking clearly, not when I am can't let go of things.

I didn't give him any answer as I walked away to the door.

Blake (Chapter 82)

Thursday, January 22, 2026 12:18

I am sitting in the conference room, my legs shaking anxiously. This has to gone as plan. We have prepared as much as we could to handle any accusation or demand Citradel makes of us. I take sip of my second cup of coffee and talk a look at tablet nots I made. The door opens and Luther walks in, you got in pretty quick. I says, I have been here since 6 AM. He laughs, you need to relax. We got this. I scoff, I will relax once this whole ordeal is over. He has a snack on his hand and takes a bite of it as he takes the seat beside me.

I glances over my notes. I push it to him for his opinion. After long through it, he says, this one. You sure about this. He see the line he was pointing. I say, don't you think its better this way. Citradel hasn't join us, I rather not give with our people. Let them focus on only theirs. Luther nods, I suppose. But I would at least have them the transcripts and reports. I thought about this compromise. After mulling over it I say, okay. I scribble it on the screen, if they push for it, I will offer them this. But not before.

He agreed, that works. He then says, I don't see any issue with the other things. But have to ask, were you able to hack into the hard disk. Sommers was very reluctant to hand it over last night. You know, between Marina and him, I am getting cornered by you warriors. That made me chuckle, don't worry. It's just a little bit of ego. He says, tell that to them. But anyways, what's the latest on that. Yesterday I had given a deadline for the IDF to work on it. Even with the extra resources, they couldn't open it. They did have an option, but it was way too dangerous to try it out.

Others may believe me and Marina are working on it. But the truth, we gave it to our Shadow apprentices. I don't feel good about it, I basically pawned it off to them. But I told them in all honestly what I was asking and why. Thankfully, they understood the situation. In fact, they were glad to be finally active now. It helped a lot when Marina jumped the gun and told them that our Shadow strategist is ready to address them now. So far they only know he existed. That lit a fire under them.

I say, me and Marina working on it still. We have something going on in the background. Lets hope it pans out. Luther looks at the time, any idea if that happens in the next 2 and half hours. I wish I know. My hesitation got him an answer, understood. Well, in case it doesn't, you okay to go head with that response. I nod, yeah. I don't like it, makes us look weak, but I rather say this instead of lying. The idea was to say that since Citradel people are also involvement, it has caused us to be more careful. Arguably, that's a pretty weak defense, but it's not a lie.

I say, we will handle it when the time comes. Lets go to the next action item. He says, all right. David got in touch with Deni around 4 in the morning. That me made alert, and? He smiles, he did it. I was skeptical about this. But dudes a bloody magician. He says he got everything we wanted. He gave me his export schedule and a plan to get it into the island. I tilt my head in joy, that's awesome. At last, some good news. Now we don't have cover anything on this front. Luther says, you said it. I was a little uneasy on how to handle this if it David hadn't pull through with this one.

I still can't believe him. Even when so much going on with him, he managed to priorities this. Me and Marina are still feeling a bit of all the massive truth bombs he threw at us. Even now my thoughts keeps drifting sometime to our discussion. David being messed up yet again due to a woman. My dad and her mom in the Shadows. Our history intertwined with Shadows. The real Wagner. Him knowing everything about the new Shadow recruits. I still can't believe so many things remained secret for years, for decades.

We were at least in the comfort of our homes while processing it. But he was on the move constantly. He might actually be more at ease outside the island too. People are gunning for him everywhere. But at least he has more resources the out. Luther says, one thing though, he can't make to the meeting. I know you wanted him here. Tina said it was unavoidable. He had issues on his side and it delayed his return. I don't know when he will be back, but its not today.

I say, if that's a compromise we have to make, its not that bad. Luther shook his head, I don't like it. He is out there, all alone. Aren't you worried about that. People did ask me yesterday why I let him leave alone. I didn't have a good enough reason for them. David was very cautious of any officer right now. And so was I. I tell, you have to ask him. He just put it off saying that if he needs protection, he is not worthy to be fighting Charles. That's pretty much what I have been telling others.

He smirks, I understand that sentiment. I guess there's nothing I can do now. But its not all bad, I got him to agree to join in the call. He said he will figure out a way to join. With that settled we moved on to discuss other topics. After going through some political stuff, we arrive to the nitty gritty ones. He says, Vanessa handed me all of her reports. I was very anxious about her. I may have been too harsh on her. No, I chided myself. She was out of line. She was not talking to Elina, she was making her miserable. Regardless of what Elina thought of David, I had asked Vanessa not to force David's name. I don't know what exactly she wanted from Elina.

And oh boy, I can't believe I never noticed that behavior from her when I mentioned Wagner. Its like one of those things when someone doesn't notice it unless they are aware of it. David might be actually right about her. And on top of it, she and Ned are still fighting. Catherine told she still hasn't met with Ned. Not even once. Far from me butting in their relationship, but hasn't it gone long enough. Catherine said she was going something similar, so she sympathizes with her. I couldn't muster to ask what's up with Rob and her. I thought she would be happy now that David would stop meddling between them. At times like this, I am glad I am not in a relationship. Its not like don't want one, but its not the right time.

I ask, all in order. He says, yeah. We got all the statements from everyone now. Including all Citradel people. I ask, and Quintin. He taps his tablet, all ready to be shared. You sure you won't to go through them again. Its quite an interesting read. I say, I am sure it is. Nathan has been talking to everyone nonstop on how he got them talking and what they said. I feel I already heard it multiple times. He says, that is that right, with a light chuckle. He says, I didn't hear about it. I guess it must be just recent.

It was a little white lie. I already know what happened, saw it from the horses mouth. But just to cover my bases I did a quick glance at the reports now. Luther says, honestly, its nuts they all fought each other, believing each other to be the traitor. And since Wyan is not talking, we got to assume each of them have their own agendas now. David's plan was working. He caused so much confusion and made a narrative for people to guess themselves, its turned everyone into an unreliable witness. Some of them blame each other and some blame Wyan. Since they all were arguing themselves before David stepped in, its became even more chaos as everyone wants to save their own ass.

There are people, like Roland, who still believe someone else is involved. But no has any proof. So they aren't willing to force their opinion on others. After going through this, I ask, and how about Elina and Ryan. Did you find any connection with them. Luther scratches his head, none. As you know, Roland finally got Ryan talking. And we thought, he doesn't know anything. He doesn't even remember how he got out. Just said he was cold and everything was black.

I think he might be referring to the bots cold metal and David's Kuret. But there's nothing tying to him. I knew there was nothing to be worried about it. That's why I was more interested checking on Elina. Aside from the lead that Tessa is trying to follow, Vanessa may have agitated her a bit too much. She was a little different ever since Vanessa talked to her. She is little more annoyed at her being questioned, again and again. Somers send a message this morning that she was little incorporate too initially with another round of questioning.

I shook my head. I should have stepped in much earlier. I didn't realize Vanessa was prepared to expose David's fake identity this far. Even more surprising is that David somehow already had a real guy, with a real job, house, the whole package. I was sure he was a decoy, but then I along with Sommers report, I saw Ruthers. He said Mack was at home when he came by and nothing looked out of place. I am still confused about it. Did he take an identity of a real guy as his disguise. Bue the real Mack spoke about Elina. I don't know everything, but Mack has no apparent connection to David. Just what kind of illusion is this.

Its amazing and I wanted to know desperately how he managed this. I just have to patient until David returns. Luther interrupts my thoughts, Elina has grown tired of us, I think. I figured he would notice it too, she is still cooperating right. He hesitates, on paper. But I guess the shock of her almost dying is wearing off. I won't be surprised if she demands to be released today. And she would be right to ask us. She mentioned to Somers in their last discussion that they have not found any evidence on her. She has been transparent about everything. Its been 3 days now. I am also beginning to think she is innocent.

Vanessa rattled her a little too much. I say, what did Vanessa suggest. He says, not much. She went home early last night. Said something about taking an early dinner. I am waiting to talk to her today. Yeah, good luck with that. I basically ordered her to cool off. Even if she comes in today, I will force her out. I can't predict what she might do next when I am not looking. Soon others started to arrive. When Tina arrived she told me the latest updates on David's travel. He will be in a private Jet when he joins in the call. He travelled in public to avoid suspicion, but apparently, he was in Saudi Arabia, where travelling in Jet is more normal for a wanted criminal.

With the clock hits 9 AM, all most everyone arrive. I was now anxious. Marina is with the other Shadows, so if they are able to crack it, she was supposed to bring it to me. I don't know if they will make it in time. I familiar presence comes from behind, morning Blake. I turned to see Catherin, in her work clothes. I say, hey. How are you today. She pouts at me, you know, you don't have too keep asking me that. I smirk, I will keep asking until I am sure you actually are.

She clicks her tongue, I am fine. I know I said yesterday I didn't like not knowing what you all talked about with David, but that's just me venting. Her aura told something else. She caught me noticing, well, not completely. But don't worry. I am not going to push for an answer. I talked to Marina and she gave me hints about it. I raise my eyebrow. Now what did she reveal to her. Catherine laughs at my stern face, I am kidding. She didn't say anything I could understand. She doesn't have a good poker face, but she can confuse the hell out of anyone. Classic Marina defense mechanism. I don't know if Marina wanted to tell about her family, but I wanted to know what was the other thing that Catherine didn't like about them.

I didn't get a chance to ask her, this was too personal for her. Also our work as kept us busy. Catherine had also begin her own spying to uncover the people behind the stolen drugs. I whisper to her, so any progress in your hunt. She teases me, really now. You think I am that easy. I am not going to show what I found so soon. I doubt she found anything in just two days. I say, just be careful. Those people don't mess around. She smiles, yeah, well, neither do I. I got this. At least she was confident and not depressed about her family.

Then she pulls out tablet, enough about that. You have a job to do for now. She has become more of her usual self now. I say, yes mam. I took from her and go through the list I asked her to bring. As I go through it, I get familiar with the contents. She asks, you don't think this is a bit too much. You are basically going to insult them. I replied, its not that. It about leveling the field. I have no doubt they will try to blame us and use this to discourage Citradel people from joining us.

She asks, but there are their own people involved in this. They are already partially responsible. I say, it happened in our city, that makes it more our responsibility. Don't worry about it, I am preparing it just in case they start causing a ruckus. I am not going to do it if all of us remain level headed. She was little relieved to hear me and looks at me with pushing her lips, you are too good at this. Must be yours dad's influence coming out of you now. I made stiffed laugh. If only she knew how close me and dad were really.

At the end of the list, I saw one strange entry. I ask her, this one is strange. She puts her hand on my arm, trust me. I got this one straight from an unexpected source. Her devious smile was vexing, but I guess its not a big concern if its true. After checking everything I was satisfied. She then says, one more thing. David called me an hour ago. I gave her the tablet back. She had a confused look. She says, he wanted to know I know where Citradel

get their materials. That’s not that strange, he had some troubles getting last few. I bet he was looking at all possible places to find it. I did ask him to check if we can get it from the same source as Citradel, but he said he won't be able to get all the materials within a week from their sources.

She says, I assumed as much. That maybe he had to buy or steal from their usual suppliers. The actual weird thing is the time. I just met Tina and she told David contacted her early in the morning. So if had everything already by then, why call me. This is mildly unsettling, did he tell you why he wanted that information. She says, he said he was in a hurry, so I just assumed he was still trying to gather all the stuff. I don't know why he wanted it now. Should we be worried.

I was a little anxious too, maybe. But lets trust him. Maybe there was an emergency and had to search for alternate sources. She says, he did say he was delayed. So I guess that could be why. I just thought to tell you this. Don't want to be blinded by him, again. We both have a good laugh at David. After chatting with others a bit more, I take the center stage around 9:30. Everyone looks at me, all right people. We are all good to go. Luther says, nothing on the hard disk. Many eyes fall on me, I says, apologies, but I guess we fell short for that.

I see a lot of disappointed face. A voice comes out, you guys are thinking too much. Its still a win that we got all the people involved in this. It was Nathan, I saw him coming in earlier with Jess. She was a bit more tiered than him. That was expected. But Nathan was too eager to call this out. Tessa says, don't start Nathan. I know you helped out this time, but that data was important. The people who bought the smuggled stuff were just as guilty as the people we have.

People were murmuring in agreement. This wasn't going to damper his chipper mood, true. They are the buyers of the smuggled stuff. And they knew all the risks buying them. But isn't it better to look at the win rather than what we couldn't. Also, its not like all is lost. We can still crack the data, it just might take more time. He was trying to elevate the slightly depressed atmosphere. I didn't like the way he went about it, but its not a bad thing. I bring the attention back to me, anyways. We still got everyone involved in the actual smuggling, like he said, we should focus.

A moment later the conference door opens and my eyes dart to the person hoping it to be Marina. But it was Vanessa. Shit, she didn't listen to me. She hurries inside with a calm demeanor, sorry everyone. I had a late night. I pause a little while I try to figure our her aura. She was much calm and determined today. But like yesterday, it could change any second. She stands beside Tessa. Nathan says, such tardiness Vanessa. Twice in a week. Are you sure everything is fine.

This was really the worst time to prod her. But her aura remained intact, yeah I know. Work's been crazy at IDF, but you all know about it. You and Rose were able to pull out information from the three people, but a lot of it is just them simping on Rose. Obviously I have that in the report. I spend extra time redacting that. This caused a laugh among the people. I can't tell if she really did that or not. Even Nathan giggles at her. The only guy who was unaffected by her was Ned, who had a slightly sullen face.

Please don't tell me they had another fight. For now I have to trust Vanessa isn't going to cause another scene. I says, anyways, as I way saying. I grabbed the attention back, our focus is on ensuring them that we had a fast and swift resolution to this. If they start saying unreasonable things about our negligence, don't panic. We are going to expect some blowback. But trust me, if they go overboard I am not going to stay quite. Just let me handle it. People remain steadfast at my confidence.

Luther takes over, all right guys. Lets clear the room, except for the top officers, please go to the next room. One by one people start leaving. I was setting up my place in the conference table when an unexpected person approached me. He asks, Blake. Do you have a second. I turn to Ned. Oh god, what did Vanessa do. I hide my nervousness, what's up Ned. I haven't seen much of you around the office, you know. The corner of his mouth twists, don't I know. While you are busy helping this gigantic mess, someone still had to focus on the upcoming matches.

His team was still working with Citradel side and coming up with the plan about the match. I say, sorry Ned. I have been a little too busy to focus on that. I know we were supposed to go over it by now. He says, understandable. Given the mess those guys made, I knew it wasn't the priority. But I like to setup some time once this over. I nod, for sure. When I told everything that this week was going to be a crucial, I didn't know it would also a wild one. He laughs, no one could have predict that.

I take a quick peek at Vanessa talking to Sommers. Then I turn back to him, so. What's up. He says, I was just wondering if you know when David is coming back. I thought he would be here by now. I talked to Tina, and she doesn't know. I thought you would have some idea. I respond, no clue. Did you checked with Vanessa. I tried to test the waters of their relationship. He sighs, she and I are in a fight. I think everyone knows by now. We haven't talk much lately. So she didn't cause any more issues last night. At least not with Ned.

I wasn't going to comment anything about their fight, what do you need from him. You can still contact him, you know. He says, I wanted a face to face conversation about the ideas we have for the match. I didn't want them to be shared over remotely. I say, you will have to wait for sometime then. He looks around, I suppose that’s unavoidable. His travel is very unexpected, I understand he had to priorities, but this is important too. I understood his concerns, don't worry. He will join in the call.

That somehow relieves his tense expression, is that so. That’s great then. I was being concerned for no reason then. With that he leaves us and follows others to the next room. Soon it was just the high ranking officers in the room. I am in discussion with Luther when Marina rushed in the room. He hair was messed up, likely she came flying at top speed. He had a bag with her, oh thank the Kuret. I made it in time. She hurries to me and drops the bag on the table. Luther asks, are you all right Marina.

She was breathing heavily and is now tidying up her crumbled clothes, I just came here at a sonic speed. Give me a second. People gather around her hearing that ridiculous lie. But I was more interested at her bag. I hastily open it and saw the hard disk inside it. It was connected to another device through a connector. The device had a lights flashing on the side. I got excited seeing this, I shriek, is this what I think it is. She fixes her hair, yeah. Special delivery of all stupid guys who bought the smuggled goods.

The room now was filled with excited aura. Luther says to Marina, I knew it. Shadows are the goat. She was smiling ear to ear. I don't know why she is so smug about it. We didn't crack this, we are just taking the credit. Nathan walks near me, well, damn. I lost the bet. Jess elbows him in his stomach, not now. I will pretend I didn't hear that. Catherine helps out Marina, girl, you are messing your hair even more. Let me. Marina turns her back to her, thanks. I didn't get time to fix it before I left.

Somers had a wide eye staring at the hard disk, what the hell did you guys do. There were 3 fail safes in this device. He incredulously looks at both of us. I stayed silent, letting Marina handle this. She laughs, sorry. Trade secret. I don't think we had any better excuse than this. Luther was in glee, while Sommers eyes was twitching. She says, that device is connected to the network and decrypting the data on the hard disk. Tessa asks, so you got all the names of the people.

She sighs, unfortunately no. We got through the safeguards and firewalls, but the data is itself 512 AS encryption with a rotating algorithm. Suffice to say its quite advance. We don't have the names and the smuggled goods right now, but this is the best we can do for now. I hand over the hard disk to Vanessa, I am giving this to you. Tell the Citradel IDF cracked this. This caught her and everyone else off guard. Marina flared her nostril, but I already told her I was going to do this.

She asks nervously, why. I say, its not going to be fair if I tell them me and Marina personally cracked it. IDF is going to have a little bit of backlash because of this incident, but at least you can show you guys are still reliable. Sommers, you want us to lie. I shrug, this doesn't have it be so bad. I am sure you would have done it if you all more time. I wanted give you more time, but Citradel didn't budge and wanted to meet now. He was not convinced, probably not happy with me or Marina that we cracked it less than the time they had it for.

Marina pleads, hey, you know. Its best not you lie, you know. There were so many layers of emotions to her voice. But her aura was clear. She wanted to enjoy the attention. She is being way too petty, considering we didn't actually do it in the first place. I say, I told you. Shadows don't care about stuff like that. She got the hint and gets annoyed. How would it look to our recruits if we can't do what they just did. She says, fine. Yeah. Whatever. She grumbles while Catherine finishes her hair, there. Isn't it so much better.

She was more presentable now. Vanessa takes the disk from me, I don't like this one bit. I gave a intense look that said deal with it without making a scene. She relents, but yeah. This will help regain some of the trust we lost. Somers mumbles something while Ruther puts his hand on his shoulder calming him down. I don't have the time for people to be worried about things like this, it’s a win guys. That’s all what matters. Isn't that right, Nathan. He smirks but doesn't say anything back.

Jess asks, what if there are names of recently moved Citradel people in it. She had a good question. Luther says, it’s a fine line, but its still our jurisdiction. Anyone who moves here are now under our purview. She asks, I get that, but what I mean is that how do people know about these people. Its not like they are advertising right. Its basically something like a reference and word of mouth. So I was just thinking if there are only island people or from other communities in this disk.

Deni says, we had similar questions during our investigation. Unfortunately, there is no way to know until we get one name. I say, its fine. We will figure out what to do once we get the names. Lets not assume anything right now. Nathan turns to Tessa, I hear you got a lead. Tessa scoffs, it’s a very thin one. I feel like this disk will crack before I do. So that didn't pan out much huh. I say, it was a good idea. Luther asks, did Elina offered any other shipment. She says, nope. I wasn't even sure we will get one. Getting more from just Elina is a bit unrealistic.

Vanessa says, so we have only this to rely on. She turns to Marina, I don't want to give a vague time frame. How long before we get the names. You must have some approximate time in mind. Crap, she doesn't know. She eyes to me, what, neither do I. Marina plays it off, its not an exact Math. It could take a 3 hours or even 3 days. Nathan asks, really. I assumed you can at least predict how long the decryption will take. Fortunately, I got an answer from the hidden person in the room. I step in the conversation, what she said was just the lowest and highest limits. It will around 14 hours to get each names.

Somers says, what. Seriously, you are saying we have to wait that long. How many names are in there. I looked for help again before anyone could recognize them. I say, its between 60 to 70. That’s the best guess. I have no idea how they arrived at this number. I am just the messenger here. Ruther says, holy shit. So many. I was expecting there are maybe less than 30. Elina had made only 30 orders in total. Vanessa says, either some people were purchasing same thing or there were multiple smuggled items. Ruther says, I get that. But the crates don't have enough space to hold big stuff.

Marina adds, small things can be valuable too. Speculations were running rampant with the new information. I say, okay guys. That’s enough. This isn't the time for this. Vanessa, this much should be enough for now. She the bad on the table and puts the hard disk inside it, its much better than being clueless. Jess says, it would be really bad if the first name turns out to be someone important. Nathan says, that’s entirely possible. I sure hope that doesn't happen, because we would have a lot problem. People trust would waiver around unpredictability.

While everyone got ready for the meeting I spoke to Vanessa briefly, I told you to take the day off. Vanessa expression contorts a little now that its just me. She answers, I was out of line yesterday. I know that. It won't happen

again. I didn't believe her, because she herself didn't believe it. She says, and besides, regardless how I acted, if I am not present here, then it would look bad. She raises the bag, we are trying to show Citradel and any other community that we can handle our own shit. I am the head of security of this place. Do you believe it will show strength if I am missing.

I retort, before you handle the entire islands shit, can you handle yours. I was not holding back right now. Because I need to decide is she would not get carried away again, like she said yesterday. This got her to think hard, but she didn't say anything. I ask, David is going to join the call. How am I going to believe that you won't try to accuse him of hiding his involvement again. We got bigger things to worry than your trust issues. I had being harsh, but asking the questing I had to.

She answers, I will be fine. I am going to be fine. Trust me. You can ask Tessa to keep an I am me, you really don't think I can handle it. I say, I was already going to do that. If you don't mind it, then maybe nothing will go wrong. Vanessa says, don't worry about me. You got other things to worry about.

I was about to leave, but turn to her, what does that mean. Vanessa says, nothing, just saying things to myself. I really hope this turn into a mess.

Blake (Chapter 83)

Thursday, January 22, 2026 21:04

In another 15 minutes, the meeting started. We had setup a video conferencing setup with all of us here. There is feed going to the other room and to all the rest of the officers in the building. Once the screen opens, the first person we see is, Kafar, sitting in the middle. To his left is Geisha and on the right a younger guy I didn't know. Though facial recognition system runs on the screen and it shows his name, Winden. I think that's Ryes son. Huh, what happened to Ryes. And finally we see Derek in the far left.

Just these four people. I guess others council people are busy dealing with Heraknus movement. I open first, good morning everyone. They all greet to all of us next. Kafar says, this is quite unfortunate Blake. To think this happened this week. I say, I know. And here we thought Heraknus was the biggest highlight of the week. That even made Kafar smirk. Geisha says, everyone here is shocked and can't believe so many were involved in this. I answer, the shock came to us too.

Derek says, I know we got a lot of things to ask. But first I have to ask, where is Quintin. I turn to Vanessa. She says, we have him in a prison cell. There was an escape attempt by one of them, so we have them on lockdown. Winden speaks up, I don't understand this. He is one our best warrior. I refuse to believe that he is involved in such a thing. Vanessa says, no one saw it coming. Not about him, or Polly or Cory. It took us a lot of time, but we have their confessions recorded and the physical evidence of their involvement. So as much as we like to believe it was a mistake, its not.

Winden shook his head in disbelieve. Derek says, when are you going to share it to us. Vanessa signals Sommers and he taps his display. He says, I have just sent it to you in your IP address you sent us earlier. Kafar says, you already have everything ready. I answer, of course. We had a couple of really busy days. Somethings even ran till this morning. So apologies for not sending it before. But our team has everyone in custody now. Geisha asks, Derek, please have you team look at their evidence.

Derek says, will do mam. But I like to interrogate him personally. I say, you are free to do it. But let me tell you, he has been really uncooperative. We got him to open up only after grueling work and effort. Nathan says, these guys have strong Kuret resistance. So we had push them harder. Derek asks, let me worry about that. But you are right about one thing, he won't answer my questions when I am not around. Ideally I would want him to hand over him to us, but.

I interject him, you guess right. Our mess, our prisoner. If you want, feel free to come here yourself and talk to him. Derek smiles turning to Kafar, thought so. Kafar says, you won't budge that request huh. I say, its nothing personal, but we caught him red handed where people are injured and one almost died. Do you would hand over one of us he they had gone to Citradel and caused trouble there. Geisha says, I guess we won't. Winden asks, I know you won't try to hide anything, especially when Heraknus are going to move your city. But how can we believe anything you say.

This guy seriously thinks we are fabricating the whole thing. He seems to be more hot headed than his father. I look around the confused faces in the room and then I turn to screen, I should have asked earlier, but why is he here. Kafar says, that's rude Winden. Don't try to make a mess. Winden backs down like he was on a leash, sorry Blake. I should messaged earlier. Ryes is stepping down from his position. Instead we have his son taking over. Don't mind him, please. He is still new to this.

This is the first time hearing about this. I turn to Catherine quickly who shook her head slightly. She also didn't hear from her contacts then. I ask, is that so. Did something happen. Geisha says, nothing to worry dear. He just wants the younger people to take the reins. You know, like you all. He was just appointed last night. Winden says, apologies. I didn't mean to accuse you. I just, I have known Quintin for a long time. We weren't close, but he wasn't into hurting people.

Derek says, or being bodyguards to smuggler. I too find it hard to believe. But, he turns to him, since they are openly sharing evidence like this, its hard to ignore the facts. This put a lid on Winders anger, for now. Kafar asks, speaking of hurt people. How is the young women, Elina is it. I hear she is fine. Vanessa says, how did you find her name. We haven't told anyone but the officers. Kafar just smirks, please, don't underestimate our influence. It is necessary to be updated on situations like this.

Vanessa was about to say something, I cut in, that's fine. Its not like we were hiding her, it was just so that she could help us. Derek says, so she is not involved in this. Tessa says, not that we can see. Her brother, on the hand is one of the main smugglers. Derek says, using your own sister as a mule, that is either clever or pretty damn disgusting. Kafar says, I say both. No wonder no one suspected this was going on for months. This is where he begins his campaign to blame us.

Geisha asks, how come they all remained hidden. I get that there was a tournament going on, but this is quite disturbing. I say, they are pretty good. That's how. The boss, Wyan, he has quite a impressive operation going. I signal Luther who shares another set of document. I continue, take a look over these guys. One of them is, Kiera. She is the daughter of the alpha from Citradel. Technically, she participated in the tournament, but got unlucky and got eliminated when facing an omega in the first round.

They all take some time looking over a separate screens with the profiles involved, excluding Elina and Ryan. Kafar says, when Reish heard, he went mad. Said it was a mistake and wanted to get her back himself. They are still waiting for her. I say, we haven't harmed anyone of them. I will be sending you a live feed of them, you can share it her family. Not just her, all the 5 Citradel people involved. But I suggest you prepare all their families for a hard truth. No matter what they say, we have them dead to right next to bunch of smuggled drugs.

Whatever Kafar would try, I would have a counter for it. He asks, I see. Its quite fortunate for you that all of these people were found together with the evidence. This all seems very, Derek adds, suspicious. Lets not mince words Kafar. Derek seems to not care about bring subtle. I guess he was being impatient and cutting to the chase. Vanessa says, there is nothing suspicious about this. Oh no, hear we go. I sure hope she doesn't botch this.

Winden asks, how do you mean. She says, we got everyone claiming they fought each other because they were accusing of being traitor. If you look at the their statements, you see they all attacked each other. Its a whole lot of mess, but not that hard to imagine what happened. Kafar says, but don't you think its highly unlikely everyone self destructed like this. She answers, that's what happens when you have a mele with three strong warriors. Kiera said she was attacked by Polly, while Polly is trying to cover her ass by denying it. But she is claiming she fought both Cory and Quintin.

She was laying it pretty good to them. She continues, the boss is not talking, and trying to strong arm us with information. His lackeys are all blaming each other as traitor, and we have a guy for attempted murder. Are they all unreliable witness, a hundred percent. We have people saying they are not involved, but their Kuret signature and DNA are all over this. They are all involved in illegal activates. Not even you can deny that. So however the circumstances may look like, it is what it is.

She was getting angry a little, but that helps her case. Geisha asks, I am not questioning you dear, its just hard to accept. I think Vanessa did her part so I jump in, it was harder for us to accept this. We welcome you to inspect everything yourself. The scene is under lock, all evidence is prepared and tagged. All the people involved, even the ones on the bottom ladder are in custody. They are not going anywhere. Kafar says, but you are not going to hand over any of them to us.

I just shrug in response. I wasn't going to repeat myself over this again. Derek says, I guess we have no choice but to go ourselves and check it out. Winden says, and what about the exhibition match and Heraknus. We are not in position to do our own investigation. Kafar says, both you make good points. Lets table that discussion for later. He pauses for second and asks, lets talk about the people involved, as you say. Last I heard, you have only the smugglers in custody, but not the people who used them to buy stuff. And Wyan has not been cooperating, right ?

I say, that's just old news that you heard. We will soon have all the names and the smuggled goods. Geisha is surprises, that's new. Who are they. I gestured Vanessa. She says, they were using a hard disk to store the data. We recovered it and its being decrypted. We will soon have all the names of all 60 clients. Kafar says, my word. So many were involved. Derek asks, and what exactly did they smuggle. She answers, its talking time. The encryption is heavy.

Kafar says, lets not waste more time. How about you share it us. We have own tech team that can crack it. Vanessa says, I don't doubt you can crack it faster. This is pretty advance stuff. But besides that, there is evidence that Citradel tech was used when we took the internal x-rays. I will share that to you all as well. I am sure your team will recognize the designs. Geisha says, that's not good. Just how did Wyan get access to it. Kafar says, lets say it is really ours, then it makes sense we are best to crack it.

I take this request, sorry Kafar. Like I said, our mess, your mess, still our responsibility. I see his annoyed face, so I add, you are right about not wasting time though. But we only just cracked it this morning. I am sure we will find a way to get the data faster. You can't expect us to get it done in a day. Even you will have a fairly longer time. Unless of course, you can explain to our tech team what resources you have that we don't. This put a stop to this pursuit of this. Beacon they will not reveal their hand like this.
Derek says, you guys are pretty sure you of it.

Vanessa says, of course. We are all over it. I swear I could see Kafar glaring me for the corner of his eyes. I just pull a small smirk to him. If he thought I was going to cower to their advance tech capability, they are wrong. I add, once we get the names, I will share it with you. Though only if any of the Citradel people is involved. Kafar says, naturally. You don't want to disclose your own people. I say, not before we catch them and recover the smuggled goods.

Geisha says, you seem quite reluctant Blake. Is there any reason you don't want our help. I was waiting for this question, I am not happy with this situation. We never realized such a dangerous group running their operations. If I can't show you all that we can handle it, what's the point in bringing more people in. We don't have the long stability like yours, but we are getting there. And with Heraknus house coming, its even more important that we can improve our administration. This was a disaster, but's also an opportunity for us to grow. Isn't that how communities grow. We make a mistake, we learn from it, we get better.

This was a prepared speech from Luther. I liked so much that I didn't change anything and said it word to word. Luther smiles and shows a small thumbs up. Even Kafar had a hard time refuting this. He says, quite a bold statement. I nod, it is indeed. Geisha says, all right. I suppose we will continue to trust that you can handle this. Derek says, Vanessa, is it possible I can talk to Wyan, I am okay with you guys observing it. If he really used our technology, I would like to know he got it for himself.

Vanessa says, I can do that. Ruther, setup some time later for this. Ruther notes this down on his tablet. Derek says, thanks. Since you are no decrypting the data, what happens to Wyan now. He was withholding information from you all, what now. She says, to put it simply, he is screwed. Since his own people are blaming him, he will now want to save his himself as much as possible. We are very certain he will spill the bean on the entire thing. Where is the money from his operation going, how is he getting his clients and who his contacts are outside. He will squeeze everything out him.

Derek says, okay then. I would like to sit on that interrogation as well. She nods, gladly. I think we are making good progress. It was good that we weren't not going to acquiesce to any of their request. They will get only what we give them. Kafar says, this is all well and good. But let me ask this now. Your point to show your city's strength is commendable. But we don't have time for that. We never know when Hive will attack. And we are still in hostile planet. We can't have more problems like this for Heraknus. What if Heraknus were the victims in this, when they don't have their Kuret, they would be in grave danger.

It was bound to happen. Kafar is very predictable. No, actually it was obvious he would try to stop them moving here. I didn't want to open that can of worms, not yet, so I went with a diplomatic answer, I know all the concern people have. But the hard truth is, no one died. That’s a big win in my book. Sure, people were hurt, but that’s the price of being living on in a community trying to survive. If you expect that there won't be conflicts and problems, you are not being realistic. There will always be danger to people, not because they are in the wrong city, but because they are in the wrong plant.

My confident attitude made them stun for a second. I wasn't going to lie and sugar coat the hard truth saying we are going to protect everything. That's not possible. That's what the different between our ideologies. I thought this would be enough for Kafar, but he wasn't backing down from my strong sentiments. He says, you are right. This whole situation is a problem caused by something bigger than us. There are no good solutions. However, people still have to think which place is best for them. If you are going to be always in danger, best to stay in a place where it is less.

I guess I don't need to hold back now, are we talking about dangers to Heraknus or to everyone. He says, everyone who comes to your city. Be it an alpha or a regular person. How can they live in a community that is still not stable and dangers lurk everywhere. Is he even trying to hide his blatant accusation now. Gisha even tried to lean and tried to whisper something to him, but he didn't listen. Just how desperate is he for this. I could tell people here were also becoming annoyed at him now.

I turn to Catherine. She nods her head, all though she was reluctant about it. He leave me no choice but to reveal it then, if you are now talking which city is best place for Heraknus, why don't you explain about the fires to your harvest 3 years ago. I hear 3 people died and numerous people were hurt. This shocked everyone here, but even a bigger shock appeared on him. His eyes widen and he became frozen solid, did you find the culprit, or are they still in the wind. Didn't that create a shortage of your yield and you had to supplement with human replacement for few months.

Geisha says, someone is well informed. I nod, of course we are. Quoting what Kafar said in the beginning, don't underestimate us. We may not have your technology or skills, but we have one thing you don't have. Winden asks, what's that. I answer, it should be evident already. Our experience. We have lost many people. Many have struggled hard to survive. Its a powerful motivator to adapt and get stronger. Kafar says, one incident doesn't negate our advantages. We already know you have skills we lack. That why we want you here instead.

Guess he won't make it easy for himself, does strong people in your city really makes it better. Then how about you explain the robbery of a your weapons cache 6 years ago. An alpha died stopping the robbers, what was his name. Catherine says, Eren, I snap my fingers, yeah. Him. Seems like even with the current stability and security of that time, you had a severe causality. This made him nervous finally. He now knows that it was a fluke that we know about that one incident.

Derek says, how did you know about that. Not even some of the council members know about it. I say, I told you, we are good at adapting. I am curious though, did you catch the culprits. Derek turns a little grim as he turns to others behind him and then says, not all. Some escaped. Though we know who they are. I say, if you want, we can help you. We got a good track record of locating people. Though we use it to offer them a choice to relocate to one the large communities.

Derek says in low tone, I will think about it. I answer, good shall I continue. Because I even know the thefts of your Kuret cloth synthesizers. Winden says, synthesizers. Huh? He turns to both of them who were clueless, but not Derek. He asks, you know about that too ? He turns to Kafar, we had some devices stollen few months back. Kafar asks, stolen devices. Derek says, actually they were defunct, and we were going to use them for scrap parts. Geisha asks, stolen defective devices ? Why didn't you inform. Derek says, they were about to be destroyed, the theft itself was useless. I ask, really now, how is it I know about this incident, when you yourself don't know.

Their reactions is even more priceless. How the table has turned. I was ready with 2 more incidents. But I think Kafar had a fill of it, you made you point. Catherine, you has been very busy. You managed to get hold of our most guarded secrets. Catherine says, just doing my job. You should have better security. I didn't ask her to add more salt to their wounds, but I guess that put an end to this. Kafar had no more ammos to fire. There was an awkward pause among us.

Derek says, lets take a step back. Kafar, if you allow me I will ask next questions. Kafar could only wave to procced. Everyone relaxes now. The heavy mood was still there, we had to sit it aside for now. Derek says, what about your leads on who poisoned you, Marina. He had to ask the hardest question right after this. Marina had been very quite until now. But now she gets the chance to speaks up, I questioned Wyan myself. He doesn't know who stole the drugs. He has been cagy about his clients, but he didn't hold back being angry about the theft itself. You should hurry up and question him now, because I will get another round with him now that we don't need his cooperation.

He asks, you seem too fired up. I should prioritize that first then. Marina smiles like she was enjoying the thoughts of beating up Wyan. He asks, so your working theory is that whoever stole the drugs are the same clients who used Wyan. Vanessa answers, that's very certain. We are not giving up, but there's no lead, except this. She raises the hard disk from the able. She says, I know its unlikely, but maybe we get lucky and get the name of client in this.

Derek nods, yeah. But what if the people escape fearing the capture. Vanessa says, no one has every escaped this place in two years. And no one will ever. I say, besides, even if they do escape by some miracle, its good riddance. We will be safe from any further dangers from them. Then I would be than happy to let Marina pursue them outside to her hearts content. I pity those who made an enemy of Marina. She laughs hearing I was okay giving her free reign when that happens.

Even Derek mood lightens at that, I can personally attest to that. Seems like there is some funny history there. He continues, I suppose that’s all we can do is wait for the name to pop up. Geisha says, I must say. You have things running very tightly. Even I can tell it must have been tough getting this done so fast. I wish I could take the credit. We all have worked hard on this. But the main person who actually made it happen it is yet to join us. Geisha says, we have take some time to go over the data you have sent.

Vanessa says, I will open a channel with Derek later for any questions you have. She nods, thank you. That will help make things easier. Kafar says, I guess that settles that. Just one last thing. I answer, is it about the construction materials for Kuret enrichment. Thankfully Marina has already given us the list before. He says, did she. That makes things easier. How quickly can you gather it. We are preparing to send a team tomorrow. They will reach you in the next 36 hours.

Marina says, we got it covered. We will have everything on this list by the time the come. She taps her tablet and shares the list to them. Winden says, hold on. This is a little more than we thought. Kafar cuts him, no this better. Have a surplus amount. You were right to assume we needed some redundant materials. Derek asks, but did you really get them all. Marina says, I made the list the day you all went. So we had enough time to work through it.

This is the second time they were speechless. Winden asks, in 3 days. How did David manage that. I say, oh, so know about him. He says, yeah. He left some your city a while ago. But we don't know where he went. I was hoping they didn't know that. But its fine. I say, we have him on call. Shall I let him in. Kafar smiles, of course. Luther begins to type in the keys on the laptop. After a while a new screen on our connects and opens a view.

David is siting inside a plane with camera in front of him. He said he was in a jet, it does look like he is alone inside. The window behind him showed night time. Then is still quite far from here. He says, hey guys in grim voice. Something was wrong. He is forcing a smile. This is different than when he was putting up a performance. Something is up with him. Some of us clocked it too. Catherine, Vanessa, Marina, and Nathan aura changes. Derek says, hey David. You look tense, everything all right.

He shakes off the expression, just the lag. I haven't slept in 32 hours. Marina made quite a ridiculous demand. Marina says, not my fault. David laughs with some tension on him. He says, anyways. It was quite a challenge. Though I am happy to announce I got everything you would want. Even the equipment's. Widen says, that’s awesome. Did you find the industrial laser carbine cutter. We can send it over if you need it. There are very difficult to get by. David says, that is true. I only got one. If you can to send it, that will speed up the construction.

Widen says, great. Kafar, I will authorize to be sent with the team. Geisha asks, dare I ask how you got it. Because we had to steal ours. I didn't know that it was so difficult to obtain this equipment. David says, given the time frame, I bought it from the owner. Stealing leaves quite a trail for this type of equipment. She smiles, that’s one way to avoid troubles. Derek asks, how are you going to ship it to the island. He says, I shared the details to Tina.

Tinas turn comes up, we have a simple strategy. David is loading up ships with the materials and equipment's in the port of China. They are on course to the US. We will intercept them in the ocean, swap in the entire contents of the ship with different materials and it carries that to the US. David is going to hack the manifest so that what China is sending items which US will not be aware about. Instead they get what we swap in to the ships. They are simple alloys that China frequently exports.

Kafar says, this is simple in theory. But its not practical. What happens an inspection happens on. David cuts in, I have taken care of it. I have bribed the customs to turn a blind eye. They will approve our modified manifest. Kafar says, what about the water border patrols. They do regular checks on that routes. David nonchalantly says, bribed them too. I don't know what exactly is going on here. Is Kafar trying to trip up David for a mistake or testing him.

Kafar says, and what about. David jumps the gun, the port masters are also in. I had a chat with Patrick Drognerwind just few hours ago. He was more than happy to take a bribe. Turns out his son needs a start up money for a new business venture. Why did David explain so much more for this one specifically. The reason was because this caused Kafar's with an astonished face. I ask, any problem. Geisha says, ah, its quite a coincidence, we also use him for our transports.

David says, seriously, what are the chances of that. David says, I guess everyone would also use the same routes. Derek says, its the one with least suspicion to us. Was it really a coincidence. I am don't feel so good about this. Tina continues, the ships will pass through us about 480 miles away. We are going to intercept the ships tonight. Most of the humans will be asleep, the rest will be forces to be asleep for few minutes. In that time we will swap in our stuff. The crew won't even know we robbed them.

Derek says, okay. Sounds easy enough. How many ships will there be. Tina says, David only shared for tonight, around 5. David says, make that possibly 8. I just acquired a supply from the South Africa mines in the Ewaka region. So instead of waiting till tomorrow night, I will try to get them tonight. That’s actually why I am delayed. It was an unexpected opportunity I didn't want to let it go to waste. Winden says, you work fast. David says thanks, it was actually a really good luck that.

Kafar cuts in, hold on. Did you say Ewaka. By any chance are you talking about the Titanium mine in the village. David says, you know about that. Don't tell me you also use that and the routes. What is David doing now. Derek says, yeah. We have a contract with the local government. David shifts uneasily on his seat, really. Since when. He says, its been years. We couldn't steal Titanium in large quantities, so we had no choice but to buy these materials from them. Very less human know about it. We deliberately kept it this way so that less people monopolies it.

David says, ah. This is a little awkward then. What is going on. Behind me Catherines aura shine with a lot of confusion. Didn't she say David contacted her a while ago. He says, I bought the mineral rights of that mine. So, he makes a face that looks guilty, I guess your contracts are with me now. Derek jaw flew open, you did what. David shrugs, I thought the same as you. I wanted to capitalize on the entire mine. Great minds think alike I guess. I have never seen Kafar this nervous before. If we weren't in this situation, I would laugh at him being so speechless.

I grip my hands tightly as I turn to face others. None of us knew what David was doing. Catherine whispers to me, I told him that this morning. What the hell is David thinking. Geisha says, is this really a coincidence. David says raising his hand, what else could it be. I mean, it would be really a freaky coincidence if you also exclusively use the small platinum deposit from Germany. But that not possible. Its just a small vein that opened in the mountain 7 years ago. Funny thing, that mountain is not registered as an actual mine, so I had to buy the whole freaking land from the government.

They were hit with another shock. Geisha whispers something to a panicking Kafar. Derek was now staring hard at David. On stark contrast, all of us nervous at David blatant disregard for what he is trying to do. Why is he intentionally provoking them like this too. David sees them and laughs, no way. Okay, now I am sure something is very weird. How did this happen. Did you use the same guy, Orlove Koskov, to make the deals. Because I don't fully trust this shady guy.

That was the final straw from them. Kafar snarls at David and then says something to Geisha. Geisha says, ahm. Blake, sorry. We need to cut short this call now. We have to, hum, check on few things. Before I could say anything to them, she and Kafar both got up and left from the view. Winden was confused and didn't know what just happened, so he also left following them behind. Only Derek sat there with a grim face. He clears his throat, you got us good David. David behaves clueless, maybe we can made some sort of deal. I didn't know you guys were also being supplied from there.

He says mockingly, of course you don't. Well played. I assume this is retaliation for what Ryes did. I hit the limit of my patience, I ask, what the hell is going on. Am I missing something here. Derek says, you haven't heard, that’s a relief. Well, I can't explain it right now. But before I leave, I want to apologies to you, David. I tried to stop Ryes. But it was too late. Believe me. David had a very serious face now. No, he was pissed off. He didn't say anything and kept quite now.

Derek scratches his head, anyone would be angry at that, but only you have the means to do something about that. Just let me handle this. Okay. Blake, you don't have to worry about Citradel not coming now. They might call for Davids head, but this was our own fault for allowing Ryes to go after David like this. I will see you all later. Before I could get any more words in, their videos turns off. Now it was just us worried officers and a pissed off David. Nathan asks, ah, someone's explain what just happened. I stand up, what did you do David.

David takes a glass from his side table. I don't think it was water. He takes a sip and says, what I had to. Marina asks, what does that mean. He sighs, do you what happens when a dog keeps barking at you. You smack it down and remind who has the leash. I just reminded them of that. Marina gets nervous at his demeanor, what happened. What did Ryes do. After contemplating a lot, he says, first, take me off the video call from other officers. I will tell only to you all. Luther says, it something sensitive. He nods, very. Luther turns to me. I had to trust David had a reason. I nod. Luther goes back and starts typing on his laptop. After few heavy silence of seconds he says, done.

David says, I don't know how this happened. But 8 hours ago, one of my sources told me Ryes gave an their interview in Citradel. It was broadcasted to other communities, excluding us. The whole time he was defaming me and involve other's along with it. I ask, what. Ryes would never do anything like that. David says, I don't know how it happened. I heard only pieces of that interview, but it was clear what is goal was. Throw all the possible dirt on me to create doubt people from moving to our city. Catherine says, hold on. This is the first time I am hearing of this. He says, Kafar has somehow able put a lid on it. Or Reys planed it this way.

Luther asks, what was Ryes saying. David says, he has dig up my past on Earth. Not just any, but all the worst parts of my life and twisted them to absurd lies. I knew I was about to garner a lot of negative attention due my sudden fame from the finals. But I never imagined this. He was dead set on making Heraknus change their decision. I yell, no. That can't be, he has been a supporter of moving here. David says, then Kafar or someone else got to him. Because he had sudden change of heart and began a complete smearing campaign.

This is unbelievable. I can't believe Rayes would do this. Is they why his son was here instead. Marina asks, what did he say exactly. David was a reluctant a little. Then he says, Ryes said I hid for years in Greenville, living a ignorant and blissful life while everyone else was trying to stay alive. I was somehow the reason why half the people were mascaraed 5 years ago when Hive attacked the compound. He began lying and giving fake evidence that I somehow led people to their deaths. That’s why I always remained behind the scenes, to cover up for my failures. I gasp, what the shit. Vanessa says, what a load of crap. Because of you, half of them made out alive.

David says, if it was directed at me, I wouldn't have retaliated like this. But then he somehow found about our tussle in the Valley. Shows photographs and eye witness claims that I released the poison gas to kill the other MARs children, like a mercy murder since they were dying anyway. I use the panic I caused myself to become a hero when I risked my life from it killing anyone else. Catherine says, holy mother of. Then all our eyes to go to Nathan. He was just as clueless as us, I swear I didn't tell anyone about this. David says, I know you didn't. Because you are painfully aware not what would happen if you ever said a word about it.

Nathan was put under pressure from David's glare. Only David can him so nervous. I ask, what kind of fabricated proof he showed. He turns to me and says, don't know. All I know is that it was so convincing that more than few people believed it. They also know that I killed, someone, to take over his criminal empire. Twisting the truth was not enough for him. He said I was tried to kill Nathan because he was against human experimentation, while I wanted to do it. Freak. This one must hurts us the most now.

Nathan snarls, what the hell was Ryes thinking revealing that. David says, that’s not the end of it. He says I somehow used Oriana with a cold and calculating manipulation, made her to save Blake life even at the cost of her own. I don't even know how he could make anyone believe I did that. My confusion turn to anger. Did he really drag Orina into this nonsense too. Catherine says, that’s complete bullshit. David says, tell that to him. I have know historical real life dictators with less notoriety than what he kept painting on me with.

Luther shouts, has he lost his mind. David says, he might have. The last thing I learned was how I roped Marina in and got her to betray Citradel. For years. Then I used her, poisoned her and Blake once they cleared in enough people and I cheated my way through the finals. I had to sit down now. My head was throbbing and aching now. Marina shouts in anger, bloody freak. He said that. David says, there were other minor things, but these were the major highlights.

I shook my head wrapping around this. Did Ryes betray us or was he blackmailed. But either way, Citradel allowing this to happen in the first place is completely unacceptable. Tessa says, how did this happen. Even I don't know much about these thing before I met you all. I says, he knew enough truth to twist them into convenient lies. My Kuret bursts out of my hand and table edge crack under the pressure of my anger. Luther takes a step back. I never imagined Oriana death be used like this.

Viens pop in my head, you let them off easy. I heard people gasping behind me from my sudden anger. David says, I know. There is only so much I can do without completely shattering the deal I made with Charles. This was the only choice I had left. Luther says, they purposefully left us out in that broadcast. Did they think we weren't going to find out about this. Nathan asks, are you sure all this happened. Maybe you were fed wrong intel. I have people in other communities, no one told me this happened.

David makes a scowl, you think I would do this without absolutely making sure the authenticity of my information. Go check with your people if you still think this was a lie. David's anger put Nathan doubts away, no, you wouldn't do something so drastic if it wasn't true. Vanessa asks, how did he found about all of this. David didn't answer. Only select people know that someone is betraying us big time. It was only Marina and me that were targeted before. But now its David too. David was right to not involve others, he foresaw him getting targeted next.

Catherine says, the timing of this is also suspicious. You left the city and then Ryes goes live with this crap. She was right. This had to be deliberate. David says, I agree. He knew I would retaliate, so he did it when I was away or on the travel. Once I realized what had happened I had to make my moves immediately. If I wait and give them time to anticipate my move, I don't know what else they would have done. Once I made up my mind, I got the details from Catherine about their recourses and went to monopolize it for myself.

He says, now, no matter what kind of dirt they throw at me, destroy my reputation, they are at my mercy if they want to expand their infrastructure. They no longer have the resources do it themselves. You all heard Derek, he understood how it impacted them. I am sure they will try and resist this. But its futile in the end. I am awe in the swift and ruthless action. Just in one move, he has completely destroyed Citadel's potential to move people in.

Marina says, holy shit. Damn David, you got them by the balls now. Luther says, we need to mitigate the fallout. He turns to Tina, contact others. Send out teams to other communities and explain them this is a lie and not to believe anything Ryes said. Before Tina could say anything, David says, no. Don't do that. Luther asks confused, what. He answers, denying it so excessively will not solve anything. The more you deny it, the more people will believe its true. Like the rumors about me cheating. Do you really believe if I had denied, people would accept it. No. Even if I explain how I did it, their doubts will never be gone.

Vanessa says, so you are not going to do anything about it. David scoffs, do anything? Didn't I just say I took their toys away from them. What more do you want me to do. Its already more than appropriate response for this. Luther says, its not just about you David. All of us are being dragged through the mud. David sighs, I had time to think over it. Take some time for yourself too. Even if Citradel now makes an apology for Ryes actions, my reputation has gone to shit. This isn't court and there is no government to uphold our actions. Word of mouth has lot of weight right now. You make a wrong move, you will get dragged down with me.

Vanessa says, we can make it right. We will tell everyone the truth. David says, to what end. The events itself wasn't lies. Just lied about my involvements and intentions. No matter how much truth we tell, there will always be a nagging feeling that I am at the very least not reliable. Whether I lose to Charles, or win or just surrender. The doubt will never go away. And that by extension means you all. They might not show it, but they will think you are complicit in some, if not all of my actions in the past.

I slam another fist on the table and stand up. My Kuret settles down a little, so what exactly are you saying we do here. David says, I only offered my opinion on not making a rash move. I'll leave it to you decide how to handle this. I did what I could to counter the effect of this smearing. Ryes wanted to stop Heraknus from moving, I made a move that forced the Citradel to move. I won't do anything more. If you want to deny or tell the truth, fine. I won't stop you. I never plan to order you. Just voicing my opinion. I have my own troubles right now.

I say, Citradel won't let this go so easily. They will fight, try to get back the resources you stole. David says, let them try. This was just the start, I will soon monopolies all the mines and deposits they use. Even if they look for someplace else, I will be ready to snatch it away from them. All the purchases are not under my name, but they are done by my people, who have the major government support. So the local government can't side with Citradel. Unless they make bigger waves and attract attention of more humans, they are screwed.

Nathan says, just how much loaded are you right now. Didn't you just gave away a large amount of money in a bet. I ignore him and ask. Okay, but what if they forget about getting it legally and steal it. David laughs at me, I already planned for that eventuality. You think I am just buying the mines and deposits. No, I am going to empty it immediately. Citradel don't have the resources like I have to extract the ores and minerals. Pretty soon they will be dry and Citradel won't be able to steal anything, because there will be nothing. Tina says, what the. That’s why you are sending more ships tonight.

David has everything all ready planned out. He did say that he had time to figure out a plan. He has completely outsmarted Citradel. I couldn't help but enjoy that they are all panicking right now. Luther says, that’s a genius move David. But still, I don't think I can keep quite about this. Soon everyone in the city will hear of this. You might have forced Citradel to move, but what about you. And the people Ryes involved along side you in this lie. David says, I am not saying not to do anything. I am only cautioning against what not to do.

After a tense silence he says, I have to go now. The deals I made are not completely finalized. I got the ball rolling, but I am on my way right now to finalize it. I am about to enter into a monitored air space. Look guys, the bottom line is, I made a decision that I am fine with. Whatever repercussions happens due to this, I am fine as long as its just me. I strongly urge you to stall for some time before people learn this. He then turns his neck to something off screen, all right. I will see you all tomorrow. The connection turns off.

I turn to angry and confused faces. Everyone where in utter disbelief. I say, I don’t know about you all, but I am not planning to just let this slide.

Vanessa (Chapter 84)

Friday, January 23, 2026 12:54

I had a little cry last night. It was embarrassing. But I needed to get it out of my system. When I went back home, I shut myself inside the room and stayed in for few hours. I was immersed in self doubt and shameful behavior in front of Elina and Blake. I couldn't believe I was so angry at David and Ned that I would be looking for petty revenge. But I had learned by my lesson from last time. Being cooped with frustrating thoughts just don't do any good for me. I went to the gym later after dinner and poured all my anger out on a spontaneous workout.

I must have destroyed the kuret filled boxing bag before I left. Thankfully Siera was busy and came late last night. I managed to avoid yet another embarrassing encounter with her. I couldn't handle her being disappointed in me. Letting out my anger was good, because I became so tiered that I dozed off immediately. I felt much better than yesterday, and honestly, I could see how spiteful I was acting yesterday.

I couldn't believe how gullible Elina was with David lies. No, she knows he had lied about few things. Yet she even has a crush on him. I still couldn't wrap my head around it. I was projecting my own insecurities on to her. How can she trust a person who lies like he breathes. What would she do if she knew what David as been doing.

But what's even crazier is that Mack is real person. Its so confusing that I continue to waver if David using Mack's identity or if it was someone else. There was nothing to go apart from the name to link to David. David isn't paying him to use his identity. So what's up with that. I had to shake those thoughts because I had work to do and I promised myself that I won't let my emotions get the better of me.

I had to make Blake believe I was fine today. I half expected that he would force me out. The case I made him believe I was thinking clearly now. It was a relief that he allowed me to stay. Things were going smoothly at first. There was some back and forth, but we assured them we can handle this mess on our own. Like most, I knew Kafar would use this to try and make this meeting about our shot capabilities. What I didn't consider how Blake was ready to counter this. His merciless rebuttal against each their verbal attack was very precise. Catherine must have found out about those incidents.

Everyone knew there will be issues in any community. But Citradel had hidden them well, claiming the title of the most safest place for us on Earth. That illusion was shattered and they backed down before Blake broke more of that illusion. I thought it was over then. Jeez, I was so wrong. I don't know why, but whenever David is involved with Kafar, there is always a danger looming in the corner. I thought Blake was bring ruthless, but David trumps that. David was so condescending, I thought it was simply just because he could. But then reason come out. David doesn't like to talk about the past, for many reasons. He told me many times he made lot of mistakes and doesn't want them to be define him.

Its just him that thinks that. Its true I am having trust issues with David, but that doesn't mean he is a bad guy. He is a terrible person, but not how Ryes kept slandering him. They thought with David busy, they would get away with it. This is what happens when you piss off David. Ryes had betrayed us or he was never in our side. This is all Kafar, he used Ryes to lower our guard around us or threatened him. With the unexpected power of money and opportunity, David gave a devastating blow to Citradel.

The aftereffects of the meeting still continued to lunch. Blake issued few orders. Its not been ever done before, but he asked to close off communication with other communities for several hours. Luther played it clever, under the guise of a system upgrade, the network has been down since morning. This may not prevent the news from spreading, since few people have their own separate communication system. But this will buy us some time. The next order was to send a team to Citradel incognito.

Many volunteered, even Marina and Catherine. But he denied them, saying Citradel will be already on high alert for these two people. After a lengthy conversation, Blake decided to form a team on his own. Without anyone knowing so that no one can leak it to Citradel. We didn't understand who would be good enough to break into Citradel, if not the two Shadows. But he later says there is a team he has in mind. In the end, we left that to him. The final order was for specifically to me, Marina and Catherine, he wanted us to meet him after lunch.

I could imaging what Blake wanted to talk to me about. During my lunch with Tessa and Sommers, many officers wanted to know from us why David did that. Tessa helped cover it by revealing portion of it to the rest of IDF crew. That Citradel made a desperate attempt to keep Heraknus from moving. We never explained how to anyone, just that it so bad that David fought back. Sommers says, David does not mess around. He absolutely crushed them in the most brutal way possible.

Most of high ranking officers knew that David was being framed of crimes, even without us clearing those accusation. Deni was the vocal about it. They weren't for many the stuff before we came to the island, but she had enough trusted him a lot. If this happened yesterday, I would have been more conflicted. But after sleeping on it I wasn't bothered by David's actions. Tessa smiles, just how much money did he spend for this massive endeavor. Citradels only chance is to try and get it back from him before David empties the mines.

I have seen a little bit of his criminal network, but this had to be one of most impressive feat yet ever. Sommers says, you think they will try to stop him for purchasing it. She nods, David told himself, if those mines becomes his, he will not sell it back. They would have no legal option left, no way they will go to human courts or civil administration. They can't risk opening a fraud case when they themselves don't want to be caught in it. So they have to stop him from taking over.

I say, or steal from him later. She nods, that's more easier. I say, David must know that already. He probably will hire an small army to protect the places. He had done something similar to this before. Sommers smiles, dude's hardcore. He is has been glazing him a lot, but it' true. Tessa says, I heard he was in Germany now. So he is working down the list somehow. Do you know who his allies are? They must be quite powerful put these things together so fast.

They both turn to face me. I shrug, no clue. Since David is posing as a wanted human criminal, he wants to keep us and that world different. And I am very happy about it. But, I try to recall a conversation few months back, I have some suspicion though, he has visited Europe several times. So I am guessing someone very powerful is backing him. Somers ask, the prime minister? Tessa asks, someone higher perhaps. Maybe the queen of England herself. I laugh, maybe. I wouldn't be surprised if it were both. I get an alert on my message. Its Blake, he is ready for me now.

I got up with my empty lunch tray, I am going to meet Blake. See you in a while. After cleaning up and I head back to the officers building. Just like yesterday, Ned had left me a voice mail today too. I would have deleted it again, but I decided to listen to it now. He says, Vanessa. I really hope you get this message. I know you have been busy past few days. But I never wanted this to drag it this long. I know we can find a way to talk through our issues. Give me a chance to make it up to you. I may not look like it, but I miss you. Please, meet me at my place tonight. Like yesterday, I will keep waiting until you agree to meet.

This is like the first time I am getting some sort of apology from him. I am seriously having mixed type of emotions. I want to do both, talk to him and not. It's just messing me up even more. I sigh as I enter the building, deciding to think about it later. A while later I enter Blakes office. I assumed Luther was with him, but he wasn't in. Marina and Catherine were here already. And couple of unexpected people. June and the alpha twins, Frank and Chealse. This a very odd group of gathered here.

Blake says, close the door will you. I lock it behind me and take a place beside Catherine, so, what is this about. June asks, is this everyone you wanted. He says, not quite. Just waiting for Derek to join in also. I notice there was a Kuretine device flaring on the corner of the table. I wave to the 3 Citradel warriors, hey guys. Its been some time since I saw all of you. June fleshes a smile and waves me hi. Chealse says, yeah, I think last time was the flag capture game we saw you. Frank says, hey Vanessa. Its been long too. The tournament was just ended, but it feels so long ago.

I felt the same way. June says, any idea what this is about though. I shrug. Marina says, let me tell Vanessa and Catherine first. These 3 have decided to join us here, in the city. I was a little surprised, but also glad. Catherine says, that’s awesome. Welcome. I say excited, this is the best thing I have heard all day today. June says, I know. I was wavering a lot, but yesterday I told Citradel I moving here. Frank says, there are actually few of us.

Marina tells, around 26 Citradel warriors are going moving here. Catherine says, that’s a whole lot of them. Did you decide as group. June nods, we did. Honestly, I would have liked to join along with Marina, but she jumped the gun. Marina stand proud at her impromptu switch. I ask, that’s wonderful. So I am guess you all were chosen to be high ranking officers too. Chelsea says, we do. Frank says, I would have been happy either way. June says, I actually didn't want to be one.

I ask why, you were in the top 8. She shrugs, same reason I didn't want to join you in that VIP group. I don't like to stand out too much or have too many responsibilities. But Marina changed my mind after learning of the benefits. Blake sighs, please know she would have exaugurated it a bit. June says, oh I know. But if she is fine being one, I guess its not that bad, huh? Marina says, exactly. I don't think she realized June was mocking her. Blake says, well, Luther should have briefed you all yesterday, and you since haven't changed your minds, I am guessing you all no issues.

They all didn't seem to have apparent problems. I ask, which department are you all planning to join. June says, these two haven't decided. I am planning yours. I smile at her. She says, you guys were very efficient in handling the smuggling gang. And its impressive you got caught all the people involved so fast. We had issues in Citradel before, but not like this. I ask incuriously, really. I turn to Blake hinting at the Citradels supposed hidden incidents. Blake got the message, listen guys. Since you are all joining, there are few things we will have to tell, things Citradel hid from general public.

Frank asks, like Heraknus, because we didn't know. People have asked us so many times, its pretty embarrassing. Chealse says, honestly, that gave me panic too. How the hell Kafar kept them a secret for so long. Marina says, that too. But other stuff too. Because we were hiding among Human, Kafar was very easily able to hide many things. I still mad at Melinda being Charles wife. She fooled me completely. Her Shadow pride was hurt a little. June says, so what else is there.

Blake says, a lot more. But lets table that for later. I have gathered you all here to discuss very urgent matter. His expression becomes serious. Catherine asks, its about Ryes right. He nods. Just then the Kuretine device flares up and a hologram of a certain figure comes in view. Its Derek. He says, is this everyone Blake. Blake says, yes. Thanks for joining. David must have thrown you into a frenzy. Derek says in a stern voice, its chaos here. I don't suppose you can tell where David is ? I am supposed to send a team to stop him.

Blake mood had improved, but not so much that he would agree to his earnest request, sorry. At the moment, I am not going to help Citradel in any way. He nods, I understand. It was worth a try. Frank asks, what's going on guys. I thought we were holding a meeting with just us. Derek says, hey now. Just because you left, doesn't mean you forget I am still your friend. Frank snickers, then prove it. Everyone has pleaded to leave Citradel and come with us.

Seems there is some friction between them. Marina adds, I know. I tried to get to change his mind too, Frank. The guys too stubborn. Chealse asks, you know, some of are haven't forgotten you lied about Charles. Derek sighs, this again. Chealse, this isn't the place to bring that again. Besides, you think I wanted to lie. I have told you, I need to be on Kafar's side. At least for now. You think this is bad, if I am not there to handle him, it would be worse. Marina asks, worse than Ryes spewing lies on TV.

June asks, Ryes. You mean chancellor Ryes. What's he got to with this. Blake says, before I explain that, let me tell you all why I have gathered you all here. He turns to Derek, this might take some time, can you spare an hour. Derek says, I assumed as much. Yeah, I asked for some time alone. We should be good. Then Blake explained his reasons. With four newcomers, he had to explain from the beginning, I am going to tell you talk about some

details the investigation of the smugglers and how they link to the sabotages.

I thought he was going to reveal David's role. But he told them nothing about him. Instead about the details not released to the public. About the drugs stolen, and then used on Marina. And then he explained new stuff even I didn't know about. Turns out there was another drug involved, which Peter continently forgot about. That coward. We have questioned him so many times, how the hell did he forgot something so important. He said he learned it from Wyan, but I know we haven't gotten that information from him yet. Since the client list is not decrypted, he has remained silent, trying to keep his leverage which is sinking.

I assume then it was David who told them about it. Even Catherine didn't knew about this. Then he explained how its possible one of our officers were involved too. Its something I dismissed early on as a possibility, since we didn't have any proof of it. But there is a strong possibility now. If Blake believes it, then David believes it too. Then he told how they initially suspected Citradel to be the culprits, but now its one of us. And after today, its high chance of it. Now that Marina, Blake and David are being targeted, its likely from the same people.

June asks, how does that make sense. If someone is betraying you all, what's the point going after him and try to dissuade Citradel to move here. Marina says, that’s what confusing. No one knows why create such chaos like this. But didn't you hear about the rumors of him cheating. Chelsea says, yeah. That was the day after the tournament. I thought it was the admins who started it. Blake says, not them. It was Kafar.

Then he explained how Melinda had visited us 3 in the night. He didn't talk about the second portion of the talk, likely knowing that it didn't directly effect David, but it would to me. He wasn't wrong. He even made a slight eye contact at me to make sure I don't talk about it. I got the message and didn't dare. Marina also caught that and remained away from that topic. June says, Kafar really has bug up his ass, huh. He would go so far to question Davids history and try to stop Heraknus.

Frank says, its not that hard to believe. Derek, you said you didn't want to leave Kafar. Did you meant for this? Derek says, not just this. Back in Citradel too. But I can't tell about it. I just can't go against Kafar. Not until we all move to the island. I need to remain on his side. Frank nods like he somewhat accepting it. Chealse asks, so you think because of that rumor, David would be targeted too. But didn't you said it wasn't Kafar, and someone from this island.

Blake says, they maybe working with Kafar. Or maybe using him. Derek shook his head, no way. I know the guy better than himself, he would never work with others. Catherine asks, how sure are you. Because you didn't believe Quintin would be involved in this. But he had another side hidden. This made Derek anxious. She made a good point. June says, I didn't know Quintin well, but even I was devasted to know he was involved in that mess. The two twins also were frustrated with him.

Blake says, be that as may, the point is, you don't know Kafar's every move. Do you? So keep an open mind about it. Derek remained silent, lost in his thoughts. Blake continues, that little rumor was enough to make David believe he was next. It turns out, David was right. It was even done so publicly. June asks, what happened. Seems like something big happened. Frank asks, you spoke earlier about David leaving a mess in Citradel. Blake then revealed what happened today.

After listing this, all three had to sit down with anxious looks as he talked about Ryes interview. Blake was visibly getting angrier when he talked about Oriana. Catherine and me helped him out in between the explanation so that he calm downs. They all had bewildered expressions. Marina asks, that’s not you expected your first day here to look like, right. Hope you don't regret it now. June says, this is very different from Citradel. That’s for sure. Chealse says, now I know why the network is down. This would definitely cause a major distrust on David.

Frank tugs on his hair, Ryes is a level headed guy. To think he would do something so underhanded. Are you sure he would with be working with someone. Chealse says, do you think these guys would be so angry if it was a lie. Derek says, allow me to explain a little. All eyes feel on him. He says, last night, Kafar agreed to let Ryes take an interview. I was told it was going to be shown to all the communities, including yours. Everyone thought it was going to be a debate on why we should all move to the island.

His eyes widen, little did I know it was the complete opposite. Everyone panicked and I rushed to stop him. But the most crazy thing was that Ryes was hijacking his interview to look like it was from his home. I broke inside his house where only his wife and son where there. He was never there. We searched everywhere for him in Citradel. By the time we found where the interview crew was taken, it was too late. I didn't hide my rude voice as I ask, please don't say he is missing.

Derek sighs, he is not in Citradel. We found a footage of him leaving Citradel. Don't know where he went. Blake asks, you lost him. That’s pretty convenient. Derek replies, I know how it looks like. But believe me, none of us know why he did that. Or where he is now. I got an idea, that’s actually good news. We can go look for that bastard. Blake takes a moment to think, are you searching for him. He says, of course. He made the biggest blunder of his life. We have sent a team after him, searching every safe house, and every place he ever visited. Catherine asks, you know, he could have been blackmailed and then kidnapped.

I didn't think that was the case. Few of us believed he was just cozying us up, trying to get people on his side and throw a big mess at us. Derek says, I can't be sure of that. But regardless, he went for David's past, dredging up painful memories for him and twisting the truths. I am very certain that David is hunting him too. Marina asks, does he know Ryes escaped.

Derek shrieks, really Marina. You think a guy, who was able to find this out, even after we did everything we could do to suppress it, doesn't know Ryes left. Nah, he knows. Regardless of whether Ryes is innocent, or complicit, David is going to hunt him relentlessly. And when he gets his hands on Ryes, there will be hell to pay.

He was right. David said he wasn't going to do anything more, but I doubt he will leave this matter alone. Blake says, after you left the meeting, he was very mad. I don't know what he might do. He turns to me, how quickly you can form a team to look for Ryes. I lean forwards, I can have people ready in an hour. Many officers were confused earlier about David's actions, but now they have some idea on what happened. I bet they will be ready to back us. Blake says, good. Form your team, tell them what really happened and Ryes is in the wind.

He turns to Derek, I know this is very rude, but unfortunately, if we find Ryes, we are not going to hand him over to you. He nods, right back at you. He then looks around the room, if you wanted to talk just about this, you wouldn't have explained so much. So what's the ask. Derek must be wanting to finish this a little faster now. Blake says, right. Now that you all know the situation, I need all of your help in finding out who is behind this. I can see what Blake was planning with us now. Frank asks, how. And why us.

Marina answers, simple. You guys are in the clear, there is no point for any of you to go after us. I recommended you all to Blake to help out. Chelsea asks, but we are new. Blake nods, exactly. Meaning you will be impartial and see things we won't. June asks, you want us to investigate this matter. Its not exactly our forte. She was right. They are fighters, not detectives. Blake says, what I need from all you is eyes and ears. Nothing more. Since you all recently joined, any strange behavior will be chalked as curiosity. Making it less suspicious to the people behind this.

They begin to finally understand their roles. June says, that is something I can help with. If its just about observing, I am very good at it. Chealse got weirdly excited, a spy. I know its serious thing, but I kind of feel we would be good at it. Frank makes a scowl, speak for yourself, I am bad at hiding. Marina says, don't worry about that. You being nervous is completely fine. And if you play it correctly, it will even help you to blend in much better. He wasn't exactly thrilled by her support.

Blake says, she is right. I am not asking you to do anything you don't want to. This is strictly observe and report. But in case you do want to do some more digging if you find anything, take help of your supervisor. They will also be made aware of you. At that June says, okay. But how can you be sure its not someone from the high ranking officers. No offense, but isn't Nathan a prime suspect. He has known David for long. He could have supplied Ryes with the information. Catherine says, normally yes. But he is living in this island with under a careful scrutiny. If he did anything like this, we would have found out.

Chealse asks, but still. He is good at hiding stuff. He could planed this long before the tournament. I join in, IDF is tracking his every move. If you want, I can check and tell you what he ate for todays breakfast. Every communication to outside the city is monitored. I then take a sigh, besides. Even if he wanted to do this, he can't. He knows he will be snuffed out. Frank asks, and by that you mean ? Blake says flatly, David will straight up kill him. He was already close to doing it 2 years back. The only reason he lives is because of Jess and Freya. Nathan may not never show it, but he is more scared of David out of any of us. So yeah, if he even is partially involved in this, it’s a death sentence for him.

June asks surprised, seriously. He is a royal alpha. I say, doesn't matter to us. As long is Freya is alive, its fine. I don't think they were expecting us to be frivolous with his life. Derek says, lets not assume anything. I also like to believe no one from you all could do this. I am sure one of you would notice it right away. Blake says, true. That’s why there is benefit of doubt. Frank asks, so why aren't everyone here then. Why only us. Marina answers, two reasons. One, just because they are not involved, doesn't mean someone close to them is innocent. They could have stuck close by and gathered information. That made sense, otherwise how can anyone know so many of our past.

Blake says, second reason. The people here I have here will not, in any circumstances, talk about our past. We have been with David longer than others, and all of us want want to keep it private. There is actually one more person more closer to David than us, but I didn't involve her. June asks, and who is that. I answer, Cassandra. She used to meet David and his human guardians for years. She knows things even I don't know. Derek asks, and why don’t you want to involve her.

Blake hesitate to answer. Marina answers for him, because she is the most likely source. I didn't know we were suspecting this. Catherine asks, are you serious. But why. She wouldn't tell anyone. I say, not necessarily directly. But she could have been hacked, or spied on. I hate to think, but yeah. She may not have realized it. Derek asks, isn't that a wild guess. Its too week of a reason. Blake says, there is another reason. He sighs, among the things David told me about Ryes accusation, he said Greenville.

June says, so? I see, I never caught that before. Catherine says, shit. David never told where he used to live. Derek says, seriously. He never told you guys? Blake remains quite. Marina asks, yeah, why not tell us that. I know why, I answer, This is the first time I heard about too. But he didn't want to tell anyone about his foster parents. He has human enemies, so if it ever got out he lived, then they could find a trail and try to catch them. Marina says, wait, so is he like protecting them?

Catherine recalls something, hold on. Yeah. I remember this. They are with Home, aren't they. I mean before Echo forced them to run. I nod, yes. To this day, only Cassandra knows about them. Since she is in the city, even if she talks about them, Medrones won't care. But outside this city, some communities have beefs with Humans, Echo, Home or just normal humans. So being called out where they used to live is a big deal for David. Chelsea, holy shit. Doesn't that mean she is literally the leak. Does she know about this.

Blake says, its not for certain. Just like Ryes, I am highly suspect of this. And she doesn't know about it. Not yet at least. But I want you all to leave her alone. That’s because I will personally keep an eye on her. I say, David would do something familiar. He must have also thought what we suspect. He nods, most definitely. A rather long pause remains in the air. Then Derek says, seems you made up your mind on how to handle this. But you are telling quite a lot about this. Why trust us to tell us so much.

Blake says, take a look around us. I didn't chose you all just because you all are new. All of us were in tournament. And we fought someone involved in this. It took a second, but it clicked. Derek says, quite the clever team you formed. June and others understand too. Marina says sighs, I see. Now I understand why wanted Derek too. All of you have fought David. June scoffs, more like smoked. The twins become a little irritated being reminded of

that. Blake says, I wanted people that have seen him up close. This all started with his rumors of cheating. Setting aside the abilities he showed in finals, do you think he would cheat?

That question made them recall the tournament and their matches. David had joined the tournament initially to systematically defeat as many Citradel warriors as possible. I still don't know how he twiddled through games and rounds to get matched with so many Citradel warriors. Save for me and Marina, everyone here had fought him in the top 500. June says, it does sound a little absurd. He never used those things against me. He didn't need to struggle so much with me or Derek if he had that option.

Frank says, hey, I don't like that tone. You think he went easy on us. Chealse nostrils frails, yeah. We gave him a tough time too. While that is true, David wasn't serious about defeating them. He was just using them to gain attention. But the two of them also didn't believe he needed to cheat. Cathrine says, is that good enough for you Derek. He smiles, I didn't think you of all people would rub it in. But yeah, I do feel this just enough to give David the benefit of doubt and get our help. But why me. I am still with Citradel.

Blake says, I wanted you in for another reason. You see my thinking is that whoever is behind is, they are naturally wary of the new people. They would be much harder to snuff out. He says, you think I can help from outside. Blake says, exactly. I am not asking you to do something kafar doesn't want you to do. Instead I want to warn in advance and prepare for what I have planned. This was news to everyone, even Marina. Derek says, so generous. I can't tell if it’s a threat or not when you say it so ominously.

Blake says, its strange. I know, but I am going to tell you what Luther and I decided to do to avoid people from believing these lies. He says, I am guessing its not denying right. Because as much as I want to tell the truth about it, I don't think people will easily accept it. Marina says, you sound like David. He also didn't want to outright deny it. Derek says, it’s the most obvious, and a hard play. Ryes has given solid proofs. Even if they doctored, he said it first. People have already formed their opinion about it. It will be very hard to refute that, especially when none you seem to eager to share your past.

He was right. As much as I wanted to immediately tell everyone the truth, after spending just few hours with other officers, I begin to feel the slight pressure of how to make them believe us. Blake says, its not that. No matter how much I want to set the record straight, it won't help us in the long term. So we are going to do something else. And for that I needed you to understand our situation first. He says with conviction, you can't betray Kafar, I gather that much. But you can hinder his efforts, even if it goes against Citradel. There is a very fine, but clear distinction.

Derek smirks but doesn't say anything, likely signaling that Blake is right. Blake says, I am going to publicly blame this whole smuggling operations on Citradel.

David (Chapter 85)

Sunday, January 25, 2026 18:26

Are you listening to me kid. I answer lazily, yeah, yeah. No need to be loud. The voice on the other end of the phone says, no you are not. I can hear you thinking something else. I looked at the sunrise through the window my speed boat. The sun has just begin rising from far end of the ocean line. I answer, I can multi task. He grumbles, them multi task and tell me what you are going to do about it. I had so many things to worry about. For now I focus on him, because soon I will cross the city barrier and this call ends.

I answer, don't you think I know how it impacts us. He gets annoyed, then why did you do it. Your impulsive decision has cost of billions of dollar. I reply, 1.14 billon dollars. Not actually enough to make it a plural. He says, save your witty answers for others. I thought you would return the materials we got as a sort of trade for this, but no. You had the gall to take everything. I say, I need it for my other project. You know which one. I could hear him getting angrier now.

He spats, that was supposed to be done in slow perpetuity. Not in this bulk. You only met with the our guys and the local government officials. I am handling the real players. How do you think they will respond when I tell their investment is all gone in go. His anger is justified. But that doesn't mean I what I did was wrong. I had a major crashout when I heard about Ryes. If wasn't so tired and worn from the journey, I would have destroyed the whole apartment in anger, and not just the room I was in. That room is littered with broken pieces of the table and sofas. I had to pay the people I was staying with for the damages.

I answer, let me be clear. Its your job to handle the politics and money. Like you wanted. And I keep my end of the deal by keeping Echo, Home or Hive out from your operation. Now, could I have done things differently. Probably. But I couldn't wait for the other options. I had to settle this very quickly. I could hear him breathing hard. I continue, I also know it put a very big hole in our pockets. Its not lost on me that without them bank rolling us, we are in real trouble.

He barks, if you know all this. Then why haven't you traded from the materials. Lets sell it off and rake in the profits now. I answer, really now. When have you been so bothered by taking money and clear the debts so soon. He says, because this time I am trying to poach them into becoming our clients. Having them to invest in us will benefit us immensely. But we can't show our worth, if I can't show the fruits of their investment. Finally the truth comes out. I was waiting for the real reason. I knew it had to be something not related to money.

I laugh, I knew it. You greedy bastard. You used this opportunity to look for gullible wealthy people who are also unpredictable. You don't want to loose their interest in us. So thats why you are hurrying for this one. He stays quite a second, hold on. His voice lowering, you kept dodging my calls, just to make me reveal this. Didn't you. I smirk, I had enough time to prepare something for you. And I was going to tell you about it, but you were uncharacteristically too pushy about trading off something for the money. I wanted to know why.

He makes audible snarl and says, you freaker kid. You think you are so clever. I say, I am clever. Enough to know I anticipated this would happen, though I didn't knew you used money from prospects. I need to who these new groups are. He stayed silent, don't worry. I only care about their alliances. Since you approached them, they must be just dirty enough to met your requirement. I just want to check it for myself. If you don't want to tell me about them just yet, that's also fine. I am already busy right now. So I will check them out later. For now, at least tell me if how rich they are and what's their age.

He asks, their age. Does that matter. I say, of course it does. I want to show them something, something worth investing in us. But what if they are bunch of old people, almost ready to retire and just looking for fun. They might only find it amusing and not be serious about if. He asks, what exactly do you want to show them. I tell him about ART. Not too much, just the highlights. His voice finally becomes normal. He says, that project already progressed so ahead. I thought we wouldn't see it full potential for at least an year.

I answers, sometimes you get unexpected breakthroughs. Its still a prototype, but its functional and ready for a demonstration. I am not going to hand over anything, but these clients, if they are young, they would invest in it more seriously than old people looking who are in for just amusement. He finally gets what my intension is, they are mostly middle-age guys. And they have young families. And enormous connections rather than wealth. So yeah, they would have a more reasonable interest in us.

He then finally laughs, kid, you were just messing with me huh. I replied, I have a lot of things on my mind, I don't have to mess with you. Instead of going the longer approach of me going your back, as usual, I wanted to hear from you directly. He says, jeez. Just what made you mad so much. I sigh, it doesn't concern you. Someone has just openly threaten me and few others. Someone very dangerous. He says, you mean the guy you sent my men after. You didn't even tell the guys name, just a photo of him in a train. I have never seen you so nervous. I just found a while ago that you put a million dollar bounty on him.

I snarl, I would have preferred if you didn't know about it. Not so soon. He doesn't concern you. Just focus on getting us those clients of yours. My beef with that guy is just between the two of us. He finally backs down, all right. Messaged received. That guys has screwed the wrong person. And just because you have given such a nice gift, I will add another of my million on the bounty. I shout, don't but in. I just said stay out of it. He says, I am helping you out. More bounty hunters means you find this guy faster.

I say, he is not your typical person. He has alien technology you can't fathom. I put a observe request, its already difficult to do that. You putting more money would make people suspicious. He laughs, don't worry about that. You placed the bounty on the dark web. I got my own guys. And they are aware who he is, a Medrone. I really didn't want to involve him. But its true I need the help. Ryes may most definitely know who put him up to this.

M says, boss. We are going to be crossing the border in 2 minutes. I say to him, fine. If you trust those guys and they are aware of the danger, I will up the bounty to three mil. Add your two as well. He roars in laughter, so demanding. Just now you didn't want my help, but now you want to increase my share. Well, this is what I like about you. You know how to adapt to changing situations. I'll get it done. This guy has pissed you so much. We will find him, even if he is living inside a cave in the Himalayas.

I had to believe this much bounty haul will make people even more incentive to find him. I say, I am nearly here, so lets finish this up. I'll tell you later where and how the demonstration will happen. To keep them interested, I will share a video. Its your job to make them believe its not fake. I can't send ART in parts, it has to go all together. Also I can't do it very soon, maybe a time-frame of 2 weeks. He says, I can work my magic until then, keep them hooked for this long. But I need a location for this.

I think about it a little, somewhere in the ocean. He says, seriously. That’s it. I say, yeah. You said to keep him in anticipation. Isn't that good enough. He laughs, I guess so. You know, one of these days I am going to figure out where your island is. I smile, do you have a team of hackers trying to trace this phone. He chuckles not confirming this. I didn't want to give any hints, I am dropping the call. He says, such a poor sport. Fine, lets talk soon. The line disconnects as I get up from the seat.

I take the mini stair to the deck and feel the wind on my hairs. I speak loud into my watch, transmit transponders codes. After a while M says, codes accepted. I could see the tiny island coming into the far end of the view. The island is tiny, but the problems I am about to face is large. Now that I can focus on this, I needed to put my emotions aside. I was in complete disarray yesterday. I had hoped I would get rest in the flights. But the locals were not really happy when I plan to buy their properties. Not just that, I had to buy off local militias or government contractors for security.

And then yesterday was supposed a relaxing day. Get my body and mind recharged. But my capacious luck keeps butting in. Ryes had me going full on rampage in the room. Every lie coming out was a dagger thrusted deeper to my heart. I think at one point I was so mad, my eyes became wet with tear. My whole persona of a mysteries but dependable reputation has gone dog shit. The only solemn I have is that there was a deal with Heraknus. If that wasn’t already in place, this ploy to sabotage Citradel would be not truly efficient.

Citradel would fight much harder to get their resources back if Heraknus weren't moving. Most people had already given up and were going to follow Heraknus. But with Ryes ranting my entire past to people, there was a very good chance Charles would break the deal himself. He was already suspecting me earlier and had to send Melinda to confirm I wasn't cheating in the final. I don't know if it would be him or other pressuring him to break the deal. If that had happened, this whole tournament would have gone to waste. I couldn't let that happen. So instead of waiting or convincing Charles that these are lies, I went with the plan I never wanted to execute.

I never had such intension take away Citadel's resources. If it weren't for the circumstances, this plan would have forever remained in last resort section. I made this plan, if we had lost the tournament. That was before I saw decently strong people in Citradel. I could have imagined doing this in a future where we had truly lost. I had scraped that plan and decided to leave it up to fate later. And that ended with me in the finals. I never thought I would actually do this. Thank the heavens my contact told me about Ryes in time. I ask M, any news from our friend in Citradel.

M says, none boss. I suspect they have broken the interface too, since I am not getting a ping. That’s probably the right decision. Finding my source in Citradel is right now low on their list, but better to remain cautious since I have declared war on Citradel. I could see this go two ways, first one, they fight me. It would be long protracted political war demanding I give them their property back. The only viable threat they have is Heraknus. But I highly doubt they can stop Charles. If Citradel had that ability to that, they would have never acquiesced to Charles accepting the deal in the first place.

The other way, the difficult but also easy one, is for them to surrender. Our city is going to get a massive infrastructure boost. They would be stupid to overlook that. Their goal is also to make one big community we ever want a real stable society. I am very sure they are still trying to figure out which is best. The third way, which is highly unlikely, is they do nothing and wait for the dust to settle. They allow Heraknus to move here, but keep others in Citradel with their stagnated resources. I don't think it would happen, but its still a possibility I have to prepare.

I said earlier to others that I won't do more than this, that is still true. All these are eventualities that I am only being aware of. I'll follow Blakes lead. M says, boss connection to the network reestablished. Scanning through the news and message boards. It will take some time for M to analyze through it. So I manually scroll through the news orderly in the timeline. I began reading about the arrests of all the people. They didn’t mention Elina's name, but they said the victim has recovered completely.

Then I read all the people have been confirmed in their involvement and are going to wait for the tribal until Citradel arrives. Makes sense they postpone it since there is one confused and pissed off Citradel warrior in jail. So far no one has any proof of a third party involvement. Some people still believe it but there are no evidence. So those concerns are loosing its effect. People are more interested about punishing the guys, rather than knowing who did them in. Blake and Vanessa have done a good job keeping IDF and people focusing the criminals itself.

There were lot of theories floating around this. One article says they think Peter took advantage of the weakened warriors and finished them off with some of their own smuggled in weapons. Not a bad theory. Only people who didn't know Peter would think this. So far my plan had gone without a hitch. So much confusion has been caused, people don't believe one thing, they believe either nothing or everything. This is good, whoever is behind the scenes doesn't know I am onto them.

I would need to manipulate the situation even more now. People were confused about this situation. But now the confusion has shifted about my past. There is nothing worse for a Shadow to get his secrets revealed. Not just that, using them as weapons and against me. I still have no idea who the freak is it. I really wanted to suspect the small circle of people beside me. But this could be a double bluff strategy to keep me looking in wrong place. Its not impossible someone got to one us. Someone like Cassandra, who knew I lived in Greenville before. But its strange though, they could have just fabricated total lies. If the intention is to create doubt among the public mass, creating completely believable lies would still get the job done.

Instead they deliberately left out specifics. Just the events and added lies. That’s what made it even frustratingly mad. They had to know I killed Sophies dad, Rick. Saying that would make the lie even harder for me to refute, since that is actually true and theres a public record of this death. But they only talked about a cliché criminal beginning. The same about MARs subjects. They already know so much what happened in the Valley, they must know about Liz. So why not name her too, the people from Valley will know her. Adding such details would make it much harder to prove all this wrong.

Its possible they don't have complete information, and I was overthinking it. But I can't help the nagging feeling that someone is playing a game within a game. No doubt that denying any of this is infinitely harder now, since there are truth mixed in it. If it wasn't directed at me, I would be impressed. This is something I would have done too, but not at such a platform. To have phony but believable evidence, is something I don't prefer to do. Someone really clever is behind this.

I have been racking my brain all night on how to tackle this. People are going to go for my neck. Everyone loves to drag people down on from their high pedestal. Its a question of how to salvage my image. I thought about completely being neutral about it, like I was last time. But it won't fly with many people again. In a week, I am center of rumor twice. I could play it as coincidence and blame jealous people. Maybe even say a dirty tactic from Citradel to keep Heraknus.

But its not really enough to make them believe I am reliable. I had realized the way of this mess is to prove I am reliable, regardless of my actions, my decision or even personality. A person can be the worst kind, like Nathan, but still be called reliable. Its about general public perspective, not individual. I don't know when, but last night I recalled my time with Sophie. How she deals with things like this. Its funny, since she is not really the best person to learn this skill.

It was really interesting to think how she would approach this. She would say people are all selfish in the end. They don't care about the truth, just want excuse. She wasn't wrong about it. But she never really cared about others and what they thought. She could manipulate others into doing anything she wanted. I something wish I could do the cold logic like her. Like how I was really portrayed by Ryes. She doesn't have emotions like regret or fear, so doesn't feel pressured. I have crippled by both right now. I don't want to play on people's emotion.

I shook my head, frustrated at my naivete. I don't have much choice. I have to imagine she is here and embody her mindset. That’s the only I can get out this mess. I don't know what Blake has done to keep people the from panicking about me. I ask M, delay analyze on everything, just get me the partials on what happened yesterday. M says, scanning past 24 hours partials. A moment later she says, here are the results. I look at the news. Wow. I wasn't expecting this. Blake has gone nuclear. He is blaming the whole criminal operation on Citradel.

I didn't anticipate this move. This is bold, ridiculous and pure genius. After a half day of so called network shutdown for upgrade, the fist news flooding the network is about Blake officially accusing Citradel of the entire thing. Apparently Wyan has finally been cracked by IDF, he is saying he was hired by Ryes, got the tech from him and even had Quintin join him. This has to a big lie, no way Ryes is connected to the smugglers. Wait, the actual reports from IDF says he is suspecting its Ryes, but not sure if it is him. But a suspicion at a recently escaped person is believable. Wow, this a dangerous play from Blake. I see what he is trying to achieve here. They must have made a deal with Wyan, if he agree to point at Ryes, he gets a lighter sentence.

He is doing the same thing Ryes did, except to the people in the city. Throw a suspicious blame at Citradel, before everyone learns of Ryes interview. Its an risky plan, but its good. Ryes is on the run, either betraying Citradel or kidnapped, and Citradel can't refute this without Ryes. Blake is creating a smokescreen of the truth in all these lies. Now no one knows what to believe. If this narrative is done correctly, then it would look like Ryes tried to discredit me after he was about to be found it.

Ryes is being used as scapegoats from everyone. I am little worried about the people behind this and they plan to do with Ryes now. I am very mad at him, but its still possible he was blackmailed. That’s why I want him alive. But now, he will not be easy to find. Two communities gunning for him. If he was forced into this, I feel pity on him. However, this is good for me. I am a little more confident I can get out of this mess. I will still have a whole lot of scrutiny on my character, but if I play this correct, I can make everyone believe I am an asset to them.

I have to gain people's trust here. I recall Sophie saying once that she can imitate the emotion of the person in front of her and make them trust her just by her body language. I can't do that at her level. So I have to reveal a little bit truth here so that people will be satisfied. Its going to be a hard challenge. These are my one of the most gut retching experiences of my life. And I still have PTSD, I may be much better mentally, but anything could trigger me again. I have to be careful in what I say and how I say.

I ask M, is the analysis completed on the news. M says, 80 % completed boss. I see the island becoming larger, I have 40 minutes before I reach. This has to be enough to get understanding of the people opinions. I say, run the prediction algorithm on my choices based on the feeds and comments about Ryes slandering. M says, isolating the comments and running sentiment analysis. After about 10 minutes M says, I have the results boss. I ask, what is the successes probability if I deny everything about Ryes. M says, close to 38% satisfaction. I thought it would be worse, but clearly its not viable. I ask, what about staying quite.

M takes some more time this time for a prediction. Few minutes go by and she says, approximately 11 to 14 % satisfaction. Yeah, that makes sense. I can't have an indifferent opinion like how I was accused of cheating. Then I ask, how about me correcting those lies with the actual truth. I never want to do this because then it implicates others for those things. And that it will just create unnecessary distrust for the high ranking officers among the mass. M takes some time to crunch this new prediction. And then comes the response, around 46 to 53 %. Damn, this is brutal. I thought it would be a bit more higher. But just half the people will believe the actual truth. Even if this just a mathematical prediction, its still disheartening to see its so low, just one of two people.

Then I ask for the final prediction. This one takes the most time for M to process. I wait in anticipation as this is the only hope I have. M finally says after 5 minutes, its in the range of 80 to 95 %. Shit. I knew it this is only option that would work. And such a large gap, possibility because M has to take into account the various unknown variables. And M just proven in math what I believed true in psychology. After then I check with M with different prepared responses for the people. Some were good, others were still bad. Using her model prediction as a basis, I adjusted the details of the responses.

Just before I reach the island, I get a numerous texts and emails. M says, boss you are being flooded with huge number of messages. 22 % of them are spiteful and hate categories. I sigh at such a high number. I tell, hold all the these, don't delete them. There is a very low chance, but maybe the one behind everything has also messaged me. Analyze all suspicious messages and give me a report later. M says, running ancillary analysis. I say, also, tell me if any of the messages that mention anything about the real truth of the events. I would assume some people know they are lies and cross check any connection to the officers. If any names comes up, add it to the suspect list.

M says, objectives updated. Shall I recommend another task. Using the past days timeline and the spread of messages, I can formulate clusters of rumor origins in all the officers. This may reveal outliers that are potential suspects. I nod, yeah, do that too. M says, done. Also, you have many calls that I have blocked for you. I say, did anyone important call me. M shows me the list of people. I have many calls from the general public, so just swiped them away.

Then I notice Vanessa's name. I am a little vexed about her. We spoke 4 days ago and it ended badly. She did talk to me yesterday, but it was only because we were in a group. Knowing how stubborn she can be, she hasn't forgiven me. I say, call Vanessa. I don't know if the person on the other end is going to get angry for leaving her to deal with the mess with the smugglers or be the chief of IDF. After few tense rings, the line connects. Even though she picked up, she doesn't say anything. For a few seconds neither do I.

But this no time to be nervous. I ask, Vanessa. You there. She finally answers, I was just. Her tone wasn't angry, so may be its not that bad. She continues, no nothing. Before I get to the main stuff, I want to get somethings straight. I listen carefully, she says, I am not going to apologies for any of my behavior. I am sure you must have heard about it already. I was just carried away a bit. It won't happen again. What was she talking about. Is she still talking about how she responded when she caught me in a lie. Why is she feeling guilty about it. I was clearly in the wrong there.

I didn't have time to worry about her right now, so I say, I understand. You don't have to say anything more and I will not bring it up. We can still be professionals, despite our personal differences. I bluffed hoping that would ease her. She says, we can. Yes, that’s better. Besides, you have lot to worry about right now that broken trusts. She still jabs me with hurtful words. I muster myself and say, you got that right. You got Wyan to lie and put blame on Ryes.

She says, it was easier than I thought. Once we hacked the hard disk and got the first name, he was done. He no longer had any leverage. But then Blake got this crazy idea to use him. I don't like lying, but I subtly gave him hints about our situation and he caught on. To save his ass, he started making up stories about Ryes. He is nothing but an opportunistic snake. He was very convincing in coming up with a story that it neither lie nor far fetched. The result is a flurry of blame going on everywhere.

I say, I saw few of them on my way here. You guys might have just saved my ass. I wasn't very confident about getting out of this mess. Thanks. It was my sincere appreciation. She says, save it for later. You still have to deal with people demanding for answers. I asked all the officers to defer all the questions to you, so you better have a plan. I say, I do. She asks, and what is it. I say, before I explain that. Tell me I need to ask two things. First, are there reporters at the dock.

She says, unfortunately yes. We tried to hide your presence once you entered. But people found about it 5 minutes ago. They are all swarming in the pier, and we are trying to barricade them. I say, okay. Second thing, where is Cassandra. She pauses for a second, she is here too. I ask, anyway to get her out of here. She says with a exasperated tone, we tried. But she insists to be here. When she found about this, she went livid. She doesn't remember if she ever told anyone about where you used to live. Despite that, she thinks she somehow is the leak and is very guilty.

I can imagine her to be blaming herself. I hesitantly ask, is she the leak. Vanessa was somewhat reluctant to answer, no one is sure. Blake did ask not to pursue her. He himself is keeping an eye on her. I think he must have assigned a Shadow apprentice on her. I ask, I wanted to talk with her, but not under public view. She asks, what are you going do then. Are you going to deny it. I say, no. As infuriating it is for me, denying will not help. I will have to tell a version of the events which people will believe.

She says, you mean more lies. I can detect slight disapproving tone. I wasn't going to just take this from her, if these things were directed at you, how would you handle it? I ask her for her opinion. I was being defensive about my choice. She was the last person I should have to explain why lying is best for me right now. And yet I feel she is also the right person to explain my reasoning, would you tell the truth? You were there with me for better part of the years when I became active. Those vile things people are saying of me, do you think I can set it right and everything goes away.

She was quiet, the only sound was coming from my side of the water slashing beside the boat. After few seconds she says, I don't know what I would have done. I got an confused answer from her. I was wrong to put my frustration on her, but I needed to make her understand this. I say, I know its difficult. Imagine how I feel. You think its easy for me to lie to others. I was making it personal now. But I had to vent out a little bit of my anger on her.

She was somehow talking my ranting without rebutting. But I can't push it. She is still hurt by our last conversation. I back down and say, sorry. The stress of it is getting to me. I wasn't trying to put this on you. This whole situation is new territory for me. I rather fight the Charles than deal with this. I think that broke a little bit of tension there. She says, I don't like it, but I get it. Marina was defending you against some officers at dinner. But they were making it hard. I think I realize some situations cannot be handled the right way.

Is she saying its okay to lie then. A small hope builds up in me. But then she stomps it, don't think this changes anything between us. You can't manipulate me. I sigh, that wasn't my intension. I wish she stops thinking everything I do is lie. But I don't want to get into this with her, lets not waste more time. You must have called for something. What is it. She says in a grim voice, we want you to tell the people truth about you undermining Citradel. I ask confused, say what. You want me to publicly tell everyone that I sabotaged Citradel because Ryes came after me.

She says, Its non negotiable. You said yesterday you are okay to take the responsibility for you decision. You have made peace with whatever happens. So prove it. We want people to know it your personal decision, we weren't part of it. People haven't heard about your behind the scenes monopoly on the Citradel resources. We all discussed about it and decided its best for us if you tell it first. Before Citradel makes any move. I am not happy with this. I wanted to let Citradel come to the decision, on their own.

I ask, if I do this, won't it back fire. I haven't heard any major moves from Citradel. I know they have sent people and trying to stop from me acquiring their resources. But I have confidence that they won't get it. Even if they plan to steal it now, I have extracted 24 % of the deposits. By the time they actually decide to do anything about it, it will all over. Why should I poke them and influence their decision in any way. She says, its not about them. You keep thinking about Citradel, but you underestimate the panic in the city.

I ask, what do you mean. I have read the news, are you saying there is something else brewing amongst people. She says, there is no new issue going on. That’s not what I mean. Its the officers. They are giving off a vibe of confusion. Their subtle nervousness and silent judgement. Many officers are questioning Blake. Since none of us are explaining the Ryes lies, their faith is us has taken a hit. I know this is not your fault, and you might have saved us from a potential disaster by sabotaging Citradel. But while you saved our future, Its not enough to just assure people in the present.

I took few seconds to think about this. Maybe I was focusing a little much on the bigger picture and not enough to the officers. I assumed they would have same mentality as the general public. But it seems Ryes lies has done more damage than I previously anticipated. I ask, you think if I reveal that, the officers will get be reassured. She says, not exactly. Its not the ideal solution we are looking for. But if everyone hears you doing something so drastic, most people will question you, instead of us. Your past, your decision to fight back.

I answer, in short, you want to save your own ass while I take the heat. She didn't respond to my accusation. It must be it. I shake my head, is that why you offered to call me first. Kick me down when I am already at my low. She hastily replies, that’s not true. I didn't believe her. A part of her definitely wants me to be punished for lying to her. Breaking her trust. I girt my teeth in annoyance. I say, this is freaked up. Just because you guys can't handle the bad attention, you want me to take it. Just who came up with this idea.

There was a long pause. I sigh realizing, of course, it was you. Makes sense. I hurt you, now you want to take it on me. She rebukes, I told you its not like that. I just. She couldn't form the words. I ask, since you are asking me, even before I step on the island, you want me to tell people now. Isn't that right. Another long silence gave me an answer. I yell, freaking Ryes. I don't know if he is innocent or not. But the people using him as pawn are making it personal now. I know I have enemies, but what did I did to incur such animosity.

After a long moment of lingering tension in the wind she asks, what are you going to do then. I don't have time to think. The pier is beginning to appear now. With a heavy heart I say, fine. I did say I will take any repercussion from this. I can't go back on my word. She doesn't give her appreciation nor she consoles me. I don't think she wanted this, but she must be enjoying seeing me suffer. I can't do anything to fix our relationship right now. Then I had a thought and decided to add a condition. I add, tell Blake I will do it. I need a favor from you instead.

She asks confused, favor. What kind. Because if you want me to forgive you. You are crazy. I reply, I know that. That’s not what I mean. You have a compliant Wyan with you right now. Let me talk to him once, alone. No recording. I need to ask him something. She says, why. I answer, its about him accusing Elina and Ryan of stealing. She asks surprised, you think they did it. But didn't you tell Blake its not them. I say, I know they are most likely innocent. But I was there when Wyan was accusing them. I want to understand why he believed that when others weren't convinced.

She says, we have interrogated him days. He says it was just his intuition. Nothing else, no hard evidence. Why do you want to question him again. Do you not trust your friend, who has such unshakable faith in your fake self. I lean in forward, you talked to her about me. She says, I asked her about Mack. My arm slips from the railing of the boat. Freaking shit. I panicked hearing this from her. Why did she ask her about me, and as Mack. This sent me into a whole range of flurry of emotions. What did they both talk about.

Did Vanessa told Elina what I did and who I was. Shit. I underestimated how mad she is with me. I thought should would at least not involve me in any way with that. I had to calm down. I can still save it. I need to talk to Elina too and ask her not to tell anyone. But not right now. I say a little angry, well shit. I can't believe that after all I did to keep my involvement hidden, you go and tell the one person you shouldn't have. She immediately responds, what are you talking about. I didn't tell Elina about you.

I clench my jaw, of course you didn't. I am highly suspicious of her. I doubt Blake would have not done anything about it. Unless Vanessa spoke with Elina without him realizing. I say, forget it. Just tell me if you can allow for me to talk to Wyan. She thinks for a moment and tells, fine. But I need to be in room. Whatever you have to ask him, I need to know. Bloody girl is making me more harder to remain calm. I say, fine. Just you, no one else. She says, okay. Tell me when and I arrange for it. After a moment she asks, but why ask for permission. Why didn't you just do it without asking me.

I spat out, because I am trying hard to regain your trust. But you are making it even harder for me now. She pauses while talking in my sudden anger. I continue, whatever. I am reaching the pier. The next time you see me is in front of a camera, talking about the worst moments of my past, trying to get sympathy out of the lies. She didn't responds to me anymore. So I end the call and grab the railings in anger. This is so jarring. I kind of understand the position everyone is due to this. But now I have figure out a way to make it all about me, even the things I don't want to.

I slam the railings hard with my hands. It slightly hurt under the palm. I lead forward and stare at the ocean water zipping fast me. This is bad, I thought I had gotten my bearing back from yesterday, but clearly my emotions are not in control. I could literally have a nervous breakdown. I can't risk another on again in front of a camera.

Whoever is behind this. I am going to get you and I am going to freaking kill you.

Blake (Chapter 86)

Monday, January 26, 2026 23:31

A whole crowd of people were gathered around us. I think more than the last time when we were sending off Kafar and Charles. They were several reporters along the line talking about the current situation. I should have know it was fruitless to try and put a lid on this. Yesterday evening, we planned and accused Ryes backing the smugglers. I thought it would make things less crazy. But then Nathan told us about a new problem. The officers were not happy with us and some even were complaining to us whole day. I never thought it would become so bad.

Marina was this close to getting into a fight when an officer told she was probably faking being poisoned. I thought I had to worry about people, but now I had to worry about the moral among the officers too. Then we held a late night discussion, when resulted in a outrageous suggestion by Vanessa. She basically wants to focus everything on David, since he is already in a bad spotlight. Many were against it. But then Nathan smooth talked us into this. We have 3 new high ranking officers, I didn't want them to feel pressured since I already asked their help before.

And with great reluctance we decided to let David handle this. But when we asked who talk him into it, the last person in the city offered her assistance. I immediately told her not to, I offered to do it, even though I don't like it. But its better than using Vanessa into what, guilt trapping David into agreeing to it. She claims she only offered since she gave the idea. Since everyone just decided to leave it to her, I had to let it go. But then after the meeting, I spoke to her privately.

I ask, what is it you are trying to achieve here. She shrugs, nothing. I told you. I gave the idea, its only fair I tell him. I shake my head, no. You want to punish him. Don't you. You have been trying it for some time now. She makes a hard expression, that was a mistake. I am not trying to do get revenge on him. I say, it sounds like you are. Why not let me talk to him. She says, because I know if David talks to anyone, he will talk his way out. He will either say something to cover up or give a different solution. Only I will not back down from this.

I am surprised at the sheer distrust she has for him. How deep is her connection to freaking Wagner, that anyone who lies about him, she is so emotional that all reasons are thrown out the window. I say, if you know half the things about him, you wouldn't be like this. She snaps at me, there you go. He got you to trust him. Marina was always supporting him. But I thought you would see through it. I don't care what his reasons are, he keeps justifying his actions. I just can't take it.

I didn't want to make a scene with her again. I so wish I can tell her about Wagner. But the way she is behaving, that will only drive her further. I take a deep breath and say, fine. But don't antagonize him. The guy has already enough on his plate with the Ryes lies. She nods, I know. I am not heartless. I didn't say it to her, but I wasn't sure if it’s the right call. And now I am waiting for to finish her call with David. In the windy pier, a person comes beside me. Luther asks, there is too much wind in the air today. This is not the ideal location to allow David to talk to the reporters.

He was right, the wind had picked up more. There is no storm nearby, but there are some white clouds in the sky. I say, any suggestions. Behind her Tina says, well, we could take David to the officers building. Have him take the questions from his office. Would make it look more authoritative. Luther says, that is good idea. I rebuttal, no. All the officers are there, don't forget that. He would be surrounding by curious eyes. After what we discussed yesterday, I don't want anyone near him when he talks.

They both nod realizing my concern is valid. Luther says, that’s possible. We can't clear the entire building, not even the floor for him without making a scene. I thought a good place, his place. Isn't that better. Luther says, yeah. That is good. Familiar, more comfy and less space for people to hover on him. Tina says, and you get to talk to him also while on the way. Luther says, lets get a car for him. We will immediately get into one from the pier and take him to his place.

Tina asks, and what about the people here. I say, don't tell them anything for now. Pretty soon they are going to realize where we are taking him. Let them follow us behind. The more time we get with David, the better. They both get to work and talk to the officers about the change of plan. I stare at Vanessa's back and wait in anticipation. I can tell her aura is flickering quite fast. She may have a poker face, but inside she is feeling too many things. After the call ends, she comes to me with a confused look on her face.

Oh no. I felt a small despair. Did David decline for that unreasonable request. We really shouldn't have asked him to take the burden alone. She stops in front of me and says, he is in. I am shocked at the strange expression of hers. I asks, that's good. But why are so nervous. She hesitantly replies, he got angry. I ask, on whom. She says, I think at everyone. No, more towards me. This is a bad sign. I ask, but he agreed to do it. She nods, he also wants to talk to Wyan privately.

I am guessing he wants to know something about the stolen drugs. I ask, and did you. She says, I want to be there when he questions. I nod, a little relieved. We asking a lot of David. But she is still nervous about something. I ask, what is it. She says, I think this is getting to David more than I thought. I scratch my temple in reflex, how do you mean. She says, he didn't want to reveal about his plot to sabotage Citradel. I thought he would not like it, but agree to it. But he just snapped at me. I think the stress of his past being used against him is more than I thought.

I yell, shit. Did he actually say that. She says, I didn't expect him to be so down. I think I may have unintentionally provoked him by talking about Elina. I yell at her, Vanessa. What the hell are you trying to do. I keep asking you to lay off him, but you ignore it every time. She rebukes, but I didn't do anything. David just assumed things on his own. I grab my forehead, frustrated. Not on her, but myself. Why did I let to talk to David. I should have done it. This is bad, what if David has another PTSD trigger right in the middle of this.

Vanessa was even more nervous than me. We can't let this continue like this. I have tell Vanessa so she forgives David. Just as I made up my mind, Ruther comes running to us, David is here guys. I look turn my back and see the speed boat approaching. I can't tell David's expression from here. But it can't be good. In the strong windy air I shout, Tina. Get the car right now. I ran to the dock, with Vanessa behind me. David parks the boat and he steps on the wooden planks.

I could visibly see dark circles under his eyes. He has hair all messy and even few bandages under his arms. He carry's a rucksack bag on him. Ruther says, hey David. Let me get that for you. David tried to wave it off, but after Ruther not leaving his side, he relented and gave it. Thanks, he says. I walk to him, David. You look awful. David didn't have any humor left him in, that’s because I am. I had to endure so much crap, from Ryes, from Citradel, from the people bankrolling me. And now this. I wish you let me at least sleep for a while. I am so jet lagged I can sleep all day.

He was nervous. I could tell. He is rattled for some time now. It was unreasonable to assume he would be okay. He didn't even take a look at Vanessa and passed her by as he walks. I walk beside him, are you okay. I mean, for the reporters. I don't want add more pressure to you, but they are sure to ask you hard questions. He snaps, I freaking know. Ryes has royally screwed me. Ruther says, dude, we know. But you have a plan right. David seems too much in anger to response immediately.

And it doesn't help when a army of people watch from the sidelines. Some with curiosity, others questioning him. Luther brings in a car and says, get in. David asks, are we going somewhere. I answer while Ruther puts his bag in the backseat, this place is not good right now. So instead we are going to talk you home. You can clean up a little bit before talking to anyone. He says, good idea. I will feel more comfortable there. He gets in the passenger seat, while I go back with Vanessa.

But David calls out, not you Vanessa. Vanessa says, what. Why not. I have not been so anxious in a while about David getting pissed. David says, you used to not have a problem with how I normally do things. But since you don’t trust me anymore, I can't have you judging me as I lie. I need to have a clear head. I am too tired to argue and make any other excuse. Since you want honesty, this is me being that. David openly glares at her while Luther and Ruther look at me with tense expression.

Holy shit. She did it. I had warned her not to antagonize the guy, but she completely ignored me. I say, its fine Vanessa. You can help by having some officers around David's place so citizens don't bother us. Vanessa just stares at David, who already has his turned back on us and sitting in the car. I drag her out of her daze, did you hear me. Vanessa shuts the door saying in quite tone, fine. She wasn't really angry, she was just shocked at David being so straight with her.

I ask, Ruther, you get in instead. Ruther had no idea what drama was going on. He looks anxiously at Vanessa, who nods at him. With her approval, he gets in with me and Luther drives off. As we pass through the crowd, the people try hard to question David. The Kuret drones around the interviewers try to get glimpse of David through the window. Luther kept asking people to clear the way and they did after some officers helped. Soon we got of the shore and inside the city.

The four if us were in heavy anticipation in the car. I was focused on David, but not like them. I ask, seriously, are you fine. I was subtly questing his mental state. David says, obviously not. You saw me just now. You guys didn't make it easier by asking me to reveal about me sabotaging Citradel. Yesterday, I only wanted to tell you all this, not everyone. Luther says, I am very sorry David. I know this is bad. But we had no choice. No one is happy with this. David murmurs, I bet one person is.

Ruther asks, what was that. David says, I am saying I understand the problem you are facing. But this is exactly what the people behind Ryes wants. Cornering me for god knows what reason. I offer him some support, we don't know why. But you have a plan, yeah. David sighs, I do. But don't ask me about it. I am in terrible mood right now. He is really not talking this well. Even someone like him as a tolerance limit for this. Luther turns back to look at me with nervous eyes.

I couldn't reassure him of anything. Soon we reach his house. Somehow there were already few people gathered here. Ruther gets out of the car and asks them to clear. Once we park in the driveway front of his place, David says, give about 20 minutes. I'll get cleaned up. You can have all the reporters inside. And one you inside, no one else. I ask Luther, mind if I am the one inside with him. Luther was already ready to back off, its all you Blake. Try to calm him down.

I take his bag and we both rush inside his house. David says, M, did you prepare everything. M says, as per your request. He turns to me, take the reporters to the porch. There is enough space for six people. Do not allow anyone other than the reporters. I nod, I got this. He disappears into his room and shuts the door. Meanwhile I clear out the chair and tables on his porch and make space. With Luther coordinating outside, I ask Ruther to only let the reporters inside.

Soon people began to surround the house. Vaneesa and Tessa came in next, following a group of reporters in cars. Tessa rushes towards me, I have asked the reporters to wait for some time. I reply, let them setup in the porch. One by one each person comes in and setups their Kuretine instruments. Tessa ask, Ruther said something about David being weird. I am a little worried about him. I answer, I think we have may have underestimated his tolerance for bullshit.

She shakes her head, I have never seem him like this before. I don't know why, but I always thought him as a cool headed guy. Always in control of himself. She is beginning to see another side of him. Pretty soon everyone will. This is what they wanted, to cause mental agony on David. They probably knew they can't face him head on. That’s why they are sticking with such sneaky back stabbing. I say, you only knew him just recently. But some of us have seen him at his low. Honestly, for a while too I thought nothing would rattle him. But even he is not immune to conflicts.

She gives off a tense atmosphere while peaking at the side, towards Vanessa. She says, I might understand about David. What about her. She is also acting very strange, like she has a serious grudge against David. I can't explain the situation, its personal. Best for us to leave her alone. She says, I agree. The level of animosity she has towards David or anyone who sides with him so clear. Just what happened to her. I didn't have an words of assurance. We all resumed our jobs while David prepares himself. Some time later I later hear his room door opening.

David steps out with a fresh change of clothes and a cleaned face. He was hastily fixing his hair with a comb and walking towards me. He seemed to have relaxed, is everything ready. I reply, they are. He throws his comb over to the table and faces a mirror in the living room. He then catches the hoard of people surrounding his place. He grumbles, god damn. So many angry people. Just how much they distrust me. I say, forget about people's opinion. Don't let it bother you. He turns back to me, I know that. But its not easy. I have been gained this much attention before. At least not on my real self. And such a negative one. I can feel being a wanted human criminal is far easier to deal than this.

He closes his eyes and begins to take deep breaths. His face begins to calm down a little more. I whisper, you have to be honest here. Are you going to have a panic attack now. He opens his eyes in dreary heaviness, I want to she no. But I am not sure. PTSD is not something that goes away in a week. He seems to be more aware of himself now. He says, I just took a bunch of sedatives and pills. Right now I wasn't confident of handling this all on my own. I say, that's the right call. He looks around to the porch. He says, about my behavior, I don't want to make silly excuses. I was out of line. I have a million things going on in my brain.

I wave him, don't worry about it. I don't think anyone would be taking this better than you. I'll have already told to Luther and Ruther a while ago to cut you some slack. They also understand the burden we made you carry. His breathing becomes a little slow, good. Because I was unreasonably rude to Vanessa. She already hates me right now, I might have just made it worse. I say, I didn't want to butt in, but she is not thinking right when it comes to you. I bet she also knows this can't go on.

He asks, is it true she talked to Elina about me. I grit my teeth and gaze outside to Vanessa's back. She really wants to hurt David. I say, yeah. But she didn't reveal your identity. Elina never doubted you, saying that she believed you were lying to her. He asks with a narrow eyes, about what. I shrug, like your name and some other stuff. I shook his head in anger. He says, I shouldn't have involved Elina from the beginning. I should have just gone to anonymous trauma meeting like others. His guilt was now on his face.

I reply, don't doubt yourself. Not now. You did what you thought was right. Besides, think it this way. If you hadn't met her, we wouldn't have known about the smuggling operation and Elina may have died. You may think you involved her, but she involved you. For the first time his lips from a smile, that is different way to view this. I say, it is what it is. And if we hadn't found about them, we wouldn't have used them against Citradel. He chuckles now, seemingly back to his regular self, that was struck of genius and very ruthless.

I say, thanks. I wasn't about to let Citradel get away with this. They could have warned us what Ryes did. But instead they tried to hide it, while letting other communities judge our past. I am very certain Citradel would have played clueless if this had surfaced later. And by then even our people would begin to question us. He says, you mean me. Ryes motioned other names, but you don't have to treat this as everyone problem. Its a me problem now. I sigh, you are right. That the problem with rumors and fabricated accusations, you never know how they turn into.

He tells, I got the gist from Vanessa earlier. I don't like it. But I have no choice now. I did say I will accept any consequence for my actions. So I will try and shift the narrative. I ask, how exactly. You said you were going to lie. Isn't that dangerous. He replies, if not done correctly. But I am not going to just simply lie. I asked confused, then what is your plan. He says, I am going to use Ryes lies and make them the truth. As he walks away I remain momentarily frozen. Wait, what. What the hell does that mean.

But we didn't have time to talk. The reports sitting on the chairs in the porch begin preparing the Kuretine drones with camera. David waves to them, while the reporters start shouting questions at him. Besides the four usual people, Sasha, Vance, Giana and Terry, two more new reporters were here. I have not seem them before. Their name tags says, Barry and Lena. They must be new people. Each of them kept asking David as he takes his seat opposite to them.

Vance says, David, how much do know about Ryes and his accusations. Sasha says, do you plan to deny them today. Others were asking things like, how did Ryes learn about his past, is he involved in his disappearance. David had somehow brought out his serious face now. He wasn't putting on a performance like last time. I think he is about to get emotional this time. I step closer just enough to be away from the cameras and angle to his face. If it ever felt like he was about to crash out, I would shut this whole thing down.

At first David remains composed, letting all the reports finish the ranting. Vance says, David, aren't you going to say anything. He says, how can I do that when you all are not asking me questions. Instead you are demanding all at once. You will have to give me a chance to speak. I had a terrible time yesterday and have been flying across 4 continents. So you will have to forgive me if I am not as vibrant as usual. Gone was his cool and calm demeanor he has shown to the public. He was not going to take anyone shit anymore. I can't tell if this is intentional or not.

Barry says, apologies David. It wasn't our intent to cause you more trouble. Its just Chancellor Ryes has accused of many things. People want to know if they are true or not. Or if this is Citadel's last attempt to stop Heraknus from moving here. David says, and I am here to set the records straight. So I would advice a bit of your patience and more restraint. I will answer your every questions. Just go one by one. He was showing annoyance on him. Maybe deliberately.

Terry asks, are you involved in Chancellor Ryes disappearance after his interview. David says in a flat tone, I am not. I don't know where he is. But its not surprising he left. He left before Citradel could stop him. Vance asks, so you think Citradel is lying about that and is instead helping him. David says, I don't know anything about that. You will have to ask the Citradel council. I was halfway across the world when this happened, how would I be involved with him. Lena asks, you have human criminal friends. You could have abducted him.

At this David smiles, you think I had humans abduct Ryes, who has a decently powerful Kuret ability of controlling metals. And on top of that, have them break into and kidnap Ryes from a highly secure city. Do tell me, just who are these suicidal humans who would agree to it. Citradel has one of the toughest security on the planet, apart from ours. No Medrone can break in, let alone Humans with their rudimentary tech. Let me clear on this. I have am not in anyway involved in Ryes or his escape. Or why he would suddenly slander my past to everyone before leaving.

Vance asks, if you are not involved, why did Ryes tried to do this. David waves his hand, once someone catches him, he answer it himself. He made many ridiculous claims against me. I am here only to set the stories straight. Giana asks, so you are denying what he said about you. David becomes uncomfortable, like he doesn't want to be here. He then says, he found out things about my past but conveniently left out parts from it. And even twisting the things that happened to me.

Barry asks, sorry. Just to be clear, you are not denying them. You are saying they are the truth. David says, I am saying that Ryes told half truths. He made me turn into a villain by just revealing partial stuff about me. All the reporters were shocked to hear this. I saw their aura change in utter confusion. So did the people outside who where seeing the interview in their phones. My jaw hung loose at David's big fat lie. This is he what he meant, he isn't going to deny them. Instead he will stretch it out, like complete into more believe lies.

He is playing a very dangerous strategy. It will back fire at him very easily. Sasha says, I am sorry. Are you saying you poisoned Marina and cheated through the tournament. David says, no. That one is a blatant lie and completely outrageous. Don't you find it strange he gave proofs for other things, but he only accused me for this with no reason. That is completely false, just rambling of a misguided person. You think I can cheat so brazenly by poisoning Marina. Who apparently, won despite being poisoned and almost dying. You think she, who is a Shadow, would be so easy to catch off guard. I can't believe think people would think so little of me and my friend. She is a freaking overdrive user for bloody sake.

He takes a breath, if people still think I cheated, I ask them to meet all the strong people I fought. I doubt anyone would believe such crazy lie. You are only hurting them by believing Ryes lies that I could trick them. These people have fought Hive in real battle. You only tarnish their reputation by believing in Ryes empty words. Wow. He is going hard on the people. He is deftly defends himself and other warriors to his advantages. He is being visibly emotional about it as well. He says, so I ask people to consider this, just because I don't explain my abilities, doesn't make me a liar or a cheat. It makes me cautious and alive.

So far he hadn't lied about anything. I guess he wants to first make a passionate repones in the beginning. This even momentarily made the reports think for a second for their next question. Barry asks, so if this was a lie, are the rest the truth. David says, yes. The best way to make believe something, add the best lies to truth. Ask me about them and I will tell what really happened. Lena asks, then lets start it chronologically. Can you tell why you hid in Greenville for so long.

David doesn't respond immediately, instead he pulls out a small needle from his jacket pocket. My eyes squint when he stabs his palm with it and begins to bleed. What the hell is this about. Everyone here were stunned to see him self harm for suddenly. He winces in a little pain and then raises his arm to the cameras, what do you see. The reporters weren't sure so they remained quite. He continues and points to his bleeding palm, I can't heal. Even when I do this, he wraps his Kuret around his palm. But the blood still drips from his hands to his knees.

He continues, you all know I was one of subjects of MARs project. What it means is that my body can't assimilate Kuret. What it also means is that I don't have even a speck of Kuret immunity. After barely living on Medrine and I came to Earth. Suddenly being thrusted into a new environment, with pathogens, bacteria and virus crippled me to the hospital 90% of the time. My Earth guardians had to hide me while also help with my recovery. For years, I suffered through countless diseases. Typhoid, Malaria, Syphilis, TB and bunch of extinct diseases that haven't been on Earth for decades. Ryes conveniently skips out this part.

Holy mother. I didn't knew that. I knew he said he was sick a lot of time. But this the first time I am hearing the specifics about it. Vance asks, but he has photos of you living out in the open. David says, and I have other photos of me being in and out of hospitals. My guardians took photos to commensurate every time I get cured from a disease. With his uninjured hand, he pulls out a drive and tosses it to Vance. He caught it in surprise and holds it in front of everyone.

David says, I never talk about this part of my life because its frankly quite embarrassing. What kind of Medrone can be trusted when he has same weakness as Humans. Even something as simple as a common cold would be ridiculous. But since Ryes is calling me a coward, I rather be called weak and selfish. That drive contains a copy of all the photos of my hospital and medical data. I haven't seen the photos Ryes showed, he never shared it to anyone, but I am giving you the physical photos. Check their authenticity. See if they are fake. If someone people still believe it's a lie, I would ask them to meet Yana.

Terry asks, who? David says, she is the younger sister of the famous alpha Loid. Many people remember him. After arriving to earth she was supposed to be the next alpha, but couldn't become one because Earth has caused to have a vascular blood vessel disease. She needs constant blood transfusion. For many years, she to remain out of the fight, bide her time until she could find a way to mitigate her illness. Now she is an alpha who was in top 100. Her efforts are widely recognized and people praise her skills, despite her condition. I too had to struggle and just like her, I was only able to overcome my weakness only recently. There are so many stories like her. Ryes singled me out just because I made it to the top.

He already searched someone like him to relate. He is angry, but he is making it look like he is justified about it. The reporters were trained to remain impartial, but I see some speck of understanding in them. If David can bring them to their side, they would pull in other people too. Sasha, asks, so you needed time to adjust to Earth. David nods while pulling out a small cloth from his other jacket pocket and wraps his bleeding hand, lets move along, next question. Giana goes next, Ryes said you were responsible for the people who died five years ago in that horrific massacre. He has named several eye witnesses who saw you there. What happened there.

David suddenly turns somber, his eyes droopy, like they were in guilt. He says, what happened was I made a mistake. A terrible mistake of underestimating that Hive leader. I didn't get in time to the backup he had when he blew

up the building filled with people inside. He closes his eyes saying, those people wouldn't have died if I had figured out his plan sooner. I know you all have different account of that incident. I am not refuting anyone, because it was chaotic then. Ryes only told his side, I am telling my side.

Shit, he has taking it all on himself. I met David for the first time back then, but I know what really happened. He figured out the plan while me and Vanessa kept the Hive leader back. It wasn't his mistake, but ours. He triggered the bomb early noticing we were trying to stall him. David actually saved half the people. This is crazy, he is letting the lie continue for our sake. He says, with others kept him busy, I was supposed to disable the bombs. But I made a mistake. I didn't notice the trip circuit and 83 people died. I nearly died. If only I had more time, maybe I could have done things differently.

He opens his eyes and they become teary. His voice cracks a little with guilt now, that was one of the worst mistakes of my life. I should have been smarter. There was no one there that had any knowledge on how to diffuse the Hive tech. And I certainly didn't have the Kuret skills I have now back then. So it was a hasty decision that resulted in disaster. The guilt of that failure has haunted me very long. He shakes his head suddenly, but I learnt from it. I decided to never make the same mistake ever. I have to carry those people death all the time now.

Then suddenly he becomes angrier, Ryes has no right to criticize me or the people who were there. He wasn't in the war, he doesn't know what kind of split decisions a soldier, a warrior, has to make in the middle of a war. Where was Citradel in this, they could have sent reinforcement, maybe that would have changed the outcome. Instead they only arrive at the end, rescuing people with a small team. I am not going to let him slander me. I will instead take the blame from the families who lost then and the people who fought with us. But he has no right in judging me. And if anyone has anything to say to me, I ask them to consider what would they have done in a situation like this. If they say that they would have saved everyone, well, they are much better person than me.

What the freak. This is his plan. To go along with all the Ryes lies. I know we asked to take away the focus from us, but this is too much. But I can't stop him now. If I do, all this effort to will go in vain. David had moist eyes, I can't tell from anger or frustration of the lie. But he settle down a bit, any more questions. Barry asks, I am sorry to ask this David. If this was a honest mistake, why is Ryes claiming you responsible. David says, isn't it obvious. Discredit me. If I am defined by mistakes, then no amount of redemption that remove that stain. He wants Charles to know my past is loitered with bad decisions. If I may be responsible in that massacre, then everyone is. We were all fighting Hive, and we all lost. He just wants to exploit that loss and make it an example of our failures. But honestly, that’s bullshit. I would like to hear from him why he is making an enemy out of all of us.

His words are powerful. He most likely prepared them in advance. He is almost making be believe this to be true. He is strategically using us as shields and defends us at other times. This is a level of manipulation I have never seen from him before. Vance says, you are right about one things. One persons view is different than others. We need to definitely question Ryes motives here. Its working, a small hope blooms in this mess. Terry says, what about the accusation that you killed the MARs subject and then tried to stop it yourself.

David makes a show of taking a deep breath and calms down, what Ryes didn't tell was that those MARs subject, unlike me, had terminal ill. Many of them couldn't handle the Earth's atmosphere and had cancer. One of my friend, Liz, she had glioblastoma. Brain tumor. Which causes hallucinations and lapses in judgement. Near the end, she tried to do kill herself and everyone along with her. I stopped her, but then she persuaded me to help her die. I blink my eyes hard at this. Just what kind of story is he going to tell now.

Sasha asks, I am sorry. Did you say she wanted to die. He nods, yes. What they had was hardly called living. Ask the people who used to live in Valley. They will tell you that truth how those people were living. Separate from others, not even allowed to see because of their horrendous conditions. They were dying and offered their lives as a sacrifice if it helped Medrones to eliminate the weakness we have from Earth. No one from Valley talks about them, because people either didn't believe it to be true or refuse to be part of that sad story.

Mother of god. Its terrifying how he lied here. MAR's kids were experimented in secret, only scant few knew about them. He is using the Valley people's ignorance as a distraction of his lie. He says, when I saw how bad it had gotten, I relented and give them a painless death. The poison gas Ryes said I released, it was poison only to us. It reacted differently to them and they died without even feeling a thing. Barry says shocked, you admit you killed them. David leans back on his chair, I took their pain away. I told you, MAR's subject had negative reaction to Kuret. Everyone knows that. Nathan was even trying to help them, but there are sometimes no cure of things beyond your control.

I clench my teeth. Nathan didn't help them, he was only making it worse for them. Freak, I can see David bloody fist tightening up in anger as he had lie and cover for Nathan. Lena says, but they were important. Weren't they, don't you think it was wrong to give up. They could have helped so many others. David snarls, at what cost. They were in constant pain, they wanted to free from it. As a scientist, you may say it was a irrational move. But when you face a crying friend, begging to die and would do anything, take her own life, I like to see you choose what to do. I took most humane choice and helped them die peacefully. That is something not many get on Earth nowadays. I ask this to Ryes. What would he have done.

David is completely twisting the truth and looking for ways to get sympathies from people. And you know what, its very possible he may get it. Vance says, if that’s the case, why did you try to stop it. David says, Ryes showed you evidence me stopping the poison. What he didn't show you that there was a leak. The gas spread escaped through the vents. I wasn't going to let anyone else die, so I risked my own life to stop something I started. Everyone there would have seen me rushing to close the valve before it reached the Valley Kuretine groves. No one died during that incident. I wasn't going to make another mistake like before. This wasn't to impress others, this was about responsibility.

The way he speaks, his body posture, his timed voice trembles and his anger at untrue things. This all makes it incredibly true and easy to accept. I don’t know what's going through his mind, but making the lie even bigger is something only he can do. And people were eating it up. I can't tell how much, but the people outside were silently listening and have stopped being angry on him. David says, but Ryes is completely making be responsible for everything. He should not but in things he doesn't understand. No one from Citradel was there with us. So just listening to one sided story from disgruntled people is hardly the source of all truth. With careful weaving of the stories, David is making it look like he is the victim now.

Giana asks, such a terrible story. It seems Ryes didn't have the whole truth. David says, or he only told the parts that made me look bad. She nods. Barry asks, if you were against the experiments on MAR's subjects. Why did you tried to resist Nathan. I could see him clenching his fist even tighter. So much that more drops of blood was falling down on the floor. This was the time when he was out for revenge. David calmy answers, I told you, I had a friend Liz. She sacrificed her life. I wanted it to mean something. Using the research Nathan acquired I looked for Human subjects to test.

He then leans forward, to be very clear. I didn't harm any human, or any child. I only took their blood samples. I did not kidnap or kill any Humans in the name of experimentation as Ryes claims. He doesn't have any proof of this too. Just baseless accusation. But I have proof. I looked around children with the same diseases many of the Medrones have. I took tissue and other sample from kids who were cured from those terminal illness and tried to find a similar cure for Medrones.

Before anyone could ask for clarification, he asks, do any of you have kids. The reporter turn a little anxious being called out. Lena says, I have a daughter. David asks, how old is she. Lena says, she is 8. David says, that's great. She also had the check done like all the children come in. Would you mind telling us anything the doctors told you about her. Lena is confused. So were many wondering where is David going with this. Lean says, she is a healthy child. There is nothing wrong with her, if that’s what you are asking.

David nods, that’s good to hear. But there should be something else. Something specifically we tell to each parent when they step in the island. Something clicks in her mind, yeah. Now that I am reminded of it. I was told to give her a Kuretine drink for few days. It was something to boast her Kuret immunity, something called. David steps in, its called Repesomnal terial. I will spare you the jargon, basically it replenishes the missing Kuret in the children born in Earth now.

Huh, is that right. I did hear Nathan saying something about it a long time ago. I know we give supplements to children so they acclimatize to the sudden introduction to Kuret environment. But did Nathan did that. I realize what he plan to say for this specific issue. He says, this is the fruit of that labor. After years and months, we couldn’t find a cure for us, but at least we found a way to supplement what the kids born on Earth lack. This is same thing that Citradel does, we shared the formulae to them. So that every child will be not develop any earth born diseases like us.

Majority of the people didn't know the history behind this. People only care about saving their children, not learn history lesson on it developed. But it was Nathan who found this after his experiments on human children. He must have realized he can't actually dismiss every lies just by himself. He is stealing Nathan's discovery. Why is David doing it, wouldn't this enrage Nathan. Lena says, my word. I never realized that was the case. Barry says, but its been said that Nathan was the one who came up with this.

David nods, I helped him. Nathan was grateful enough to leave my name out of the public, because of what happened between us. Vance asks, what did happen between the two of you then. He says, as everyone knows. We kind of went through a tough time fighting each other. Ryes was right about us at each other throats. Nathan didn't want help from Humans. He didn't like Medrones being dependent on Humans. Anyone who knows Nathan would know that to be true. He refused to even let me work on my own, believing we Medrones should figure things out on our own.

What a wholesome lie. David continues, I don't completely disagree with that. But what Nathan failed to understand is that I wanted to use the knowledge of Humans for our benefit. A royal alpha like him didn't want to admit out weakness. And maybe I was being too hard on him. I really can't say which of us where right at that time. And so, with diverging ideology, we both fought. Anyone who was there would know that we both only wanted what was best of all Medrones. Once we settled our difference, we agreed to a compromise. Rather than using Humans as lab experiments, we stick to a slow but steady gene and Kuret research. Its not fast, but its better than us fighting over it.

I wouldn't have mind it if David had thrown more blame on Nathan. I suppose since he was basically stealing his achievement like this, he wanted give back some of his fake good reputation. Barry asks, so this how it happened. Did Ryes not know about this. David says, if he did and purposefully hid it to create another rift between me and Nathan, then he is worse than us. David supports Nathan and then uses him as a shield. I bet even Nathan wouldn't be minding such attention on him from now on.

Sasha asks, we will have talk to Nathan and ask if Ryes lied. David nods, you can't judge us when you don't know the whole story. Vance asks, he also mentioned about you killing a human to take over his criminal business. What do you have to say for that. David nostrils flare. Oh shit, that hit a sore spot on him. He says, I have nothing to add more. It just what he said, I killed someone and took over him. He was a bad guy who was doing inhuman stuff. And that’s all I am going to say about him.

Barry asks, you can't tell us why. David says, no. And it shouldn't matter. This is my business. That involve humans. As long as it doesn't effect Medrones, it doesn’t matter who I killed and why, does it. I doubt even Ryes knows about it, since he only say to turn me into a murderer. Well, here is a news flash. We all killers. Hive are also people, they have society and culture. And sure, they are a race of war mongrel hell bent on only on destruction and domination. But you wouldn't take a moment to hesitate and kill a defenseless Hive all alone. So I ask Ryes to cast aside his small things and leave that to the people like us. Our warriors, our officers.

Lena says, you might be right. Humans have hunted us, and they have killed some of us too. I doubt one less criminal human will make any difference. David really didn't want to talk about Sophie or her family. It makes sense, they are still alive, unlike Liz. Vance then says, please tell us about Oriana. We already have asked few people involved in the war last year and saw you taking to her.

My crossed arms fell down and I lean in closer. At the same time David looks at me with guilty eyes. Almost like he is apologizing in advance. The realization hits me after thinking over it a bit. He did the same thing earlier with Liz. I bit my lip in anger. This is not David's fault. I shouldn't be mad at him. I need to remain composed. This is about our future, not our past.

David has been dodging the blames by either accepting it or taking responsibility for it. He would also blame it on someone. He was going to put it all on Oriana, because dead people don't talk.

Vanessa (Chapter 87)

Tuesday, January 27, 2026 16:54

Peoples eyes never left the screen of their phones. Some of us were close enough to listen David from the front lawn, others were far and had to see the broadcast. But one thing was everyone, complete silence. David had everyone wrapped around his finger. The way he planned to get out of this was not to deny or tell the real truth. But make the lie into a reality. Freaking shit. No wonder he snapped at me earlier and didn't want me with him. I am sure my presence would cause him to flinch and second guess himself.

But what a lie. Every accusation Ryes threw at him, he took it head on. Not denying anything, but instead filling in the missing gaps. He even went as far so hype up Nathan. I never imagined he would go this far. Its vile to see how seamlessly he is able to wrap our perception of him. I know this was a desperate gamble, and I would never do it myself. But he wasn't wrong either. Many people behind me where not angry anymore. On the other hand, some felt sympathy for him.

I don't think he was even trying to hide his emotion. It was all over him. His anger, frustration and guilt. He was channeling it into his stories. This is by far the most complex, hardest, but the only way to reclaim his reputation. And after I while even I begin to believe those lies could easily be the truth. At least from others perspective. I could sense pain in his voice. He isn't acting that. Did I cause him that much pain. But he doesn't trust me. Why make me feel guilty about what he did.

I don't understand why he became so angry with me. I was so shocked earlier, that my own anger subsided. He didn’t even care if other officers heard him. I had to tell Ruther it was a misunderstanding between David and me for him to back off. I thought I would be making him only guilty, but his sudden anger at me makes me very suspicious about Elina. He clearly didn't want Elina to know about him. Just what kind of relationship these two have. But he wants to talk to Wyan. Did he not trust Elina, when she trusts him so much. I don't think Elina was complicit in anything.

I couldn't give it enough thought once David's interview started. And we are at a very sensitive topic about Oriana. Vance asks, David. Are you all right. I angle my self a little to see David's face. He turned away from Blake and says, yeah I heard. I was just wondering if any of you had to make a sacrifice. That question tripped the reporters. Davids voice angers, what am I saying. Of course you have. Everyone has done something to protect people they love. I am asking, if you know anyone who would die for you.

What is his angle now. David says, let me clear this up. Oriana was one of those people. I didn't manipulate Orina into doing anything. I only asked her to do the right thing. She betrayed is in our misguided war with Nathan. Did you know her parents were sick and needed help. Help that comes with a cost. That cost was us nearly dying. I won't tell how or why. I won't give this satisfaction to Ryes by mocking Oriana's death. What I will say is that I wanted her to repent her actions. I wanted her to believe that her actions were cruel, but not unforgivable.

His anger then turned to fury, was I wrong to ask of her. In retrospect, maybe. I didn't know she consumed with so much guilt she would completely forfeit her life for Blake. I am going to repeat myself, those who were not in the war have no right to judge me or Oriana. Especially not Ryes or Citradel. Who like always called in the cavalry too freaking late. Everyone deserves second chance, so did she. I am more mad at her than myself that she didn't get a chance to make things right with us.

What the freak. He is putting the blame on Blakes dead girlfriend. Just how far is he willing to go to save his lie. Lena asks, so you didn't ask her to die. David yells, freak no. I wanted her to live. To help us fight. Ryes believe I am so cold hearted and manipulative. Where is he now. He was only supposed to be only giving a debate, not go live and spew nonsense about people's death. He is the one who is using a people sacrifice to make everyone against me. He collected so much information on me, and yet he only tells one sided story. How is that any fair.

He is riling up the scene too much. I don't believe for a second this is a performance. He really is mad. He no longer cares about portraying a level headed guy. David says, Orina made a mistake, but I didn't held it against her so much that I would need to punish her. How could I when I myself am responsible for many deaths. That was the final straw for him. He stood up, I have read what people think about me. I am not angry at them, I just pity them because they believed Ryes so easily.

His body tenses and waves an index towards us, if anyone has any problem with me, say tell it to my face. Don’t be a coward like Ryes who tainted my past with half truths and just ran off. Lena says, but what about. David cuts her off, by now you must at least believe there is another side to anything Ryes has said. And I will be ready to explain it. But I want Ryes first. If he has so many things to say about me, why doesn’t come out and face me directly. It all started with a debate. So lets do that exactly. What's with his disappearing act without a trace, and how come no one from Citradel knows where he is. Not even his family.

Sasha says, you think Citradel is lying about him. David says, if they didn't know that Ryes might be involved with the smugglers, what else they might not know. I find it very suspicious they do all this just when they lost the tournament. It can't be just me who thinks the timing of this is just coincidence. Many of the Citradel warriors are joining us, full aware Citradel is not the right place for them anymore. Barry asks, but there is no proof of their involvement. He says, that means we just have to find it.

David is on a mission to bring down Citradel. Ah, I see. This is how plans to reveal what he did to them yesterday. Giana asks, they might not be related to any of this incident. David says, maybe not. But honestly, do you not find it even a bit suspicious. They tried to hide Ryes disappearance. Did you know that. They appointed his son, Winden, as the chief of staff. They didn't even wait a day to replace him. Sowing seeds of distrust on people. The same thing Ryes did to everyone. He continues, Blaming us for Marina's poisoning. Then almost a week ago it was rumors of cheating and now this. I don't trust Citradel anymore.

He continues, they used to be the safest place for Medrones on the planet. Maybe that’s still true. But is that the best place for your children. They might live in safety, but surrounded by people who only think about making enemy of me or our people. That’s no way to live. Our real enemy is the Hive. Something many have forgotten since they haven't attacked for long. He then takes a pause, and because I don't trust Citradel anymore, I don't believe they are going to honor the agreement between Charles and me. They are already doing whatever it takes to hurt me, hurt my friends. So in response, I have retaliated.

This is it. Sasha asks, what do you mean by that. He answers, I have bought all of the Citradels resources. Since they don't want to play fair, neither will I. I am going to ship all of their resources to our city. Citradel no longer has the resources to expand and let more people in. Meanwhile we have the space and the opportunity to make a far better city. This news causes a lost of murmurs and whispers behind us. He stuck to his promise and told everyone about it. Even giving a justifiable personal reason.

Giana asks, is that really true. You went behind Citadel's back. David says, I did. Yes. I don't believe for a second they thought about us. They didn't even tell me about it, I had to find it own my own. I have to face slander in front of the whole world. Drag me and my friends along our regretful past. While they says, oops, we totally forgot to tell you about it. He shakes his head, I want Ryes here. Unless he is brought and explain to me what made him go after me, I am not going to give back the resources.

This is incredible, he is making a show of using those resources as a bargaining chip to flush out Ryes. Damn you crazy genius, I have to give it to him. He knows how to play on the changing situation. Barry asks, what happens when Ryes is not caught. David scoffs, they you all a choice. He turns to the look straight at the camera, you decide if you want to go to Citradel, the safest place on Earth. Or to our city, the place where we fight back. At that last line he turns his back to the reports, that’s all for today. If you want to question me more, bring me Ryes first.

He passes Blake near the door, while the reporters try to follow him in. This was a chaos, David just left the scene so angry that it felt justified. Blake stops the people with his arm. He had a fowl expression on him, that’s enough people. You asked and he answered. I suggest you give him some time to rest. And if he agrees to it, you can all question him again later.

The reporters were clearly not satisfied. But its not they could force their way in, not when their prince is giving them a hard glare. They back off and apologies to him. Lena says, we didn't mean to upset him so much. His is all right. Blake says, don't worry about him. He had a rough week. This wasn't a lie. His word were lies, but not his intent. And I feel even more guilty now. I thought I wasn't fazed by my cold behavior. But clearly, it wasn't all of it. He was just better at hiding it.

One by one reporters leave David's house. People gathered here had mixed reactions. But if I had to say which was more, it was anger and confusion. Most of them wanted to believe David, others at least doubted his reckless decisions. But at least no was angry at him. I tell Ruther, lets get the people out of here. Ruther nods, all right people. The show is over. The officers follow his suit and make people leave the property. Soon Blake comes out of the door.

As soon as he left, the door shuts hard behind him. All the window turn to tint black. Blake looks at the house, I guess we won't seem him again today. I answer, did you know he was planning for this. Blake responds, no. He just gave me vague answer just before doing it. I honestly, can't believe David did that. I answer, he said he was going to lie, I just assumed it would be things about Ryes. To discredit him. I didn't expect this. Blake says, I am sure no one expected this.

He then hesitantly says, and yet I hate to say it. But he. I gave him a subtle nod, he was believable. So much so that I would have preferred some of those lies to be true. I was talking about our mistake which David took it upon himself. We didn't stop the Hive leader from blowing up the building. David saved us, not the other way around. Tessa comes beside me with a forlorn face, that was not how I expected this would go down. I am assuming by the look on your faces while David spoke, that it wasn't the truth.

Blake says, far from it. Tessa nods, I assumed so. I don't want to put pressure on you, but the reporters asking for you. Blake says, to confirm what David said. Tessa shrugs, and not just you. Most of the high ranking officers. I am in no mood to talk about any of this mess. Seems Blake was on the same page, tell them no. And especially Nathan. I need to talk to him immediately. He turns to me, pass on the message that no one is going to talk to reporters for anything related to David or Ryes. If they want to talk about Citradel or the smugglers though, that’s fine.

I agree with a nod. He then walks a bit away from us. Then his brings his Kuret to envelope himself and take off into the sky. At this time Nathan would must be at the officers building. Tessa and me coordinate the officers to handle the press. There were very persistent, but we had enough of a drama today. Luther comes to us, where did Blake go. Tessa says, to Nathan. Only he is the unpredictable guy who might screw up David's story. Luther scoffs, you know, I wasn't really confident about this. David was freaking out earlier. I wasn't sure he would be able to pull it off. But that was something else. He sold his story so good, I couldn't believe it. Even now I am terrified how angry he became.

Others notices it too. It was genuine reaction from David that really makes every people believe him. Tessa asks, so whats the plan now. David did what we asked of him. Probably even more so. Luther says, I know it feels sudden, but we have to focus on our work for our infrastructure expansion. Last night Tina led a team to get the materials from the ships they intercepted. They are talking a longer approach to avoid detection. But we will soon have all the construction materials to enrich Kuret. We had a unpredictable few days. Dealing with the smugglers and now this. But David's effort will all go to waste if we don't start making progress.

I ask, what if Citradel doesn't send those team. We don't have the skills or the tech to do enrich them with Kuret. Luther says, yeah, about that. Turns out they send them anyways yesterday night. I gasp, what. Why would Citradel do that. Luther says, I asked the same to Blake. He said something about Derek helping us without Kafar knowing. I realize what happened. Yesterday, when we were in our secret meeting. He told Derek subtly that he can help us. That’s why he warned him beforehand. Derek knew a shit storm is about to them, so he must have rushed for the teams departure.

Tessa asks, that’s incredible. So they are on they way. I ask, won't they turn back if Citradel calls them back. Luther says, they have a lot of tech and machines with them. Their route is planned and scheduled by the hour. Going back now with that much stuff is going to be very difficult. Still, its possible. So we already sent a team to them. I asked them to use force if they try to escape. But these people are architects, designers and scientists. They are care about their work, and not about politics. The people guarding them may pose a problem. But not much.

I understood his thinking. He says, best they can do is stall. We have very lucrative incentive for them to come work for us now. We are getting the raw materials instead of Citradel. They will soon realize its best to stick with the plan and come to us. That made sense. Blake and Derek planned this very well. Tessa says, what about Citradel then. They haven't contacted us, but soon they will. I say, let them. We have them by their balls. They screwed up with Ryes and made an enemy of us.

Luther corrects me, of David. I wasn't certain how serious David was until I saw the pics of 8 ships he sent last night. The guy actually made it happen. Tina says, based on the estimate of Titanium he sent, its already about 10% of the total deposit. Citradel has been slowly mining it, but he did 3 months of mining in 3 days without humans noticing it. Dude's got some seriously powerful friends. Did he really took over someone's criminal organization. He immediately backs down when I glare at him.

Tessa says, don't even joke about it right now. Luther panics saying, sorry. I get it, it’s a very sensitive topic among you guys. I won't press for any details. David lied big time to save our asses by taking too much of a blame. I turn to the closed house, unsure of what happened to David. Luther says, anyways. That’s the plan for now. We finally have some breathing space to begin working on our expansion plans. If Citradel contacts us, we will handle it then. Until then, lets just get back on track.

He was right to keep our focus on the goal. There are so many things to worry about, but its not the right time right now. The rest of the day we spent back in our offices. The officers attitude wasn't changed too much. It was highly unlikely that they would immediately back off. But I could definitely sense less wariness from them before by lunch. I was able to get some work done. The hot topic all morning was about David's interview. His passionate filled words resonated very strongly with people. Its too early to say what impact it would make. But suffice to say, it feels a slightly different scene from yesterday.

Even during our lunch, we had people asking us about David, and if he is doing okay. There was a growing concern about his current state. Most people have not seen this side of him, so its not surprising. I went to IDF after lunch. At the entrance I see June waiting to me. I ask, did you wait too long. She shakes her head, not much. I didn't want to be late on the first day. Blake has assigned her to me. I didn't object because she was definitely a great addition to our team.

As we both walk around the place to let her get a feel for the place. Surprisingly she didn't ask about David's interview. She instead talked about the different jobs and sections we have. After the tour was over I finally asked, why didn't you ask about David. She smiles, I figured it wasn't my business to ask. I saw his interview. And I don't know what is true and what isn't, but I know it was personal. I don't understand much of politics, but I know people don't want to talk about their personal business.
☐I chuckle, you will definitely fit in this pace. She says, lets hope so. Then I let her meet our fellow high ranking officers in IDF. Sommers says, welcome to IDF. What do you think. She says, different than Citradels place. Junes thinks for a second, I would say this is much better. We have bigger building, but its filled with humans. So we have to be very careful of that. Also, I saw you have prison cells in the next building. That is much better arrangement what we have.

I remember a little when I visited Citradel last time, it’s the same as the county jail with a secret inner basement section. She nods, yup. Its a pain every time we have to capture an escapee. Ruther says, you have escapees. She nods, of course. The cells we have are advance, but past that we don’t have any Medrones stationed. But don't worry, they would be caught immediately. We have humans not only for cover, we can use them to track their movement too.

So that’s the trade off they have. Seems difficult for us to comprehend how they would work so seamlessly, but that’s just because we haven't lived there long enough. Sommers tells, you don't want to worry about that anymore. Here you can use your Kuret freely. I remember you can fly right, our own chief does that very often. She smiles, it would be a little awkward for me. I don't like to stand out unnecessary. Besides, I can't really fly. Its just levitating against gravity. Not really convenient for travel.

Deni says, that still cool. Come on, let us show you your desk. June says, I already have one in the officers building. Sommers says, of course. We all have one there. But we have one here too when we are working here. June got excited to know about her second work place. I guess this is something Citradel can't do. While they help her sort out her new place and job. I get to work on mine. I had a bunch of tasks I hadn't looked at for last 4 days. Since the expansion plan didn't involved much security upgrades and IDF, my work was more business as usual.

I reviewed the plans again and reassigned the team we formed the day after the tournament. With so much disturbance for past few days, it was actually good to do resume our mundane activities. It was around 8 that I got a message from David. He wants to come in after dinner to IDF and talk to Wyan today. I thought he would take the day off. What is so urgent about this. Since I had no idea when he would arrive, I decided to stay for dinner inside IDF. I had some officer grab some dinner for me on his way back.

I waited in anticipation at my desk as I eat my food. What do I do when he arrives. He was in a fowl mood with me this morning. Would he still be angry. But why am I stressing about that. I should be the one who is mad at him. I haven't forgotten that he lied about Wagner. I can't let it go, no matter how much I want to. I was too lost in thought as I ate completely distracted from my surrounding. A voice comes, are you done with that. You don't have any food left in that box.

It was David. I jerk and push back my chair. He was standing in front of me and observing me stare at my empty food box. I dust of my hands and stood back up, when did you arrive. I think he slept off the whole day, because his eyes were much brighter than before. He also changed out of his clothes. He answers, I didn't want anyone to see me. I look behind him, even though we have skeleton crew at night. How did no one saw him. I got annoyed at him, did you just break into IDF without anyone noticing.

He didn't respond and instead says, lets not waste time. You promised to let me talk to Wyan. Or did you change your mind about it. I stare at his flat face. He was not going to make any small talk. Actually, I preferred it this way too. It would just turn into messy argument otherwise. I wave my hand, follow me. He tags behind me as we walk to prison cell we were holding Wyan in. David looks around the outside of the prison cell. It was just the two of right now. He asks, did you clear the crew.

I nod, I asked them to take a break. I planned to be her till around 11, so a bunch of locked up criminals are no threat when I am here. He says, good. Then lets get on with it. He raised his arm and speaks to his watch, M, loop the camera for next 15 minutes. And let me know if anyone approaches us. M says, done boss. I get annoyed, don't just hack our security. He scoffs, I didn't hack anything. I have the access codes that works when you haven't used yours.

He just nonchalantly tells me this now. He didn't even explain more and just goes towards the window of the Wyans prison cell. He was in his usual posture of sitting cross legged on the bed. He used to be so much reluctant to use it for sitting, saying it was dirty or beneath him. But we have cracked three names by now from his encrypted device, he has lost all sense of superiority. He knows he is screwed now. I thought David would enter now, but instead he stays still.

I ask, what. Don't tell me you don't want me to go in. Because that’s the only way I will allow you in. He turns to me with an annoyed look. Was he really being angry with me. Before I could ask to change his attitude towards me, he says, its not that. I am just preparing a little. I ask, for what. He turns to me, for this. I didn't see from this angle, but he was actually using his Kuret. More accurately, he was making his Kuret storm. I ask, what are you doing. I didn't say you can hurt him.

He snaps, stop judging me. Its fine if you don't trust me right now, but don't just assume stuff. I am not going to hurt him. I don't want him to know I was questioning him. So I am preparing a Kuret that will confuse him and also make him compliant. That’s what he meant earlier. He didn't have to be so rude to me, I set it aside for now. I take a step back when he pulled more Kuret around him. The last time I had seen him use it this close was during the tournament when me and Matt were helping him from being thrown away to the barrier.

Two minutes goes by and his wild Kuret stabilizes into a storm. Even after seeing it so close for the second time, I can't understand how he is is able to change Kuret. He walks to the door and pushes it open with his foot. He points his mini Kuret storm to the door and fires a Kuret. This was a yellow Kuret. I think I have seen it somewhere before. He said he wanted Wyan dulled, maybe he copied one of the tournament warrior Kuret. Wyan notices the Kuret and shrieks, what the hell. What is this. Help.

He tried to shout, but he reacted took late. The yellow Kuret blast had filled up the entire space inside. He got off the bed and tried to run, but he slumps back on the bed as fast he got up. David says, he is cooked. Lets go in now. I follow him instead. I prepared a little bit of my own Kuret around me to keep the yellow Kuret away. David says, no need for that. His black Kuret runs around the air wildly and cleans up the excess Kuret. This Kuret of his was far stronger than I have seen it before. I had almost forgotten that he fought Charles with this Kuret, he had to gain enough power to do that.

After few more seconds of Wyan breathing in that yellow Kuret, he becomes completely inebriated. He makes weird expression on his face. I ask, is he drunk. David says, close enough to that. He switches to a different Kuret next. This one expands from his Kuret storm and envelopes the whole room in a thin invisible barrier. I see small glints of Kuret at the edges. I ask, what is this. David says, a sound barrier. I can't have make a sudden loud noise. Damn. Just what kind of ability is this.

I doubt he would explain how he can do this. So I just let him do his work. Once the sound bubble is stable around us, he switches into another Kuret. This one was familiar, it was Rose's Kuret. But he didn't keep that for long. It was probably for just three seconds and he dispels his Kuret storm. I ask, why did you stop at just this much Kuret. I have seen Rose use it many times now. She uses more than this. He responds, a Medrone mind can only sustain so much of Kuret effects. I already have dulled his senses, if I use too much of Rose Kuret it might work against it and he would wake up. I have never tried this before, so don't know what kind of tolerance people have. But he doesn't have a strong Kuret, so this much should be enough.

That made sense. Its incredible to see him use his Kuret outside of the coliseum. I ask, is this how you fooled Cory and others too. Use different Kuret on them. He turns to me and doesn't answer. Instead tries to observe me, like he was trying to figure out something. I say, what. He says, lets just focus on the him. So that’s how we wants to be. Fine by me. David says, Wyan. Can you hear me. Wyan body was slumped with his back on the wall and his neck tilting down sideways. With his eyes closed and jaw loose, he looked exactly someone who is drunk off his ass.

Wyan grumbles a little but didn't respond. David leans and snaps his fingers around his ears, wake up Wyan. I need to talk to you. Wyan grumbles, shut up Sara. Go away. David leans back, who's she. Before I could answer, M says, its his girlfriend boss. Actually ex now. David smiles, well. I guess now I now how much Rose's Kuret worked on him. He already has M with him who has all the data on Wyan. He came prepared, that not surprising. He says, Wyan. Its Sara. I need you help me out with something.

I can't tell if he is serious about roleplaying like this. But Wyan grumbles, go away. I am busy with Irina right now. David says, two timing bastard. Well, its both of us. Sara and Irina. We have questions for you. Wyan chokes up a little, you two are together here. Lets forget about talking baby, come on. Lets use our mouths for something else. The hell he is, I was about to smack his face. But David grabs me my arm and signals me to back off. I shove him off and raise my hands. Fine, I'll let him handle this looser.

David says, that’s why we are here. But you know, we heard something awful. You are interested in another girl. Wyan cries, what. Who told you that. David says, Grover. He said he saw you with someone girl named Elina. Jeez,

its like seeing a more hyper focused Rose working. I should have used David instead of Rose. She'd danced around them far more than needed. Wyan says, he lies. That bitch is a two face liar. David faces turns grim. I was curious about this now. Wyan has always been adamant about this. But now maybe I will get to know more why he believed that.

David asks, why do think that. She seems so innocent. Didn't even knew her own brother was a smuggler. Wyan laughs, of course she didn't. She is dumb bitch. Lets forget about her though. Come on, ladies. He raises his arm, he is trying to grab them. David raises his arm like he was about to punch him, but then he puts his fist away. He says, not before you tell explain why you are so sure she is lying. Wyan snarls at us. David says, if you tell us, we both will do the thing you like.

Wyan perks up, even though his eyes are closed. He says excited, you mean that. David says, yeah. What is this type of interrogation going on. So different than Rose, yet so familiar. Wyan says, don't break your promise. Okay, you know I don't like girls who lie. We both patiently wait for him to spill more details. He says, that freaker Peter was using her sister good. She has a good body and nice tits, but is not so bright in here. He taps his head with his palm, I wasn't even buying one second of her weak little act. I know she stole the drugs.

David asks, I don't understand. She doesn't know about Peter's real job, why do you believe so much she stole it. Wyan says, she is opportunistic women. It takes one to see one. She must have figured out sometime ago and thought to sell of our stuff to get more money. Bitch thought we wouldn't notice. But I keep track of everything. David says, you have no proof of that, you only assumed that since others were clean. It could have been someone else who stole.

Wyan waves his index finger and signals no to us, task, you both are dumb too. I know it was her. I have kept tabs on her. The only thing besides her looks is her need for money. Peter was giving her enough dough to keep her ignorant, but she is just as greedy as me. Their youngest one, Rotan. She noticed same symptoms on him as hers and believes soon it will develop into the same problem as her. She wanted to save up enough money to get the Kuretines that can cure him early. So she will looking for anywhere to get money from. Even if that meant stealing from me. Dumb bitch thinks she can steal for me. I need to teach her a lesson.

I couldn't keep it together, call her a bitch one more time. I dare you. Wyan yells, who is there. David faces me and grabs me by the arm. I try to get off, but he was too frustrated at me and held his grip tight. He looks at Wyan and then at me. He then says, Wyan. You need to help us. Its Elina, she is here. Wyan barks, what. I should have recognized that voice. Give me my drugs bitch. Did he really confuse me with Elina. Because I have been talking to him so often, he must vaguely recall me. David let goes of my arm and motions me to be silent. He says, she isn't leaving. She says that you are liar.

Wyan snaps, you bitch. Let me get my hands on you. He waves his arms around the empty air. David says, she isn't budging Wyan. I think she wants to know why you keep suspecting her. She knows nothing. He says, trust me ladies, she is lying. I know it. This isn't going anywhere. He is really just assuming its her without any actual proof. I knew it, he was just throwing hot air. David says, you told us last time there was a way to prove it. Maybe you tell us now so that it make Elina run away.

What is he talking about. Wait, he was there. He might have heard something Wyan hasn't told us. Wyan says, huh? Oh that. Yeah. Nice one Sara. I knew you had a something better than that tiny ass. He makes slapping motion in the air. Just how much are we going to make him make a fool of himself. David says, please tell us. Wyan says, I was going to ask Peter to bring out our ledger. I got anxious, what do you mean by that. Wyan says, I won't let you go away again. He arms fails around the air again.

David didn't interrupt me this time. Probably thinking it was for the best for me question him now. I say, what do you mean by Peter has a ledger. He says he doesn't have anything. Wyan laughs, I am not talking about his ledger. I said I was going to ask him to get it. Your brother is coward, but he is still smarter than you. He said to keep a backup record of every order you make. Make it easier to track and tamper your records with just enough so you never find about it.

A backup records. That will exactly tell what were her actual shipments, and not the doctored one. Tessa had a tough time following this lead because it was difficult to figure out what was tampered. But if we have the original, it becomes simple. I ask, Peter didn't say anything about. Wyan laughs, because he never has seen it. Like hell I will let your brother get his grubby hands on it. He would change the records himself and no one know about it. I have sealed it an Kuretine lock and gave it to him.

David says, Sara here. Why would you keep the book with Peter. Wyan says, Sara babe, don't you know I am very cautious. I am never going to keep something such dangerous with me. Its better to keep it with her brother, he is basically a patsy. He can't open it, or lay his eyes on it. Its genius isn't it. David clicks his tongue, it is. You are so clever. I think he really is impressed with this trash. David says, where is this book now. Wyan mood turns sour, she stole it. Peter said it was stolen along with the drugs.

I push my lips in anger, you are kidding me. That was stolen too. Wyan barks, don't play the victim. I know you stole it. You live in the same place as Peter. That's why I am know you stole the drugs. Is that all he was basing it on. I say, you dumbass. If someone was good enough to steal drugs from you, they can easily break into her house and steal it. Wyan says, its you bitch. Don't lie. You stole the drugs. Give it back to me. You screwed up everything. Everything was fine until you came in.

David shook his head, that's all. Irina and I don't believe it. Even after the security you have in place, you think Elina can just steal it under your nose. Wyan says, that's why I kept asking her, who helped her. She must have hired someone to do her dirty job. David says, so now she is hiring people to steal from you. Wyan shrieks, yes. Exactly. Nothing else makes sense. They must have saved her in that hanger. David says, but I thought someone betrayed you. He wails, I am telling you bitch, everyone is in on it. Elina, Grover and even Peter. They are framing me.

David had enough of this. He walks away from him seemingly given up. Wyan says, don't go away Sara and Irina. I telling you. They all are just using me. Even that bitch Vanessa. She has got a even smaller brain than Elina. Making me use as a weapon against Citradel for such ridiculous things. I don't care about Citradel. I care about me. Oh no he didn't. David didn't even raise a finger to stop me. I punch him straight in his cheek. I think I broke his jaw as he winces his face in pain. His loud yell dies down immediately when he slumps down sideways to the bed.

It finally felt good to shut him up. David remains quite, seemed like he was enjoying it. I ask, will he remember any of this. David shrugs, don't know. Maybe he would assume this was a dream. Or a nightmare. He walks to him and grabs his arm and pulls on him. I ask, what are you doing. He says, can't leave him with a broken bones. It won't heal by tomorrow morning. I can't have him claim IDF brutality even if he deserves it. Its good he is here, because no way I was going to help this trash.

David prepares another Kuret storm. This one he prepares pretty quickly. He throws Johnathan's healing Kuret on Wyan's face. Soon his jaws sets back and he bruises go away. He then looks are the drops of blood trickling to his shirt. He says, I can't do anything about that. I say, leave it. Let him think he has a nosebleed or something like that. You already healed his face. He says, fair enough. I didn't realize but the sound barrier was gone. That was enough time.

I ask, so this all for nothing. David says, perhaps. But at least you know about the other records they keep. I say, what's the point. We have searched everyone's places. We didn't find anything like it. Whoever stole the drugs, also stole the book. He says thinking, it does look like that. But. He is lost in his thoughts. I ask, what. You believe Elina stole the drugs and the book. He says, I didn't say that. I am only confused why steal the book. What could be in it that is so important to risk breaking into their home.

He wouldn't be suspicious about it for no reason. I ask, you think that book contains some damaging info. Perhaps they didn't want us to know Elina's order and actual shipment discrepancy. He suddenly turns to me, what did say. I say, what. I am asking what kind of information would be there be just from bunch of shipment orders. It have been useful to us before we had cracked the hard disk, but now its not really important. He says, right. Not important to you guys. But maybe, its important for someone else. He was staring into the wall, deep in thoughts.

Did he figure out something. I ask, do you know something. He shakes his head, no. Nothing. I thought I made a connection, but it doesn't add up. I had a thought that maybe they stole other things too. That's probably the only thing that makes even sense to steal the book. I ask, stole something else. Like what. He says, don't know. I am just spit balling here. It could be just nothing and maybe a misdirection to throw us off. After yesterday, I am not dismissing any possibility.

He is weirdly making sense. There could be something else in the book that could give us some clue. David says, anyways. I'll leave that to you. I was only here to know why he kept terrorizing Elina. Turns out it was all a hunch and nothing else. He walks out though the door like nothing happened. I rush behind him, hey. Wait. That's it. You are done. You won't even see Elina. He stops in his track and turns to me, why. I answers, oh I don't know, Guilt? You have lied to her. And she still trusts you so much. She deserves to know the truth.

I guess he picked up my real intent as he walks up to me, what I tell her has nothing to do with you. You and I have our own issues. Don't involve her in it. He kept a straight face while he spoke. The nerve of him, I don't believe it. You won't even see her. He says, I already saw her. While you were staring at your food. I checked on both of them. If you are suggesting I come clean to her about me. Think again. Right now I am subject of everyone's scrutiny. And anyone beside me is a target. Ryes declared a war on me. So don't think I am being cold to her just because I am being a coward.

Something has changed. He never used to be so direct with me. But now, its like he has nothing holding him back. He continues, don't start talking about trust. Because I already know how you feel. All I am saying is leave Elina out of it. She is suffered enough. I came here just to know for sure about her involvement. Nothing more. I already took the blame for things I didn't do. It may be weird to say this, but its better when I am blamed for correct reasons. I know I am using Elina. But not in the way you think. I ask, what. How do you mean.

He clicks her mouth, forget it. I mean it. You are usually so rational about so many things, but when it comes to certain someone, you lose all reasoning. I got angry, what are you implying. He says, I am not saying anything. Just leave Elina alone. He turns his back to me, since this pretty much shows Elina is innocent. I hope you can clear her and let her go. I yell, I don't orders from you. He replies, it wasn't an order. It was a request. I just don't want to see her cry to sleep every night.

He knows about that too. I might have jumped the gun thinking he didn't care about her. He has been keeping an eye on her. I saw his back disappearing from the corner. I pull myself out of my thoughts and run after him. He can't leave from that side. The late night shift starts soon. They will see him. I turned around the corner to stop him, but I stop immediately. He was nowhere to be seen. How the hell did he do that. I didn't see any doors he walked through.

An officer comes and ask me, Vanessa. Are you looking for someone. I ask him, did you see any guy walking here. He looks around the place, a guy. No. I just came in. Didn't see anyone.

David (Chapter 88)

Wednesday, January 28, 2026 11:01

Things have been going normal for the past two days. After my epic emotional nervous breakdown in front of everyone, I stayed in my house the whole day. The exhaustion had hit me so much I didn't realize that I slept all the way till night. I wanted to stay hidden the house, away from people. I don't know if I can handle any more of their stares or gossiping behind my back. This sort of stuff never used to bother me. But Ryes had changed it. He exposed me in front of the whole world. This is the downside of have fame. I always knew there would be people not happy with me, but I thought it would happen later. I never imagined it to be so soon.

I had to shake off that duress, because I had an opportunity to talk to Wyan. Its still bothers me that he would make Elina suffer through much on just a hunch. After an awkward talk with Vanessa, I got the real reason he was so adamant about her involvement. Certainly, from his perspective Elina would be a prime suspect. If both the drugs and the book had been stolen, his behavior made sense. But all other things like Elina hiring someone to steal the drugs is just a wild conjecture. IDF has gone through everyone financials with fine comb tooth. Elina doesn't have any other thing to trade off in exchange of hiring people.

But something Vanessa said made me come up with a theory. A totally unfounded one that doesn't make sense. But then again, I couldn't really dismiss it too. I need to see the recording of their interrogation. Wyans and Grovers. And Elina's too. I don't want to come to any conclusion right now.

I was heavily jet lagged and once I had my dinner I slept again. The sedatives I took helped me have a peaceful sleep. I half imagined being haunted by the nightmares or hearing his voice again. But when I woke up, I was fine. No, I was feeling much better. I had a continues stress inducing days. Having to sleep and wake up normally felt like a bliss. I was lazy yesterday morning, reviewing the progress of the material shipments. I had to make some calls also to coordinate some hurdles in the village in Ewaka.

Citradel had sent few of their council members to negotiate their contracts. I had a good laugh when the local chief said they were exchanging other things like tech to purify their local river. Citradel were underestimating me. My small misdirection worked. I have been telling everyone that I was buying the land, like giving them cash. But that’s not completely true. These are rural towns. Sending them cash wouldn't help them if they don't know how to efficiently use them. So instead of sending hard cash, I sent money to a organization that helps in building better infrastructure.

I already negotiated a deal to build roads, better homes, electricity, fertilize their farm land, water purification plants and an aqueduct. I knew Citradel would think I made a mistake and waste valuable time sending their higher ups first. The chief said they couldn't offer anything else valuable to them and they left after failing to persuade them. They would have a better response if they weren't thinned out from so many things. Searching for Ryes, planning for Heraknus travel and dealing the pressure from Blakes blame on them. But still, I am very sure that Citradel have a backup plan to steal the money should this fail.

So stalling for time was important. M showed that the ores and mineral extraction had been only 25%. I need to be at least double of this much to make a significant blow to Citradel. I made calls all morning warning the security people and government about possible interventions. I was reassured by them that they are guarding the machines and mining people all the time. But its not enough. Based on the latest projections, its going to take another week or so.

I was dancing around with different strategies to stall for more time. Because I know that no matter what security these people have, if Citradel sends even one warriors, they stand zero chance. The security was a layer of protection from other humans interference. And that’s when I figured out a very risky plan. It would be attracting a lot of eyes, from everyone. But I can handle the other side of this, Citradel can't. I checked with him if had any news stations as our clients.

He gave a very long list. I smile at the sheer amount of information control this guy posses. But for now I need only few. I arranged for the news station heads to meet with the organization in charge of building the infrastructure of the town. I had them talk about a collaboration and making a documentary of the town. This gives a spotlight on the organization and the people in the city. It took whole day of me talking and making this collaboration as fast as possible. This couldn't happen in a day or two. They needed more time to finalize the scheduling, travel and other various things. I put pressure on the station head using our mutual friends name, he agreed to send out few crews to the city ahead to start filming the progress of the town immediately.

I told the lady that she wouldn't be able to get good footage and the viewership if she waits long. I promised her that the construction is going be fast paced and all over the town. She would get lot of viewers if the filming crew would record it from the start. And the charity organization would benefit from the exposure as well. Its a win a win if they agree to start the ground work immediately while they hash out all other corporate stuff. And they agreed. In the next 10 hours, a big crew with camera's and recording equipment's were on their to that small town in Africa. I told the village chief of this, he wasn't happy about it. But he understood that while the mine would dry up and I would leave, their town would continue to benefit from this.

After a grueling day of work, I ask M to end the hundredth call. I was exhausted by making other arrangements similar to this, under a different organization and buyer in other towns and city. Some were semi urban areas, so they already knew how to invest in the cash. I received a message that Citradel had sent people to Germany as well. They offered them double the money to buy the land back from me. But that’s not even legally possible. They seemed to even trying bribing them.

Unfortunately Citradel came up short on that front too. If bribing would have worked on the people governing there, I would have already done it. That’s why I went with the expensive route to just the mountain and its land for a private resort. I don't know what exactly to do with the land once the ores are extracted from the veins. I hope the client who paid for it would think of something. So far none of Citradel direct approach would work. What would have been a guarantee was Blake sending some of our people to protect the mining team. But that’s never going to happen.

I ask M, any suspicious activity from Citradel. M says, nothing out of the ordinary boss. I can't track their locations in any cameras or satellite surveillance. Well, they weren't going to be so easy to find. They are incredibly skilled in travelling without detection. I ask, and anything from our contact in Citradel. M says, still no response. Should we be worried. I reply, no. This is just a precaution. Otherwise we would have gotten an urgent extraction request. Lets wait a bit longer. I am only worried about any people Citradel sends to sabotage the mining crew or their equipment's.

They should have a very tough time making any noise with so many scrutiny on the towns I could get media attention from Humans. That should stall them, hopefully long enough that its extracted. The next move they could make is intercepting the mined materials while it is on the move. Hijacking it during road transportation is possible, but unlikely due to risk of involving police for the theft of such precious materials. Then the logical move is during the ship transport. The ocean is so large and not everything is tracked by satellite. They could steal it much more safety there.

In anticipation of this, I had asked the transport crews to split the ores into smaller containers and transport it via different routes. Now Citradel people won't be able to recover all it once. Its very possible they might intercept few of them, but not all. The materials transportation cost and time will increase due to this, but its far more reliable. I let M decide the best routes and different check points, like switching trucks, cargo, ships and crews to add layers of deception to Citradel.

When I finished my dinner, M gave a modified itinerary plan. After some minor modifications I sent to the team in charge of transport. I gave them an excuse that there was threat from some environmental extremist group and needed extra caution while transporting. They complied since they already suspected something was strange about the hastiness and amount of materials they had. I gave them extra bonuses to let their mind be at ease. Even if Citradel pirates them, they are not going to harm the Humans.

I was completely exhausted now. I lay on my bed. I wish I could sleep in my actual house. I don't feel enough secure right now. But I had to send ART away to our R & D team. Seems they had some breakthrough with interface and they might have a way to fix the defense mechanism system. That’s actually good timing. Because many people know about it now. And I can't have a dangerous weapon with me. They said it could take another 2 weeks to test out the new changes. I gave them a deadline since I also have to send ART for a demonstration to the new clients.

M says, boss. Would you like to read the news articles about you. I have complied them for you. I reply, no. I don't think I am ready to read them. I have been purposefully avoiding them since yesterday. I had a lot of trepidation about my public display of anger and self pity. I rather not know what people think. At least not tonight. I had already stretched my mental capacity to block Citradel from any encroachment.

Yesterday, Blake and Marina had messaged me that our training would begin from tomorrow. They needed some time to come with a plan. That actually made me happy knowing they were taking it seriously too. I took a quick shower and dozed off immediately to get all the rest I could for tomorrow. I thought I would have night terror or maybe just a nightmare. But nothing, I woke up fine. I did sweat a little hard last night, but that’s nothing compared to the time I was suffering in the first month.

They both could only spare an hour today morning. They need to head back after 8 AM. Since this is the first day, I know it would be mostly preparing. I'll take any help I get from them. I put a lightweight track pants and jacket and head out to the spot in Section 4 they asked me to meet. I took my normal car to the rocky shore GPS location he sent. When I step out of the car, I smelt the salt from the ocean waves hitting the sandy beach. This is actually a busy place later in the morning.

I thought we would be in a secluded place. But its possible they both wanted to be open, in public view. I don't want people to see me training my Kuret abilities. Not until the match with Charles is done. I hear a sound of wind in the sky. I lean away from the car hood and take a few steps as Blake lands on the sandy ground. Blake was dressed in causal clothes like me. He says, dude. What did you do. This is not boding already. He had sense of surprise in his voice.

I ask, what happened now. I gave a slight smile trying to think if I screwed up anything. He says, Citradel is furious with you man. Oh, that’s what he meant. I shrug, what's new. I bet they aren't happy with the both of us. He says, I can't deny that. But I got a call from Derek around 3 AM in the morning. He says you have screwed up their plans and Citradel are livid. I says, and by their plans, you mean? He says, they sent out two teams to the cities they get their materials from. One was a diplomatic team to try and negotiate a deal. And another team sabotage the mining equipment's, stop them from extracting the materials.

I answer, I already know about that. I spent the entire yesterday to undermine Citradel. I wasn't sure how effective it was, since I didn't see anything suspicious in the news. But from your reaction. He nods, Derek said the team almost destroyed the machines, but had to back away since there were filming the entire town. Tell me you didn't just use a filming crew to stop them. I chuckle, what Citradel values more than anything is their discretion. They might be able to destroy the machines, even under the filming crew's eyes. But that will involve the police then. The best they would achieve is stalling for time.

Blake then laughs mockingly, I can't believe this. Derek and I weren't sure until now if this was really you. Because it's a risky plan. There are so many eyes on those cities now. I say, true. But I rather see those materials be confiscated by the governments than Citradel getting it. They know that too. I am sure they will have take some time for their next move. Blake says, Derek was conflicted, he wanted to praise you and curse you at the same time. Just imagining that made me proud of my decisions.

I say, and what the technical team they sent. Pretty sure they were called back after yesterday. Blake says, just as we predicted. They are stuck with a hard choice. They had travelled two thirds of the distance before Citradel asked them to bunker down at a checkpoint. We have team there trying to negotiate. I sent both Luther and Tina, because it needed more personal touch. I nod, so for the time being they are at a statement. Blake says, it would have been better if they had reached us a little early. But, he shrugs, I guess this is not bad too.

It was best of the most chaotic situation. Blake asks, hold on. You didn't know about that Luther and Tina. I thought for sure you would already know about it. I wave my hand at him, past two days I have shut myself in the house. I didn't see anyone nor did I look up anything happening in the city. I was getting a much deserved rest. And like I said, I was completely focused on stopping Citradel yesterday. Blake shocked says, that long huh. Well, you did take an very difficult task.

Since he brought it up, I had to apologize to him. My voice becomes low, listen. About Oriana. I am sorry. I was pressed for time and I had no good option. Blake fortunately understood the plight I was stuck in, thanks man. I know you didn't want to do it. I could see you slightly trembling near the end. He did caught that moment I had slight tremors on my hands had to grab the seat to hide it. I sigh, I really didn't want to use Oriana like that. He nods, its not your fault. You did what I couldn't, and it was needed. It was Ryes who brought it up and lied. We asked to take the heat for us too. It would be unfair of me to be angry with you about it.

I was glad he wasn't mad about it. The small linger doubt vanished from me. He says, you do seem a little better since then. I crack my neck, the pressure had gotten to me. I have no excuse. He smiles, I would be more worried if you hadn't. You shouldn't have needed to do it if it weren't for someone who is betraying us. I ask, I couldn't do much investigation on that. Did you have any luck. He says, not much. But I do have something in motion, with some people. He explained about the Citradel warriors he included to spy on the officers.

I say, It's good idea. I think I saw June in IDF when I talked to Wyan, where did the twins go. Blake says, Frank went to Nathans team. I had to warn him about being very cautious about that. But he said it would be fine, so I assigned Nathan to the R & D department. I say, did Nathan agree to this. Because I basically stole his achievements. Blake says, I had a talk with him. He didn't mind since you put his name under a positive light. Most of the people in Valley would not be contradicting your stories, since they didn't know everything. But some do know the truth, Nathan said he would keep them quiet. No one wants to be involved in that mess anymore.

I says, that’s a surprise. I was sure to believe Nathan would resist or ask for something in response. Blake says, he knows asking more would just aggravate us. He should be happy with this much. I had no choice but to trust Nathan right now. He continues, Chealse went Tina's department with logistics. She thinks she can fit better with accounting work. I say, I don't know why, but I thought the twins would be in same department. Blake says, I know right. I was surprised too. Frank said it was just a gimmick in Citradel about having same interest. They wanted to explore different things here.

As long they are excited to belong here, it should be okay. Blake asks, I heard from Vanessa about your chat with Wyan. She thinks there must be something with the missing ledger. I needed to be careful in my words here. I don't want to make trouble for Elina, possibly. That’s just a wild guess. I might have mistakenly led her to read too much into this theory. Blake says, maybe. Because while she released Elina and Ryan, she has them in surveillance and scheduled check ins.

I say, she did huh. I hoped Vanessa would release them after the final missing piece. I ask, what do you plan to do with the two of them. He says, for now I asked Elina to remain insider her house all the time and not to talk to people. Especially about Peter or his smuggling operation. I ask, and her job. He scratches his chin, Vanessa asked about that too. Unfortunately, I can't let her open her bar. Even if she is innocent, I can't. Its a consensus among the officers that her bar has to be closed off for a little longer. Besides, people are suspecting her involvement. So I doubt that even if she reopen it, anyone will go to her. Elina wasn't happy about it too, but I think she was smart enough to know that lying low is better for her.

Considering the situation, that’s the best decision. Fortunately, she has enough money right now to sustain her self for weeks. But that’s only materialistic things. She has no moral support right now. Blake sees me a little disappointed, sorry dude. I know she is your friend. I couldn't veto others. I says, its not that. I was just wondering what it would take to let her get back on her feet. Blake says, honestly. Its difficult to say. Maybe just give her some time. People might start suspecting her less, and maybe get back the public trust.

I say, the IDF and officers need to also be able to trust her, right. He nods, the constant check-ins definitely makes Elina less trustworthy. I am not in a position to help her right now. Getting involved with her will make only make things more complicated. I say, thanks for the update. I just wanted to be aware of it. Not like I can do anything about it. He says, yeah. Its best if she first settles herself and Ryan before worrying about the future. As much as you and me want to help her out, we have other things to prioritize first. I guess I have to put the matter of Elina for another day.

He looks around the beach, Marina's late as usual. I shouldn't have asked her for late night reports on her blueprints. She stayed up late last night going over her designs for Heraknus community. I says, did Heraknus contact her. Even with the state Citradel is in right now. He smiles, you should have read the news. Well, I'll let her tell you about it. He seems to be excited about it, so it must be good news then. He then asks, since I have you here. I want to ask you something.

I say, sure. His pushes his mouth together and makes a confused face, I have been thinking about my Dad yesterday. You told there were some strange things in Shadow history. Like Dad choosing someone outside family. I cross my arms to his confusion, did you figure something out. He says, I am not sure. I wanted to ask you if know if have heard about Kinsley. I try to recall this name for a moment, no. I don't think I know anyone by that. He says, shucks, I thought maybe you would know if she was a Shadow before Wagner.

I say, before Wagner. What do you mean. I only saw Slater and Wagner in that summit. He says, but its possible that she was one too, but not present there. I says, you mean she died. He shakes his head, not died, but clinically brain dead. I had to take a step back, who is Kinsley. He clarifies, my older cousin. She is around 8 years older than me and would have been around the same age as Wagner. She was a talented girl in our house. Even when she couldn't receive the alpha powers, she displayed unique ability to imbued Kuret into things.

That’s impressive, Blake can also do it, but only using hid mothers bloodline ability. She could do it without it. I say, that takes some serious skill. He says, exactly. She couldn't maintain it for long, but it was a feat almost no one could do. I remember Dad saying she was very popular. I see what he is getting at, you think your Dad chose her before Wagner. He says, I have been trying to recall. Even talked to Nathan to confirm when she was injured. It was around the time Wagner would have joined the shadow.

I ask, hold on. What are you implying. He says, I don't know. But ever since you told the truth about Wagner, I have been thinking what lengths he to go. We already know is not beyond threaten children as a diversion. So maybe. I stop him, I am not the right person to ask this. Do I believe he would kill people for personal reasons, I wouldn't put past him. And if he did that, my fist tighten in sudden anger, he is even worse than I ever believed. He says, so there is a possibility.

I could tell he was too much conflicted by this. I don't have an answer that can reassure him. Honestly, if someone else asked me if Wagner killed a royal bloodline member for their spot in Shadows. I wouldn't hesitate for a second to its possibility. But this is Blake and his family we are talking about. While I was thinking what to say, I hear a whooshing sound in the air. I turn up and saw Marina approaching us from the sky. I turn to Blake, I don't have a definite answer for you Blake. The only thing I could suggest is to leave the past. I know its pretty ironic coming from a guy stuck with PTSD from past, but that’s why I implore you. Whatever happened, it doesn't change our present.

He says, I am trying to do that. Its just I have been wondering a lot about Dad's choices. I guess I was just thinking what I can do better. Is he having doubts about his shadow recruit. Its not something for me to intrude. Let him decide how to proceed. Marina lands on the beach with a bag on one shoulder. She was wearing jogging shorts and a top. She was hyper agitated, dammit. I am late aren't I. This is bad, people will thing I am tardy. I say, what people. Blake says, people already think that.

She makes a pouting expression to us. She then walks to me, before we start, I want to know if you are okay. Her concern was evident on the sudden change in demeanor, thanks Marina. I am better than yesterday. That much I can say for sure. She nods, thank the Kuret. You had me worried when you just stormed off in anger from the interview. I wanted to be there, but Blake here said too many people would only stress you out more. I smile, nah. Never. If you there, I would have been more relaxed. She gets excited, see. I told you. Blake answers, Don't twist my words. I was talking about you putting other officers in duress.

She clicks her tongue, tsk, whatever. I thought about checking up on you, but I figured you needed the rest. I say, appreciate that. I haven't had rest for a while. I needed to cool off. She says, but not your brain. She chuckles, I heard about Citradel pissed off at you. Blake says, who told you. She says, please. You think Derek is the only there. I got friends too. Blake says unsure, really. A friends you didn't recommend along with Derek. She says, I didn't want to involve in something risky. Isn't it better to have some allies there too. Blake says, that makes sense.

I had a thought. I ask her, how much do you trust this person. She asks, why. I explain, I have a friend in Citradel too. He pretty risked a lot to send the message about Ryes. Without him, we would have been pretty much screwed. And we haven't been in contact since last three days. Its obvious that he has gone silent to protect himself. But since I couldn’t do anything from here, I am a little concerned. Can you ask your friend to check on him, or at lease give any indication that he is trouble.

Marina says without hesitation, I can ask. He is eager to help us out in any way possible. I nod, my contact's name is Jack. He is the head of the communication department of Citradel. He had access to the secure lines of Citradel network setup, that's how he got me the info. Blake says, that’s a very sensitive department to have connection to. How did you pull him in to your side. I say, I didn't. I recruited him 3 years ago and asked him to spy for me in Citradel. Both gazes fell upon me surprised.

Marina says, freak. Now that’s some serious dedication from him. Blake says, he has been with them for years, without them realizing it. I say, he is from the same bloodline as the guy Nathan has than can camouflage into his surrounding. He wanted to join us during our campaign against Blake, saying he has beef with his relative. I don't know what it was, but he couldn't approach him while Nathan was with him. So instead I made him a deal, he if agreed to this, I would instead take his relative down along with Nathan. We only agreed it partially since I hadn't stopped Nathan. I told him zero contact for the first year. But due to my accident, that stretched out to two years. But he still remained in Citradel because I kept my word to him.

Marina says impressed, what a guy. For him, you disappeared during that time. Yet he still played his part. Blake says, we have to get him out of there. He saved all our asses. I say, that he did. I have a way to extract him in case things go wrong. I don't want to pull that trigger until I know if is in trouble. Marina puts the bad down and pulls out her phone from her jacker, I am on it. She begins typing her phone with the message. Blake asks, he was in high position in Citradel and still didn't know about Heraknus.

I shrugs, I know, right. I contacted him during the tournament and he tried his best. But its not easy with Humans everywhere. He couldn't freely move around without causing a lot of suspicion. Blake says, jeez. Kafar went great lengths to keep Heraknus hidden. Marina says, done. I'll let you know if he has any information. I say, thanks. Then I look at the bag, what's in that. She gets excited, don't tell me you forgot. He opens the bag and brings out a large old book.

When my eyes fell on it I immediately flash backed to the time I was with Istra. Her office table in Marina's house. Its the same. The brittle binding ends, the various Kuretine locks on it. A green Kuretine embedded at the edge of the book. Marina grabs the book with both hands says, I am not waiting any longer. You need to show me the way to open the restricted pages and where the hidden ones are. I ask, right now. I asked for your help. She slams the book with one palm, payment up front.

I chuckle and turn to Blake. He says, hey man, you have been stringing her long enough. I guess that’s true. Marina was super hyped about this. I couldn't just deny her child like enthusiasm. I say, I have been keeping you waiting for long, that’s true. She says, like ages. Come on. Chop, chop. She didn't want to miss the chance. I look around to a good spot and asked her to come to a large rock near the beach. All three us walk towards it and Marina lays the book on it.

I tell her, hear me out. I promised to assist you to unlock the pages. Unfortunately I don't remember all the pattern of the charm Istra used to open it. She shouts, what. You lied. You freaker. I raise my voice, hold on. I said I don't

remember everything. I took a broken tree stick and started to draw the partial pattern I do remember on the sand. After I was done, Marina was staring at it, is this right. I reply, this is about one third of the charm Istra used to open. I don't have total recall like you, be glad I was able to memorize even this much after all this time.

Marina was already lost in thought inspecting the charm I drew on the sand. She was murmuring things to herself. Blake asks her, can you figure out the rest with this. Marina then immediately jerks up, shit. I was looking in the wrong direction all this time. What is this. Its completely different than what Mom said it would be like. Are you sure this right. I say, I vaguely remember knowing more, but I am not sure of that. But his much, I point with the stick, is hundred percent correct.

My confidence gave her assurance, then I can work with this. It might take some time to figure out the right charm. She then points her index to me, you gotta help too. I say, how about I help in a different way. If you remove the complicated stuff of Kuret, its just a pattern prediction and recognition right. You can use the computing knowledge of a powerful AI. Marina says, of course. That’s right, using M would makes things go faster. I was relieved she took that suggestion. Because I didn't have time to do manual puzzle solving.

She gets excited, tell me about the hidden pages. I lean in forward to the touch the book. She jerks, don't touch it. Anyone other than me who touches it will instantly be zapped with a Kuret blast. But I ignored her and put my hands on the large page. I nonchalantly begin flipping that large heavy pages with my fingers. Marina bends her neck eyeing me and the book, what the hell. I laugh, don't worry. I have my Kuret resistance working for me. Istra was dumbstruck too when I accidently touched it. Maybe that’s why she found me interesting and showed me things.

Marina was still in shock, this is unbelievable. You know this book is our sacred treasure. Only our bloodline alpha's can open it. Blake says, you were carrying your sacred treasure in a satchel. Marina rebukes, it’s a very nice satchel. I think about this books history. This book has gone through much in centuries, so I doubt it would mind that. One I recalled the position of the page I stopped. This one, I point, I remember this page. I can't understand any of this language. But yeah, this part here. I point to the familiar written language I remembered, I am very certain its in here.

Marina shoves me aside, rude, and inspects the page. She chuckles, ha. Seriously. The irony. The is about charms that unlocking Kuret binding. I didn't find this content useful. Which section. I say, no idea. I think she was expecting me to hand over everything on a silver platter. She gives a annoyed look. I say, what do you want me to do about it. I don't even know how many sections there are. I just remember the page. She sighs, you did say you only know the page location. Fine, I guess this is still better than searching blindly. Where's the next.

She is borderline being impertinent with me. But I let it slide because she was so excited I found it funny. I flipped around the pages. Somethings strange. I flipped the pages again from the back. But I couldn't find the page. She asks, what's wrong. I ask, it may be a bad joke, but are there any pages missing. She elbows me in the guts, stop messing around. This pages look like they are normal, but they are insanely strong. Its easier to burn or destroy the book rather than ripping off pages.

I assumed so too. I flipped the pages faster, this is weird. I can't find that page. She got worried, seriously. You didn't forget about it. I scoff, please. If I wasn't so sure about it, I wouldn't have even mentioned about the other one. After a while Blake asks, I don't know if it makes sense, but our place had some sensitive Kuretine books that sometimes have pages that shuffles its position in the book. I was surprised, seriously. I have never heard about it. Marina immediately grabs the book and starts flipping the pages, holy shit. I never realized that. Yeah, your royal books were also old and used to have similar tricks like ours. She flips the pages around, but I couldn't see the page anywhere.

She kicks her legs on the ground, I thought maybe it would open up to me. Dammit. Her pride was hurt. I say, for now let me draw you the language script I know. Maybe that will help you find it. She nods, good idea. She pulls out her phone from her pocket opens a notepad. I draw the partial scripts I remember. Once done, she looks at it trying to figure out what it means. She says, something to do with Kuret purification. I ask, what the hell does that mean. She says, no idea. Never heard anything like this before.

She puts her phone back inside, anyways. It looks like I still have some work cut out for me. I ask hesitantly, so we good. She says, are we good seriously. You tricked me into using an Averna charm and all I get is hints. She was purposefully making me wait in anticipation. She suddenly chuckles, I was just messing with you. I let out a sigh. You never can tell her when her mood changes. Blake says, that’s great. Because we have wasted 10 minutes already. We should focus on you now David. I reply, yeah.

I say, my game plan is simple. Like I told earlier, I want to improve on two fronts. My new Kuret techniques and the Kuret sphere. They both get into this with excited expressions. I continue, before I show you what I can do, I need to explain what I my thought process was during my battle with Charles.

David (Chapter 89)

Wednesday, January 28, 2026 16:43

It took another 15 minutes to explain the tribulation I went through during the match. I had my Kuret around my hand and just waving around them as I told them. Blake says, so vibration? Really. I snuff out my Kuret and says, I mean from a science point of view, yeah. I saw thin amount of Kuret on Charles constantly moving around. Unlike other Medrones, he made his Kuret was so dense it became extension of his body. I imagined for a similar result. Admittedly it was a shot in the dark, but it worked. I have looked at the footage of my own battle, and unconsciously I did the same thing with my Kuret before I even realized.

Marina says, I remember. During the initial confrontation, you were evading Charles and your Kuret around you rotated on you. I say, that's right. It must have been instinct, like my brain registered Charles Kuret even before I realized it myself. Blake says, that's unbelievable. I have known people learning new stuff in the heat of the battle, but this is first for me where you figured out something so subtle from your opponent. Marina chuckles, your battle instincts is top notch. She makes a okay gesture to me praising my efforts.

I would have felt more pride in it but its not the same right now. I say, but I haven't been able to pull that final form again. The wild exploding Kuret is the best I can do right now. Blake says, so I assume its not about your recovery, right. I nod, I have checked my vitals this morning. I have a little bit of soreness in my lower back, but that shouldn't stop me. Marina snaps her fingers, you need to remember your rhythm. Its obvious, isn't it. This happens so many times. You were locked in during the battle where every second counted. You went beyond your limit and can't recall that same condition again.

I says, that's right. I believe the same. Its not mental, or physical. Its conditional. Blake says, what did you do back then. I say, I can't say for sure. Like Marina said, I was completely zoned in and flying of my instincts. He says, you basically got lucky. I had to agree to this, yeah. Marina says, beginners luck, as they say. Blake thinks for a second, okay. So our ultimate goal is to help you achieve that state. I ask, how do we do that. He says, first things first. I need to show you something. A demonstration of sorts.

He takes us to a nearby large rock and says, I have seen your battle too. And I have leaned a lot of things. I listen in close. He point his hand to the rock and throws his Kuret at it. The Kuret wasn't powerful, it just blew some dusts of it, this is what you could do normally. Your Kuret didn't have any weight or power. Then he pulls out a lot of Kuret around and expands it, like I do with my dome. The space around him is filled with Kuret and then he attacks again. This time it creates a large crack on the rock.

I say, and that's what my Kuret dome can do. He disperses the Kuret, correct. You have power, but it doesn't last long. And then you learned to do this. He walks to the rock and wraps his arm in Kuret, watch this. He punches the rock while wrapped in Kuret it cuts a piece of the edge. The broken debris falls on the sand creating a mini dust storm. He says, this is what you did with Charles. Now you need to learn this, he kept both his arms down and instead attacks the boulder just with his Kuret. The force of the impact was the same, but without physical action. Another piece of the rock chips off and falls to the ground.

I ask, you want me to do this, with just my Kuret. He nods, you have already done it before. You created a shield on you when Charles attacked, you even created a spikes on it when he kicked you. I recall I was able to do it against Polly too. I say, but that's just for a split moment. I can't control it beyond a second. He nods, that's what you have to learn first. You were running around with your Kuret controlling you, instead of you controlling it. I understand it was your first time using it. But it doesn't change the fact that you don't have control over your new Kuret. When you run, your legs are out of sync and uncoordinated.

He correctly observed the same thing I did. My Kuret assisted physical coordination is out of balance. He continues, there was a moment just before you got knocked out that looked like you let your Kuret control you like a puppet. That is the overly extreme and excessive control of your Kuret. You were incredibly lucky you didn't break your joint during that movement. That confirmed for me that even if you could use that Kuret form, I wouldn't want you to. Because you will be wasting your energy and stamina in superfluous movements.

I nod, that is absolutely right. A lot of the time I was letting my body get dragged by Kuret. He says, you drove a plane before learning a car. So that's why we have to first you need to learn to controls your Kuret without physical movement. I ask, but how does this help me. My fighting style is all about being having physical combat. He says, until now. There is a limit to it with just physical movements. There is two step to this. First was creating your stronger Kuret. And once you learn that. You get this. He asked us to gave some space and prepared another punch. This time he made a physical jab but the same Kuret power he showed earlier.

The result was not simple addition. The force was multiplied, his arm dug into the rock and giant web cracks grow from the impact point. Soon the entire rock crumbles. He takes a small breath, this is what you get when you have total control of you physical and Kuret strength. I realized his point, I think I get it. You switch between different type of attacks, a plain physical Kuret boasted attack, a pure Kuret attack and then a combination of both. He says, that's a good way to think about it. You learn these types individually first. Maybe you will learn it fast. But the real trick comes when you have to combine your skills.

I say, I has a similar type of idea during the match. Incorporate what I learnt into my existence techniques. He says, not bad. You had the right idea. But your execution order was not correct. It probably worked with Charles because, like Marina said, you were in a zone. But you can't rely on that. You need to consciously learn to do these things before. I say, man. If you were in your top form when you fought me, I would have a lot of trouble. He smiles, maybe. I shake my head, nah. I know. That's why I never fought you head on, never once tried to block a full punch from you.

He laughs, that was the right call, not going to hide that. You did the same with Charles, but you either got carried away or couldn't dodge some of his attacks. Normally, you only take a hit if you can prepare a counter for it. I add, or you attack with same force. He says, that's also a way. You did that by flying up in the air and using the momentum of the drop to even out Charles blow. Quite a reckless move though. I had to agree with him. That was a little terrifying. Marina asks, have you tried flying. It would be so awesome if you could do it.

He make nervous laugh, hell no. The most I can do is jump high and slowly decent. Like the entrance I made with Drew. You called it earlier, I wasn't thinking about the dangers and just winged it. Marina says, that was wild. You made a powerful blow on Charles, but don't think you can do it every time. I say, agreed. That's why I haven't tried it once. Even though I sometimes badly want to soar through the air. I don't know if you guys know, but I envy you, him and Vanessa to be able to fly.

Blake slaps me on the back, if things go well. Maybe you could do it too. Just imagining that gives me goosebumps. He then says, one more thing. While we train, we will use Charles fighting style so that you get used to him. That means every attack is physical but covered with strong Kuret. Marina says, that's a good idea. I say, maybe initially. But I rather not get used to his bulky body. Blake asks, wait what. What do you mean. I say, that was his normal Kuret. Now picture what it could be during overdrive.

They both think about it for a moment. Marina says, if its anything like ours, his transformation happen from inside the body. Right. Blake says, yeah. I imagine his body turns into a real Kuret body. I say, but you are imaging him to be bulkier. But what if he becomes slimmer, more leaner instead. Like a Chettah. Then would his entire style be flipped to speed type. If I only learn heavy punches and blocks, I will be freaked if I don't cover other possibilities. Blake says, I never imagined that. Marina says confused, he could have even more tails. Or no tails.

I say, that's also possible. You guys have variety of abilities in your arsenal to tackle anything thrown at you in real time. But my true strength comes before the fight begins. Blake says, yeah. I was trained for power. Marina says, I was training for versatility. I say, I was trained to see all possibilities. Never I imagined I would ever reach to a point where I need to learn different abilities. And I get your point Blake. I was jumping the gun by asking to learn the physically boasted attacked directly. I need to take a step back to that as well.

He says, its going to a lot of work. I have a basic outline to get you a feel for using your Kuret psychically. But your Kuret vibrating thing is not really something I can understand. He pulls his Kuret around his hands and forms a small ball, eventually everyone learns to use their Kuret without thinking so much. We don't have to really understand how it functions. I mean we can, but we do it subconsciously. Marina says, he is right. Its like breathing. You don't consciously put effort into breathing do you.

They made the observations I was painfully aware I lacked. But it is what it is. I have used my Kuret my own way. Marina says, doesn't matter though. Every person is different. We may say it nonchalantly because we have alpha level Kuret control. I know many struggle through it differently. You are basically an anomaly. She flashes her teeth, enjoying the fact saying I was very unique. Blake says, speaking of that. I think its time you explain how you can use different Kurets.

Marina grabs me by the shoulders excited, yes. I am dying to know that. Ever since you told me you copied me I have been racking my brain every night. I put my hands on her elbows, all right. Settle down. I laugh and she let goes of me. I say, you heard earlier how I am able to gather the ambient Kuret in the air. They both nod. Then I next explain about my prism light refracting analogy. Marina shrieks, seriously. That is not how Kuret works. I say, well, it works for me. I don't know how else to tell you.

Marina says, the pure Kuret have all the properties of every type of Kuret. But you can't split it. That's like saying you want to pull green from white. I say, I know. Its confusing. Let me show you what I do. I take few steps back and ask her, hurl a blast of pure Kuret towards me. She exclaims, huh. Ahm, okay. She pulls out her Kuret and I prepare mine. I figured since Blake is here, I should convert to his Kuret so that he can see it for himself. I raise my right arm and flow my Kuret in my palm.

Just like I have done numerous time, I wrap my palm in Kuret, shaping it in the form of Blakes bloodline sigil. They both look a little confused at this. I imagined anyone would be. Marina had a charm ready to fire a blast. I say, throw it. She extends her arms and it flies straight at me. I will the Kuret on my palm to get stronger and then as soon as the pure Kuret ball comes it contact, it splatters into different directions as small fireworks. Most of the Kuret scattered were pure, but there were sparks of blue mixed in.

They stare hard at my palm. Marina rushes over in an instant and takes my palm in both her hand like she was checking my nerves. She yells, what the freak was that. I tell, the secret of my technique. Blake follows her behind, you mean to tell me that was real. I make a face, seriously. Did you actually thought I cheated. Blake says, no. I mean, you can't tell me this is bonkers. What did you do. I say, I did nothing. Marina uses a charm on my hand, but it doesn't reveal anything.

She says, what kind of sorcery is this. Ironic, coming from a bloodline that are basically witches. I say, people keep asking me how I do it. The reason I keep saying is because I didn't others to know my weakness. The other reason is because this is completely accidental and I have no clue why it works. Marina let goes of my wrist, what the hell. I explain, last year, when we battled. You sent an attack at that Hive leader and he deflected it. Well, a part of it fell on me. I was kind of distracted by someone and I couldn't make a Kuret wall in time. It came out all web shaped. I saved myself from getting pummel by it. But at the edge of my hand were I had wrapped my Kuret, I saw sparks of different glimmers. Like colored glimmer.

She tries to recall that moment, I remember that. But I didn't sense different Kuret coming of from that. I say, there were many Medrones beside us. You probably missed it. Besides, it was for fraction of a second and just Infront of my eyes. That was the first clue I had something was strange. I didn't make much of it because, well, you know, I was going through therapy. Then tournament started and I was somewhat mentally ready. So I started to investigate from then. First it was very difficult to reproduce, because I didn't have a source of pure Kuret. And I started to buy Kuritines we use in our medical department.

Blake says, you mean the Kuritine crystals that used for backup in generating electricity. I say, that's the one. Once I found suitable source, I began testing. After few days I realized one common thing. The Kuret change happens only on contact. I turn to Marina, you can produce different Kuret in your overdrive by making charms. But they don't have to be physically on you. That's different for me. She says, so you need to be contact with the Kuret. But doesn't your Kuret breaks down Kuret bindings.

I says, that’s the subtle difference in what I showed just now and what I actually do. Once I was tested it repeatedly, I formed a hypothesis. Something in my unique biology allows the Kuret on my skin to cause minor fluctuations to pure Kuret. Call it science, call it chemistry. I have even used a microscope to understand this. The best I can say is that being a MAR's subject and my lineage has created a very unique DNA. Its like asking how Marina can sense Kuret. She can naturally just do it.

Marina says, what, like a physical ability. I say, could be. Blake says, what the hell dude. Just how did you get from there to now. I continue, I knew there was potential here. So I explored it. In between the matches I tried various things. But it wasn't working. But then I saw a match between Marina some guy, I don't remember him. Marina used a charm that resembled the Kuret web I had thrown last year. I tried to copy you. And it worked. I realized different pattern lead to different Kuret.

Marina breathes loudly, this is crazy. You used my charms as a reference. I say, I did. But I wasn't getting any real connection. The Kuret changes were happening not really uniformly, some mixed with multiple. Some weak. I didn't realize until later that I was missing one important detail. Blake says, you need to make the bloodline sigil. Marina says, the same way I do when I create my charms. I raise my hand and pour Kuret in it. I form sigil markers of different bloodlines.

I show them the changes I make to the design, making it exactly as theirs. I say, I don't really have a good grasp of Kuret convergence and its correlation to sigil markers. I never can see Kuret, so I don't have a complete idea. Marina says, that’s because you need to know a lot of Kuret mechanics to know that. Sigils of a bloodline isn't just random design. Think of them as DNA for Kuret building. All of us have sigils engraved inside our hearts. Its where our Kuret spreads from. Our bodies absorb Kuret and turn into out bloodline Kuret because of this divergence.

Blake says, that’s common knowledge. What isn't is how David is able to do it. I say, like I said. I can't understand working of others Kurets. I only have science and trial and error to understand. She sighs, many people have their own view of understand things. What one believes it to be true, doesn't make the other one wrong. Looks like it’s the same in your case. Your unique way of looking at things is what made this possible. I say, I guess so. Now you get how I was able to use different Kurets.

Blake says, not really. You couldn't focus it nor control it. I nod, that came after. While this was cool, it didn't have any way to use it in actual combat. That’s when I started to look for ways to gather pure Kuret with just my Kuret. I have told this earlier. My anti Kuret works like opposite sides of a magnet. That’s how I can throw Kuret and run along it being dragged towards the cluster of Kuret in the air. Using that same principle, I began experimenting trapping Kuret. It took a crazy amount of time and effort to finally find a viable solution.

Marina says, your Kuret sphere. Or Kuret storm. Whatever you call it. I say, its actually a sphere. I purposefully wrap it in a mini storm for stability and also physically hide what happens inside. Blake asks, so you learned how to trap Kuret in the air and condense it. I say, not immediately. First step was making my Kuret dense. And that I learnt from you. When you battled against Ned, I saw your technique of filling the air with Kuret. I copied it. Blake says, wow. So your Kuret dome was actually a by product of your actual goal.

I say, you can say that. When I fought Catherine, Jess and June, I used my Kuret sphere. It wasn't really stable, but I was able to catch them off guard with it. Marina eyes widen, that’s why you waited to be either hidden or not in view from anyone. I say, of course. I knew there were really tough people waiting in the finals. I wasn't going to reveal it then. But then Derek happened. He was far stronger than I imagined. I revealed the Kuret dome. And almost revealed the pure Kuret blast back then.

Blake says, that’s what caused those burn marks on him. Derek thought it was from the friction caused by his own Kuret. You were using it already back then. I nod, yeah. At that point in time, I was able to explode the trapped Kuret, like a bomb. Then the real game changer thing happened. I point to Marina, I don't want to make light of you almost dying, but your overdrive battle with Vanessa gave me a lot of clues. She points to herself, you couldn't leave my overdrive too.

I shrug, I saw you using different Kurets. The very thing I wanted to learn. Using your battle, I found out a way. In your overdrive, you gather Kuret and change it instantly around you. I couldn't understand it, let alone do that. But I studied the science behind it. You pass the ambient Kuret through the charms and then gather them. Changing the Kuret first. I figured if you do it this way, and then with an anti Kuret properties, I can do it in reverse. I first gather pure kuret and then change it. I already knew how to this before. And that’s how I was able to make the first of my Kuret spheres.

Marina looks genuinely shocked and impressed at me, so basically you used me as a muse. Blake says, by learning from both of us. I smile, more or less. And when you two fought, I studied more of your Kuret science, the way I can understand. Once I have Kuret condensed, I create a small instability. Very minor. Enough that a piece of the Kuret breaks from the center and then bounces around the sphere. With the sigil marker I form in my hand, that piece strikes my palm and slowly create sparks of the new Kuret nature. Those transformed Kuret then creates the other pieces into same nature. And with this chain reaction, a few seconds later I open a tiny gap though which the Kuret flows out and naturally gains the properties of the bloodline.

Blake says, that slight vibration we see just before you throw an attack, that’s what it really does. I say, I perfected the Kuret technique over time. Well, calling it perfect is a bit too much. More like functional. Marina puts her hand on her waist, mother of Kuret. I thought I our family were prodigies. No wonder mom took so much interest in you. I wouldn't be surprised if she was one of the people who voted for your selection. A chuckle slips past my mouth, maybe you are right. Anyways, I explained things by oversimplifying the inner mechanics. I turn to Marina, I can tell you more in depth later.

She says, I really need to know the details. She then turns to the book in her satchel, I guess I should also start looking into trying out things differently too. Blake says, for real. You understood that, because I didn't get everything. Marina says, don't let anyone hear you say that. Otherwise they will think royal education is not as good as Ozareks. Blake face turn a bit scornful. Marina laughs at him. I ask, so. I guess you understood the general idea. Is there a way you can help improve this technique.

Marina thinks about it for a long time. I thought best to give her some time, because I had another question for the time being to Blake. I ask him, I noticed it a while ago. There are many people gathering around us. I turn around the beach and people were gradually growing in numbers. A couple of officers for their routine water patrols. Few were heading out to the ocean to work on the security upgrades around the island. Some were fishermen.

I thought Blake picked this spot because we would be secluded and the only people who would come are regular people. This beach isn't so big that people can come to relax and play. But the majority of them are normal citizens. I saw a couple in their workout cloths, few teenagers and people in their work clothes. I thought they would be passing by. But they were hovering around us. I swear I could see glimmers of their phones pointed at us. Blake smirks at me, you really should see the news.

I sigh, what's the point. I basically admitted to mistakes and decisions that led to many people dying. I rather not be seen with you guys. They might think something is up. He says, something is up. I gave him a confused look. He says, you have turned into an overnight celebrity. I should have known I was getting bad press. But the way he has been talking, somethings strange. I look around the crowd looking at our direction. I couldn't see the glimmers from this far, but I saw majority being surprised and enjoyment. Huh, wait what. Blake says, there was a discussion yesterday about your actions. I don't know if you follow the Cranston show, but he goes around and puts spotlights on people.

I know that guy. I ask, he is the one Marina talked to few days back when she joined us. He replies, that’s right. He is quite an influencer in our city. A lot of people follow him. Turns out he was impressive by you and decided to do a video about you. He went to you, but I had stationed officers near your place to not disturb you. That didn't stop him. So instead he went talking to folks and began a agenda to create more positive awareness on you. My jaw hung loose, huh. Did you put him up to it.

He raised his hands, I didn't. I promise. That was all him. Your interview got to him. And as it turns out, to many. They just didn't went out of their way like Cranston did. In just one night, he got most viewership than he ever got. So he isn't just doing it completely for you. But he did champion you for thwarting Ryes slander. I didn't feel even a single bit happy hearing this, but I lied to everyone. People have wrong impression of me. He scoffs, Ryes lied first. And besides, your story makes you more relatable. They only seen you winning. But now they have seen you at your low. Its not a surprise when people see you struggle that they feel connected to you.

This is nuts. I wasn't expecting this. Did someone plan this. But what would be point in first smearing my reputation and then making me look good. After realizing that the people were here for me, I noticed something. I say, you planned this. You knew coming here would make noise. Didn't you. He didn't responds, just drops his shoulder with his hands in his pocket. This guy, he wanted me in public with them. Most likely to give team vibes and hints about them helping me train.

Marina steps forward, you spoiled the surprise Blake. I wanted to tell him that. He says, you snooze, you loose. She flares her nostril. She turns to me, so, you enjoying your fame. Honestly, I am more uncomfortable right now. It was one thing to take the blame, but now, to be appreciated for it. Feels the trade off is suspicious. She says, don't look so gloom. Think of it this way, you were never in the wrong. You did what you thought was right. And so you are getting the credits you are due.

I guess that made sense. But weirdly, I didn't feel good about this. I should be happy that people don't hate me. But it’s a strange feeling. I say, its going to take a minute to process this. But lets set that aside. Did you figure out something. She smiles, I did. At first glance it seems what you do is efficient, but its not really. I ask eagerly, how so ? She explains, first. You take a long time to prepare that technique. While the trade off balance it out, its not practical. She is right about that. The first time I used in the field against Cory and others made that even more aware.

She says, since we can't really change the process. We can cut short the time be using a different configuration. She draws a circle with her hand, you use sphere, but that’s not really the best. A circle or elliptical is far better. I am confused, but how do I gather Kuret without trapping it. She says, I got an idea when you spoke of magnets. In that final Kuret form of yours. The Kuret was circulating on you and very dense. I think we can use that when you gather Kuret also. Instead of you trapping the ambient Kuret, you suck them into the space inside the circle.

That sparked so many confusing thoughts in my mind. But I asked the important one, is this something to do with Kuert physics. She says, give that man a prize. Yeah. Its no wonder you didn't think of that before. You need to see and feel it for yourself. My mind in thousand directions on this new avenue. She isn't wrong, I have treating Kuret like a scientific energy. But certain laws apply different to it. She continues, you gather Kuret like you are gathering balls in the air in your hands, on by one. But a much faster way is to like suck all the balls in one go.

If I can do that, then I can speed up the time it takes to prepare. But then I had a thought, hold on. I get that I overlooked many things. But even if I could do this, the Kuret I gather isn't stable. It will be highly volatile, since its no longer covered completely in all directions with my Kuret. Or do you have a way to stabilize that. She says, if you were like me, then you had a shot to do that. But that’s not possible. So I propose something else. She raises her arm and pulls out her Kuret over her arm.

She was purposefully making her charm mimic my Kuret form. She then says, you are right about it being unstable. You might have just one or two seconds before the pure Kuret breaks down and dissipates. But before it happens. She creates the sigil of royal bloodline on her hand. The pure Kuret she has slightly changes into Blakes and vanishes. She sighs, I can't do this without my overdrive. But you get the idea. I got excited at this demonstration, because I got what she meant, you want me to make a smaller Kuret ball and use that immediately.

She nods, exactly. There is no guarantee you will get enough time in a battle field to prepare it. Instead of trying to fire 8 or 9 Kuret blasts. Just do single Kuret nature change attack. Gather it again for the next. Blake asks, I may

be wrong, but won't it effect the output. The attacks David threw on Charles were on alpha or omega level. She nods, nice catch. That will happen. I don't have a solution for that. He turns to me, there is a trade off. Your attacks will be faster, but they won't be as strong.

I think I get the whole picture now. I say, its like a quick and dirty Kuret attack. She smooches one eye with her cheeks, something like that. But I was okay with this, its actually better. If you seen my match with Charles, you would know that I was wasting a lot of the Kuret. I had the option to do that because I had a bigger reserve of pure Kuret. But not all Kuret need to be powerful. She says, I also believe variety is better here. Besides, this was just me giving an idea. Give me some more time. I can some up with something more proper. I will check with type of Kuret configuration works the best for you. Who knows, if we do this right, you might be able to even control the output of your attacks.

Blake whistles, seriously. That will be sick. I was now smiling ear to ear. I don't have any idea if I could manage it in 3 weeks. But with Marina here, I have a chance. I say, thanks a lot Marina. I am glad you are here. She smiles, anytime. Then she turns a little hesitant. I ask, what. She says, nothing. Just. She turns to Blake, if he help this become stronger, his stocks will go even higher. We might be unleashing a monster, even bigger than Charles. She knows I am here right.

Blake giggles, you should have thought before you accepted the payment. She snickers peeking at the bag beside her legs. She says, true. Do you not have a problem. Blake turns to me with a sly smile, I will be lying if I am not slightly envious. But hey, I am here to pick on his brain too. You already said his thinking is very different. I am sure that will benefit me also in someway too. I think those two are here for themselves just as much for me. I was more than happy to reciprocate that help. I say, I will do what I can. But don't expect too much, even after getting my memories, Kuret science is a difficult for me to comprehend.

They both get a good laugh from it. They support was honestly more reassuring that I ever thought. Marina looks around, by the way. Seems a lot of people have gathered around. Seems kind of waste. Don't you think. I looked at my wrist watch, you have only 10 minutes left. Don't think we can do any actual training today. Not that I planned for any from the beginning. Marina smiles, why not give people something to see. She starts to give poses to the people, arching her waist and raising her elbows to her hairs.

I burst out laughing, what are you doing. Is that a swimsuit model pose. She gives another pose, hey, I need to get some attention too. And not just for my fighting skills. Its not fair you are hogging everything. I am giving you a lot of my precious time. Be glad. She has just committed to this bit on a whim. I turn to Blake who was stifling a laugh. He sees me and says, I am not joining that. That’s all her. I reply, not what I was thinking. Marina is giving more poses now. Does she really have no embarrassment while she goes on her knees and gives a more erotic pose.

I need to stop her. I don't know about Blake, but I am getting embarrassed from people watching me just gawking at her. Before I could approach her, Blake says, Marina. I got a better idea. Oh, no. Not him too. Marina stands up excited, what. He points to the a group of large rocks, you are just hogging the attention, like him. We are here to train him. So lets just show the people what they came here for. I can't believe he was suggesting this to her. Marina got excited, I love it. Oh yeah. I shake my thoughts and decided to play along, why not. If I am going to be under people's scrutiny, I might as put on a show. Marina fists my shoulder, that’s the spirit.

Its been a very time since I wanted to do something that didn't have any hidden agenda. Just something fun. Blake says, we each will pick similar sized rocks and throw an attack once all together. Whoever pulverizes the rock wins. Marina says, and the loser buys our lunch for the week. I yell, wait a minute, I will definite loose. This isn't fair. Blake shrugs snickering, who said about being fair. Suck it up. I guess even Blake is salty like Marina a little bit about the media. I says, well, in that case let me prepare my Kuret storm. I will turn all the rocks into dust. How's that for being fair.

Marina dips out, freak no. Blake lets not wait for him to do that. All attack now. Huh, what. Marina was already producing multiple charms around her arms. Then on my right Blake was to gathering his Kuret. Freak you guys, I yell. I make a yell and bring out my wild Kuret. I already know I was going to lose though.

Vanessa (Chapter 90)

Thursday, January 29, 2026 13:40

Things in a small island can change very easily. One day you are at the receiving end of wary eyes. And then suddenly you are respectable again. That's what happened last few days. David wasn't seen anywhere in public since his outrage accusing Ryes and then Citradel. And then Cranston made a live stream about the officers and David. While people were skeptical of David, majority of officers were backing David now. And from there he had managed to garner sympathies from people. No, not just that. Admiration. Its like people are gradually believing that Ryes had a person grudge on David since he made Charles give up. Cranston had a live talk with Reinhart and showed that it was a mutual decision. No one was forced.

Cranston sparked a lot of controversy among people. Many remain unconvinced, but they can't do anything about it. And then last night Marina send out a group message to us. Charles had contacted her and confirmed their deal hasn't changed. They will be coming to us as promised. They even shared their requirements and preferences on where to live. Blake had called for a discussion today with Marina and some other developers. Though we can't really start any construction. Not when Luther and Tina are still trying to convince the tech team stuck in Italy to move to our city.

I haven't heard the latest updates from them, but Blake was quite confident after getting the news from Marina. Slowly things were turning in our favor. The smuggling operation is running full steam ahead. We had arrested around 19 people by today morning. Most of them were normal people, who didn't like that they had to give up things before coming here. Its a very strange behavior, if they didn't want to give up those things, try to convince us before resorting to illegal imports. We are not asking them to forget everything about Earth, just remember our own heritage.

One client had even imported a stolen artifact from some place called Lurve. I don't know where that this, but few officers knew and were outraged. They wanted it to return immediately. Deni said it was a very important cultural item from Human history. Keeping it here was a heinous crime. Others like Tessa just wanted to return it so that no one traces it to them. We had seized various things from the people in IDF. But they are just under lock and key for the time being. We have a team ready who will plan to take it to back to the government, or their owners.

There were so many things like that, a painting called Rembrandt I didn't understand, illegal human drugs for recreational pleasures, even some weapons I am not familiar with. That last one made everyone hesitate. Why even need it, but Sommers said they were just low level weapons that were mostly for self defense. Still, we couldn't let them keep it. Some people had harmless things, but it didn't change the fact that we can't have it in the city. I am leaving it to the tribunal to decide how what type of punishment they will get.

Speaking of punishment, there is talk amongst the officers about the warriors in prison. Having such powerful people in cells is bad. Many hold a popular opinion to stipe their alpha powers and give it to their relatives. That did felt justified. But with Polly, we didn't have an option. So rehabilitation is possible. No one died, so all three have some chances of getting lighter sentence. If Elina had died, they would be held accountable much extreme. Like exile or permanent presentment. That headache was for others to decide. My job was to keep catching the people the hard disk spits out.

After lunch, I am reviewing some of the footage of Elina and Wyan currently in IDF at my desk. Ever since David pointed out something about the book, I have been suspicious. At what, I don't know. David said he was looking for some physical proof on Elina and since there were none, he seemingly gave up. Maybe he was right. Though I held back some reservation. Behind me June approaches, still watching the tapes. I saw you watching yesterday too. If still something is strange why release Elina.

I pivot my chair towards her, don't mind me. I just want to cover my base. June says, no doubt. You guys seem pretty chill on the outside, but inside you are all about work. I smile, that's because everyone wants to finish up work and leave early. No one wants to work more than necessary. June asks, I am beginning to see that. I thought it was because this is hard work. I say, no. its because there is always more work. June laughs, which apparently you are taking a lot of it. I have seen you working till late. Don't you want to go home before dinner.

I could have told that's its just work. I feel guilty lying to so many people. The actual reason is that I have been avoiding going back home in case Ned shows up. He messaged me about meeting at his place. I haven't done that. So he might just come to my place instead. June says, don't you have a boyfriend though. I would assume you want to spend more time now that things have settle down. I make a somber expression. She says, oh wait. So you two are on the outs. Really, I thought that was just a rumor.

I ask, a rumor. June plays dumb, but I prod a bit, what are people saying. June says, well, I am spying on others as you know. I do hear gossip as the new person. On one hand I found it reassuring that she is mixing in well with the people, but the flip side is she will know what others think of me. I sigh, me and him are just having a spat. No big deal. I straight up lied, hopping she doesn't pick up more. She eyes me a little bit leaves it alone, all right. Just asking. I respond, Blake told we all will have busy days. There are things that only I can do. So, I do have to stay back for a little while.

She nods, I guess. I don't know if that was good enough reason for her. I ask, how about you. Did you find a place to live. She smiles, I did. Got a nice little house in section 2. Me and Sam needed some lawn area for our pets, so that place worked. It is a little expensive, but I rather live there than the other place I saw in section 4. I ask, and Sam is your? She shrieks, oh shit. I didn't tell you. Sorry, I thought I told you. He is my partner. We have been together for three years now.

I ask, then he is also from Citradel. I don't think he arrived with you, did he. I would have known about him. She becomes disappointed, he didn't. He is vet, so he wanted to stay with the animals patients. He said he would be here for my match near the end of tournament, but he had an emergency and couldn't leave. I was so mad at him before, but honestly, I am also glad he wasn't here. I didn't want him to see me so down after I lost. I got a little anxious, does he loves animals so much he rather not see support his girlfriend in the first ever Medrone tournament on Earth.

June leans, exactly right. Boys are so dumb. He watched all my matches at least. I wasn't going to let him off the hook. But to be fair, he was very busy with treating and training animals. He had wanted to leave, but some council member wanted him to there longer and couldn't make it here. I had to forgive in the end because it wasn't really his fault. I say, still. Its bad he wasn't here. You might have gotten a great support and beaten David.

She laughs hysterically. But then she saw my serious face and her laughter died, you are serious. She shakes her head, you don't think I didn't give it my all. Girl, you are giving me way too much credit. I was in it for the win no matter what. But now that I have seen the matches after mine, I had no chance.

I suppose it would be unreasonable to think she would falter just because he wasn't here. I smile, as long as you don't regret. She nods, no regrets and I gave it my all. Unlike me she is satisfied with her match. I got curious, you haven't told anyone about Sam. I bet all the guys are hitting on you would back away knowing you are taken. She smiles, let him get jealous. Serves him right for not bring with me. I chuckle, bring Sam in sometime, I like to meet the guy. Talk some sense into him about leaving you alone.

She says, I would honestly love that. But he isn't in the city right now. I realized something, hold on, he is still in Citradel. Seriously, you moved here, even brought a place for the two of you. She shrugs, this one I know isn't his fault. Citradel council have banned anyone from entering or leaving. Ryes escaping has hurt their reputation in more ways than one. And ever since both Blake and David have shaken them, they are trying whatever they can to keep people from leaving.

I am horrified that Citradel is keeping people against their will, did you talk to him. She nods, yeah. Not for long, just enough to know he is fine. Citradel is basically keeping people in the name of finding co-conspirators of Ryes. A clever plan to stop people from leaving. Sam already quit his job once he got a new replacement. She snickers, just last night the replacement also quit. I feel bad he has to leave the animals unintended, but he promised me to not delay any longer. So the moment Citradel opens their border, he will leave.

I lean back in the chair, does Blake know about this. She replies, yup. He already knew it before me. I wanted to get his take on this and see if there is anything he can do. Unfortunately, I have to wait. I know I wasn't expecting Blake to just demand people over, but I had to try. If this is happening to one person, then it maybe happening to others too. Has it gone this bad or was I just exaggerating it from just one instance. June says, he is fine. I keep in contact with him daily. She sighs, I just miss him. Its been months since I saw him. And I like his help to setup our place, because no way I am doing it alone.

I tell, if you need anything let me know. She says, thanks. She then thought of something. I thought she was about to ask a favor. But instead she goes, when he does meet you, could you maybe bring Ned with you also. I ask confused, why. He becomes a little nervous, he has a thing for you. Nothing serious, just a harmless crush. But I don't want him to meet you alone, the guy may look decent, but, he is guy in the end. I had a genuine laugh, are you for real. And he told you that.

She is really a nervous, yeah. And then imagine the shock when I told him I am working with you. No, rather you are my boss. He said he was seriously going to hop over a fence. Like there is an actual fence in Citradel. The nerve of the guy. I can't believe I still have admirers. I thought many would have lost interest in me after I also lost. She says, hey. You look a little bit more happy than you should. I fidget a little. She smiles, just kidding. But seriously, he is intimidated by you as well, so keep your usual self and that will scare him away.

I get offended a little, hey. I am not scary. June makes a unconvinced face. Wait, seriously. I hesitantly ask, I am not, though. Right. She sighs, I don't know if you heard, but have a intimidation aura on you. I mean, when was the last time you had something fun. I say, I have tons of fun times. She waited me to explain. I nearly brought David's name in reflex and shut my mouth. I can't believe I almost said his name instead of Ned. She says, see. You need to live more. Just fix things with your boyfriend.

I can't deny that I haven't been able to enjoy much these days. She says, and you know what. We can. Suddenly I hear a loud commotion. Then someone yells, guys we got a runner. I sigh and stand up muttering, not again. June looks around the place confused and says, what happened. I gesture her to follow me and we walk to side window. There was a women running with hand cuffs on her away from IDF entrance screaming, I still love you, even if you are in prison. June shouts, did that happen again.

This was the third time someone tried to escape. Props to this women, she was the first to try out in the open. I saw Sommers at the entrance with two other guys, both in cuffs. June says, shouldn't we help. I decline, lets just see for now. They aren't going to get far. Sommers sprints into action and leaps into the air towards the running women. The women cuffs should have dampen her Kuret. But somehow she broke through it. I see her skin radiating Kuret in thin slashes thought the air

Oh boy, did she just cut the cuff even with so much Kuret dampening her. Sommers lands a few meters beside her tried to grab her. She cries towards me, leave me alone or I will shred you into pieces. Sommers barks, give it your best shot. That caught her off guard and Sommers side steps towards her. She threw a flurry of slashes towards him. I don't think he was keen on dodging, because he ran straight ahead. The girl screams nervously as the slashes cuts on him, but he just brushes them off with his bare hands.

She throw more at him at this distance. He wasn't getting hurt, but he had to guard his face with his arms. June says, shouldn't we help him. I say, no need. He has been in a fowl mood ever since Cory almost escaped under his watch. When he gets like this, better to just let him do it on his own. And on that cue Sommers leaps towards her again. The girls Kuret slashes were weakened so he rushes in close and grabs her arms from the behind. She screams, let go of me you freak.

She struggles under his tight arm lock. She must have tried to throw more of those slashes, but before she could manifest them completely, Sommers tackles her down face first and plants his on knee on her back. She screams under her face. I tell, looks like attempt number third failed. When are people going to learn. June says, I don't think ever. Because those two guys are already running. I turn to the other side and see the two guys running. One guy

shouts, I already forgot about you. They both also got out of their cuffs also.

One guys grabs the other by the shoulder and they both start to fly up in the air. I smile, not bad. A Kuret was forming in one guys legs and was using it like a staking board in the air. I have seen this Kuret somewhere before. Sommers saw them surfing away in the air and leapt up to stop them. But they were out of his reach. The guy who was being carried by the arms, laughs, get lost sucker. My brother has a warrior friend from the top 100. Better not mess with me again. One word and he will kill you.

Seriously, that threat felt a little bit weak. I open the window and raised my foot to cross outside. June pats my knees, wait. Let me. I saw her getting a little bit excited. This was her first job as an officer. I let her, they are all yours. Just try not to kill them. June activates her Kuret and levitates out through the window. Once out she raised her hand and creates her gravity Kuret ball aimed at the fleeing guys. A few seconds later they get immobilized suspended in the air.

I hear them shouting, what the freak. Other guy yells, why are you stopping. He replies, I can't move. Somethings pulling me back. June levitated closer to them and they began to fall backwards towards her. Their panic reach a new level when they see her approaching from back. They guy yells, freak. Get away women. You don't want to mess with my friends. I got connection to Citradel warriors too. June ask who is it. I might know them. The guy panics, that's the gravity women. Lets go dammit. He shouts, I can't.

June gradually settles down on the ground and then yanks them both down hard. The two guys fall straight to the ground and get plumed in the lawn grass. They writhe in pain lying flat on the ground. I think one guy got a broken arm and other got a broken leg. June says, shit. I messed up a little. She walks to the guy who was threatening earlier, I wanted to cripple just your legs. The guy while in pain tried to crawl away in fear. Sommers rushes in, thanks June. These are some slippery bastards.

June releases her Kuret, no problem. But how did they get out of the cuffs. Sommers turns one of the guy in pain on his back, we used old one I think. They must have gotten weaker with repeated uses. I need to ask the R & D to fix that issue. Other officers came and picked the three people from the ground. I turn around the gawking people from this side. I yell, shows over people. Unfortunately, no one escaping today to.

People scatter away realizing the attempt failed. Ruther comes to me, they are getting even more desperate now. I nod, these clients aren't snitching how they get in contact with Wyan. So it's a pain to go after them one at a time. Gives them a chance to run. Ruther says, a team caught them near the shore this time. I think we should triple the patrols in the barrier. I say, we have no other choice. Even one escaping just to the water itself is not good enough for IDF.

Ruther pulls out his phone and makes a not of it. He then gets excited, speaking of shores. Did you see the viral video going from this morning. I ask, huh. Is it about Cranston. Did he post today again. He says, I knew it. You were either in office all day. I pull my phone and view the social site. There were a lot of messages floating in the network. But then I saw a short video. At first I didn't understand what I was seeing. I saw Blake use his Kuret, then Marina. And David was there too. They all seemed in deep conversation. I ask, are they working on something.

Then the video cuts to a different scene. A shock appear in my face. Is this Marina doing a photoshoot in her jogging shorts. She was in multiple poses, like for a beach commercial. The other two were in the corner staring at her. The sound of the people cheering came from the video. I ask, what is this. Ruther laughs, right. Marina's got style and confidence. You can see it right, it made the guys nervous. How hilarious is this. What the hell is going on. Are these guys having fun in the beach. I ask, when was this. He shrugs, don't know. It happened this morning though. But that's not all. Check out the rest.

Suddenly the video cuts to them all standing in a line up and reading their Kuret to attack on a rocks. Blake uses his Kuret kick from a jump into the air and pulverizes the rock. Marina's charms creates a crack on the rocks they blast into pieces. David had dawned his wild Kuret and landed a punch which did the least damage among them. He broke the rock from the middle into only few pieces. They had a competition in which Blake won and David lost. Daivd slumps down on his knees, like he was devasted from the loss. Marina beside her points to the people victory pose with her fingers.

I laughed at this amusing scene. I say, what were they doing there. I put my phone down. Ruther says, I heard they were training David. My leg almost slipped, say that again. He says, imagine the surprise. I haven't gotten to talk to any of them. So we aren't sure. But a friend told me they were talking over an hour. So I think this is some sort of special session. Two Shadows helping out David. That's going to seriously make even Charles nervous. I didn't expect this. Its true David hadn't gotten the chance to begin his training for the match. And now that Heraknus are confirmed to move, its high time he resumed the original goal.

What are they helping David with. That question lingered all the way till night. Around 8 I got a message from Blake that all high ranking officers are mandatory at the dining building. What is this about then. All four of us left from IDF 15 minutes before that time. Sommers says, probably to welcome Marina, June and the alpha twins. We didn't have official one and not everyone has spoken to them. I say, probably. Any news about Luther and Tina. Deni says, I got a incoming request from the barrier control. They are heading back now. I ask, with others?

Deni says a little desponded, empty handed. I ask, what happened. Something went wrong in the negotiation. Ruther says, didn't hear about that yet. We might know might now. June says, its not all bad right. No news doesn't mean bad news. I hope that's the case. When we reach the dining building, I found a officers table and saw Blake, Marina, Nathan, Jess and Catherine already seated. They all seem in better mood than us. I slight tension vanishing seeing Blake in good spirits. It doesn't look like any issue happened.

Blake notices us and says, welcome guys. Take a seat. I take the seat beside Jess, hey. So what's this about. Jess says, something about Citradel. Must be good because Blake called all of us, outside the office. Blake says, we are waiting on others to arrive too. Just few minutes. Sommers ask, is this about Luther and Tine. I hear they are back. Blake says, yeah. They just arrived an hour back. I ask, then about the negotiations with the tech team. I thought they won't return without them.

Blake says, that wasn't the actual goal. We told them our proposal, and now its up to them to choose. Ideally I wanted to let them discuss more, but apparently Citradel has been issuing a sort of clamp down. Not letting people leave or even talk to other communities. So the Citradel guards with them stonewalled us since this morning. Luther wasn't able force himself in to their rooms. I wasn't expecting them to send 5 warriors. He turns to Marina, do you know any one of them, Lorance, Uni, Wade, Esin, Piper. They had participated in the tournament too and went back after they lost.

Marina says confused, Wade's was with them. She shook her head. June says, I know Piper too. I hope they didn't antagonize these two people. I ask, are they trouble. Marina wiggles her palm to us, while June shrugs, in a way. They both are alphas, but their bark is more stronger than their bite. They are decent fighters. More then relying on Kuret, they use weapons. If the tournament didn't allow for weapons, they would have gotten farther than others. I hope they didn't hurt anyone.

Blake says, no they didn't. Nathan says, so couple of alphas relying on weapons. I can relate with that. Catherine asks, so what happens now. You just let them leave without doing anything more. Blake says, believe me. I didn't have much choice. With strong guards, they couldn't do much. So I just called them back. But its not all bad. I ask, they are still in Italy then. He says, they won't come with us, but they aren't going back as well. Not when Citradel is in lock down. So for the time being they are stuck.

Then its still the same situation right now. I ask, but then our expansion gets delayed. Doesn't it. Blake's shoulder drops down in a slight disappointment. Marina says, that can't be helped. Ruther asks, you have any expertise in the Kuret enrichment Marina. Marina says, some. But not like them. We can try it our own, but that means its slow and also error prone. Nathan says, not a good idea when we don't want to waste our materials. Marina nods, that's right. We might have it in surplus, but its not good to let it to go to waste. I ask, but isn't this bad then. The longer this drags, we more our plans get delayed.

Nathan smirks, Citradel council knows this. Those cunning people are not giving up the fight yet. If they can't stop David from robbing them blind, they can stop their tech teams. Which is very actually very weird. Why send it in the first place. Could it be some internal discord. He was close enough, only 5 people knew how that happened. Blake says, in any case, Citradel blocking them is putting us behind schedule. Marina has laid out the foundational plans and blueprints are nearly done. But those people are absolutely necessary.

Citradel isn't going to back down so easily huh. Blake continues, I have two things to discuss today. One is to welcome our new Citradel officers into our ranks. The other is to get any idea on how to break the stalemate. June says, you didn't have to do this you know. Blake says, nonsense. I wanted to this much earlier, but we were in a critical time. Things are much better right now. He turns to me, where is Tessa. I though she was in IDF. I answer, she went back home early. She will join in a minute.

Blake says, something wrong. I reply, no. She has been non stop hunting for the people on the run. I asked her to take the latter day off. Marina says, that reminds me. You had another escape attempt today, didn't you. Sommers replies, please don't remind me. I can't deal with more people. He turns Nathan, your Kuret suppressors gets worn off pretty fast. Nathan says, what can you expect from those silly things. I have been asking Vanessa to other alternatives.

I reply, I am telling you those are too harsh. They are for actual dangerous criminals. Not regular people. Nathan clicks his tongue, keep having that softer restraint and you will have to deal more of that. He turns to Sommers, Frank is saying he wants try out something that Citradel does. So maybe that will help you out. Sommers nods, that would be great. Blake asks, is that why he is also late. He replies, the kid's taking initiative. I thought he take another day to settle in, but he jumped straight in. I might has well use him well then.

I say, but you left him alone. Nathan scoffs, wrong, he left me alone here. I told him to take a break and join us. But he was in a zone. He should be here soon. Blake says, okay. Chealse is at the office wrapping up some work too. These alpha twins might really have a physic connection. That made everyone giggle. People broke into their discussion for a while. I joined in the conversation between Catherine and Marina. Catherine says, Marina, I saw your video from morning. That's was so funny I almost dropped my drink.

Marina gleams profusely, yes. Its going well then. Jess beside me asks, you planned that, didn't you. Marina says, of course. I just feel Blake and David have been talking the spotlight a little too much. I can't be the only shadow left behind. That's a weird way to do that. I say, so you pose like a model. Seriously. I laugh remembering that ridiculous images. Marina puts her tongue out amused my by reaction. Catherine says, you have gotten attention from all the boys for sure.

Marina says, that's the idea. People only talk to me about my Kuret or fighting style. I gotta show my feminine side too. Otherwise I am not going to get a decent boyfriend. Jess asks surprised, you playing the field then. Marina thinks for a moment, I mean, not right now. Too busy. But sure, I am just dropping out some hints. I say, and what way to do that. I clap to her. She laughs, thanks. It was just a whim. I thought it wouldn't work. But honestly, the guys reaction made it even better. Catherine peeks at Blake and back to her with a smile, I think Blake was worried you were going to ask them to join in.

Jess laughs, that would have been even funnier. Marina says, nah. They were just intimidated by me. I say, more like frozen in shock and awe. Catherine asks, that's so true. David looked the most panicked. I think being in the limelight has him nervous. Jess says, I have seen him less nervous during battle. That's right. He felt out of his element. I ask, so is true you were there to train. Marina says, yeah. We discussed on how to improve his Kuret skills. I ask, I have been wondering about that for a while. How exactly.

Marina smirks, listen to this. He has studied my and Blake Kuret very closely. And using the, she makes air quotes, science behind it, to use that technique to generate multiple Kurets. I lean in closer, did he reveal it to you. She nods. Everyone gets excited at this. Jess asks, well. Don't just keep us in suspense. Tell us. Marina makes a hesitant face. I ask, what. She replies, sorry you guys. I rather not tell. I scoff, really. Did David ask you not to tell. Because that's just crap. She says, no. He said its fine I want to reveal it now. But I agreed its better to keep it under wraps.

I don't believe it, why. She says, the whole things is a little complicated. Catherine says, hey, you calling us stupid. Marina gets a little anxious, not like that. But lets just say he told me something completely ridiculous and unheard

of. I like to study more about it and help him first before telling anyone. This is suspicious. Even Marina doesn't want to share it with us. Jess asks, you mean its unique to just him. Marina says, exactly. Once I heard about it, I couldn't believe it. His way of thinking is very different than yours or mine. The way he copied me is nothing short of brilliance. Suffice to say its not something people will accept easily.

Just what did David tell her. But if even Marina is not ready to explain it, its something really serious. I point to Blake, if I ask him. Marina says, try him. Poor guy tried to act like he understood, but I know his brain fried and later said to me he rather forget about it. Jess says, jeez. You know, the way you talk about David. Why not ask him out. You two are close anyways. I turn to Jess with a sharp glare. Jess leans away a little with a smile, what. Just saying. Marina laughs, nah. He is more like a brother to me. I rather not think him of like that.

Catherine smirks with a sinister smile, really. And why is that. Marina says thinking and searching for words, well, he. Jess asks, different? Catherine asks, too brainy? I ask, keeps too many secrets? She looks at us with flustered face, no. I don't have problem with that. But, she becomes even more flustered, he knows more about me than anyone. I rather keep some things simple between us. Besides, he is not my type. And I am not his. Catherine asks, I see. Interesting, what does he know about you. Like your childhood. Marina nervously smiles, not going to talk about it.

Maybe Marina has things even she is embarrassed or want to keep private. I ask, so wait. What is your type then. She says, if I had to say one thing in particular, someone who can keep up with me. All three of us lean away and look away from her. She cries, hey. Rude. I know I am high maintenance, but come on. How hard is it to find a guy. I have no idea if there is anyone that can be in tune with her. But who knows, maybe someone is perfect match for her. But the thought of two of them makes me anxious. Jess asks, you know David's type then. I should have known it would eventually come to this. I wished we didn't talk about David's dating life.

Marina smirks, really. Is there trouble with Nathan? Jess flairs her nostrils, no way. David is too scheming for my taste. She wasn't really wrong, people who haven't seen what he was like in the beginning tend to think that. She says, few of the girls were asking to me about him. Catherine remained impartial, but I wanted pay back a favor to her. This is a good time if any to ask about it. I ask, other girls are interested him. Catherine says, of course they are. He has been raking up quite a bit of name for himself. And now he went on live broadcast and said deeply emotional things. You do know that girls are attracted to that right?

Can't say I feel the same, he lied about everything though. Jess nods, that’s true. Its a tricky thing, that’s why I didn't want to intrude on him. Marina says, but that’s not really a problem, is it. Sure, he lied. But the reality is he was never guilty of any of those things. So what's the problem. Her logic made me even mad, not because I didn't know it he was innocent of it, but because this made me envious. He gets to lie, keep secrets, and doesn't trust people. And yet people admire him. I am angered thinking why I am not able to reconcile with the other facets of him.

Jess says, you known him longer than us right. So you must have some good idea about his type. What kind of girls has he dated. I was being cornered by three curious and excited gazes on me. I can't say what he likes and doesn't. His past girlfriends is either dead or trying to catch him. I say, its hard for me to say. You know how he is. But maybe he. The gods heard my silent plea and got me off this topic. Because there was huge commotion downstairs. I heard many people cheering and clapping.

Everyone here got up and walked to the edge of our floor. Below us people had gotten up and surrounding a figure crossing them in the middle. It was him. Dammit, did he bug us and planted to make an entrance just to mess with us. Blake says, finally. I thought he wouldn't show up. I wanted to do this during lunch, but he was busy then. I ask, you called him too. He replies, I did. He needs to get out of his house, thought this could help him out. Nathan says, look at him struggling. This is a rare treat.

I thought he was just being salty from the attention David is getting. However, it turns out David is not really acting like himself. He has wary eyes with unsure expression. He nervously chuckles as people give him fist bumps and waves to him. Even when shaking hands with him, he takes a delay to contemplate about it. Marina laughs, he is like a small fish trapped in the sea of piranhas. Catherine says, he needs to shake it off. Blake says, that he does. We can't have him act awkwardly all the time. First few times people will just shrug it off saying he was probably taken by surprise. I should talk to him about it later.

If someone had said few days before that David is going to be a celebrity like this, I would have just flipped them off. But seeing it in front of me, I just pissed me off even more.

Blake (Chapter 91)

Friday, January 30, 2026 15:27

We took our seats back once David approached out table. He had a nervous smile plastered on him. He waves at everyone as he passes around us and takes the chair I left open for him on my left. I say, you are way to troubled. He reply, no shit. I am really not comfortable with this level of reaction from people. Nathan says, you surprise me. You show a cavalier attitude when they be cautious or be suspicious of you. David makes a disappointed face, I can't help it. I have gone from being called a cheat and manipulator to this. This is way too fast and unpredictable. Every smile I see, I am either overthinking or not believing them.

I assumed as much. A paranoid guy like him is at ease when adapting in bad or difficult situations. He obviously never had received praised for his actions like this. He shifts uneasily on his seat, lets not make it a big deal. I will try to not be so awkward around people next time. People gave him encouraging smile. At least he is aware how is appearing to others. Then I shouldn't butt in and ask him to adjust his attitude. He turns to June, welcome June. You were Marina's top candidates, and its good to have you. June replies, thanks David. Its been a wild ride these months for me. Its help me realize this place is better for us in long term.

He says, glad you came to believe that as well. If only all of Citradel came to that conclusion. She says, they will. Especially when you are making their lives so miserable. That invoked a laughter from us. David smirks, funny you should say that. He turns to me, I couldn't make it during lunch because I had to deal with another pushback from Citradel. I ask curious, what did they do now. He replies, lets wait for others. I think I saw Tessa behind me. I agreed, so I filled him the current situation with Luther and Tina.

After the report he says, so Citradel is not playing ball on that front too, huh? Seems about right. Nathan asks nonchalantly, can't you do something about it. He snaps, I am already struggling to keep the materials away from Citradels grasp. Anymore than that and I might as well just declare war on them. Jess says, lets try for a diplomatic solution for them instead. Nathan says, that’s too slow. Blake, you said it right. We are loosing time. How much delay can we take.

I say, I need ideas, not complaints. Just then we see Tessa joining us, hey guys. Sorry for being late. I say, hey Tessa. No worries, we waiting for everyone. She takes her seat beside Vanessa, are the twins not coming. I reply, they will be here soon. Then I spotted Luther and Tine near the entrance. Their defeated aura showed their tired state. A few minutes later they walk sluggishly to our table. I say, you both look awful. Tina says annoyed, I hadn't had a shower until now. 39 hours. This is the worst. She takes a seat beside Luther. He was more collected, but visibly stressed, it was a bust on top of that. We only got to discuss some time in the night two days ago and since then we were blocked from even seeing anyone.

I say, thanks for trying though. Tina says, wait. David's already here. Oh shoot. I was supposed to make you the schedule of the next shipments. David says, don't worry about it Tina. I have made one for you already. Take a look at it in the morning. It can wait until then. She relaxes, oh jeez. Thanks. You seem much better than last time we saw you. Luther says, you have become quite a celebrity too. I saw Cranston's video on the way back. Marina says, though he is too shy. Its really not a good look on you.

David gives an short annoyed look at Marina. Luther says, really. I thought you wouldn't mind it. People are loving you and it makes also look good. David sighs, just stop it. I know this is good, but I rather not be praised about lying to people. Vanessa says, when has that ever stopped you. I was waiting for her to snap. I know she and David spoke recently, but she is still so hostile to him. He didn't hesitate to reply, the difference is it was about my past. There are people I don't want to bring into peoples conversation.

I ask, you mean about your guardians. I don't think you have to be worried about that. No one here can or will do anything to them. David wasn't convinced even after I all the times I tried to assure him. He might be also worried about Sophie. Its true that if Echo learns of this, they all will be jeopardized. Luther says, I understand the concern. But if keep that aside, it’s a matter of perspective. You did nothing wrong, don't forget that. David stayed silent, probably wondering on how to adjust to this new situation.

I say, regardless. This is pressuring Citradel even more. Did you hear about the latest Citradel policy. Luther nods, a rather typical response I would say. Nathan says, I find it very counter productive. People must be anxious there right now. Luther says, they were already before. If you think about it, with Heraknus being revealed and their sudden departure announcement, they were in turmoil way before this. Marina says, that’s true. My friend in Citradel said she say people were desperately trying to convince Heraknus to stay.

Luther says, that was the beginning. They are in worse situation right now. The first thing they gotta do is to hunker down and sort their houses. Because its crumbing down. Stopping Heraknus, finding Ryes and his possible co-conspirators, and holding on to their resources. Its no wonder they have closed the border. Next few days, maybe even a week will be tough for them. Nathan says, I get all that. But it feels this response was a little excessive. I feel something else is brewing there.

Marina asks, like what. He shrugs. I am beginning to feel the same, I wondered about it too. But Derek's not responding to me, so I have no new information. Marina says, my friend didn't mention anything. June says, same with my boyfriend. I turn to Catherine who shrugs saying, my contacts have either left Citradel before or not responding. So I got nothing. Then I turn to the silent David. He was worried about his contact, so I doubt if he also knew anything.

But turns out his contact is much better than anyone's. He says, Nathan, you might be right. I may know something. But I need all the Citradel people here to confirm something, because I don't understand it completely myself. Tessa says, in that case wait no more, here they come. All eyes turn to stair case and they both were climbing to us. Chealse says, shit. We are the last ones. Frank says, doesn't look good for us, right. I says, hey guys. Thanks for joining. But I thought I said to take it easy for first few days.

They both greet us all. Chealse sits beside Tina, I know. But Tina wasn't here, I thought to take some slack before she came back. Tina sighs, sorry for dropping things on you. Did you run into any trouble. She says, I would be lying if I said none. Lets just say I didn't know I was given my own person desk. Tina asks suspicious, what did you do. She says, you can see tomorrow. They both sigh. Nathan asks, so, you make any progress. Franks says, I got that component working half way. Nathan gets confused, half way. How the hell that makes sense. He shrugs, I know right.

I stand up, all right enough of that. Lets raise a toast for the four new officers. I took my drink from the table and others followed suit. David took one out of politeness. I walk to the edge of the railings and shout, guys. Just a minute of you time. People below stop gathering and turn their eyes above. I clear my throat and say, Everyone knows this already, but I wanted to formally welcome some new people from Citradel joining us. Everyone who just joined us, could you stand up and everyone gave a round of applause for them.

Around 35 Citradel officers stood up from various seats. Everyone applauses for them and cheers them on. I had made sure everyone of them were here tonight. I then wave to the four here, and here we have new additions our high ranking officers. You all already met Marina. She is joining our city admin team. And before anyone asks me, yes, that’s me in that video. But if anyone asks her what I was doing there, do not believe her. The hall bursts into sounds of laughs and Marina mocks at me smiling. I continue, June has accepted to join at IDF. If anyone wants to see her in action, I take a pause, don't. She is not be messed around.

People snicker and whistle at my joke. June made a flustered face at me, and took one step back in shy. Vanessa grabs her arm helping her stay. She really doesn't like to stand out, like David. I say, and you know these famous twins. They are one omega together, but double the strength of alpha's. So do not mess with them either. They both in proper gimmick raise their arms in unison and even turn their neck around in sync. People were eating up their performance like crazy.

I say, Chealse is in logistics team and Frank has joined our R&D team. Thankfully, they choose different department, because I didn't have the heart to separate them myself. The two of them laugh at my honest thoughts. I really was a little worried for a while. I raise my glass, so here's a toast to our newest team of recruits. You made a decision, and you choose right. Welcome to our city. A thunder of claps seers through the hall and people cheered. It would have been if everyone were happy, but many had trepidation. Its to be expected. They were from Citradel initially. Given time those worry will go away.

After a minute of celebration we come back to our seats and took our drinks. I asked the chef to prepare a special one today. All glasses were empty in few minutes while people congregates the 3 of them. Marina says, hey, no one said anything to me. Vanessa says, that’s was for others benefit. You are already a part of us. Don't forget about viral video. Maina remains still left out. She still is enjoying herself, I think. I wanted to dive right in, but I thought to at least have out dinner we get to our agenda. Everyone began to get tray from the buffet and started eating, well except for one person.

David remained behind reading something from his watch's hologram. I felt a little bad calling him here at the actual dinner time. He said he didn't mind it. June asks him, are you skipping dinner. He says, I had it before. She looks at him trying to understand why he do that. He replies, you haven't heard about me. June is confused, huh. About what? She really didn't know. I guess the details of this condition are not yet known to everyone. I tell her, he can't consume Kuret food or drinks. She puts her drink back on the table astonished, what. Since when. David replies, since birth. June jaw looses, is that because of MAR's.

David nods, yup. Other subjects had the same symptoms. June asks, I thought you just couldn't heal. But not able to eat is worse. What did you do on Medrine. He says, I didn't have much choice. Kuret free extracted foods. Which was basically chemically filtered goo. It was edible and nutrient sufficient. But barely. I was malnourished. The part about my medical condition after arriving on earth was actually true. June says, Jesus. I can't believe it. Marina sits beside her now, don't pity him though. He figured various ways to supplement his intake. I remember this one time at the university chemistry lab where was growing pure organic vegies inside a glass box in a cupboard.

June laughs. David turns a little embarrassed recalling that, you remember that. Please forget it. Marina smiles, no way. That was so damn funny. Who was the prof that had to bail you out. David quickly peeks at Catherine, who realized also who it was. He says, lets not talk about ancient past. Marina chuckles seeing a cornered David. She doesn't get a audience like this often. She was flaunting in front of everyone about knowing him back on Medrine. Well, beyond the Shadows that is.9

She looked like was going to share more embarrassing stories of David. I was actually looking for it. But David is not having it. He says, Marina, if you are going to revisit the past, I might also share things about you as a child. So lets not. Marina says, I am an open book. I got nothing to hide. But her aura showed some hesitation. David made it look like a challenge. I smile seeing something interesting. He says, courtyard of your house, evening on your 11th birthday. Shall I go on. As he was saying Marina was getting a little pale with each word. That instantly shut her up. She gets back to eating quietly. She whispers in very low tone to Catherine, see, I told you. What was that about.

Everyone had a nice laugh seeing someone was capable of making Marina awkward. This is where his skills shines the most, knowing people's secret. Marina shouldn't have tested David when its about his real past. Deni and Vanessa prodded her for details, but she just shrugs off. Nathan says, that’s not nice David. You shouldn't use shouldn't personal information like this. David titled his head to him, do you hear the words coming off your mouth. A second later he backs off him with a chuckle. Nathan's the one here that’s used it against David the most.

We all broke into more laughter and people began talking in small groups. I wanted us to finish our dinner first before moving to the main discussion. I was enjoying the little break too. After some light chit chats, Deni asks, hey Vanessa. Shouldn't we ask for their opinion about the thing we were discussing this morning. Vanessa says, lets not talk about that right now. She says, I get that. But it’s better to ask them now. We need help. I ask, its fine Vanessa. We are here to help out each other. Is there a problem?

Vanessa gave a disapproving look at Deni but then sighs to me, well, I didn't want to talk about work. Tonight is about these 3 people. June shakes her head, I don't mind. Its not lost on me we are in a middle of crisis. Besides, I really don't want to explain to Catherine why Sam loves his pets more than me. I gave a questionable look to Catherine, who felt she was betrayed. She panics with a nervous smile, that's not what I asked. Chealse says, don't mind us too. Frank nods along with her.

Vanessa says, if you are okay, then I guess its fine. We are having a problem with the cache of smuggled merchandise we recovered from the peoples homes. Sommers adds, we do? I didn't hear about it. Tessa asks, is it about the our contact team's refusal to take these items with then. Vanessa says, that's right. They are claiming the pieces are too dangerous to take them back and think to either destroy it or keep it with us. I ask, hold on. I saw reports of harmless stuff mentioned in there, paintings, artifacts and other human cultural significant items.

Luther says, are you saying that they have what, like some sort of tamper proof failsafe. Marina says, that seems overkill, don't you think. They paid so much money for it. Why risk that. Vanessa says, hold on guys. That's not what I meant. They didn't mean dangerous like that. They mean by their value and significance to Humans. Jess asks, you mean like Humans know they are stolen. Deni replies, we don't know that. But suffice to say that sending it back without explaining how we had in the first place could ring major alarms. They said that Humans might trace it back to us.

I ask, seriously. Did Wyan had such a wide network outside among humans. I turn to David, what do you know about it. He says, practically nothing. I mean I tried to find about him, but unlike our small population, there are far too many organizations out there. Though, if I know what kind of stuff we are talking about it could provide some hints. Deni says, they are old relics, that what we can make out. I don't know what's the fuss is about though. Vanessa says, agreed. I mean, we saw have painting this one paining a single women in it. I get that it was drawn by early humans, but I can't figure out why its so important.

Ruther asks, a painting of a women. Deni nods, yeah. You haven't seen it. We kept it in a storage room with others. Sommers says, yeah I saw it. A smiling dark haired women with some mountains in the back. I thought it was decent painting, considering it looked old. Ruther says, I think I have heard about it before. Now where did I remember it from. Jess chocks a little while eating and coughs. She asks, are you kidding me. Are you telling me there is a painting of Mona Lisa sitting in IDF right now.

This causes visible panic among few people. David besides me jerks, Nathan scoffs. Tina shrieks out a little, Catherine puts her glass away in haste and Frank puts his hands on his jaws. Ruther snaps his finger, yeah that one. Wait, holy shit. I didn't know what happened that made them this worried. I ask, who is she. Some famous painter. Tina ignores me, is that true. You have a painting from da Vinci collecting dust in storage. Vanessa was nervous just like me, I mean, we the team asked to lock in a safe place. But what's with the weird reaction.

Nathan says laughing, do you seriously not know what you have there with you. Deni turns pale, does this mean its really important. David says, just wait. He extended his arm and says, M show image of Mona Lisa. His watch throws a hologram in the middle of the table of a paining I saw in Vanessa's reports. He asks with a gulp, is this what you have. Vanessa says, yeah. David lets goes of the hologram and slaps his palm on his forehead, freaking shit. Wyan is far more of over achiever than I thought.

Tessa says, come on guys. You are exaggerating. Franks says, no we are not. This is a very big deal. Its an important part of human history. Catherine says exasperated, its around 500 years old. Its got a long history. Tina says, I can't believe I have a chance to see it in person. Seems only half of us knew what its real worth is. I ask, so I am guessing if we were to simply it back it would cause a problem. David says, a major one. The Italian government will search high and low to figure out how it was stolen and why they have forgery instead.

Tina asks, why do think there is a forgery in Lurve. He replies, Mona Lisa being stolen for the second time would be a big news. There are many legal reproductions out there, but none is currently hanged in Lurve. Either they are hiding that fact it was stolen or it's a forgery. Tina says, yeah, that's makes a lot of sense. Luther asks, this is really bad for us then, right. Marina says, can someone explain how its so valuable. David says, I don't know how to explain it so you can understand it. Someone please help me out here. Catherine says, I got this David. Guys, have you all must heard about the famous Kuritine sculpture made by Jenfroya Payalia.

Of course everyone knows about it. Its one the things very Medrone kid learns about our history. Vanessa says, isn't that the one in the Dorena city. Tessa says, the 5 meter tall statue. I have seen it too. Nathan says, that's the one. Catherine continues, imagine that, but even older and suddenly stolen from the Dorena elders. You think they would sit quiet after learning someone stole it and returned it later. I begin to realize the seriousness of the situation. David says, now you get it. Then something makes him jerk again, wait. If Wyan is able to smuggle that into the city, what else he got in.

The people with Human cultural history knowledge turn to Vanessa and Tina with horrified expressions. Vanessa says, hum, yeah there could be more. We have a painting called Rembrandt. Frank says, freaking shit. Chealse says, hey why do you know that. He says, better question is why you don't know about it. We took Earth cultural classes for a while together. She gets lost in thoughts trying to remember that. Nathan asks, which one is it. Jess says, please say its one of the famous missing ones. That would be incredible. Tina voice goes low, ah, I don't have a clue. David says, this is crazy. Did people really not care about keeping it for themselves here.

Marina ask, I didn't think you were into this so much. David says, I am not. But I am not so callous to not know their importance to Humans. Things may evolve, but not their place in history. Tina says, he is right. Catherine says, maybe its just a coincidence. Lets not make it panic before we know for sure. She turns to Vanessa, do you have something called Goya as well. Vanessa hesitates a bit not responding. Catherine scoffs, I was only kidding. Okay, we can now panic a little. Ruther says, I think I have heard that one too. Damn these people. They were using Wyan to steal these so brazenly.

Nathan says, what's next, the Shrik. Jess says, I doubt anyone has a taste like that among Medrones. Marina asks, what's that. Sounds so strange. Deni says, I don't think we have anything like that. Catherine says , that's the Norwegian name. Its English name is Scream. Deni shakes her head. Nathan says, dang it, I thought it would be here. David asks, do you have something that looks like it was made by a kid and someone is posing and screaming. Tina looks at Vanessa at that description. Their anxious expression gave it away. Jess smiles, I stand corrected. Apparently there is someone who likes it enough to steal it.

People began murmuring and whimpering about this stolen artifacts. Luther asks, lets try to think this through. What if don't give it back, just keep it with us. Even if humans know they are missing, the last thing they will suspect is aliens among them. Tina says, its not just that Luther. Keeping it here longer in dangerous, what if it gets destroyed. I know we lost a lot of our culture, I rather not see Human loose theirs too. A few shared similar sentiment as her. Catherine says, I am with her. We need a way to get it out of the city. Frank says, I rather we keep it with us. Wyan has already stolen it without alerting anyone. But if you guys think its better, I won't get in the way.

Nathan says, it's a waste to give it back. But I know the safer this way. Jess nods along with Nathan. The general census was best to give it back immediately. I say, If you all believe so strongly about it, I guess we need to figure out a way to get rid of it. A few moments of thinking and everyone's eyes fell on one particular person. David scoffs, right. I guess I am the only option huh. I ask, can you return it back without raising any suspicion back to us. He thinks for a moment, easier said than done. We recovered only partial items from people. I am guessing there are more people in the list yet to be decrypted.

Vanessa says, yeah, we are not even halfway done. He replies, so we can expect even more ridicules paintings, or even something else. I won't find it surprising if someone asked Wyan for a dinosaur fossils now. I wanted to believe that was joke, but I can't be sure of it. He continues, I can't give precious items back to government all together. Someone might link the thefts and involve the Interpol. That's especially bad for me. I am not charged for art crimes. Not yet at least.

Marina says, you worried about adding those charges on your name. He says, I am. Having more crimes pinned on me will make it difficult for my other businesses. He then cocks his head to the ceiling for a moment and then back to us, that being said, its not a bad thing if I do this correctly. Luther says, dude, only you would be okay with more crimes pinned on you. Maybe fame has messed you a little bit. David smiles, perhaps. Anyways, I am thinking for selling it to people, instead of giving it back to the owners and museum.

Vaness says with a snark, you dog. You want to make a profit from this. David defends himself, hey, its not me who stole it. Blame Wyan for this mess too. I am just explaining the reality here. I can't just courier Mona Lisa in a box to Lurve. It will cause a massive international manhunt. A trail that not even I can hide us as the source. Maybe I can return some items back to smaller museums or personal owners. But what if they report the unexplainable theft and even ridiculousness of its anonymous return.

He had a point. David turns to Tina, I know you want to give it back to their rightful place. But its very risky to do it ourselves. Tina replies with a somber face, I get what you mean. It may not be the right move for us. David nods, and I can't just sell it for free to other people. That's even more suspicious. So I gotta sell it off quickly and silently. I think I can find a way that they remain undetected for long enough that trail goes cold for anyone to find out about us. It may take months, or even years. By then the original source of the theft will go unsolved. That's the best option right now.

I consider this for a moment, if you believe that, then I leave it to you. David nods, great. It will take some time though. He then smiles, actually, it's serendipitous. I have burned a lot of cash fighting against Citradel. This might help in making me whole again. I know one person who would be ecstatic and back off me. He turns to Vanessa, keep it safe in IDF right now. Once everything is cataloged, I will take it off you. People had mixed feelings about it, especially Tina. Her aura showed a lot of regret. Nothing can't be done about it though.

But Vaness remained a bit unconvinced. I ask, something else the matter? She gives us a big smile, like she just thought of something sneaky. She says, if you are going to sell it for money, tell me why I should be giving it you for free. Marina whistles, that's cold, Vanessa. She ignores that snide comments, if you are going to get benefit from this, why shouldn't we. Everyone were stunned by Vanessa's sudden reluctance. I thought things had cooled down for her. But maybe that was just wishful thinking. Does she still carries so much petty anger towards David.

David was even caught off guard with this. He says, a few minute ago, Deni was telling us how you guys were thinking of destroying it. And now you are using it as leverage against me. He smirks at Vanessa's change in demeanor. She laughs, a minute ago you weren't going to sell stolen things too. David scoffs, so you want me to buy it from you. Vanessa shrugs suggesting it was the only way. Beside her Sommers, Deni and Ruther gave nervous look to watch other. Tessa and June were also confused.

Nathan says chuckling, bold move. I kind of like it though. David gives slight glare towards Vanessa. Oh boy, he is not going to let this go easily. He tells, you do know that if I want, I can just break into IDF and take it for myself. Vanessa remains skeptical for this, if you could, you wouldn't be so bothered by it. I am guess you don't want to make an enemy of IDF by doing this. Don't you? And by that she meant herself. She was intentionally provoking him in front of everyone one. I sigh realizing she still has enough grudge against David to rebuttal this.

Others from IDF didn't share the same confidence as her. Ruther whispers to Deni, ah, is she going to make an enemy of David instead. David pulled back some of his annoyance back while observing others. He snickers, all right. It does seem unfair to you. So lets make a deal. What do you need. A bigger budget for IDF ? Because I got the bank with me, he slaps Luther on the shoulder. Luther says, hey now. That's not how economics work here dude. He replies, I know, but you can make exception right.

Luther says, no way. He then turns to me, how about I get the coffee machines, like mine, for the officers building, seems a good compromise then. I didn't even hesitate, Luther maybe we can make an exception just this time. Luther turns to me incredulously, coffee, really. Marina spats, say that again after you tried it once. I have been dying to grab another one for few days now. Others were not sure what happened. I think I might have been influenced by David's seriousness. But honestly, I do believe if Vanessa needs a bigger budget, we can give it to her.

Luther was caught between him and me now. I remained silent wondering in Vanessa really wanted money. She says, really now. You think I am so shallow to ask money for this. Sommers, actually we already sent a request for

that a few hours ago. We got a lot of new officers joining our department than any of others. So its fair, right. I turned to Luther, who says, I was about to discuss it for tomorrow. Vanessa says, that’s not what I want. David sighs, thank god. Because I was not ready to be extorted like this. Looks like no coffee for you guys. Marina and I made a slightly disappointed look.

This made the mood a lighter amongst us. I think David wanted to take away some of the awkwardness Vanessa was causing everyone. Vanessa says, we are not in shortage of people, and yet our security is not enough. We have had increasing attempts to escape recently, things are becoming gradually becoming difficult for us to guard all the edges around the island. Tessa says, she makes a point. On top of that, the expansion plan doesn't include our security as high priority.

Vanessa adds, right. Its fine for outside threat, but the inside threat is a growing concern. Blake, I know you wanted people to keep their faith in IDF. I just think finishing up the smuggling criminal case is not enough. We got lucky no died. But I can't let it happen again. Seems she has been thinking about it for a while. I nod, I get your concerns. But what is David going to do for you that we can't.

She says, glad you said it that way. I heard about those autonomous bots David has. I want him to give it to us. Even the killer robots Marina told about us a while back.

David (Chapter 92)

Saturday, January 31, 2026 14:23

What a little minx. She is definitely gunning for me because of my behavior last time we met. I was out of line, I get that. But in my defense I had to lie to every Medrone about my past that day. I was also on edge since I heard she tried to reveal my identity to Elina. The issue was between us, why bring Elina into it. Once I noticed she wasn't going to hide her resentment, I decided to distract everyone and make some jokes. I managed to diffuse the situation before she escalated any further. There was no way that Luther would bank roll me. But its was funny that Blake almost did it when I bribed him with coffee.

The heavy air seemed to less and for now at least Vanessa didn't push it further. But then she asked something completely unexpected, my ART bots. You want those. She nods, is that what its called. Then yeah. Its clear she is not letting go of the grudge. She is cleverly blanketing with something reasonable. Frank asks puzzled, you have robots with you. He gets excited about it. Marina says, oh he got lot more than that. Let me tell you new joiners. She began tattling about my ART house.

But my mind is hooked on Vanessa. She seems to enjoy putting me on the spot like this. I do know she is thinking about IDF and its reputation. But she could have made it less mischievous or asked for it separately later. I turn to Blake who was probably thinking the same. Did he or Marina told Vanessa about them from the video I showed them earlier. No, they wouldn't have. Vanessa hasn't seen them. She probably just heard about it from them. Or maybe from Catherine. So what should I do now. This deviates from the plan I had for the bots a little. After thinking over it, I decided on a negotiation plan.

I needed to confirm few things so I waited for Marina to finish her story. Nathan turns to me, I didn't know you were looking into this avenue. You are holding out a lot from us. Aren't you. He is involved in one major research mission with me, so I am sure he suspects there are other too. Frank says, I need to see this man. You have successfully integrated Hive tech into Medrine tech. I correct him, not Medrine. Earth technology. And its not completed. Marina is so up my ass about finishing it up quickly. She scoffs at me, because I only got to see it from outside. Catherine got a inside tour. Catherine sighs, again, I didn't see much of anything.

Vanessa asks, so how about it. You can give it to us, can't you. I am sure you other security measure available. The island needs it more. I could feel the pressure from few people now. But I had already made up my mind and just smiled, sure. I got no problem. Vanessa smirk slightly wavered, probably wondering I am giving it up so easily. I add, they are not combat ready. Any person with strong Kuret or a decent weapon can destroy it easily. Vanessa remains silent at my acquiesce behavior. Sommers says, that’s perfectly fine. We only need it for surveillance and minor scuffles. Deni says, we can come up with a response based actions then.

Tessa asks, I have a suggestion in that case. We can rearrange our crews to be more spread inside the city rather than out. Avoid another situation like this. Can these bots can go underwater ? That will save a lot of effort and time in manual patrolling around the border. I say, sure. I designed them for underwater operations. They can even shift into marine life, like fishes, sharks, whales, or seafloor faunas. And they can mimic the biological signals of the creatures they shift into, so unless someone is at close proximity, they are virtually undetectable.

People are impressed by the tech. June asks, and it has no Kuritine or Medrone tech. I shake my head, none. So not even Echo know about it. But I am not sure about Hive. Its their tech, I haven't been able to field test that. Luther says, that's plenty stealthy already. But why have such advance tech. I sigh, because the house I am living is much more important. I needed max security for it. I don't think its time to reveal my ultimate goal with it. I let that sink in and let others believe whatever they wanted.

Tessa asks, what about arial surveillance. Marina said they were flying. I reply, unfortunately there is limit there. It doesn't have a sufficient power source to sustain itself for a perpetual flight. The last test I did showed around 1 hour of aerial time at a max height of 0.7 miles. But you can send it in separate batch for continuity. Ruther says, that’s awesome. We are lacking in surveillance from above. I add, the cameras on them go to about 400 optical zoom. I have been playing around the idea of a satellite system with this. Though its just an idea for now.

This made many excited. Blake says, seriously. We needed an interface like that. Nathan, we were planning for it right. What was the progress for it. He says, its just at the design stage. We were more focused on reinforcing ground infrastructure first. Which type of interface are you using for it. I say, lets not get into technicals now. Just know its the same software as what SpaceX is using. Its not integrated into a single interface, but maybe you can look into it. He nods, that I can do.

Marina asks with excitement, what about those killer bots. I laugh at her excitement with others. I answer, they are functional too. But a word of caution for them. I face Vanessa who was no longer enjoying anymore. She really thought I would cause a scene by getting angry at her for such a demand. She asks, what's the catch. I say, they are not people friendly. I programmed them for operational efficiency and combat flexibility. I haven't focused tested about their appearance with people. Their tech doesn't allow for much shift in exterior form, but only on weapons. I am very certain its going to scare people instead of making them feel safe. Kids will most definitely be wary of it.

Blake asks, the one Marina and I saw weren't that scary. I say, those aren't combat bots. They weren't present in the video I showed them earlier too. I turn to Vanessa, I tried to change the design but it was interfering with other operations. So I didn't pursue it. Luther asks, its actually better for us if its intimidating. But on the other hand. Blake completes his words, if this makes people unformattable it could be difficult. Marina says, we can just dress them with a designer metal frame.

I say, maybe. Like I said, I wasn't going for aesthetics right now. Try to upgrade them without restricting any of their core designs. Have at it. Nathan smiles, I feel you are just dumping things to me. I nod, that’s right. Since Vanessa is haggling for it, I might as well let you guys finish the tech. Tessa says, that’s all fine. But what's the power source. If its not Kuritine, then I don't think its simple as a battery. I look around people and say, I wanted to confirm this. Are you all okay with keeping that a secret. Vanessa says, you don't us to tell anyone about it. Why.

I was intentionally making a show to her. She was slightly annoyed with me. But I had to make her believe this is me not playing any tricks on her. Otherwise she might sense my intention. I say, people might try to steal the tech or study it then. Blake says, all right. Anyone has any problem with keeping it just between us. Vanessa slightly hesitated, but others agreed to it without an issue. I waited for a verbal confirmation from Vanessa. She finally says, sure. That’s all I needed. I say, I got my hands on a the designs of the tech Citradel uses to power majority of their other techs. My science team found a way to alternate the Kuritine supply with a cold fusion drive.

As expected not many people understood the concept. Save Nathan, who shrieks, holy shit. Cold fusion reactors. They are real. I thought it was a just a theoretical concept Human scientist have. I say, well, its not exactly that, but its close enough. We reversed engineered that tech from Echo's war ships. They have far advance power source, and we only were able to achieve 30 % of their energy output. At least, for now. But we if you guys can figure out a way, you can reinforce it with Kuritines source. I haven't researched that. Its another development you guys can look into it.

Nathan asks, if its fission, then it means nuclear materials. We aren't exactly a big supply for it. And it will take time to modify the tech of our purposes I reply, I got you covered. I will provide enough cesium to last for another two years. That must be enough to come with an alternate source. Nathan says, you just have that much lying around with you. I say, be thankful to the actual team who are in charge of it. I design, give directives and provide the science, but they have much higher IQ than me.

He asks, just who are they. I want to meet them. I reply, dream on. They are people who I am trusting with these tech. I have to think about their safety. Nathan clicks his tongue at my rejection. Catherine says, I didn't understood the science, but I am still stuck on the fact that you stole the designs from Citradel. Do they know about this leak. I shrug, I don't know. I have been asking them for years. I didn't realize they would be so stingy with at least the designs. But they didn't comply. I didn't like the fact that they were hoarding it for themselves. I told you that I have contact earlier, he got it for me around 18 months ago. It took a lot of time and effort in this development. But I am quite happy with the result.

Blake asks, you had the designs this long. Why not share it with us. I reply, I was about to share it. But then they went ahead with the idea of tournament. And everyone accepted it. Do you think it would be wise to reveal it back then. They had their spies everywhere. It would jeopardies many things. So I figured to just keep it hidden a while longer. Besides, didn't I say already back on the pier that its still a prototype. I didn't want to give unfinished products, not the house or the bots. Franks says, but you said its functional. I reply, functional, but not flawless. There is a 33 % chance of it overheating and exploding. Imagine if it was in middle of crowd or a bot is flying over in the sky.

That made them wary of it. Actually it was a lie, it had only 10% percent chance of malfunctioning. But I was over estimating it so that Vanessa doesn't pick up what I was doing here. She already takes whatever I say with a grain of salt. I didn't want to make it look I was hiding it for something else. Vanessa says, I think I understand now. We are right now pressuring Citradel. We already blamed them and Ryes for Wyan. So we can't let them know this and make it worse. I nod. I think she is accepting it for now. Blake asks, that would be bad. But on the other hand, when they do join, won't they figure it out eventually.

I say, if you want to use my tech, you are going to have compromise something. Luther says, Blake, we can keep it under wraps and then make it look like we got their designs after they joined us. Right. He gesture to confirm it with Nathan. He says, well, sure. I mean, if we want to use our own tech in it, we need their help. So I suppose it wouldn't be hard to make it seem like they shared with us. I am glad they were quick on deciding this. I turn to Vanessa, you cool with this. If you are then I am ready to hand it over to you.

The ball was in her court now. People were waiting for her response. She looked at Tessa who also convinced it was good enough. She then replies, fine. Since its for our protection, a little white lie won't be a problem. I swear I could hear her grinding her teeth as she said that. But others were more glad about the tech being introduced to the island to notice that. Blake says, that’s settled then. But are you sure you are okay to give it away. I say, its fine. Vanessa makes a hard bargain. But she is right, IDF took a hit and they need to do more to assure people. Not just the people in the city right now, but others also who will join.

The IDF team got excited and even praised Vanessa for it. She had lingering doubts, I am sure. But she was smiling nonetheless with them. I add, however. I need one more help. Or rather two of them. Vanessa smiles instantly drops. I smile thinking she was panicking a little. I say, don't worry. Its more like a favor. Loan me your boyfriend and Sommers for time to time. Sommers raises his eyebrows, wait what. I explain, Heraknus are coming, no matter what Citradel do. So I need to fight Charles. And I need all the help I can get to prepare for it. I would like you to help with spars a couple of times in the next 3 weeks.

Sommers was caught off guard, but then he understood it, oh, I get it now. You want my help to prepare for Charles strength focused attacks. I am game. He turns to Vanessa who was still thinking about it. I added, Ned can copy Charles Kuret and help me with real sparing. Even if its not the real deal, it would be a lot of help. She asks, why not ask for Matt? I nod, I will. Even Cassandra too if she agrees. I rather not ask other of their people. Sommers alpha Kuret strength should be a good enough. And since we don't know where Matt and Neds alpha's is, I'll take both their help.

She thinks for a moment, you talked to Ned. I reply, not yet. But I will. I am just letting you know now. I might have hit a nerve. So I guess something is really going on between Ned and Vanessa. I haven't looked into this, but Blake said something about it in the morning. That could be a reasons why she is so angry with me. Its possibly she is redirecting at me. I was being rude to her now. But I didn't care. She wanted to put me in a bind in front of everyone. I can't let her think I am so easy.

She relents after a while, if he agrees to it. I got no problem. So a roundabout way to say she won't ask him. I guess that shows they did have a fight. I turn to Catherine and waited for her next. She shrieks, me too. I nod, it would help with visual training when others are busy. She replies after a second, okay. Sure. But it would be just a hollow Kuret body. I say, don't worry about it. I was talking to these two in the morning about it. Charles overdrive form might not be same. So it would be better to prepare for different possible forms he might take.

That impresses her, that’s a really good idea. In that case, I am in. The next time in contact with him, I can copy his Kuret appearance. Then I turn to alpha twins, I like your help too. But only its not awkward. You know, since you

just transferred here. Chealse says, I don't mind, but our Kuret isn't a strength type. Frank understood before her sister, I get it. You want to prepare for the endurance challenge. Charles may be fighting for 10 minutes, but it will be very intense. You want to prepare for continuous barrage of attack.

He is smatter than he looks. I say, your both can switch your attacks without exhausting individually. Chealse, oh that makes sense. Damn David. You have given it a lot of thought. I nod, I had some time to prepare for it. So how about it. They both look to each other and continuing with their gimmick, they give okay gesture to me with a smile. This was an unexpected opportunity to get people's corporation. I had just given up something to the island, so I didn't want to waste this opportunity to get some favors in. I could have done this later, but somehow it was satisfying to do it in front of Vanessa. I am very sure she thinks I was planning for this. But actually it was cover so that she doesn't notice the other thing.

I put that thought aside for now, thanks guys. Appreciate it. I turn to Deni, can you get me access to the stollen items then. I like to catalog it as soon as possible. Deni says, yeah. Sure. Ruther asks, how many of the bots do you have. I take a moment to recall, I have 250 of the small drones for both flying and underwater expeditions. 36 ground bots with different weapon configuration. And about 12 of the actual killer bots. Marina spats out, what. That’s not security, that’s a personal army. What the hell. I shot her a look, the number doesn't make lick of difference against strong Medrones. It may be crude to say, but anyone from the top 500 warriors from the tournament could crush dozens of them.

Blake says, when you said they aren't combat ready, you meant it would be only useful against regular people. I nod. Luther says, still, its good enough for the island. With those numbers we can cover every sector in the island. Marina says, its more than that. I say its almost enough to cover the island and the extended ocean border. I held my tongue here, hoping no one catches how close Marina guess was. Thankfully no one paid attention to it. People were enjoying that fact I had such impressive tech.

Vanessa asks, when can you send it over. I answer, I need around a week or so to configure it. Once its done, I will explain to your IDF tech team on how to operate it. She says, seems like a good plan. How will you sell the artifacts, out team said they would but difficult to deal with. I say, let me worry about it. Its the business I do with Humans. I figure you rather not know about it. She sighs, that’s true. Blake asks, Luther, where does this makes us with the expansion plan for security.

He thinks for a second, I like to say about a third of our plan. Why do you ask. He smiles, because this helped me find a solution for current dilemma with Citradel tech team stuck in Italy. I had an inkling what he was thinking about.. Blake says, why don't we show this technology to them. So far they thought we were behind Citradel in terms of technology. And we are in many domains. But this one is far more advance than Citradel.

Nathan jerks, genius. He turns to me, no offense. I shrug putting it off. He continues, since we don't want to force them or abduct them. We give them something they can't no to. Those nerds would no way be intrigued by this. He is right, those Medrones might believe siding with us gives us the best chance for tech development. Tina asks, but aren't those team more specialized for Kuret enrichment. Would they have the expertise to even understand this.

Luther says, even if they don't, its fine. They will relay it back to Citradel to others. I guarantee this would make them reconsider even more. Either way, if we show them the thing we lacked, the council members would be even more pressured. This could work Blake. Blake says, lets hope so. I was hoping to hear ideas from others to help me out here. I didn't expect something actually promising already. We should try it immediately.

I had a little concern and ask, why the hurry. You can wait them out. Blake shakes his nod, its like you told us before. Better to not give them time to think and retaliate. I get what he was trying to do. But he didn't have the information I got this morning. I say, just hold that thought. He is puzzled like others. I say, lets set aside the ART tech for a moment. Everyone prepared for it. Let me tell you something. I waited for Vanessa to give me the go ahead.

Then I tell, who hear know who is Selene, an alpha from house Reton in Citradel. People turned to the Citradel folks. June says, sounds familiar. Marina says, me too. I know I have seen her somewhere. Ah, geez its been so long I can't believe I would forget people. Chealse says, seriously guys. You should have visited the church more often. She is the priest there. That made them recall her. Marina says, yeah. That’s right. Catherine says, hold on. There is only one church Medrones visit and Selene isn't the priest.

Chealse says, she just recently became one after replacing the old one. Now the message Jack sent made sense. Ruther says, Citradel has a church? What religion are they from. Marina says, sort of all combined one. It took a lot of cultural stigma's and hurdles, but the previous priest made it under one convent. Hoping to make a new religion people can follow on Earth. Frank says, I think I have met her when she was studying under the priest.

I ask, how much sway does the church has in Citradel affairs. June says, I don't really know. I know that the priest in the council. So at least they have a vote on things. Marina says, why are you asking about it. I reveal the info now, I heard something concerning from my contact. There is a reason for Citradel sudden clamp down on closing the border. I don't know why, but Selene, using the Church name and is preaching hard to everyone that Blake, Marina and Charles are our hope. Chosen by gods due to their overdrives. So they should move here.

Blake says, she said that? Marina says, chosen by gods. What a load of crap. I say, I didn't know she was the priest. But now I know why her name came up. Council think she or someone in church might be in league with Ryes. And there is some friction due to this. Marina leans her head on the back of her hands on the able, never mix politics and religion. Always a bad combo. It was a very simplistic way of thinking, but she wasn't wrong. Vaneesa asks, is she working with Ryes. I say, no clue. I have seen the church before, but I didn't thought much of it back then. But this is the first time they are voicing their opinion this hard.

June asks, but Sam didn't tell me about it. I say, if you talked to him yesterday, then he wouldn't know about it. Selene wasn't making those claims until this morning. That’s why I couldn't come by during lunch. Blake says, what happened today exactly. I say, I don't know the whole story. Selene is gathering people to leave Citradel. I don't know if its mutually agreed or if she is forcing people. My contact said one of his friend was approached and it almost seemed like they weren't giving him much of choice. But then another friend joined on his own volition.

Luther says, this is not good. We don't want to have a internal conflict within Citradel. That will only divide them further. Blake says, it’s a problem. But we can't do anything about it, can we. I say, true. That’s why I rather not kick the hornets nest even more. You really want to go to Italy with this tech, fine. But you have to be careful what you say to them. Like Marina said, politics and religion is a dicey combination. Blake says, that does make things a little difficult. Tessa tells, there has to be a way to make convince Citradel, with or without this tech.

I guess I made things complicated for them even more. But its better they know it now, than later. Blake, Luther and Nathan were in deep discussion about this. I let them decide the best course of action. I am glad I don't have to take any decision with this. Marina asks, so your friend made contact with you. I nod, he did. Thank your friend for me. Turns out he was unsure what to do next. When your friend contacted him, he decided its time for him to leave.

Catherine asks, isn't Citradel on lockdown right now. I lean in closer, he still wants out. He said things are spiraling out of control there. He wasn't in trouble, but he didn't want to risk it. And I agreed. Vanessa asks, you are going to break him out of there. How? I say, we have a plan and a way out. I am sure they notice him missing. But it will be too late to do anything about it. Jess asks, is he coming here. I say, yeah. I am going to ask Blake to hide them here under different identity. I am not about to make them an enemy of Citradel.

Marina says, them. You have more people. I say, when arranging their transport, he told me he got married and has a one year old son. He kept it hidden for me all this time. He was probably thinking I would question his loyalties. Vanessa asks, and do you? I scoff, of course I do. He would naturally priorities his family now. I don't want him to live in constant doubt. Raising kids is already stressful enough, him spying would be just cruel. Marina asks, what did he tell his wife for leaving Citradel.

I say, I am not sure. Either he told her everything, or she is just following him. I didn't waste time asking about it. He doesn't feel safe for his family. That was enough for me to extract them out. Marina asks, how exactly? We had escapees before, but the security's gotten better later. I smile, I have visited Citradel exactly three times. By the last visit, I found a way to break in or break out. Its a way that is not secure. But once its used, the council will know about it and close it.

Marina asks, sewer systems. That’s the only place I can think of. I say, not quite. Lets not discuss about that, I rather not tell anyone about it until I get him and his family out of there. Marina says, I got it. But I would really like to know where me and Derek missed. I sensed her to be a little defensive about this. I will tell her about it after the meeting privately. June the asks nervously, ah, David. Is it possible for you to get another person out of Citradel. I turn to her puzzled. Then I remember she has boyfriend. I ask, Sam?

She nods hesitantly, I wasn't worried about him until now. But now Selene is causing a ruckus. So much that your friend is risking to leave Citradel. I don't think I want leave behind Sam. I get her concern but its not same. I tell, look. My friend is spying for me. He is worried about being caught. So I am getting him out of there. But I don't think you have to worry about Sam. Marina adds, Citradel council will not let harm anyone. No matter what happens. June says, I get that. But what happens that changes. Selene is a far more progressive priest if she is forcing people to join her side. Sam isn't religious, but what if he is roped into it.

Chealse says, you are making me worried about my girlfriend too. Frank says, don’t forget about our foster parents. Catherine says, guys. I get you all are worried. But its not so dire that they need to be pulled out. Vanessa says, she is right. We can't just irresponsibly extract people from Citradel. It would make things worse for us. June says, I know what I am asking. But you can't guarantee their safety there, can you? Tessa asks, if you are so worried, how about asking for help. Maybe some friends or someone can to protect them.

June says, I don't have many friends left in Citradel, certainly not close enough to ask them this. Frank says, I know some people who can help, but I can't just involve them like this. Not until there is direct threat. Chealse says, a lot of the warriors have moved here, so we don't have many dependable people left back in Citradel. Jenna isn't a fighter. She is a simple fashion designer. She has no one to protect her too. As I listen to them I was thinking a way to help them ease their concern.

Vanessa was right about the repercussions. I can't just pull these people out of Citradel without a clear threat. But on the other hand they won't be able to completely let go their worries. At least not without some sort of back up plan. I say to them, guys. Listen. I don't want to make a real enemy of Citradel. So lets do this instead. The plan for him to leave is going to take some time. 5 days. That’s how long he has left in Citradel. His absence would be noticed, but no one will no he was a spy. There are many loose ends to tie.

Vanessa says, so they have the same time to decide. I nod, like I told earlier, the escape route is a one time thing. Even if you ask me to help them out, my first priority is to get 3 people out. So the original plan will not change. That being said, I may be able to allow others to join them. June gets anxious, you are going to help. I say, hold on. You are skipping a lot steps before that. First talk to your people. Ask them if they are really okay to leave Citradel like this.

Tessa says, they will need some time to think about it anyways. Catherine sympathizes, its not easy to leave the place you lived for so long suddenly. June and other didn't thought about that until we pointed it out. I say, at the very least tell them to be wary of the situation. Their consent is paramount for me to trust that they are serious. Vanessa says, if possible, ask them to first contact the council. They are not allowing people to leave, but it would be better to know if Citradel is seriously complying or not. Makes it easier for us to believe Citradel is using any excuse to keep people. And easy for us to help you out.

She brought up a good idea. Chealse says, yeah. I guess we should try the correct way first. I say, there are no wrong ways. Its just about knowing which way will have less consequences. My words resonated with them now. I think

this was the right call. Give them time to think about it. Vanessa says, I want to help you all too. If can convince Blake and Luther about the real dangers, we will support you guys. June says to me, thanks. I know I am making an unreasonable request. I should talk to Sam first. I'll call him immediately. She got up and walks to the corner of the room.

Chealse follows suit, might as well confirm with our people too. Frank nods and they both find a separate corner of the room. Marina gets up as well, I don't think my friend will go for this, but no harm in checking. She joins the others on their phones. I turn to Blake and Luther who were listening to us. I turn my eyes to him. He says, yeah, I heard. Luther says, if there is a legitimate reason, we will get them out. But until then we aren't going to provoke Citradel in such direct manner.

I say, I am just the middle guy here. What about your negotiation tactics. Nathan tells, we will use your tech as a incentive. Despite the obvious dangers, its still the best play. Blake says, its true this will make Citradel more angry, but it’s a risk we have to take. Besides, he smiles, they are focused on you more than me right now. I only blamed them on a probable suspicion, but you are openly attacking them. These bastards. They are banking on the hope that the council is going to be focus with my external efforts to undermine them, rather than the internal conflicts. I turn to others who were probably on the same page as him.

I sigh, you are going to use my sudden popularity as part of your game. Nathan says, of course. Why else we asked you to tell others. He isn't even making an effort to look guilty about it. Catherine says, don't worry David. We got your back if anything happens. Vanessa smiles, you have to know you are our city's favorite poster boy right now. I bet even the other communities would soon be on your side. Tina says, they are beginning to. We send teams to them earlier to asses the damage, and its being slowly replaced in your favor.

I was unconfirmable before, but now feel the weight of it even more. Others make a light banter seeing me so cornered. I think I heard Deni saying I am being shy about it. Someone said I am pussy. And I heard one particular girl whispering I faking this whole embarrassment attitude. I need to do something about her. Ruther asks, hey David. I got to know something. You said you had a way to get in and out of Citradel undetected. Does that mean you have something for this island too. Sommers says, no way man. Unlike Citradel, we don't have to worry about Humans. We got Kuritine barriers and maned patrols.

I gave them a slick smile, not confirming anything. Sommers chokes a little, nah, you are bluffing. I shrug. Deni gets excited, so you don't know how to do it. I didn't respond. Ruther says, you do know. Tell us. Now I gave them a wicked smile, wanting to exact a small revenge for messing with me. Vanessa tells, he is just messing with us. This place is secure, no one will ever escape or break in. I respond, its good to have such confidence. She glares at me, trying to figure me out.

Tessa says, I am not sure about it. We are soon going to use his tech. So even if he didn't have a way, he might have one now. She ogling me with a smile, but I didn't take the bait. I tell, maybe you are right. But who knows, one day we might get to see if its true or not. People gave me questionable looks, and I am enjoying each of them.

David (Chapter 93)

Friday, February 6, 2026 13:11

I yell, this is not working, Blake. He answers, then we do this until we get it working. Its been already 30 minutes me hanging upside down from a tree. The ropes on my legs and arms strapped on me were stopping me from balancing from the swaying. Blake launches another Kuret attack, I could vaguely see glimmers of the Kuret behind my back. But this position makes it impossible for me to predict the moment of impact. I will my Kuret towards the back, hoping it will shield me this time. But I misjudged the timing and could only protect my upper back.

Pain surges through me from my tail bone and I grunt aloud. Blake says, its still not strong enough. Stop trying to predict it and focus on gathering your Kuret. Easier said than done. I sway in the air while focusing on strengthening my wild Kuret. This is what Blake planned to train me this morning. We first sparred on the ground. But I was using my hands to block Blakes Kuret blasts every time. Then we decided to tie my hands behind my back. But turns out my brain is hard wired to predict his attack from the glimmers, I was making Kuret shields on my body before he even threw his Kuret. After an hour he realized I needed to be in even more unpredictable situation.

And that's where I am right now. Hanging from the top of the tree with a rope tied to my legs. Initial few attacks I could parry, but then he started to swing me around the tree, up and down, side to side. This makes it impossible for me to plan anything ahead. Many a times I relexify tried to free my arms to block the attacks. Its hard to change my habit of using physical movements and rely on just Kuret alone. Blake approaches me from the ground, any changes to your Kuret.

My sweat flows backwards to my hair while I gasp for some air, not really. Its really frustrating. I feel like it's just there, but the moment I think I get it, it slips away. My arms are sore, falling above my head. I have been trying for more than an hour, the most I achieved was to keep my wild Kuret around my body. But stabilizing it instinctively is proving to be really difficult. Blake says, we won't see any improvements in the first day. It will take a lot of practice. We will keep at it in the first few days. You should soon begin to control your Kuret whenever needed and save your stamina for physical movement.

That's the new goal. I focus my Kuret to cut the rope around my legs. But it didn't break. I sigh when I forget it was carbon steel. If it were a normal rope I would have broken free already. I say, a little help. Blake says, you done? I reply, not really. But its 8:30 now. You have to get back to work. He pulls out his phone from his jacket pocket, its time already huh. Didn't realize we have been at it this long. He then fly's over to top of the tree to unknot the rope. Once it loosens, I fall to ground. But my Kuret cushions the fall with a burst of impulse thrusting me up and land softly on my feet.

My breathing is ragged and the sudden blood rush away from my head makes slightly woozy. But by now I had gotten used to this many times, so I wait for Blake to return and untie my arms. He lands behind me and works on the rope. I ask, you are going to send some people to Italy. He nods, last night we discussed our options. Its not my first preference, but sending Nathan and Frank seems the logical choice. They can speak their language and they both can handle the Citradel warriors.

I didn't like it either. We have many eyes on him inside the city. Sending Nathan alone and unsupervised makes me anxious. But we can't afford to send more people and antagonize them. This is a scientific discussion now, instead of a diplomatic effort. Blake says, I would have liked someone from IDF to tag along him. I says, but they are needed to find all the people who have smuggled items. I understand. Just make sure to educate Nathan what will happen if he causes any trouble for us.

He smirks while releasing the restraints. My arms ache a little from being bounded for so long. He says, I will. Jess asked if she could go with him, hoping she could reign him in. I smile at that thought. He continues, but I want to know if Nathan can be trusted enough for this. He was more or less well behaved during the interrogations. So I need to know if he is really on board with this. I sense a little more to this than just caution. I ask, you don't think that he is the one behind Ryes and the stolen drugs. Because that's.

He says, I know. Its impossible. That's why I trust him enough to send alone. The worst case would be picking someone who is backstabbing us. That's not I am worrying about. Its just that Frank is with him. I just hope he doesn't cause a scene by making use of Frank. I can imagine Nathan trying to win them over by explaining the recent transfers of Citradel warriors. I answer, he is smart. He knows what cards to show and how. He won't use that card unless needed.

Blake says, lets hope so because I can't clean up his mess out there. I already knew what he wanted as a backup, you plan to send a shadow to keep an eye on him. Aren't you. He says, don't read my mind dude. Not cool. But he chuckles at me, yeah I will. I have asked to not reveal themselves under any circumstances, unless someone is in mortal danger. We have a lot riding on this, can't have Nathan screwing up in any way. I add, it's a good idea. I like to see their individual capability too.

After then we started to walk out of the forest, back to Blakes car. I pull out the towel from the seat and rub my face. I had a workout this morning, and with this sort of training, I was drenched in sweat from head to toe. Blake asks, I haven't asked this before because I didn't want to stress you out. But tonight's your meeting with Drew, isn't it. I nod, it is. We spoke yesterday and made plans to meet at my place at 8. He asks, did she tell what this treatment is. Because I can't wrap my head around it.

I say, I don't think its anything surgical, but she said its radical and experimental. Not much to go on from there. Blake asks, will there be risks. I didn't want to sugarcoat the truth, perhaps. Its experimental and so its not tested. But I have faith in Drew. You heard her last time, she just warned me ahead so that I can prepare myself better. Blake says, you know, you may not need it to do this. You said you haven't had a panic attack in days. Maybe your symptoms are subsiding.

I smile at that optimism. Its true I haven't had an episode for a while now, but it doesn't mean I am in the clear. I answer, it's not a physical trauma that can be healed visibly. I am psychically better now. But I am not there yet. I can feel it. Its not something I can put into words. He makes an anxious face trying to understand my plight. He says, I suppose if Drew said it would be dangerous to leave you untreated, then its really needed. I toss the towel back inside to the seat. I add, you saw me crashing out during the interview, and how I am behaving towards Vanessa. This something I need to do make sure I don't loose it again.

He raises his eyebrows, speaking of her. Vanessa is furious with you. I lean towards the car with a droopy shoulder. Ever since the tournament I have wondered how I can make her understand. I thought I have been sparing her feelings by not talking about Wagner. But now its gotten to a point where whenever I talk to her, we are confronting each other for any reason. I regret my decision by keeping her in the dark, but it was for her own good. Or so I believed since it is now costing our relationship.

I sigh, I know its gotten bad. Yesterday she tried to put the screws in me. I thought she was being salty, but she is trying anything to get back at me. I finally got the chance to see her questioning Elina. Blake says, it was more like a mission to expose you. She never liked the plan to hiding your involvement. But even I never thought she would go that far. We can't keep her making waves like this. He sighs, not at this critical time. I felt the same. I don't blame Vanessa for her actions, but she is isn't going to stop. She will keep pushing me until I break with another episode.

I say, I don't plan to do nothing. Blake crosses his arms, so you will tell her about Wagner. My instincts kicked in before I even a rational thought, no. I mean, yes. Maybe. I was confusing myself now. I can't sort out my thoughts about that. I ask, what if she doesn't believe me. She already hates me, imagine how worse it might get if I tell her the truth. Blake says, few days back I casually mentioned Wagner, and she looked like she was about to punch me. Getting through to her will not be easy. She is too stubborn. And like you said, maybe she has replaced her memories with Wagner. I can't think of a way to break this to her.

After thinking about it for a moment I say, Its my mess. I will tell Vanessa what she needs to know. He leans in closer nervously, what does that entail. I say, not sure. But I need to start being honest with her now. Its not fair to her. I am being angry at her when she retaliates due to my lies. I have been postponing it for a while. But it can't keep going on like this. Blake nods, okay then. Lets at least tell her together then. I raise my hand, no. I alone to tell her. She would just get mad at you too for no reason. He asks, but I can help you. Aside from you, only I personally know about Wagner's hidden side. She will believe it more when we both explain it.

I answer, maybe. But I rather it come from me. I am okay with taking the blame of hiding things from her. You would just get caught up in it in for no reason. He replies, are you sure. I answer, I am. I may not know how much I will tell her, but I am sure I want to do this alone. After a tense silence he says, all right. But at least me be there tonight when Drew comes to your home. I wasn't in favor of it, I really didn't want to be distracted with my well being. But he was giving a stare that said he wasn't going to back down from this. I ask, I am guessing Marina will be there too.

He nods, she will be. She started her work today early so she can finish early. Same reason why she didn't show up now. She is surveying the sector 2 middle zone. She said she will be off by 7. I wished they wouldn't be bothered by this so much. But that's the reason I was in a situation with Catherine and now with Vanessa. I can't keep pushing people away from my private stuff anymore. I pull the door, fine. You guys already know so much about me now. Doesn't make any sense to keep things separate. He nods will taking the driver seat, good. You are learning about sharing stuff now.

Maybe. He turns on the engine and we head back inside the city. We chat a few things about the Citradel current affairs. No new development about the search for Ryes or the stirs of conflict from the church. Blake said he doesn't like being involved in their religion. Overdrive is purely based on luck, not a sign from some higher power. But who are we to stop people from believing anything. I kept assuring Blake to not be worried about it. Selene might be just using their names as a way to gather people and pressure the council.

He relented in the end since there is nothing we can do about it. Though, its curious that even though Blake blamed Ryes, and in extension Citradel, and yet there are people backing us there. I used to believe Citradel people are united very strongly. Blake says, it's bound to happen. People there are slowly realizing the benefits of moving here. Heraknus will be here, many of their warriors are already here. I reply, that would be the obvious thing. He asks, then what's not the obvious thing.

I reply, not really sure. I mean, we wanted this kind of thing to happen. Force Citradel and make them move here. However, the religion getting involved so blatantly is suspicious. Blake says, you mean the timing of it all. I say, they could have done this before Ryes accused me. And yet the schism is happening when we are gunning for them from multiple fronts. A second later Blake hits the brake in front of my house. He asks, I also find it pretty convenient. I got a message from Derek early in the morning that the council are trying to appease the priest and their followers.

I ask, how's that working for them. He shrugs, no idea. I get out of the car, let me ask Jack to dig around. He still has some time left. He thinks about for a moment then says, about their new identities. I have asked Catherine to create them. She said it will be done by the time they arrive. I should thank her later for this. I close the door, thanks. This will make him less apprehensive about leaving Citradel. He nods, they deserve it. I grab my stuff from the back, see you later tonight. He waves and drives off.

I get back inside and take a shower to clean up the sweat and dirt I was covered in. After that, I reviewed todays training session. I have been trying to stabilize my Kuret since yesterday. I spent hours, before the dinner meeting and after that last night till 2 AM. I have exhausted all my mental efforts, and yet I couldn't do achieve that same form during the match with Charles. I don't know what's stopping me. What condition's has to be met to get that form.

I continued my workout trying my Kuret form again. I decided best not to focus on the that and work on honing my Kuret control instead. Morning's restrictive training helped me a bit to gather Kuret without physical

movement. I did different Kuret techniques Blake taught me this morning. Best to cement the basics down when I remember them clearly. Its hard to understand what Blake said about gathering Kuret, so instead of teaching me the process, he showed me the end results of the Kuret techniques. I had to figure out on how to make them myself.

I sat down drenched in sweat in my home gym room. M says, boss, your calories levels are too low. I said, I already had meal hours ago. M replies, the mental exertion has burned away calories from lunch. I lean to the wall with a sigh. I have never done a workout like this, using Kuret without using any muscles. I have been replenishing with electrolytes all day, and yet I am so exhausted. I expected this type of training to be different, but I didn't realize it would be this arduous. I say, M, create a new nutrition plan based on today's workout. Focus more on replenishing blood flow and sleep for brain restoration.

M says, calculating the changes. Increasing glucose consumption. Done. My body doesn't ache, and yet repeating making my Kuret gather around my skin makes it feel its aching. This is new territory for me now. Instead of my body effecting Kuret, its Kuret effecting my body. But I still laugh in spite of this hurdle. This just means when I control this Kuret nature, I will be strong enough to handle whatever Charles throws at me. M says, boss, this is a reminder for your meeting.

I close my eyes and my emotion that was elevated takes massive dip down. I have been distracting myself from this. I didn't want to face certain people. Drew was right to call out saying I was not showing kindness by keeping things from people. I can't keep them in the dark anymore. I don't know if it will help me untie this knot in my heart, but I know I can't keep it in anymore. Whatever happens, I can't chicken out now. I thought my resolve wouldn't waver again. But as I cleaned up to visit them, my body felt heavy. Like my own Kuret was resisting it.

What will Vanessa think of me. What will they all. I wished I could go back to training like I did the whole today, focus on what I can control. That’s much easier than what I am about to do. M says, boss. Its time. Shall I send the message. Its 6 right now, I suppose there is no backing away from this. My heart feels like is about to come out from my throat. I just gave a slight nod, hoping I don't have to say it. M says, message sent. You should leave now to avoid being late when returning.

It must be nice to have decision running purely on logic and probabilities. No guilt, no remorse. I take the car out of the driveway and head to Vanessa's house. In 15 minutes I was standing at her doorstop. Even though I messaged ahead, I couldn't ring the doorbell. I kept pacing a little, thinking of excuses to get out of this. Every time I muster up with determination, I fell back in the last moment. Its so pathetic that its almost comical. I just hope the neighbors don't see me stumbling like this.

A few minutes later the door opens on its own. My heart beats a little louder. Siera comes out, just how long were you planning to stay out. She was alone in the house right now. I immediately felt embarrassed knowing she saw me hesitating for so long, sorry. She opens the door for me to enter. I say, thanks for making time. She closes the door behind me and we walk into her living room. She was in a workout clothes, its all right. I just came back from a run. I look around the house, it's been a while since I have been here. They have moved around some furniture's and stuff.

She says, what's this meeting about David. Its a little suspicious. I give her a nervous smile, does it feel that way to you. She says, your messaged said to meet me and Vanessa at our home. You are a celebrity now, so yeah. Its a little odd you coming to us at an odd time. I don't know what Vanessa has told her. She wasn't here when Melinda talked about Wagner. Vanessa could have told her everything. But it doesn't matter. Since I came here to hash out everything.

I reveal, Its been a week since the tournament, I owe people answers. That’s why I am here. She raises her eyebrows, answers, huh. I see. But why tell me. Why not just Vanessa. I answer, I will explain once everyone are here. She takes a second to think, you called someone else too? I nod while we both take our seats. She puts on a jacket and offers me a water. I decline, thanks but I just drank like 5 liters whole day. I feel like I might burst any second.

She smiles, is that right. So this is really true, Blake and Marina are training you. I nod, it was just Blake today. But yeah. She says, incredible. I had to agree with her, they are key to mastering my Kuret. I need all the advantage I need right now. She says, Vanessa told me you enlisted others too. Since she brought it herself, I hesitantly ask, what else she told you. She turns a little confused, honestly, she's been working late this week. I don't get enough time with her to chat. Its probably going to stay that for a while until the mess with Citradel blows over.

So its pretty good guess that Vanessa hasn't told her about us. I don't know how to feel, should I be glad or be more nervous. I say, its my fault. I selfishly decided to attack Citradel. She waves her hand, no, its not. I don't know everything, but Vanessa said what you did was justified. She suddenly chuckles, only you could go after them like this. Let me ask since you are here, are you really stealing from them.

I smile, as of today, I have extracted 23 percent of their mineral deposits all over world. She shakes her head amused, its amazing. But they must be retaliating. I reply, they are. I have made contingencies and for the most part its been working. She asks, they must be stealing them back from you. I nod, I have lost around 5 percent, so yeah. However, I am not losing here. Not really. She thinks for a moment, so I let her. She snaps her fingers with a smirk, I get it. I heard from some officers that we will have more than necessary resources. Anything you steal now, it’s a bonus. But its their loss. You must be giving those away so that no one gets it.

She got it right, I clap my hand to applaud her. I say, you guessed right. I have split of the shipment of the mined ores and minerals. Each of them taking different routes. But more importantly, I added a failsafe. In case the shipment gets compromised, only one of two things will happen. Either I report the stolen items at the borders and customs will seize it. Well, at least those that get caught. Or more easily, just blow it up. She jerks at my nonchalant comment. She scoffs, you blow up the shipment.

I shrug, the blown up shipment attracts enough attention from the agencies to cause panic for Citradel council. Sure, its not a fool proof solution. If there is some decent Kuret users, they could abscond with the stuff no matter what I do to stop them. In fact, I suspect they already were able to secretly steal back around 3 of 10 shipments daily. Its an acceptable loss. She says, damn David. You are playing a very dangerous game. She was equally impressed and horrified. I reply, I know. But they didn't tell me about Ryes and probably never wanted me to find about it ever. I needed to teach some sense into them. Not to mess with me again.

I got back some of my confidence when I re affirm my ideals. Enough that made Siera look at me in admiration. She says, you have changed. You are you, but still different. She has no idea how much of that was so true. She says, the old you would have at least attempted to deny Ryes claims. Instead you just lied on top of it. I shift a little uneasy in my sofa. Siera wasn't there for most of the things that went down. Or she was there, but wouldn't know the truth. She figured out my confusion, Vanessa told me. And even before that I sort of figured out your plan.

Its strange. Vanessa told her this, but not about our fight. I ask, did you tell anyone. She replies, don't worry. Few people asked me about it, but I since I wasn't there I didn't have to hide much. She then becomes a little tense, however, based on what Vanessa has told me, seems you weren't planning for this though. I sigh, I was hoping to just create doubt and stall until Ryes was found. Not this. This isn't how I imagined I get famous. Its all lies. And even when I am innocent, I feel its undeserved.

She takes a suspenseful silence trying to come with words. I don't think I will be okay with any excuse or reasoning. No matter how true they are. I say, I am so much conflicted about it. I don't make public appearances alone right now, because then I would just feel guilty. She nods, I can only imagine what you are going through. I can't say anything to comfort you. But if there's anything you need, let me know. I am so glad she was not trying to convince me. I reply, in that case. I want a small favor. I am going to reveal things that will make Vanessa mad. I might be unfair to ask this, but try to remain impartial until the end.

She is clearly confused at my strange request. Nonetheless, she regains her composure, all right. I can do that. I feel a little better in preparing her beforehand. We talk for few minutes about mundane activities. Since we couldn't really talk about my stuff, I asked hers. She was enjoying the more quite life now with just teaching kids about self defense. Then the door bell rang. So its time. I grab my collar and loose it a little, hoping to catch more air. Siera opens up the door to Cassandra and Vanessa. They must have met up before coming together. My throat felt dry with anticipation.

Cassandra asks, hey Siera. Long time no see. Siera asks surprised, Cass. You were invited too. I haven't seen Cass almost a week. And I have been avoiding her the most right now. Last I heard she was laying low because she thought she was the leak. Vanessa steps in, I met her in the trolley. So what's this about. Why did he. She stops when she catches me sitting in her living room. Like a clueless guy, I wave my hand, thanks for meeting with me guys. I didn't know what Vanessa would have done when I sent her the message. She could have just easily blown it off.

Vanessa remained quiet, maybe trying to rien in her frustration on being ambushed like this. Cass says, David. You are already here. I say, yeah. I didn't think Vanessa would open the doors for me if she was already here. I came in earlier a little while to avoid that. I wasn't holding back anymore. I didn't want to beat around the bush and be delicate about it anymore. Otherwise I would just waver my resolve. Others were confused by my attitude. Vanessa just crosses her arms not giving me any rebuttal.

Cass looks around us, what is going on. I say, not many people know this. But Vanessa's has been mad at me for a while. I am here to clear it up for once and for all. I blurted out before I get embarrassed or cower in fear. This made even Vanessa puzzled. Siera asks Vanessa, you had a fight. With David too. I guess she was talking about Ned now. So that means she is taking a lot of anger at me. Cass is so confused and asks, why. And why did you call me here then.

I say, lets take a seat before I explain. Its going to take a little bit of time. Vanessa is suspicious of my intension. I guess its nothing new for her. Cass and Siera leave her behind and take the chairs beside me. Vanessa was alone standing and with our eyes staring hard. She finally relented and sat opposite to me, throwing daggers at me with her eyes. In the middle of our silent confrontation, Cass interjects. She says, David. I need to tell you something first. I turn my gaze to her. She was puzzled earlier but now I see guilt. She says, you have been avoiding me. And I know why. Why did you ask to me here now.

I answer, it wasn't how I wanted to play it out. But its what had to happen. Siera asks, what do you mean by this, Cass? Cass responds, didn't Vanessa tell you about that. Someone used me to get to David. Siera didn't the whole story. Vanessa breaks her heavy expression and says, only Cass knew where they lived before meeting us. Siera than clicks her tongue putting it together, ah right. That’s true. But then how. Cass butts in, because I have blabbed about it. She tucks in her hair behind her ears, I never thought someone would dig up our past. I have been asking around people I talked to ever since Ryes mentioned it. But its been so long that I can't remember everyone.

Its was the right time to quell her guilt. I tell her, you don't have to take this on yourself. She rebukes, but I messed up. We agreed not to talk to people about our past. I say, its fine. Really. She says, how are you calm about it. Ryes found about. I cut her off, they are safe. You don't have to worry about them anymore. She blinks at me confused, but I hear he has pictures of them too. Surely he knows about them. I reply, I don't know if knows about them or not. I sent them a message a while ago to relocate just as a precaution.

She is surprised to realize I was in contact with them. She asks, wait. You know where they are. I say, no. I had a single one time emergency way to contact them. And since I didn't know what Ryes or whoever is behind this would do with this information, I wanted to avoid contacting you. At least until I was assured they were safe. She asks bewildered. I explain, I can't say for sure how he found out about other stuff, but I am hundred percent sure the Greenfield info came from you. This makes her anxious.

☐Vanessa tried to speak something, but my sharp gaze stop her. I continue, I haven't told anyone about it. So it had to be you. By extension, someone around you blabbed to Ryes. So I had to wai
before I approached you. I apologies for not coming to you sooner. I didn't want to risk their safety in any way. Not even a text message was safe. She shakes her head, don't be. I was a little frustrated for a little while, but then Matt made the same argument as you. We figured you were trying to find out who it was without us. I am glad she understood my intent.

Siera asks, since you are talking to her now, I assume your human parents are fine. I say, they are. I got a message last night. I could have told you this morning, Cass. But I wanted another day before I tell you. The arrangement I made for them was in haste and needed some more time as a precaution. By now, their new identities should be setup properly. So no matter how it was leaked, its safe for me to talk to you about them. This relieved a lot of the tension she was carrying on her. She says, thank god. I have been worrying so much about them. You know, Matt and I have been combing our house and office for bugs every night.

I smile a little picturing them looking for signs of sabotage. I say, sorry for the trouble. I didn't want to influence you in anyway in case someone was still watching you. She grabs her hair back her head with both hands, I am so relieved. I have been a mess thinking I got them in trouble. She leans in back to her couch. A big weight lifted off from her shoulder. Siera says, where are they right now. I reply, someplace safe. But this time I am keeping that information close to me. Cass raise her arms to me, I rather not know about it. Safer for everyone.

Vanessa didn't feel the same, shocker. You hiding things from us. Well, at least you are being open about it. This garner two pairs of confused eyes at her. I guess Vanessa is also not hiding her displeasure with me anymore. Siera asks, just what is going on with you. I thought it was about Ned. But what did David do to you. Cass also joined in, David, what is going on with you two. Vanessa seemed like she wasn't going to offer any help. Its not surprising since I came to her in person.

I lean in back and close my eyes. This is it, no more stalling. I clutch the chair ends tightly with my fingers. Cass asks, what's happening. You are acting very strange. I nervous smile appears in the corner of my mouth, that’s because I have been in therapy for months. Then followed few seconds of silence. I open my eyes to see confused faces gawking at me. Vanessa uncrosses her arms and gives a suspicious look. My grip on the sofa tightens as I continue, I have been diagnosed with PTSD and currently undergoing treatment for it.

Cass asks bamboozled, are you serious right now. I answer, ever since I got my memories, the floodgates were opened to all the horrors of Medrine. Its been causing me a lot of mental issues. Siera asks, that was almost a year ago. You had PTSD since then ? I thought it was scary to reveal this to Blake and Marina. But its so much worse with them right now. Vanessa asks with wide eyes, that can't be true. You have been fighting in the tournament for four months.

I shake my head a little depressed about it, I have been hiding it. Or more accurately, I thought I had moved on. Drew and I thought I was mentally stable to participate in it. And I was okay, all the way till the end of tournament. But then everything came crashing down from then. Siera asks, Drew. That is your therapist? Vanessa scoffs, stop messing around. There is no doctor named Drew in the trauma counselling department. Her skepticism was expected. I answer, she isn't your typical doctor. She isn't listed as a doctor. She was trained in human psychology, stuff not related to Kuret. Things I needed from her can't be gotten from regular doctors.

Cass leans forward shocked, I don't understand. What caused you PTSD. And why the hell did you not tell us about it. Vanessa asks, this is hard to believe. Are you just making excuses for your behavior. Siera reprimands her, Vanessa, stop it. Vanessa gets mad, don't tell me you are buying into this. I cut her off, don't just assume I am lying. Few people already know about it. She turns to me, what. Who. I had to start from the beginning, you saw me passing out while I was carried out of the coliseum. It wasn’t from exhaustion. I was having a panic attack.

Vanessa recalls the moment from a week ago. Her expression changes to confusion, what do you mean you had a panic attack. I thought I was over it, but I still felt a sting from the weakness of that moment. I sigh, it's exactly what I said. Blake and Marrina carried me out before people saw me in a much more pathetic state. I had to tell them to get me help from Drew. They got in contact with her later. And the next day Catherine spied on me meeting with Drew and found out as well.

Cass jerks, Catherine knows about this too. My god. David, what the hell. Her outburst was mixed with anger and concern. Vanessa exclaims in anger, they knew and yet told know one about it. At least she didn't think I was lying. I could keep my hands on my knees to stop my legs from shaking too much. I tell them, its already bad enough that I am suffering from such a weird PTSD. I didn't want people see me like this. I look away for a second, no that’s not totally true. I didn't want you all to see me at this ridiculous state.

I know it’s the right thing to tell them the truth, but its so damn frustrating. The mortification I felt was unlike anything before. Siera asks, David. I am sorry you were going through so much. I had no idea. Cass says, I can't believe it. He turns to Vanessa, you didn't know about this. Vanessa shakes her head quietly, this is the first time hearing. She turns to me, if this is true, why keep it a secret. We have so many people going through traumas. I myself had to adjust a little bit after the incident with the Valley war.

I tilt my back to stare at the ceiling, if only it were so easy. I face them again, I have been trying to change. Get better. But its not easy to change certain habits. Especially with my memories coming back. I get a little annoyed at myself, it wasn't easy to keep this from you. I turn to Cass, I should have told you before. You were there for me in the beginning. I owe you that. But its was way more complicated. Cass is visibly concerned for me, why did you feel hiding from it from me. I sigh revealing my biggest shame, same reason I asked not tell anyone about my situation in Greenville. You visited me mostly in the hospital rooms. I didn't want you think even less of me, again after all this time.

Cass becomes enraged, come on, David. Do you really believed I would held that against you. I had no words to make her believe it wasn't the case. I really didn't want my oldest friends to know about my issues. Siera asks, I have seen you make some rash moves and even behave strangely at times during the tournament. Is it because of. Her words trail off. I reluctantly nod, I am not making any excuse of my behavior, but yeah. It was a big part of it. Vanessa has been silently taking all of it in. I am sure she must have been trying to recall all the times I was being cagy about things. Particularly about one person.

Cass becomes despondent, I don't like this David. You shouldn't have kept it from us. Not from me at least. I wouldn't have judged you. She eyes towards Vanessa, not like others. Vanessa asks, what does that mean. She replies, nothing. I am just saying it wasn't something he needed to be ashamed off. She turns to me, I could have helped you. This is what I was avoiding all this time, the pity and judging from others. I reply, I told you. I wanted to get better. Therapy was the only option.

Siera asks, I get it would attract some doubt from others. But still, you risked an awful lot during the tournament. Cass chips in, yeah. You said you had a panic attack. How many times did you get one. I wasn't going to divulge my weakest moments, a few times. I had it under control. I would have never joined if there was an issue. Drew made sure of it. Vanessa says, you said you got one when we were with Charles and Kafar. But why would that. She halts when she pieces it together.

I didn't want to reveal the next part of my redemption plea. This is the most personal stuff sworn not to be revealed. I say, there are certain things or names that triggers me. If I am careful about it, I can manage it. But I was caught off guard when I heard Wagners name from the last person I thought possible. Vanessa eyes sharpen at me. Cass asks, ah, yeah. You sounded different after that. Siera says, you said it in the interview that you got carried away in the moment. I grit my teeth, it was half truth.

Vanessa blurts out in anger, you lied about knowing Wagner. Didn't you ? She gets a little agitated, you asked about his fighting style to Charles. Tell me how you know him. I knew it was just time until she becomes hot headed. Like me, she also gets triggered in a different way whenever its about him. Cass asks, wait. Why does mentioning him caused a panic attack. Siera asks, how did you know him. My arms felt it weighed ton when I rummage in my jacket pocket and pull out an item.

I say, I know him. I know a lot of influential people back in Medrine. Because, I toss the item straight at Vanessa. She reflexes catches it with one hand and opens it confused, what is this. Her palm opens and reveals my shadow ring.

Vanessa (Chapter 94)

Saturday, February 14, 2026 15:30

I was annoyed that David backed down so easily yesterday. I have never been this petty in my life before. I could have asked him outside the dinner meeting. But I wanted to see David struggle in front of others when I asked for his bots. I never anticipated he gave it up so easily. He even went as far to explain the tech. It had to be a trick. But I couldn't understand what it was. Even if it was in exchange of those stolen artifacts, the tech must have been something he worked on for quite some time. And it concluded in what I wanted.

It felt strange, but I had to move on to other things. I had work to do today. I didn't want to face David again, because even though I got what I wanted from him, it feels I lost somehow. Then he messages me out of the blue around 5 and asked to meet him at my home. I wanted to ignore it, like I have been ignoring Ned. But this is first time he wanted to meet me somewhere not work related. I thought I had resolved myself to not listen to any of his manipulation tactics. No matter what has happened, he has lied to me about Wagner. He can't be trusted.

But curiosity got the better of me. I took off early from the officers building and head back home. On route I met Cass who was also coming to my place. This made me very nervous, what did he want with the two of us. I went in home early to first make sure Siera doesn't let him without giving us the reason. But he beat me to it. It seems he gave me a time, but arrive much earlier. When he confirmed it so openly, I was so shocked that my mind went blank for a few second.

He wasn't hiding it anymore. I felt pressured by others gazes, but I maintained my composure. Whatever David's game was, I wasn't going to be manipulated so easily again. I knew he didn't trust me, so I shouldn't believe anything he said. Then he drops them bombshell about his therapy. I can't believe he hid something so big this long. I reminded myself he is good at making convenient excuses. Maybe it was just some causal consultancies he had. But as he talked, my emotions turn to turmoil.

I wanted to believe he was lying his ass off. But he was visibly troubled by this. At times it felt he was so ashamed of himself that I almost pitied him. But then I would mentally slap myself. No, this is another justifications for his actions. If he trusted me, if he cared for me, he wouldn't kept it from me. I was battling myself, trying to figure out what to do with this information. But one thing was sure, I couldn't bring myself to forgive him. He said lying was his habit and wanted to change it. But I can't believe it.

There is nothing that can convince me of this. Then he threw a small object towards me. I caught it mid air and open my palm. It was a ring with a small engravings on it. It had a small gem rock in the center. I didn't understand how this explained all the secrecy. David didn't offer any explanation to it too. I just stared at the ring. Then suddenly I remember vagally seeing this small rock somewhere too. As I tried to recall it, Siera beside me snaps in confusion, David. Where did you find this. He voice shrouded in ominous shock.

He answers, I didn't find it. Its mine. Just like others have their own. Then it clicked. I yell, this can't be. You are. Cass beside be shrieks, what the hell. She also realized what this meant. I turn to face a nervous ridden David. He makes a nervous smile, saying, you are looking at the 342th Shadow strategist. A cold shiver went through my brain. There is a moment of complete shock. Until Cass breaks it, the freak. This is not funny David. David says, its not a joke. I never told anyone last year when my memories returned. That ring is part of the same insignia as Blake's dagger and Marina's neckless. If you check, you see my blood on the rock.

I hastily check the sides of the rock, it had red stains on its sides. Its exactly like the other two. I get angry, you. Are you one of them? This is unbelievable. Another surviving shadow, and of all the people its him. Siera asks, I don't believe it. Wait does that mean Blake and Marina. He cuts her off, know about me. They do. I told them a year back. Cass's jaw opens in shock, they know and never told anyone. The freak David. David clenches his mouth, trust me, its wasn't easy for me. I took an oath when I joined Shadows. I couldn't just tell anyone about this.

I shout out, why not. My anger rose, they both have told the whole world the truth long ago. He replies immediately, they had years before told anyone about it. My memories came back just recently. Try to imagine my situation. I learned an entirely new persona and identity suddenly. At that time, my mind was so screwed up that I instinctively only trusted the two people I knew the most. He makes a scowl, Marina is the only alive person who knew me before Medrine and I met Blake in Shadows. All the others I ever interacted before were dead. So trust me when I say that I was a mess. Revealing such an intimate and personal wasn't possible for me. At least not yet.

He looks so defeated right now that my anger subsided a little. Its true that he didn't have the same situation as others. I didn't like it, but it made sense why needed time to sort himself out first. And on top of the PTSD, it seems more and more that he was telling me the truth. Cass says with a somber voice, David. She couldn't say all her words at this shocking revelation. Siera picks the ring from my hand and inspects it. After a second she says, never did I imagine you were a Shadow. He suddenly drops her hand and faces him, no wait. It actually makes. When we met, you were displaying unusual skills and uncanny abilities. Your physical strength didn't match your intellect, but it wasn't something you expect someone to have without any training.

He says in a low tone, without me realizing, I was subconsciously using my Shadow training. This is ridiculously confusing. How the hell I never thought of this before. I ask, Blake and Marina said all other Shadows were dead. He leans in forward, I wasn't with them when they boarded the ship. Shadow strategist are given special privilege. Something only the other shadows know about it. He takes a small breath, I know the identities of all shadows. My palm curl into a fist, what. Cass cuts in, are telling me you knew Marina and Blake were in shadows. Like before they told.

He nods, I do. That’s how I know they were safe when they boarded the ship first. I stayed behind to coordinate an platoon section to buy time for the two ships. This is hard to believe when he was just a kid back then. He was commanding a whole darn army. Siera asks, damn. I heard rumors of this, a shadow strategist, even an apprentice could command a entire force alone. Cass clicks her tongue, seriously. I don't remember much about them. Holy shit. You kept Hive off of the ships. David seemed reluctant to tell this. He makes a disapproving face, don't be impressed by it. Those rumors about us are greatly exaugurated. Part of the whole lore, as you know.

I ask, what does that mean. He replies, was I coordinating our defenses. Sort of. But was I alone. No. I was still an apprentice. I was only taking the reins which my predecessor gave me. He did most of the heavy lifting. I almost died several times after he left to command other troops. It was the most horrifying thing I ever did. I had taken missions before, but not at this scale. He closes his eyes and shakes his head. Its like he is trying to forget those memories. When he didn't answer for some time Cass asks, David. You okay.

He opens his eyes, no. I am not. That’s why I am in therapy. He turns to me, I didn't tell anyone about my PTSD because I am different than others. And its not about being arrogant or confident. I was chosen and then trained to be one the most important pillar of Shadows. And later for the every Medrones left alive earth. And I squashed it all away when I lost my memories. The guilt and regrets I carry is nothing compared to any perceived accomplished I have had since then.

This is not what I expected from him. I couldn't be angry at him any longer. I have seen him hurt and depressed many times. Even when he had been guilty of things he shouldn't be. But this is something I can't wrap my head around. Everything about his screams he has been suffering for a while. A small thoughts come in between trying to continence me that he was lying. Or manipulating us. But the sincerity behind his eyes and his broken voice made it difficult for me to believe that.

Siera asks, you take on too much. It wasn't your fault. Being a Shadow doesn't mean you are impervious to feelings. David leans back on his chair. There is a long silence and then he says, its my fault. Because this could have all been avoid if I hadn't taken my own memories. A moment later his words sink in. I yell, what did you just say. After then he revealed his most horrifying experience. He told about the dead bodies of the solders he saw at the front lines. Then about deaths of the few important people. He didn't tell us their names, but he saw other Shadows death in front of him.

The horror was too much for him to bear. So he took the serum he always planned to take. The serum which he made before Hive ever attacked, since he was dying on Medrine. 10 minutes later we all sat in utter silence. His horrifying retelling had made David asking for water numerous times. Siera even asked him if was having panic attack. But he just waved it off saying it was just nerves. But no one believed him. Cass asks, holy shit. You went through so much as a kid. No wonder you are. She eats her own words before saying them.

David scoffs, don't need to hide. I know I am a mess. I haven't told this to anyone. Only 3 people know about it. Now it includes you all too. Its was a messed up discission by a kid who just wanted to get it over with it. Not be haunted by the memories. Cass says, no. That’s what I meant. She tries to hide her intension from before, but it was clear everyone were thinking it. I ask, you told us you were slowly getting malnourished on Medrine before. But you were dying? He says, in a way. I would have died much earlier than I predicted.

He makes a depressed laugh, try to rationalize this. Hive attacked us, billions were killed, and that somehow paved a miracle for me to survive. I arrived on Earth, which not only cured me, it made me stronger. This was beyond any type of survivor guilt. I never ever wanted to tell people about this because its totally insane if you think about it. Siera assures, you can't think like that. He replies, but its what happened, didn't it. No matter how many times I am told it wasn't my fault, it isn't easier for me to let it go. If I could have, I wouldn't have PTSD or needed therapy.

Cass says, David. How in the world does that makes sense. You don't know that would have happened. He waves, it doesn't change how I feel though. We can keep arguing about it but I would always feel like shit. At the very least I shouldn't have been so scared and took that serum. I am a shadow for freaking sake. We are supposed to have strong mental fortitude. He sighs and takes another sip of the water. This is really causing him mental strain. He says, imagine if people know a Shadow strategist turned out like this. Hansen must be berating from his grave.

I ask, Hansen? David looks up to me in confusion. I think it was a slipup because he corrects himself saying, forget it. Just someone I used to know. He just told us he didn't know many people outside Shadow. Then this person was probably someone from Shadow. Siera consoles him, let's not keep pressuring him on this. Seems something that is meant for therapy. She had a point. Cass says, but that’s not right. David says, doesn't matter Cass. I am telling this to you now, but I have been struggling for a year now. It may not look like it, but unless I am actively talking about it I can manage my emotions well enough.

This is very strange type of coping mechanism. Bottling it up is never good. I should know, but I was like him. I can see myself in him, trying to handle it all alone. Cass asks, jeez David. This is lot to take. He nods, for me too. He then takes a pause, but I am getting better. At least much better than a week ago. I hit a low point that I couldn't use my Kuret for a while. Not unless I had a panic attack. I spat, hold on. When did that happen. He says, right after the tournament. I talked to Drew about it. I needed help desperately. That day was the longest for me. I had a panic attack when we talked on the pier, then later I almost slipped up during the interview.

I recalled the events of the day. He was suspiciously jumpy when I was talking to him. Its so damn frustrating to think about it. At time he acts like he is fine, but other times so different. It makes sense now why his emotions were all scrambled up. Siera asks, but you got over it. He nervously nods, I did. Wasn't easy. I had to accept certain people's death. Death that could have been avoided. He stares to his right, like seeing something beyond this room. The turns to me, not just theirs. Being a Shadow strategist kept me in a very precarious position. He then places his hand on the side of his temple, I have seen, people dead. People close to ones I care about.

My heart immediately beats faster. My gut was telling it was about Wagner. I wanted to know, but I was too afraid. I was in too much of a shock to even speak about it. Siera asks, what do you mean. Who did you see. Cass says, you said about visiting the front lines. David jerks of head, trying to not recall those faces. He then takes another sip of water, I was searching of survivors. Anyone I could help before I went back. But the dead bodies were everywhere. Those who were barely alive, I tried helping them. I don't know how many survived in the end. However, I found many people who I recognized. They were relatives of yours.

All of us held our breathing as he clears his throat. Cass asks, whom did you see. David was stalling. No, he was reluctant to say them. Siera asks, girls. Lets not ask so much of him. He is too much troubled by this. This is probably

why he doesn't talk much about your families. This made me a cold shiver. Is this why he never spoke of Wagner. Because he was there when. I couldn't finish my own thought. It was too complicated to untangle of mix of emotions I had. David says, I want to Siera. What's the point of going to therapy. Or coming here. They are the reason for my PTSD. It triggers me in strange ways whenever I talk about them. So I avoid them actively. But I am much better now.

We wait until he gets ready to tell in his own time. He then opens his mouth, out of respect of the dead, I won't talk about others. If you want to know, then ask Blake and Marina. I told them who all I found. Because I want them to tell you, if they want. Its not my place anymore to tell. He gave us a version of it that met us in the middle. If its two of them, its possible its their families. He turns to Cass, how much do you remember of your great aunt. Cass immediately arches her shoulder, you know Terrisa. He continues, she was a shadow two generations before.

Cass adjusts in her seat a little ahead completely amazed, no freaking way. I ask, hold on. How do you know that. He says, I just do. Lets leave it at that. I should have asked more, but his heavy eyes made me realize he doesn't want to dredge up that past. Cass says, she was my grandfathers sister. She becomes a little curious, she wasn't an alpha though. David says, you don't have to necessarily need to be an alpha to be in Shadows. Blake wasn't one, neither was I. What we need is talent. And Terrisa was special.

Siera says, I think I remember her. When I was little I heard about a women from your house. Cass says, yeah. She was had a physical gift. Her Kuret abilities could in certain conditions exceed our alphas. That’s incredible. I ask, how come you never talked about her before. Cass says, honestly, she was remarkable person. But not very sociable. And she had a big temper. My dad didn't like her much, so I kind of don't talk about her. I turn to David, she was in Shadows despite that.

He scoffs, one is not judged on personality to be in shadow. If that were a problem, Marina wouldn't be one. He made a strong argument. He says, I don't know all the shadows personally. But lets just say many have distinct personalities. But what binds us is talent and skill. Its crazy that I am having a conversation about Shadows from David. Blake and Marina only know a facet of the organization. But it looks like David knows a hell lot of more. Siera asks, interesting. What was she.

David face contorts, I rather not say. These people are gone, but their decedents are alive. Even mentioning Terrisa is breaking a lot of the oaths I made. He sighs, but I wanted you to know, Cass. He faces her with sudden seriousness, I found her near a building. She was an elderly lady, but she was still hot blooded and fighting even at her age. Cass sat back up, my god. He nods, she must have fought off Hives while people escaped, because she was all alone outside an empty building. I don't know about your parents, but I hope you know your family was strong. Be proud of them. Cass shakes her head with a little smile, she died like how she lived, huh.

He says, that she did. I ask, who else was there. I must have sounded insensitive to Cass. But I am impatient. David faces with such seriousness that I wondered if I pissed him off. But I didn't care about that. I just wanted to know. Eventually he gave up, yes. I found Wagner too. My heart beats faster. I have talked to countless people till now and no one was able to tell me about Wagner. Its strange that the person who did know was with me this whole time. He grits his teeth, I don't have any words of comfort. I found him dead with his own dagger in his heart.

I jumped out of the couch in anger, what the hell does that mean. He tilts he head to me, I don't know what happened. Maybe some Hive decided to kill him with his own weapon. Or maybe. He trails off. I ask in hast, what. What happened. He says, I don't know. I wasn't there. He makes it clear he was only there after he died. My fist tighten in such blaze of anger that I couldn't control. I blurt out, my brother wouldn't have died like this. He was the strongest. Tell me what happened.

I was asking something unreasonable. But I didn't care. I had to know. David looks over to others and then to me, my answer is not going to change. I found him with other soldiers. I can only assume he was fighting of some of the key Hive commanders. I don't know what killed him. I can only tell you how he died. I take a step towards him, towering him and ask, tell me the truth. David nostrils flair a little. Siera says, Vanessa. Behave yourself. I wasn't going to, I say to her, not this time. I want answers. Siera says, what kind of answer are you looking for. He was a kid back then.

I was too emotional to think clearly now. Not when I was so close to knowing about Wagner. I turn to him, you knew him. Didn't you. You could have helped him. He would have been saved. I finally said out aloud what I was thinking. What was I even saying. Cass says, Vanessa, that is. David cuts her off, this is not possible. I was barely able to help myself back then. How do could I have helped him. I got angry at him. I spat out, how do you know him. Was he also. David buts in, I know him because some of my previous missions clashed with him. He was the crown, he was involved in a lot of sensitive matters to the country. I met him several times.

He explained how he knew my brother. But I wasn't satisfied. I ask him point blank, was he in Shadows too. David gives me a blank stare silently. Siera asks, is that true David. He thinks for a moment, what does it matter if he was one or not. I ask, that is not an answer. He closes takes another sip of water from the glass and this takes gulps it down all in one go. I take another step towards him demanding an answer. He puts the glass down and says, if I say he was one, would you believe me. Or would you prefer he wasn't one.

I wasn't going to play any games right now, just tell me. He then suddenly takes a stance, no. What is this. What the hell is he thinking. Is he really going to provoke me right now. He stands up in front of me, if I say he was one, you would blame me and the shadows for leaving him to die. And if he wasn't one, you would still blame us for not saving him. Siera says, that doesn't make any sense. He says, that’s right. It doesn't. Yet its true. Right now Vanessa truly believes that we are responsible. No, rather I am. I clench my jaws in anger. The sheer arrogance of him to be so haughty.

But what's worse is that he is absolutely right. I couldn't form those words, yet I was thinking the exact thing. He read me like an open book. Cass says confused, Vanessa, do you really think that. I couldn't answer her. My attention was squarely on the person in front of me. I ask him, he was the strongest Medrone alive. He wouldn't have died if you had helped him early. David's eye squint, strange. If he was the strongest, how the hell did he die then. I couldn't take it anymore, I pull my arm and slap him on his cheeks.

David slouches a little from the hit. The other two stood up behind me and Siera grabs my arm, Vanessa. Stop this right now. I shove her back as David straightens back up, did that feel good. He didn't look even one bit apologetic. It only ticked me off more. He grabs his jaw where I hit. He says, I have been waiting for you to let out this anger. Because I am tired of tip toeing around you. I yell, what do you mean by that. He replies, I know Wagner is a sour topic for you. This past year I have tried to tell you. But you never try to listen to reason. So I sort of hoped you would leave it alone. But I can't anymore.

Siera asks, what exactly happened with you and Wagner. He turns to Siera, I have tried many times to talk to Vanessa about Wagner. But every time she shots me down. I am sick of it. He faces me, your brother had a dark side to him. You only remember one thing about him. But I have seen a whole lot of him. I say, lies. He was the most decent person I knew. David's demeanor had changed completely now. He wasn't nervous at all anymore. He says, if that’s true, then why is Charles claiming he made a ruckus at his village.

I take a step forward, he was just making things up. Cass asks beside me, what about Charles. But neither one of us explain it. David says, Vanessa, you make him out to be a god. But he was a person, just like us. Flaws and all. He had a darker side to him. I am not at all surprised he did something that endangered children. I had enough of this lies. I went for another slap. But he grabbed my wrist before I made contact. He nonchalantly says, you only get one. I tried to pull back my arm, but his grip was so tight it hurt me.

He continues, having admiration for him is fine. But having blind devotion, that’s dangerous. I angrily yell, you think you are so hot shot being a Shadow. You think you him better than me. His own sister. Then he does something out character, he laughs maniacally. He says, you know what. I do know him better than you. He was the strongest, there is no doubt about that. But he was also harboring anger. Anger and hate that you don't seem to know about.

I wriggled under his grip. I aimed for a punch with my other hand. But before I could, I let goes of my arm and I stumble back a step. Siera catches my arm and I regain my balance. I shout, you are just spouting nonsense. He was the most decent person. He sighs, and that’s why I never wanted to talk about him. You have romanticized your childhood memories to an absurd level. Everyone naturally would want to believe their sibling were good and kind. But they at least recognize some of their faults. You on the other hand are too stubborn and never once believe that to be true.

I am so much mad I might punch him again. I say, I never said anything like this. He says, try to recall. I tried to broach the subject about the next crown during the flag capture game. You straight up said no will ever be as strong as Wagner. And everyone should try to be like him. He then shakes his head, I am sorry to say. But we already have multiple people here who have surpassed him. Or at the very least at his level. My veins start to pop up, I get it now. You are jealous of him. That’s why you are even willing to risk your life fighting with an overdrive Heraknus. You want to become stronger than him.

He gives a flat response, you are right. Not about being jealous. But I want to be better than him. Let me be clear about something though. I am perfectly okay with you believing Wagner was good person. What I don't understand is why you can't stand anyone talking anything less about him. I get its important to hold on to memories, I know more about it than anyone. But you are holding it like its your life. You don't even want to entertain any flaws about him. There is no such person who is all good always. They are just delusions of kids.

Those words made me so mad I felt I was boiling. Wagner is the strongest. He was the most decent Medrone ever. But why can't I remember anything other than that. We had so much fun and he was always caring for me. And yet I can't remember anything bad about him. This made me even more furious. This the same thing Cass was talking few days back. I am did the same thing to Ned, put my own selfish desires on him. I am so confused now, why am I even thinking this. Wagner was a good person. I know it be absolutely true.

But then why can't I convince David of it. In a wrapped sense, he was making sense. I don't like anyone putting Wagner down. Even if its about something so silly as the title of crown. No, its not silly, Wagner was the crown. But then David voices echo's to me, so were others before him. I grab my burning head trying to break out of this turmoil. David says, I don't want to argue this with you. But I care about you. And I needed to tell you what my feelings are about this. I even called in Cass and Siera because I wasn't brave enough to do this alone.

I look up to him. He wasn't angry anymore, he was very said. He continues, I have tried different subtle ways to make you understand this. But you are strangely adamant about your own believes. All I want is for you to acknowledge that I will not have the same believes as you. He earnest request was making me angrier by the second. Am I really being petty with this. But its Wagner we are talking about. My brother. The strongest Medrone. My eyes swell in tears. Why am I getting like this. Why can't David believe in my brother.

David sighs, but if you can't even do that. Then you are in need of therapy too. He words cut me deep. Why can't I let it go. Cass says, that’s enough. You should stop David. You are hurting her feelings. He says, I wasn't planning on doing this. But even I have a limit on my patience. She was demanding me to accept something about Wagner which I didn't agree. I am not giving an excuse for my behavior. I am only telling what I feel. Why am I not even allowed that, while she is not being fair. This is my way of making amends.

Cass says, how is this. He says, my mistake was not about lying or hiding the truth. It was being dishonest about it. I should have been honest about knowing Wagner from the beginning. But I am still not going to tell what I know, and how I know. Because I truly believe its best to leave it in the past. That’s why I didn't about Terrisa to you, Cass. Why should I open wounds from the past that can't affect our present. Cass remains silent. I couldn't open my mouth even a little anymore. I was a bag of angry and confusion. He says, same thing happened with Catherine.

Cass asks, what do you mean. He shakes his head, ask her. Ask her if its better to know about your family in a long lost planet. He takes a short breath, this is my problem. I wanted to reconcile my past self on Medrine with my current self. Knowing so many secrets suddenly about so many people took an unexpected effect on me. That’s why I ended up in therapy. And I am trying hard to change. I am trying very hard to accept my reality. Blake and

Marina had years to adjust this new life. And while I was technically living on Earth like everyone, I am basically having an identity crisis recently. I am trying to make it right with everyone. I don't want my Shadow past to define my behavior anymore.

He faces me, I regret how I handled things with you. Its that I didn't trusted you, I didn't trust myself enough. I thought you would just hate me always about this. Instead of explaining my reasons, I hide the reasons it self. That was the mistake. But I am trying not to be like this anymore. Its taken me months, but I have been gradually confiding in people about things. I told everyone about my eyes healing on Earth. I told you about my life in the university. Maybe not everything, but I was opening up. Just like how I am telling everything now.

He intense gaze pierces me so hard I feel dizzy. I can't seem to let of my anger at all. What's wrong with me. David is rambling and pouring his heart out, and yet all I feel is anger at him. He walks back and takes the jug of water to his mouth. He drinks it halfway empty and then wipes his mouth, sorry. My nerves were acting up. Needed to cool down. Siera asks concerned, are you really okay. You are way to riled up. He sighs, I might have taken it too far. Because after this, I am meeting with Drew with some sort of special treatment.

Cass asks, what. Now. He nods, yes. I wanted to clear up things with you and Vanessa before that. Because it seems there is some risk to this. My anger subsides with complete confusion. Siera asks, what kind of risk. He shrugs, don't know. It could be anything from a hypnotic congenital exposure or a straight up hard core medication. Cass asks, why so sudden. He sighs, because I still have PTSD. I may have gotten over some of my issues. Not all. And its dangerous to leave it untreated any longer.

Cass says, you going to fight Charles despite your condition. He says, I have no choice. I made a deal with him. That deal secured our future. And I have been painstakingly making efforts to make sure Heraknus follow through it. Even if that meant raging a political war against Citradel. Siera asks, and that somehow equates to you taking a risky treatment. He says, I can't deny I am worried about it. But I trust my therapist. I recently learned she is much smarter and skilled than me. Objectively speaking, that says a lot about her. She predicted a nervous breakdown even before it happened and prepared a sedative in advance. I have complete faith in her abilities.

This is absolutely bonkers. What kind of person Drew is that made David trust her this much. Cass says, David. This is too risky. You are not in right mind right now. She peeks at me from the side as I remained silent all the while. Siera says, she is right. You need to settle down. Maybe delay it for tomorrow. David says, there is no point to delay it. I have been dealing with this for months. I am ready to be done with it. This week has been tough on me. But I rather face my demons.

His determination was strong now. His lost vigor had returned. While mine was dwindling away. It had has been ever since he called me out so openly. I looks at his watch and turns to us, its time. I need to go back home in another 45 minutes. I wasn't planning on arguing with anyone so I didn't thought I needed a lot of time. I should have come earlier, but I know you all are busy. I squeezed out a lot of time without meaning to. Siera says, forget about us. Are you really not going to postpone it now.

He says, I am not. I might look like I am unstable, but trust me. This has been going on for a week. Therapy has helped me a lot to handle my emotions. Actually, its not been much help recently, but I do feel it would have been worse without it. And that’s why don't care about the timing right now. In fact, this maybe the best time. I know its strange to say out aloud, but I am feeling much better now that I said my piece. Especially about Wagner. I will say it again. I wasn't planning to be so confrontational about it. Still, its made me feel better. Even if I hate myself for putting this on you, Vanessa.

I don't know how he can be so considerate of me right now. He basically said I am delusional about Wagner. The person I admire the most. Gah, my head hurts now from the internal conflict. He then turns to Cass, I know its not fair. But I would like you to be there too. Cass takes a second to respond, if you are going to be stubborn about doing it. I might as well see it through till the end. He nods and turns to me, I don't want to cause more duress on to you. So I leave it up to you to. But I would prefer if you are there too. Both of you. He turns to Siera.

She looks at my quiet demeanor and says, ah, we are going to need a minute to think about it. He nods. He prepares to leaves the room. But before he leaves, he says, one more thing. I would really prefer it if you don't tell anyone what you heard today. At least until the match with Charles. I am not asking you to lie, just don't mention it to anyone. Something this personal could be used against me. I am worried about people targeting me. This sort of stuff is exactly the thing that would create a chaos that I can't cover it again.

I couldn't give it any thoughts. I was a mess inside right now. Siera says, of course. Be assured that I won't be telling this anyone. Cass didn't make the same promise, she just gives a slight nod. He says, you all have been there for me in the beginning. You saved me many times back then, so I owe you the truth about me. Sorry it took so long. I just needed time. Cass says, its all right David. I don't like it, but at least I understand it better now.

He says, thanks. He turns his back t us, see you all later. He abruptly steps out of the door. The three of us where standing in my living room like couple of confused people gawking at the retreating figure of David. Cass turns to me, Vanessa. I don't exactly know what really happened with you, David and Wagner. I don't want take sides. I am only sorry this happened. Between this and Ned, I don't know what's going on with you. But all I know is that I want to trust David. Even when he was ranting like crazy few minutes ago.

She was clearly taking his side, despite what she said. I can't blame her though. And yet I couldn't utter a single word. I was lost in my own thoughts. Siera covers for me, you'll have forgive her. She is shaken up by this ordeal. Can't say I am faring any differently. That was a lot. Cass says, that I get it. Are you going to go to his place then? Siera says, I am not sure. But you go ahead. If we do leave, it will be later. She says, I need to talk to Matt too before I go to his pace. Siera asks, hey now. Didn’t David tell not to tell this to anyone.

She scoffs, I am not like David. I can't just keep such a massive thing from Matt. I didn't verbally agree to it, did I. David can be mad at me later. I need Matt with me right now. She already had her phone open while walking out of the house. Siera sighs, maybe David had a point to keep this hidden from people. No matter how much you try to hide it, the truth always comes out. She looks at me, you have been quiet for too long. I am getting worried about you. Say something.

I lost strength in my legs and I slump down in the couch. With a meek voice I say, I don't know what to think. I can't believe David said so many wiles things about my brother. We have argued so many times. But never like this. Never something so personal. She sits beside me, you know I am always here for you. I am on your side, but I can't dismiss him too. You love your brother a little too much. I face her angrily, sounds like you are taking his side. How is that right. I can't understand my own emotions anymore. Why is everyone siding with him on such things. I hate this.

She reaffirms me, Vanessa. You are stronger than this. She reprimands me like she always does. The familiarity of her commanding voice makes me feel a little better. She says, I don't know what David knows about Wagner. Its honestly unbelievable that the clueless kid we met all those years ago is actually someone important. You him much better than me. Do you think he is sort of a person accusing people for no reason. I spat out, don't tell me you believe him.

She says, its like he said. It doesn't matter what we believe. Its all in the past now. It was on a different planet. I am only agreeing with David on this point. You should try to leave it alone. People can have different views about the same people. It doesn't have to mean one is wrong or right. I have noticed it for some time, but I didn't realize it was this deep. I ask, what are you saying. I know my brother was a good person. She says, I am not denying that. But you don't have to this angry with David for not agreeing with you. I have many issues of how he spoke to you. Maybe its because he is in therapy, or something else. But at least he has a good excuse. What's yours.

She was making me question things I didn't want to ask myself. I had an unshakable faith on Wagner. Even after all this I refuse to believe it. And yet I know how unreasonable I am being with this. David himself said he was okay with me, it was me who wasn't okay with him. It just pissed me more that he was somehow having the moral ground right now. Siera then says, listening to David make me wonder about Wagner myself. I ask, how do you mean. She says, I am not sure if its related. But I have always found it weird. You once told me a story about your brother. I thought I remembered it wrong. But something David said makes me curious.

I didn't like where this was heading. I can't handle if Siera begins to lean towards David now. She then begins to tell me story that makes me leaves speechless once again.

Blake (Chapter 95)

Sunday, February 15, 2026 09:25

Where are they? She asks me again for the fifth time. My answer hadn't change again, calm down, Marina. We are early. We both were waiting in front of David's house. His car wasn't in the driveway, so we know he was somewhere else. We were waiting beside my car and pacing around for the time being. She says exasperated, I can't. I have been avoiding talking about it because I didn't want David to feel pressured. But now that its now, I am freaking out a little.

I can understand her worry. I am worried as well, however, David had made up his mind about this. I tell her, its going to be fine. We need to trust Drew with him. Marina clicks her tongue, we still don't how she plans to treat him. I can't help but imagine its something like a lobotomy. I scoff, that's not true. I think David once mentioned its non surgical. She says, then it could be a non invasive lobotomy. I don't even understand what that meant. Don't think Marina knows it herself. We chatted about the different possibilities for a while. Then 30 minutes before we saw he car approaching.

Marina yells, finally. I was worried he might have bailed for some reason. I don't think David would do that, but anything's possible right now. We parks his car and gets out. The moment we saw his face, Marina and I immediately knew he was upset about something. His eyes were droopy and his posture looked lopsided. Marina asks, David. What happened. David turns to us walking to him. He says, hey guys. Ah, he sighs heavily, nothing serious happened. That didn't exactly make us less anxious.

I ask, you look exhausted. Don't tell me you in a fight again. He smiles, not exactly. Marina crosses her arm demanding answers. He relents, I just met with Vanessa, Cass and Siera. This garnered an immediate anxious reaction from us. He says, I told them about my PTSD and I was in Shadows. Marina blurts, holy shit. You did what. I bit my lips, you told them everything. He replies, not everything. I didn't tell them who the other shadows were. Well, expect for Terrisa.

I turn to Marina who shrugs at me. She asks David, and who is she? He replies, a Shadow from Cass's family. She was the retrievalist from two generations ago. I am surprised by this new addition to our mysterious Shadow history. Marina asks shocked, someone from Cass's house were also part of Shadows. He nods, like me, Zakerine and Wagner, she was an outsider. I ask, and you told Cass about it. He says, I figured I come clean to her now. I don't know if people targeting us would use it against me. I rather tell them myself first rather than hear from someone else.

So this is what he decided to do in the end. In the morning he wasn't sure what to do with Vanessa. Seems he found something to say not just to her, but also others. He says, ever since I told you guys about our Shadow history, I have been thinking about telling both Cass and Catherine. I need to clear my conscious. Anything that will help me get over my PTSD. His desperation to get over his issue is apparent. Can't say if it's the right call though. Marina says, so does that mean you told Vanessa about Wagner.

He makes a irritated face, I couldn't. I only told few vague details to her that Wagner wasn't a good person like she thought. I ask, that's all. You didn't tell her he was a Shadow. He says, I couldn't. Vanessa was at my throat, believing I was wrong unquestionably. And based on how our conversation went, I realized she wouldn't be okay with either way. If lied about him, I would have only made it worse. And if told her the truth, she would undoubtably blame us for not saving him.

I ask, that can't be. She can't blaming us for that. He says, she didn't put it in so many words, but I know she was thinking about it. Marina says, that's freaked up. He says, she couldn't reconcile Wagner dying a ordinary death. She has told us numerous times how he must have died heroically. He probably might have. But reality and perception are different things. Marina asks, I feel sorry for her a little now. And what about your theory about her trauma replacing memories. He clicks his tongue, I already broke her heart and basically made her hate me even more. I had nothing left in me anymore. I kind of rushed out of there in a hurry not wanting to have a panic attack.

I take a nervous step, did you have one. He cracks his neck and puts his hand behind his neck, not really. I thought I had one coming. But it was just my nerves acting up. I thought for sure talking about Wagner would cause him to have a panic attack. He already had it several times before. But he is in much better shape than I thought he would be. I ask, so you are okay. He scoffs, relatively speaking. Though, I feel much better now that I have come clean to them.

Marina says, damn dude. How can you say that when you look like you are beaten down. He gives a nervous smile, I don't doubt it. Maybe I am just exhausted from training entire day. Or its something else. Its strange, isn't it. Who knows why. That's why I am in therapy. He wasn't making any sense, but that's exactly what he himself acknowledges. It feels like he is coming to terms with himself right now. I ask, you wanted to tell them just before a treatment. Seems kind of unfair to them.

Marina says, yeah. That does seem strange behavior from you. He says, I have been stalling entire day struggling with this. I know its not right, but I don't exactly know what this treatment entails. I know I said its not dangerous, but I don't want to risk it. I should have told them earlier, that I admit. I can't make all the right decisions, now can I. I can't tell if he using his PTSD as an excuse or its really making him do strange things. Regardless, I know he didn't mean to hurt anyone.

Marina sighs, all right. You get a pass since you are not well. But try not to anymore rash things. That's my thing. She lightly taps his one arm. He gives a little smirks, that won't be the last one. But I will sure tell you beforehand. That makes Marina punch his arm again. He says, ouch. Marina scoffs, don't get snippy with me. Its difficult to grasp him. He seems stable, but also not at the same time. This is a completely new avenue. But I shake it off and ask, I am guessing you also tell them about you are meeting Drew now.

He says, I did. Cass will be here soon. Don't know about Siera and Vanessa. I reply, okay. So we better get out stories straight. Marina says, yeah. What did you not tell them? He gave us a rundown on what he said. He didn't tell about our family, nor Catherines. He didn't leave hide much about his PTSD, so that's a good. Because I don't have to hide it anymore from others. He even told about them his guilt about taking the serum. Marina whistles, jeez David. You didn't hold back did you.

He says, I didn't see the point in it. I didn't want to make another mistake, like I did with Vanessa. So that's everything I told them. I scratch my head thinking about it. Its good he freed himself from keeping so many secrets, but at the same time I feel anxious. What will they think of me and Marina who kept his secret. My nervousness was read by David, don't look so down, Blake. You both did what I asked of you. Just tell others it was my decision. You don't have to feel guilty.

I smile at how he read me so easily, did I look worried about that. Marina says, you kind of. I ask her, you don't have a problem. She chuckles, dude, I am freaking out a little inside. But come on, we all decided it was for the best to hide his identity. I am glad I wasn't the who had to tell anyone though. That would be too awkward. This is so like her. I am a little envious of her. She has a much better positive attitude than me right now. David says, you both don't have to be worried. Then we hear a car coming from the side. David says, I am the one who should be on edge right now.

This is it. It was Drew's car. She parks it beside my car. I saw a lot of stuff in the back seat. She is wearing a large coat as she septs out from the car, good evening everyone. I figured there would be an audience. David walks to her first, evening doctor. They both shake hands. She says, you look tired. Busy day. He says, busy week. As you know. She chuckles, quite the celebrity you have become. David makes a scowl, it's a phase. It will die out soon.

She scoffs, I don't think so. Your passionate speech convinced everyone. I would love to hear sometime how much of it was true. David snarls, don't mess around. I may not have told you everything of my time on Earth, but you must might have pieced enough stories about me. She says, maybe. I have some suspicions for few events. I know you are not really responsible for those people dying in the warehouse. But I can't be sure of it. That stung me a little. It was mine and Vanessa's fault. She correctly guessed it was a lie.

David says, doesn't matter. Its the official truth right now. I hope you are not telling anyone about it. Especially your family. She says, of course. I know that. You are creating huge waves against Citradel. My opinions are just that, nothing more. Though. She turns a little quieter, my daughter is smitten by you. And I don't like that. That made me and Marina laugh a little. David however played it slyly, really. That's good to know. He gives a wicked smile. I can't believe he had the nerve to make jokes to her right now. Drew immediately straightens her back, I can easily mix poison in your sedatives. You won't even know about it.

David chuckles, didn't she broke up with her boyfriend recently, this makes Drew even more anxious. Marina cuts in, dude. Stop antagonizing the person who is going to poke around your brain. David smiles. Drew shakes her head, lets not get into it right now. She then meets us, Blake. Marina. We both take turns to greet her as well. I ask, so this it huh, I point to the bags in the back. She says, yes. Marina asks, and what is it. Drew says, some equipment's, pharmaceuticals, and all kinds of fun stuff. He peeks at David like she wanted to scare him, maybe get a little revenge for earlier.

I don't think I have seen any doctor like her. She doesn't know what's been going on, but its refreshing to see she has a sense of humor. Marina scoffs, you won't tell us. She says, not right now. I am in the presence of very high profile people. I don't want to give false promises until it works. I say, you don't have to be worried about that right now. She smiles, I cannot be not worried. I am guessing more people know about this than a week ago. Right. She looks around our apprehensive face.

She ends up staring at David. He says, like Blake said. Lets not be concern ourselves with it. Drew scoffs, so others know about me as well. She shakes her head a little, I guess its fine. Thankfully no one has approached my house demanding answers. Though, I expect some discretion. Please leave my family separate from this. Can I at least count on that?

I want to assure her privacy, I will make sure no one disturbs you. Marina says, we will not allow anyone to interfere with your daily life. That we can promise. She takes a second to take it in, thanks. She turns to David, you have good friends. You have caused a lot of problem for them. He smirks, don't try to make me feel even worse then I feel. Not right now. She analyses him for a second, you seem different. And the earlier banter too seemed off. Did something happen. She picked up on his behavior. He waves at her, I had a rough week. I was entangled in a big criminal business and then blindsided from Ryes. Me being strange is actually not that strange.

Her eyebrows furrows in a little, hum, that's true. Well, in any case, if you are able to look at yourself this objectively, that's makes me feel better at the odds of this working. David says, great. Then lets get started. We all help her get our stuff out from her car. Marina offered to carry all with her Kuret, but Drew said they are all delicate equipment's. So we chose to carry them in hand. In few minutes we set her stuff in David's living room. He had earlier cleared up all the furniture and made space there.

Drew says, thank you all. But from this point on words, its just me and David. I ask, we can help you setup your equipment's. She says, thanks. But its better if I handle it myself. Among us, only she was only medically trained so I can't really argue with her. She needed some space from us to work. David says, I will help her however I can. So its fine. Then came a heavy atmosphere because its time. The highly anticipated stuff we have anxious about is finally here. Marina says, you better not wake up a zombie okay. She gives a tight hug to David. She pats his back, if I do, just smack me around to wake me up. She smacks his back of his head after pulling away, don't think I wouldn't do that.

Then me and David lock in our arms, do whatever you need to do. And don't forget we are here for you. He smiles, thanks. I need to hear that. We let go of our arms. I add, we will outside the whole time. Give us a shout if anything goes wrong. Marina shots me a look, don't say that. Everything is going to be fine, right? She turns to Drew. She says, I am here. M is here too. He points to a hologram of her from a side display. She continues, have faith in us. I promised David to help him, and don't plan to break it now.

David is the most anxious. I know he is putting up a strong front, but anyone in his place would be terrified. Especially since he also doesn't know what this radical untested experimental treatment is. David says, don't worry

guys. I need this. And everything is going to be fine. We didn't have any choice but to have faith in his wavering confidence. Marina says, Drew, please take care of him. She nods, I will. I give a subtle nod to David. After that tense exchange, me and Marina step out of the house.

We both remained silent as we sat on the lawn chairs. David kept few out since we weren't going to leave his house. There were some additional kept out too, in case others visit here. Marina becomes very nervous and begins shaking her leg in quite suspense. The house begins to make a noise. This was familiar. The same thing happened few days ago. All the doors and window close. Windows turn to black tint. And the faint noises of stuff moving inside stops.

Marina waves her charm in the air and focus around the house. After a minute she disperses it, can't get any read. Whatever they are doing, its not related to Kuret. I ask, what do you think it is then. She says, no idea. I read up a little about behavior modification and correction. Some treatments are mild, while others are drastic. But they are all for a human physiology. I ask, for a Medrone it has to different, right. She didn't have an answer. All we can do is wait.

We chatted about our Shadows recruits. The tail we set on Nathan and Frank reported no problem so far. And she tells that she hasn't heard any new news about the culprits amongst us. It was going to be difficult, but we gradually we were crossing off officers who were completely innocent. We aren't completely sure if it was an officer who stole the drugs, but at least they seemed to be some connection with the smuggling operations. After around 10 minutes, Marina says, I sense someone. She turns towards the road where a car is approaching.

I follow her gaze and check the area. I could see a familiar Kuret aura coming off someone. It was Catherine. She parks her car beside Drews and runs off in our direction. She halts when she sees us sitting alone in the lawn, shit. I missed him, didn't I. I reply, yeah. They already begin about 15 minutes ago. She shakes her head, I should have just given the work to Jess. She turns to the house in lockdown, I assume those black windows mean I can't just knock and see him right now.

Marina pats to the seat beside her. Catherine gives a little frustrated scoff and took the seat. I ask, its fine Catherine. We all are busy. David knows that. She says, you guys got here fast. Marina says, I finished my work early to meet him before. I add, ditto. She lays her hand on her chin, I wanted to done the same. But some kids made a mess in the guest houses and I had to deal with it personally. I ask, anything important. She waves her other hand, nothing serious. They just were making a scene about Citradel.

I have been getting reports like this for past few days. Not everyone is happy what David and I did to Citradel. But they can't really side with Citradel officially. So they create feuds just to vent their frustration. Marina asks, you called in the IDF then? She sighs, I didn't. I have been calling them numerous times, and besides, they are busy with catching people on run. I stayed back to deal with it myself. She turns back to the house, enough about me. What about David. Will he be okay.

I give a nervous smile, we hope so. We still don't know what kind of non Kuret treatment is she administering. Marina says, based on her bags, I can't even tell what kind of non surgical way it is. Catherine leans back on her chair, resting her head. She says, I suppose we are going to just wait then. Marina and I gave a silent agreement. We passed the time the discussing about the exhibition match. Since things have settled down a little bit, Ned had been asking me to start focusing on that.

He has sort of became a liaison with the admins. Citradel isn't helping us with this right now, so we have to start preparing it ourselves. This week has been all sorts of chaos, but next couple weeks it would be about our expansion and the match. Just 3 weeks left, but it will fly by soon. Marina is already done around 80% of designs and geographical plans for out city. We can begin our work as soon as the tech team arrive. In another few minutes, next group of people arrived.

It's now Cass's car. I spot her and Matt coming to us now. I turn to Marina who was a little apprehensive too. David said he only told Cass, but what are the chances Matt just came here to just talk with us. She looks around us and asks, is he already inside. I nod, yeah. Matt looks like a clueless person and gives me and Marina and thorough stare. I sigh, she told her. She had to. Matt gulps a little, ah, hum, so its true. I wasn't sure exactly what he meant. I ask, what do you know.

He looks nervously at us and then to the house. He seemed so confused I felt a little pity for him. Did Cass drag him without telling the whole truth. Cass sits on the chair beside me, I thought they take more time. Should have arrived a bit earlier. She then looks at me with curious eyes. Marina sighs, Matt. Take a seat. David is not going to come out anytime soon. He looks around us and takes the seat beside Catherine. Catherine was also confused about these two. She asks, you know about David.

Cass didn't have words to answer her. Matt leans forward, you knew then. Catherine scoffs, when did you find about it. Matt slaps his temple, like just now. Cass told me. Catherine turns to Cass, who told you. Cass replies, David told me, Vanessa and Siera, like 2 hours ago. Catherine scoffs, so he just came clean about his PTSD right before this. What was he thinking. Matt looks to her, I don't believe it. He has been hiding his PTSD from everyone. He then faces me, who else knows about this.

I says, apart from people here, only Siera and Vanessa. Marina says, unless David went around telling someone else too and just didn't tell us. Its not entirely impossible. Matt says, you guys should have told us before. Marina says, it was David's decision. Don't blame us. Catherine says, I did the same. Cass asks, then you know everything too. Me and Marina remained impartial here, because we don't know who knows what exactly. But the situation so confusing, its about to come to a head.

Catherine says, I don't know the whole deal, but I know enough. Matt says, jeez. And you two, you have known about David for almost a year. I can't believe this. Its clear now Cass told him everything. Catherine jerks, what do you mean a year. She turns to me, you said he told you after the final match. I don't want to be the one to explain things to her. Neither did Marina, because she just shakes her head. Cass says, nah. They know. Once David memories return he told them he was a Shadow too.

Well, cats out of the bag now. Catherine jaw hung loose and then looks around the confuse faces. She yells, what the freak did you just say. I lean my head back on the chair. Matt shrieks, you said you knew everything. Cass shouts, about his therapy. What do you mean David's a Shadow. Matt turns to Cass confused. Marina puts her hand on Catherine's shoulder, Catherine. David conveniently left out things. Though we knew about it too. A completely bamboozled Catherine looks at her, you are not joking. Are you?

Cass says, you really didn't know. Catherine shakes her head, what the hell. David's a freaking Shadow. At this point I had enough. I need to step in, lets clear this up for everyone. Yes, he is really our Shadow strategist. For years I believed I was the only survivor of Shadows. I am sure Marina felt the same. I bring out a chuckle, but turns out we always had another one among us all this a long time. Imagine the surprise. Catherine makes a scowl, holy shit. A strategist. That is, ah.

Matt helps her out, perfect for him. Don't you think. I just heard it from Cass and I almost crashed my car while I was driving. Catherine turns to Marina, how in the hell you kept this from us. I didn't like the fact that she automatically assumed I was never going to tell her this. I have already told her many things before. Marina says, hey. Don't make this about me. I can keep secrets when I want to. I wasn't in Shadows for just my pretty face. She didn't had it say it like that.

Catherine asks, I can't believe this. I knew he didn't telling me everything. But I never imagined this. She turns to me, how come you didn't figure it out before ? Didn't you train together on Medrine. I sigh, he was very different in Medrine. Even his voice, the way he spoke and body frame has changed since then. Marina gets a little guilty, maybe I should have figured it out. But David knew our identities, so he sort of took extra care around me. I had no idea it was him all this time.

Catherine says, wait. He knew about you, but you didn't know him. The hell does that make sense. This is going to take a while. I let Marina explain the internal mechanics of Shadows. Matt listened in closely, while Cass filled in stuff she learned from David. After a long discussion Matt asks, he knows all the Shadows identities. Holy mother of Kuret. Cass says, he didn't really tell us how he knows that. Many eyes feel on Marina and me. Marina says, sorry. But that’s Shadow business. I explain before she makes everyone angry, what she means is that Shadows has long bloody history. Disclosing those names would be dangerous.

Catherine asks, why is that. Are there more still alive? I stayed silent because I had no intention of giving any more of our history. Thankfully Marina agreed with me and didn't tell anything. Cass says, you guys are making me my head hurt. And now David's part of this too. Matt asks, lets keep aside the Shadow for now. Why didn't he tell us about his therapy. This I can help understand them. I answer, you do know how does therapy works, right? Matts gives a strange look and thinks about it for a second. A second later he snaps his fingers, oh damn. I get it.

Others realized it too. Catherine says, for this to work, he had to tell Drew about his past. Didn't he. Then Drew knows about him being a Shadow. I say, she has never said it, but we kind of figured it out the first time me and Marina met her. Marina says annoyed, that’s actually second time for me. She didn't believe me the first time, don't forget that. I wave at her to be not petty about it now. I continue, anyways. I can understand why David didn't tell anyone. Since Drew knows more than anybody, even than us two, if people knew it would be bad.

They had to know how dangerous that knowledge would have been. Cass says, you mean what Ryes said. Marina says, yeah. Thankfully that didn't happen. If he did, it would have been much damaging. Matt asks, I suppose that makes sense. But then why tell any of us. He turns to Cass, I mean I am kind of glad to know one of the most important people survived Medrine. But now we know. And people are trying to expose him. Isn't it a risk telling people. He had a point. I didn't think David would do this. Expose himself, right after nearly dodging a public attack.

I shrug, you should ask him. I thought he was only going to tell about his PTSD. Cass adds, he said he wanted to clear his conscience. Marina asks, he said that? Cass nods, yeah. He seemed weirdly forthcoming about stuff. Going on about something like a identity crisis. I recalled Drew something similar earlier. Cass sighs, I hate to say it, but it that kind of make sense. Having lived such a wild like he had and then forget about it. That’s going to take a toll. Cass says, yeah. But you know, even without his memories, he has acted like a Shadow stagiest. You remember how he tricked Nathan 3 years ago. She chuckles, that was a mega brain move.

The discussion then went on about stuff his was up to on Earth. Me and Marina already went through this phase before. But it was amusing to see others going through it. Its different than us, since they were normal kids. Marina joined to share her Shadow experience, and I had to steer the conversation in between whenever she ventured about talking about our parents. I don't think its right to tell Catherine about her family's role in Shadow. I don’t like keeping her dad's and brothers death from her. She has only recently became her self again. I don't want to hurt her again.

I thought it was only going to be us, but then another car rolled into Davids driveway. Its already been 40 minutes since David and Drew went in. It was Vanessa car and then both her and Siera came out it. Marina says , I didn't think she would come. Cass, didn't you say she and David kind of fought. Cass says, more like a screaming match. It was crazy. I still don't know what David knows about Wagner. Cass told about the heated exchange earlier. Only me and Marina knew the truth about this. There was no point in telling them and cause more mess. So me and Marina stayed out of that matter. We assumed they weren't going to show up. But here they are.

Siera says, evening everyone. She looks at our tense faces. Vanessa is looking like hell. I think she was crying hard too. Her distraught and pain were visible on her face. The vibe here immediately shakes up and becomes suspenseful. Vanessa didn't say anything to us. She just stared at the house for a moment. Siera says, I am sorry to intrude on you all like this. I say, its no problem. But you should know he is already indisposed right now. She nods, I understand. We still like to stay though.

I take a quick peek to the other concerned faces. Obviously no one really had any reason to deny them, yeah. Sure. Take a seat. We had one seat less now, so I got up and offered mine. Siera says, I am fine with sitting on the

stairs. I say, come on. No need to be formal with us. We are off clock right now. Cass says, there is a garden chair in the garage. David showed me some time ago, I can get it. Siera says, thanks. She takes my seat. Vanessa finally unfreezes and walks to Marina.

She bends down whisper to her ear. After a moment, Marina nervously says, ah, yeah. Sure. She gets up and they both walk away. Everyone eyes glued to their retreating figure. Knowing what David told Vanessa, it could be only about one things. Her brother. Others figured it out too. Catherine asks, ah, Siera, is Vanessa okay. Siera says, no. Not right now. She looks around us, so I assume everyone here knows why they are here and what happened. Matt says, yeah. Cass told me. And we sort of told Catherine.

She turns to Cass approaching with a smaller chair. I thank her and take the chair from her. Siera says, you shouldn't have told Matt. Cass takes her seat back and scoffs, come on. You think I could keep such a big thing from him. I am not good at keeping secrets. And even I am, Mel is sure as hell not. Siera sighs, this is not good though. More people are going to find about him now. Cathrine says, so its that bad, huh. Siera says, you were just kids on Medrine. But us older people know how influential Shadows were.

She turns to me, maybe you and Marina also know. But all you were still only apprentices. Being a Shadow strategist is one of the most difficult jobs there is. I have heard many rumors about them. This is a little interesting. I ask, you mean how they are ruthless and dangerous. She smiles, you heard them too then. I say, of course. Even amongst us, there are many stories about them.

Catherine asks, stories? Siera says, I am sure not everything is true. Cass asks, are they really powerful? Siera says, all Shadows are crazy powerful. As you already know. But strategist wield different kind of power. She knows her Shadow lore. I know people now are more aware of us due to me and Marina. But Shadows were an enigma back in Medrine.

Siera lays it out, their knowledge and secrets are their weapons. Some so powerful entire nations and army can be toppled just like this, she snaps her finger.

Vanessa (Chapter 96)

Monday, February 16, 2026 20:35

I didn't want to be here. Not after what went down. Its too embarrassing people seeing my pitiful self. But after listening to Siera and crying, I settle down a bit. I still don't believe any of it to be true. But I am not going to stay cooped up in my room right now. I don't want to repeat the same mistake I did with Ned. I need to confront this instead letting it consume me. When I got here, 5 people were already here. I knew already that we were too late. David was in his house with his therapist doing god knows what.

I wanted to know more about Wagner. David said he knows Wagner due his Shadow mission. Then it means apart from him, Marina and Blake could also know the truth. I decided to ask each of them one by one. I grabbed Marina first because I thought she would tell me the truth. Blake already knows I am being unreasonable. But Marina wouldn't held anything against me. Once we were a distance away from her on the other side of the house, I ask, thanks for coming with me.

Marina says, I know what you are going to ask me. I make a confused expression. Then I noticed Cass coming out of the garage door. I ask, she told you. Marina says, yeah. Sorry. I know its private. But she was there and wanted to know more. I didn't waste my energy on being mortified so I ask, and. Is it true. Did you know Wagner too. She nervously answers, I'll be honest. I don't know. I have only Wagner twice, and it was a social events. I ask, so there were no missions that involved Wagner.

Marina says, I didn't say that. I ask in haste, what do you know then. She answers, look. Shadows work in pairs. There are at most two working at any given time. Kind of important to keep low profile so we can't really move in groups. So if David met Wagner, he could have done with others. I get annoyed, who then. She says, no idea. We keep secrets within ourselves too. Us apprentices don't even know each other identities until we become graduates.

I ask, does Blake knows then. Marina becomes suspiciously quiet then. My heart beats faster and I remain in heavy anticipation. She says, I don't think he knows too. I mean, if he knows Wagner, he would have told you. Wouldn't he. And from what I saw a week ago, when we were with David, he didn't know this about Wagner. My fist tighten up. This is just great. Just how screwed up is this. I get angry knowing they both don't know Wagner. I ask, are you lying to me. Did David put you up to this.

She sighs, look. I get you are angry at David. So I am not going to make things worse. Would I lie to you. Yeah, sometimes. Mostly about Shadows though. But if I know more about Wagner, I would tell you. I promise that. I couldn't tell if she was lying or covering for David. However something tells me she was telling me the truth. I ask, then do you believe him. That my brother wasn't a good person. Tell me he lied about that. Marina bit her lip and pauses for a moment.

She was probably being considerate of me. I say, please. Just tell me he was lying to you. She says, I don't know. That’s the truth. He didn't tell us anything specific. But, she makes a quick peek behind the group of people, I think there is something not right. My heart plunge into despair and anger, how can you say that. My brother was the most powerful Medrone. He was the role model for everyone. I grabbed Marina's arm in frustration. She lightly pushes me off, jeez. You need to calm down Vanessa.

I was being rude to her. But I didn't care. She says, I don't want to be in this position. But if am going to pick someone to trust, I am going to trust David. He has kept many things, sure. But that’s just because we are Shadows. And his job is all about using knowledge. I don't think he would lie about this. I mean, what would be the point. I answer, jealously. What else. He wants to be like my brother. Marina says, yeah, I don't think so. I get even angrier. I know many people who envy my brother. I say, David took the deal because Charles couldn't defeat my brother. He wants to prove he is stronger than him.

Marina thinks about it for a moment. Then she says, I don't want to seem insensitive to you. But, how is that wrong. Anyone at his position would be tempted to try and beat someone who gave the crown a challenge. I know I would. I couldn't believe what I am hearing. I need to make her understand, he is lying to everyone about Wagner. That’s what wrong. Marina asks, so you think even Charles was lying. I nod vigorously. She sighs, I really don't like being in middle of this. But I mean, do you honestly have no doubt. Not even a second about your brother.

I shake my head with resolve. Marina was getting impatient with me. She then mutters, god. It was right in front of me all this time, how in the hell did I never notice this. I get furious, what does that mean. She says, I think you should talk to Blake. He is better at this stuff than me. And you already know my answer. I am not blinding trusting David, but I am at least giving him the benefit of doubt. I hope you can do that to. I'll send Blake to you, so wait a second. After giving me this advice, she left me alone for a while.

My heart is in turmoil. Marina has bought into this nonsense too. This is so ridiculous its almost funny. Not many know Wagner personally since most of those who know him are dead or were too young. And the ones who do seem to be close to him say he wasn't a good person. I am so mad at them. Its infuriating that I can't let this go either. Siera has been trying to convince me that it shouldn't matter anymore. But it does to me. I have looked up to him all this time. Trying to fill the hole he left by staying back in Medrine. I idolized him, trying to be like him. What would say it about me if this was true.

In the middle of my anger thoughts, I hear Blake approaching me. He seems concerned about me. He asks, Vanessa. Maybe you should go back home. Take some rest. I ignored his plea, tell me about Wagner. Marina said you all have missions separately. So did you have one with David. He says, so that's what Marina called me here. He takes a moment to himself and says, I have met Wagner few times publicly. Like I told you some years ago. But I don't know him well enough to become acquaintance. I don't know if this makes sense, but even though I didn't know him personally, I finally learned truth about him.

I take a step towards him in frustration, tell me they are all lies. Wagner didn't kidnap children then. He says, I don't know anything about that thing. That was all Wagner. I get annoyed, you said you weren't sure of that. But now you do. What lies did David said to you. Blake gets a little louder with me, just stop this Vanessa. He gives me a intimidating expression. He says, you need to stop assuming David is lying all the time. That’s not true. What he has is knowledge that he keeps from us. Most of them for good reasons.

I yell, you believe him then. My brother, who has been always good to me and others. He was lying all this time. I don't believe it. He says, you don't have to convince others of it. Don't you get it. Cass told me what David said. Your problem isn't about Wagner. You keep making about him, but its about you. He might have been good, or maybe bad. Or maybe he just a person. Who can do mistakes. Just like anybody. I am so mad at this because I know he was right. But every fiber in my brain is telling me they are all wrong. What's going on here. I am so conflicted that it is giving me a headache.

Blake says, I don't like how David handled things with you. But I agree with him saying that past is the past. We should learn from it, not obsess over it. And he is currently the last to person to say that. His PTSD stems from the past. You need to learn to let it go. I say, I can't. I just can't. He won't even tell me how he knows Wagner. Was he in the Shadows. Is that you all know him. He asks, what did David tell you. I answer, he didn't confirm or deny it. He sighs, typical. But even if he was one, how would that help you. Hypothetically, if he was one, that means he didn't tell you about it. How does that makes you feel about him. You precious brother, who already kept his overdrive a secrete from you.

That stung me. My throat get stuck and I couldn't form any words. I never thought about it like this. This creates a whole new mix of emotions in me. Blake says, you heard it from David, Marina and me. You know where we all stand in this matter. I don't to us to keep arguing about this. And I know it looks like we all are being against you, but its not true. Whatever Wagner was like, he was still your brother. Its natural your feeling be different from us. We can agree to disagree and move on. Or you can keep wanting to make us villains.

His word cut me even deeper. All 3 of them said it differently, but their intention were the same. I should move on. But I can't let it go. I can't tolerate anyone speaking ill of Wagner. But its almost like a sickness now. Blake says, this isn't your fault. Its natural that you love your brother. But understand this, this isn't our fault either. Sure as hell its not Davids. He turns his back to me and leaves me consumed with confusion and guilt. I came here hoping to they back me. But it didn't happen. Blake seems even more sure about Wagner's so called hidden side more than Marina. Wagner definitely has same connection to them.

I stayed alone for a long time, hoping I could calm myself down. But when that didn't really help I thought of going back home. I would only make others uncomfortable by others. But I also didn't want to be alone, without Siera right now. I would only spiral down even more. So I made a painful decision of sitting with them. When I approached them, their discussion stops abruptly and stare at me. Their eyes showed pity towards me. I felt so ashamed at my behavior. These are my friends and the people I work with daily. I just hope they don't ask me things.

I take the empty chair beside Siera. She gives a consoling look and then faces back others, as I was saying, these are the stories I heard. Matt says, damn. How much are they true. Marina scoffs, not telling. He makes a snarl, come on. At least tell us you weren't involve in the incident in Lititana. I vaguely remember about the city's government disbandment. It had to be you guys. The place became a ghost city in two days. Blake says, you should ask David. Because we are not going to disclose anything. Cass says, oh we will. Trust me, he ran off before I could ask anything. I have about a hundred questions for him. Catherine scoffs, try a million of them. I still find it unbelievable that you two never realized it. She eyes Marina more than Blake.

Marina gives a depressing laugh, I told you before, he was more careful with me. Whenever he came by our house, he acted clueless about our Kuret around me and my family. But during our Shadow training, he helped me with my charms construction, despite not being having knowledge of Kuret. That kind of makes it difficult for anyone to think it was him. Catherine asks, and you guys never tried to find each others identities. This made Marina and Blake more nervous than anybody thought. Even in my emotional state I could tell they were hiding it.

Blake says, so here's the deal with our generations Shadows. We didn't know who they were, but David told us about them. Siera says, but you won't tell us. Blake nods, if I believed that knowing that would help anyone, even like finding peace, I would tell. I rather not create more problems. Marina says, I feel the same. Though, I think its okay to tell one of our fellow Shadow's whole bloodline is gone, along with them. That stings me a lot.

Siera says, that is sad news. Blake says, it is. And David confirmed their deaths in person. So, he turns to Matt, no new Shadows will pop up unfortunately. A disappointed Matt looks to the sky. Catherine asks, but about older generation's Shadow. You said David knows them too. So you know too right. Maybe someone survived as well and have been in hiding. Marina says, it’s a wishful thinking. If they were someone, they would surely approach us by now. But none have. Blake says, all the previous generation are gone at least. Siera asks, David?

He nods without giving any further explanation. The air becomes thick with suspense. I wasn't paying attention to much of their discussion from here on. How could I. They were all now talking about different possibilities. What happens to David's after this PTSD treatment, the Shadow's boast in ranks and his fight with Charles. I zoned out for most of their discussion. I still heard them, but I was non responsive. I am grateful to others not bothering to check on me. I am painfully aware of their wary eyes on me.

Cass question pulls me out of my funk, isn't it getting late. Its already been more than hour. Didn't his doctor tell how long will it take. Blake says, no idea. Marina says, I don't think it will take whole night. Matt says, I know this is terrible timing, but I am getting hungry. Cass pulled me in on my way to dinner. Catherine asks, yeah. Me too. Shall we take a break and come back later? Blake says, you all can leave if you want to. Me and Marina will stay behind. I felt a little better knowing we are possibly leaving. I am not in a shape to worry about David right now. Though, I am now a little concerned after listening to others.

All the time I have been mad at David, but he undergoing some weird treatment. I didn't have much spare thoughts to worry about that. Most of it were frustration towards him. Cass says, I'll stay back too. I don't want to leave. At least not until I get some news. Matt looks at the time, I guess we can wait a little longer. Siera says, lets give it about another 20 minutes. And so they decided stay longer. I am so mentally exhausted and wanted to

leave. But I had no courage to voice my sole opinion.

And there was another brief discussion about different topics. 10 minutes went by and we still didn't have any news. But that’s when we all heard a explosion. That shock made us jar and stood up. My mind which had become numb come alive again. Marina screams, what the hell. She already produces a Kuret charm towards the source of the blast. David's house. Matt shouts, shit. Blake already brought his Kuret around and dashed towards the broken deck.

I tell Siera, stay back. She nods and gestures me to go ahead. I ran fast behind the others. The explosion was big, but there was no fire. Once I came close I saw the wall broken and from the debris a lone figure standing. Blake shouts from ahead, David is that you. It had to be him. I heard Drew yelling out, restrain him quickly. A cold shiver ran though my body. What just happened. Did the treatment went sideways. There was strange laugh coming from around us. It took a second to realize it was David.

Marina shouts, what's the hell is going on. Suddenly David's Kuret surrounds us. It instantly fills up the air around the ground. I bring out my Kuret on my arms and defend myself with wind. Blake shouts, David what are you doing. Then the black mass of Kuret from the middle shoots straight up in the sky. I gasp when I realize David just fly off into the sky dead straight. Marina shouts, the freak is going on. Drew comes rushing out coughing up, thank god you are all still here.

Blake screams, what happened. Where is he going. Drews cuts him off, just get him back immediately. She pulls out a small injection device from her coat pocket, quickly before there is any permanent damage. I shout out, what do you mean. Drew shouts back, no time to explain. She hurries back inside the room. Blake says, shit. Marina, go after him. I yell, I am faster. But Marina didn't wait to listen. She already had made a bunch of Kurets charms and blasted off in pursuit.

Catherine comes beside, help her. I saw his faced covered with blood. I didn't wait any longer. I gather wind around my feet and fly into the dark night. I add bursts of fire to my tail and accelerate faster. David and Marina weren't far. In fact I could see David is slowing. I catch up to Marina quickly as the wind around me glides me faster. Marina throws a charm towards David and it turns into a massive web around David.

I hear David saying something, but I couldn't make out what in this speed. But David's Kuret was different than normal. The charm web Marina threw disintegrates before it could wrap around him. Marina throws a bunch of her charms. I realize she isn't close enough for her charms to physically reach him. There is no other choice. I had to be use force. I prepare a fireball in my right hand. It slowed my ascend, but I launched it anyways. Marina saw me throwing it and threw her own Kuret into my fire.

The fire immediately picked up speed hits David. The fire explodes into a blast and it envelopes him inside. I can't believe Marina made it this lethal. But my concern was not needed. The fire dissipates and I see David falling back down unharmed. Now that I see him closer, I saw his form. He was covered from head to toe in his Kuret armor. It was dense and up close I could feel its moving around him like how my electricity moves on my skin. But the explosion broke his Kuret armer and exposed parts of his body. Marina grabs on David with a restraint charm and starts to descend back down.

I stop my own climb and follow them behind from above. As we gradually go back down my eyes fall on his face. It was covered in blood. I felt shivers in my gut. What the freak did this therapist to do David. But what's even strange is that I could hear him laughing. He didn't appear to be in pain, but that bleeding coming from his face didn't match his voice. He was laughing hysterically. I hear Marina shouting at him to wake up. Soon we were close to the ground. Then David decides to act up again and creates a Kuret blast around us. This Kuret attack was so strong it physically hit us. Marina's Kuret broke and her charms on her legs disappear. David gets away from her grips and launched himself straight into the ground.

I wanted to dive and get him, but Marina was momentarily not without her Kuret and we were dangerously close to ground. I decided to head towards Marina first since she was closer. She was flailing a little in the air, regaining her balance with another charm. I grabbed one of her arm and she levels straight up. She creates a large Kuret charms around us, cushioning our fall. We both land softly on the ground. I look towards David, but he falls faster from the force of his own Kuret. The impact unearths a grass and dirt around the place.

Once Marina and I stand on out feet again, I ask, you good. I let go her arm. She nods frantically, thanks. David momentarily broke my Kuret access. I have never seen him do this before. Others gather around the small crater where David fall. He was still lying on the ground. But his own Kuret acted as a physically broke his fall and he didn't appear to be hurt. But what's crazier is that he was laughing like a maniac. Catherine rushes to us, David. What the hell is wrong with you.

David raises his one arms to us and gives a thumbs up saying, that was awesome. I give it a ten. Lets do it again. Matt shrieks, dudes' lost it. Cass shouts back to the house, Drew. What the hell did you to him. David slowly picks himself up. But his movements are sluggish. His Kuret has formed into rings and spirals over his body. This is the same form he had when he was fighting Charles. This if my first time seeing up close, but I can felt his Kuret is humming with power.

Cass shouts, David. What happened to you. David faces us properly now. But then we finally saw the damage Drew was talking. It wasn't just his face was covered in blood. He was bleeding from his eyes, noes, mouth and ears. I shout, you are hurt. Let us get you help. He scoffs waving his hand around us. He suddenly stumbles a little to his side, hell no. Why should I leave now. You all are here, so it’s a party now. He is gone mad and spouting nonsense. Marina slaps her head, freak. Drew messed up his head.

Behind me Blake came running. He shouts, you are bleeding too much. Stop this. He raises his palm, showing the same injection device Drew just had. He walks gradually to David, but David just unleashes a blast of Kuret with his palm raised to us. I immediately ducked to my side, escaping the barrage of physical Kuret over my head. I was right to dodge it, because this wasn't just meta physical. His Kuret was physical in nature now. Cass guards Matt with her own Kuret body.

Blake grabbed Catherine and Siera out of the way. Marina created a charm to defend herself. It cracks a little but she managed to keep it intact despite the pressure. I shout, someone grab him quickly. Cass runs jumps towards him, you freaker. You finally lost your mind. Mel had taken over now. She ran with an arm extended for a punch. David glees like a child shouting, hell yeah. That’s more like it. Mel lands a blow from below. David didn't even try to dodge it. His Kuret gather around his leg and he blocks her with his knee. The impact makes a large sound.

Mel didn't hold back, but somehow David wasn't blown away. Mel shouts, you little shit. Mel went for another punch. But David lost his footing on his one leg and falls on his ass on the ground. Mel fist passes in the air. David chuckles, that was a good punch. I call it a solid seven. I should return one though. He joins his hands and throws a Kuret blast. Mel brings her arms around her arm. Normally she should have been able to tank it. But something was wrong. The black Kuret shove her backwards into the air.

I saw Cass's face. I immediately ran behind her and catch her before she falls on the ground. I grab Cass's back and ask worried, are you all right. Just like with Marina, David's attack broke Cass's Kuret connection. She was back to her self now. She blinks hard, what happened. How did he do that. I grit my teeth. This is bad. David's kuret attacks have gotten stranger. Matt saw Cass with me and was relieved to see her okay. He shouts, Cass, is it you. She nods in confusion.

Matt then sprints off to David. Marina runs behind him, wait. Matt don't. Matt yells, you need to wake up. David stands back again, hey Matt. Great, is it your turn now. I see Matt using Cass's Kuret. He must have copied hers just now. Matt went jumps up in the air and goes for a high kick. David nonchalantly grabs his ankle on contact with his Kuret covered hands. He was pushed back slightly. But it wasn't enough to topple him. He pushes back Matt and he lands on his feet. David laughs, that’s was a six. You can do better though. Marina joins Matt from the side screaming, Blake hurry.

I saw Blake running from the side. I decided to join him. Blake says, restrain him. David raises his arms enjoying the chaos, yes. This is more like it. Lets see who is the strongest now. He wasn't moving all the entire time. But he finally makes his move. He rans straight at Matt and Marina. Marina waves her hand around to create a bunch of Charms. David crouches down while running and then speeds up suddenly. It was the same speed he showed in the match. He zips past Marina, breaking her charms before they are created completely.

He then stand up in front of a terrified Matt. He shows his bloody teeth, hey Matt. Want to know a secret. Matt throws a punch in response. David catches his arm by the elbows and restrains him. David says, I am a Shadow. Always have been. How crazy is that. Matt cries, yeah, no shit man. David then twists around with roundhouse kick straight at Matt's chest. Matt's Kuret protected him, but he went flying straight into the air. Marina jumps to the air behind him to catch him before he hits the ground. She also realized his Kuret connection is broken.

Ahead me Blake halts his approach and signals me to do the same. I ask, what. He yells, everyone. Stay back. Only me, Marina or Vanessa will go near him. Its too dangerous for others. David makes disapproving voice, tsk. Blake, no one likes a party pooper. Then suddenly he coughs, and more drops of blood comes out it. I can't believe he is not even acknowledging his own condition. He shows his teeth, what's this. He laughs. I shout, you are bleeding dammit. You need help.

He barks, nah. This is not blood. This is proof of my power. He raises his fist like it was some victory. Blake whispers to me, you go in front, I will go from behind. I nod and we both rush ahead. David wasn't even paying attention to us. He was in his zone. When I came close, I gather electricity on my hands. He finally saw our approach. Blake levitates straight at him with his Kuret grabbing David. David's Kuret flair in response and he tries to break out of the restraints. Unlike others, Blake was putting in more dense Kuret. David couldn't break it off completely.

I used this opportunity to get in closer with my palm raised to him. If I just come in contact with him, I can produce a small jolt current to knock him out. But before I could, David yells out aloud and his Kuret armor expands outwards. Shit. It was his dome. The dense Kuret comes in between me and him. And the pressure from the force made me stop my assault. David chuckles while stumbling a little. But unlike me, Blake thrusted forward and pushed David from behind.

He drags him from away from me and pushes him into the ground. I thought this would finally wake him up. But David wasn't even fazed by this. He says, finally. That’s was a crisp nine. Blakes puts a knee on his back and keeps him restraint, sorry David. But you are making it hard for us. David yells, I don't mind. But I prefer being stomped by her. What do you think, Vanessa. He has the gall to be sadistic while eyeing me. Blake then frantically pats himself on his jacket pocket, where the hell is it.

I realized he dropped the injector somewhere. I look around the place, but David's Kuret was blocking a lot of the vision. David laughs, I knew you were trying to kill my buzz. I knocked it out from your hand earlier. Good luck finding it now. This insane person. Even inhibited he was himself. I shout, guys. Find that injector. David clicks his tongue, nah. I am still enjoying this. You can't take away my fun. He raises his arms from the ground and snaps his fingers. It took a moment to understand what he did. But I was too late to do anything. I hear something being crushed.

Blake grabs David's head and pins him on the ground, what did you do. Even with his face mushed into the ground, I can hear his laughs. Suddenly the dense Kuret around him sucks back into David. The Kuret grabs Blake from behind and tried to pull him away. But Blake wasn't going to give in. He fueled his own Kuret to stop from being pushed back. He yells to others, someone get Drew. She must have another on of it. I rush towards Blake and gather ice around my palm.

David couldn't stop me from covering his back with my ice. The cool chill creates vapors on his body. Blake says, yeah. We will keep him immobilized like this. I nod and shout, where is she. Catherine shouts, I see her. Marina is running with Drew from the house. But that’s not all coming from the house. Two large figures appear behind Drew. They were 10 feet tall and slim. A moment later I realize they were robots. They had six arms on its torso and

a cubical shaped head. The bots were running on four legs like a spider. What the hell are they. The robots rush in ahead and began spraying a gas around us.

I didn't feel any Kuret mixed in the gas, so I think this is some sort of knockout gas. David felt it too. His voice rises, but he was not going anywhere when me and Blake are pinning him down. I thought it was finally over, but David wasn't done. He moves his Kuret around like a storm, creating a small hurricane. I let go of my icy grip and tried to counter my own wind tornado to stop his Kuret. But I didn't have time to build it strong enough. His Kuret slowly clears the gas around us.

I yell, Blake, just knock his ass out. He isn't going to stop. Blake was covers his Kuret on his arm for a blow to David's head. But Drew loud voices reaches us, don't hurt his head. You will do irreversible damage to him. Blake halts before he had a chance to throw down his hand. He yells, then what I do. Before Drew could answer, David found the opportunity when we are distracted. He gathers enough Kuret around him and drags away from below us. Blake grabs him with his Kuret. David threw a wave of Kuret at Blake and me. We both held our ground, but David used the force to propel himself away and creates some distance from us.

He uses his Kuret to support himself and stands up. His face is covered in dirt and blood. I think his nose was broken. He should be in pain, but he was having the time of his life. He was raised his arms in joy, yeah. This is great. I am finally enjoying the thrill of a fight. Don't you just love it. There is no reason to him anymore. Blake steps beside me. I ask him, any ideas. He shouts back at Drew, why can't we just knock him out. Drew wasn't listening to him though. She was speaking something to her tablet.

The bots behind her take a stand. All twelve arms pointed at David. Blake gestures me to clear out of the way. I step aside and let the robots do whatever they are doing. Marina had a charm running and pointed at David, make it fast, Drew. I sense he his loosing too much blood. Drew shouts, do it now M. The robots had some sort of dart guns attacked on their mechanical arms. David says, bring it on. The robots fire some small projectiles. But they never came in contact with David. His small Kuret dome was protecting him like a cocoon. The darts suspends in the air. David makes a show of plucking them from the air and says, this is a mediocre three.

Blake yells, Drew. She shrieks, I know, I know. The bots fired another round of darts at David. But none where doing anything. David begins to wobble a little. Like a drunk person. But he was still not going down. He says, woops. More blood pours from his eyes now. My fist tightens harder. This is no good. I can't just wait for him to bled out. I ran at him. Blake says, wait Vanessa. I didn't care. As much I am odds David right now, I don’t want him to die on me. I thought he would focus on me. But he turns his back and gazes into the ground.

The ground shook and a huge snake appeared from below. But before it could wrap itself around David, David already jumped into the air. He throws his Kuret around the snake and it gets pinned in the ground. David lands on top of the snack and gives a pose like he was climbing a mountain. He says, I give it a seven for ingenuity. The snake begins to transform back to Catherine. She had tried a sneak attack on David, but he saw her coming. Just how cognizant is he right now.

I rush faster with a fire ball ready. Instead of throwing a multiple smaller shot, I prepare to throw it like a flamethrower. It was a little extreme, but I need to stop him before he breaks down. David was focused on defending against the darts and pinning Catherine. He can't stop this. I throw my fire and it hits dead center in his Kuret dome. He was strong, but his focus was divided. The force was enough to push him away and he was flung into the air.

I shout, this is our chance. Blake was already on the move. So was Marina. They both flew to the robots and yanked their dart guns from their arms. They then flew back to us. David was now lying on the ground with his Kuret dome much smaller now. This fire was strong enough to burn him. But he was still laughing. He says, that’s was a twenty. Awesome. Its a shame we never fought in the tournament. He uses his Kuret to get up. I went into check on a coughing Catherine. I slouch down and help her up.

She was half naked since she had to ditch her clothes to transform. She had covered herself in violet fur to hide her skin. I ask, you good. She gives me a subtle nod, forget about me. Just stop him. David walks towards with slow steps. He was gathering his Kuret behind him, like a raging fire in wind. I can't believe he is this reckless. Marina just said he is loosing blood. But the currently insane David was enjoying the battle. He says, bring it on guys. I am loving this.

He gathered more of his Kuret around him and it becomes the armer we wore earlier. Blake and Marina zip past us through the air and in a synchronous attack push through his defense. David had no chance of stopping this. They both easily broke through his Kuret defense and grab him. Blake went low to grab his legs and Marina went for his waist. Together they drag David backwards, straight towards were are cars were parked. They crash into the nearest one and it gets crushed under the pressure. I feared a gas tank explosion so I ran behind them.

I immediately prepare ice in my hand and wave it behind them. I shower the cars with my icy wind as I wave my palm around. I didn't see any fuel leaking. But I still kept showering my ice around as a precaution. Blake stabs David on his thing with a dart and Marina stabs another on his neck. David eyes were covered in so much blood he had closed it. Yet he was grinning. He says, that was a hundred. You guys rock. He then winces in pain, I will get you next time.

They both let him go as he slumps on the distorted metal car frames. Marina slaps his cheeks lightly, there is no next time you crazy jerk. David finally stops his movement and his Kuret retreats back into him. His voice comes out like a whisper, this feels great. Blake says, you are out of your mind. He replies, pain is good. Means I am alive. Just what happened to him. Finally his Kuret goes away completely. He was barely clinging to his consciousness now. He mumbles, I told you Wagner, I will be better than you.

What is he dreaming about. I know its inappropriate time, but I needed to know. I ask, what do you mean. Wagner? He says, that guy sucks. I prefer her sister. What is he even saying. But I couldn't get anything more from him. He is finally succumbs to the sedative and is unconscious now. Marina yells, we should get to him to the hospital. Blake says, how are they going to help him. This seems completely different kind of problem. Marina yells, we can't just let him bleed. Behind us Drew runs. She struggles while running. Did she hurt during the explosion.

Siera came from the side and helped her. She approaches us, give me second. We give her space to check on David. She waves a device around David's face. She asks, M. Hurry. M says, scanning complete. He has a concussion. The sedative is working, its coagulating his blood vessels. I didn't understand the meaning, however Drew lets out a relieved sigh. She then lightly pats a sleeping David chest. She the continues waving the scanner around his neck and other body parts.

Blake asks, mind telling us what the freak just happened. I ask, he wasn't even himself anymore. Marina add, I have never seen anyone enjoy himself while bleeding from every orifice in his face. Others finally catches up to us. Catherine collected her clothes and walks with Matt and Cass. Cass asks worried, what did you to him. Drew was more focused on completing her inspection. M says, boss has 3 cracked ribs, a hairline fracture in left arm and a cracked femur bone. No internal bleeding.

I ask, what about his bleeding outside? Just look at his face. Drew says, he is going to be fine. We made it in time. She stand up slowly. Blake grabs David slowly from the crushed car. He uses his Kuret to make sure David doesn't fall. I ask, careful. Blake says, I got him. But what do I do with him now. Drew says, take him to the basement. He has a nano bot tank there. I grab the other side of David around my shoulder. We both carry him back to his house. Marina asks, what went wrong with the treatment. He behaved like he was high on some drugs.

Now that the David's rampage is over, she finally tells us, he was actually high. This was a side effect I didn't anticipate. I know it looks like a disaster. But it wasn't a failure. It was a success.

David (Chapter 97)

Wednesday, February 18, 2026 11:11

This is your brilliant idea. I thought she was just messing with me. But her stern face told she was not messing with me. My jaw hangs loose, you want me to do acid. And this, I point to another beaker kept on the table, this looks like shrooms. This is your radical and experimental treatment. Sorry to break your bubble, but this is sort of thing many humans already do. Sometimes more than a few times in a day. She sighs, you really think it that's simple. I face down on the other vials. They were giving different glimmers and few are probably chemical compounds that are harmful to humans.

She says, I didn't say it was ingenuous. I said it was untested because this brew of psychedelics don't work on Medrones and Humans will definitely die after an OD. You are in rare thin zone where we might have a possibility of unlocking your subconscious. I gulp a little trying to wrap my head around it. I grab a beaker and analyze the blue gel, and what is this. Doesn't seem like a typical consumable drug. She answers, a formulae that will lit up your amygdala, the part of the brain that. I answer, controls emotions and responses. She nods, that's right. But more importantly, processes fear too.

I put it back on the table. I felt a little anxious facing my own fears. She picks up her tablet, the drugs will lower your mental guard. The subconscious prevents you to look at your self objectively. We are going to break through that and I will guide you in REM sleep through the maze, which is your mind. I hesitantly ask, so technically this is a deep hypnosis visual memory therapy, but for a Medrone. She is a little impressed by my insight, looks like some has been doing their homework. She points me to the display screens we setup around us, it's called a deep trance. Ideally, it is aided with just vision, sound and sense. But you are different.

I say, because of my Medrone nature. She says, that's a part of it sure. But I am talking about your brain ability's to process thoughts. I say, you can just its because I am a genius. She smirks, I was talking in terms of biology and physiology, but sure. Yeah, your neurons faster than average Medrones. And as you already guessed it, it also means your subconscious will not make it easy to uncover the crux of your memories. I get what is happening now. I answers, those drugs are going to inebriate me enough that I my brain will not wake me up. She says, exactly. We need your neural activity to get low, but not too low.

I look around the bunch of injections she setup earlier from the vials. I say, I am guessing the risk is this massive amount of drugs. She picks up one injector device, I had to work up a balance of psychedelics and make it safe for you to consume. However, as I have been saying. Its completely unprecedented. I am good at this stuff, but not that good to anticipate what kind of side effects it will have. In worst case you will OD and suffer a brain stroke. I take the couch prepared for me and sat in it nervously.

I look around the equipment she had with her, an EKG, a neural activity scanning using a modified live MRI and a blood dialysis machine. The last one is to probably to regulate the amount of drugs in my system. I finally grasp the severity of this situation. This is not a novel treatment, but a different process. Drew designed it specifically for me. I sigh, you know, I told everyone I had faith in you. But I am a little terrified now. She says, its perfectly natural. I would be worried if you aren't scared. You should be wary of the risks.

It took a few minutes for me to think this through, but I had no choice. I already decided to see through whatever this was. I say, lets get started then. She takes a seat beside me, you sure. Once we start, there is no turning back. We only got one shot to do this. Dozing such heavy synthesized into your bloodstream more than once will negatively effect your heart and kidney. The damage from this one session can be reversed in time, but only once. Suffice to say there will be no do over. She made sure I understand the risks. My confidence is waring like a needle in a campus that has lost its directions. I gave her weak nod regardless of my hesitance.

She says, I got the patients consent. She grabs the blue gloves and puts it on. With dexterous movements she begins to mix in the compounds into a single beaker. While she did that I hooked up myself with bunch of wired sensors around my head where she had marked my skin. M says the nano sensors inside my body will not be able to accurately function with copious amount of drugs in my veins. So need to attach physical sensors. A majority of them are on my face and temple. I removed my shirt and place few on my chest and abdomen. Drew says, keep that here. She points me at the exact position. I say, but that's not my heart. That's probably.

She answers, your lungs. Unlike Humans, your lungs functions differently. I need to monitor that much closely. I don't know if its possible, but your brain might forget how to breathe. If that ever happens, I will manually inflate with air. Besides, we need to monitor your heart more closely. She pulls out a long, thin needle with a device attached at the other end. I make a scowl, don't tell that is going where I think it is. She nods, unfortunately yes. I need more than just your heartbeats. I will stick this through one of your valve. I never imagined it had to be this invasive.

And now it makes sense why she brought straps with her. She was going to restrain me in the recliner chair so that I don't jerk around and tear an artery or a vein in my heart. I sigh, do me a favor. Stick that after I am buzzed. I don't want to see it sticking it out of my chest. She smiles, don't worry. I can't do this while you are awake anyways. It will hurt. My stomach feels colder imagining it piercing my heart. But I had to tough it out. She rubs a gel around me and puts some more sensors on my torso.

She says, all done. She brings up a beaker and holds it in front of me. This isn't what she was mixing. I ask, what is this green liquid. She says, a rejection suppression booster. You have a transplanted heart, don't you. Doing hardcore pharmaceuticals is already risky, but doing this is on a transplanted patient is dangerous. This will help with maintaining your heart. I am curious though, its been years since the operation. And I been through much worse than doing drugs. Why do think it will cause an issue.

She takes a moment to her herself. She then says, honestly. You are right. Your heart is yours now. But I found some irregularities in your x-rays this week. I lean my head back up, seriously, like what. I have been taking care of my health this whole year. And M never said anything about it. She says, I don't know what it is. But the cardiomyocytes have unnaturally high fibroblasts. Now, its entirely possible it was necessary during that operation. I says, I know I am not a heart surgeon, but I read up later that its not really a bad thing. She says, neither am I one. And yeah, it shouldn't cause a problem. In fact, I say your doner had a strong and healthy heart.

I recalled memories of Liz. I told Drew about her and she knows about the contrasting nature of her physiology. A weak body, but a strong heart. She says, still, a strong heart doesn't equate to strong resistance to drugs. This is a harmless precaution. I am only raising your tolerance with this. I lean back on my seat. I know she is covering all the bases, but this wasn't the best time to remind me of Liz. I ask, what were the chances if it was my actual heart. Less than ideal? She says, don't think like that. Not right now. We make hypothesis, not second guess ourselves. The one thing I learned from running and hiding on Earth. You can't control everything. You do what you are dealt with.

I take her advice and the beaker. I raise it to her, well, here's to taking control to what I can. I drank it without thinking about the taste, which was horrible. I chugged it all the way before any gag reflex kicks in. I cough a little putting the empty glass away, you couldn't inject me this instead. She chuckles, I could have. But its better for your body to not absorb it immediately. She speaks to her tab, M, you are on. M says, starting the timer. I am guess they are going to time it so that the effectiveness is at its peak.

She finishes her final preparations with the drugs, I say, you know. This is my first time doing acid or weed. I make a nervous laugh seeing her fit a small vial into a injector. She places it beside the table. She then setups the monitoring devices. While booting them she says, really? That's surprising. Given your long stretched history of hospitalization, it wouldn't be unreasonable to think you got hooked on it. I answer, I never enjoyed the numbness. I tried as much less morphine I could have. Around the second year, I began researching the same statistics you summarized. I had no intension of becoming a junkie.

She laughs, bold move from a small kid. I reply, I didn't have my memories, but I was still trained tactically. She says, that makes sense. The rumors of shadow training are intriguing. I know where she was going with this. I say, I hope you are not drugging me to get info out of me. She gives me a sly smile, the thought did occur to me once. She places a metallic ring around my forehead, the one to monitor my neural activity. She says, but don't worry. The whole goal of this is to make you cognizant enough to talk through the memory. And even though you want to change your habit of keeping secrets, we aren't talking about sharing private thoughts.

She was implying something else too. I think she meant about the people I still haven't told her about. I told her about Wagner, Brandon and Zakerine. But not about John, Hansen, Istra, Slater or the other Shadow personals. Maybe even about my feelings towards a certain angry girl. She caught me looking worried. She says, I know its uncomfortable. I will try not to intrude too much. However. I nod, there is good possibility I will slip up and tell you things. She lays her arms on her knees, I won't deny that. But we are way past that point. I hope I have enough of your trust from spending these months together.

I sigh, not like I have a choice. And I am sorry for making you complicit. When I say the wrong thing, I don't want you to be responsible for it in anyway. She puts her arm on my elbows, I appreciate your concerns for me. But I completely aware of what I signed up for. I know the risks, so don't have to worry about me. She pauses for a second, I used to believe that you would definitely cause problems for me. But thanks to you, I have recognized that I can't really change myself. I like being a doctor. I hesitantly ask, and is that a good thing? She nods, it is. But enough about me. You focus on just yourself now. I can't deny she has been invaluable to me.

She takes my arm and wraps a hard rubber band around my biceps. Near the joint she finds a vein. She taps my skin few times. With a slow movement, a needle gets pricked in that spot and blood starts to pour out into the tube. She says, you barely reacted to it. I answer, I have a lot of experience with needles, unfortunately. She turns towards the display, M, start us off with the phase one. M says, need confirmation from boss. She picks up the injector from the table and waits for my call.

I close my eyes and settle my thoughts. I have tried to suppress all the different kind of emotions I have been going. The argument with Vanessa and the guilt of lying to her. I have been purposefully keeping it aside, but I can feel it consuming me again. I focus on my breathing. I can't tell how long I took to settle, but Drew was patient with me. She was sitting beside me, not moving a muscle and letting me do my thing. I was grateful for that. I get my courage back, do it.

M says, phase one initiated. The lights go off around me and it turns dark for a second. Drew puts on her goggles which had a display in it to track my vitals and share any readings. Drew says, this is your last chance. She places the injector near my neck. She waits till I assure her of this. I start breathing hard with my mouth and I gave a nod to her. She takes that sign and pushes the needle to my skin. Upon contact a warm and strange shiver went down my spine. I can't tell if its from the cocktail of drugs or just nerves acting up.

She pulls it away, its going to be administered in intervals. We can't risk introducing foreign substances in large quantities. She uncorks the empty vial and replaces the empty one with a new one. I didn't feel any difference, but that's because it hasn't travelled everywhere. She says, we are going to start with slow biaural sounds to relax. She picks up a different injector, this is a mild melatonin. It will help you sleep better with the drugs in your system. She doesn't delays it and injects it on my other neck.

This one I was familiar with and begin feeling the effects immediately. In few minutes my eyes becomes heavy. The sound of sea and other natural earth elements makes my drowsy. Few seconds in, I didn't even realize my eyes were close. I was only hearing and imagining the slow hums of whales or the rain drops in a forest. Soon I was drifting off. I was nowhere now. Everything around me was pitch black, but I didn't feel scared. There was lingering doubts, but I was more relaxed.

Then I hear a voice. A muffled voice that I didn't pay any attention to. But then it grew louder. Its calling a name out in the abys. I couldn't ignore it. Who was it. The voice becomes much clear after a second, David. Can you hear me. The voice jarred me out the trance. I floating body formed a shape and also a voice. Who, I grumble. She says something about phase two. Then my surrounding changes from black to bright. Shades of red and orange. The peaceful noise I was hearing slowly turns into something different. I wanted to go back, but the voice telling me to move ahead. I didn't want to go anywhere, but then I hear sound of fire. Then came noises of things crumbling.

No. Not this. I had on idea where I am, but I could feel myself resisting. The voice says, don't resist. I mumble, I don't want to go there. The voice says, you have nothing to worry about. Just follow my voice. I am here to help. The calm voice help me feel less agitated. And suddenly I am thrusted into a open air. My body feels heavy, like I falling down. I couldn't feel the wind, but I felt the heat. My surroundings take shape and I see blurry things. Like a thin veil around me is obstructing my view. The air is so thick, I feel like I could just grab it.

The voice says, where are you. Describe it to me. My environment is smoldering hot and fire everywhere. The voice says, follow that glow. See where you are. I vaguely felt having a body. But I needed my legs to move. Instantly I felt my legs moving. I suspiciously move around to inspect my surrounding. I saw blue sky, red sky and then dust clouds. Where is this place. A mouth appears on me, I ask, where on Earth am I. Then comes noises of strange animals. Their blurry visions appear in front of me.

Those noises, I heard them before. The voice says, yes. You know where you are. Just say it. A moment later I spoke aloud, Medrine. Everything comes crashing down on me. The blurry image becomes clear and I see streets on fire and trees destroyed. My close my eyes to avert from the destruction. The voice says, don't avoid them. You have to go somewhere. Where is it. Find it. I am so confused, where am I supposed to go. I look around the abandoned street. I recall this road, this city, this planet.

Another wave hits me and I fall down. But I was still standing. This doesn't makes sense. And then everything does, Drew? Her voice comes, yes. David, I am here. I stumble around my shaky surrounding, like I was being dragged in different directions. She says, focus on one thing. Don't get distracted by anything else. I put all my will into one thing, the place I need to go to. Then another wave hits me and pushes me down. But I am standing again, like it never fell down. What is going on.

I say, this is dream. I am dreaming right now. Drew says, good, I thought I lost you for a second. You took a lot of time to remember me. That made me recall everything happening. I mumble, I am not in Medrine. I am on Earth, my house. She says, you are in both place at once. That's not possible. But everything is real around me. Like the fire in that alley, I think I might get burned if I walk past it. Drew says, don't go there. That's your subconscious fighting back. Using your memories to scare you. Don't give in. Just look for the place.

I ask, what place. She replies, the place where it all began. You know where. I tried hard to recall. But I couldn't. She says, that's fine then. Look around you, you will have clues. Clues, huh. This is a dream. Yeah, it makes sense. Actually, no. It really doesn't. But I had no choice. I began lazily walking around the empty road. The debris were all around me, trying to block my path. I had to zig zag my way through it. Drew says, good, you are slow but fast learner. Don't let anything stop you.

I felt encouraged and pushed through. But then a huge tsunami was coming for me. What the hell, I am not anyplace near the shore. Drew didn't advice me on anything. Did she left me alone. I decided to run into a building nearby and take cover beside a pillar. An insane amount of water gushes out into the street and begins to slips inside the building too. I panic and ran inside further. I don't know what this building is. I couldn't even focus on it, but I could vaguely sense the direction. I ran straight ahead until I saw a staircase. I jump on it and began climbing up. The water races behind me, trying to catch me and sweep me away.

Drew was still not with me. But I no longer cared now. I just focused on climbing up. Soon I exited through the top door. I rush out into the open sky and look around. The water tried to seep out, but I pushed the door close before it escapes. I ran around the place looking for any escape, but I couldn't focus on anything. It felt it the scene in front of me is breaking. What's happening. A muted voice looms in the air. I cry out, Drew? Her suppressed voice comes, can you hear me.

I felt relieved to know she was still with me. Want happened, why did she leave. Drew says, your subconscious is pretty stubborn. Its not allowing you to even move freely. I had to adjust the dosage. I recalled what was going on. I recalled that I was being drugged. But for what. Drew says, don't focus on it. Focus on going ahead. But I am stuck on the terrace. There is water everywhere. Hold on. If this is my dream, then I should be able to control everything. Just like that the air around me fixes and the image becomes clear.

Suddenly I am standing on the road again, but there is no flood. The tsunami is gone. Drew says, how do you feel now. I say, darn frustrated. I can't believe I did ran up a building for nothing. She replies, not nothing. You are fighting back, taking control. That's good. I continue walking the debris covered road. I don't have to find a way around it. I just will it and all the broken building parts just vanishes. With nothing to bother me anymore, I cut through the path much easier.

Another obstacle came, a rain of glass shard showers from the above. I try to make it go poof, but it doesn't do anything. The pieces of glass becomes bigger. I needed my Kuret. Wait, why did I say that. What's that. The haze in my head, it feels important. But my immediate problem were the glasses. Then I had an idea, if I can't remove the glass. I can visualize other things. I raise my hands, which became more real to me and I create an umbrella.

It was a weird looking umbrella, it was made purely of black substance. It feels familiar, but I didn't know what it was. The shards fall on me, but I remain unhurt from it. Drew says, well done. Only you would be testing out the defenses of your dream. But a piece of advise. The more you try to control, the harder the fight will be. So look for a middle ground. I felt more of myself now. I continued walking while the pieces of glasses continue to rain on me. But where I am going. The place I need to be. What if I am too far from it. Drew says, this is you dream. Distance means irrelevant. You have looked around, now visualize where you need to be.

I focus on the escaping memories. I can feel I am close. But where. Then a large object approaches in the sky. It makes a big shadow on the ground. Its flying in the sky. The rain stops and my black umbrella vanishes. But now I am facing a grey ship. Its so familiar that I almost can tell what it was. A sense of dread swells up in me. Its them. Drew says, did you find them. I say, it's the Hive. I ran without thinking. I forget all about the sense of direction. The only thing what matters is to get away from here.

But this wasn't a dream. It was a nightmare. Turns out any direction I choose, I am heading straight towards the ship. The ship descends down and few people jump onto the ground. They were wearing some grey metal suit with a gun on each arm. Oh shit. The five people began firing at me. Duck down and cover my head with my arms. The terror grips me hard and I am immobilized. I can't move anymore. Drew says, David. They aren't real. You don't need to fight this. No way I they aren't real. I don't know what to do.

She says, then fight them. You have been fighting them for years. You know their weakness. I have no idea where she is getting her information. I have never fought them. I crouch down even deeper now, like the ground is burying me alive. I can't to this. I am too afraid. Drew was trying to encourage me. But her voice was getting buried with me. This is it. I am going to die. But then suddenly I am thrown back into the air. The next second I am hugging the ground like a caterpillar. I hear a barrage of noise piercing the air above me.

What the hell is going on. I cover my own ears. But my ears were not covered, my hand just goes through it. The noise becomes clear by the second. Its a sound of a machine gun. I peek my head up and see the Hive being pushed back from the hail of bullets. They were firing their own pulse guns at something at my side. The white smoke covers the ground above. As a lone figures appear from it. The long barrel of the machine gun was creating the white smoke.

The person appears in front of me. A completely new emotion comes from me. Confusion of the highest level. The person grins at me, are you going to lie there whole day. Come on. Get up. Its him, its James. He gives extends an arm to me. I was hesitant to take it. He says, hurry up. I don't have enough bullets and you don't have enough lives. I shake off the haziness keeping me down and take his arm. He pulls me up. His face becomes clear. The same stub beard, the same scar on his neck. Eyes that had such hate for aliens. What the hell is going on.

He says, who the hell knows. I am just glad I finally get to kill aliens again. And with so many around, I think I am going to enjoy this. I say, you are dead. He says, tsk, why does that matter. This is nuts. I called for Drew. But there was no response. What the hell happened. Where is she. He says, no one's going to rescue you if we stand here in open. Come on, lets move. He ditches the machine gun and grabs me by my collar. I didn't know I had a collar. I turn down and look at my dress. Its the same as that day. The blood stain on my jacket was there too.

He says, yeah, you remember now. He drags me out of the road we somehow end up in an abandoned half broken building. He leaves my collar and I stumble back to a wall. He smiles as he sees a crate in the middle of them room. He opens the tarp and inside was large cache of weapons. He begins to grab whatever he could. He then finds his favorite shotgun and begins loading the shells. I am bamboozled at this scene. He says, sweet. We got everything now. I couldn't stay silent now, you are dead. I watched you die. He suddenly aims that weapon at me, you mean how you killed me.

I get angry, I didn't kill you. He laughs, that's right. You like specifics. He lowers his weapon and resumes packing up his weapon in his pockets. He says, you didn't save me. Instead you saved the other people. I says, the people you almost blow up. You couldn't let go your revenge. He raises a bazooka on his shoulders, psst. That's ancient history. Besides, I am here now. Ready to whoop some alien ass. This is nuts. I realized something. My dream, my memories and my imagination.

He laughs, correct. You called me to help you. Be happy, I get to save you sorry ass again. I can't believe he was my choice. What was I thinking. He picks up a grenade belt, look at you being choosy. What a hot shot you have grown into. But to me you are still that clueless kid. I grit my teeth, speak for yourself. My freaked up brain decided to take his help. There must be a reason. I walked to the weapon create and begin looking for guns. I found the grenade launcher and the tactical rifle gun. Its the same, the exact same I used when I went raiding with James in that Hive hideout.

He says, this brings back memories. You remember those days. You and me, going around, kicking doors and killing Hives. I remember them now. Its weird how clear those memories are now. Its feels like it were just yesterday when we were bombing the bridge to stop the Hive in the helicopter. James laughs, now that was a good one. That the was moment when I believed our team is going to clean up the city. But then I recalled what happened next. I grab a pistol, if only you weren't consumed by blind rage. You could have saved a lot of people that week.

He loads up his bazooka with a large shell, you know me. I wasn't going to ever help you once I realized you were one of the aliens. I picked up some grenades, then why help me now. I have grown farther away from a Homo Sapiens as possible. You words, if you remember. He chuckles, don't I know it. He stuffs a box of bullets in his belt buckle. He replies, I don't know, maybe I want to try a different way. My hands freeze. I spat, seriously. It took dying for you to try this way. He smiles saying, don't think I am getting soft on you. I don't like any alien. But, he hands me a box of bullet, you are probably the least irritating and tolerable alien.

This is surreal. I know he is just a figment of my imagination. But still, it gives me some twisted sense of empowerment. Besides, I know the real James would never say this stuff. He says, it doesn't matter what he do. The guy died and now is reborn. Wow, my subconscious has morbid sense of humor. He says, but that doesn't mean you can't wish for it. He made some sense. I know what kind of person he was. If it weren't for him, I would have died back then. He shakes his head, never thought I would have to save you again. Can't a guy remain dead in peace.

For the first this thing started, I had a laugh. I say, for you, peace is overrated. I unlock the rifles safety. He grins and give me big smile. He slams his hand on his shotgun, damn straight. Now you are like yourself. Perhaps that's why he is here. To remind me of that and also give me the support. When he was alive he was rude, obnoxious, and held dangerous ideologies. But he was also dedicated, focused and fueled by unshakable determination. The quality I need to need remember.

He pulls a bag out of nowhere and says, stop it. You are being way too sappy. So, are we doing this or not. I replied, freak yeah. I imagined a bag on my shoulders and it appeared. I hug my rifle on the shoulder and grab the grenade launcher. We both instantly transport to a front door. He kicks it open and a fire breaks out. I shout, what's the play. He says, there is a battalion coming from the south and east. We are going to west. You are going to be on my six. And cover the tail. Got it.

It felt good to have him here. We ventured out in a hailstorm of bullets. We both began firing at our targets. A Hive in grey suit and a knives was coming at me. I aimed the launcher at his face and blasted him off. The Hive vaporizes on impact. There were a whole army behind it. But I wasn't scared anymore. I began firing on the crowd while dodging the return fires. The heat from their blasts grazes my body. It should have hurt, but it felt nothing. Its a dream, nothing can hurt me. With that unshakable truth me and James made a run to the west.

We threw grenades, and even reloaded our guns as our assault grew over time. It was crazy that I was reminiscing this feeling. A Hive suddenly came out of nowhere. James grabs me by the arms and drags me down before the blasts hits me. He says, don't just stand looking pretty. Get you head in the game. One wrong move and you are dead. I smile and nod, while also realizing the ridiculousness of the situation. He levels his bazooka on the ground, aimed towards a low level flying cruiser. The missile hits the target and it crashes down in ball of fire.

He removes his pistol and open fires on the Hives coming at from the side. He waves his arm around yelling, hell yeah. This is what I wanted. I am glad you brought me to your planet. Its a open buffet and the main menu are these freaker. He aims his shotgun at two Hives approaching us. His passion is infectious and I begin to feel the allure of it. The strength and the power. I pull out a machine gun from the bag and open fire on another troops of Hive coming with a daggers. James yells, that’s it. Now you get it. You seem to have become complacent and forgotten your killer instinct.

It finally clicks together. This is why he is here. To remind of that. We continue firing on the squad and crushing them. Our approach was steady but gradual. We were heading somewhere, but I can't tell where. He scoffs, get a grip man. We don't have infinite bullets. Where are we heading. I look around the place. I remember this area. Its familiar. Then another invisible wave goes through me. And I remembered. I say, we need to go towards the shore. There are some people I need to see.

He laughs, awesome. You are taking me to more aliens to kill. But that’s when I realized the futility of this particular mission. As I take down another batch of Hive I say, James, I am grateful for you help. But. He cuts him off, I know. Me being there with you will be make it difficult for you. It was frustrating that I couldn't take him with me. But there's no point, he would get in my way. Even as my imagination, he will always be an alien killer. I don't want to change that about him. He laughs laughing when launching another missile at a cruiser.

He cries, damn right. I won't change. I don't need to. But you have still some soul searching to do. So here's what I will do, he points to the corner, I am going to the opposite way and you head in. I say, but that place is miles away. I still need backup. He slaps me on the back and pushes me ahead, you don't need me anymore. I have done my job. And besides, you are damping my moment by being so damn emotional. He was right I was feeling sad and depressed. He pulls out his grande buckle and chucks it towards a group of Hive.

He runs away to a white smoke again. His laugher carries in the air, I am coming for you all. Get ready. It was a funny yet sentimental scene. James was dying in life and always had a death wish. But he wanted to do this always. Even if all this was imaginary, he was providing cover for me. I didn't waste this opportunity and ran to the corner. Hives were popping up from everywhere, but I was gunning them down with my riffle. Even though I know that these are ineffective in real life, it was enough here. It was a homage to James, the fearless guy who was there when I needed him.

As soon as in turns around the corner, my scene changed and fell flat on the ground. My bag and guns were gone. So were my clothes. I was wearing something different that I can't recall from where. I get back up and inspect my surrounding. This is the place, yeah. I saw this countless times in my nightmares. The place were they all died. A voice zaps through me, David. Can you hear me. I ask, Drew. She makes a relieved sound, what happened. I lost you there.

This is really a dream. I say, I got lost. But a friend reminded me how to fight back. Drew says, James got through to you. That’s a relief. I didn't think you recognized his photo. I ask confused, what photo. She says, don't worry about it. Are you there yet? I look around the place. I say, yeah. I am here. She asks, and who are there with you? I know whom she is referencing, but there something really strange going on. I run around the plaza, but I can't believe what I am seeing. Or rather not seeing.

Drew asks, what's going. The air feels heavy and feel like I am drowning in confusion. I answer, I don't see anyone here. There are no bodies.

David (Chapter 98)

Wednesday, February 18, 2026 16:53

I probably ran around the place twice and found no one. Its strange, I know I have seen them here hundreds of time. How did they leave. Drew says, are you sure you don't see them. Maybe you can't focus on them yet. I yell, they aren't here. And I know this is dream, or a nightmare. Or something in between. So what exactly am I missing here. I looked under the bridge, inside the burning buildings, and even under water in the beach. But they have just vanished. It left I have spend days searching for any clues. But my stupid consciousness wasn't giving me any.

There were no blood trails, or any drag marks. How in the freak the bodies moved. Drew says, your subconscious is you. Its clever. You didn't want to find the bodies and relieve those traumatic moment. So you moved the bodies. How the hell does that makes sense. I am trying to find something I don't want to find. That makes this whole thing a big joke. Drew says, there has to be something. Some way to find them. Your ego can't just do something you can't. You must have a way.

I wave my arm around in anger. I can't believe how much mad I am at myself. That actually makes sense if I think about it. If Drew said what is true, then I think the effectiveness of this trance is weakening. I am being more aware of myself. Drew says, that is true. That last detour burned through a bit of the haziness. Its probably why the bodies I was sure of was here were moved and there are no clues. I have been at this for hours, or at least feels like its been hours.

Then another wave hits me, toppling me on my back, but somehow I fall on my stomach. And the same time I was standing. The air becomes hazy again. Drew says, how do you feel now. I couldn't recall what happened. I was brought here with James, but then, What did I do. Drew says, you are exactly where you need to be. Find the people. There have to be clues. I followed the voice and looked for the missing people. I don't know why, but I feel I have already searched everywhere.

Then I step on something. A small piece of cloth I didn't notice before. It had a strange insignia. Feels important all of a sudden. Drew said about clues, is this it. She says, yes. That’s it. Remember where you have seen it. Go there. I try to pick up the cloth, but my hands pass though it. What's going on. I try to grab it again, but it feels like it wasn't real. Like this is a dream. Wait, it is really a dream. Then I can just imagine it. As I did, the cloth begins to fly into the air. I chase after it, its leading me somewhere. Drew says, follow it.

It felt like I have been chasing the cloth for hours, maybe even days. But I couldn't catch it. And I think its leading me in circles. This makes no sense. Where am I. I realize I am back again where I started. Its so damn frustrating. The cloth was flying just out of my reach and its been mocking me. Suddenly the cloth wraps me by the neck and try's to strangle me. What the hell, I couldn't breathe and struggle trying to remove the cloth from my neck. Drew says, its not real. Its not chocking you.

The hell it isn't real. Its on my neck. Then it was around my heart suddenly, crushing me from inside. I felt like I was dying. Just what kind of cloth is this, first making it chase me around and then suddenly trying to kill me. My hearts about to be crushed. I need help. But Drew's voice was again softening, becoming muted. That’s just great, I lost her again. The cloth of death kept trying to chock my neck and heart. Someone help me. I then hear a clack of metal and my chest tore open.

I thought I was done for, but the cloth torn itself into pieces and someone stands in front of me. A women was standing with a crutches on her left arm. I gasp for air trying to breathe. The woman says, come on David. You are not losing oxygen. That just your fear. That voice. I know that. It was unmistakable. It was her, Liz. I sigh and stand up, so its you now, huh. Great, I look up at the sky and scream out, freak you. You are one twisted guy. Liz pats me on the shoulder, you know you are talking to yourself.

I turn to her, doesn't mean I am wrong. She was wearing the same dress the day she died in. Her right arm had black skin, the poison that killed her. Her hair, still messy the way it was earlier. She smiles, I thought I told you stop being reckless with your life. And here you are almost dying again. I say, this time I am not trying to self destruct. She scoffs, oh I know. She points her crutches end to the torn clothe pieces, that was killing you. I couldn't deny that. What the hell I do want with myself. She says, that’s a great question. But why I am here though, I thought I was done saving your life.

I look down to my shirt and it had a whole in it. I am missing my heart. Liz says, ah yeah, I am here aren't I? That’s my heart that you just tried to crush. I gave it to you so can live. And you just tried to kill yourself, again. So I think I'll keep it away for the time being. I smile. I missed her. Even though I remember her, its been long and I have sort of forgotten her face. It makes me feel guilty. She puts her hand on my chin, don't be. Its natural you want would want to forget. You went to war for me. That was more than enough to honor my memories.

I felt even more guiltier. I didn't kill Nathan because of her. And yet I felt I was led astray by her too. She says, hey. You already forgave yourself. So don't revert back to that moody person looking for revenge. You saw James now, didn't you. It wasn't just a reminder you to keep fighting. It was a warning. To fight for the right reasons. I guess that’s why she is here now. To remind of that again. She pulls her hand back, maybe. She looks around the empty plaza. She gets suddenly excited, so this is the famous Medrine, huh.

She has only seen pictures before. But this in this fantasy, she is with me, here. I grab her hand and point her to the bridge, remember that. She says, oh. Yeah. That was the engineering marvel people were talking about. Said to be 300 years old. I say, 290. And it stood tall until the end. She says, that’s incredible. The next moment, we were instantly teleported in the middle of the bridge, standing at the railing. There should have been wind, but all I felt was woozy. Liz grabs my hand tightly, easy there. We can't have you tripping out yet. Too late, I am tripping on acid. She laughs at my joke.

This is reminiscent of the time I visited her in her room. Telling stories to each other. Her being in my head again is weird. But this time, she wasn't appearing as a hallucination. I am in one. She says, rude. You saying I am not real. I grip her hands tighter, hoping she wouldn't care regardless. She says, I don't. She grabs my arm and enjoys the view. We were now walk around the bridge, and it felt good. It felt like we were on a date. She scoffs, date. Jeez, you are being way too needy right now. I haven't been with anyone since she died.

She stops to laugh at me. This is incredibly weird and inappropriate. I am basically laughing at myself. She says, you know that’s sad right. You are a celebrity now. What's stopping you now. I am sure there are many girls crushing on you now. I say, yeah. Well, I am looking at only one special girl. She turns to me, please don't say its that Sophie girl again. You need to move on. How long are you going to hung up on her. Yeah, I don't think I have any shot with her. I killed her dad and she is actively hunting me. She feels nothing, and yet she has enough emotion to have a grudge. I think that’s a pretty big hint and that ship has sailed away.

She says, good. You deserve better. I don't know about that. I can't remember her name, but I know someone I have hurt terribly. She says, wow, look at you. You already moved on. She is enjoying watching me squirm. But that’s how she was. Living her life to the fullest, all the till her last breadth. She then says, guh. Enough about this depressing thoughts. I am actually envious that you lived on Medrine. I am a little mad too. It feels like you betrayed me. I thought we commiserate over our shared past as MAR's subject. But turns out that while I was frozen and sleeping on Earth for a century, you were living here.

I scoff, living here? I would have preferred to live on Earth with you all. This planet might be were my parents lived, but I was born on Earth. That’s my home. She sighs, home, huh. Its a difficult to say what home is really. She becomes forlorn, remember I used to believe the Valley could be a home. Then when you promised to take me away. If her plan was to make me feel guilty and resentment, mission accomplished. She says, its fine. Its all in the past. I am just reminiscing. I looked at her other arm. I don't understand why she has crutches. If this my imagination, why keep her in pain.

She chuckles, always so considerate of me. Even now. But don't need to be. You are the only successful MAR's kid. You should be proud of it. I lean on the railing. Be proud of something so messed up. I don't think so. The most I can be is grateful that I am living. She leans her head on my shoulders, that’s good enough too. We stay here for hours, days. It feels like eternity and at the same time it was brief. In my confused thoughts I looked at the city which was burning. I tried to forget about it. But Liz says, don't. Ignoring it will not do any good.

I say, not ignoring it. Just delaying it. She lightly pokes at my chest, that’s also bad. Stop procrastinating and get a move on. She brings the piece of torn cloth from her palm. Was she carrying it with her this whole time. Its funny, it was trying to get away, and now its showing up in front of me. She says, we got a job to do. I ask, there is no we. I know I was being rude, but I know she isn't here. She flicks my forehead, that old thing again. Its been years you needed my help, but you are still the same.

She puts her hand on my empty hole in my chest, I, we or something else. Doesn't matter. We both are always here, she places her palm on my bare chest. The sad part of this nightmare is that I can't feel her touch. I am just imagining the warmth. She smiles, ghosh. You are being too sentimental. You need to relax and learn to be more trusting of yourself. She then turns to ocean and the city view, letting it soak it in one last time. She says, its not the last time. I am with you always, that means I can see this place all the time. There was no literal sense to this, just a poetic one.

She turns back to me, its time I guess. I can't be a good role model if I keep delaying things like you. She steps a little closer to me and whispers, I hate to see you waste your life on just fighting. Try to get laid, will you. At least for me. What the freak kind of advice is that. She then reaches her fist straight into my chest. I get one last message, but don't ever forget your first. The scene in front my eyes changes I am now standing in the plaza again. I pat my chest for a hole. My hearts back in my body. What's more, the piece of cloth that was trying to kill me is in my fist now. Its not torn anymore, its back to its original form.

She had to make things weird for me. But maybe that’s what I am telling myself. I hear a voice now, David. Are you back. Its Drew. I guess this is going to be thing now. She says, did Liz help you out. I chuckle, she did more than that. Made me realize I have not been living to my fullest. Drew says, that’s good. Do you have the clue now. I look at the cloth. Seeing it up close I remember what it is now. Its the Shadow insignia. A wave of thin air and haziness sweep me. It consumed me.

The drowsiness hits me and fall straight down on ground. I felt the ground was hot and dirty. I look up and see the entrance to my old university's gates. My memories of it flow into me, I know where I have to go. Drew asks, can you reach there. I already began walking through the gate the next second. I say, those people weren't taken away. They moved back to the one place which was their home. Or at least the closest to it. That’s what Liz, or me, was talking about. Questioning what home is for a person.

Drew says, that’s where you will find others. It probably makes sense now why I chose this place. I am now roaming around the courtyard, garden and lecture halls. Then I reached my department. If I am right, Brandon should be here. I look into the chemistry lab, but I see no one. That’s strange. This where I spent so many time with him. I look around my old lab desk. But my things are gone. No, I have forgotten about them. Just have some vague memories of it.

Suddenly the building shakes and there is a loud explosion. I fall down on the floor and gets transported outside to the hallway. I see the ground was cracking open like an egg. I look up and see dozens of Hive approaching us. This is just what I needed, a hallucination of them trampling the university grounds. I run in a different way, but the cracks were following me behind. I jumped around the building, from stairs to corridors. Then from classroom to bathrooms. But the earthquake followed me like a snake.

I ran to the most logical place now, the headmasters office. Don't know why, but I felt safe there. I ran inside and shut the door. Thankfully nothing followed me behind. No quake, no Hive. I laid back on the door. I immediately jerk when I hear someone clearing their throat. It was Hansen and Branden. They both were sitting on the chair like nothing was happening. I am so confused, why are you here. Branden scoffs, you know this is our university too. I used to be a student here before a teacher. Hansen raises his hand, same here. I even had a brief stint has the headmaster.

With anxious steps I look around the place. Their gazes never left me as I peek outside the window. The university is on fire, literally. The building are breaking and the garden is torn apart. I turn back to the two people chilling nonchalantly. I blurt out, what the freaks going on. But I couldn't hear Drew's voice now. Great, she is offline again. Hansen says, I always knew therapy would do wonders for you. Great, a witty banter from my dead mentor. This had to be the worst kind of twist here.

Brandon says, since we have time to talk. Can I just say, I don't like you told my daughter about me and John. It paints me like a villain. Ah, I slump down on the corner tile. I say, really. There is a freaking war going on outside. And you want to talk like there is nothing going on right now. Hansen says, there is a war somewhere always. Didn't I taught you to savor the peaceful times in between. I wave my arm in reluctance, look. Its great to see you guys. But I am in pinch right now. There is a quake after me, chasing me like a freaking magnet. I need to get to the entrance of our HQ.

Brandon says, why the hurry. This is not real anyways. Breaking the forth wall already I see. I say, yeah well, I don't have full control. So pardon my urgency. Hanson says, interesting. I like your therapist. She has a good understanding of your state. I didn't need to be psychoanalyzed right now. Especially from a Hansen me. He laughs, that’s true. Its way too meta. Brandon says, that’s rude you know. We are fellow fallen Shadows, have some respect for us. I blurt out, I didn't say I didn't acknowledge you guys. I am just in a hurry to leave.

Branden says, you think its that easy to get rid of us. I say, look. I am sorry I told Catherine. Happy? I didn't tell her everything, did I. Besides, in time she would understand everything. Branden sighs, only when she has a child of her own. But even then I hope she never has to choose her children. She is mad at me, isn't she. I don't know why I am asking this myself. Of course she is mad at both him and me. I basically told her she was a backup and not the first choice. Kind of hard for anyone to forgive.

Branden says, I know. Its not your fault. But now I can't feel anything, but the shame. If he felt this, I did too. But there's nothing I can do about it now. That promise was creating a wedge between us. I was pressuring her stay away from Robb, which basically makes me just as guilty as Branden. Maybe even more. Brandon says, will she ever forgive us. I hope she does. Even though we are on speaking terms, I think she still resents me a little bit. I can't recall, but I kind of excluded her from something. And now she is doing something about it.

Branden laughs, that’s my girl. She has grown up to be a very beautiful and independent woman. I wish I get to meet her now. Tell her how much I am proud of her. How much I miss her. He faces me, will you tell her this. This had to be one most freaked up thing since I arrived here. My subconscious is asking me to convey a message from myself on behalf of her dead father. I think I just broke my own mind. Branden says, yeah. That really doesn't make sense does it. He gets up from his chair, at least tell her to be careful with her human boyfriend. She is my precious daughter. If he hurts her, you kill him, okay.

This is getting out of hand. He walks to me, I would have preferred she be with you. You are far better choice. Now its definitely weird and embarrassing. What am I saying to myself. Branden says, anyways. Make a different promise now. You won't interfere with her life again. I was more than happy to agree to it. He says, set her up with Blake if you she ever breaks up with her boyfriend. He will protect her in ways you can't. I think I am being rude to Catherine, Blake and Brandon, all three of them by having this conversation. Branden says, nah. Its all good. This is all, in your head in the end.

Just like that he steps out from the door. But before he leaves he says, I will stall the Hive a little longer. Best you find the entrance yourself. With that cryptic message he left. I turn to Hansen, what did he mean find the entrance. Isn't it near the. I forgot my words. This is strange. Where is the entrance. It was in this university. I am sure of that much. But I can't remember where. Hansen says, I guess we need find it. Don't we. Figures its his turn now. He stand up and helps me get up. Instead of taking the main door, we take the back door.

I don't remember this office room having a back door. The outside is a bright place instead of a room. We were now in front of a club building. He gestures me inside, ah, this is no time to play games. He says, why not. Its a good place to hide from Hive. They wouldn't dare to disturb our game. I turn back and group of Hive was running at us with weapons aimed at us. I didn't understand the logic, but I followed Hansen inside. I close the door behind us and the game room light turns up.

This is the room I spent some time alone. Whenever I wanted to get away from other kids, I would come here on off hours and just take my mind off by playing games. Hansen says, that’s right. You could bypass the Kuretine locks and come and go as you please. I always knew you had a place like this to go to. I scoff, no you don't. You are just seeing my own memories. He smiles, who knows. Maybe I knew about it but never told you. I could actually imagine this to be true. We walk around to different areas, strength, intellect and strategy type games. There were all different kinds of it to nurture the students here.

The next second me and Hansen are sitting across each other and facing a game of chess in between us. I had the white faced towards me. Hansen says, your move first. I am confused, chess was never on Medrine. Why not play the 5d version of chess here. Hansen says, I am tried of playing the same game so many times. Chess might be simple, but its fun because its simple. I always wondered how good Hansen would be in a game of chess. I played my usual move of pawn. He moved his knight instead. Its interesting he would do that.

The chess board instantly changes around the pieces and suddenly we are at a critical conjecture. It feels like I played with him for hours in less than a second. Coming at each other with unpredictable moves, keeping each others pieces in check. Even sacrificing my queen or his bishop to gain any advantage. And right now its anybody's game. Wait, does that mean I am playing myself. Doesn't that mean I am the loser and the winner at the same time. Hansen smiles, quite the predicament you are in. Do you want your subconscious to win, or your awareness to win. I don't understand what I want here. What is the point of this game then. Hansens says, you are asking the right question now.

He leans away, your fight with Charles. You were in predicament, much like this one. Weren't you. Out of moves and out of chances. Then I recall the memories of the match. I blurt out, you. You were there. You said something crazy, like I was going to get stronger and I would face challenges that I couldn't find a way out of. The same is represented in this chess game right now. He says, but with a little bit of luck and will, you made it though. Nothing makes me prouder than that. I stomp my hands at the edge of the chess board. I yell, I need to know. Why did you have so much faith in me. You are optimistic, but you were even more pragmatic.

I was a kid with a short life ahead of me. No Kuret, no family. And yet he made claims that turned out to be true. That is not probability. He says, that is only for me to know. I gave you the push you needed. I was a little worried since you basically forgot about me for more than a decade. But I am glad you remembered my advice when you needed it. I don't believe this, he isn't giving me a straight answer. He says, much like you don't want to answer your friend. Don't you think its little bit hypocritical.

I am confused, who is he talking about. Am I keeping something from someone. Hansen says, I am not here to accuse you. Only to assure you that my reasons are mine. I may have known you were a MAR's kid, or I had a way to save you. Or maybe I knew about your family. You can keep guessing things. But it doesn't matter. Because the truth is I placed my trust and faith in you. I gave you the skills you need to take down any advisory in your path. Whether it’s the Medrones, Humans or the Hives. I say, its not enough. I want to know the reason why you believed in me so much.

Hansen replies, I believe it, because you believe in yourself. I am tired of going around in circles. What kind of meta mind game are we playing here besides chess. Its abundantly clear I might never know the truth. Does he want me to be at peace with it. I might never know how anyone can put so much trust on me back then. Hansen says, its like this game. We can keep playing at each other infinitely, but eventually we have to stop. The question is, can you make peace with your decision. Sometimes giving in is better than being stuck.

Everything with him is a lesson. I get what he is trying to make me understand. But its hard to let go. Hansen says, of course its hard. If everyone could do it, they be no one with any regret. He is asking me to choose, either to keep playing or end it. Ah, this is such a head scratcher. My mind is telling me one thing, but my heart is telling something else. How can I end this. I pray for someone to help. Maybe someone would help me here again. I waited, and then some more. But no one came. It felt eternity went by and no one came to help me choose.

Hansen extends his arm, what do you say. Call it a draw? I can't focus on the chess board, and all I know is that its anybody's game. Maybe I can win. But what exactly am I winning or losing here. I sigh, the real enemy is someone else. I don't know if I am ever going to be satisfied with this. Not knowing the truth. But I don't want to be stuck. I want to move on. This whole thing is to find a way for me to change. Hansen says, you will do that. You don't have to know how. You can only trust that you will get to a state where you are your best self.

I suppose this had to be enough. I can't keep getting stumbled at every obstacle, looking for answers or reason. I grab his hand, good game. The chess pieces all tumble down one after another until all it vanishes from the board. Hansen says, its good that you want to let it go. I hope you do the same with her. Again, who is he talking about. He pulls his hand back and begins to fold the chess board by each column, like it was a cloth. He says, and by the way. I would have won. Huh, what. Was he teasing with me. Or am I myself that petty. Guess we will never know. Suddenly the room goes dark and I find myself in front of a big black door. It had the shadow insignia on it.

No goodbyes from him, typical in this nightmare. I look around the place, it was just a dark room I can't recall and a single door. But this is not the entrance to our HQ. I don't know where it is, or how it looks like, but this is too open and simple. I just know this wasn't the real entrance. I still can't hear Drew, so I don't have any choice. I grab the door handle, twist it and open it. The dark room is instantly shined with a green light and I am sucked in. I hit face first into a strange wall. It didn't hurt, but it felt like it was pricking me.

I gently push away from the wall with my hands. I looked around some weird room, seems very familiar. Then the next second my senses distort and I realize I wasn't on the side wall, I was on the ceiling. I scream as I fall backwards on the actual ground. But my fall was broken by a couch. I am relieved it was a soft landing, not that I felt any pain. The couch was covered in a lavish styled material. It was glimmering with different kind of gems. I know what these colorful gems are. I have seen then many times. What are they. They are so beautiful.

A woman says, I always know you liked them. You said it was too gaudy the last time you saw it. I jerk to see an elderly women standing opposite to me. She was wearing a dress that radiating colors, like a rainbow. Her sleeves were only to her elbow, but it revealed a long insignia all over her arm. Its a tattoo that was glowing green. I have seen and that green color before. She scoffs, you are staring too much. Don't be so rude. You are still a child. That snarky but teasing comment triggered a memory.

I say, Istra. It was her. The next second there is someone beside my couch, it was Istra too. But this was the dead body of hers. She was lying in the same position as the day I found her on Medrine. The terror grips me and I stumble away down, trying to get away from it. The alive Istra says, apologies. That’s not I wanted you to see me. I tried hard to hide, but you kept searching so earnestly. I had to be found, like how you found me back then. I couldn't take me eye of the dead body. I feel like someone's hand has gone through my throat and pulling me out from inside out.

She says, what a terrible imagination you got there. She walks slowly to her dead body and covers it with the same material of the couch. She says, its better now, isn't it. I don't think hiding her is accomplishing anything. I can still her dead. She says, of course. Nothing can change that. But I don't want to see myself like this. Its too disturbing. I rather you remember me like this. She sits in front of the couch, blocking the view of her other body behind her. Was this some sort of representation to remember her by this and not by the dead one.

She smirks, you are clever. I made the right choice by entrusting stuff to you. Guess its time to face her now. I gather enough determination and get up. The next moment me and Istra are sitting on the couch, her dead body was no were to be seen. She says, its still here. You just can't see it. I look around, but I don't know where it went or why did I hide it. But I feel much better now. She says, you must have a lot things to ask me. I reply, yeah, well, Hansen beat you to the punch. I am sure you won't answer why you helped me so much.

She smiles, you learn quickly. I say, besides, I am sure you were just trusting me to help your daughter later. You told me about your family secrete book when you didn't need to. My best guess is that you didn't want to burden Marina. Maybe keep me indebted to you for allowing me in the ship too. She says, is that what you believe. I say, maybe. Or something else. Doesn't matter. I am grateful you helped me. I don't think anyone else referenced me

on that ship. Must be a painful decision to choose both me and Marina when you were supposed to send only one.

She says, you shouldn't worry about such things. I would do anything for Marina. But you, she chuckles, you were always going on the ship. Like Hansen, she is being cryptic. I ask, Hansen? He already sent his grandson. Braden sent Catherine, and so did the other shadows. They all chose their families or loved ones. She says, you are trying hard to justify your survival. I get knowing the truth matters. But its not like its end of the world. You being on that ship, was a blessing. You went to save countless people.

I say, I lost people. I couldn't save everyone. I felt like the embraided cloth was slowly climbing my body, trying to cover me, the same way it did with the dead Istra. She says, you are not a god, son. No matter what you do, sacrifices will always be there. She turns to see a side wall. The wall immediately filles up photos of the Ozarek family portraits. I saw photos of her, with her husband, Olander. Their three kids, Marina's older twin siblings, Sam and Violet. She says, I sacrificed my family for others. For a future where the people who could leave Medrine and save others. Even if one of them would be able to help Marina, in any way, that would be worth all the this.

Her fierce determination was apparent. When she was alive, she was known for her indomitable spirit. She was perfectly able to make choice and not look back. Very few, like me, knew she had a warmer side to her. Like Marina said, she cherished her kids lot more than she let on. She shoos me, you are going to make me sentimental. Not a good look on me. I prefer you always see me as someone who would do anything for my family. A new type of guilt swells in me. The embroiled cloth climbs even more and covers my torso now. She says, why are you sad. Its not your fault I died.

I blurt out, but you could have chosen someone else. Why send me of all people. I wasn't powerful, I was barely a Medrone. The only thing I had was my intellect. Which I have wasted it for years. You could have send someone better, an alpha or even an omega. They could have changed the tide of the war. Able to do things I couldn't do. I was stuck in a place without memories and bound to a hospital. She didn't give an answer. Figures, whatever she says, its just me talking back in the end. The cloth begins to tighten and it covers my neck now. I feel like I am stuck in the sheets, slowly dragged inside.

Istra says, do you believe you aren't the right choice. I say, all the time. I have many regrets. I chose to forget about your sacrifices. I chose to be a nobody because I didn't want to remember this. Its was too painful. She sighs, I can't deny that. It was a very selfish decision. The grip tightens around my neck, almost cutting off my air. She says, but do you think anyone else would fare any better. Is she really saying that others would fail. That is completely egotistical and hubris. Having pride is okay, but being conceited that others were the wrong the choices. I can't believe that.

She says, I am not saying that others would fail. I am saying to give yourself the credit you deserve. The cloth looses a little before it reached my mouth. She continues, did you know when Marina was a five, she used to cry all the time when she got hurt. So much so that she said she would never wanted to be warrior. Never wanted to be an alpha, let alone an omega. This momentarily made me left bamboozled. Is this a made up story from a hallucination. She says, come on. Don't tell me you forgot about that. I was discussing this in the shadow HQ one day. Don't you remember.

What is she on about. She says, try to remember. You didn't know who I was back then. And I was feeling down that day, because others were pressuring me to choose my successor. My predecessor, my grandmother wasn't allowing me to choose other children. I remember it now, something so long ago and insignificant, that I had forgotten about it. She was talking to Hansen and I happen to listen in. I remember I was with someone else. Who was that. That person was someone I was close with.

Istra says, you remember now. Yes, I was speaking with Hansen. I was telling how my family wasn't letting my other kids to be next Shadow. But I wasn't going to let Marina be one. I am confused why she didn't want that. Marina is very strong and capable. She smiles, of she is. But at the time I was being selfish. Marina was born because Violet couldn't be my successor. She wasn't capable, like Marina. But Marina, she was so full of heart. You know her best, don't you. Do you remember what I told Hansen. What she said when wanted to become grow up. I rack my memories, trying to find those particular words. I say, an artist. She wanted to create things so that you wouldn't have to. To make your life better.

She nods and looks away with pride, imagine my small child saying such big imagination. I wanted to protect her dreams. She has born with a gift I didn't want her to be forced to be something she didn't want to become. Not like how I was forced to be one by my grandmother. What happened then, why she change her mind and recruit Marina. Istra says, I wasn't the one who changed. Huh? If Istra remained firm on her decision, then it could be only one thing. It was Marina who changed.

The haze appears in my memories and I begin clearing them. I think I am onto some thing here. I remember Marina saying something about changing her mind a long time ago. Istra says, let me help you out. It was you who changed Marina. What. That’s impossible. The cloth around my neck unwraps and falls below my chest now. Istra says, don't you know what you said to her to in our house. You told her she could do both the things. She could be a warrior and an artist. I recall a vaguely something like that. I was visiting her home and once I saw a Kuret structure. I was impressed by the engineering attempt, but she was afraid to show it to others. Her mother was hounding her to be a warrior like her and she didn't want that.

Istra says, no need to be impudent. I was also being pressured by my family. Is this how Istra really was, or am I just picturing her the way I want her to be. But it makes sense if she was really asking advice from Hansen back then. She was concerned for Marina's decision and didn't want to force on her. Istra says, but you had a positive influence on her. You made her question that she could do both. I am sure she was inspired by you. And because of that she chose to become something she was hesitant initially.

I did that? How in the freak did I never realize that. Just how lucid I am in these dream memories. Istra says, you were blinded by your own insecurities. You never realized you had positive effect on her. I don't know how I feel about Marina following in my footsteps, but you helped her become the woman she is now. Strong and still valuing her freedom. I can't ask for anything more. The cloth slips past my waste now. Its like my guilt is slowly slipping away too.

Istra says, just like her, you had positive effect on others. You lost many people, but you not only saved people, but helped them grow. You helped stopped a epidemic attack on Humans. And singlehandedly stopped a misguided royal. You saved Blake, because of which a freaking terra is alive right now. Do you believe someone else would have done the same as you. Maybe things would be different, but do you honestly believed you should have stayed back on Medrine. There are many reasons for you to feel guilty, but you only need one reason to be alive. Because you are worthy.

Those words were something I never knew I needed to hear from her. No, from anyone who died on that day. The clothe vanishes, freeing me from the terror and guilt. I know I did a lot to balance out my selfish decision. But I never once believed it was enough. But even hearing it from a fake Istra was enough to give me some hope. Istra puts her hand on my cheek, you don't have to stop feeling the guilt, the frustration. But you can however stop doubting yourself. For whatever reason, you were chosen. And whatever you do with it, its your choices that will effect the future, not the past. We did our part, you do however you can.

This is probably the first time I could feel some warmth in this dream. Istra says, I thought you believed this was a nightmare. I say, ha, maybe it’s a good nightmare. She laughs so hard that I was sure it was a just a product of my imagination. She pulls her hand away, and it felt she took away all the confusion I was feeling with it. I felt re invigorated. Maybe this whole story was bullshit and I made it up to feel good. Or maybe it was real. Regardless, it felt good to realize that I should value myself more.

At that moment, the couch begins to glow. The different colors were blinding, but it was very familiar. The dark room was enveloped with kaleidoscope of glimmers. The couch I was in vanishes and I fall on my ass, but I somehow was also standing. This is dream is just getting weirder. Istra says, well, its your dream. You are definitely weird. The glow flows out from the gems stitched into the cloths. No, they are not gems. They are Kuritines. The room changes and instantly I am transported to the basement under the library.

I look around the place, the memories are so strong here I could see everything clearly here. Istra says, this the door to the HQ. You made it here. I turn towards the hidden entrance behind this door. It looked like a ordinary door leading to the adjoining room outside. But there is switch mechanism that changes the destination. I place my palm around the side which triggers the secrete door. I need something to open it. Istra ruffles something in her hands and produces a ring in her palm.

That’s my Shadow ring. I pick it up and new memories of it flows in me. All the hardships I had to suffer, but also the good stuff. Istra says, you are ready. Well, as anyone could be. I understand what she means. Behind this door, there lies a person I had a bone to pick with. Someone who I have been ignoring for a long time. Istra says, I can't say it will go the way you want. Things rarely go the way we want. She sighs, even though Marina changed her mind about becoming a warrior, I would have been okay with her being a normal person.

I ask, but then she wouldn't have been there during the war with Hive. She saved countless lives there. And help defeat the Hive commander. She nods, look who has recently started to appreciate things. She chuckles, a mother can still dream. Even in someone else's dream. That joke was making my head hurt. She points to the door, go on ahead. I nod and place my ring on the wall. The door makes a noise and the ground beneath us shake a little. The leavers and gears were moving behind the door. It felt like eternity as it opens, but it takes a second for the door to open.

Istra says, I won't ask you to look after Marina. She is perfectly able to protect herself. Though, she leans a little, she is a little too unpredictable. I hope you will keep reining her like you always do. Once again I am in a very awkward and baffling position. Just how much twisted is my subconsciousness. That being said, its all make believe, but not the emotions I am feeling. I say, you say I inspire her. Well, she inspire me too time and again. Istra gives me the biggest smile she had to offer.

Suddenly a hand comes from the open door and pulled me inside to who knows where.

David (Chapter 99)

Thursday, February 19, 2026 16:03

I thought nothing would surprise me anymore. But when a strange guy pulls me in and then drags me to hell, I had to reconsider how much messy my emotions are in this place. I can tell this is Shadows HQ, but its on fire. There walls are torn open from blasts, the floor have been ripped apart and numerous broken equipment's. Stuff were exploding from the assault of weapons. What I was thrusted into now. I was being dragged by a smaller kid now. He feels familiar. But I couldn't put my finger on. I know he was a Shadow, but I can't recognize him.

He pulled me my the arm and dragging me across the burning rooms. We finally take a cover beside a wall and crouch down, seriously dude. I know we weren't the best of friends, but come on. How can you forget me. He knows who I am. Then he back fists me in my chest, duh, its your nightmare. That voice, I remember now. John? He gives me the Shadow greet with the hand gesture. It was him. He says, of course dude. You have kept me on the sidelines a lot more than I thought you would.

He wasn't wrong to complain, I had more or less a strictly Shadow connection with him. Its sad truth, but we haven't spend enough time together outside the Shadows. He was friends with so many people. Even someone mutual. Ah, I still feel I am missing someone. He was a polar opposite of me. I was gloomy and serious, while he was cheerful and easygoing. If I had to put in words, I'd say I envied him. He smiles, really. I never knew that. He is being facetious, just like this father. I ask, I thought you be more angry. Even though you were the oldest Shadow to join in our generation, I haven't been mourning you.

He says, no worries. Our relationship was different than others. I preferred to keep it that way. That was my choice, do you not recall what I said that day. He did say that once. Maybe I am just drawing this from that reference memory. He says, I am not too much mad about it. I figured I keep this life separate. I didn't have to keep contact with Blake and Marina too. But I did my part in the missions. Remember the time you had me investigate the thefts in the city. You said it would take a lot of time, but we got it done in just three days.

I remember it now. I say, you almost got caught that time. You were cocky and made a blunder. He scorns, how was I supposed to know the person I took the identity was the guards son. I say, that's the first person I told you to not take the identity of. He replies, no you told not to take his daughters face. Said nothing about his son. I can't believe he is nit picking such small detail with me. He says, I thought you loved being technical. I am just saying what you ordered me to. I smirk at his witty response. He was always a wild card, different from Marina. He chuckles, I wasn't that bad, was I.

I smile, no. You were someone I believed had a proper balance in life. Didn't let your Shadow work interfere with you private life. Unlike mine, your world was bigger on Medrine. He replies, you say that but I can't believe dad was sponsoring you the entire time. Just how did you to manipulate him to do that. Mom once asked if he was cheating on her when she noticed his account draining so suddenly. Now I realize you were the reason. I had forgotten this memory. Branden once said it to me and played it off like a joke. He then asked reduce the budget for our department next semester. I don't know if that was a joke or a real thing.

Regardless I laughed aloud. He scoffs, real funny man. I say, sorry. I don't know he was like that at home. Your sister told me about this a while ago too. I guess even Shadows can't get away with everything. He asks, speaking of my sister, I have a beef with you. Ah, not him too. He gets annoyed, did you thought I wasn't going to say anything. I had enough of the scrutiny from their dad about this. He says, I got my own stuff to say. Its my baby sister and you caused her pain. I sigh, okay lets skip to the part where you tell what you need to tell her. I am guessing we are on a clock since you pulled me in here and hiding.

He says, we got time. Why, you in a hurry? There's someone I need to meet. Someone I had been avoiding for a long time. I only had the urgent feeling. But not their name. its frustrating. That's why I need to hurry up. He sighs, fine. I get it, you have become a big deal. I am now envious of you now. He looks round the place and faces me, since dad covered pretty I glaze over the details. I want you to tell Catherine about me. I ask, that you were a Shadow? I don't think. He shakes his head, not that. She was only eight when I died. She barely remembers me. I was most of the time in the university or participating in Shadow related stuff. I barely got any time for her. To her I was just a name and sibling.

That is true. She doesn't remember much about him. Though she remembers Branden. He says, yeah, well dad had a much better work life balance than me. Did he not. I have been so careless, doing my own thing, that I never got to be a big brother. Forget about being good or bad like a certain someone. Who is he talking about. He says, you will met him soon enough. So my ask is to tell her about me. As strange as it sound, you are the only person left who knows me. I want to be remembered. If possible not just by her, by others too. You could have told Blake and Marina a little more about me. Did you thought I wasn't interesting enough.

I didn't have a good enough reason for him. At that time I was telling them my worst mistakes and guilty secrets. I didn't tell them everything. Because I didn't want to talk about dead people's life. I thought I was sparing them unnecessary hurt. But now I see John asking for it. His annoyance is a directed at me, so its actually at myself. I have told people a lot of things, helping me unburned myself, but all I gave them were the cliff note versions. Not the real, the actual important moments and conversations. When did I decide its okay to forget why people mattered.

He says, now you get it. Its okay to leave the past and move on. But no one is asking them to forget us. People matter. No matter how little they impacted ones life. We want to be remembered, our own unique stories. That's how we stay alive. For someone to truly let go of the past, you have to know why its okay to leave them behind. He places his hand on my shoulder, I know you don't want to cause pain. But pain is how we live. How we grow. You can't heal without knowing that pain.

Its different when are you told something, rather than just knowing something to be true. I always knew its never better to lie, but I never corrected my behavior. Because I was scared. Fear of getting hurt, being scorned by others or even blamed for things just because I survived. Hering it from a face like Johns, I realize I don't have to sideline people. I need to let them in instead. Its not easy though. He scoffs, doing the right thing is never easy. Especially the ones that really matter, they are the hardest. I don't expect you to just flip a switch and start revealing everything immediately. That's nuts.

He puts a finger on his lips, we are Shadows. We have responsibilities and some secrets that should remain as it is. But we are people too. So when the time is right, help remember people about us. I ask, how will when it's the right time. He says, you will know it. Don't you worry about it. Just promise me you will not try to hide us anymore. And you will tell some non Shadow related stories about me to Catherine. I know I should be used to this by now, but every time someone asks me for something, I feel all different kind of awkwardness. I am yet again asking myself to promise for something.
☐John says, that is pretty weird. Not going to lie. He acknowledges the ridiculousness of the situation, and yet he waits for me. I sigh, yeah, yeah. I promise. The goal is to change and be a be
take it one step a time. See you later. What does that even mean here. A loud explosion occurs beside us and a white flash blinds me. I felt we were transported someplace again. The air around me changed to a little cooler, did I enter deeper into the HQ.

I raise my imaginary arm to block the imaginary light. A girls voice says, you'll go crazy if you think too much about this. The light goes away. I am in different room. I recall this is the training room. And in place of John, a girl is sitting ahead of me. Her hair was tied into a ponytail and she had blood stains on her abdomen. Do I know her ? She scoffs, jeez. Well, freak you too. She slaps me out of nowhere. That slap actually resonated to my core, like my entire being was shaken from inside out. Those vibrations evokes new memories. The ones about her. Zakerine. She smiles, I don't like the fact that I had to make you remember me, unlike others.

I didn't care if this was fake. I went in for hug. I held her tight, believing that if I let her go, she will vanish again. She snickers at my sudden emotional outburst. She says, its good to see you too. My arms wrap around her tiny body even more. That made her irritated and shoves me back, you could have done it without calling me tiny. You are just gotten older. I am forever young, you know, because I died. She even had that sense of humor. She says, you know me the best, so here I am. Apparently she was the most clearest memory of mine.

She says, I am honored you keep me so close. She then becomes annoyed, but I never thought you would do something so crazy. Shall I list all your greatest hits. Oh boy, this is going to hurt me a lot. She says, so I died and you spiral out in depression and decide to erase your memories. Which turns out you were starting to not want it. What a douche move, by the way. Then when, a Zakerine less David scums around with different girls. First one friend zones you and dates your human friend. Then you go meet a terminal women and decide to lose your virginity to her. Gross by the way, you are one nasty dude. All the while screwing around with a Human psychopath. Am I getting this right.

The embarrassment was enough that I felt like I was sinking into the ground. She grabs me up my by neck and pulls me out. Turns out I was actually sinking in the ground. She is really angry at me, and then you go crazy after losing both women. Spend years planning for a revenge and then don't go through it because the said women stopped you. And now you spent this year flirting with two women again. I ask, what. Who? She says, agh, forget it. Its a pain for me to talk about them. I can't believe you grew up to be a complete player.

I rebuttal, I think you are just salty. If had stayed alive instead of stupidly dying like that, we could have stayed together. If you think about it, everything started because you died. So, its not really my fault. She gives a stink eye, so I am to be blamed. I shrug, am I wrong? After a tense moment she relents, guess I should own up to that. Besides, I know you weren't fooling around with those girls. But Sophie, really? What the hell do you even see in her. I should be more embarrassed and confused about it. Talking about my alive ex to a dead ex. But I gathered enough of my wits with me. I say, you don't get to decide about me anymore. I will choose whom I like. She crosses her arm, is that right.

I nod, I don't know how exactly, but I have dealt with your death. Its sad and disappointing. But I had some time to process it. You made a choice, nothing I could do about it. The best I can make sense of that avoidable death is that you didn't want to lose anyone. Not after loosing so many others. She asks, what if there was a different reason. I say, my answer would be the same. It was your choice. Do I regret not able to stop you then. Hell yeah. But I can't obsesses over what I can't control. Some reminded me of it recently.

She smiles, you have some clever friends. Or at least you used to have. I say, I still have them. Everyone. John helped me remember that. She becomes depressed when I mention him, when I saw him dying. I didn't want to lose another friend. I lost already everyone I cared about, even before then. But that day, I didn't want anyone else to die. Not if I could help it. I know I made my peace with it, but it still stings me that she went so insane and didn't even heal herself while trying to revive John. She says, you don't need to remind me of that. It was, what did you tell others, a pointless death.

I try to come up with a excuse for my behavior. But she puts her finger to my lips, don't bother denying it. You were there, I was there. Its true. Not all death are due to noble reasons. Right. I had to agree with her. She sighs, I have so many reasons to explain what I did, or why I did. But none that will ever make you see the logic in it. She knew me well. Aside from the obvious reason of her being me. She pouts at me, not everything had to be rational. Like you thinking that saving Ryan and Elina would save me too.

She got me there. When she mentioned their names the memories of that instantly fills me up with a whole lot of emotions. It doesn't makes sense who the two different seem the same to me. She says, it doesn't have to. You see what you want to. And sometimes that's okay. I need to hear that from her. I feel a lot of my burden being lifted from me. Like I had been carrying the weight of the entire world. And each passing time, they were peeling off. She dusts off a little dirt from my shoulders, whoa, that's quite literally. You seem to be shedding your worries.

I guess she really did have a purpose to be here, other than to criticize me about my choice of women. She punches me in the chest. I chuckle, faking to be hurt. She says, you know you were a mess a while ago. All because you loved me. I say, yeah, well, chalk one that to suppressed anger and fears. Its not been pleasant regaining memories one bit at a time. She says, you are much better now. I nod, yeah. More than better. I realized I was making this all about me, but like John said, I need to share. She says, oh, you are going to tell the girl you have a crush on about me. Isn't that a turn off, to talk about ex.

I ask, Elina? I don't think she mind. Zakerine makes a heavy sigh, not that one. The other one. I ask, there is another girl? She looks to the celling, damn. You are lost cause aren't you. You need to fix things with her, like pronto. I don't like her much, especially not her brother, but you like her. That's all I care about. Who is she talking about. I feel someone very important to me. Someone more than Zakerine? She punches me again, hey, I am still here.

Well, not here. But you know what I mean. Actually I have no clue what she, or I, mean. This the only constant in this dream or nightmare. It confuses the shit out of me.

She laughs, I guess my jobs is almost done. She stands up. Wait, what. I stand up, don't leave. I have so much talk to you about. She gives me a disgusted smile, you clinging to me is even worse. You have already moved on, don't go back. I say, I am not. But I don't know if I ever will get a chance like this again. She says, and what was this anyway. You are only hearing what you need to. I blurt out, I will take what I can get. I grab her face my hand and come closer, I miss you. She joins her head together, I know. I miss you too. And its okay to feel this way. I am not going anywhere. But Liz is right, you should start living your life the way you want. With whom you want.

She pulls back, I am always ever going to be kid. Its not fair to keep me bounded. Others are alive and I am just a memory now. There is literally no completion. And so I am doing something I don't really like. She pulls her face away. she says, I am letting you go. This is weird, I should be the one to let her go. She says, I know, right. This is a little messed up. She continues, you should be free to do what you like, what you love. No more hiding from your true feelings. I ask, you aren't just talking just talking about love, are you. She says, you are holding back a lot of yourself. You don't have to stifle those feelings. Let yourself feel whatever you want to.

I don't really get what she meant by that. She says, you know about it soon. She slowly begins to walk backwards. I want to follow her, but my legs are stuck. She says, don't. Its fine. I am done holding you back. But do me a favor, when you tell others about me, tell them I made a mistake, not some foolish girl who died pathetically. If possible, make it look like I was heroic. You will have a tough time to sell, but I hear you are good at manipulation. She begins to fade. I try to move, but I am stuck like this. She is pushing me away. She mouths to me something inaudible. I realize what it was, me too. That’s all I could say before she vanishes in front of my eyes.

The next moment I am standing in the middle of the training room now. I can move again now. The Kuretine crystals were glowing in the walls. This is really the same room where I and others trained. I look around for others, hoping to find them. But I was all alone. Where is everyone. I desperately looked for Zakerine. Maybe she will be here again. I looked for her everyone, but there is no place to hide. Its like everything is out in the open. Then I hear a guys voice, what kind of a man are you. You need your imaginary friends to help you.

That voice, that coarse pitch, gravelly timbre. It felt like a train hit me and all the memories return to me. It made me so angry literal hell fires erupted from the corners of the room. I turn to face the source of my anger. And there he is, standing with a knife wound over his chest. That same face that makes me want to shove my hand into his chest, pull out his heart and feed it to him. He claps at me mockingly, what an active imagination. You know, in this place, you might actually get that wish. Want to try it out. Everything about him is making me nauseous. Of course he is the person I have been avoiding this whole time. I rather face a hundred Hive than see that smug face.

He walks closer to me, you got a mouth on you, you little shit. Don't think you have changed because you got stronger. All you have done is achieved a little bit of fake fame. He is goading me. Of course it’s the first thing he does. He says, actually, I am not doing anything. Its you who is doing everything. I am just the messenger. Someone needs to whoop your ass and beat some sense into you. Its official, I am my own worst enemy. My own subconscious conjured him physically to torment me.

He smirks, yeah. Its fun to see you squirm by our own mind. Tell me, how does it feel. It feels like I want to kill you. Too bad you are already dead. We walk around each other, circling in mirror opposite. Stop, I said. He shrugs, you are not me. Just some dark twisted part of me. A wrapped sense of humor. He says, I see we no longer playing along the roles given to us. I reply, what's the point. You know what I am going to do, before I even think about it. He clicks his tongue, that is partially true. The drugs are quiet potent, so much that it can bifurcate your conscious. Ever that of that.

I laugh, yeah. No. I know my own tactics. Trying to get inside my mind, trying to make me believe some plausible expiations. Too bad its not going to work. He stops, oh, are you sure. I say, enough of the games. Why are we here. All the peoples I have met had a purpose for me. What is yours. He says, you really have no respect for me. You need to learn some you punk. I bark, educate me. I want to know what a child abuser can teach me. He lunges at my throat, I dunk away before he could grab me.

He goes for a sweep kick, but I crawl away to get a distance. He says, look at you. You think just because you enough meat in you, it has changed you. I get back up and raise my arms to guard, no, I think experience has changed me. He smirks, you think you take on the crown. Don't delude yourself. You are nothing. My anger boils hotter now. The fire spreads around the room, enclosing us inside. I gesture him to come to me. He dashes at me with a right fist hook, I block it my arm and go for an elbow shove to the wound on his chest. He backs away a little from the impact. He snarls, you freaker.

My mouth turns to a big smile, what's wrong. You thought it would be like the last time. You thought wrong. He came at me again, this time with more vigor. I dodged it and knee him. He blocks it with an arm and goes for another punch. I block it and get pushed back a little. We kept attacking and blocking each other. I didn't feel any pain, but I was getting frustrated. While he remained the same jackass. He continued taunting me cursing any chance he got. I was fighting him for hours nonstop. Neither he nor the fires stop.

If anything, the longer this went the more angry I was. I should be stronger than him now. But why can't I finish him off. He aims a kick to my face. I block it with my elbow and jabbed his knees with me leg. He side steps from the impact and we take a few steps back. He laughs, I'll give this much to you. You have become a little bold now. All you had earlier was your mouth, but now you can at least move. I shriek, shut it. I will kill you. He snarls at me, and what will that achieve.

I reply, I will eliminate the part of me that causes me my PTSD. He chuckle surprised, you think I am the cause of your issues. You give me far too credit. I say, deny all you want. But once I cut you of my mind, I will finally be free. He says, you think you can get rid of me that easily. I don't think it will be easy. But I didn't care. Everything I did, it lead me to this moment. I gone through a transformative experience. And the only obstacle left is him. Once I prove that I am better than him, I will be free of him. Forever.

He says, didn't you hear John. The past lives in our memories. Even your pathetic brain believes that removing me is not the solution. I ask, I don't care what you think. There is a tense moment between us. I thought he would attack me. But we just stood there, like he was waiting for something. He says, your hate is even bigger than me. Letting it blind you. You been holding onto a grudge for more than 20 years. I am not the one with issues, you are the one. The fires burns hotter around us. Is he trying to teach me something just wanted to torment me while spouting nonsenses. I guess all he knows is to torment.

He says, nonsense. Look at you. Playing make believe in your mind here. Tell me what is more ridiculous than this. He extends his arm and circles around himself, this is all you. The fire, the floor, the air you think you are breathing. Even the both of us. We are all representation of you. You attacking me is you fighting you. He stops and faces me directly, you cooked this all up because you are sad little boy, who still thinking he is strong. Every word he spouted fueled more anger at me.

I tighten my fist in pure anger. I need to end this and get out of here. If I can't beat him in a brawl, I need something else. I am stronger, but what exactly did make me stronger. I felt like I was missing something, a core component of my abilities. What was it, a secret strategy or a weakness of his. How have I beaten other after him. He says, seriously. How freaked up are you, kid. I feel sorry that you are one of the Medrones left alive. There are so many others who could have replaced you. Many people who died sending you to Earth. If they saw you so weak, so helpless, they would have never sent you.

That does it. I don't care what I am missing. I rush ahead with my fist raised up in the air. He didn't try to dodge it, instead blocks it and grabs on tight to me, not letting me attacking him. He barks, so that’s all you got. A measly half punch. Jeez, you are so pathetic. You dying here would actually save a lot of trouble in the future. I am disappointed that I am dead. Because I could never see you epic your downfall would be. The fire reach smoldering hot around me. This heat is so strong, I think the heat is melting the air around me.

I need to find what I am missing. There should be something I know than can defeat him. Suddenly a muffled voice echo's in the room. He shoves me away and we book around the burning room. I don't see anyone, but I can hear a faint voice saying a word. I listen in closely and heard a voice. Drew says, Kuret. The ground shakes and I topple over. The room begins to vibrate crazy. Its an earthquake. But why is that. I topple down again while I was already on the ground. Its like I was stuck on a loop, the ground shakes and kept getting knocked down. What is freak is going on.

Wagner says, looks like this your real nightmare. You have no one to help you. All alone and powerless. His taunt made me infuriated, but not like these constant quakes. It looks like he wasn't being effected by this. What does this mean. Drew said something. A word, something that struck me to my core. But she isn't saying anything anymore. He laughs, that was me. You won't hear her voice anymore. I didn't want anyone to interrupt us. This is between you and me. What does that mean. How can he control this, I am one in charge here.

He says, you sad little boy. You are the one who kept getting knocked down. Not me. Ah, every time I try to get up or try to crawl away, I am forced to fall back on the ground. What's even strange is I can't recall what Drew said. She said something, feels very important. He walks closer to me, forget it. You are too weak. A little bit of power is not enough to beat me. If I had my real teeth, I would have cracked them from the pressure of my anger. This is so damn frustrating. I had enough of this quakes. I decided that I am going to first destroy it.

Instead of jumping out, I decided to give in. I face down and fall straight into the ground. The floor immediately breaks apart. Huge cracks starts to form around me. I was falling into it, but then the next second I was standing in the middle of it. I was standing at the epicenter of this quake. Hold on, from here I can see something I didn't before. This quake, it was chasing me earlier when I entered the university. Yeah, it’s the same one. Did it follow me all the way from there. I thought it was trying to kill me. But maybe.

I crouch down and lay my land inside the cracks. The vibration stops and a dark veil erupts from those cracks. It surround me. I was terrified for a second, but then I felt a familiar sensation. Something I had forgotten. Yes, this is my power. My Kuret. It flows into me and so did the memories. The next second I am back in the room with Wagner. The fire is still burning at the edge of the room. But the cracks in the floor are gone. I raise my palm and bring out my Kuret. That made me chuckle, this is what I was missing.

I wave my Kuret to Wagner who wasn't fazed by this. He scoffs, so you remembered your Kuret. Big deal. He pulls out his own Kuret. He aims his arm at the fires and some it gets pulled into his hand, you gained yours, so did mine. You actually did me a favor. Now I can kill you. I spat out, try it. He throws a fireball at me, I dodge it and throw my Kuret. He gathers wind on his feet and flies up. I throw a Kuret line to the air and get pulled into the air. He prepares for a gust of wind towards me.

I change my direction in the last second and summersaulted in air to land a kick to his face. He narrowly dodges it and return fires a hail of icy bullets. I throw a Kuret line from my back to the ground and get pulled down before they catch me. My feet skid a little as I land back on the floor. He throws a lightening bolt at me. I yell and create a Kuret dome. I fill the space around me with my Kuret to block that bolt. Then I grab him using his Kuret. He tried to fly off away from the Kuret. But I had prepared a Kuret wall to cut his escape. He instead decides to create a huge wall of ice around him. The ice too think for my Kuret to break. If he thinks this will stop me, if was dead wrong.

I gather Kuret around my arm and thrust myself towards the ice barrier. I crash throw it. Turns out he was preparing another thunder bolt inside, I wrap the Kuret around my like an armor and we both clash straight into each other. The resulting force knocks both of us away in opposite directions. I gather the Kuret behind me to break my fall. He does the same with wind. A strange emotion emerges deep within me. Excitement. I am finally fighting him. This is the opportunity was waiting for ages. I can finish him off with this.

Then begin a very long fight. Sometimes it felt we fought for a second, other times felt decades. I realize I am fighting the grudge I have been holding all this time. Then it means I just have to keep this up that long. Only then will be satisfied. Our Kuret clashes a hundredth time. He threw everything at me, electricity, wind, fire and ice. But I countered all with my physical Kuret. I even downed on the wild exploding Kuret to keep this battle engaging at his level. I know I am stronger than him. But he had a sadistic smile plastered on him all this time. Like he is enjoying this. I get frustrated and ask, what's do damn funny.

He backs away and we both take a breather. He says, this is awesome. That weak little child has all grown up. And yet its so disappointing. He says that, but that relaxed smile never shows any changes. He says, that’s because I know you are holding back. You do better, can't you. Show me that form of yours. The one that pushed Charles so much. I smile, I don't need that to beat you. You couldn't beat Charles, even with your overdrive. That lead you to

endanger innocent children. All because you were weak.

He smirks, such a weak ass approach. Trying to make be doubt myself. I am you, so I know you can't use that form. Your lies don't work on me. I spat out, why don't you show me your overdrive and make me use that form. Once I beat you in your peak, I will have finally gotten rid of you. I tried a little bit of goading myself. Hoping he takes the bait. He suddenly bursts out laughing, look at that. You say you don't want to be like me. But you are exactly doing that. I immediately throw my Kuret at him.

But something weird happens. My Kuret vanishes and leaves me all alone with Wagner. But so did his own Kuret. What the hell happened. He says, do you have a brain damage. This isn't a real fight. You are just a child throwing a tantrum. Not knowing why you were fighting. He raises his arm and snaps his fingers. Immediately I get strapped down to the floor, like an invisible force is pulling me down. What the freak is happening. I can't move from this spot and fell down on my knees. He walks slowly to me, I grew tiered of fighting. So I decided to just end this.

I wriggle out of the invisible shackles. It makes no sense, I was winning. He crouches down, how deluded are you. There are no winners. Only losers here. Only you. I don't get it, what was the fight about then. I bark, you said you wanted to teach me lesson. I haven't learnt enough. Lets continue learning. He sighs, what a kid. I am asking you again, he flicks my forehead, you can't get rid of me. I am a part of you. I yell, never. You are a bad memory, that needs to be removed. He flicks my forehead, wrong answer. Didn't you learn anything. I thought Hansen choose at least a good student. But you are nothing but a disappointment.

I lash out, trying break free. But the bonds get tighter and I get sunk even lower to the ground. Why can't I fight back. He says, because you are too weak. Too afraid to admit it. I ask, admit what. Suddenly, he punches me hard. For the first time I felt pain. It shook my entire being. He says, did you feel that. I am getting stronger. As you continue to hide behind weak reasons, I take more control. I receive another punch on my other cheek. I felt blood trickling out of my nose now.

This is not happening. I can't let this be the end of it. I got my Kuret and beating him. This isn't fair. He grabs my hair and yanks me up, life isn't fair. You of all people know that. You suck it up and move on. But you don't want to. You are too afraid. I yell, I am not afraid of you. He gets closer to me and barks, You are. There is no hiding here. I am you, remember. I know all your deepest desires and the delusions you make for yourself. He drags my head and thrusts me into the floor.

My head shoots up so much pain that it sends shockwaves all to my core. He yanks me by the hair. This is so damn frustrating. I can't believe I am being manhandled like this. This is so embarrassing. He laughs, it is. The great David. You have defeated so many people, but you are still so afraid. That’s why you can never beat me. He let goes of my hair and I crouch down. The blood trickles from my head to the floor. Each drops brings even more emotions. Anger, hate and beyond all, confusion. Why am I so pathetic.

He says, don't ask me. I am you in the end. He then raises his arm to the fire. Is he going to kill me. He says, I am. You will die here, and all that remain will be me. The fire comes closer to engulf me, I felt my skin singeing from the heat. He says, I will be take over you and defeat the Hives. You are too weak. You have created a fantasy to help you recover, but all it did was unleash me. The air becomes thinner and I start breathing from my mouth. This can't be happening. I can't die here. Not like this. All the lives lost would be wasted if I do so pathetically.

I kept pushing myself to break from the shackles. But I just can't. I am too weak. He says, and nothing will change. You refuse to learn the thing I was teaching you. So you will remain weak. He is spouting about things I don't understand. What I am not learning. What I am not admitting. The air becomes so thin, I feel my lungs is on fire. He laughs, you feel that. That’s your brain not having oxygen. Huh? He continues, you moron. You are going to OD. Those many drugs in your blood, did you thought nothing would happen.

The freak. I shakes becomes so tight that I begin to feel the despair. No, this is a trick. He is lying to me. He says, you don't believe. Why don't you see it for yourself. He waves his arm and I begin seeing visions. Something was bright and I saw some screens ahead of me. It was red and dark, like this room. But the terrifying thing was the sound of Drew yelling, M, stabilize him quickly. His heart is defibbing. He is going into shock. Another voice says, oxygen level critical in boss's brain. Drew says, give me his sodium levels. I need to synthesis a sedative.

I am pulled back into the room, chained to the floor. He smiles, see. You are going to die from your own stupidity.

David (Chapter 100)

Friday, February 20, 2026 21:33

All I feel is the pull of a dark void. From within me. I feel its tug so strong I think I am going to topple inside any second. Wagner was laughing out so loud that he was tearing my ears off. Is this it? My final moments are of an imaginary person enjoying at my death. The air is thinning out that makes my body hollow. I think my legs are also disappearing. Wagner says, give up. Its better if you don't struggle anymore. I can't understand him anymore. No, I don't know myself what I want here.

He says, you finally ask the tough question. What do you think you want. To defeat you. He says, that's obvious. But how will you do that when you never learn. So make it easier for both of us. Just die and let me take over. Let me take the wheel. What the freak is he saying. If I die, so will he. He says, I guess that is confusing. Well, your therapist is good doctor. I am sure she will keep you alive a little bit longer. A second there is minutes here. Don't you know about the basic dream rules. He chuckles, or a nightmare. Whatever you believe this is.

I realize what his plan is. He wants me to die and then he wakes up, as me. He says, ding, ding. And once I am out, I will do what you are too weak to do. This is all kinds of wrong. Is he talking about a personality takeover. Is that even possible. He says, who knows. I am willing to gamble on that chance. I will get much stronger than you were ever. Because I have no qualms about myself. I know who I am. I can't believe him. I can't let a freak like him go out. He would only terrorize people.

He says, what I do doesn't matter. I will be born again. This was the plan from the beginning. Letting you go through the hoops of your trauma was a bonus. The freak is he talking about. This is not his dream. He says, not at the beginning. But don't you see how much control I gained since then. I don't even need Kuret to kill you. You are killing yourself. All I have to do is wait. No, no. This is not happening. I rather die with him than let him out. He smiles, just how much do you hate me, kid.

There are not enough words to show much I do. He is deluding himself if he thinks he is a better than me. He says, oh really. Tell me why. I am the most powerful Medrone. There is no one better than me. Just because you are strong, it doesn't make you better. Look at me, I am the prime example. He comes closer to me and kicks me in the head. The pain stings so much its hurting me all over. He says, just die already. I don't have to prove anything to you. A better person will wake up then.

The air is hardly there anymore. The oxygen is not reaching to my brain causing me start hyperventilating. How much longer will I last now. Seconds? Minutes? I refuse to give into the despair. The dark abys within me so strong I feel the moment I give up, I am gone. He says, don't struggle. There is no point. This is not how I die. I need to figure something out. I have been in hopeless situation so many times. There is always a way. He says, there is none.

I raise my eyes at him. He was truly enjoying this. The anger and hate I feel towards him is literally going to kill me. Why would my subconscious even bring him to me. Do I have a death wish. I need to do something. He has been lecturing about me not realizing something. He said it many times. I have been so furious at him that I never thought to think about it. What does he mean I am not accepting something. What is there to admit. I already want to be better than him. He had so much power, but he wastes it on being a trash. I would never be like him. Ever. Does he want me to admit that I am afraid I will become like him. Despite how much I detest him.

He chuckles, such delusions. Its actually funny to see you trying to figure this out. The time is ticking, I suggest you rather say goodbye to your imaginary friends. No, that's can't be true. Its something else. I may use his knowledge, but never be like him. I refuse to believe any part of me admires him this much. Then what is it. He suddenly grabs me by the collar, you are one stubborn bastard. Just how long are you going to keep this farse up. Give up and die. You will be doing the world a favor.

He starts to relentlessly punch and kick me. The pain slowly spreads. There is hardly any air left that I beginning to fade out. The dark void is pulling me in. I can't keep my thoughts straight. The singular moments when he pauses in between his attacks feels getting shorter and shorter. I hate him. But I hate myself more. I can't let go any of this hate. How insane it is that I refuse to let it go. So many people helped get where I am now, guiding me and pushing me ahead. Their faces pop in my head.

I saw James grinning at me. Liz holding my hand. Branden helping me. Hansen guiding me. Istra assuring me. John reminding me. Zakerine loving me. Wagner killing me. Is this my life flashing before me. No, I am missing so many others. People are depending on me. But what can I do. I am getting beaten down in my own nightmare. In fleeting glances I saw Wagner gleaming with bright eyes as he continues to inflict mind numbing pain. How sadistic he is. I don't even remember him being this much in the real life.

Real life? I was about to lose hope, but it burned a little longer now. That question triggered a chain reaction. Wagner stops hitting me and pauses, you have nothing. Just die. He grabs me by my neck and starts to squeeze the life out of me. My body feels so light, deprived of air and hope. I might disappear any second. I gather every ounce of hope I can gather to fight back. I feel like I am the cusp of grasping something. And Wagner is afraid of it. That's why he is getting desperate.

His grip tightens further proving my point. What is it he is afraid of. Something about him being different in real life. But that was just a thought. Its not really possible. Is it? He was a menace and abusive. Just like he is now. But I feel like someone close to me thought he was decent. Who was it. How could anyone believe that lie. He was a monster. Then an image of a women pops up. Who is she. Why is she so familiar. Something about her makes me feel stronger. I need to remember her, she is my only hope right now.

Wagner yells, she has nothing to do with this. That throws me a spiral of emotions. He knows her. And then before I could even realize I say, Vanessa. I can't believe I had forgotten her. Wagner yells, she can't help you. Not here. His fist feels like it dug deep into my throat. She claims she saw a different side to him. But I know what he was like. She was little child back then. She would hardly remember what he was like. But why do I keep circling back to this feeling. I saw what happened, the atrocities he did. He wasn't a good person. She is wrong about him.

And yet I can't let it go of that suspicion. Is he really the villain I am making him out to be. Wagner yells, there is nothing to understand. You hate me. There is nothing else. What he said was even more strange. He said I was deluding myself earlier. Perhaps he did have some lingering goodness of him. Just then he begins to choke me harder. I barely had any essence of my being left. The void is beckoning me. I can feel it. The only thing keeping me sane right now is the hope I just got from Vanessa.

What am I missing here. Come on, think. Think. He is just as bad as I remember him. He had the same smile when he fought me earlier. The same menacing smile, enjoying the fight. He was completely immersed in the thrill of the fight. A chill ran through my body. What. The. Freak. In here, he is me. Then what I saw was myself. My own reflection. I finally realized something. Something insane. Wagner gets mad, just die already. You are weak, you are no one. This is simply not possible. It can't be. But I felt it so strongly.

Wagner says, just few more seconds. Then I would be finally be born. This isn't Wagner. That's what Vanessa came to show me. He never enjoyed when he was being abusive. That's what I made up about him. All this time. I thought I was trying not be like him. But I am him. I get it now. Wagner screams, you get nothing. But his words had lost its effect on me. I need to say it. I feel that once I say it, I will be free. Free from this chains. Free from this delusion.

Wagner tried to shut my mouth. But I don't need mouth to this. This is my dream. I am terrified to say it aloud. Everything will change once I say it. I will start believing this. The fear is so damn chilling that I can feel it swallowing me up. But I had to say it. Will all my resolve I blurt out, I like my power. One of the chains snap and I get my strength back. Wagner tries hard to put me down. But I continue, I want to become the strongest Medrone ever. Another shackles brake. Wagner's grips on becomes weak. He yell, no you don't. You are afraid of becoming like me.

I reply, that's what kept me from realizing the truth. You said you were teaching me something. I get it now. You were showing what I really wanted. The thrill of a deadly fight. Another shake broke. Wagner is forces back and stumbles back on his ass. The force pulling me down had gotten weakened that I was finally able to stand up. This is my deepest desire. I have been refusing to admit this. All the time on Medrine, I envied people with strong Kuret. I was literally the weakest Medrone to have ever lived on Medrine.

But that has changed now. I have gotten power to rival many of the strongest Medrines now. I say, I want to beat Charles and become the strongest Medrone in history. The shackle are so weak now that I can almost feel I am free from it. Wagner is confused and anxious. As he should be. Because I am admitting the stuff I never knew I had. He says, you are being arrogant. And conceited. I reply, I am. There is no denying it. I began to feel this way back when I was fighting Charles. I experienced something I never felt before. Many people have asked me about this, but I just put it off. Giving vague excuses or refusing to admit it.

He says, what's that got to do with you hating me. I explain, I was feared myself and I made that fear into you. Because you were the easiest person for me to blame everything. The final shackle broke, releasing all the restraints on me. I felt like the weight of an my entire existence has been lifted from me. It feels so good to finally admit how I truly felt. I say, I wasn't afraid of becoming you, I was afraid of what I will become. What will I be when I am so selfish. And you were my scapegoat. A coinvent villain. I blamed you so much that I distorted how I saw you.

I walk to him, just like Vanessa replaced your memories, I did the same about my feelings towards you. I was just a child back then. And one with a rough life. I am sure you had one too that made you like this. I sigh, you are not a decent person. But you aren't what I am making you out to be. Ever since I saw your corpse, it created a domino effect. Hating you, then hating myself because it terrifies me. My body gradually starts to materialize.

The fires around me also gets dimmer. They were representing my anger. Now that I am accepting that part of myself, I am no longer angry. I have been bottling it too much, it was eating me from the inside. The air was back too. Wagner stands up and faces me, but you still hate me. I says, yeah. But not for the right reasons. I was fixated on you for many reasons. You had strength, abelites and reputation. I am envious of that. I want that too. Maybe not the way you had. I want my own thing. He says, you want more than what you already have. That's just greedy.

He wasn't wrong. I am guess I feel like universe needs to give me some kind of reward for all the crap I went through in life. But its not that simple. I know that. And yet I like being powerful. I want to beat Charles in his overdrive. I want to kill the Hive king myself. I want to live the life I want to without feeling guilty anymore. He asks, didn't you say having power doesn't mean you are better than me. I smile, I was wrong. Power only corrupts if you don't value it. It can make me a better person when I use it correctly. And believe me, you will be my biggest reminder to not screw up.

I step forward. He thought I was trying to attack him and raise his arm to defend himself. I think he loosing his sense of identity. Maybe I am realizing mine and he is crumbling away. I say, you can stop playing the tricks on me. Don't you think we had enough of it now. Wagner says, I don't get what you mean. I say, really. I thought you knew what I am thinking. Stop this and show yourself. The scene changes in front of me and we are now standing outside on the plaza. The same place were all I found everyone on Medrine.

But this time, all the bodies were back in their place. I saw everyone here, the people I didn't recognize and the ones I do. Slater, Istra and Wagner. I finally found them and brought them back here. A voice behind me says, this place has haunted me for so long. I thought hiding them would have made it better. I turn around and see the person I wanted to see. It was me, but the child me. Its me when I saw this the first time. He says, you really think it will be all right.

I shrug, no idea. It scares the hell out of me. But it feels me with excitement too. He asks, what if he turn out to worse than Wagner. I say, that will never happen. Unlike him, we have friends. He says, that’s true. I also had few good ones in Medrine. But almost all of them are gone. I answer, I made new friends. People I can trust. Who can trust me too. He asks, even after all the lying. I answer, well, its going to be hard to change. But its not impossible. I prefer to think this a new beginning for me. For us.

He looks around the dead people. He says, I want one. The plan I had for my future is gone. But maybe. I help me out, we can make a different one. And it starts by embracing the truth. He sighs, I never thought I would ever like this life. The constant fighting and scheming. I say, neither did I. I had a simple life for a while. Like how you wanted. But things change. And its not all bad. We can finally enjoy what I have been denying. I want to get better, not only for others, but for myself. I want to see how much far I can go. How much we can achieve. Don't you think that sounds awesome.

He smiles, sounds, he pauses a little and says, interesting. I say, you made me jump through all the hoops for this. Didn't you. He says, not everything. We are not always in control. You know how it is, some pieces of memories, some liberties and few theories. You know, the usual. That made me giggle. He says, sorry about Wagner though. You were too stubborn to admit what you wanted. And nothing makes me more angrier than him. I had to use that to pry open your emotions. Sometimes you don't need a pen. I answer for him, you need a sword. He nods, I hoped Wagner would invoke all kinds of emotions out of you.

I say, only I can be so diabolical. We both laugh at that thought. I ask, and what about me dying and him getting out. He says, creative liberties. Needed to push you to your limits. I can't believe my subconscious was so scheming. I guess I should be impressed by myself. I outdid myself. Which is all already very confusing. He says, lets not think about it too much. Otherwise you will go insane. I say, by admitting the truth, I am already a little insane. He says, maybe you have to be to live in such a crazy world.

That is true. The world I live is messed up. I have to be a little crazy. He says, but a good kind. I answer, the best kind. Having such a strange existential conversion with myself had been enlightening. I am having a feeling that its time. I ask, how much will remember of this when I wake up. He says, no idea. But I hope you remember the important things. I want that too. The warm glow beings to wrap me even more. Before I get swept by it I say, you coming. He smiles and walks to me to join in the embracing light.

I feel my emotions are heightened right now. I feel great. Acceptance is such a powerful thing. My body shakes a little as I begin stirring and wake up. I couldn't move yet, but I felt something strange. Something new. My Kuret was flowing into me. What's going on. I see pieces of my vision. I am back in my house, sitting in the couch. I can see the glimmer of my Kuret flowing in me from my surrounding. This has happened to me few times before. The first time during the fight with Hive commander six years ago. Then when I got my new heart. When I almost drowned in the sea water. Last year when I was in the war with Hive. Just like then, I can sense that the new black Kuret is flowing inside me.

Its probably the drugs making me feel woozy. But I swear this is happening. Every time I had a break through of some kind, my Kuret grew stronger. If this happened again, does this mean what I think. The Kuret is so much present in the air, it feels overwhelming. I couldn't feel everything, but I know it is flowing into me. I don't think Drew this. She is siting beside me like nothing was going on. Then maybe I was still hallucinating this.

My eyes lazily open. The first thing I could recognize was the multiple screens in front of me. It should different images, some were shades of colors, some themes and others were places. Something gets stuck in my throat. I cough a little. I hear a faint voice of Drew moving around me. I feel her cold hands behind my neck and she puts a pillow behind it. My lungs feels like it is on fire. My skin feels so itchy that I could just scratch my entire skin. Drew comes closer to my eyes and says something inaudible.

What's going on. What happened. It took a long time for the disorientation to leave. Drew kept asking me something. Her voice was slowly getting louder. She throws a light at my eyes and inspects my condition. I know the light is thin, but it felt like floodlights to me and blinds me. Few minutes go by and begin to hear Drew, can you hear me now. My throat is so heavy and sour, it pricks a little as I move. I managed a blink to let her know. She says, good. Her voice shows relief. She says, where does it hurt right now. She places her hand on my chest. She says, tell me when. I blink twice when it was near my throat. She nods, okay. That’s what I expected. She turns around and picks up a beaker.

She lifts my head up and brings it closer to my mouth, drink this. This will clear the blockage. She pushes it against my lips and try it hard to swallow the hot liquid. The warm liquid soothes me a little. But then I immediately feel nauseous. The hell she gave me. I felt like throwing up. She knew I was going to have this reaction and brings a garbage bucket. I tilt my head and lean towards it. I cough up the liquid and a little bit of blood. That was disgusting and brutal.

I lean away when I empty my throat. I lean back on the pillow. But I felt infinitely much better, like my lungs were cleaned out. I open my mouth and ask, what happened. She says, a lot. Take a minute to gather yourself first. She was right, the weird sensation was slowly going away. My skin begins to feel my own. She brings her tablet, M, run a complete diagnostics on him. Do a full workup of his blood and tissue. I need to know if there was any adverse negative side effects. M says, running diagnostics.

Another minute went by and I could feel my body getting better. I look around the room. She had dragged more table around me with her stuff on it. I look down on my chest and see a small bleeding coming from the spot. She says, that was from the needle in your heart. You will feel a little prick from inside. So move very slowly. I pull myself slowly and try to sit upright. The pain in me chest stung me sharply. She wasn't kidding about the pain. But I muster through it as Drew helps pull the recliner into a sitting position.

I turn to see the dialysis machine running and cleaning my blood with the two needles on me. The metal ring is still on my head. Drew brings out a scanner device and begins waving it around my neck and chest. When its done, she says, all clear. You don't have any other blocked passages. I think that was just a small tear in your esophagus. The drug from your blood spilled out and hardened a little from your spit. You should be okay now. My feel shaky, did I die a little bit?

She becomes curious, you remember that. I nod. She has a nervous smile, you were in a such deep trance. I lost you for majority of the time near the end. I try to recall what happened, but it’s all a blur. Actually, it gave me a headache when I try to think too much. She says, take it easy, David. You went through something completely untested. We don't know the side effects of this yet. Don't strain yourself. Just relax for now. Deep breathing. With me now. She takes deep breath, it helps to mirror her actions.

Another minute goes by. It helped me calm down a lot. M says, boss's blood work are done. He still some drugs left in his system. But the sedatives you administered are flushing them out. Drew says, what about this neural activity. M says, boss suffered through near cardiac arrest, and the drugs are still burning him up. I can't get an effective scan until it cools down. I ask, cardiac arrest. You don't mean. She says, you went into a shock 10 minutes ago. Your was body shut down, and your heart stopped. Freaking hell. I ask, how long. She hesitantly says, 62 seconds.

Bloody hell. I spat out, I was dead for a minute. She says, clinically dead. But yeah. I had to a use the defibrator to restart your heart. Thankfully, you made it out before you suffered permanent damage to you brain. It was deprived of oxygen for few seconds. I get a little confused and angry, I thought you had the dosage right Drew. What the hell happened. She puts her hands on her knees, I told you this before. This was experimental. Things could go wrong at any moment. I recall about the risks. I sigh, I remember now. Sorry. She says, don't worry about it. Just focus on you breathing. Besides, I didn't anticipate it would turn this bad myself.

I say, I feel parched. Is it okay to drink water. She grabs me a jug, more than okay. Keep yourself hydrated. I gulp down the entire jug of water. Water spills around my mouth on my skin, I still have a slight headache. She says, perfectly normal. I am not turning on the lights because your nervous system is short circuited. Your nerves are hyper active. I say, I have numbness on my hands and legs. She says, I sedated you with a nerve relaxant. Its more effective in your limbs right now.

I suppose she is covering all her basis. I say, thanks for saving my life. She says, you are welcome. But don't overthink it. You are my responsibility. She bites her lips. Its unsettling that this happened despite when I took every precaution possible. The worst I believed was you going into a shock. But your nervous system refused to corporate with any of the sedatives. I ask, what does that means. She says, not sure yet. I will do that analysis later, once M runs all tests. I lean back my head back on the pillow. My headache is getting better for a while. I am strangely not panicking, even though I nearly died.

I ask her, how long was I out. She turns to one of the displays which had a clock, its been 97 minutes. So about 92 minutes. I scoff, that’s all. I feel like I just spend days stuck in a dream. She grabs her tablet from the table with a digital pen. She begin taking some notes. She says, I have been documenting each step. She scribbles down while I flex my wrist a little. After she is done, she puts the tablet down and faces me, how does it feel. Any soreness. I say, not really. Just feels a little heavy. She says, lets test your motor skills. I want to see if we damaged any of your nerve endings. She begins physical checkup of my joints in my arms and legs. Then we inspect my senses. I let her check my iris reflexes to see any signs of visual feedback damage.

She performs the same for my hearing and my tongue. Apart from the bitter after taste of few pills she just gave, I didn't feel anything wrong with my taste. She says, I didn't find anything wrong. You show signs of dehydration and a little bit of shingles, but that’s normal under the influence of the drugs. How's your head. Any particular area you feel pain. I point to one part of my skull that was still throbbing. She asks, M, what is going there. M says, boss's neurons are still hyper active. His pain receptors are still active. She asks, even after so much time has passed. I ask, is that bad. She thinks for a second, I mean I thought it would dissipate in few minutes.

I look over to the table beside her, maybe give me a sedative for a pain killer. She turns to the injector and then back to me, sorry. I know you are in discomfort, but I rather not risking inflaming your tissues. Instead, drink this. She brings out a different bottle. This one had a very familiar scent, she says, its just electrolytes mixed with some mints. It might help with the pain. I gladly drink it. She was right about be dehydrated. I swallowed the whole thing in one breath. She then places an ice pack on my head where I felt pain. The cool contact immediately soothes me. She says, I was afraid you would go into a withdrawal.

I say, I am guessing I got lucky. She says, not just that. Your medical history boasted your white blood cells. Your immunity. He scoffs, what a delightful coincidence. I don't know what would have happened if you never went through that cycle of treatments. At least there was some upside of being hospitalized for years. She asks, M, turn on half the lights. I think his disorientation is gone. The side profile lights turn on and I squint my eyes a little. For a brief moment my eyes strain under the light. However, like she said, I adjusted to it quickly.

She says, you okay. I nod, just shaking off nerves. I look down to my body and I realized I had been sweating like crazy. My pant is drenched in sweat. God, I hope I didn't peed myself. She then pulls her tablet, you show remarkable resistance to the drugs. Are you sure you feel okay. I crack my neck a little from the sourness of my position I was stuck in. With slow movements I stand up. She puts her arm on my shoulder, what are you doing. Don't get up. Too late, I immediately stumble back on the chair from the heaviness of my body.

She rebukes me, there are still lot of drugs coursing in your system. I turn look at the dialysis machine that was filtering my blood. I ask, you gave me a sedative right, can I at least get this off me. She takes a moment to think about it. She made up her mind, I guess its fine. Few minutes later I have gausses and bandages where the needles were. It felt better. I couldn't exactly explain the feeling. She says, how does it feel. Better. She says, I see. That must be also causing you pain in your nerves. Good call there. She picks up her tablet and taps something.

She asks, I know you need rest, but I need to do a physiological test. I am confused, now? She nods, it is imperative. You just went through a visual therapy. Your experience is still fresh in your mind. This will help me check if your mind experienced any phycological trauma. She made sense, though I felt a little concerned. My memories are still woozy about the dream. But I honestly don't feel anything wrong. There is no harm in checking. She first gives me an IQ test for 5 minutes. After that she says, 158. Huh? I scored 2 points lower. She saw my confused state and smile, its all right. You didn't get dumber, there is a margin of error I anticipated from the drugs.

I hope she is right. My IQ is my biggest tool. She then gives a simple color coding question to judge my emotional state. She says, that’s good. You seem to be responding well. She then points to the screen, next is the word association test. You know the drill, just tell me the first thing comes to your mind. I had a few reservations about this. What I say something wrong. She say my worry on my face, relax. I rigged the images that could cause issues out of this. I am only checking for positive reactions, not negative right now.

That made me feel less anxious. She says, lets begin. The first image is of Medrine. I say, lost. Then its Earth, home. A picture of puppy, pet. A spider, creature. Kuret, power. Fire, destroy. Forest, nature. Weapons, tool. Sky, vast. And mundane things like that continues. I kept answering with the thing that comes first in my mind. She looks over her tablet down, excellent. You don't show any physiological degradation. That’s good. Turns out, I was being nervous for no reason. She asks, how you feel if I give you another round. A little harder one.

I ask, like the stuff that is a minefield for me. She answers, in a way, yes. I like to see how you respond to something contentious. I don't know about it. She gives a moment to think about it. I have a mild headache, but that’s all I feel right now. I am beginning to be more aware of myself with a clear thoughts. With a slight nervous expression, I give her a nod. She says, at any if you feel anything wrong. Just raise your hand, you don't even have to say it. I will stop this immediately. I nod appreciating her concern.

She starts new images. The first is about a burning city, sad. Alien ships in the sky, flee. Bodies of some blurred out dead people, disaster. A group of Hive solders walking on a street, run. Destroyed buildings and roads, devastated. Medrones fighting Hive, revenge. Hive attacking Humans, helpless. Image of a war from last year, avenged. I gave my answers all related to our current struggles and war. Drew asks, are you sure you don't feel any discomfort. I ask, yeah. Something wrong? She makes confused face, not sure. You gave all normal responses. I say, I think I would have given the same answers before this.

She says, its not that. You are inebriated right now. Your first impulse and reaction would be what you say. Your answers could be the same, but your minor physical reactions are different now. They are in the normal range. She is talking about things like micro expressions, breathing changes and heart beats. Stuff like that. I am actually very happy with this result, isn't that good. She faces me, it is. Its just I was anticipating a bit higher number. Logically this only makes sense if your consciously making an effort to hide your reactions.

I didn't know if this was really a cause to be concerned. I say, the deep trance worked then. She scoffs, this improvement is suspicious. Didn't you feel anxious about you almost dying. Wouldn't that make you even more scared after see these images. I gave her my honest feeling, its not like I don't feel sad or depressed about risking my life. But I signed up for this. She asks, you don't have any regrets to have risked so much for this. PTSD can be resolved normally. I answer, it was a calculated risk. I don't feel like I should make a big deal out it.

She inspects me like I am a rat. She even comes closer to check my pupils, they are slightly dilated. You don't seem to be lying too. She scoffs, if this is really how you feel. Then this is incredible. With just one session you seem to have overcome few core issues. I say, you said it was all or nothing. She says, I wasn't expecting this to give results immediately thought. I had a thought. If Drew was saying this was beyond expectation, could I really be okay with the actual stuff. I ask, lets try with the core issue ones. The usual suspects of my triggers.

She says, absolutely not. We don't know if the drugs or you got lucky or the instruments are misreading. We can try it once you get more rest. I insisted, think about it. You are saying I am recovering. I was apprehensive about it a minute ago, but I think I can take it now. She says, there is too much risk. At least wait for some more time. I say, didn't you say its best time to check. I am being brutally honest right now. So is my body. Shouldn't we confirm it now. She has a hard time to accept my proposal. She turns to the screen, M, show up his neural activity. M brings up my brain activity. There were spots of red and yellow. The middle was mostly red.

She says, its very curious. You just had a stoke, and all you have is a some abrasions on your brain. M asks, there is a substantial increase in with the atropine levels in boss's cranial epidural tissues. Drew says, that is because his brain is trying to stay awake and aware from the effects of the drugs. She turns to me with a hard stare. After a tense moment weighing out all the options, she shakes her head. She says, fine. Lets try it. But this time I will use my own desecration to stop this whenever I feel like it. I say, that’s fair. I felt a mix of anxious and excitement.

She says, relax back. She picks up an injector, I will use this to knock you out cold if I see any hint of an adverse reaction. I nod in anticipation. She sighs, god. Why did I listen to you. He gestures me to the screen. She asks, ready. I nod. The first image is of me as a child bloody and hurt. I immediately say, struggle. Drew looks over the screen beside her. She didn't flip over the next image. She glanced over the screen and to me. She says, that’s all. Honestly, it was a disappointment. I ask, why did you think this would be a trigger for me. That’s just me miraculously surviving Medrine.

Drew's eyes widen. She stares at me so intensely that I felt uncomfortable under her scrutiny. She says, all right. Lets try the next one. Its just a word saying Zakerine, tragedy. She pauses to read my readings. She asks, you don't feel guilty or anger. I answer, of course I do. I feel responsible for it too. She could have saved herself. Or maybe I could have saved her. That being said, it was her decision. I can be angry at her, but it wasn't truly my fault. She ask, you have forgiven yourself. I think about it for a second, more like I have accepted that her death was a tragedy and something I couldn't control.

She clears her throat, you remember how you were obsessing over it a week ago. How does that feel. I say, confused. And embarrassing. I understand the emotional trauma I was going through. I remember the frustration too. But mostly I feel pity on myself. I took a lot of unnecessary burden. She says, unbelievable. Those are some. She mumbles a little. I ask, am I being too callous. Because I am trying not be. She says, no. These are normal response. Someone who has grieved over loved one's loss and moved on. I am glad that she understood my intent.

She flips the next images. Blake, friend. Marina, funny. Catherine, hot. She gives me curious look. I nervously smiled and blurted out immediately, ah, I mean that objectively. But why are you showing them. She answers, I need a baseline to measure. I want to see it there is a new trigger instead. That’s a terrifying thought. But I wasn't too concerned about it. Next is Nathan, problematic. Jess, potential. Tessa, dependable. Matt, good. Cassandra, sis. Vanessa, love. I started coughing a little. What the freak did I just say. I nervously bit my lip and peek at Drew. She is more composed then me. I sneakily turn away and wait for the next image.

This is so mortifying. I basically outed something very personal. I am so confused about it. I have never been so forthcoming about this before. Thankfully Drew didn't ask for details and we move on. Next was a word. Hansen, respect. Shadow keeper, strong. Shadow retrievalist, mystery. Shadow spy, guidance. John, regret. She pauses for a second. She turns to me, be prepared for the final one. I already knew who it was. An image of Wagner appears. I thought this one would stir up a lot of emotions. But the only one I felt relevant was, jackass.

There is utter silence in the room. The only sound was some from the machines. Drew had the injection placed near my shoulder, that’s all you got. I am a little taken aback from this too. I say, I got more. She waits for me. I says, a pain in the ass. Worst person I have ever met. Regret that I never fought him. She stares at me and then to the screens. Even I felt weirded out by my clam demeanor. It seems so childish that I used to get so much angry at him unnecessary. She says, M, what's the verdict. M says, no adverse reaction beyond the acceptable range. All vitals with normal range. There is no increase in emotion center of boss's brain. She asks, deviation? M answers, ten percent.

I get a little anxious, hold on. Deviation of what. I didn't lie anything. I was honest. She says, its not that. Deviation is the difference between what you said and how your body reflexes reacted. Ten percent is. She trails off with a serious look. I gulp a little, I thought I did good. But maybe I was being too optimistic. She says, its natural. I am so glad she said that, then its normal. She says with a deep thought, it is. A sudden realization came to me, hold on. I didn't have any adverse reaction. Doesn't that mean I didn't get triggered ? What about my PTSD then.

She nervously swipes her lips with tongue. She didn't say it, but her nervous and obvious shock said it all. I don't believe this, this freaking actually did it. I stood up in excitement. Drew didn't even stop me. She just stared at me and the vitals back and forth. I raise my fist in air and shouted, lets freaking go. I did it. No, we did it. I grabbed her hands and clasp it together with mine. She was bewildered to the point she was stunned. All she gave me was a curious look. I understand her shock. We both didn't know how effective this would be. I say, thanks Drew. You the best doctor I could have gotten in the whole god damn world. This is awesome.

It turn to look at the screen where Wagner's image still remained. I didn't feel angry anymore. I didn't have the need to gauge his eyes out or break that jaw. Just a normal mix of hate and pity. She stands up with a jacket for me in her hand, I have never seen this before in my entire career. I happily take the jacket and put it on. She says, you don't have a panic attack, or at least an outburst. She pulls out the metal ring from my head, I feel some lingering anxiousness. But not enough that would make me nervous.

She puts her hand on her temple, this makes no sense. There is no magical cure of PTSD. You don't just wake up and suddenly its gone. I get she is worried, but unlike her I am thrilled with this outcome. She asks, what happened in the dream. I ask, what do you mean. Didn't you guide me through the trance. I heard your voice. She says, initially. But then I lost you after a while. I try to recall the moment, but the memory is till fuzzy. I say, its all a blur at the moment. I know I died, but that’s probably just because it was the most recent memory. I gave it some more thought, I think I met people. She says, beside James and Liz?

Their names makes me recall flashes of visions and faint memories. I say, weird. Shouldn't I know more about it. You were there with me. She says, clearly the drugs effects are still there. You will remember soon. I really want to know what really happened. I turn to the door, I remember Marina and Blake are outside. I think I should let them know I woke up. I take a step forward towards the door, but my lazy leg hits at the corner of the couch. Drew says, you really shouldn't move around so much.

I says, sorry. I'll be careful. I just got. I couldn't speak another word. Something strange happens and hunch over. I grab the side the table for support. Drew rushes and grabs my arms, what happened. I couldn't explain this. My body is suddenly hot. I look down at my knees and saw that I unconsciously called on my Kuret the sport where it hurt. It begins to pour out of me without my command. What's going on. Suddenly my brain is on fire. There is loud alert coming from M. M sounds, Dr. Drew. Sedate boss immediately. My vision gets hazy unsure what was going on in the screen. But I felt no pain. Actually, I was feeling awesome. A bliss that I never felt before.

Drew screams over the sound of the alarm, what happened. His vitals were fine a second ago. M says, unclear. There is massive hemorrhaging from bosses entire nervous system. What is she saying, I feel no plain. I feel awesome. My Kuret soothes my agitated skin. Even without asking for it, I was wrapped in my Kuret. I stand back up and suddenly I felt a rush of adrenaline. My thoughts became lazy, but it was the best feeling. Drew backs away from my Kurets rampage. I topped over a table and few glass and its content spill on the ground. Few beakers broke as well.

But I didn't care. I am having the time of my life. Even why I felt metal taste in my mouth I didn't care. Nor when I saw red blurriness near the end of my vision. Drew yells, stop it David. You are sick. I yell, nah doctor. Its the opposite. I feel like the world is mine now. I tighten my fist and expel all my emotions towards the deck door. I didn't even feel commandeering my Kuret. It acted on impulse and I tore through the wall instantly. Drew backs away in the corner to safety. I hear M also saying something. But I no longer cared. I was free and I wanted to enjoy my freedom.

I walk out through the broken wall and doors. My Kuret wraps around me so intensely that I feel invincible. With this power, I can do anything. And to prove that, I thrust myself into the sky.

David (Chapter 101)

Saturday, February 21, 2026 19:22

I stir from the sound of a low music. What happened to me. My eyes open lazily and it takes a few seconds to clear the haze above me. Ah, my body feels sore. I try to move, but I couldn't. I felt my arms and legs were restrained. What the hell. I blink hard and focus on myself. I look around and realize this is my bedroom. I look down to see a strap around my chest that goes around the bed. I had shackles around my wrist and ankles. I wriggle out in frustration. Why I am chained up here. My voice hurts a little for a second. I yell, who did this to me.

The music stops and a soothing chime rings around the room. M says, good afternoon boss. Your vitals have improved considerably. But please don't force yourself. You will break your needles. I say, what is going. M says, what do you remember last. I lean back on to the pillow and try to recall how I got here. The memories become clear after a while. I was with Drew, then my Kuret started acted kind of funky. What happened then. I have vague memories of me doing something. I think I saw people outside my house. Then I jerk suddenly when the memories become clearer, did I fight others?

M replies, you did. You were under the influence of heavy narcotics. We didn't anticipate such a severe reaction to your body after the treatment. You went on a rampage and attacked others. Bloody freaking shit. I recalled glimpses of it. I was mercilessly plundering through others. I didn't have any control over myself. I spat out, I was tripping on acid. M says, a reductive but accurate assessment. Oh shit. I yell, did I hurt anyone. M says, rest assured boss, with Blake and others there, you were got man handled. Though, I get nervous, you totaled your car.

I sigh a relief in response. My car being the only collateral damage was fine with me. Based on how crazy I was acting, I got off easy. I move my arm a bit, what's with the prisoner treatment. M says, yesterday you suddenly woke up in the middle of night and hit your head while trying to walk without seeing. This was done to stop hurting yourself. I click my tongue, I don't remember that one at all. M says, that was the last vestige of the effects of the drug. You were heavily sedated and barely conscious.

Jeez, what a mess. I ask, what happened to me. I was okay, you said so yourself. M says, you were boss. There was no problem with you. Aside from an irregular neural activity, you were recovering. But the moment you used your Kuret, your vitals changed. And for reasons unknown, the drugs that were inactive in you system suddenly interacted. Resulting in a brain hemorrhaging. I recalled the taste of blood in my mouth. And I think I was bleeding through my eyes too. I asked shocked, I was bleeding from inside out. What the hell. Please tell me that is no longer happening.

M turns on a display of my brain activity. I have seen enough times to understand that its normal now. M says, the neural chip embedded behind your neck had short circuited and we had replace it. I ask, how that happened. M says, your brain activity generated so much heat that it broke it. My jaw hung loose, my brain fried the chip. All because I was high on drugs. That is ridiculous. M says, please wait for Dr. Drew to arrive. I saw your neural activity spiking and messaged her. She will be arriving shortly.

That’s good. I nervously look around my body. I was wearing a thin white cloth. But then I focused my eyes on something small. I ask, you said something about needles. Is this. M says, acupuncture needles. You have 87 pressure needles from all over your head, your face to your scalp. This is to stimulate your nerves. Please be mindful of that. She should have led with this. I take a deep breath and relax myself. I ask, I think am okay right now. Get me out of the straps. M says, Dr. Drew gave strict instructions for you to not move.

I sigh, I won't leave the bed. I just want to sit for comfortably. M says, all right boss. However, please restraint yourself from using your Kuret. We don't know what other side effects there will be. I nod. The next second I hear a mechanical noise. Then a combat bot in its compact mode approaches me. I ask, its been reactivated. Since when? M says, Drew asked for assistance for delivering the sedatives. My objectives allowed to wake them up in case of emergency. I ask, did others saw it too. M says, they did. I sigh, I was hoping they didn't. I was going to give them to IDF, but I needed to explain its function first.

The combat bot had shifted to two legs and three arms. With meticulous movements, it removes my restraints. I am finally able to move again. The bot leaves the room as I slither back and take rest on the pillows. There was a bottle kept on the side labeled, drink me. It was from Drew. I uncorked it drank it without checking what it was. My throat was so dry that I didn't care. It tasted like electrolytes. I could a little as I wipe my lips. I ask, how long was I out. M says, you have been unconscious for 39 hours. The shock jerks me a little, two days. Seriously. M says, another consequence we failed to anticipate.

I lost more days due to this. I lie back trying to sort out my memories. Few minutes went by and I began recollecting everything after I started the hypnosis deep trance. I smile when I realized what had just happened. I got over my PTSD. The joy surged though me like electricity. The dream I was having is also somewhat clear to me now. Did I really talk to myself disguised as dead people. I think I made promises to certain people too. This is so weird. But I was curious of something. I ask, M, run protocol for evaluating PTSD triggers. M says, boss, I strongly advice that.

I say, just do it. I want to check it if really happened or was that because I was high. M turns on the display on the other wall. M says, advising caution. The she starts to play photos of all the Shadow members. One by one they go by in different scenarios. Alive, then dead. They were all generated variations to test my emotions. It ended with Wagners photo. I quint my eyes, blink hard. Even tilt my head sideways. But I felt normal. If I wasn't covered in needles, I would slap my own cheeks to confirm. Nothing. All I feel are normal emotions. This is really happening. My PTSD is gone. I haven't had a panic attack, or a night terror. Does it mean I have gotten over my issues.

I raise my fists in the air overjoyed and started laughing. Then I felt a little sting in my chest. M says, careful boss. The nano bots didn't have time to completely heal your ribs. I stung a little, but it still felt good. I decided to view the recording when I woke up that night. After seeing how crazy my behavior was, I hear a car approaching. M says, Dr. Drew is here. A minute later she walks in. She wore hear usual jacket and jeans. Drew says, David. Glad to see you up. She puts her crane and bag to the chair and walks to my bedside. I say, its good to see you too. I made a lot of mess, didn't I. She asks, did M tell you or you remembered.

I say, both. I just saw the video recording of me absolutely humiliating myself in front of others. She smiles at me. I can't believe how I was cruelly rating everyone's attack. I was being especially rude to Vanessa. She says, they understood it wasn't you. You were, I offered, high on drugs. Wasn't I. She nods, there wasn't much left in your system. I say, we should have just kept the dialysis machine running a little longer. Could have avoid all the mess. I don't know how I thought it was okay to take it off. That’s my bad.

She says, you were awake and aware, but you couldn't process complex thoughts. Its my fault too. I didn't realize sooner what just happened. I ask, does that means you figured it out what really happened. She sighs, I spent the whole day yesterday and this morning to understand what went wrong. At first it didn't make sense. You just woke up and displaying extraordinarily ordinary responses. The same stuff that would trigger various complex and intense emotions few weeks ago. I add, and FYI, I just tested myself again now. I had the same response.

She asks, seriously. You could have just waited for me. I shrug, the curiosity was eating at me. She chuckles, its fine. I found out something last night and knew you were going to be fine. These restraints were just a precaution. I ask confused, so how is it am already cured. She says, like I was saying. It was strange, and then something even stranger happened. The moment you used your Kuret, your brain started to do act up. A completely unprecedented chain reaction happened. I nervously ask, what kind of reaction are we talking about.

She pulls out her tablet from her chair and gives it to me. The display was split into two halves. One said before and the other after. It was a snapshot of a few seconds of my neural activity. She says, this one is before we started our therapy. And this one is from this morning. Notice any differences. I didn't understand her. This wasn't a typical MRI scan. It was showing a 3D grid of neural pathways and activity. What difference will this show? Regardless, I analyze the data. If we are talking just about visual difference, I can easily spot it.

I point to a section at the corner, this one. It's a little different. I see a new fork in the path. Then I notice a difference where the fork is now a new path. I didn't understand the meaning behind it. Considering Drew should me it to me personally, I am missing something here. She says, the difference you are seeing is the cause of that sudden hemorrhaging. I realize something and asked horrified, you said this is my neural pathways. I am guessing it doesn't change naturally.

She says, unless you have an accident or loose cognitive ability, this type of restructuring doesn't happen. At least not without severe consequences. I am lost here. I ask, what are you saying to me. She says, your brain rewired itself. I drop my tablet in utter shock. I bit my lip confused, how did that happen. She picks up the tablet, it doesn't happen naturally in Humans. But this happens to Medrones. I ask, seriously. When does that happen. She asks, how much do you know about Ketriya.

The name sounds familiar, I try to recollect that info. She cocks her head, you do? How. I couldn't tell her how, its not like I know everything. I say, I read about it once. But I don’t recall everything. She says, its a hormonal growth in young Medrones. Typically between the ages of 4 and 6. It used to be common knowledge back on Medrine. But now with so less people, only few knowledgeable know about it. Mostly those trained medically.

I gathered the rest from this information, children born on earth don't go through it anymore. Isn't that right. They go through it during puberty now. Very less percentage of our current young population are teenagers, around 40% will through it in two years. She says, you know your stuff. I say, it’s was a fascinating statistics. But what is that got to do with me. She says, children go through Ketriya when they awaken their Kurets. Its a natural and normal growth for kids. Since you heard about it, then do you know how it work.

I didn't know the details, refresh my memories. She says, until kids use their Kuret, our brain is very identical to Humans. But as you grow, it changes bit by bit. It normal for both species. Except there is one critical difference. Medrone kids brain goes through a metamorphosis. Speaking your language, it recodes itself. Changes the neural paths to adjust for the new conscious control of their Kuret. Every kid goes through it, with no exception. It happens slowly over a period of weeks. And its completely harmless and painless. Almost no one realizes it since its become such a norm. A natural growth for kids

I finally understand what she is telling me. It only made me puzzled, are you saying I went through Ketriya. But I am already an adult. Besides, you said the brain develops for Kuret control. I already have it. She says, like I said, there are no exceptions to this. That is, until two days ago. You became the sole exception in entire history of Medrone to go through Ketriya as an adult. The most extreme case I heard back on Medrine was of age 8. You broke the record by three times. I am bamboozled from being such an aberration.

I shake my head, no. That can't be. I have never gone through any sort of Kuret puberty. She says, you did now. I confirmed it last night with multiple tests.. Ketriya is a phase where Kuret grows along with restructuring of the brain during the weeks in brief phases. You, she points her index finger to me, have been going through it for the past 20 twenty years. This is an unpreceded case in which you are an extremely late bloomer. I sigh, I have become a more unique outlier in all of Medrone.

Freaking hell. I finally experienced something that normal Medrone have. This made me strangely happy too. Like I belonged to Medrones and not just due to biology. I ask, so the bleeding from my brain. It was because Ketriya happened to an adult brain. She nods, young children's brain's are plastic, able to handle modifications much easier than adults. Your brain experienced a massive growth that night. Such a long Ketriya had bound to cause a lot of scaring and abrasions. I suspect if you were normal Medrone, you wouldn't have survived such a brutal evolution.

I can't wrap my head around this startling revelation. There had to be reason for this. I ask, is it because was a MAR's subject? She nods, most likely. She nervously shifts in her chair, I have a wild theory. Would you like to hear it. I say, you know people like us love theories. Lay it on me. She says, back on Medrine. I had a chance to see MAR's research dossiers. The agencies wanted to understand their extremist ideology. Me and many others people were consulted. And it was pretty much what everyone knows. They were experimenting on infants to make them live on Earth with access to Kuret. I had forget about a term I saw in that research, Ketriya deficiency disorder.

I understood what it means from the name. But I haven't come across this from our secret project research. She says, it doesn't exist. I am confused, so it’s a made up disease. She says, not quite. MARs claims this is real, but no

one could study it to prove its existence. A moment later I realize why, you think MAR's were kidnapping pregnant women and children before anyone knew. She says, we can't prove something exists when we can't test it. I vaguely remembered the details outlined in that research. So here's my theory, MAR's were either targeting people with this disease or maybe even causing it to susceptible people. I can't comment why or how, but they might have chosen people with this genetic mutation for their research.

This is the first time since Nathan that I heard a theory like this. I ask, any evidence? She says, the research might have mentioned something about prolonging KDD. Stretching it out over years, rather than years. That way, even without your Kuret access, the rest of your brain could develop uninterrupted. At the time it was completely ludicrous. Delaying Ketriya will result in Medrone kid's death in a few years. Everyone dismissed this outright and called them pseudo mad scientist. But now its possible we have found a case. You. Your growth doesn't matched exactly like how they detailed. But this is actual, nature influenced, evolution and that was a theory on a paper.

I took a moment to take this in. I ask, so they modified our genetics to adjust Ketriya period. Something that would be lethal to normal kids. Assuming if we had KDD at birth and diagnosed to die soon since we wouldn't survive without it. Does that mean MAR's were trying to saving us? This made my thoughts upside down. All this time everyone, including me, have assumed MAR's were crazy scientists and lofty agendas. Drew says, maybe. They could have found a way to cause it artificially. We can't rule it out. She is right, there are still suspicious. But this opens a new discussion about them.

I say, there is a lot of maybes. She says, it’s a theory. I couldn't really fact check this. There are few trained professionals in the Island, but none know about their research. But I believe few people from Citradel could know about it. They have more scientists and research data. Another reason for me to bring them here. KDD is an intriguing research subject. I ask, can you share what you know about it. She says, sure. I have been making notes from memories. Why do you need it. I couldn't tell it was for my project. I answer, I have my own private genetics labs with my team. If your theory is right, I like to find prove of this. She nods, that could be important. It might be helpful in the future for our kids in case this KDD is real.

She made a good point. MAR's experiments were on Earth. So are every surviving Medrone. The chances of KDD happening naturally might be low, but its still possible. Once again I am reminded of how my value as a test subject. I sigh, I wish at least one MAR's scientist had survived. There are so many questions to be asked. Why people were left on Earth cryogenically frozen and tool some of us back to Medrone. Drew says, perhaps they were failed subjects while the kids with you in the orphanage were successful. I didn't like the thought of labeling Liz as a failure. But I get Drew is only viewing this from a scientist point of view.

It can't really deny completely though. Nathan once suspected the same thing before. She says, anyways. That’s just my speculation. From this point on, its hard facts. I ask, there is more? She smiles, there is. I haven't explain why this happened to you so suddenly. She takes the tablets and taps on the screen. A minute she says, M, run the program from my tablet. A hologram shows in the middle of the room. It first showed a map of neural pathways. She says, this is your brain after you arrived on Earth. You had taken many MRI's and CT scans, I was able to make a model from the data.

M says, its accurate with only 63% confidence. Drew says, it’s a good enough approximation. Then another neural map forms beside it, this one is when you had your heart transplant. Then three more appear, this from 8 months ago, 2 days ago and this morning. Laying my brain scans juxtaposed in a timeline, the differences in the pathways becomes much apparent. Drew explains, this is how I know your Ketriya been active for years. I don't any data for your time on Medrone. So I don't want to assume anything. But there is clear changes since arriving on Earth. Actually there is trend, first 8 years, the changes were very minimal.

She points to the fast three scans, its been progressing much rapidly. Culminating with the highest 28 percent change 2 days ago. When you accidently used your Kuret, it triggered the final phase of Ketriya. My eyes dart around the timeline. Specifically the time she recorded the data. She didn't have all the data. I think there is even more evidence to support this. I say, I have experienced my Kuret evolving differently than others for few years. I didn't tell her about how I imagined seeing Kuret from the surrounding flowing into me.

She says, so you felt it too. In fact, in your match with Charles, a few pathways tried to change, but it reverted very quickly. Your body had resisted Ketriya. But for that brief time, your Kuret control skyrocketed. Damn, that was my physical Kuret breakthrough. That's why I haven't been able to use it since then. Freaking balls. I scoffs, are you telling me that it wasn't due to how I learned from Charles about his Kuret. It was a freaky coincidence? She says, who says it can't be both. Fueled by the intense pressure, your Kuret control and Ketriya both augmented each other. If it you hadn't resisted the transition, you would sustain brain bleed there itself.

In hindsight, that was actually a good thing. People didn't know about Drew and Drew wasn't remotely prepared to treat me. I say, between your theory and my Kuret awakening, I have a lot to think about it. She nods, take your time. I only explained what I know how your Kuret is different. I ask, so what happens to it. Did I magically gained the complete form. Maybe I will go though Kizaton like how others go through during puberty. She says, I had the same questions. Hard to say. Maybe you already went through it while recovering on Earth. Your optic nerves healing could be part of it. Or maybe its yet to happen. Its hard to predict with your physiology.

I sigh, I am going to need a stiffer drink. She puts the tablet down, save it for later. Because I haven't even told the really fun part. I was ready to be done with this much. What other revelations of my strange existence can be there. She points to the neural maps, look at the timeline. Then think about this past year. And then two days ago. I glances my eyes over it again. I didn't know what I am missing. She says, a hint. See the correlation with your psyche. Her cryptic clue didn't really help. What's so important of the timeline.

Then it hit me. She has been explaining all this for a simple question I asked her. How am I suddenly not having PTSD anymore. If what she is implying is true then. I couldn't finish my thoughts. She realized I caught on, you didn't undergo a lot of drastic changes in your brain for years on Earth. Even after accessing your Kuret, it wasn't significant. But then things took a turn 2 years ago. You started to gain back your memories. We all, including me, assumed that the serum you took lost its effect due to time. But that’s not the complete reason.

I close my eyes, my brain had recoded enough time that the memories came back flooding in. Didn't it? Just like how the drugs that were in my blood started to effect me suddenly. She says, yes. That’s correct. Did you clock the rest too. I gave a subtle nod, between the start of therapy and now, the percentage difference have been substantial. And along with that my PTSD worsened. Dammit. My PTSD was linked to Ketriya. I open my eyes to her, was that even a PTSD? Or deranged physiological issue manifesting as PTSD. She says, there was many component of PTSD, I am sure of that. Because the therapy was working for you. However, the evidence is compelling.

I get a little annoyed, this is nuts. Not even a million years would I have ever guess I was suffering trauma from both, a physical and phycological issues. That has to be one of the most freaked up thing I have experienced. I am angry, to whom I don't know. Maybe the universe. Maybe myself. She says, I know its tough to swallow. I know you suffered a lot, but you come out strong. And I don't mean figuratively. I am only telling you this because you are like me. Soon you would have driven yourself crazy trying to make sense of how you are magically cured. I couldn't let it go until I found the answer. Scientifically or Kuret related.

I take sip of water from the jug beside me. I feel like my brain would explode. I smirk knowing it actually did. I say, thanks. For everything. And I mean it. You are right. Getting to the truth is important to me. Don't know how I feel about it though. I am going to revisit all the various decisions, all the therapy work we did. Try to make sense of this sense. She leans forward, I understand. But know this, whatever happened, only reasons changed. You still had to do the work, learn more about yourself and get better. You were still sick. I know she was trying to assure me this wasn't a waste. But I wonder now, would I have still had PTSD if I had gone through Ketriya a tad bit earlier.

I scratch my back since I couldn't do to my face with the needles still on my skin. I take a deep breath, is there anymore more. Because if there is, I had my fill of fun, as you so amusing put it. She smiles, that’s all I got. I hope you don't take this the wrong way, but you are a much interesting research subject than I ever imagined. I laugh at her serious but nervous tone. She looked tiered, so I assume has spent nights working on figuring me out. She says, I if its not too much trouble, I would like to keep this particular treatment under wraps. I want to go through the whole thing again with different perspective.

I smile, you sound excited. What happened to sticking with just therapy. Don't tell me you miss the science. She becomes a little hesitant at my teasing. She remains a little quiet after realizing she was doing more than needed. I say, its fine if you miss this work. And don't worry, I am not going to recruit you. But the door is open for you. She scoffs, please don't. I won't deny I am getting a little ahead of myself. But that’s a lingering feeling for a long buried past. I reply, so that’s what denial looks on you. She shots me a look. I say, trust me. I know what it feels to hold on your past with guilt. My brain was physically stuck in the past.

I could tell she wants to avoid talking more about it. I didn't want to push it. Its her decision to pursue whatever she wanted. She says, look at you mister I know it all. Your brain only rerouted new paths, it didn't effect your personality. Mind telling me happened after you stepped into your university. I say, that’s where I lost you? She nods, yes. You gone mute and only mumbling few words. I didn't want to administer another dose since I already gave you once before. So I had to let you go unguided. It was unsettling for me to leave you alone in your own exposed mind. I had no other choice to wait. I only got through to you later when you were screaming for missing something and I mentioned your Kuret to you.

I remember it now. It was when I was fighting Wagner. I think I was stuck and needed to remind of my Kuret. I smile, sorry. Its deeply person with Shadows. It involves people other than Zakerine and Wagner. She glares at me a little but doesn't make a frustrated expression. She understood it was my private thoughts. I continue, I will tell that many people showed up and helped with certain perspectives. Of course I knew at the time it was talking back to myself, but it changed me little by little. The screaming you mentioned, that was my final fight with Wagner. I thought I was meant to defeat him, to finally get some piece. But it was all a distraction to the real truth.

She asks, which was? I replied, like you don't know. Tell me, when did you realize I was unreasonably hating Wagner. She remains unfazed trying to play dumb. But she has been poking at my thoughts for months. No way she didn't know about it. After a few moments of silence she finally broke, I wasn't sure, but I noticed clear signs of deflection on the second month. I chuckle at being so transparent. I say, and you didn't say anything. She replies, that’s not how therapy works. Not at least with you. I had a strong suspicion. Last week you blamed Zakerine too. I realized you hide your reasons behind them. Its a classic coping mechanism. I am surprised you never noticed it.

Great, she is turning it on me now. I sigh, touché. You wanted to let me figure it out myself. She nods, if couldn't accept it yourself, there would be no point in me revealing it. So, she nods at me, seeing how Ketriya came though, you finally accepted everything about yourself. Its hard to know if noticed she knew about me before or not. I gave a sly smile and came out, yeah. I had a very hard time to accept my selfish and arrogant side. But I don't want to give any excuses anymore. I had to show her my clear intent. She learned enough about me from this. She says, good to hear. Having modesty and humility is fine, but times like this, in war, you need more. You need to have enough confidence in yourself.

I ask, even when its borderline narcissism. She replies, in wars, soldiers need to be in a particular mindset. You can't expect you all to have rational feelings. She has never been in battle, I am sure she has treatment many people with familiar stories. She gives a serious tone, but reign in some moderation time to time. I say, don't worry Drew. I feel a hundred times much mentally ready now. She nods, glad to hear. She stands up, I need to get back home soon. But I want to test one last thing before I leave. I ask, you just got here though. She says, no. I have been spending a lot of time yesterday. I can't keep making excuses for my absence to Parry and the kids.

She already did a lot for me, I can't keep her occupied with this any more than necessary now. She works on pulling out all the acupuncture needles from my head. Then we walk to the destroyed deck. There was a makeshift wooden planks nailed to the wall, with a tarp wrapped around it. The combat bots must have sealed it shut and tried to hide the damage from the outside. We take the other door and step into the lawn. There were few patches that were covered with soil and no grass. I asked, do you know how this was covered.

She explains that Blake made an excuse that this was a training session and things got out of hand. The only really damage was to my car, which got destroyed and sitting inside the garage. That is easy enough to convince others. Drew says, I checked for any physical issues last night. Nothing alarming. But there is a slight increase in your ATP generation of your brain and spine. You might have not noticed it yet, but your oxygen intake by the tissues is increased by 15 percent. Damn. I had a thought just now, so will I expend more energy. She says, it’s the equivalent or normal people burning more ambient Kuret in their body. You just do it with oxygen instead.

Burning oxygen means more output calories. I suspect she wants to test my Kuret, I saw the footage of my Kuret. You want to know if there is any adverse reaction to using my Kuret. She says, physically you have recovered. But I couldn't test anything with your Kuret. So as much I don't want to risk this, its more risky to not check it out. Your Kuret also evolved along with you. And based on what others told me the night, you displayed radical abilities. I want to make sure they aren't going to negatively impact you. You are sure to resume training soon enough.

I am thankful she also anticipated my plans for the future. I know the reasons for my sudden change in Kuret, but that doesn't change the fact that I need to train and master it. I ask, what do you want me to do. She bring out a single injector, I want you to bring out your Kuret. But only for 10 seconds. M will monitor your brain from the modified chip I implanted yesterday. And if anything goes wrong. She waves the injector to me. I got the message. I

ask, I think its overkill, but maybe we should bring a combat bot too. She says, I have asked M to have one in standby. Besides, 10 seconds won't be enough for you to go fully berserk.

I didn't want to leave it to chance, if don't stop, just use it regardless. She takes a step away from me as I prepare myself. The feeling anxious and a hint of excitement. I take a whole minute of deep breathing to lock in. I give a signal to Drew and bring out my Kuret. I felts nothing different for half a second. But then it felt like the dam broke open. My Kuret comes out from my whole body even when I wanted only on my hands. The Kuret was vibrating so chaotically I didn't realize it initially. I waited for five seconds, but I didn't feel any pain. I started to enjoy this incredible feeling of tingles coming off my bones.

But then I started to glimmer and raised my palm over my eyes in reflex. There were so many different spectrum of colors and so intense. I closed my eyes and it caused me more disorientation from the sudden influx of glimmers. I felt down on one knee breathless a little. Drew came rushing yelling, what happened. I could see the glimmers of the injector closer to me. She is going to inject me. But before she could push it against by neck, I intuitively guarded myself with my Kuret. I didn't command it to vibrate faster, it already turned into the wild Kuret and stops the injector. Not just that, I accidently blew it away from Drew's hand. She jerks a little and stumbles back with her cane.

I raise my palm to her, just wait a second. I will my Kuret to settle down. I already crossed the 10 seconds mark, but I had gained enough control to pull it back in. The glimmers in my eyes lessen and I could see normally again. She hesitantly asks, David, is everything all right. I sigh as I get back on my feet, sorry for scaring you. I acted on impulse. She turns to the crushed injector on the ground, its okay. You didn't hurt me. But I felt your Kuret. She raised her palm, very interesting. Your friend, Cassandra said something like you cutting off their access to Kuret. She puts her hand away and smiles, that is quite the troublesome power you have.

I inspected her hand. I feel relieved that I didn't bruise her. Then I wished I could see with my glimmers to know what happened. She says, I am fine. Trust me. Lets hope she wasn't putting up a front for my sake. I say, the glimmers were too much for me. I couldn't see anything. She leans in, you were blinded from it. I nod, this was too much. I don't think only my Kuret has improved. Did you happen to see any changes in my optic nerves. She says, I did. As you suspect, it is linked to your frontal cortex. So naturally it has changed too. I reply, I had a very similar problem long time ago. I think I need to relearn this again. Its like there is a massive reset.

She nods, you may be right. Your eyes might have become much more sensitive now. I know I had to relearn my control, but this only excited me more. And Kuret feels on whole new level. Maybe this my Kuret was supposed to be from the beginning. She says, you will need a diet plan to compensate for your new changes. M showed me your latest nutrient strategy. It wasn't half bad, but I have recommended changes to incorporate new changes. I reply, thanks a lot. That will help a lot.

I turn my hand into a fist feeling jubilant. I have only shown false confidence to others until now, but with this new ability, I can now match against an overdrive Heraknus.

Blake (Chapter 102)

Tuesday, February 24, 2026 14:16

The officers building is empty right now except for few people. Me, Luther and Tina stayed back to finish up objectives from our latest success. Few hours back we got a message from Nathan that he was able to get through the science team in Italy. Despite the obvious obstacle from Citradel warriors, three days of relentless efforts paid off. The warriors couldn't stop Nathan or Frank from meeting them. Frank mentioned in his message that they didn't want to escalate by fighting two warriors. That was the outcome we were hoping.

Luther gives me the action items. I take a look at it and hand it back after confirming the details. I say, this is good enough. Just go over with Tessa over assigned personal people for them. Luther says, I have a meeting with her tomorrow. After the admin meeting, of course. Tina asks, anything we need to prepare for it in advance. I waved my hand, I don't think there is anything we can do any more. Heraknus didn't say much who they are sending. We will prepare the usual place for their brief stay.

Tina says, you know, I didn't think Heraknus would agree to our meeting request. Citradel is still in lockdown, aren't they. Luther says, same. I can't imagine their council is very happy about this. Means the Heraknus are really serious about moving here. I say, Charles has publicly agreed to corporate with us. That means they no longer are tied to Citradel. A little chuckle passed through my lips at the thought of them breaking out of Citradel. Tina says, council must have tried to stop them. Luther scoffs, it would create a bigger chaos. They already have their hands full with other stuff.

David's human organization has been continuously hijacking and stealing their precious resources in broad daylight. Tina did mention in her report this morning that the shipments are getting smaller. But we have a surplus of martials to work with now. So much so that she requested for additional land to store them. Citradel is not only bleeding dry from this, they got their own internal strife. Their priest Selena hasn't stopped her blatant campaign of convincing others to move. We heard a rumor that its escalated to the point of protests. I don't know how much that is true because its not covered by the human news stations in Citradel.

I say, it doesn't matter if Citradel supported Heraknus or not. They are coming tomorrow. Lets focus on that. Tina sighs, it would help we know how many individuals are coming. Luther shrugs, I tried asking. But they didn't want to leak any particular information in case other communities got wind of it. I don't know why they couldn't at least tell us. We are going to be neighbors soon. I partially agreed with them. Its a little suspicious they only told they are coming. I say, who knows. Maybe Charles is with them. Tina replies, I don't think so. Luther asks, you know something. Tina says, not really. Just a hunch. Would he be busy with his house members in Citradel.

Few officers also believed he would be arrive. I honestly don't know. It would be better if he arrives, since its his match we are going to discuss tomorrow. But its not totally necessary for him be here. Luther says, I am more excited to know more Heraknus people. I know they are normal people, but they will become famous soon. He wasn't alone. Everyone on the island have been waiting to meet other Heraknus. The public only know about Charles for now. Tina says, speaking of famous people. What's our recent celebrity doing. We messaged him this morning, and he hasn't responded to us.

David's sudden absence had people nervous. I couldn't exactly tell them the truth. So far we covered with saying me and Marina spared with him and it got out of hand. But it wouldn't hold up for much longer. I say, I am going to meet him for dinner. The guy has been holed up is house coming with different strategies. Luther asks, I get that. But he can at least see his messages. I have been thinking of sending him a priority alert message many time today. Tina scoffs, I hear he had been getting too many calls and messages from people. Even those from outside. Just a life of celebrity, I guess.

I need to defended him for now, he might be very busy with blocking Citadel's efforts to steal back their stuff. I imagine its very time consuming coordinating stuff remotely. I gave a white lie hoping they will buy it. I have been telling versions of it all day. Tina says, yeah. The shipments have started to become less bulky. Luther remained unconvinced. But I am meeting him directly, so there is no problem. He asks, I guess that is very challenging. Anyways, be sure to tell him to show his face in public. We can't keep placing officers around his house to stop reporters and kids. Tina smirks, don't forget the group of girls that tried to sneak in. Do they think they will see him from outside.

If only they knew the whole story with David. I say, I will tell him. I eye to Tina, maybe not about that. I don't want to stroke his ego. We had laugh to relieve some tension. I look at the time, I should get going on. See you guys. We all parted for the night. I decided to not take my car and instead fly there. Last time my car was nearly destroyed. If it weren't for his car blocking mine, I would be mine that be totaled. I get a message from Drew around 3 that David had woken up and was back to normal. I messaged others about his condition. But I still cautioned them to keep a little distance. For their safely just in case David looses his mind again.

Matt and Cass took some convincing, but they agreed to wait for David to meet them. Catherine said she is coming. I didn't have any good reason to stop her. Siera and Vanessa said they just wanted latest update. I am guessing Vanessa didn't want to face him again so soon and Siera is just backing her. In about ten minutes I reach his house and descend down. Once I landed on his driveway, I heard people talking inside. I look up their aura. Marina and Catherine are both inside. I guess its my time to be late. I dispersed my Kuret and rang the bell. M voice responds, Blake, you can head through to the basements. Boss and others are in lab down.

What are they doing there. The door opens and I takes the stairs down. Besides their voice, I heard a machine buzzing. Are they working on something. I open the door and peak inside. The table in middle of the room is covered in sophisticated chemistry setup. There are different chemicals being passed though the beakers and long glass tubes. In the corner, a large 3D printing machine was running. Beside it, others were sitting. I see David among them. He looked much better than yesterday, when we visited. He had down a workshop apron. He also had some sort of big cloth around his neck. Did he get hurt again.

David waves at me, hey Blake. Its good to see you. Marina pouts, you are late. I ignored her cheap jab. Catherine and I wave hi to each other. I walk closer to David who stood up to meet me. He had a little serious expression, let me just apologies for my actions. I scared a lot of you unnecessarily. He really is much better now. He raises his fist to me. I nervously fist bump him not really sure how is so chipper. Catherine says, look at your face. You weren't expecting this, huh? Honestly, I don't know what I was expecting. Its not just he is better, he is relaxed.

I ask, so no more tantrum like that. He smiles, yeah. That's the last time I am ever going to do any king of psychedelics. More than being mortified by my actions, I am more horrified what a disaster I become. I take an empty seat beside Catherine. I ask, as long as you are better, its all good. But you scared us a lot. You weren't just high, you showed crazy strength before. I turned to Catherine, did he explain how this happened. She waves, no. He wanted to wait for you first. That's a good call. She says, besides. I had a lot to say to him before. That's right, she found about his true identity.

Marina says, you missed a lot. Catherine laid him out pretty good. I smile imagining that. Catherine scoffs, I should have seen the signs. You three are so close. She eyes me like it was my fault too. I can't exactly say I am blameless. David says, since you are here. Settle us a bet. Who was the one who told Catherine about me. I can't believe the atmosphere had become so cavalier. David wasn't even bothered by the slightest. I say, it was Cass I think. He clicks tongue, damn. Marina says, ha. I told you the truth. But you kept believing Matt would bring it up immediately. What kind of game were they even playing. I am so confused.

I turn to Catherine who was also enjoying this. She asks, what. I ask, I thought you be more angry at him. She says, I was initially. But he explained his reasons. While I didn't like that he kept something so huge from us, from me. I understand his reasons. David says, besides, I think she is more impressed with me than be angry. Whoa, what happened to him. He sounds far more easygoing for someone who went something harrowing. Marina says to me, even he noticed it. Can you imagine what he said to us when Catherine and I showed up. I am hesitant to ask what he did. Normally I wouldn't be bothered by it, but I have a suspicion its something aberrant.

David gives coy smile with a little awkwardness, it was nothing. I just welcomed the ladies. Lets not make a big deal out of that. Marina scoffs loudly, you think we can just forget it. I turn to Catherine with a curious look for answer. She sighs not amused, he subtly insulated about a threesome or something like that. My eyes widen with utter shock. I turn to David, who was not being enough guilty about it. He chuckles, it was clearly a joke. What do you think people will say if two beauties visit me in the night. I turn to others wondering who would even believe this. Marina says, please. I got standards. Catherine gave Marina a look asking if she meant Catherine doesn't. David says, I admit it was in a poor taste. It was a harmless joke. Don't you think?

He was asking me to bail him out. But the surprise of cheerful attitude hadn't left me yet. I ask, you are really feeling okay. He says, never better. Didn't Drew said so herself. I blurt out, then what the hell happened. You acting very different. He smiles, that's because I am. And I am not being glib about it. Before I ask what he meant, he then raises his palm, hold on. I think the solution is done. Give me a second. He walks to the platform and puts on a goggle from the counter. He then takes a dropper and begins to perform some chemistry.

I turn to Marina, has he been acting like this all the time. Marina smiles, kind of. It surprised the hell out of me too. But to be honest, I kind of like it. Catherine says, he does seem to be less burdened. I whisper, is he like. I point my finger to my head. David behind me says, I saw that. I thought he was engrossed by his work. Marina says, he says he isn't forcing himself to be like this. But who knows. Catherine says, I thought he was a little crazy in the beginning. David puts his goggle down, that's fair. Don't worry though. Just thought its time to improve my social skills a little. He then pours a liquid, and I haven't lost my touch too. The liquid sizzles a little from the beaker.

I turn towards him, what are you doing there anyways. Marina says, he is making a coating of boron lining on a pair of shades. Marina says, maybe he wants to style up his life. Based on how he is acting, its wasn't far fetched. He says, I wish it was just a fashion statement. Its less interesting. He picks up two lenses with tongs and dips them into a petri dish filled with a black liquid. We all hurdle around him as he pours another liquid on top of the lens. He then repeats it again with another petri dish and another set of lenses.

Once down he sets his goggle down, this should set in about few hours. I ask, are you ready to tell us what is going on now. He faces to us, leaning against the table. He says, let me just clear one thing first. I can't talk about my treatment. Drew put a gag order explaining it was untested and technically unethical. And I agreed. So unfortunately I will not disclose the methods. Marina whines a little, you are going to hang us dry like this. He cuts her off, I know its frustrating. But those are my doctors order. And I am going to respect her decision. If you have a problem with it, I suggest you ask her.

He makes it very clear he wasn't going to go against her on this. Catherine says, I can understand Drews concern. But we were there, you know. We know some stuff already. I nod, yeah. She said you were high, and you said it yourself about using drugs. Marina says, can you tell us what kind of drugs were used. He smiles at her, trying to score some drugs from me. Too bad. Your going to have to ask the dealer directly. He was clearly enjoying keeping up the suspense. Marina knew he was deliberately goading her, but she was giving David the evil eyes.

I didn't know how this new dynamic would explode, so I get us back on track, what can you tell us. He turns a little hesitant. Catherine says, at least tell us how your Kuret got stronger. I am still so embarrassed I couldn't do anything back then. She is referring to her failed attempt to catch David off guard. David says, I not trying to hide anything. I am just thinking how to explain it. We wait for him to tell what he was having hard time to say. He says, I guess I'll do how Drew explained it to me. What do you know about Ketriya.

Now that's a word I haven't heard in long time. But other two didn't seem to know about it. Marina says, no idea. Catherine says, I think I have heard it back on Medrine. But I can't remember what it is. I say, really. You guys don't know what it is. I am disappointed. Catherine asks, what is it. Some sort of Kuritine. Its not that. Though I can't imagine how it is related to him. David gestures me to explain. I say, it's a phenomena that happens to us as when we are small children. When we first get the first taste of our Kuret. Marina says, there is specific term for such an obvious thing ? Catherine says, all I remembered that was something related to children.

I say, its an old terminology. But still, its pretty damn important if you ask me. David says, I am guessing royals consider it to be special. He guessed right, some of our family members still celebrate it. Its not a custom, but I remember attending a ritual of passage to a cousin once. Catherine asks, whoa. You guys are so lavish about it. I shrug, dad told me he did it for me too. I was too young to remember that. Marina asks, I didn't know people would be considerate of this. I don't know if mom did it for me.

I say, I guess not everyone cares about it much. David says, that’s actually normal. Even I didn't know about it. When Kuret biology is common in Medrone society, you don't put significance to every little thing. Drew did say it’s a piece of lost medical knowledge. Not many would know about it. And even if they did know, they wouldn't put any real significance to it. With our current state of things, that’s actually the most probable effect. Marina says, fine lets chalk that to list of things we should learn. What its got to with you.

He raises his eyebrows to us waiting to get the hint he seems to be giving on his face. What is he implying. He says, I thought you would guess it. But its pretty far out. So let me just say it. I just had my Ketriya. As in, when I am an adult. That makes no sense. He already has uses Kuret. Marina giggles, be serious. David says, I am. Then he told us all about Drews insights and conclusion. After 10 minutes of full surprise and shock, he ends up saying, so yeah. That’s how I cured my PTSD. He makes air quotes on the last word.

I was stroking my chin, because I was just dumped such unbelievable explanation. Catherine says shocked, so to summarize. Your Ketriya ran for years, unlike ours. That saved your from a genetic disorder. And it also made your Kuret change over the years, the same we do but in weeks. Marina says, and it's also responsible for your PTSD. I continued on, your head was bleeding because your brain finally adapted to Kuret control. I am flabbergasted to hear such a incredibly convoluted medical history.

The only who wasn't shocked was David, who was now preparing our dinner. He had ditched his neck comforter, which was actually a neck massager. I couldn't believe he was so chill about this. He laid out the plates in front of us on the table of his dinning room, bon appetite. I couldn't really focus on the steak and salad he had prepared for us. Marina cries out, how are you okay. He says, I had a day to sort through this. After a while I just sort accepted this absurdity. At least he is honest how he himself feels about it. I ask, then your Kuret is complete now? He takes a sip of wine from the glass, unclear. Drew said Ketriya is 99 percent over. But no one knows, just like no one knows when Medrone kids go through it. Its up to biology and nature.

Catherine, which nature. Earths or Medrines. Because you are more closer to Ketriya in teenagers growing on Earth. He says, take your pick. I am sure there are arguments for both side. He swirls his glass amused by our confusion. Now it is making a little sense how he was able to use suddenly such a strong Kuret. He says, in any case, now that I have gone through it. I have undergone a bit of metamorphous. Just like how children behaviors changes, so has mine. But in my case it’s a little severe. I ask, because it happened to you late in life. He points the wine glass to me, yeah. You think you are shocked, imagine my surprise when I noticed more changes.

I ask, like what. He says, let start drinking first. Its been a strange long day for me. Among us, only him and Marina were drinking. Marina was puzzled, like us, but unlike us, she didn't hide her thirst. After few more insistence from him, me and Catherine took our glass. I had to praise his selection, this was very delicious wine. I could taste a hint of bitter fruitiness. This must be from his old collection. When I check out the bottle label, I think I have seen it before. But I couldn't recall from where. Catherine was the most enjoying from it, nice. Its been so long I had a wine like this. I miss outside food a lot of times.

She needed to change her pallet to Kuret nutrients food after coming here. She takes couple of more sips savoring the taste. Marina was already pouring next glass but then abruptly stops, is this an attempt to get us drunk. She gives nervous smile to David. He cocks his head, please. I wouldn't do that. She resumes pouring her glass. He says, at least not with this. I got another bottle that will make you so drunk that not even your Kuret immunity will be able to metabolize it. I would love to try that one out. But it would be a chore, there is only one bed and I am not sleeping on the couch.

Marina almost spilled wine from David causal retort. Marina starts laughing, you sleaze bag. I get you are trying to turn over a leaf, but you need to work on your timings and the people. He turns to Catherine, is that right. Catherine nods, you are trying too hard. He takes a drink and makes a expression like he is contemplating his approach. I ask, please don't come up with something else. I already feel strange you acting this way. He laughs, just making mental notes. I am terribly behind my social life. Its not like I am seeing a completely new side of him, but he isn't hiding his thoughts anymore.

Marina says, stops stalling. Explain what you meant when you said there are changes. He puts his glass down, right. See neural pathways in brain is just neurons firing messages and instructions. Having a different route shouldn't really shouldn't change anything. But that’s true for a Medrone children, wholes brains aren't developed. As an adult and a denser brain, there are regions of my brain are already had hardwired. So there are certain aspects parts of my neural makeup that corresponds to years of habits, preferences and actions. And two days ago, those pathways suddenly changed. And that will result in various aspects of my life.

I ask, Kuret being the main one. He nods, of course. That’s the most prevailing one. The Kuret control. I have been doing social tests all day. There is divergence of about 24%. That is way to abnormal for anyone. Marina asks, what kind of deviations are we talking about. Catherine stares at the drink, like drinking wine at dinner. Because I have only seen you do it few times. He says, good catch. Yeah, tastes is just electrical impulses to the brain. I didn't care for wines. But now its like a new pallet option is opened up. Meanwhile a particular fish I used to like, doesn't taste good anymore

Catherine says, but that’s normal. You can't take that as sign of change. He says, it could be a placebo effect from the treatment. But there are other subtle things. Like my favorite mathematical equation in physics was hooks law, but now my pick is Bernoulli's equation. I didn't understand how math is involved here. However our resident mathematician spoke up, that’s not big deal. My favorite equations change every month. He reply's, shocker. But that sort of thing doesn't happen for me. Even I set aside my personal preferences, you can't deny I am trying to be more proactive. Would you ever imagined me making jokes about women like this.

That is suspicious for sure. He could be playing around intentionally, but seems he is just telling the truth. Marina says, I don't really buy it. David thinks for a second, then let me ask you about happened when you went through it. Marina says, you mean when I went through Ketriya. I don't even remember it. He says, since you are an over achiever, I bet you got it early on. Think back when you were a kid, you may not remember when Ketriya happened, but you have total recall. You must remember when you gained your Kuret. Marina thinks about it for a moment. David adds, I vaguely remember around the time you were building something with Kuretine.

That jolted Marina's memories, my first successful master piece. I remember it now. Oh, whoa. That takes me back. She starts to reminisce about that time. She smiles, how cute you remember that. He says, its hard to forget a 6 feet tall structure that wasn't really shaped like any building I know of. I chuckle, that does sound an over achiever to me. Catherine scoffs, what were you even doing with it. Marina says, I was just trying to build something for my parents. Back then I wanted to. Now, what was it. After a few seconds of wait, she says, don't remember. But yeah, now that I think of it, it took me months to do finish that, and then I decided to begin my training next summer.

David clears his through, any particular reason you decided to change a career path ? You already had an older sister to inherit the alpha Kuret. She thinks hard as she bites her lips. She sighs, can't remember. I guess it just a push from the family. For some reason David becomes a little sour, like he didn't like her answer. He shakes it off the next second, see. That was around the time you changed too. I bet that was a big change in habits. She says, kind of. Yeah. I didn't know what engineering, but I wanted to build things with my charms. And then later made an effort to join shadows.

I didn't exactly understand the purpose of asking Marina this. Children go through this all the time. Even Humans children changes. How does this prove anything. David says, if you had remembered the feeling, then you would know what I am going through. Its possible I am just fooling myself by overdoing stuff. But I feel a lot calmer, more in control and aware of myself. It could be because I was lacking it for so long. Only time will tell though. I guess I was suspecting him a little too much. He just wanted to know about others experience. Since Marina is possibly the only one who could remember that phase in her life.

Catherine says, I think I understand. Its not that you have completely turn over a new personality, you are not unburdened anymore. I raises his glass to her, I like that. I might use it to explain it to others. I can't deny I used to feel chained down, thinking that people died on Medrine and I wasted their sacrifices. The guilt had been eating me up for years. More so this past year. I ask, and now you don't. He says, that’s not something that I leave behind ever. But at least I won't drag me down. I ask, I don't know if that’s a healthy attitude or you are faking it. He smiles, don't forget being delusional. Just how much changes are we going to witness. He usually acknowledges weakness or self pity with us. But we have Catherine among us right now.

Marina says, yeah. Definitely the last one. Especially after how he has been treating me and Catherine. He scoffs while cutting up the stake. We talked a little more, try to pry out more about his secret treatment. He never divulged anything apart from some vague details. He only told us about Ketriya. When I asked if there were more details about why it happened, he said everything else was still speculation about his biology. He was especially evasive when Catherine asked if it was due to MAR's testing. That is the only logical reason for all the mess he is caught up in.

After finishing up our dinner he says, I heard on the network about our scientific conference is successful. They are coming. I nod, yeah. They finally acquiesced today morning. Catherine says, Nathan took his sweet time. Do you think he was playing some angle. Why take so long. I reply, I am expecting the transcripts of their conversation tomorrow. We will know more what he promised them. Marina asks, they want something in return. I say, I am sure they do. David says, if he didn't ask for your permission, if they did want something, Nathan can handle it own.

That’s what we believed it too. I say, Luther wasn't really happy not keeping us in the loop. We will soon know about it. Marina says, before tomorrows meeting. I nod, they will arrive tomorrow morning. David says, what meeting. I scoff, you don't know. I though you were tapped into everything going on in the city. He says, I have been a little busy today if you recall. I haven't been checking my messages. I only heard about the science team from Drew. What's happening tomorrow.

He really has been living under a rock today. I guess I was unreasonably expecting him to know things. His casual demeanor made me forget he spend almost two days unconscious. Marina says, the Heraknus are sending few representatives to discuss about the relocation. She turns to me, I am assuming they want me to tell them about their living situations. I reply, most definitely. You done with the checklist? She pulls out her phone and scrolls through the list. After checking she says, all done. The tunneling, foundations and blueprints are all done. But I do have questions about some things for them.

I ask, anything important. She says, not really. Just need to hash out some logistics. David says, weird. I asked M to notify any movement from Heraknus. How come she didn't caught this. He peeks to the side display for a moment, I'll check that later. Anyways, who all are coming. Catherine says, don't know. What make my job a little harder. She teases me for not able to figure it out. If I thought I wanted to know, I could have dug deeper. David says, okay. Did they mention if Charles is with them. I shrug him no. He scoffs, so keeping it under wraps huh.

I ask, but they did ask for you specifically to be there. He asks, the exhibition match will be discussed as well. I say, most likely. He says, guess I need to put on my game face on. Marina scoffs, I am dying to see what that entails. We all laugh, even David himself. We chatted few things about tomorrows meeting. We have been dealing with so many other issues that we never noticed how close we are getting to the match day. Catherine asks, you barely trained this past week right. Isn't that bad.

He says, you don't have to remind me of that. I didn't have much physical training, but I had a mental training done. So from now I will be more diligent. No more distractions. I ask, if that brief brawl we had with you is any indication, you are no where close to handling your Kuret. He says, you had to say it like that. He leans back and folds his arms, I know my current limits. But don't think I am just recuperating. Today, recuperating was my training. Drew said the more I let my body adjust to my brain, the better. I have another issue with my Kuret right now.

Marina asks, is that something to with your lab setup in the basement. He says, yeah. My optic nerves have reset, so I am sensitive to glimmers. I got completed blinded when I tried to look with my Kuret. I used that glass coated boron material to help me learn to control it few years back. I need too keep it on temporarily, even when I am not using my Kuret. I chuckle, it’s a coincidence. Dad said his brother once said he went through a similar phase. The aura was too much to see when he was a kid. I say, nice to know it has happened to someone else too. I don't have much reference on how to handle Ketriya. Do you guys know anyone who can help me?

After a lot of silent thinking, no one came up with any suggestion. He sighs, I guess its up to biology and luck then. Marina says, how long till you get adjusted. He says, a week at least. I wanted to give tomorrow day for relearning it. But now I need to pick a more fashionable shades. I hate to be so gaudy as to wear black shades inside. But I can still rock the look. His makes a crooked but confident smirk. Marina will be getting her wish for David to put a show tomorrow.

Marina says, someone feels cocky. We will see. And about your training with Kuret copy techniques. He asks, I can manage that at least. She nods, I didn't want to mention it until I was confident you were okay. But you seem better now. Maybe more than that. Think its time we work on it. He gets excited, awesome. I can't believe you found time for it after being slaved to work so much. He peeks at me a quickly, blaming me for that. I took offensive, I told her to delegate task. But she is not just over achiever, but a perfectionist too. Blame her.

She gives me a smile, we both are to blame for the work you are putting on me. I sigh and face a giggling Catherine. Marina says, it took some time. I may have few solutions for your particular problem. We can go through it tomorrow. He says, that’s excellent news. I am sure you have made some sort of schematics and designs. Send to me tonight. Marinas gives him a thumbs up. Then he pauses for a second, but lets not do it tomorrow. You might be a little busy tomorrow in case you are called by Heraknus for some ground survey.

She says, oh right. They will ask for a tour of the city. Then let me spare some time for Thursday. I am glad they agreed to let be free tomorrow. Catherine whispers to me, is he talking about that Kuret storm thingy. I nod. She scoffs, isn't it too much. He just recovered from a major brain trauma. David caught her murmuring to me, don't worry about me Catherine. I got everything under control. Trust me. And I will be asking you soon to help out with the training.

A devious smiles forms on her, I know I said I'll help. But I was caught up in the group flow back then. I am also very too busy you know. She remains silent and nods ever so slightly to Marina. David caught it too. I say, let me guess. Marina told she isn't helping David for free. And now you don't either. She shrugs playing innocent. She is enjoying herself a little from having an insider information. I didn't think she had anything to extort David. He didn't mind though, what do you have in mind. Whatever she wanted, she wasn't hesitating sharing with us. David laughs, whoa. I didn't think you were going to ask me out for this favor. Bold move Catherine. I am sorry though, I got hands full at the moment. How about after the tournament.

Catherine repudiates him, you wish. I already have a boyfriend. We only made it look like we broke up. Marina was stifling a laugh while I was uncomfortable. I didn't want to be in a conversation about Catherines relationship. David says, don't look so appalled Blake. I just messing with her. Did I showed it on my face. I quickly shake it off. He turns to Catherine, how about you tell me after the meeting tomorrow. She thinks for a second, I can work with that. I am sure I can come up with an equal compensation.

He grins, it’s a date then. I don’t think he is going to stop his weird flirting anytime soon.

Vanessa (Chapter 103)

Friday, February 27, 2026 11:47

The cruise ship was now visible in the horizon. Sommers yells to others, stay sharp people. The Heraknus are here. All the officers gathered in the pier is a circle. As usual, dozens of people and reporters are waiting to see them. I message Blake that they will be arriving in 10 minutes. He responds saying he will be here in another a few minutes. Everyone here is anxious to meet the Heraknus people. Some officers met one or two Heraknus before, but majority of the people haven't seen anyone.

Tessa and June approach me. We discuss about the occupants of the ship. There can't be more than two dozen people in that small boat. So we prepare for the cars accordingly. June asks, aren't going to let them rest first? Why take them to the admin building immediately. Tessa says, they messaged saying they want to finish up discussing about the match before retiring for the day. I say, they are in quite the hurry though. I thought they would wait another week. June says, maybe they decided to leave Citradel as soon as possible.

That was the popular reason everyone were thinking. Even though we called for them to meet, we expected them to delay it. Let the stuff going in Citradel settle down first. Tessa says, It was sudden, but its not a bad thing. This weeks been going much easier than the last one. I say, that's for IDF. Other departments are bring crunched by the expansion phase. The construction was in full force for past couple of days. Other officers are pressed to finish tasks before deadlines. June says, its not we have it easy though. We are only just halfway through the list people from the smugglers data records. Tessa says, that's is there. But I heard Ruther is going to be briefed by David with his tech. She turns to me, are they meeting today?

She opened that can of worms. David's not been seen in public past two days. And we have been covering for him. Drew sent a message to us updating us on his condition. On one hand I am glad he is recovering. I am so confused on what I am going to do with him. We didn't part at the best of terms before. He basically told me to screw off and left angry. I had a lot of time to think on how to confront him. But each time I think of something, I remember Wagner. I was resolved to never forgive him. But is that okay. He has apologized and even came clean about many thing to us. I wanted to know more how he knows Wagner. But I couldn't ask anyone without getting frustrated.

The only solace was Siera was there for me. Her support helped me to not get broken down again. I honestly don't know what I would have done without her. June asks, you okay? I didn't realize I was silent with my rambling thoughts. I say, just thinking about it. He reached out to us last night. He plans to send a batch of surveillance bots tonight. But he said he is busy today, so we come by another day. Tessa says, its not surprising. I hear he is doing some sort of special training alone for few days.

They began discussing about different possibilities. I didn't want to lie, so I just stayed quiet. I hope he has recovered enough to come to the meeting. As they discussed how he would prepare from his home, I drifted to think about the Shadow. Even now I am having trouble accepting he was a freaking shadow. Matt was boasting how he is perfect for the job. And I couldn't deny he was right. But I was more troubles by how an important person like him was in hiding all this time. He lost, no, erased his memories due to trauma. And that single choice has rippled out to a lot of mess.

Honestly, I could accept him being a Shadow. But hiding his therapy from us. That's what hurts me the most. I didn't believe any of his excuses about him sharing his Shadow past to his doctor. When I think about how he was targeted, it was good he took precaution. But still, he could have told someone. He went through the tournament in such a state. My brother was a trigger for him and yet he never once hinted about it. All he did ever was be quiet about it whenever I would mention his name. And if I am being completely honestly, that's what infuriates me the most. What kind of relationship did they have.

I didn't realize it was too late when I blurted out, what kind of Shadow is David? He has a such ridiculous issues. I immediately jerked when I realize I said it aloud. Even though it was a lower tone, their discussion halted and they face me surprised. I immediately broke in sweat. What is wrong with me. I was praying they didn't hear me. June says, what you mean. Tessa eyes raise curiously, David. Shadows? Bloody hell. Just how lost was I in my thoughts that I let it slip out. Their face showed confusion and shocked. I nervously say, nothing. Just rambling. Just saying that Marina and Blake might be training him at his house.

Tessa says, that's not what you said. June leans in closer, did you imply that David is. I cut her off, I misspoke. Nothing else. They were not buying it when my composure is breaking apart. I desperately looked for an excuse. Thankfully it came in a form a car. I turn my back, Blake's here. Lets break for now. I took few steps away from them and called to Ruther. I actually didn't have anything to say to him, but I wanted to get away from two bamboozled expressions. I just ask him for confirming of people in the admin building. He was confused since they we just went through it a minute ago. I just hope he doesn't pick up the strange vibe behind me.

Me and Siera have been talking about it so much, that I slipped it out to others. Cass has been blaming herself about leaking information, and now I am doing the same. This is so embarrassing. How could I let it happen. I need to distract myself. I saw Blake, Tina and Marina approaching from the car. They were norming uniforms like the rest of us. A minute later, they joins me. He asks, are we all set. I nod. ETA 5 minutes. Marina says, we got delayed at the admin building. Blake says, a lot more people are gathered than here.

We expected that to happen. Everyone got into place and wait for the cruise to arrive. But before they did, I had to know something. Once Tina left them to check on the transports. I ask, how is David. I heard you met him last night. I was expecting them to be concerned. But their different reaction made me even concerned. Blake sighs shaking his head. Marina just shows her teeth with a snarky smile. I ask, what happened. Is he okay. He says, sorry. He is fine. A lot saner than the last time you saw him. Marina chuckles, but boy did the treatment did wonders for him. Even I am get uncomfortable sometimes around him. But I kind of like this new David.

Blake says, that's because you encourage him a lot. She pulls her tongue out, now you are going to deal with him too now. He didn't like the prospect, but he also chuckles a little. What is going on. The last time I saw him, he was out of his mind, bleeding from his eyes and fighting us. Blake says, sorry for the confusion, Vanessa. Its just a lot has changed about him. I ask, like what. He says, you will know when you meet him. I don't understand the unnecessary suspense. Marina says, yeah. Its hard to explain ourselves. Blake says, there is a lot to talk about. But for now, just know that he no longer has unresolved trauma. Its hard to believe, but he has been cured of it.

I didn't understand how he can be cured from a trauma. I have seen so many people struggling to adjust even not traumatized from the past. I ask, are you seriously saying the treatment fixed his PTSD. In one night? How does that make sense. He scoffs, trust me. This was hard for me to take it in too. Marina says, I know its strange coming from me, but he is even more effusive than me. Blake nods, that is true. I can't believe what I am hearing. Blake saw my utter confusion and says, lets just say there was more going than just PTSD with him. And the treatment, which by the way Drew told not to tell anyone, has been miracles effective.

I am so lost here. When the doctor said the treatment was a success, I thought she was just trying to cover her mistake with some false hope. And from their words it seems it actually wasn't a failure. Blake says, lets save the rest for later. I see they are docking now. I wasn't satisfied by their strange reactions. But for now we had a job to do. Soon everyone gathers at the dock. Catherine and Jess joined us as well. Rest others will meet us at the admin building. Blake asks me, you still don't know who all are coming. I shake my head. Marina says, lucky for us, I found out. Remember my friend, she was able to check who all left the Heraknus house.

All the officers gathered here lean to her. She says, sadly Charles didn't came. And I know Melina is one of them. She smirks, guess she wants to meet the tech team that arrived this morning. Blake says, damn. I was hoping he was here too. Catherine says, are they sending her to represent him. That's what we had to believe. June and Tessa were peeking at me time to time. But I remained stoic, determined to not let them see me nervous. I hope they forget we ever had that conversation.

Soon the boat docks at the pier. After few minutes, a group of people disembark. The first one was Rory. He was carrying a rucksack bag on his shoulders and another bag in his arm. Behind him was Melinda. I didn't recognize anyone else in this group. Blake steps forward, welcome back everyone. Rory puts extends his free hand shake with Blakes, glad to be back Blake. Blake says, Melinda. How are you. She gives us a warm smile, I am good. Though I am tired from the journey. We took a different route last time, and this one was considerably shorter.

I saw their route. They crossed over the Atlantic on the flight this time. So I think they spent cramped with humans much longer this time. Few officers come to help pick their luggage's. Three people came beside Rory. A guy that looks like his fifty's with a bold head. He was a thin guy with a patterned beard. But his posture and demeanor said he was someone important. Beside him stood a younger guy. He was lean and tall with a studier build. Beside him was a elderly women with grey strands of hair. Her wrinkles showed she was an elderly lady.

Rory puts his bag down after he greets us. He says, everyone. I want you to meet few people. He gestures to the elderly women first, this is my grandmothers sister, Reina. Her son, Barnard and this is his son Eric. We finally meet other Heraknus. Blake shakes hands with all three expressing gratitude. Reina says, so you are the terra, prince Blake. Blake says, just Blake is fine. I didn't exactly inherit any royal title. That distinction is for Nathan. She says, oh. That's right. Where is he by the way. Your family helped us in the evacuation from Medrine. I wanted to thank everyone of you. You all sacrificed to save us.

That's news to us. Blake becomes anxious, I didn't know that. She says, oh yes. Charles told me he shared with you few things about the royal house supporting us. He didn't tell you everything. Blake nods, that's. He seemed to lost for few words. Then he gains back his composure, you don't have to thank me. It was all my family who helped you. But if you get time later, I would like to hear about it. She says, of course. Barnard steps in, I want to show my gratitude too. If it weren't for their help, Eric and me wouldn't be here. It looks like Charles hadn't told us everything about their connection to the royal family.

Did they priorities Heraknus to board the second ship. Blake says, its great to hear my family was there for you. Barnard says, I know its probably self serving to say this. But we hoped they would also make it out with us. If they had tried to save themselves too, they would be here too. Blake says, I am not sure what happened with Heraknus. But I recently learned where my dad and mom where in the last day. So I assure you, they had other plans. They were on the other side of continent fighting off the Hives. They made a stand, and I am proud of that.

This is also I never heard from Blake before. But then I realized that David said he saw many people while escaping from the city. He must have told Blake about it. Riena says, is that right. I met Slater few times with my sister. Guess we have a lot to talk about. Blake smiles, we do. Lets have you get rested first. Eric who has been quiet this time speaks up, Blake. Its a pleasure to meet you. He had a brisk voice, and showed a little tiredness from it. Blake shakes hand with him. He says, Rory and Gina told me a lot about the island. I am excited to see it.

Blake gestures to the people behind, and so are the people behind us. Rory whistles, we made quiet an appearance showing up so suddenly. Few drone were up along the barrier taking pics of them. We had instructed them not to cross the barrier. But their zoom lens and Kuretine microphones could probably pickup some conversation. Catherine comes up forward, morning everyone. I am Catherine. I am help you settle in our guest houses. She meets few other Heraknus behind them. From there everyone mingles a little. I thought I would meet Melinda, but Rory comes between us, hey Vanessa. How are you. I smile, I am good. Did you come alone. Tory?

He sighs, she wanted to come. But dad wants her help organizing and packing up our stuff. After years of living in one place, she has accumulated a lot of junk things. She is taking too long to sort which things she wants to bring here. Honestly, how long does a women need to choose which makeup set to bring. I laugh, if she is anything like me. A lot. He sighs, and don't get me started with Gina. She had so many clothes she doesn't want to discard. Our home is right now a dump. Behind him Melinda appears, I heard something about a dump. You must be talking about our room.

He says, don't deny it. She says, its less organized. She didn't want to give wrong impression to us. He sighs, lets not say too much. What would they think if they knew so many slobs live in our place. I couldn't resist a smile. Siera is a drill instructor when it comes to keeping things neat and tidy. Melina agrees with him and moves to meet June behind me. Taking this opportunity with us alone he asks, and where our celebrity. Don't tell me he is

going to make another entrance. I say, not this time. He is going to meet us at the admin building. He says, great. I hesitantly poked him, you still not giving up your theory he cheated? His response was just a smile to me.

He didn't say anything and moves on to meet other officers. A few minutes later Blake raises his arm, guys. I am sure we want to talk more. But let them rest first. He turns to Melinda, I am assuming you are going to represent your husband. He is probably thinking the time she visited me to discuss maters Charles wanted to say. She gestures, I am here for the tech team. I know some of them and would like to extend my help. Besides, I am here primarily to scout some homes for us. She gestures to Rory. He says, dad allowed me to take over any negotiations for him.

I can't tell if that's the right decision or not. So far only I have seen his petty side. Blake says, all right. Catherine says, you all mentioned in your message that most of you are for looking at suitable prospects of houses and not participating in the meeting now. So anyone who wants to take rest, please follow us. She and Jess breaks into smaller Heraknus groups. I ask to the women still contemplating, how about you Reina. She turns to me, Charles said to take it easy and leave it to Barnard and Rory. But I can help along with the discussion. Eric says, grandma, you couldn't sleep much in the flight. I suggest you go with Melinda. She says, I should, right.

A moment later she makes up her mind, actually, if I can get a cup of tea Tory was telling me about. I can attend the meeting. Barnard asks, are you sure. She nods, yes. You know we will talk about Charles. And I think I need to judge David myself. Looks she has a lot on her mind. They all agreed and everyone split into different groups now. 8 people were coming to the meeting, while rest 15 opted to go to the guest house. In an orderly fashion everyone got into their vehicles we prepared for them. The people who are coming with us had their luggage's sent along with the rest.

Rory, Barnard and Riena took a car with Blake and Marina. I took the a group with Sommers. And the rest were with June and Tessa. I felt a little guilty rearranging the order so that I don't seat with either June or Tessa. But thankfully they either didn't notice or didn't care enough to object. I was with Eric. All the ride away, the other Heraknus were chatting with us about the city. Me and Sommers explained the city layout and the current infrastructure. A Heraknus girl says, this is so awesome. I can't wait to live separately now. I had enough of us grouping together all the time. She becomes excited. I think they finally realize that they no longer have to hide.

They can now live openly and choose their homes. A luxury they didn't have in Citradel. I say, we will be handing you a digital guide of the city soon. Their faces showed their happiness. But some, like Eric showed a little nervousness. I ask, something wrong. He turns to slowly. It takes a moment to gather his words, I saw the people and reporters back then. Its a little annoying. Judging by his face, it meant he didn't care about being popular. Sommers says, we are sorry about that. Its just people are curious to see Heraknus after all this time.

A guy says, I share a little bit of Eric's concern. Same thing happened in Citradel too after Charles introduction in the coliseum. The girl says, I get what you are saying. Initially people were glad to know about us. But that died down pretty quickly. Many are criticizing us for not showing up before. So it happened in Citradel too. Jess told me a while ago how few people are now raising concerns on Heraknus decision. Charles explained why they couldn't help before. But that didn't alleviate the frustrations people felt. Especially from the people who lost their families in all the wars since coming to Earth.

I turns to face the four Heraknus in our car, I don't want to cause any more concerns for you all. While you won't face a lot of resistance from your presence, but there will be some friction. Even among the officers, some concerns are spreading. I hope you can ignore it. Eric says, I don't blame them. Many of us had requested Charles numerous time to let us fight. He would either refused for us to act independently or we would be too late. The other Heraknus gave silent agreement. I ask, I am sure he had reasons. He says, he did. And yet we shouldn't have been restrained like this. Kafar's agreement with us protected us, but it also alienated us.

Its natural different Heraknus will have their own opinions. Eric seems to be more respectable guy than Rory. At least for now. I ask, Charles said many weren't happy being revealed about your existence though. The girl scoffs, yeah. Many didn't want to leave their safety zone. My father didn't want me fighting out in the open. The guy who hadn't spoken said, its not really their fault. They were just far too used to living without scrutiny. Sommers asks, sounds a lot of problems stirred within your house.

Eric says, too many to count. The girl says, you know, all of us in Citradel were in a disarray for a while. Once Charles came back, there were arguments flying around. The guy laughs, and then Citradel made a big mistake. That made everyone supporting Citradel lose hope. I ask, you mean about Ryes. He nods, I never met him. But I heard he was a pretty nice guy. I never expected him to start accusing David. Eric sighs, then Blake blamed your criminal problem to Ryes and Citradel. That put the nail on the coffin. The girl says, yeah. People began to lose hope in Citradel councils. The guy says, I still think someone else stole the tech from us. But that's just me.

David's continues assault on Citradel probably put them more on edge. Eric says, I don't want to say ill of the place we lived for so long. But the situation has only worsened since David is stealing their resources. The quiet guy says, I still can't believe how continues to dry them. The girl says, Kafar is losing is hairs trying to contain this. I thought about a question, I hear your priest is also being vocal. Can you tell us anything about that. I don't mean to pry thought if its personal. The guy says, nah. Its all good. Ever since we decided to move, we sort of cut off from Citradel. Though we can still see what is going on there.

The girl says, they church is on missionary complain like never before. The guy says, I thought that priest was just hot chick. But turns out she was spicy one. I heard before we left she is planning another protest. This time in front of the council. Sommers ask, and they are allowing them? Eric says, they all are regular people. Nothing wrong with a harmless protest. I heard Blake did something similar after the tournament. I recall that long and tumultuous day. I was not around much that day, but I saw the aftermath on the news.

The girl says, only when they are not causing trouble. I still think that broad is interrupting the will of gods too deeply. So the situation hasn't improved on the ground. If their fears are correct, they are not stopping anytime soon. The quiet guys says, lets not talk about things that don't concern us anymore. Eric rebukes him, just because you don't want to weigh in this, doesn't stop others. Everyone here wants to be aware of Citradel and their issues. The guy backs down after being reprimanding from Eric. Looks like Eric is even bigger deal than I thought. The other two also pull back their concerns.

The guy says, dude chill. Lets switch it up always. We saw your matches. And it was awesome. The mood improves dramatically. It was still nice to be appreciated. Sommers also got few praises for his efforts to be in top 100. But he still hadn't let go off his brawl with Cory. He says, I still need to get my act together if I need reach for higher ranks. At least he isn't being a downer. Eric says, that's a good attitude to have. He turns to me, I was impressed by your match with Marina. I didn't know which way it would go in the beginning.

Everyone assumes that it was a fair fight. But people know Marina was poisoned and still beat me. I didn't think I deserved too much appreciation for it. I say, I tried my best. The girl says, you did. Marina is, well a Shadow. So she had an edge. Its been painfully made ever to me now that how much stronger shadows are. Now that I know David is one too, his feats makes even more sense. The girl says, speaking of Shadows, Blake was so close to reach the finals. I heard from Charles that he too has trouble controlling his overdrive. Is that true.

I nod, yeah. He will deny it, but everyone knows the match could have gone more his way if had control. Eric says, that was surprise for many of us. The guy says, we were hoping for Charles to fight off against a terra. How crazy that match would have been. The quiet guy says, my mother thinks their overdrive clash would be too destructive and could have destroyed the coliseum. I smile imagining that fight. I don't know how that would have gone. Eric says, even I can't deny I wanted to see that. But Charles overdrive is dangerous.

So they their bloodline know about it. The guy says, true. There is a debate among whose overdrive is more crazier. But you what even more surprising. David's kuret. The guy showed some crazier stuff pushing back Charles. The girl asks, you have to tell how does it. How can he copy others Kuret. This was bound to happen. Sommers says, sorry guys. None of us have any clue. He wants to keep it an ace until the exhibition match. The girl clicks her tongue, I was looking forward to know it. The quiet guys says, you can ask him when he meet him. I didn't think they would get any other answer.

Eric asks, I am very intrigued to meet him too. The way he appeared on the interview was, at the very least moving. Has been getting time to train though. I heard he told Charles about getting stronger. I couldn't answer him without explaining so many crazy stuff. I played it safe, he is preparing the best he can. But I can't deny he has been busy. Sommers says, but soon he will kick it up a notch. I heard from Tina that he requested for using the coliseum training center to train.

I turn to him surprised, when was this. He says, heard it over the breakfast. I don't the whole details, but I think he is starting tomorrow. Eric says, you mean the obstacles of the preliminary rounds. He nods, that's the one. Its one of the best training center of our island. So it makes sense he go there. The guy says, I love to see that too. They looked wicked in the broadcast. I didn't think David would be already ready to begin training. Didn't he spend two days unconscious.

Eric asks me, tell me one thing though. Is he really strong as people say. Because people say he got lucky. After witnessing his Kuret from the other day I had no qualm saying this, I don't want to presume anything. But he is on whole other level than many alphas. My specific words convinced them of something. Maybe they didn't think David had a chance to survive Charles overdrive. But I knew things many people didn't. Him being the shadow strategist was the biggest reason. Too bad I couldn't tell anyone about it. I think I finally seen a smile on Eric, awesome. Can't wait to meet him.

Few minutes go by chatting about other things happening for the tournament and we reach the admin building. Like Marina said earlier, there a lot of people on the street now. Many were gawking and trying to break through the line of officers to take a peek at the Heraknus. I say, I know it's a lot. But please don't worry about the people. We will make sure they don't bother you. Eric says, much appreciate it. The girl says, we had to prepare this sort of response. I just hope they soon realize we are normal people. One kid in Citradel asked me if I turn into a tortoise. I didn't know how to deal with that. I wish she ask about me about my Kuret endurance instead.

I grin without realizing. If I remember Kafar said Heraknus have different forms. Somers asks, are you all warriors then. The quiet guys says, except for the Reina and Brener. Yes. I did guess a while back from their toned bodies. Eric says, we are what you might call a swat team. There are half of us back in Citradel. I ask, so you guys are the top of your house. The guy makes a prideful voice, you got that right. Trained by Charles and Berner themselves. I wished we could have participated in the tournament. He murmurs, damn that Kafar and his ultimate surprise.

Sommers drive us through the sea of people, navigating and finally crossing the boundary we set up. The people ease a little up after seeing the people leave behind. The three cars stops at the entrance. Sommers says, it got here a little late. I say, its okay. The meeting will start in an hour anyways. I turn to others, you guys can freshen up in the admin houses here. I point to the independent houses we had prepared for them. We come out of the car and everyone congregates near the entrance. Blake comes to the middle, we have setup a little breakfast bar in the main building. Once you ready, please meet us there. Few people still had their bags with them. I think it contains something pertinent to the meeting.

Heraknus begin to disperse into smaller groups. The officers we stationed guarded their rooms. Eric says, see you later. I nod and wave our new friends. Deni walks to me, there are way too many people. Sure it won't cause any problem. I say, its fine. Once the meeting starts, they will go away. I turn to the large crowd. Many people were trying hard to see the Heraknus. The drones were zipping around the air. Unlike the shore, we allowed them to hover above us. But they will be asked to leave once the meeting starts.

Blake approaches near me and asks her, is everyone in. She says, almost. All the admins are here. And the necessary personals for the exhibition match. It meant Ned was here too. But I doubt we will get any time to talk privately. Not like I am willing to meet him. Blake says, who is missing then. She sighs, take a wild guess. She gave an obvious look. I sigh, you told him the time right. He says, I did. The meeting is at 10. I told I need him to arrive at 9. Deni says, he isn't late though. Blake says, for now. Wonder why he is taking his sweet time. We waited for 5 more minutes. And just before it was 9, there is a large commotion among the crowd.

I face the direction of people cheering. I say, guess he just made it in time. We see a lone person being escorted with officers among the crowd. Blake asks, is he walking. Why is he on foot. I reply, his car is a wreck, from this training accident. Remember. He scoffs, that doesn't mean he needed to come without a car. If I knew he was planning on taking the trolley, I would have giving him my car. The drones were now hovering more closer in the air towards him. I think I see few reports tagging in the crowd.

Soon he appears through the crowd. He wore officers uniform, but he was wearing a black shades and gelled up his hair outward. I ask, what's with this sudden interest in showing up like a tortured artist. He wasn't just cutting through the people, he was also shaking hands, fist bumping and taking photos with people. He looked like a fish out of water last time. But now he is swimming and enjoying himself. I swear I could hear his laugh from all the way here. He was not used to this, because he kept making mistake with peoples greeting. But its far cry from the awkwardness he was during the dinner that day.

Blake says, Deni, help him out of that. We can't have him getting hogged by the people like this. She laughs, on it. She leaves us to help him out the officers. Blake says, see that. That’s the new David me and Marina were talking about. I ask, how do you mean. Isn't he just used to the fame now. Blake says, that’s part of it. But be prepared to see a new side of him. Then leans in closer, try not antagonize him today. I don't know what kind of response he will have today. I don't understand this warning. His wasn't serious, yet he was anxious.

I ask, is this some sort of side effect from the treatment. He leans away, in a way. But this effect will be lasting. What happened to David for others to be acting this strange. With Deni's coordination, David finally made out of the crowd. Blake says, I am heading back in ahead. You guys can come when you get over the shock. He left leaving me stunned. I hear Deni laughing loudly now. David says, its true. You saved me. One girl was asking for me to sigh on her chest. I wasn’t ready for that. Deni says chuckling, stop it. I saw you. The most that girl was ask a photo. He says, yeah, with me beside her chest. You saved me from becoming a terrible meme. What the hell are they talking about.

His laughs slimmer down seeing me in their path. He says, Deni, can you give me and Vanessa a moment. Deni says, sure. And now its just the two of us. He pulls out his shades, underneath which revealed a black left eye. I ask concerned, what happened. He says, its part of the cover you guys gave me. Upon closer inspection, I think he applied make up to create the wound. I look at the shade in his hand and then back to him. He says, oh this. I am having trouble seeing with my Kuret. Need this to help me keep in control. Otherwise I might accidently see what people eat for their breakfast. I can't have me getting dizzy right now.

He puts on the shades back. How is so composed talking to me. I thought he would be either very serious or angry with me. But seems he is just so unbothered by the argument. He says, I want to apologies my rude behavior earlier. I said few things during the fight. I didn't mean to scare you. Chalk that to a drug riddled brain. He gives a big smile, and yet still guilty of those crazed comments. He says, I understand the confusion. I don't think others told you what happened to me. I say, they said you changed. He says, an over simplification. In a nut shell I am trying to be a different person. So bear with me.

I blurt out, what does that mean. The last time we spoke, you told me to get help for my issues. Ironic coming from you. He says, and I was justified. You did say some unreasonable things. Before another argument broke out, he cuts in, but so was I. I wish I didn't took it on you. I thought Wagner pulled over a wool over you. And I was desperate to fix that. I kept a lot from you. And truth is, its wasn't just you. So many people. He sighs, no more though. You want to know about Wagner. I will tell you. He says this with such a straight face that I remained speechless. I say, I don't trust you. You said you won't tell me about him.

He says, I know what I said. Feels like I was different person back then. I was thinking that shielding from truth is kindness. But that’s a convenient excuse. Like I said before, my mistake was hiding the reasons. And when you hear them, and you still want to know everything. I will tell you. Something's strange with him. He was so adamant about keeping things secret. But now he just ready to share them. I don't trust that. He says, I can guess what you think. I am being manipulative, trying to lie. But I am done with that. Its not like I am ready to divulge everything. Some things need to remain buried. Its not because of you. Its because of other reasons.

He walks closer to me. My heart take a beat faster seeing his serious face. He says, but know this. You won't like everything you hear. You say you want to know truth about him, but don't want to hear anything you don't like. You don't get to have that luxury to pick and choose. Let me know when you ready, we will talk then. I couldn't form any response. He is warning me about my brother. I feel annoyed and the emotions I have been suppressing come up, I don't believe you. You will lie to suit your needs. He nods while leaning away, that’s fair. I need to work on gaining your trust back. You got any ideas. Because I am lost here.

I am frozen how he is not holding back his thoughts. Openly asking for my suggestion. He says, well. If you do think of anything. Let me know. Maybe then I can make you see things you don't like. He then looks around the area, looks like I was the last person. I knew I shouldn't have taken the trolly. But I was envious of the couple I saw ahead me and asked tips for effective communication. A mistake, they gave me stuff not really relatable to us. Should have known I can't really crowd source solutions.

I ask him confused, you asked advice from strangers. He raises his arms, trust me, I didn't say your name. All I said I was in a dog house from a gorgeous and terrifyingly intimidating friend of mine. So don't be mad. Is he messing with me. But the that relaxed smile is way to real to be fake. He says, fine. I added the intimidating part. Just trying to score brownie points. I didn't like how you were getting angry with me. Hope it puts at least a smile on you. See you later.

He walks away, always like he is fleeing after messing up something. I don't know what just happened. First he warns me and then he compliments me. What is his deal. I followed behind him. But he was already inside the building. I saw Blake talking to Reinhart at the corner wall. He excuses himself and approaches me, what do you think.

I say dazed from the conversation, that was David. Wasn't it. Because I can't tell anymore.

David (Chapter 104)

Friday, February 27, 2026 20:36

I think I am making good progress. Especially with Vanessa. I was scared for a second how I might offend her. But I am okay with how it turned out. Direct but also cautious. I really hoped the couple would give me some ideas. But they were far too excited by the fact that some girl was angry with me. We laughed about it when they said any angry with me wouldn't be for much longer. They clearly haven't met Vanessa. It wasn't even half as nerve racking when I was greeting the people outside as I was with Vanessa. I just hope I didn't made her more angry. The most she would be right now is confused. I am okay with that.

I met with the admin crews I haven't seen for some time. Many were asking about the shades and seems they all believed my story about the accident. Technically, it wasn't a lie. So we should be good. I heard from Sommers that the Heraknus will join us soon. I ask him, anyone you find interesting. He scratches his neck, you should meet Eric. He seems very dependable guy. He then told me about the special team within Heraknus. I can imagine this squad is probably the very strongest within Citradel. I say, more than dozen alpha level in one team. And all sharing same Kuret and weakness. They would make a very balanced and powerful team.

He says, absolutely. Though, I couldn't see much of their Kurets. Charles wasn't kidding when he said Heraknus are effected coming to Earth. I was talking to a guy in our car, he said he needs at least 3 minutes to build his Kuret body. And another one said he can maintain his form for 4 hours, but gets interrupted at least 50 times. To cover each other weakness they fight in groups. That is the most logical way to overcome drawbacks. I am curious about one thing, they told you their weakness. Are you sure they told the truth. He says, I get what you mean. I don't think they be trusting us so much already. But I didn't feel like they were lying.

Maybe I am reading too much into this. But why tell anyone about your problems in their first meeting. He says, maybe they are trying to be friendly with us. You know, try to look more normal. That could be one of the reasons. I ask, I also don't know why send so many warriors. Even if others aren't really fighters, they are still Heraknus. They are stronger than your average Medrones. He says, don't know about that. I heard from Tessa that their access to Kuret is really inconsistent. They can't control when they loose out their Kuret reserve. The warriors are trained to counter their problems.

All that sounds logical, and yet I can't shake the feeling. They didn't need to send half their team here. We have strong warriors of our own to protect them. I say, why do you think the warriors came to the meeting. They are here to guard others. He thinks for a moment, that’s actually a good point. None of the warriors with the others in the guest house. What do you think that’s about. I had a theory, but for now I wasn't sure of it. I say, we will soon know about it. I didn't want to feel suspicious of our guests right at the beginning.

A person approaches beside me. Its Ned and he is carrying a tablet with him. He says, can I talk to you for a minute David. I turn to him while Sommers excuses himself. I say, long time no see Ned. You been busy. He says, a little too much. I have been trying to reach you many times over the week. But something or the other kept that from happening. I smile, apologies. If only he knew the whole truth about the stuff I went through. But I can't just tell him. He might tip accidently tip off the people or officers targeting us. He says, I understand. I am not holding that it against you. Not for that at least.

That tone suggests he is wanting to blame me for something else. There is only thing that he probably wants to talk about. But I let him breach that first. He put downs his tablet and asks, this isn't about the match. Its personal and I need to ask you something. I prepared myself to keep my composure. I pull out my shades and look at him squarely. He reacts to my fake black eye a little but ignores it. He continues, I heard you and Vanessa have been arguing for quite some time. I want to know if that’s true and what its about. He seemed to let out a frustration too.

Its not that I don't sympathizes with him. However, I wasn't going to be swayed by his passionate plea. I ask, really. That’s news to me. Who told you that. He gets a little annoyed, don't hide it. Vanessa hasn't been talking to me no matter how many time I reach out to her. I want to know what did say to her. He is getting a little agitated. From his perspective it may seem I had something to do this. I say, you assume wrong. I didn't say anything to her. I made it that he is being presumption. He gets irritated, then what is going with you two. I say, nothing much. Just a silly argument.

He leans in, is this about Wagner. He knows about that too. There is only one person he would know this much and tell him. I say, what exactly did Siera say to you. He tried to hide the surprise, but I saw it. I say, I don't know what she said, but it’s a simple misunderstanding that I intend to clear up. He asks, that’s not good enough. She is dodging my calls, not allowing me any chance to talk. He sounds desperate to get to the bottom of this. I say, I am sorry for what's going between you both. But I am not going to make it messier by getting in the middle. He wasn't going to let it go. So I add, from what I heard, seems you started it. Though I don't know how or why.

He looks to the other people's gazes, wary of the buzzing people surrounding us. He says, it was just a stupid bet. She blown it out of proportion. She thinks only she gets to be angry. He then explained the bet which happened in the VIP room during the match. I actually knew all this already. I just didn't know this was how their fight started. He says, tell me how did I hurt her. It was a harmless gamble. I just chose Charles because I thought he had the best chance of winning. But Vanessa, she interpreted it that I never take her side. He was now less angry and more upset.

I had no intention of playing advocate for fixing their relationship. Vanessa is mad at both of us. However, its for different reasons. The way I see it, he would have been able to fix things with her much easier than me. But he has been making mistakes. Like I have done. I ask, what exactly do you want me to do. I already told you, I didn't say anything to her about you. And frankly, you are not having enough faith in her to think I influenced her in any way. His quiet indignation makes it clear I was right on the money. I say, I'll take a wild guess here. You both think that the other should apologize first. Well, I don't that will cut it. The issues you have run deeper than that.

If it were just about that, they wouldn't have been fighting this long. They don't seem to have some hidden securities of their relationship. I had daring and impertinent thought. I shouldn't get in the middle of this, but the curiosity got the better of me. I explain, if you want someone who you will understand your every decisions, get a different girlfriend. Because Vanessa deserves much better. He grumbles a little when I came out right. He snarls, are you telling me to break up with her. I smile, I didn't say that. That was you suggesting it yourself. See. I gesture my palm to him.

He says, I don't believe this. You don't want us to patch up. Do you? Don't tell me you are. I cut him off because I know what he was insulating, you got it wrong. Trust me. I am saying from experience. You both think that other is being irrational. But you can't accept it either. That, I shake my head, is not how you maintain a healthy relationship. He says, really. You are saying that. The guy who loves being logical and analytical for everything. A person with a checkered past. I don't know how much you said in the interview was true, but you at least have a questionable history of screwed up relationships.

He is deliberately taking a shot at me by bring up Liz. I feel a little angry swell in me. What the hell he knows about my past. But then a moment later I settle down. This is a reaction because I provoked him too much. I think I tested his resolve enough. He won't let go of Vanessa without a fight. I don't know if that’s good for her or bad for me. I sigh, I won't deny it. I mean, what do I know about being in love. Right. I give him a chuckle that confuses him. He scoffs, what the hell happened to you. You are different now. I reply, I am a changed man. I suggest you do the same. For Vanessa's sake.

I take a step away from him, you should talk to her instead of asking talking to Siera, me or anyone else. He says, I told you. She is. I pull my shades back on, tell me. Is this island so big that you can't find one person. You know her home, her work and the people she spends time with. And yet, couldn't find time to talk to her. Please, you are running out of excuses. Your believing that I am the problem is also an excuse. Don't waste looking for reasons that aren't there. You either fix it or pull the plug on this thing. But choose one. Because I don't want to see her hurt. Not more than she already has.

He gives a puzzled look. I am getting that quite a lot since yesterday. And now I beginning to get amused seeing different reactions. I say, hope you figure it out soon. I'll see you inside. I leave him to his thoughts and head inside. That felt gave me a bad taste in my mouth. I probably gave away a lot of my actual intent. I think I want them to break up. But I am conflicted hurting Vanessa. She will hate me even more when she finds that I basically told her boyfriend to confront her. I don't know what will happen. Truth be told, I don't think they are going to work things out. This makes me selfish, petty and jealous. I guess I should start owning my feelings from now.

I spend the remaining time talking to few admins. They had different scenarios of the exhibition match in mind. It was basically the same but with minor variations depending on how much Heraknus agree to it today. They knew some of the dangers of Charles overdrive. I hinted them that there is more and to keep all the options. When the time came Blake gestures me to meet up with him and Reinhart. We meet up and step into the conference room. Reinhart says, hey David. I heard about your little accident. A training exercise mishap? I chuckle, yeah. I got a little ahead of myself. But its all good now. He nods while talking the seat beside me and Blake.

Blake whispers to me, I saw you and Ned earlier. I saw his angry aura. I haven't seem him like that before. What did you do. I answer with a furrowed brow, he was blaming for the fight between him and Vanessa. He blinks a little, he was. Why would he think that. I say, he heard she is angry with me as well. So I guess he interrupted I said something to her to cause friction between them. Which I obviously didn't. Blake says, I am little confused why he would believe that. I sigh, when it comes to love, people don't make sense. Maybe he feels bad for what happened. But he is taking it on the wrong person.

He says, you sure you don't feel any guilt. You did cause their fight, maybe not indirectly. I scoff, maybe initially. But not now after all this time. I am not going to be sorry about something I shouldn't be. He whistles, whoa. I ask, do you think I was wrong. He tilts his head, I don't think so. But I am not sure they would feel it the same way. I say, I am okay with that. I can't be held responsible for everything. He nods, that I understand. We halt our whispering when people started to pout into the room. Luther sits beside Blake and the rest of the admins fill the other seats.

Soon all the high ranking officers came inside. I got strange looks from few of them. It made sense when it was from Vanessa, Ned, Catherine and Marina. But I felt a stare from Tess and June. I lightly waved at him with curious looks. They waved back and took the seats at the end with a pleasant smile in the end. So I didn't think much of it. Ned took his seat opposite to me. He was obviously shaken up from the earlier confrontation. Yet he had managed to settle down and have a stern face. Got to admire him for being able to set his priorities.

And then arrived the Heraknus. Based on the interactions I had with others and from M's recon, I had memorized their names and a very basic profile. They greet the admins and then take turns meeting me. First few were the warriors. Up close they all were normal Medrones. Even when I used a tiny bit of my Kuret, I couldn't see their Kuret. Just like Charles. Its eerie to see more people not exhibiting outright Kuret. One more noticeable trait was their lean frames. Their training must be heavily focused on Kuret and not much physical. They had different reactions to meeting me. Some were excited, few neutral and others were plain curious.

I met Bernard and Riena the last. He says, nice to meet you David. You have made quite the name for yourself as he takes the seat beside Reinhart. I say, thanks, but some credit goes to your alpha. Without him wouldn't be in the spot light. He gives me a laugh for my perspective. Beside her sat Riena, it’s pleasant to make your acquaintance David. I says, yours too. Finally, Rory their place beside her. She leans in closer, you caused a lot of stirs amongst us. She gestures to the warriors sitting at the end of the room. I reply, I have known to have that effect. That made all the admins snicker a little. Rory says, hey David. Dad says he is sorry he couldn't be here with us.

I wave at him, its fine. I understand you will be making decisions for him in his place. He nods, that’s right. But if you have any concern I can call him in a video. Reinhart says, hope it doesn’t come to that. With the current unrest within Citradel, an open communication there is not a good option. Rory says, dad will be on standby only for urgent messages. He then faces Blake, before we start I want to make one thing clear. We have no connection what so ever with Ryes or the smuggling criminal he is working with. Berner add, alleged criminals. Reina says, or with the current problems with the church. Bernard says, we separated from Citradel, so whatever they have done, please know we weren't part of it.

He was looking at me now. I waited for Blake to respond first. He says relieved, that's good to hear. Though I would like it if it came from your alpha, no offense. Riena says, no, you are right. Charles will reach out to you later today. Rory asks me, you gave Citradel a good beating for that interview Ryes did. Many us are still not accepting this is was you. I laugh, does it matter who did it. Besides, the credit actually goes to the people who helped me do this. I was merely the gravel that decided to retaliate in the most befitting manner. Blake asks, I hope things didn't blow back too much on you. Bernard nervously says, Charles had some troubles. Reina says, but nothing big enough to be of concern.

I don't think they would reveal that to us anyways. When the last of the crew entered the conference room. The meeting got started. Rinhart takes it away, thank you everyone for joining us. Especially to our guests from Citradel. A roar of cheers and claps came from the officers. He continues, its great to see so such a legendary bloodline amongst us. I am sure everyone will need some time to adjust in the city. So please, Heraknus, take your time settling in. You are here for 4 days, lets make the most of it.

I decided to use a little bit of my Kuret in my eyes to get hints of their state. It took a few seconds to adjust the new glimmer sensitivity. I see majority of the Heraknus being excited. A couple of them remained unconvinced or hide their apprehensions. Rinehart continues, let me introduce a few of them. For the time being he only formally mentioned the 3 Heraknus sitting on the table. Reina says, I am so happy to be here. I look forward to see your city. Bernard and Rory said the similar things. With the brief introductions done, Reinhart jumps straight in and explains todays agendas. He had two important discussion to have. About the rules of the exhibition match. And the other was about the broadcast. The second topic was perhaps due to the dangers of Charles overdrive.

The discussion went initially on how I learnt from the admins before. We were going to re use the coliseum for the match. Instead of a grassy ground, the battle area will instead be a landscape comprising a small forest, river and even hills. The Heraknus were very excited to see such a vivid battle ground. Few officers didn't understand the need for complexity. Ned answered saying that this technically not part of the tournament. We want to make sure people know I was the clear winner of the tournament. By changing the battle ground, it will bolster that fact. Few thought it was too gaudy, but it was a good promotion campaign. I wasn't choosy with any landscape.

Blake interjected to clarify the new changes when Riena and Bernard had questions. There were few changes here and there based on the discussion that the admins took note of. In the end they decided we need to expand the battle field by breaking down the seating areas and few rooms. I was actually happy with this decision. The last time one of my uncontrolled Kuret blast nearly burned a section of people. This time the people will be seating outside the whole stadium. Heraknus were stressing on that part. They didn't haven't said it outright, but they know that Charles could hurt others.

The broadcasting streams and channels would remain largely unchanged from the tournament. The media team has been reaching out to the other communities and Medrones living outside to view the match with their familiar setup. Ned claims the tournament was such a success, that more communities have reached out. They must have heard about Heraknus coming out of the shadows. This increases the workload of Neds media team, as well as Catherines external affairs team. Blake proposed to hire more people for their teams. Its good that we still have few weeks left to get everything ready.

I didn't have any issues with the discussion happening in front of me. The most my participation was agreeing to after their discussion. Rory was mirroring the same as me. It makes me even more curious why other Heraknus warrior were here. With just these three, the meeting would have progressed the same. There must be a reason and not just because its their first public Heraknus appearance. Around 12 the talk was moving towards the rules. The admins prepared a document for us and shared it to the tables on the table.

This part I have to be wary of. The last time someone found loopholes that caused a lot of problem for many people. The were less rules this time, but they were more concise and clear. Charles had pitched the match to be 10 minutes, but now its said until his overdrive is over. Blake says, this is different than what Charles said. Rory says, about that. We don't know exactly how long his overdrive will last. Dad said he wanted all the time he could get. It could be 10 minutes, like he said. But it might very well be less than 8 minutes. Blake says, but it could be 15 minutes too. Are you saying you don't want to keep a time limit.

This is rule is overwhelmingly favored for Charles. Reinhart says, since they asked for a personal bias, we decided to balance it with a few rules. The next one said that if he steps outside the barrier in his overdrive form, its an immediate forfeit and I win. Even if I get out along with him. But if either of us step out for more than 30 seconds, it’s their loss. That’s an interesting rule made just for us two. I chuckle, so I win if I manage to drag out Charles with me. Then I am okay with it, Blake. Riena says, that’s a relief. But you should know, getting away from him will be extremely difficult. Charles will not let go of his target in any circumstance, no matter who it is.

I wasn't scared of that. Since I wasn't planning to evade him all the time. Most people believed my only strategy for a guaranteed win is to be on the run. Perhaps that’s why the admins decided to add such mini landscapes. Even when he chases me around, the battle wouldn't be boring. But that will be boring for me. I haven't told this to anyone. If I could explain it, they will surely object and say I am insane. I will not be explaining my strategies to anyone except Blake and Marina. I say without any hesitation, I got no problem.

Blake asks me for silent confirmation with his face. I nod and he relents in the end. We move on to the rest of the rules. The barrier this time will not just be Kuret, but a carbine cage infused with Kuret. Marina told her plan to include another Averna charm to make this barrier even stronger than before. However, we learnt from last time and added a built in escape hatch. Marina says, if you become incapacitated for any reason, we will pull you out from a small hole in the barrier. Unlike last time, anyone can come in and out. Reinhart says, but if that happens and people rush in to get you, you lose immediately. Rory asks, and we can't really guarantee the response time.

Luther asks, how long are we talking about. Riena says, at least 20 seconds. That’s the best we can do. Our fastest people, with the necessary equipment, can reach in that time. It may look like another disadvantage for me. But I wasn't fazed by it. Actually I foresaw this sort of rule already. I smirk, that's fine with me. When I fell like I am done, I will step out myself. I won't risk my life unnecessary again. I hope people believed me this time. Especially the ones that were worried for me a lot, Vanessa and everyone else. I was way too arrogant and full of myself back then. The power up inflated my ego too much. I like to say it was due to Ketriya or my mental instability. I am not sure about the reason, but it doesn't matter now.

I was incredibly lucky that time. This time, I will be more strategic in my judgement. I am not making that mistake again. I give a confident smile to Blake, which he agreed not to censure this. The next rule was that I can quit anytime and I can't take it back no matter what happened next. Even if Charles overdrive is over the very next second. Next couple of rules were standard stuff, I can't cheat, or receive help from anyone. Charles also can't receive any help. To closely monitor any serious injuries, we will be chipped with a device to monitor our health. Its a small Kuretine circuit chip that will track the Kuret depletion in our bodies.

Blake says, ah, that will not work on David. Reinhart says, there is an alternate option for each of them to use their own tech to track their vitals. However, the tech have be verified by us and even share the vitals to both sides in real time. I nod, that’s fair. Bernard says, we have our own very unique way of monitoring and controlling Charles if he looses too much control. Things seems to going smooth. There were still few things to iron out, but they were minor logistic decisions that will be taken later.

Riena suddenly gets a little somber. I see dim orange glimmer from her. It wasn't just her, the other Heraknus were also suddenly serious or anxious. She asks, one last thing. She motions to her son beside her. He pulls out a document from his bag and gives it to me. A writing document instead of digital. They didn't want this to leak out. I read the first few lines and my smile dropped. I gaze up to look at the Heraknus with a shock on my face. Blake asks, what is it. I ignore him and continue to speed read the whole document. The admins were also confused as they showed streaks of yellow. Then they didn't know this too

I had to pull out my shades down to read the document more carefully. I don't care if people saw the fake black eye now. Is this for real. I can't believe they drew up such a contract. I turn to the next page that continued this ridiculous terms. After few minutes of tense silence from everyone I put the document down on the table. I should be offended by this piece of paper. It caught me so off guard that I stifle a chuckle. Luther asks me nervous, David? I slide the document to him and Blake, take a look at it yourself. It’s a freaking accidental death deniability and beneficiary contract.

The entire room broke into whispers and stupefaction. The admins had no idea as they try to look over the document these two were reading. Reinhart blurts out, Riena, what is the meaning of this. Instead of her, Rory says, it’s an unpleasant but necessary precaution in case David dies during the match. The whispers now turn to mild indignation discussion amongst people. While others were busy panicking, I calmed myself down and started to plan out my thoughts. Blake had read enough of the document. Luther picks it up and furiously reads it from his hands. Blake says, why did you decide to show this now. We needed to be made aware of it in advance.

He shows confusion and anger, which were justified reactions. Bernard says, I am sorry. It was a very sensitive topic, so we decided not to reveal it over your network. Blake says, I don't get it. Why did you prepare it at all. This whole time we are talking about different types of contingencies so that no one will get hurt. Including David. The commotion erupts louder. I turns to see the angered expression from my friends. I was strangely curious about Vanessa. Would she be worried or be conflicted. But from my angle, I couldn't see her face. I can't overuse my glimmers right now. Too bad, I will have to ask her separately.

Riena says, we are really sorry about this. But a majority of our house members would only agree to move here after this contract was brought in. Having read the document, it made sense how everyone collectively decided to move here. Luther hands over the document to Reinhart. He says, this is a bit outrageous. We need time to consult about this. Bernard says, yes. But we need David to put sign it. Rory says, and he also need to provide a admissible video explaining that he is aware of the risks and doing it on his own accordance. He seemed strangely less guilty sliding me another paper. It was a short paragraph. I read few lines understood the intent for this.

Blake is more confused than ever, is that for the public then. Riena nods showing more empathy than Rory. She says, the contract is between us. But the video is for court of public opinion. We can't have people blaming us for an accident when we were explicit about the risks. Rinhart puts down the document now, this is unacceptable Riena. This match is going to be broadcasted to the whole world. There is no future where we a death will be acceptable. Why is there such a risk. He doesn't the whole risks and to fix that misconception, Riena explains the dangers of Charles overdrive.

Until now they thought he couldn't control his overdrive, but now they know he isn't even cognizant of himself. She even reveals the dangers to people if anyone gets close to Charles. Few minutes later Ned asks, did you know this when you took the deal David. Several eyes fall on me. I reply, I did. Reinhart clenches his jaws, why didn't you tell us. Blake answers it for me, we wanted Charles, or Heraknus or Citradel to explain it. For all we know Charles and Kafar were exaggerating the side effect of his overdrive. Bernard says, trust us. Its all true. He gestures to the warriors, we all have seen him lashing out and had to work together to stop him.

Many of the officers and admins were speaking in low tones conveying bewilderment. Luther asks, Blake, you were there. Why didn't you stop David from taking the deal in the first place if his life was at such grave risk. Blake says, I tried. But, he faces me with sharp eyes, he was not backing down. I need to speak my mind before people think I was being dumb. I can't explain my actual reasons, or the ones I thought I did back then. Instead, I need to convince them I will be doing this no matter what happens and still not die.

I put my shades back on and turn around to see others. I was giving them all a silent but ominous expression to make it clear I was dead serious now. I say, I want to tell you all something. And I don't want anyone to interrupt me. I give a no tolerance bullshit until I had my piece. I continue, you all know my past is filled with mistakes and regret. And Ryes dredged up painful memories that I didn't want to relieve. One of them was about a human named James Noland. He was the first person to help me once the war with Hive escalated. And I wouldn't be here if it were not with him.

Rory asks me despite the warning I gave earlier, what is he got to do with this. I responded with a dead pan expression at him. He couldn't see my face, but my body posture scared him a bit. I could see a little bit of the glimmer. I continue ignoring him, his family died as part of collateral damage from a fight between Medrones and Hives. A killer with thrust for vengeance and anger was born. Even though it was Hive who instigated the war with us, he wowed to kill any alien he came across. I found out later he even had killed dozens of Medrones in his misguided attempt to get revenge. He would have killed me too had I showed any signs of normal Kuret.

I scoff, he helped me when no one did and I was floundering around like a helpless pup. He should me how to fight Hive and kill them. We made one hell of a team. I shake my head, but when he found out I was a Medrone, which at the time I myself didn't know, he turned against me. I didn't show me any pity and made his mission to kill me. He regrated helping me so much that he didn't even care the lives of human who got in his way. He killed innocent people, cops to try and rectify his mistake. He abandoned his quest to kill Hives in order to end me. And because of that I had to kill him.

A wave of murmuring float around the room. I never told this anyone before. Not even to Cass, or Siera or Vanessa. They only know few things about him. I continue, Ryes believes my first kill was a criminal, but it wasn't him. I had no choice but to stop James. He was planning to blow up the whole camp where the Hives were keeping the Medrones captive. I regret so many things. Maybe I had different words, I could have convinced him. Made him see reason. He was a man of sheer will and determination. He would have been our greatest ally. But he lost any good reason to live and I had to put him down.

I sigh, even in his last moments, he never let show his regrets. But I knew. He told me I was never going to change anything. That I was small compared to the colossal threat. And I believed I shared same fate like his, not able to accomplish anything. I knew he was talking about himself. He shouldn't had to die with so many regrets and nothing to show for. I then turn to Blake, I have no intention to die before I kill the Hive king. I am not going to waste my life like his. I turn to others officers, you all may think its not worth the risk, but I don't care. I had to take away a strong ally. I am not going to let go of another opportunity to get even stronger allies for the war ahead.

I can't tell how convincing I am. People should different glimmers. But I made it clear that I wasn't deter from anything they try to scare me. The room is silent with constant stares at me. I showed appropriate passion and reason. This had to resonate with few if not all. I ask Riena, tell me what happens if I don't sign this. She clears her throat and responds, this contract is represents a majority of Heraknus. Even if its not what Charles wanted, he would abide their decision and we will not move here.

This caused another panic among the people. Blake tightens his fist on the table, I know what you are trying to do. You failed to convince Charles to not take the deal. So now you are trying scare people into forcing David to drop the deal himself. None of the Heraknus made any signs of denying it. I agreed with his assessment. It was a contentious play. But Its also effective, especially when I just became famous. The response of explaining the dangers of Charles overdrive will have max impact now. The officers didn't know the whole risk, so now they want to drop this. They believed I will not be convinced directly, so people will do it for them.

Luther grits his teeth, are you planning to reveal this contract to the public too. Bernard says with somber voice, I know how desperate we sound. And I am not going to deny we are doing this to void the deal. But just like David doesn't want to loose us as ally's, we don't want to loose a powerful Medrone like him. If the worst happens, Heraknus will be forever tarnished. Many don't want Charles to test his our theory about controlling his overdrive like this. So please understand we will do everything possible to avoid that outcome.

Riena faces me, I believe you when you say you don't want to die like your human friend. But is that risk you want to take when its completely avoidable. Luther says, if the deal goes away, you will remain in Citradel. Blake says his thoughts, and there is a good chance with your support back with Citradel, they will pull them out of their current conflicts. The church may back down. And they will look for ways around their predicament of resources. All our efforts will be wasted. Rory says, we are aware. But like how dad told you once, we can't be responsible for others. We have to do what's right for us.

I looked at this from their objective and it made sense why they want to cover all their bases. If I back down, no one gets hurts. But if I die, Charles and I will be blamed for such a disaster. They want to avoid that at all cost. The admins are discussing amongst themselves to figure out a peaceful solution. I could settle the matter if I just signed the paper myself. I am resolved to do it. But that would make me incredibly selfish and reckless. I need some sort of agreement from Blake and officers before I make do it.

For now, at least people aren't trying to talk me out. They were clearly shaken when I declared I wasn't going to die no matter what. But they are just confident words and more than likely arrogance. I need to show them to prove it.

David (Chapter 105)

Sunday, March 1, 2026 22:11

As people debated on how to settle this, I was my mind went on different track. The Heraknus warrior were brought in to testify Charles overdrive dangers. Many, like Sommers, knew they were here for to talk about their Heraknus alpha. But now they realize they came to give credence to the risk. They want to scare people and convince me to not sign such a thing. However, I still believe they are here for other reasons too. Otherwise why send so many warriors. Few would get the job done.

Aside from their presence, I was beginning to see a new problem. Blake understood me the best and had resigned his opposition because I had PTSD. But recent events gave him confidence in my abilities, especially now that I have gone through Ketriya. But this contract in front of us has made him second guess his confidence in me. I didn't need to see his glimmer to see his resolve wavering. Its probably the same with others. The Heraknus kept apologizing but also kept insisting to either break the deal or sign the contract.

Rory was good at instilling fears. Him being Charles son made everyone believe him unequivocally when he said no one can stop Charles alone. At this pace, whatever I choose won't matter. People will make that decision for me. Even Ned believed this was crazy and backed me despite the verbal scuffle we had outside. He didn't want to show a match that could end in a potential death. Reinhart signs to Riena, you really should have told this much earlier. Or at least given us more time to consider this.

Riena says with a distraught voice, I don't like putting anyone in this position. We deliberated for long time, and decided to present it now. I don't have any good excuse. Just bad ones. Blake asks, at least tell me who came up with this contract first. You say it wasn't Charles, then who was it. I want to know their reasons. Bernard says, sorry. We can't tell you that. They would be singled out and be in a negative spotlight. Its not their fault for prioritizing Heraknus before anyone else. Blake had no argument to refute that. It was good attempt. But unnecessary. Its become a collective will of the entire Heraknus.

Luther asks, when if we David signs this contract, how will it uphold. We don't have laws and policies in place right now to adhere to the all the claims. Beneficiaries for getting his asset, cluses on abdicating repercussions and other stuff. Reina says, that is true. However, you are mistaking one thing about the validity of this contract. Blake rests his chin on the back of his palm, we don't have the laws, but it will change when Citradel council moves here. You are betting that they will come regardless who wins the match. She nods, its almost guaranteed they will join in the city. And when they do, these document will have value. We are preparing for that eventual administration.

We are in a deadlock situation. I am restrained due to others. Heraknus aren't backing down due to Charles selfish decisions. Quite a quandary I am stuck in. I heard a comment from an admin talking how they shouldn't have brought in the Heraknus warriors here. They were concerned it only aggravated the confusion and tension. Then I connected the dots. I remember Sommers saying Riena came to judge me. What if they came to do that too.

There were was the rumor about me cheating and they spent an entire day about proving that. Why haven't they mentioned it. I don’t think they have any new evidence to believe I wasn't cheating. With Riena and Bernard taking the lead, they have been obediently following their lead and only supported them. However, none of them has even said one about me possibly cheating. That’s what's been bugging me back when I heard they send half their strongest platoon.

I was caught off guard with this contract that I didn't realize the biggest reason they are here. I am sure many of them still feel unsure how I was able to copy others Kuret. They want to see me close and see if tricked them. I turn to Rory, who was the biggest reason why I thought its possible. He was asking about my Kuret sphere back then. I gather he must be the next strongest after his father. So his presence alone was enough to make us aware of the threat to my life. Its possible he brought others to make a prove them that I was cheating.

Maybe the next contention of topic after this would be about this. I would obviously not show how I can do it. It would bolster the fact to the warriors that I am cheating. Blake said to them a while ago that he can't trust them to not give other conditions. The admins also agreed with that point. While the Heraknus denied it, none of us were convinced. They were making an unexpected demand of me, so whose to say there won't be another. Maybe they will use it as leverage to break the deal. Unless I show proof I didn't cheat, they are sure to cock block us again.

I couldn't stop a sudden chuckle in the heat of the discussion among others. Few confused faces are directed at me. I know exactly what I need to do now. I turn to the Reina and gather everyone's attention, I want to propose something. A way to move forward this. She says, I will gladly take any suggestions. I say, I will sign the contract and even record a video for the public. Blake tries to lean in closer, but I raise my finger to him. I say, but it will not be disclosed to the public. I will not let you manipulate people with this. I will convince you that I can take on Charles with a demonstration.

This made everyone confused. She asks, what kind of demonstration. I say, I appreciate your position you are in. You all have seen Charles overdrive up close, so you know his full unbridled power. What you are worried the most that no can can't stop him. What if I convinced you I can do it, survive long enough till his overdrive runs out. Bernard says, its an overdrive. Only another. I cut him off, you are thinking of Medrine. But its gone. The rules have changed. People with unexpected powers are popping up everywhere. Is it so hard to imagine some irregular like me can't face him. You are sorely underestimating me.

Rory says, we aren't. You struggled in the match. I scoff, that was natural. I had never seen a Heraknus before. Forget about knowing how their Kuret works or any weakness. I smile, besides, I have leveled up since then. This bruise was from Blake. He packs mean right punch. He and others have been helping me whip into shape. I am very confident I will be more than ready to take him on. People were taken by my attempt at this persuasion. Rory asks hesitantly, in just over a week?

His skepticism was natural. I say, that’s why I want to show a demonstration. It will also help convince our officers that I am not foolish, but strong enough to fight Charles. I turn to the warriors, and your warriors can judge for themselves I can manage a caged Charles. This grabbed their attention as well. I need them to say it first before I do. The actual goal I have in mind. I say, I have requested the training center tomorrow. I invite you then, to see my demonstration of my Kuret. I am sure I can show enough abilities to manage Charles rampage.

This caused more commotion in the room. Blake whispers to me, I hope you know what you are doing. You aren't ready yet. I subtly nod at him. I am glad he wasn't stopping me and just warning me. Guess he also knows I won't back down. Luther asks, what if they are not convinced. You will allow this agreement to go public. I nod, sure. But I am confident people will not be scared after seeing what I have to offer. It will not be overly grand but it will to be enough that everyone here won't stop me.

I nudge them a little with a hint so that they go with a different idea I had in mind. I was waiting for someone to take the bait. Reinhart says, if we can keep this agreement hidden from people, we may be able to stop an uproar. Isn't that right. He confers with other admins. Ned says, I think its still a bad idea to sign that contract. However, he takes a pause, it would be better for moral if people not know the dangers of Charles overdrive. But how can you so sure Charles won't accidently kill you.

Actually I had a surefire answer to relieve everyone of their worries. If I reveal it here, then no one will stop me to sign this or disclose this contract it to the public. But it will only complicate things and also reveal a strategy against Charles. I have to an arduous route for now. I say, ask me that question again tomorrow. I wasn't going to give in to any pressure from anyone. I am very aware how arrogant I am being. I needed to appear this way for someone to take the bait. Bernard asks, what a bold suggestion. What do you intend to show. He gave me an opening. I say, you saw the preliminary rounds. There are so many ways I can prove it to you. Or better yet, you can suggest something. I leave more crumbs for someone to pick up.

Rory says, instead of an aimless demonstration. How about something specific. I gave him a sly smirk. He took my bait, that’s true. Its a caged match, not a marathon, or an obstacle or a test of strength. A survival match with my life is on the line. So how about a sparring match with your Heraknus warriors. He smiles in response thinking I caught on to his thinking. But actually it was me who gave it to him. I turn to others, you guys have seen Charles overdrive. I am sure you even restrained him on occasions. You guys are the best judge for this. Now peoples attention focus on the people at sitting at the end.

They all become anxious, but I could few glimmers of excitement too. I think I was right they wanted to see my Kuret up close. But none of them responded. At least not yet. I turn to Rory, how about you Rory. Are you game. He thinks for a second, sorry. I am still not sure if what you said about overdrive DNA theory was true or not. I don't want to give you any advantage. I wave him, that was just a theory. Its not an exact science. Besides who else better to judge me other than you. For a moment it looked like he would agree to it. But in the end he remained silent.

Too bad, I would have preferred him. Then I face back to the slightly anxious warriors. I say, you are here to guard others. But you have an opportunity to show others what Heraknus can do. I see some glimmer of peak curiosity and excitement. I add, don't tell me you are afraid of loosing. That did it. Eric stands up, I'll take up on your offer. We got our first contender. I raise my palm to him, we finally get someone with balls here. That’s great. Eric, right. Let me be honest here. You know I sort of goaded you into this. Are you still fine with it.

Many were bamboozled at my open provocation. Eric looks around to his people for a moment and then to me, doesn't matter. We were here to judge you if you were worthy to fight Charles in the first place. This is an excellent opportunity to test your so called confidence. See if they are just words or if you can back it up. I like him. He wasn't angry with me so much that he be bothered by this. I saw tinge of blue glimmer, he was composed and yet held enough pride. I reply, I just wanted to make sure you know what you are getting into.

I don’t believe this will appease everyone. I am sure not everyone understands how this convinces them and sign the contract. But it at least removes the deadlock we were stuck in. Eric suggests something more. He says, if we are going to check if you can survive Charles. I alone am not enough. I am curious how he indents to judge, Geroge, Lena. He points to them beside him. They both lacked the courage before, but now they gained enough to stand proudly. He says, I am not so stupid to fight you alone. You are strong enough to take on omegas.

The way he puts it makes one believe he wanted a particular type of team match up. I ask, you want me to fight you all three. All at once. He smirks slightly, I do. You don't think only one of us are strong enough to hold Charles overdrive on our own. It takes five of us. The last time Charles went berserk, we three were able to restrain him. Granted, we got lucky and it only happened once, but we are confident in our abilities to hold him down. If you want to prove you can survive alone. Then show us by doing the same. This wasn't what I expected, but he was right to test me in the right circumstances.

More people voiced their opinions now. The three of them were locked in and waiting for my decision. I say my chances have dropped a little. It will be very difficult. They only need to realize that I can carry my weight. I nod, fair enough. I am in. The room becomes slightly chaotic from this outrageous agreement. I turn to Reinhart, do you have a problem with this. He spoke to an admin for some time. He then says, we don’t have much choice right now. If Heraknus are prepared to keep this hidden, it could work. But are you sure about this. Rory says with a small smile, yeah. What if you get hurt or won't be able to convince Riena.

I turn to her, in that case you will get your wish. Many people will not be in favor of this and it most likely end with the match cancelled. She and Bernard were still amazed by how unfazed I was. The other warriors were ecstatic to get a chance to see me in action. I had the correct insight they came here to see if I am deceiving others. They won't mention it now since they think I will be showing it tomorrow. They in for a colossal disappointment. Luther says, this is nuts David. I thought you haven't trained enough your new Kuret form. How will you fight them off.

I say, I have other tricks my sleave. I was blatantly hinting that I will copy Kurets. Rory leans in closer with anticipation. I say, or maybe I just bluffing. We will see tomorrow. I think this improved many peoples anxieties, while it only increased in few people. No doubt its more in my friends. I say to Eric, since I am asking a favor from you guys. You can decide how you want to test me. He nods in agreement, I will discuss with others for the appropriate test. What time shall we meet tomorrow. I gave a thought, lets mee it same time tomorrow. Goerge and Lena gave their approval too.

Since it was lunch time now. After few final discussions about tomorrow we broke off. I am immediately swamped by the high ranking officers and Ned. Everyone else left us alone in the conference room. Marina yells, freaking

hell David. What in the world you did that for. Nathan says, taking on three of them together. That’s crazy, even by your standards. Vanessa gave me the silent treatment. I wonder if she heard about Ned confronting me earlier. Catherine says, hey, don't ignore us. I face her, I was just thinking how much time I have today to train. I was thinking of a targeting attack practice. This caused a nervous smiles and chuckles from everyone.

Blake says, you need a lot more time than just today. You just, ah, had an accident. You can't have recovered already. I say, I feel fine. Don’t worry. I did a light workout today, tested few things. I can take on them if I play my cards correctly. Many people didn't understand what I meant. June says, I think your under estimating them. I say, perhaps. But I had to do something. There was potentially another issue rising after this. Blake says, what do you mean. I explained them my reasoning why the warriors were here. I didn't have any proof, but turns out I didn't need it. None of them even mention it to anyone in the car as well.

They themselves realize the suspicious behavior. Luther says, I didn't notice that. I just believed they laid it to rest. But you are right. They stretched out the whole day due that rumor. Tina says, and they would taken longer if we hadn't forced their hand. Ruther asks, what if they just didn't care anymore. With all the publicity they got they might have thought you couldn't have cheated. I scoff, no way it will convince them of my innocence. If anything, they might be even more suspicious after Ryes going at my personal life. Any outsider would believe that if I can hide things about my past, I am not completely above board.

Deni says, still, they didn't demand for a proof yet. I say, no, they didn't. And maybe they never had any intention. But I wasn't going to take that chance. My Kuret techniques is my ace in the hole. The only advantage I have against Charles. And besides, this will put to a stop to any of further attempts to escape the deal. Even the two of them begin to realize I made a move that made the most sense.

Vanessa says, I know Rory was definitely suspicious of it. He told me outright that he thought David cheated. Despite no evidence. I don't think he let it go completely after meeting him today either. I didn't know about she had a honest talk with him. Catherine says, seriously. He seems so decent. Marina asks, why didn't you tell us.

She shrugs, I didn't think much of it. I just believed he was jealous of David or something like that. I smile at her, thanks for the compliment. I do agree with you. She gives me a confused look. June says, but to use it as another leverage. Do you think they would go that far. I pick up the document and raise it in front of her. She takes it and sighs, point taken. People take turns reading the document. Nathan says, I believe David. There is very good chance they ask this. It won't just prove he wasn't cheating, but also reveal his tricks. A double edged sword as a final act of desperation to get out of this deal.

Catherine asks me skeptically, how in the world did you figure that out. I thought you had changed. Her words hurt me so much, it left me a little berated. I say, I am still the same person, just better. The people who didn't understand her question gave her puzzled words. She shakes her head trying to hide her embarrassment. Chelsea says, back up a second. I heard from Catherine that all of you knew about Charles overdrive from the beginning. How are you guys so chill about it. Jess says, its not like we didn't know the dangers. But its David, I am sure he has some plan.

I raised by brows, curious why she thought that. She says, what. Am I wrong. You were acting a little crazy back in the coliseum when negotiating with Charles. But today you were different. Please tell me you guys saw it too. I mumble, clever girl. Ned asks me, so you already have a way to win. I thought for a second on how to handle this. I say, not exactly. I have a way to not die. No matter what situation I am in. People were waiting for me to explain. I tell, you really expect me to reveal such a strategy. I am in pins and needles with the stares I am getting. I sigh, but I know you can't just take my word for it. So here's what I am going to do.

I grab Blake's shoulder with one arm and Marina with the other. I jerk my head to motion them and come along with them. Tessa says, seriously. You trust them more than us. I felt another curious glimmer of suspicion from her. I say, ahm, yeah. They are Shadows. Then I had another thought, fine. I guess I include another person. Nathan, lend me your ear too for a second. I picked the most untrustworthy guy from the group. That turns a lot heads with confusion. He scoffs, you are not kidding. I would be your last choice. I say, that’s the point. No one will doubt me then.

He shows his teeth to others, very interesting. Blake asks, you sure. I tilt my head, trust me. Marina says, come on. Spit out then. The four of us left the others for a small while and I explained them my strategy. In about two minutes I return back to others. Ned asks, what did you say to them. They look so nervous. I say, they are just over reacting. Vanessa says, did you really them the truth. Or was it just a bluff. She is still so consistent in not trusting me. I say, ask them. Tessa asks, Blake. What is his plan. Blake expression changes to confusion, I don't believe it. I am going to have you show it to me. I gave him a subtle nod.

Marina was extremely excited, so you can actually do it. You can cut through my barrier any time. She plays on her hair ends with a nervous laugh. Nathan whistles, just how in the would did you acquire this Kuret. I click my tongue, spoilers. Come on. No more hints. Jess eyes Nathan, who just shakes his head laughing. Vanessa asks, did he really tell you his plan. Blake sighs, he did. Its unbelievable. Marina says, you guys are in for a treat. You could have told the Heraknus. They would have back down.

I say, there was no guarantee. Besides, I am going to use it tomorrow. Nathan says, you aren't. I thought the point was to shock and awe. You seem to have whole heatedly embraced that thinking. I say, there is a time and place for everything. I am not going to put my survival at risk. Then I smile, besides I have a different plan. You want a shock and awe, get your ass tomorrow and see it for yourself. He scoffs, nothing will stop me. I will clear all my meetings for it. Vanessa asks, wait. You don't plan to use your mystery Kuret. Then how do you plan to convince them tomorrow.

I say, I will figure it out. I always do. She wasn't really buying my confidence. She probably thinks I am just lying or bluffing. In that case I have an idea, since you don't know if you can't trust my decision. How about this, if you aren't convinced I can't handle Charles by tomorrow, I won't sign the contract. Her eyes narrows at me. I turn to others, actually, if even one of you think I can't do this, I won't go ahead. Frank says, whoa. You want us to decide this. Are you sure. I nod, I am not just doing this to convince Heraknus, but I am doing it for you all too.

Catherine says, you actually mean that. Deni says, that’s actually makes us even more nervous. June says, yeah. I don't like putting in a spot like this. Blake says, they have a point. You can't just pawn off your decision to them. I expected the resistance, this is not me making this difficult for you. I am trusting you guys to make the call for me. Its just as simple as that. Nathan says, what happens when you don't sign the contract. We loose Heraknus, then we loose Citradel. I laugh, that is fine too. Do you think I have only one arsenal in my bag to force Citradel to bend the knee.

Blake asks, please don't joke around. I say, I am not. Taking away their resources was a plan I had at one time. But I didn't do it until it was necessary. And given their current state, its possible to dismantle Citradel from inside out. I don't want to do that, but I will if Heraknus don't play ball. Chelsea asks, I am sorry, but how can you do that. Luther says, you say it like its no big deal. I say, I didn't say it will be easy. But its not impossible. Now that I am not crippling with trauma, my mind is much more clearer. Its like the time I was without my memories, but without the unnecessary burden I was placing on myself.

I then stared at the two people who recently leaned my true identity. They both had to realize its well within my skill set. Catherine speaks first, I see. Yeah, if its you. Then you can probably do it. Don’t you think Vanessa. Vanessa looks a little conflicted for few seconds. She then says, I guess. Nathan says, you seen to have something going on with them. Wonder what it is. I wasn't ready to reveal my identity. At least not yet. Ned asks, I am not a high ranking officer. Will you give me a say in it anyways. He probably thinks I am going to held the previous confrontation against him.

I nod, why not. You wouldn't be able to do you job if you constantly worry how the match will end. Wondering all sorts of precautions for any problems I might cause for you. Being blindsided after doing so much is a bitch. I was taunting him, possibly hint to fix or end his relationship with Vanessa. I don't know if he got that hint. He remained silent, contemplating his decisions. Marina says, you are being too cocky, you know that. I had to own that. I say, only if I can't back it up. And you know I can do. She bites her lips knowing I was right. I was taking a page out of her book.

Blake says, all right. If you insist, we will also be judging you. But be honest, what are your chances of winning tomorrow. I scratch my neck and give some thought, I say, less than 50 percent. Nathan says, its less than that. You don't know anything about those three Heraknus. You are going in blind. I say, so are they. They haven't seen what I can do now. He laughs, you take a big game. Its been only around 1 week and half. I say, a lot has happened since then. That makes some of them suspect of me. Blake says, regardless, lets wrap it up. We have still have jobs today.

Catherine says, that’s right. I need to take them a tour of the city and then Marina will take to the construction site. We have a full booked day today. Its time to take my leave, I will see you all tomorrow. And Blake, I like your help tonight. Meet me at the same place we did few days back. He takes a peek at his tablet, I will be free after 9. Will that work for you. I say, that’s fine by me. You can dinner at my place. Marina jerks, hold on. If you breaking open that wine bottle, I am coming by also. She has her own priorities set, that’s what I admire about her. She says, besides, I need to see what you said was true.

I nod, if you get time after your talk with Heraknus. You can drop by. I turn to others, apologies, but I can't invite others. You know how it is. I get few disapproving looks from people. June gives me a more suspicious look than others. Whatever it was for, it will have to wait. People begin to disperse. I peek at Ned who gave a wanting look at Vanessa, but decided to leave with others. Vanessa didn't follow him behind, but left separately with her IDF team. I feel a bad for interfering their relationship. But all I did was nudging Ned towards an ultimatum.

I tug on Catherine's arm, sorry. But we will have to do rain check on our date. My calendar is booked for the day. She pouts a little, yeah. I got it. Jeez. She leaves with Jess, who asks her, what was that about. A date with him. She scoffs, don't mind him. Nathan says, lets go wonder twins. Frank asks, where. He says, lets scope out some Heraknus. Aren't you curious. Because I am. Did he ask them because they were from Citradel. They chat a little bit and agreed to go with him. Marina strolls behind them, wait. If you are going to the guest house, I want to meet Melinda. I still haven't forgiven her.

Now it was just Blake and me leaving the room. He says, when you said you were going to put on a game face you weren't joking. We laugh sharing in our predicament. He asks, I don't know about others. But I really believe they were going to make another play. I say, I should have seen it coming. It was bugging me why their warriors were in the meeting. Did they say anything to you. He says, not much. They made me believe because Charles wanted them there. But I wonder, if it was Charles or other Herankus. Maybe someone else entirely. I say, you are thinking of Kafar. He says, makes sense right. He gave the impression he had given up, but did he really.

I can't tell it was his idea. I say, he does seem the possible suspect. Then again, it could be the people targeting us. He says, why they benefit from this. Jeopardize breaking the deal when they tried to manipulate the tournament. I say, I am just throwing out a possibility. Maybe we are overthinking and its just Heraknus wanting to cover their asses. We climb down from the stairs and step out the admin building. The crowd outside had gone away now and only officers were outside guarding at the gates.

I say, I agreed to meet Cassandra and Matt at lunch. But I can't make it now. He says, you want me to cover for you. I thought about it for a while, thanks, but its fine. I will message them I have urgent business. But if you can explain them whatever you can, that would be great. He nods, I obviously can't talk about that contract. I will tell them you will be preparing for a demo session with the Heraknus. He pauses for a second, I know you said its fine to bring all the officers, but are really okay with brining in people too. They might see you lose and your celebrity status will take a hit.

I answer flatly, if I lose, then so be it. At least I wouldn't regret not taking a shot at them. As for my popularity, it was always fickle. I accept my situation, whatever it will turn into. I'll just enjoy while it lasts.

Vanessa (Chapter 106)

Monday, March 2, 2026 23:01

Siera wraps her neck with a scarf in front of her bedroom mirror, is this better. I answer, its fine. You are being too weird about this. She sighs, I am going to meet Heraknus today. Even I feel anxious about certain things. You may not remember many stories, but back in Medrine they are legends. And now I am finally getting to meet them. She puts on her favorite jacket. I didn't know she can be such a fangirl. I decided to match her clothes and wore a casual dress with a blouse and jeans.

Yesterday after the meeting, my job was over and I went back to officers building. But my mind was elsewhere the whole day. David has changed so much. I thought he was faking it. Then I heard from Blake later what really happened. I couldn't believe he was stuck with such a sickness. I didn't know what Ketriya was. But when he explained it to me, I was dumbstruck. He has been going through Ketriya for decades. When I told Siera she couldn't speak for several minutes. What's more is that his PTSD, trauma and all the issues he has been suffering was due to Ketriya.

And now that his brain has been physically rewired, certain aspects of him has changed. I couldn't tell Siera what they were, because I was figuring out myself. Its not a personality change. If I had to say, he is become more like when me met and didn't have his memories. He is calculating, but now he knows when not to lie. Siera asked me a question that gave me a lot of headache. Did he combine his self of identity from Medrine and Earth into one, birthing a new one. Maybe she is right, he had to deal with his Shadow past and his experience from Earth. And the result is this, a guy who is jokes around and still schemes when needed.

He said he was going to earn my trust back. And he started by involving me in the decision of whether I allow him to sign that ludicrous death contract. I didn't read it, but Tessa told me the highlights of it. After the initial shock, some of us understood Heraknus point of view. Its their first public appearance after centuries and its already messy. Their alpha was beaten down to a draw and his overdrive danger exposed. They don't want to tarnish their reputation and trust before it even started. Siera calls for me, Vanessa. We don't have time for you to space out. Lets go. I shook off the thoughts and we left for the training grounds.

Blake gave most of the officers off for few hours. He invited all the officers who are available to see the sparring session. We opted to take my car this time instead of public transport. The training grounds were much father and would be slower to reach. On the way Siera asks me, its been some time I visited the place. I respond, same. It brings back memories that feels they were from years, not months. The big arena in sector 5 comes into the view. I see many people trying to get in. But only officers and their families were invited in.

Siera asks, was this wise to open to the civilians. I take the car towards the path the sign said for parking. I nervously say, Luther discussed with Heraknus and they agreed to bring in few people. But not the general public. She asks, why not. I say, Heraknus are not yet citizens of our city. They are not really our guest too. So for the time being they are given intermediatory provisions. So in the interest of protecting the general public, this compromise was done. Heraknus also want to take it slow. She says, I see. Sort of makes sense. So they are okay with few people, and not all. I correct her, only our families. Not even friends. That’s the deal for today.

I find a spot in the forest clearing and part my car. The last time I was here was when many people were busy training to improve their ranking. I reminisce a little when I see the track in the south. I took the first position in that, and I was so proud of it. But now it’s a distant achievement. After today, everyone who had fond memories of this place would be overlapped with Heraknus. Few volunteers officers guarded the arena. Even with the barricades around the facilities, we needed people to watch out for intruders.

The officer says, morning Vanessa. And this is. I introduce her to them. They take a look at their tablets and check her name. He says, all set. He gives her a card that assigns her a seat. He says, you can bring your phones inside, but we strongly discourage not to take photos or videos of Heraknus. I wave to them with a laugh, ah, guys. I gave that order myself. She already knows. The guy gets nervous at his clumsiness. He had other things to say, but he immediately steps aside, ah, I didn't realize. Apologies. We take the entrance door leading inside.

Passing through the hallways, we entered into a open ground covered with a thin semi transparent roof. Half of seats prepared for us were filled. I point out our seat to her, perks of being the chief. You get to enjoy from the best view. She smiles, show off. I signal her the way while I take a detour to meet few people. One of them that caught my eye was Freya. Nathan sat with Jess and her. Its been a long time since I saw her. She's been working with the scientists as a contractor and not as an officer. Nathan insisted she be kept away from us. She says, you look good Vanessa. Sorry, I haven't been in touch with you all more.

I say, you should get out more. I turn her brother, someone is being over protective of her. Nathan answers with scoff, you know why. She is not a fighter, and these are strange time to be out and about. Freiya gets annoyed at the trite reason. I know the main reason is because he isn't in control of the city. Unlike here, the Valley was his domain and he could let Freya free reign. We didn't force her to be more active because she was herself not willing. These two are the last two pure royals left and that comes with its own set of problems.

Jess stands up and pulls me aside. She whispers to me, I heard something from June yesterday. Is it true then. About David and you know what. My heart beats faster. I reply, don't know anything about that. She is confused, are you sure. Because I have been thinking about it for a while now. And it does makes sense. I need to get an excuse and leave. I found one from the crowd. I wave to Sommers, lets talk about it later. I didn't give her a chance to stop me again. This is bad, why did June gossip this to Jess. I curse at myself to be such a klutz yesterday. The best I can do right now is avoid talking about it. I pray they all think it was a joke or something.

Sommers came with his mom. She was in her late forties and came in with a sweater. He gets up, hi Vanessa. I greet his mother, morning. She smiles as waving to me, nice to meet you Vanessa. My son has told me a lot of things about his chief. I turn to Sommers who was gesturing her to stop. I smirk, has he been complaining about me as his boss. I want him to know how much trouble he is in. It was a harmless teasing that made her laugh. She says, oh he has told me enough. He scoffs, mom. Chill. She says, fine. I am here for the Heraknus anyways. She gestures to the Heraknus warriors around at the bottom near the edge of wall.

She says, its surreal to see them in person. I didn't notice they were already here. I ask Sommers, when did they arrive. He says, they were the first ones here. Deni said they have been here since 7:00. I see the three person discussing with others. I ask, what have they been doing for 2 hours. He says, meeting few officers and people. But mostly doing some Kuret warm up exercises. I heard one say it helps with their transformation. I see Eric using his Kuret on his body, not he wasn't really transforming. Guess they are very serious about it. His mom says, is he alpha's son. She points to Rory who was in deep conversation with others.

Sommers replies, yup. She asks, whey isn't he fighting David. He laughs, short answer. He is afraid David will figure out some clues about the alpha. She blinks a little hard, is that even possible. He shrugs. But I knew that this was a bluff from David. She sighs, David's been on the many peoples mind lately. However, I don't see him winning this session. Even after you helped him this morning. I ask, you two met today. He says, he messaged me yesterday to meet at 4 in the morning. My eyes widen, for what. He says, what else. He wanted to test out his new Kuret form against me.

I ask for details. He and David met in some cliff in sector 3 and had a spared till 7. Sommers Kuret is perfect to test out David's physical Kuret. He says, he has got some serious explosive blows. He can't maintain it for long though. We were testing his defenses too, which had the same limitations. He can physically block me with his Kuret now, but he doesn't have complete mastery. Its not surprising David would be so diligent. I am glad he wasn't being confident just for appearance. He says, its interesting that he was not trying to use his limbs. Blake gave him some pointers and he was focused on controlling his Kuret.

His jaws clenches, his Kuret has changed considerably since the tournament. Once in a while, his Kuret would suddenly act up and breaks my Kuret connection. It's very disorienting. He wants to monopolies this new side effect. I recall the fight after he destroyed his house. He was able to cut off Cass's Kuret completely. And it even effected Marina a little. He continues, If can do it consciously, then it will be highly effective on Heraknus Kuret. I ask, I doubt he learnt it in few hours. He says disappointed, unfortunately he couldn't do it a lot of times. Sort of happens on luck. So he ditched that plan and focused on Kuret attacks.

I ask him, do you think he is ready. He gives me a hesitant expression, I can't say. His Kuret is physical, but its slow. If he can get a clear shot while building enough momentum, then yeah. He has a chance. It was a little unrealistic to hope David would control his new Kuret so fast. He scratches his head, actually. I think this is his backup plan. Because after I met him, he went to meet Marina. I think they are working on his copy Kuret technique. I turn around and couldn't see either of them. I get a little nervous, if he exerts himself so much before this, he will be sapped of his strength.

He nods, can't argue there. But the guy is a freaking machine. His dedication is admirable. He wasn't arrogant for no reason. He hasn't seen his training style so its obvious he be surprised. I still have unresolved issues with him, but I know he his real skills and talent. I take my leave and let him enjoy the show with his mother. Siera was enjoying a little when I take my seat beside her. She asks, they look so normal and yet so mysterious. I think she is just letting her imagination go wild. They weren't looking physically beefed up like others, but that doesn't really matter to a Medrone. We chat a little bit what little I know about them.

In the corner of my I saw Blake coming with Catherine. They notice me and approach while talking about the Heraknus. She says, Heraknus come before us. He says, yeah. You are right. I thought they would have preferred to meet people later. They wave to Siera and me. Then proceed to take the seat in front of us. I lean forward, any idea where David and Marina are. They both turn their necks to us. Catherine asks, you mean they are together. Weird, I didn't hear anything about it. Blake says, neither did I. I just assumed David was alone. I told him about Sommers and Marinas early morning meeting. Blake scoffs, he should be saving his strength.

Catherine asks, when do you leave him last night. He says, around 12. I ask skeptically, did he even sleep at all? Catherine sighs, he didn't get any endurance increase from his Ketriya. He has a plan right? She faces Blake. He says, if he has, he hadn't come up with when I was with him. We worked on improving his Kuret control. He still has bad habit to do physical movements with his Kuret. So it was a challenge to just focus on his Kuret. Siera asks, did it bore any fruit.

He says, its not an easy thing to learn. We switched up his goals to prepare for Heraknus specifically at the moment. His Kuret reserve has improved, so he can afford some wastage. We worked on augmenting his movement with Kuret. Nothing fancy, just basic striking styles he has learned over the years. I ask, he meet with Marina later. What is his game plan. He thinks for a second, I didn't talk to him about that. Catherine asks, shouldn't he be here by now. There was only 15 minutes left. It was us now, others were getting restless too.

After a while, Tina comes up to us, morning guys. Bernard is asking how much longer they have to wait. Blake says, David messaged he will be here soon. Give it another few minutes. She goes back to report it to Bernard. Siera asks, why aren't you with them. Blake replies, they are having strategy discussion with Rory and others. I would just get in the way. I look down to the warriors who were putting on a different uniform. Catherine says, that’s their Heraknus uniform. Melinda told me about them yesterday. They are lined with a Kuretine made from their Kuret. Supposedly can stretch and also stimulates their Kuret body. The cloth was a mix of green and brown. A brown lining spread across their whole uniform.

Then a sudden roar of cheers comes across from the corner. The officers and their family cheer as two figures comes from the entrance. It was them two. David came in with a hoody over his head and a capri trousers. Marina followed behind him in a causal clothes. Catherine says, look who made an appearance. David waves others as he walks down to the ground. Marina navigates her way through the crowd high flying few people. Then takes a seat beside mine. She has her usual spark of enthusiasm, we are so late. She smirks, I am never going to hear the end of it from David. She told us they both were at her place the whole morning.

She scoffs, the bastard had the gall to use my conditioner. If we weren't pressed for time, I would have smacked him good. Blake asks, what did you meet him for. She says, its about his Kuret copy technique. I told you before I had some ideas about it. We went through a couple of them. I ask, did they pan out. She squints a little with her cheeks, I say it was a failure. He couldn't control his Kuret properly. Though his original technique is much faster now. Blake asks, how fast we taking. She says, he can load up one strong shot in about 40 seconds.

Catherine chuckles, isn't that still too long. She says, hey now. Getting to this point is pretty lucky. I got him to that point after many tries. She turns to the ground, but I doubt he be able to use it though. There are three opponents. The only opportunity he has got in the beginning, when he waits for them to transform. That gives him about 7 to 10 good shots. Maybe he uses a couple of Kuret to restrain them. Rory approaches David from their side while gesturing Blake to meet. Blake says, gotta go. He leaves us to discuss the game rules.

The other Heraknus were placing a red Kuritine paint around the field in a circle, marking the boundary. This paint floats in the air and glows all the way to the top. We waited in anticipation as David and Eric finish up their talk. Blake heads back up to us after few minutes. Catherine asks, I heard something about the changing rules. He nods, yeah. You see that line, Heraknus added few win conditions involving it. He tells us the line will be slowly moving inside and gradually limiting the area inside. While this won't happen in the actual match, they argue that David can just keep avoiding them. They do this maneuver for Charles too. Restrain him in a place.

Marina says, then is there a time limit until the circle closes them completely. What is it. 5 minutes ? He says, it was. But David wanted more time. Said he couldn't fight properly in short time. So they agreed for 10 minutes. I ask, he must want more time for his Kuret sphere. Marina says, that’s the right call. I heard from Melinda that those guys have excellent team work. Catherine says, Charles trained those three personally. Makes them the right candidates to test David. So that’s how Eric choose his teammates.

Siera says, but isn't that counter productive for David. Heraknus most dangerous ability is their Kuret endurance. Blake says, I told him the same. He said it was worth the trade, more time makes it easier for him to find their weakness. I can't say if it’s the right call, but if he think it was necessary he had to have a reason. Blake continues, they also added a rule that anyone who touches the line will cause a loss for David. I am confused, how does that makes sense. He says, Rory said it was to prevent David from taking advantage of the barrier in the real match. Since Charles wouldn’t be in control, he will likely use it as part of some plan.

Marina sighs, there is already a precedent. He used it in the match with Charles. Catherine says, but that’s so unfair. I say, why did David agree to it. Blake says, he already asked to increase the time, felt fair to him. He can't keep relying on same tactic. As long as Heraknus don't cross the line themselves, he will have to confront them eventually. Marina says, they want to force him to close combat. He says, that’s right. He ran around a lot against Charles. And while that is a valid strategy, they can't have him running around the place all the time. This is a fight for them to judge his skills.

The Heraknus logic made sense, but its weird they want to impose more stricter rules. Siera asks, what happens if the match ends in a draw. That’s something I haven't thought of until now. I am curious about that possibility. Blake says, I actually didn't ask. He smiles, perhaps they don't believe it will end it like that. Catherine says, or maybe they will do this again. That seems more plausible. Marina, if that really happened, wouldn't the Heraknus be satisfied with his ability to survive Charles overdrive. She made a point. I just hope no one calls for a redo in case anything goes wrong.

The Heraknus finish preparing the red line and clear away the ground. There are many cameras setup around the ground. They also put a big display beside the stadium wall that had something on it. My guess would a timer. Soon the only people left on the ground were the participants. David finally takes off his hoody. A round of cheers wave as he reveals his bare skin. I can't believe it, he is going shirtless for this. He had been insecure about the red scar he has from the poison that nearly killed him in the Valley. Not anymore, because he has tattooed all over the skin with a abstract design I didn't understand.

Catherine mocks at him, look at that relaxed smile. He is enjoying this. David waves to the crowd as he throws his hoodie on the side bench. I ask, when did he get that tattoo. I think he even shaved clean his chest. He picks up a thin white boxing bandages from a bag and wraps them on his palms. He deliberately makes a show of it by slow movements, gaining more excitement from people. I couldn't help but be a little jealous when few girls beside me get animated from the view.

I was annoyed so I ask, is he not going to wear anything to protect himself. Isn't that dangerous. Blake says, no need to worry about that. He can always dawn his Kuret armor. Having any cloth doesn't make much difference. Marina says, but it does make him look cool. I had to agree with her. He had lean muscle to look hot. I shake my thoughts, what am I thinking about. I get embarrassed by my own thoughts. On the other hand, he is leisurely walking through a small opening of the red barrier.

The three Heraknus follow him from behind. While they fill the gap with the Kuretine, David already starts to prepare for the battle. He brings out his Kuret and begins wrapping it around him. He did it while keepings his hands in his pockets. He seems so cavalier about the precarious situation he was in. Siera asks, that’s confidence I haven't seen from him before. Catherine says, no one has. His Kuret runs on his body like electricity. It wasn't the wild Kuret anymore. Instead they were dense and forming rings of spirals over his body.

The three Heraknus take position at the other end. Soon the stadium goes silent when the barrier is completed. Blake hesitation spills in his words, I sure hope he has more than just swagger and intimidation. He is up against three Heraknus for freak sake. Marina smiles hard, this is going to be fun. There is an chime alarm with a countdown starting. Everyone in the stadium get serious. The Heraknus also takes their stances to bring their Kuret. As the alert alarms begins to go slower, while the tension increases.

The Heraknus pull out their brown Kuret and begin to transform. Unlike Charles, they are more adept to transform. On the left, George begins to gain height while still being slender. The his skins starts to grow scales, few of them shimmering with Kuritine. His mass begins to get bulky and thicker every second. A single scaley tail begins to grow from behind that wags on the ground. His body takes a very different shape from Charles. I see his arms were bigger and large too. So was his elongated torso. He takes a stance on all fours. There is a single long horn like Kuritine coming from his head. Hold on, he looks like an animal from earth.

I can't believe what I am seeing, it’s like a rhino. He had such strikingly familiar appearance. Soon more Kuretines growing on his face and covers his head like an antler and appear as a crown. His budging neck had no much muscles, he looks like a bull from the torse. He looks so much heavier than Charles muscular form. But I don't doubt the power behind that heavy Kuret muscles. I dart my eyes to the right. Lena's Kuret was flowing more horizontally. Her arms grew in length. It didn't stop even they become twice as big before. Her arms turns into hoards of Kuretines.

Her face turned sharper and Kuritine grow from her thick chest. She even had a long Kuritine beak. Her legs too become longer. Her feet were shining with Kuritine. Are those freaking talons. Wait. That form intuitively feels like bird. My suspicion becomes true when two tails grew from her back that were swaying in air. Those tail ends had flat Kuritine like they were some like of gliding supporters. Her back also is covered with Kuritine feathers. The next instant she flaps her Kuritine wings and hits the sky. A pair of hundred gawking eyes look up she Lena became a flying Kuritine covered bird.

Then came the last Heraknus. He was also growing in size that is comparable to the other two. Unlike Geroge, his form remains standing on the ground on his legs. He is covered with an overwhelming less amount of furs or Kuritines. But then I saw his arms and legs. They were completely made of Kuretines. I thought they were just a Kuritine armor, but his joins protrudes out small sharp Kuritine ends. He had four saber tooth Kuritine coming out from his jaws. The Kuritine on his wrist comes like claws, they aren't big, but its too thick see where his palm and fingers join. His chest has a little bit fur, and there are few Kuretine stones growing there. Unlike others, he got no tail. His form looks that of bear and a chetah. He doesn't seem to have too much mass, so perhaps he was more agile.

Their complete forms left everyone speechless for a second, and then the people stood up shouting and howling marveling at the trio of humongous beasts. Lena flew low and hovers few feet above the other two. This makes them menacing and intimidating. Anyone would feel pressure from them. David was no exception. He had removed his hands from the pocket and postering with more seriousness now. His smile was replaced by a more stern expression. He had changed his Kuret to form a sphere with his hands. He should have had ample time to create multiple Kurets by now.

Soon the final alarm begins to countdown. Marina yells over the shouting people, oh boy. This is going to be a long and intense battle. Blake cries out, I sure hope David has plan that works. Because one of them is flying right above them. Catherine yells, how is planning to take down Lena. Can he fly yet. Blake and Marina shook their heads. We weren't expecting a flying Heraknus. The two on ground hold their positions, but their postures indicate they will be ready any second to pounce.

David Kuret sphere does something unexpected now. It begins to pulsate, appearing as though it was a propulsion engine. His Kuret vibrates vigorously, blowing off air around him. The vortex abruptly begins to wrap into his right arm. What is he planning to do with that. I couldn't figure out why he abandoned his Kuret sphere. I didn't have any thoughts to spare, because the siren goes off. The face off begins. Everyone expected David to stay in his position and analyze his opponents. Maybe let the trio make the first move. But that all shattered when he launched into a sprint.

He dashes in fast with Kuret straight into the trio. George and Eric run at him with gusty. George was slower, so Eric was first one to reach David. Eric slashes at David with his Kuret arm. David crouches down and slips past him. His aim was Geroge behind Eric. Lena took a swan dive at David, trying to block him. David won't be able to dodge her. He instead chose to jump high, kicks off the air like he is climbing invisible steps. With his Kuret vortex that was spinning on his arm, he throws a Kuret blast at her. She couldn't avoid it from this distance and brings her wings to defend. The force was so much that she was thrown up into the air unable to counteract.

He summersaults in the air, lands back on the ground and kicks off towards George again. Why is David diving into their group right from the beginning. David kicks off another dash towards George. George was charging in close and raised his torso in the air to pound on David with his heavy palms. With the Kuret on his arm, he blocks Georges arm and pushes it out of the way. David crouches down as he brings his arm to his waist creating a stance for a punch. All the while when his Kuret gathers over his arms even more. Before George could regain his balance, David throws down a right hook straight at Georges shoulder.

On contact, David's black Kuret tore though George from inside out. Blake Kuret dug into the Kuret body and George howls in pain. David's didn't stop his assault and instead propelled him sideways. George flings to the side, falling hard on the ground as David continued to put pressure on Georges shoulder. The impact caused the ground to split apart in contact and creates a tremble. Blake Kuret erupts from Georges body. After a second, David suddenly leapt into the sky. I thought he was going for another attack from the air. But he was thrusted into the air before Eric could grab him from behind.

He decided to head towards an incoming large bird. Lena flaps her wings and her Kuritine feathers turn into dozens of projectiles. David wraps his Kuret around himself to defend for few of them. The rest he dodges as he zig zags in the air, like scaling up between the gap of a building. What's up with David's aggressive head on assault. No one was expecting this, neither was Lena. She tried to bite him when he got closer. David pulls back and thrusts forward again. Lena tried to claw him with her talons. David blocks them with his Kuret arms. She tried to slash him with a wing. But at the last minute David kicks off into high gear and lunches himself above her.

Having gained a momentarily higher position, David pours in another ridiculous amount of swirling Kuret on his one leg. He twists down and lands his foot straight at Lena's neck. She makes a loud screeching noise when David Kuret dug into her and come out from her chest like a spike. With another thrust into the air upwards, David pushes Lena to a straight downward path. Lena was struggling to get out from David's kick. She tried to throw her Kuretines from her wings. But at the speed she was going, she was missing most of them. The rest, David disintegrated with a Kuret armor. They both crash into the ground.

Before the last moment, David leapt into the air again and stumbles down rolling at the side. Lean was writhing in pain, and couldn't get back up. Actually it wasn't just her. George was also immobilized, lying on the ground where he was knocked down. A chill ran though my spine. I stood up from my chair when others did the same. Everyone were so silent with jaws dropping everywhere. David Kuret wraps behind his back and uses it as a boast to run. Eric was genuinely surprised by his teammates sudden falling beside him. He was glued to the ground as David charges at him. I can't be sure, but was that fear from Eric.

David instantly closes the gap between them. He halts when he is at striking distance. He takes a fighting stance by extends one arm ahead while keeping the other close his chest. He looks like a martial artist preparing to throw down a single strike. Eric shakes off the confusion and goes in for an attack with his Kuritine arms. David calmly dodges those slashes while maintaining his distance. Eric suddenly jumps into the air and goes for a roundhouse kick. David blocks it with a Kuret armer around his arm while being pushed back. But the next instant David bends down and goes for a low kick while extending his leg. The vortex Kuret hits under the Eric armpit.

I didn't see enough force, but Eric made a painful scream. David black Kuret borrows deep into his thin body and pours out from everywhere. The Kuretines on his arms and legs starts to crackle. David rolls away from the kick and takes a few steps back. Eric stumbles down on one knee that was cracked. He was already healing it. But David wasn't going to let him. He approaches slowly towards Eric. Eric tried to slash him with his arms, but they had been so damaged, that David didn't even tried to defend himself. They broke when it came in contact with the Kuret armor on his neck.

David then places his palm on the same spot that he attacked earlier. Eric was healing the spot, but he was immobilized for the time being. With a yell from David, a wave of Kuret pulses through the spot causing more agonizing pain to Eric. The Kuritines on his body shatters. He wasn't able to maintain his form anymore. He just had one working leg, with which he somehow still managed to stop from falling down. His Kuret body was shattered and torn in so many places.

David slowly moves around to the front of Eric. He takes a stance for a palm thrust. Another vortex of pulsating Kuret form over the arm. Eric is helpless and watches in despair as dark Kuret begins to block his view. Then when the time was right, David yells out a war cry and thrust his Kuret palm into Erics chest. The attack was devasting that it ruptures Erics Kuret body from inside out. Like clothes being torn, he is flung backwards as his Kuret body stays behind. He is knocked on his ass and writhes in pain. The Kuret body left behind lumps down like a bag of dirty used Kuret clothes and begins to dissolve in air.

This can't be happening. I turn to look at the other two Heraknus. Surely they will bounce back. But they both are down. Not just that, their Kuret body is evaporating. They both are now lying in the ground unconscious as themselves. The only one left now was Eric, who was clutching his side chest and lying on the ground in total confusion. David is heaving hard and falls down on both his knees. He takes the support of one arm as his Kuret returns to him. Eric was struggling to get up. And after a while he got back up ever so slightly. He was bleeding from his chest where David had hit him.

David wasn't getting up, he slumps down on his back and lies on the ground. What the freak is going on. Just then the alarm goes off. The red barrier that was closing in begins to flicker near Lena. Her arm had touched the line. The buzzer rings on the display screen, which changes to an insignia. Its the same on the Heraknus clothes. Its their house marker. According to the rule they set, if anyone touches the line, Heraknus win. How in the bloody hell is this a win for them. Two unconscious, while one is barely handing on.

David begins laughing from the ground, damn. I lost. He yells aloud with an amusing tone. He leans up taking support of his one arm, lets do it again. I didn't think it would end so soon and with my loss. Eric slumps down on the ground with a dazed look on him. The red barrier goes away, but everyone here were frozen solid. Then Marina shouts, Freak yeah. She was yelling in sudden excitement with her palm over her mouth echoing her voice. Then came nervous claps, with slowly turns into a thunderous applause. Soon people began cheering like mad men. I couldn't hold it together and yell out raising an arm excited from this insane twist.

Blake yells, the freak was that. He crosses the crowd and ran down to the ground. Marina followed him behind. Actually everyone started to run. The officers down hold off the people. The frenzy was filling the whole stadium. Beside me Seira had a stone cold expression. She was in complete shock. I decided to let her process it while I go with others. It took a while, but the officers held of the families that were cheering from the walls. I scrummage though the crowd and navigated to the gate. I turn to the people, everyone. Go back to your seats. Please corporate with us. Thank you. That made few people back away.

Soon the rest of the officers managed to push the people back. I yell to Ruther, get more people from outside. Coordinate with them before this becomes a mess. He nods rushing off to the exit gate. I turn to Deni and Sommers to manage the crowd for now. I cross the gate, passing by a group of horrified Heraknus. The most confused one was Rory. He was siting on the bench with heavy eyes and palms to his chin. Marina and Blake helped David get up. He was sweaty and panting hard. He also limped a little, freak. I think I twisted my ankle. He squints his eyes when he put weight on his leg.

Marina yells, you are worried about that. What did you just do. Suddenly he yelps in another pain. He slumps straight on me. I hastily grab him by the shoulder. The excitement left me with a growing concern. He grumbles, holy shit. My shoulder. Its burning. I support him while he gains a little of his bearing. My eyes turn to his left shoulder. His arm seems odd at the joint. I blurt out, he's got a dislocated shoulder. Blake let goes of that arm, shit. Sorry. He yelps in more pain as Blake places his arm back down slowly. He hugs me more tightly from his other arm. If it weren't an emergency, I would be flushed from his sweaty skin in contact.

Marina says, I got this. She circles around me and prepares a charm over David socket. With one eye open he groans, careful. She nods, this is not my first time. She prepares a charms with which she analyses his bones and tendons. He says, wait. Towel. My bag. Blake runs back to the other bench and rummages inside. Davide under a painful grunts says, sorry. This is, ah, awkward. Ned is going to kill me. I yell, forget about that right. I can't believe he is worried about him at a time like this. Blake comes back a small white towel. David chomps down on it and then nods to Marina.

She then places her palm on his shoulder, this is going to hurt a lot. With a clean and precise movement, she throws a charms that displaced the arm back inside the socket. A small popping sound comes from the socket, following a David's muffled cry that tingles in my neck. A moment later Blake helps him get off me. The towel slips down revealing a heaving David. He still have a twisted ankle. So we help him get to the bench. He leans back to the wall still full of pain. He grips his arm that was hurting him. He has few scratch on his arm and a few bruises on his back.

He winces, that hurt Dammit. He then starts chuckles, what a poor finish. That’s so uncool. And in front of the whole world. I had the urge to slap him. If only he wasn't in so much in pain already.

Blake (Chapter 107)

Tuesday, March 3, 2026 18:48

I help him wear his hoodie back on. He shrieks when he moved his arm. We decided to leave that arm open. Once he was able to relax, he grabs another towel and starts scabbing himself from the sweat. Marina removes her charm she was waving on David's body, miraculously you haven't broken any bones. You have a sprain in your right wrist also, any minute you are going to feel that. His panting becomes slower and points to the bag beside him. I slide it towards him. He picks up a small case and gives to me, green pill. There are plenty of different colored pills. I pull out the one he needed and he swallows it.

He points to another item in the bag, blue strap. This one looks like a type of bandage. There are several of them in a bunch. He picks one to wrap it on his twisted ankle, one around his wrist and one over his shoulder. The strap begins to tighten on his skin. He bites his lips in pain for a second. The blue strap gradually turns into shades of brown and white, finally turning invisible. I ask, is this the same tech as your bots. He pulls up his sleeve nodding. Then his pale color turns back to normal. He sighs, the pain killer is kicking in. That was intense.

I had so many questions in my mind. But its not the right time to ask. Not when there are so many people behind the wall, confused, shocked and hyped. Marina says, is it okay to show this in public. He replies, someone made a bargain for taking my Hive bots tech few days ago. It was also used as an incentive to bring the scientists to us. There is no point in hiding it anymore. Vanessa just rolls her eyes at him. She blurts out, forget about that. Tell me how did you do this. He groans while standing up, not here. I ask, where are you going. You need to rest. He smiles, I am fine now. I want to check on them. Lets see if anyone else want to test me again.

Marina scoffs, tell me he is joking. I think he is just trying rub it in. We follow him from behind. The Heraknus warriors had grabbed the unconscious George and Lena and taken inside. The remaining hurdled around a wounded Eric. A guy sees us approaching and pats on Rory's back. He turns towards us with an annoyed look. Actually everyone one had a grim face. I bet no one thought this fight be over in just 53 seconds. Rory says, guys. Can you give us a minute. David says, I just need a moment with Eric. He asks, for what. David says, I think I went too far with him. I wasn't planning so much force.

He thinks for a second while eyeing others. Soon they part aside and we see Eric seating on the bench, clutching his side. David walks to him, Eric. Are you okay. He wasn't hurt anywhere expect his side where it was bandaged with a Kuretine strap. Eric turns his neck up with disappointed eyes. He lost that vigor he showed us few minutes ago. He didn't say anything while glaring at David. David nods, I just want to make sure that injury isn't severe. A girl says, he will be fine. The wound isn't deep, but its going to take some time to heal. David raises his unharmed arm, let me take a look at it. As an apology.

He begins to wrap his palm with a Kuret sphere. Everyone took a step back and David spins his Kuret into another vortex, the kind he was doing earlier as a feint. So he plans to use Jonathans healing Kuret. Its strange he is okay with doing it in the open, after all the effort to keep it a secret. I whisper to him, I thought you weren't planning to use it. He smirks, not in the match. This much is enough for now. He plans to use just one shot of that Kuret. A minute later his Kuret storm forms on one palm. It vibrates to shower the white Kuret over Eric. Eric shifts around his seat feeling uneasy about this. Yet he remained seated as the Kuret shines over his body.

David managed for about 30 seconds of that Kuret, but it was on par with an alpha level. The wound on the chest begins closes immediately and Eric looks significantly better now. Only the drops of blood trickled from the side remained from the healed spot. Eric stand up to check out his wound by moving his arm. A try's a few swings with slight ache, but he appears to have recuperated enough. He says, thanks. Feels much better. David disperses his Kuret sphere, you should still check it out. I am not proficient in compatibility healing unlike theirs's bloodline. Eric nods with a small guilt. He along with other warriors head back inside.

Only Rory, Bernard and Reina remained with us. David turns to Bernard, sorry about your son. But I have to ask. How did I do. He remains silent and couldn't form any response. Riena says, you don't need to ask David. You made your point very clear. She wasn't upset, but wasn't happy either. She sighs, I have never seen anything like this. How did you do that. He says, I found your Achillies heal. She asks, our what? Rory says, it’s a metaphor. There is a Greek mythology among humans about a immortal who was invulnerable to everything, except for one weak spot on his body. His heels. David smiles, someone's been paying attention to this planets history.

Rory answers not amused, you couldn't have found it already. Did someone told you. He says, maybe I figured it out on my own. I did fight your alpha up close and intimately. His cryptic answer left Rory in an even worse mood. I step in before David humiliates them further. I ask, Riena, you said you wanted to judge him. And even though we only got a minute of this, do you think it was enough. Or you have something else in your mind. She faces me, I am not going to pretend I understand how our three strong people lost. Nor can I deny the outcome. She turns to Bernard, are we still planning to tour the next part of the city. He takes a second to answer, yes.

She says, then let me discuss with others and get back to you later. Will that be okay. I reply, that works for us. The three of them left our side and David waves them away enjoying their retreat. Marina pokes David's stomach, stop antagonizing them. He coughs a little, they started it when he they gave me a death beneficiary contract to sign. He wasn't wrong though, they played a dirty trick trying to break that deal. Vanessa says, ah, the crowd is getting out of control. What should we do now, Blake. I gave it some thought, I was expecting this to go for few hours. Even if its over already, I don't want to take away the off hours from officers.

I signal to Tina from the crowd. She approaches with wide eyes on David, are you okay. He says, nothing I can't handle. I tell her, message all the officers to get resume their jobs second half of the day. She asks, so we still are off work until then. I nod, we gave the whole morning off for this. I doubt anyone would resume to work now. She says, I am on it. She nervously glances to David. He chuckles, impressed. I know I was. She could tried to hide a bashful smile. Vanassa says with a high tone, you should check on the Heraknus instead. She waves and goes back to the side hallway leading to Heraknus room.

I turn to Vanessa, tell the people that the show is over. Heraknus didn't say anything, but I doubt they want a rematch after that debacle. She leaves to join Ruther and Deni. David says, if there is nothing else, I like to take a nap. Marina says, you what. Right now. He says, I didn't get a wink of sleep last night. Spent about 20 hours in planning and practicing my Kuret. I feel like dead weight. We were right, he spent all the time since yesterday to prepare for this. Marina says, I'll take him back to his place. David says, thanks. I will see you in the evening. I ask, Marina, make sure he sleeps in before you leave him. She gives me a grin knowing my intention. I don't need him to rub his win over Heraknus more than he already did.

He yells as he is being dragged away by Marina, don't forget the vote on signing that contract. I say, I didn't forget about that. Meet us at officers building around 6. You can present your case. He asks, my case. I reply, I am not only one who wants to know what the hell your strategy was. Marina drags him away to the exit. I climb up the stairs and help Vanessa a little bit with the crowd control. May were asking for David and so I explained he is treating his wounds. Some even saw the ART tech he used on himself. I redirected those questions for Catherine to handle. I felt a little bad, but she is very good at mediating stuff like this. In an hour we wrapped up the training center.

I looked around the aura's of people as they begin pulling up their cars back into the city. Some still haven't shaken off their excitement. Many planned to follow David back to him home. Thankfully, I got a message from Marina saying she is taking him her place instead. He needs some space to rest up. Jess escorted the Heraknus back to their guest house. Vanessa and Tessa approach behind me. Vanessa says, they are going back to lick their wounds. I answer, they are. Must be a hell of a shock it's already over. Tessa says, he obliterated them in less than a minute. Their pride as Heraknus warriors was stripped in front of the entire world.

I just recently learned that even though we tried to not leak this to the public, someone was filming the entire fight. It includes everything, from him beating them down, to him helping Eric. It was posted on the network few minutes back. We tried to take it down, but its already gone to several servers. Vanessa says, its gone viral. No point in trying to stop it now. Its going to only stroke his ego now. That was definitely going to happen. He will be gaining even more attention than ever. Tessa asks, but he deserves that. Don't you think so. Neither of us deny this too. He said he found their weakness. I didn't hear anything about it last night.

But even then, he took out alpha level warriors in seconds. His Kuret has drastically changed his game. We had few hours off, but only in name. Even when I went back to officers building, people were giving us surprised looks. Many reporters tried to ask questions. We only gave them what they already knew. Few officers head towards the guest house in their free time. Hoping to catch the glimpse of the Heraknus. Luther, Tina and me stayed back in our offices to discuss the next plan of action. As time went, people started to resume their usual work.

Luther then presented me a daring suggestion. It was something he messaged David yesterday. And David's reply was to wait until the outcome of today's match. He says, guess this means we can do this. Right. I gave it a lot of thought before deciding it. I nod, yeah. Lets do it. I don't like to leverage this when they are already down. But we can't have them planning anything else to try and stop this. Tina says, at least this will make things equal for both of them. She had a point. Until now, we couldn’t present this to Heraknus. But now they can't reject it outright.

We met with Catherine and Jess at lunch. They didn't have anything new to report. Just that Riena and Bernard wanted some time privately to discuss their decision. Jess says, I heard the both of them woke up and have no serious injuries. They are very confused about the whole thing. Catherine says, and embarrassed. I heard Rory is mad upset by their performance. He may have believed that David cheated with the whole copy Kuret stuff. But even without it, they lost. Bernard practically kicked us out, while still being polite. I says, I am sure they don't know what to believe.

I do wonder why David showed his copy Kuret when he healed Eric. Was that just because he was feeling guilty from injuring him. Knowing him, there should be another reason. The video went viral and in few hours we learnt it even spread to other communities. At this point I suspect David himself of this. Did he plan to cause further divide between them and Citradel. Could be. I am sure soon it will reach to Citradel ears once Heraknus report back this to Charles. Many of us are wondering how Charles would react to this. Whatever his feelings were, it will not be pleasant at least.

Fortunately, todays part of the tour and surveying of the city went without any hitch. Catherine said neither the three warriors, or Rory came though. The rest of the Heraknus came as scheduled. Meanwhile I finally met the science team from Citradel today. They came yesterday evening and I allowed them to rest up from the long journey. Nathan introduced the key people from the 15. They were very delighted to be here after crossing many hurdles. Though their aura's should some resentment too. I assured them this wasn't how we planned to invite them. The circumstances change quickly due to many problems. Mostly from Citradel.

They understood for the most part it was Ryes fault. But they were surprised to see the encryption tech from Citradel here. That only gave credence in believing Ryes was behind the criminal smuggling operations too. I didn't want them distracted by the political agendas of others. So I mandated that their only concern was development of our city. They were sent to do a job, and that’s exactly what we want them to do. Marina explained all the preliminary work she did. Tina presented them will the materials we procured up till today. The lead scientist, Ivan, was grateful for our work.

He says, splendid. He hands over the inventory of the martials we have on standby to his team. They went through it with a fine combed teeth. One lady asks, we have enough platinum to perform Kuritine enrichment twice the size of this island size. Another guy asks, so the rumors are true. You stole them for Citradel. I chuckle, not me personally. But yes. And whatever you don’t need, we are hoping it can be used by our R & D team. Ivan asks, that’s our plan. We are fascinated by the technology, what do you call it. Nathan answers, ART. Autonomous Reconfigurable Technology.

Ivan says, we have tried our best to reverse engineer their tech. But not to this degree. Frank says, its by human research team. The lady asks, can we meet them or at least get their research. It will greatly advance our progress in using Kuritines as an alternative technology. Nathan says, like I said many times. That’s a hard no. You know the guy who is now on everyone lips, David. He has the humans tucked away secretly and no one knows who they are. Unfortunately, you all have to study the designs yourself and figure stuff out.

They were disappointed, but not discouraged. They understood this tech is very experimental and very controversial. Setting aside the weaponry advancement, there is a question of people's opinion. These tech killed their family and destroyed their planet. Even if they are just tools, they are subject to a lot of ire and hatred. Around 4:30, our long meeting came to an end. I took a break for next hour at the lounge. Between helping David and managing the day to day tasks, its been taking a toll on me. I have to work on a better balance of life for the next two weeks.

I head Catherine walking into the room, you look so exhausted. I know you are busy, but you should take care more. I leaned forward from the couch putting the coffee on the table, nothing I can't handle. Its what I signed up

for. She grabs another coffee mug from the counter and takes my couch and sits beside me. She says, how did the meeting with the Citradels science team go? I corrected her, they are now our team. She laughs, leave it to Nathan to sweat talk them. I told her the highlights of that. I say, it's interesting only if you are into the science. She says, I know, right. I try to flaunt a little, but my interest ends with what I use for surveillance and extracting information.

We had a good laugh from that quip. We chatted more about our daily struggles with brainiacs like David and Marina. I laugh at her joke about David finally becoming an attention hog. He is behaving like the old days again, serious but amusing too. But now he is blatantly about certain things. She says the fame is getting to his head. I couldn't deny it. He never had this much fan base. But I wonder what would happen if people knew he was a Shadow too. She says, I think many will be angry at him. You know, since he kind of abandoned us. I understand he was going through traumatic. But. I add, people won't care about it. Whatever the reason, he left us.

The would be natural from people's perspective. She says, well, even if it never comes out. This phase will die out eventually. Once Citradel joins us, things will rapidly change. I agreed with her. We still had some time left, so I brought up a question, did you decide what to ask David for your help. She smiles, its something personal you know. I get confused, what's so personal you can't tell me.. She laughs at my nervousness, just messing around. I haven't thought what I want from him. I offer, maybe get some answers about your family. She gets lost in her thoughts for a bit, perhaps. But then again I rather not know about them.

She jerks up realizing something, wait. He is a Shadow, then it means you know the same things as he. Don't you. She made the connection and I had to reluctantly nod, I do. And if you want, I can tell you myself. You can keep a different favor from him. She says, that's kind of you. But I don't know if I want to know. Do you know what happened between dad and me. I shake my head, that I don't know. I am not going to ask it if you don't want to. She takes a sip of the coffee while contemplating. She says, I want to tell you. But promise me you won't judge my family.

I assured her I won't. She then opens up to me about her dad's decision to send John instead of her. After listening to this I get a little angry. I promised her that I will keep an open mind. But I let my opinion, you have always said you loved your dad. I don't know about you, but it feels like he betrayed you. She gets upset, please don't. I say, I am sorry. I know it was a tough call. But choosing him over you for a simplistic reason like that. And such a sexist justification. That's bad. She sighs, ah, I shouldn't have said it. I didn't held back, no. I am glad I know. You should know you proved him wrong. You have become someone they should be proud of, not be ashamed.

She says, but its true. I don't remember my brother much, but he was much more capable than me. I am so conflicted. I can't tell her the truth about her brother. That would destroy her. Her self esteem already took a hit from her dad. She says, there's no point in discussing about that now. I had some time to think about it. I am sure it wasn't a decision made with malice or negligence. It was an desperate decision, He was just doing what he felt was best at the time. I learned I can't judge him harshly now.

She had a lot of time to sort her feelings about it. I am still a little enraged, but I guess if she is okay with it, I shouldn't cause her any more problem. She says, actually, if I think about it. I am glad I didn't know this before. I wouldn't be mature enough to understand that decision. I say, nah. You were plenty grown up already. He tease her to her body. That brings a smile to her face, was that a pick up line. Its good, but not good enough. I say, maybe I should be asking tips from David. She immediately shakes her face, never. He is like a horny teenage suddenly. Does Ketriya have a side effect like that. I joke, I think that's just him.

I was happy with this. Us talking together and just playing off each other, having fun. This years been a roller coaster ride and finding moments like this helps me have some balance. I spend an hour with her. It was more than I hoped to get given our busy work. It came to an end few minutes before the meeting. We set our mugs aside and climb the stairs to my office where I asked people to join me. When I opened my door, I hear someone snoring on my couch. It was David. He changed into a shirt and jeans and his dark shades over his eyes. He wasn't alone, there were already people inside.

Marina was talking funny pics of David. She is being childish by plugging a pencil in his nostrils. I had to stifle a laugh from this unexpected comedic scene. She put her fingers to her lips when she see's me and Catherine walking in. Behind her, half the IDF team were already here, only missing was June. Even Vanessa couldn't stop being amused by this. David snorts a little when Marina plug one of his nose with a pencil. I sure hope no one walks in and sees how unprofessional we were.

But David has bad luck. The rest of the high ranking officers walk and see the spectacle. Luther whispers to me with a giggle, how long has this been going on. I shrug. Before Marina would put another pencil in his nose an alert rang from his watch. David stirs up and flounders a little as the pencils slips past his face. He asks disoriented, what the hell. Why are all looking at me. He immediately pats his face when Marina burst out laughing. We couldn't help it ourselves. He straightens up realizing he was being punked. He looks down and picks up the pencils. Amongst our laughter he smiles, Marina. You know I am going to get good for this.

She opens up her phone, don't care. I got good blackmail material. She shows everyone of his snoring and pranking video. He straightens out his shirt, being both annoyed and still enjoying. He gets out of the couch, rubbing his eyes. He looks around, nice to see you all had a good laugh from it. He lightly moves his arm to check the spot he got injured in the morning. Once the teasing dimmed down, I ask, how's your arm. He says, sore. I couldn't get into the nano bot tank, so it's a slow process.

Everyone settles down and take the chairs. I say, all of us are here. So start talking. He sighs, sheesh. Give a minute. Nathan says, you had hours. I like to know how you decimated those Heraknus. You cost me a bet. Typical Nathan. Tessa asks, you bet on him loosing. Nathan scoffs, no. I bet he would win after struggle. But Jess said he win under 5 minutes. That's some high praise from Jess. David says, wonder why you thought I was capable of such feat. She gives a sly grin not giving us any explanation on why she was sure. Sommers says, when we meet early in the morning, you didn't once showed those Kuret attacks. When did you learn them.

He says, I will tell you. But before that, Blake, what did Heraknus decide. I answer, they said they will tell us soon. But they requested for more time. Luther says, I had a talk with Bernard an hour ago, they are waiting for Charles's order. Vanessa asks, isn't Rory here for exactly this reason. She is right, but if it were for normal decisions. I explain, turns out taking out three of their finest in such a bizarre manner has left them discombobulated. So they had to ask Charles for his advice.

Ruther says, they got their ass handed to them in front of everyone. I bet that is going to sting for a long time. June asks, is there really now way to stop the video from leaking out of the city. Nathan says, its hopeless. We might be able to track where all it was uploaded, but erasing or stripping is not possible. Luther asks, did you guys find out who uploaded that video at least. Deni says, it was a kid brother of one of our officers. We caught him later, but I don't know how to proceed with him.

Vanessa says, his is only 11. Apparently he wanted to show off to his friends. I don't think I can charge him for anything. But that officer I am going give him a suspension. Nathan ask, just a slap on the wrist. Come on, that stunt might have worsened our relationship with the Heraknus. Few people agreed with his sentiment. David says to me, and to think you were going to blame me for this. How in the hell did he know that. It had to be a guess since I never told I suspected that. But I wasn't going to give him that smug satisfaction.

I turn to Vanessa, if that was a genuine mistake. Fine, give me a 1 week suspension. But still investigate it was only negligence. I don't want to find out later that someone else put them to do this. Vanessa agrees, we will question them tomorrow. Lets hope it was a innocent mistake and nothing else. Nathan says, there you have it. Come on. Spit it out David. He didn't have anything else to ask us, if their decision is delayed, I can't help it. Just goes to show how awesome I was. Blatant narcissism aside, he seems to enjoy the duress he has put the Heraknus under. Some of us snicker at his snarky attitude.

He walks to my desk and leans against it. Like a teacher explaining to a class of students, he removes his shades and keeps it aside. He explains, truth be told I wasn't expecting to take them down so suddenly. I was aiming for an immediate victory, but I didn't expect it them to go down so fast. It might be self serving for me to say, but I think their legendary bloodline myth is greatly exaggerated. I couldn't refute him on that. Frank says, are you saying that just because you beat them easily. David says, no. I mean many of you could have beaten them too.

Nathan says, maybe Blake or Marina. But they weren't that weak. Marina says, I was analyzing them with a charm. They didn't have a strong Kuret like Charles, but they had the numbers. He says, sometimes having numbers doesn't mean they are collectively strong. Though, that's not what I mean. There are three things I did. First, I needed to get a modicum of practice of my new Kuret form. That I got from Blake and Sommers. You ask me when did I learn that attack, Sommers. I already was testing that with you. It was just not in that bigger scale. Sommers says, you did. Huh. Didn't clock that.

He says, I was really struggling back then. No, actually I still am. He grabs his arm, I overexerted my Kuret control. Those attacks may look cool, but it's a waste if keep getting blow backs like this. It was a desperate move on my side. If they had managed to survive those attacks, like Eric, things would have turned out differently. I did have an inkling that his wounds could have been worse if the match went longer. He says, I am glad it paid off. Still, I have a long road ahead me. Vanessa asks, so you what, let your semi controlled Kuret skewer the Heraknus from inside.

David says, not quite. The next thing I did was figure out a weakness. Charles may have led us to believe he doesn't have one, but what about others in his bloodline. We may call them alpha level, but technically they aren't one. So I spent yesterday afternoon going over the match with Charles. Did you notice how Charles changed tactics whenever he gets injure. Even if they were simple strategies, he changed his style at every turn. The memories aren't fresh, I haven paid attention to every little detail of their match.

He says, long story short. I thought hitting him where majority of his Kuret was stored on his body was key to deplete his Kuret reserve. That was a mistake. Because they have ton of endurance no matter how much I shaved. The only thing that did work was when I hurt Charles from the inside. Nathan says, that's obvious. We already knew that. He says, what was not obvious was where to attack. I noticed something in our match, while he was constantly changing his style of attack, he was also hiding his weak spots.

Marina says, weak spots? Is that where they have less Kuret. He answers, not exactly. Heraknus are crafty here. I don't know if they are doing it consciously, or it's a problem they have on Earth. These places on their body aren't defined by how much Kuret they have. Its where their Kuret flows from. I think I get what he is saying, some time ago, you mentioned that their Kuret flows around them. Are you saying it comes out from there. He says, you got it. Yeah, its easy to miss the how and where under all that Kuret meat. I couldn't see it back then too. But if you rewatch the match, you would see Charles blocking my attacks few times when he didn't need to. I initially interpreted as just a quirk of habit. But my AI, M, figured out a pattern from the recurrence.

Nathan says, fascinating. A sort of a spring well for their Kuret. Where was it on Charles. David says, that's the craftiness of Heraknus. The location keeps changing over time. Marina says, seriously. So that's a moving target. Chelsea says, then its like a whack a mole. You hit one place one time, and then it changes next time. David nods, I wish I had seen this back with Charles. Would have saved me a lot of trouble and pain. I suppose aimlessly pouching and kicking him with my Kuret was the brute force approach.

I recall the todays match, so for George it was his shoulder. Catherine says, Lena her neck, or was that her back. Vanessa says, Eric had one under his armpit. David says, I had only one chance before it moved to a different spot. If that happened, they realize I was targeting them at their weakness. I had the element of surprise for a short time. So I had to use my biggest shot. If I missed or took too long, they would have regrouped. And I would be on the ground instead of them.

Its actually impressive he found such a unique trait of theirs from that one time. Nathan scoffs, then the credit goes to M. David smiles, I would argue it was both of us. Sommers asks, but then how did you find those places on these Heraknus. I doubt you spied on them before. He says, lets just say that my eyes have become sensitive as of late. If I am up close, I can sort of vaguely see where they are. His Ketriya boasted his glimmer sight. What an upgrade to have. He says, that's why I believe they aren't invincible. If you find their Achilles heel, and strike with all your power, you will sabotage their Kuret supply. It doesn't have to be me, anyone with an opportunity and skill can do it.

Only he can tell something so casually. I say, that's how knock them down in only one or two punches. People begin to see the genius of his strategy. Tessa asks, your Kuret cut off their Kuret gate. He says, quaint term. I like it. I wonder if they have oma name for it already. When I told Rory about it, he didn't seem surprised by it. I say, they have been struggling with many weakness on Earth. And like you said, they are adept at hiding them. I doubt they

wouldn't try to mitigate this problem. Nathan says, they had to know it would be an issue if their opponent found out. David says, maybe one of them will be kind enough to tell us.

June says, that was one hell of a move David. You got each of them in one shot. Marina says, expect for Eric. Why did he not get knocked out. Vanessa says, same reason Charles is still so strong. Not everyone is totally susceptible to this. Am I right. David says, I had the same theory. He is closely related to Charles, so maybe he has stronger resistance than others. Catherine says, by that logic Charles children would also be strong. David shrugs, having no clue. But there is strong possibility of it. Charles children are direct alpha descendants. They must be stronger than Eric.

Marina asks, what about that last attack on Eric. How do you explain that. David smiles, I am just as clueless. I masked my own surprise from the pain of dislocating my shoulder. I don't expect it to happen many times. But I think its something to do with the side effect. Sommers asks, side effect? You mean the thing with the thing. He says, people who got caught up in the accident few days ago know about it. Ah, now I realize what happened. He cut off their Kuret connection. Damn, that translates very differently for a Heraknus. Tessa asks, we are missing something here. Aren't we.

David sighs, don't sweat the details. By my estimate, I have a one in ten chances of having that sort of effect. The probability is so low I got incredibly lucky with Eric. I think that makes me a feel relieved. The more he exerts, the more blow backs like that will happen. Vanessa says, you are one crazy but brilliant guy. That creates a wave of laughter among us. Its strange to see her saying it, especially given how she feels towards him. I ask, so what's the third thing. He says, that was making them believe I was going to use my copy Kuret. I told earlier I caught them off guard. That wasn't luck.

Nathan snaps his fingers, that feint of using your Kuret storm. You purposefully did that. He says, not just that. There is a reason I asked to meet at your place Marina. I wanted people to see me with you. Since that video of our training, I hoped that would spread to some Heraknus ears. Marina yells, you did that as a misdirection. Is that why you sucked bad at the designs I gave you. He is slightly offended, I didn't suck. I tanked it purposely. We were in your garden, I was hoping people saw me failing and kept pursuing it like a fool. And for the record, I still don't know if that worked out

Jess sigh, it actually did. I was the one who told Rory you were seen with Marina early morning. David gives a villainous smile, ha. So it did. Nice. I thought I suffered through Marina's harsh critiques for no reason. I actually feel pity for him imagining that. People get a laugh from their banter. Marina gives David her middle finger in response. David clears his throat, anyways. I hoped showing up you was enough for them to think that I was going to use my Kuret. I have been planting that idea to them since yesterday. Even when I asked to increase the timer. Despite an obvious disadvantage of their endurance, I sowed the idea I needed it to prepare my Kuret.

This is exactly what I expect him to do. Perform mind games even before the match had started. Vanessa says, you lied to them. He says, I bluffed them. The match was never about proving I wasn't cheating, it was whether I can survive Charles overdrive. I let them believe it I would be showcasing it today. That single, subtle thought changed their strategy for few moments in the beginning. I knew their teamwork would be hard to break. But if they thought I was going to keep my distance first, it might give me a chance to get in and take them down one by one. And fortunately, that’s what happened.

Vanessa asks, but what if they thought you were bluffing. They must have devised a strategy to counter that. He nods, I am sure they did. However, you saw how I was goading them on the field. Being all nonchalant and haughty. You think I was shirtless just to fault at girls. He chuckles, well, I am not denying that entirely. It was to throw them off even more. They might be level headed people, but I have been arrogant to them a number of times. How long can one remain calm in a battle when you know you have the advantage of numbers. Unless this was a full blown fight with Hive, they wouldn't have their guard up all the time.

I knew he was up to something. Playing such psychological games to manipulate them is right up his style. I thought he would be too much different after his Ketriya. But he still the same. Its a relief and concerning at the same time. Chatherine sighs, you played them good. He makes a show of slightly bowing to us. His smug face was plastered with a smile, so what's the verdict. Have I been satisfactory with abelites. Anyone objects to me fighting Charles. Its hard to say if this really proves he is ready to fight an uncontrolled overdrive user. But the confidence oozing out of him is very convincing.

He looks around to hear any objections. I peek at Vanessa, who was the most vocal in opposing the last time we discussed this sort of thing. However, even if she is at odds with him, he trusted her to decide. Just one vote is enough to stop him from sighing the deal. Her aura feels slightly conflicted. But she never raised any opposition. After several seconds of silence, he says, great. Luther, whenever Heraknus are ready tell them I have decided to sign their silly contract. Nathan says, hold on. We are forgetting one more vote. Vanessa's boyfriend is not here. David replies, he messaged me immediately after the match he is in.

That was surprisingly fast for Ned. David leans away from my desk, if there's nothing else. I need to rest before resuming my training. Class dismissed.

David (Chapter 108)

Wednesday, March 4, 2026 21:43

They are taking their sweet time. Its already been 20 minutes waiting at the guest lobby. Blake and Luther are talking to few other Heraknus while we wait. Melinda chatting up with Marina again today. I had some time to spare, so I ask M, any update on our contact from Citradel. M replies, the last message confirms everything is in place. They will be ready to leave in 36 hours. Everything is as scheduled. Lets hope that's true. So much can happen until then. I will be at ease only when I see him on the island.

I lean on the couch spreading my arms lazily. Its already three in the afternoon right now. They already had their lunch. Why are they delaying it the inevitable. Jess walks up to me, sorry David. They are still deliberating the contract Luther sent over. I wave at her, its fine. I have some business here anyways. She asks, oh. I didn't hear anything about that. I smile, I had a lunch date with Catherine, but she pushed it for a later time. I was hoping to meet her now. She laughs, I see. That's interesting. He sounded a little amused. I ask, what. You don't think that true. She says, about the talk. No. But a date. She shook her head.

I felt a little hurt hearing that from her. She blurts, not that anything is wrong you trying. But, she already has a boyfriend. I scoff, whom she hasn't met for months. You don't believe they have broken up. She thinks about it, don't think so. She didn't take any interest on guys when they tried to hit on her. I don't think she would do that if she wasn't interested. They were handsome guys. So she still holds that much feeling for Rob. That's good to know. I realize something, hold on. I was one of the guys. So you think I am handsome too. I was grinning ear to ear when she was lightly amused by my logic.

Catherine somehow serendipitously appeared behind her, who is a handsome guy. Jess says, someone with a big ego. Her eyes immediately fall on me. She says, really. I don't see anyone like that. They both laugh mocking me. I should be flattered she at least acknowledged me this much. I stood up when I see Heraknus coming out behind her. Catherine says, the waits over. She turns to others, everyone. Lets move to the club room. I followed her inside a room in the adjoining building. The main reps of Heraknus are here now.

There was square table laid out in the middle with two documents placed at the ends. I am relieved they finally agreed to do this. Blake says, they finally playing ball. It was just a waiting game in the end. We knew Heraknus were just procrastinating. Riena greets us first, morning everyone. We just finished speaking with Charles. Blake asks, how is he by the way. You haven't talked to him much since you been with us. She says, sadly the issues in Citradel is escalating. He hasn't been able to make time until this morning.

This was a unexpected news. Luther asks, escalating. How do you mean. Bernard says, we aren't sure. Charles was in a hurry. But you don't have to worry about it. He was wrong. That's something we should definitely know about. He turns to me for answers. I shake my head signaling I haven't heard anything new from Jack. The communication we have is very rudimentary right now as per protocol. I can't just ask him to pass sensitive message when is about to break out from Citradel. Blake says to Luther, we should investigate that later.

Rory approaches from the side, dad has agreed to it. He was surprised at first, but ready to sign it. There were resistance to him. Blake asks, may I ask who was it. He points to Melinda. I say, ah, obviously. He nods, Melinda wasn't going to just let him do it without having a long discussion. That's why it took us a long time. We had to make her see reason. Melinda notices Rory pointing at her and walks to me, I am guessing its about my concerns. Rory sighs, not again. Look, I appreciate your trying to do. But dad is just doing this to form an equal footing, politically speaking. She faces me directly now, I am really worried things will escalate because of this.

Marina says, don't be. David isn't vindictive enough to harm Charles. Are you. I reply, obviously not. This is just a standard double clause. You have seen it in Citradel also, right. She says, I never thought I had to agree to this. You know I opposed the first one too. But Charles was being pressured. Seems like we are again. She glances at Rory. He remains stoic at her worry. Blake decided to cut in, lets not create a mess. Shall we. He gestures Rory. He gives me a annoying stare. Guess Vanessa was right about him. He hides a petty side to him. He didn't object in his action though. Together, we walk over to the table and sign each others documents.

Luther brilliant idea was to draw up another deniability contract like theirs. Instead Charles name was in ours. If he died accidently by my actions, I wouldn't be sued or whatever policy we have when Citradel transition here. Luther was skeptical of their agreement to keep the contracts a secret from the public. It was just a verbal agreement in a heated discussion. He felt they would publicly release it even they were convinced I was skilled enough to fend off Charles. Its quite a bold move, and it was only viable after their spectacular defeat. Luther is a prodigy in political warfare.

Rory imprinted his Kuret signature with a quill. I was granted the leeway to use a simple signature. Blake collects both documents when its done. I offered to shake hands with Rory, but he took his leave the moment he signed. He left me hanging. I mumble, rude. The unexpected person approaches beside me. Its Eric. He says, don't mind him. He is in a fowl mood since yesterday. I say, I can see that. How are you. I eye his bandaged chest. He says, its fine. Thank you for that by the way for healing it. You didn't need to do that. He is oddly being cordial with me. I put him through a ringer yesterday. He says, something wrong.

He guessed my thoughts. I say, I should tell you. I use deception in my fights. People often label them as mind games. But it's a viable play I often use. He unexpectedly smiles, I heard. Marina told us. I turn to Marina who heard that and gave me a big smile. Why she had to say that before I had a chance to explain. I sigh, yeah. I just wanted to make sure you know I didn't do it to demean or hurt Heraknus. He says, you played us good. I heard rumors and we even prepared for different eventualities. But you began the fight even before the match. I smile, that's one way to look at it.

Sommers said he had a good head on his shoulder. I ask, I assume they aren't a fan of me. He says, you assume right. You tricked us. But we can't do anything about it. I raise my chin, because your defeat was unquestionable and direct. He scoffs, not the exact words they are saying. Its in a nut shell. Their pride as Heraknus legend was been hurt. They assumed it will be show to show Heraknus abilities, but it was a startling defeat. He says, Rory been asking around if anyone talked to you. Did you? I played dumb, about what. He says, you know what. You were able to locate our singular weak points.

I could tell him I didn't talk to anyone. But would he believe me is a different thing. I answer, it wasn't luck. That's all I am going to say about it. He says, Marina said you are hard to figure out. You know you are making us look bad and that is going to make us hate you. I laugh, hate is a strong wrong. I am not responsible here, you lost. But lets resume that judgement about it after the match with Charles. Everyone know it was a fair match and they lost. No matter how bad the optics are for Heraknus, I am not going to be held responsible for it. He raises his hand to me. I am little surprised, but shake his hand regardless. He says, next time will be different.

I answer, oh, I don't know about that. But miracles do happen. He dismisses me with a wave of his hand and leaves the roam. Soon the Heraknus clear out the room, heading back to the guest rooms. Blake asks, making enemies. I says, lets hope not. He seems more sensible that Rory at least. Blake rolls up the two documents and hands it to Tina. He says, this is the first legally binding document in the city ever. I know it was out of our hand to choose what it was about, but I wished it was less. He was at a loss of words. Luther says, morbid? Same. But it was worth it at least. Tina asks, we aren't out of the woods yet. This contract is not viable until Citradel council moves here.

Luther says, speaking of them. We should figure what's going on there. Blake gestures at Marina and Catherine to approach him. He told them what Riena told us. Catherine says, I haven't heard anything. Nor do I have any way to know. Marina says, my friends gone dark too. Sorry. Luther asks, should we press on Heraknus for answers then. Blake says, no. They already are facing people's mockeries over their defeat. Lets not ask more from them. At least not until Charles arrives and they officially become citizens. They discussed other options, but none were credible. I am also interested to know what's happening. Sadly we don't have a way to know currently.

We broke away after few minutes. I pat on Catherines arm before she leaves, did you forget. We have a date. We were walking a little far from others and walking back to the officers building. She sighs, you are being persistent. I reply, and you are being dodgy. She laughs, fine. But you are going to have come with me. Turns out she and Jess had a meeting with IDF. The most recent client who smuggled goods is a prominent person. She is one of the people in R & D. Nathan is asking to not charge her because she is vital to his team. But Vanessa isn't backing down.

When we arrive at IDF in Catherine's car, I ask, so you both are advocating for her. Jess says, more like mediating the discussion. Catherine says, we can't show favoritism, but at the same time we can't deny she broke the rules. She makes an exhausting sigh. I think its not the first time she had to deal with this kind of issues. Jess asks, you could have talk to Catherine later. I explain, as luck would have it, I was planning to come here later anyways. Catherine asks, why. I contemplated to whether tell her. After weighing my choices, I explain, did you know a guy name Dunkin. He is a prison guard here. I wanted to meet him for some time now.

Catherine and Jess shrug to each other. The moment I entered I got few cheers and applauds from the people. I positioned myself between the two women and gave a solute to everyone. Catherine scoffs, jeez. Cut it out. I fist bump a guy, you rock man. Vannesa comes out from the inside rooms hearing the small commotion. She is surprised to see me here, what are you doing here. I turn to Catherine. She feels cornered and looks guilty at her, sorry. I wasn't expecting him to tag along. Just give me some time. Jess, can you get started with prepping Saya. Jess replies, I got you covered. Vanessa gave me a confused look but didn't ask for my reasons for being here.

We decided to go to the lounge for some privacy. The girls already in here fluster at my entry and scurry off laughing. I say, I know I shouldn't say it. But man do I have fans now. She rolls her eyes, aren't you just not used to people interest in public. We take our seats, that's true. My predecessor would be flipping out from his grave had he knew a Shadow strategist has become popular. She asks, is it that really a bad thing. I reply, its not shadows choose to remain obscure. But it does complicate things. Everything I do is now in microscope. Did you know I had to lock my own house at night because people were trying to peek in at night.

She gives a scornful laughter, sounds like a hassle. I grin at her, jealously doesn't fit you. She clicks her tongue being called out. I say, anyways. Its not really a problem, at least for the moment. But people's tune can change any day. I dodged a bullet with Ryes, but the next one could be an artery, from which I won't be able stop the bleeding. She is curious about my thinking, you think you will be targeted again.

I answer, I do. I am enjoying this while it lasts. Because one way or another, this will end. Her eyes sharpen, so that's what going on in your mind. But it will be a while till things settle down. You taking down Heraknus has created big waves. You saw Cranston put out another piece last night. People are talking about it already. I put my shades on the table. He went to make another video and he somehow got hold of a Heraknus. He wasn't one of the warriors, and yet they had quite a lot to say. Wasim applauded me for my stunning win. I became a hashtag 52 from that video. Since I defeated them in that many seconds. He spoke a lot about Heraknus and their struggles.

Overall it was an effort to keep the Heraknus power still relevant. He elevated me, touting I was a once in lifetime prodigy and Heraknus had bad luck they fought me first in peoples eyes. They weren't wrong, but I still feel many others could also defeat them. I digress and say, enough about them. I want to talk to you something more important. She straighten her back at my sudden reaction. I gesture her to relax, its not what you think. She asks, how would you know. I sigh, because my thing is very different. I take a breathe, I want to talk about Branden and John. I didn't get to tell you everything last time. She shakes her head, you don't need to explain. I already forgave you for that.

I answer, I don't think its that easy to forgive me. And I am not asking for it. I will feel better when I you know what kind of people they were. She drops her eyes down to the table brooding a bit. She nervously asks, why. I tell, because I don't want you to remember them due to one desperate thing they did. You should know who they were. She is visibly curious from this. She says, did someone ask you to do this. Because you don't have to. I am fine. A little bit of glimmer appears on her. She is probably hiding her insecurities. I say, you may be fine. But I am not. I used my promise to your father as an excuse. And I have been reminded what I should have been doing.

She didn't understand what I meant by this. She turns her hand to a fist anxiously. I continue, it was part of my treatment with Drew. I need to fix my mistake. She asks, I don't understand. But I understand you that you want to clear the air. Are you sure though. Did Blake already tell her about his family's involvement in Shadows. I don't think he would do that to her. I say, lets talk about your dad first. The truth is that he was a, I pause a little as she anxiously looks to me, is a big goofball.

Her blank expression took a second to go away. She blurts out, what. I laugh, oh yeah. He talks a good game, but honestly, I think he gave me the scholarship not because of my ideas, but because he wanted me to be his personal slave driver. She was taken completely by surprise, what are you saying. I say, did you know one time he forgot his anniversary a third time. Your mom wasn't talking to him for days and he was annoying us at work. Talk about unprofessionalism and negligence in disclosing private things to students. I get he treated me as adult, but who wants to hear domestic problems.

I remember the atmosphere in lab was so bad that Zakerine insisted we do something to help me. I didn't want to meddle in their business. I say, It was so bad that me and a friend made a vacation plan for your parents. A weekend trip, while I covered the department. You see how I was carrying his water. How can such a responsible guy suck so bad at home. What a nincompoop.

Her jaw hangs loose, I have never heard anyone calling my dad a goofball before. You are making this up, right? I say, what would I gain by doing that. I am talking about things that makes him. Things that matter in the end, not his work or anything like that. She then pulls out a nervous smile, seriously. I nod, oh yeah. I hate to say this, but you mom wore the pants in their marriage. People call him responsible, but he was clumsy at his home. I wouldn't have cared to help him out, but I was being somewhat pressured into helping him. And John was a mutual friend too, so reluctantly I covered for his work.

She hysterically laughs, dad was like that. I can't believe it. My memories of him are different. I say, I am sure he was different with his children than with his wife. I sometimes think its good I never met your mom, I kind of had a mental picture of a scary women from all the stuff he dragged me through. She couldn't stop laughing. I then shared few more stories, like the time he was accused of cheating, or when he forgot the in laws visit. People all only hear stories of their Kuret or abilities. But not much about their day to day life. The thing that actually makes them decent and normal.

She only heard the stories of her dad's accomplishments. I decided to reveal his side that others don't see. I spent about 30 minutes dishing out all the quirks of her dad. Her earlier brooding expression was no more. She was so amazed, few people outside the lounge heard her. She says, I can't believe dad didn't know the difference between a frezerk and urezerk. Isn't he used to using them as genie pigs for his students. Hell, even I could tell the different back then. That’s so wired, he made such a blunder in that experiment. I would have given anything to be to see him nervous when that animal glow in red.

It felt nice to share this. I sigh, like I said, a goofball. But even with all those flaws, he was a decent person. I may be biased because he helped me, but I let you to decide that. She nods in agreement, this is gold. Damn. I so wish I could have this conversation with mom or John. Their mention brought a damper in her joyous mood. I tried to distract her, unlike your dad, I didn't know much about John. I wish I did. I hope you don't take this the wrong way, but he was probably going to be the next alpha. She gives me a pity smile, I know. I have so little memories of him. I wonder what kind of person he was.

I say, I do have one story so you can understand him. John once impersonated his friends place in an exam and saved him from flunking. I was in shadows at that time and coincidently auditing the class. I was given the exam papers to review the grade from the professor. I was testing his knowledge of the subject and thinking of adjusting his training based on that. But I never got to see that. She says, you caught him? How. I have heard his transformation is flawless. He can easily mimic your gait and behavioral style.

With a smirk, I answer, people with strong Kuret always prepare for a high detection. But forget about low specs. He didn't copy his friends handwriting flawlessly. In fact, I could match the same style of his letters from previous papers. She laughs, oh come on. That’s such an obvious blunder. I nod, it was. The prof didn't catch it, but I have keen eye for detail. Naturally I got him to admit it. But instead of reporting him, we made a deal with him to help us getting into a seniors party. She slaps her palm on her head, you blackmailed him. I scoff, you bet. And not just that. We made him do other simple favors in exchange of keeping silent about that.

I laugh, sort of. His dad is a prof in the same university. He was so conflicted that few juniors were making him do things. He once said we haunted him in his sleep. She says, I feel so bad for him. You bullied him. I say, don't think he didn't try to get out. He once transformed into me and caused an incident that would have gotten me into trouble. Fortunately for me, I was prepared. A well placed camera showed I was framed. And unfortunately for him, we got more black mail material for him. She chuckles, oh god. You were making him dance in your palm. Actually, it wasn't me at all. It was Zakerine. She was the prank master and blatantly pulling making decisions for me.

She says, he must be very angry with you. I answer, on the contrary, he kind of enjoyed the challenge. It was a race of who trips up first and gets caught. And besides, we only asked him favors inside the walls of the campus. We kept it fair since he didn't cheat for his friend unreasonably. She asks, what do you mean. Why did he do it. I remember the time Zakerine told me the reasons when he shared it to her privately. I answer, his friends parents were friends your parents. And there was some problem between. Honestly, I don't remember the detail. But the friend was caught up in it and was lagging behind his studies.

She blinks a little erratically, why. I shrug, no clue. But your valiant brother decided he didn't want their parents problem lead to kids to pay for unintentional mistakes. So he offered to help the only way he could. She says, he did that for such a reason. Whoa. That’s. I added, show's his character. He could have made us back down if told his reasons in the beginning. He may have thought it was too embarrassing to share to naïve juniors. But the problem with his friend escalated and he involved us. Despite all the pranks and blackmailing. He could have been kicked out of the university, so we made sure he got another chance.

Her brightens to hear her brothers personality, your brother made him help the guy. I tutored him where he lacked. And he just barely saved himself from dropping out. After then we dropped our ridiculous meaningless tit for tat battles. I won't say we became friends, but I understood how he was Branden's son. He smiles with tinge of regret. She says, he was like that, huh. I know it’s a little cliché, but I always wanted him to be a good elder brother. I reply, its not a wrong thing to want. But like I said, I don't know him very well. Aside from the 5 or 6 stuff we asked him as favor, I didn't have much contact with him.

I regret a little that I couldn't spend much time with him in Shadows as well. I say, one thing I did know. He had a lot of social credit going on for him. He probably was mischievous, but he was decent person. She closes her teary eyes. I waited for her wipe away the minute tears swelling in her eyes. She blurts out, I just have a dirt. Don't make a big deal. Okay. I raise my hand, I didn't see anything. She sighs, I have so many questions. Its frustrating I will never have an answer for them. She then looks up to me, I figured out one thing though. I raise my brows. She says, you have hinted it wasn't just you doing this. You had someone with you in all your escapades.

I didn't give her an answer. But she interpreted my silence as the truth, and I am very certain this person made him do this. Didn't they. I can't picture you doing all this. You were a very serious kid back then. You said it yourself many time. I don't think you are lying too. So fess up, who was it. Leave it her to her intuition. No, actually I was laying it very thin. I say, remember I told you about a mutual friend. I did all of this because she made me. She scoffs, it was a girl. She leans forward, do tell who was it. I shake my head, this isn't about me. Its about you. My reluctance only made her more persistent.

After few more insistence I gave up, she was a good friend. All right. Catherine wasn't so gullible, I don't buy it. You wouldn't so much for a friend. What are you hiding. Turns out there are still sensitive topics I don't like to share. I raise my arms, I am not ready to tell you about her. I pick up my shades and put it on. The glimmers of excitement and curiosity from her were starting to overwhelm me. She shakes her head, you had a girlfriend back then. I have to know. I can't picture anyone putting up with you. Was she like you, a brainiac. I take offend at she thinks my preference in women is so shallow. But I can't really deny how Zakerine managed to keep me grounded.

I say, she was special in her own way. She chuckles, wow. You have to tell me who she was. I sigh, I may be more open minded about things now. But I still want to keep certain people private. She finally understood I valued privacy on this matter, oh. I didn't realize it was this personal. Can I at least ask why. I say, you remember when I told she was there when John died. Well, I could have saved her back then. But I was too hurt to move. So I kind of blamed myself for her unnecessary death. That’s not all. She made a choice that still bothers me. She patiently waits for me to reminiscence about that horrifying memory.

I say, anyways. I have many reasons to not talk about her. Some are personal, others are because of who she was. I am sure she didn't understand what I mean. But it was enough for to not pursue further, I see. I am sorry. I didn't know. I wave her hand, its fine. She was one of reasons for my trauma. Or was it a pseudo PTSD from Ketriya. The line is so blur from the distinction I don't know what to believe. I will tell you about it when the time is right. She understands my sentiments, I know how you feel. I didn’t want to tell about dad's decision to anyone also. I only did it after I got over it.

She already told someone. Only one person comes to mind, how did Blake react to it. She scoffs at me for figuring out so quickly. She says, he was angry at my dad. It was sweet of him to defend me. A different reaction from hers, but I suppose she didn't mind it. She says, thank you David. And in case you still don't believe it, I forgive you. You were close to my dad, I am sure it was personal for you. I reply, I appreciate you saying that. But I still feel responsible for interfering too much with your relationship. She turns somber and mumbles, Robb. Hey eyes look far off even when she is staring at me.

I fished out a phone from my pocket, I can't take away the unreasonable demand I was putting on you. So this is me wanting to rectify it. I toss the phone to her. It was a small flip phone, a burner phone. I nod, with only one number programmed into it. Call it, there will be challenge phrase. Tell them, my cat Phillips needs an appointment. That will connect you to the person you want to talk to the most. She jerks up while opening the phone, you don't mean. I nod, yes. Robb will be on the other end. She stares at the phone widely, how. When.

I say, few weeks ago, I finally got hold of Robb, Nina and Maiyer. They have been running and hiding from Echo since a year. But once I got my memories back, one of the first orders I gave my contacts was to locate them and hide them in the safest place we can think of. She puts the phone down with a shock on her face, you found them. Where are they now. I say, WITSEC protection. Its the only way Echo can't find them. When was the last time you spoke to them. She says, I got a message from Nina about 5 months ago. Said they are going deep cover. That was you. I nod, I myself didn't know about it at that time. I was busy with the tournament. My associate did the arrangement. I still don't know how he got the into that program. Once you meet Robb, you can ask him all about it.

She got up from the chair with nervous reaction, say that again. For some reasons she is more anxious than happy to know her boyfriend is safe. I stand on my feet, I got their location once their cover was completed. It took few days, but I wrangled a way for you two to meet. She looks down at her phone in her hand. I am missing something. I am giving her a way to meet him and all I see is hesitation. I voice my confusion, I don't understand. I thought you be relieved. And happy that you can finally see him. She shakes off her ambivalence, no. Sorry. I am glad to hear that.

I ask, are you sure. Because you don't look seem happy. She gives a weak smile, I really am. Its just. She was loosing her words. I am clueless now, what's happening. I was expecting you to be in cloud nine. Did something happen between you and Robb. Did he already contact you. She replies, no. He didn't. Its just, I am ashamed to even say this. She pauses before recollecting herself, I don't know how I feel about him now. Did my ears heard that right. I scoff, you don't know how you feel. He did contact you then. It was my misguided attempt to look out for your best interest. Just tell him I was the one who tried to break up the two of you.

She shakes her head, no, we haven't spoken in a while. And its not because of you. She slumps down on the chair with a defeated expression, its me. I have changed. Living here for almost a year has made me look at things differently. I hesitantly wait for to explain more. She says, I know its not going to make sense. I was so mad at you for trying to stop me from seeing Robb, but I think that was just an excuse. Easier to blame you than myself. And now, I don't have that excuse anymore. I am the last person who should give any kind of relationship advice. But I made an attempt, you don't love him anymore?

She immediately replies, I still love him. But what you said about the consequences, you were right. I just didn't want to accept it. So I might have prolonged our fight, because I didn't want to deal this myself. This part I understood, you wanted me to stop you. You didn't want to meet Robb. She makes a mortifying smile, yes. Whoa, didn't see that coming. Jess said she was still committed to Robb. Was she just doing it out of guilt and didn't want to betray him. I ask, I won't ask how things changed for you. I know something about blaming others for something you fear. She says, then you know how messed up I am. I didn't want to admit it, but I was hating you for the wrong reasons.

I understand that too. I ask, when did you begin to feel that way. She snorts, honestly, its slowly just crept up to me. Maybe when I started to enjoy living with so Medrones again. Having a stable life, instead of missions and objectives. People depending on me. People I have grown to care about. Responsibilities. Children. All the stuff you warned us years ago, it came to pass. I hate that it really did change my feelings. I hate it. But I can't hide it too. She is reeling from a doubt and self pity. So that’s the core of her issue. I take the seat beside her and put my hands on her wrist, its okay. People change. Its okay to feel differently now. You be insane to not to.

She holds my hand tightly, you aren't going to say, I told you so. I gave her a smirk, I am dying to say it. But not today. You get a pass for now. She closes her eyes, what a mess. You gave me such an incredible gift and I can't be even be happy about it. I had a thought, I am the last person you should talk about this. But I have one suggestion though. She opens her eyes to me, you want me to meet him. Don't you. I reply, yeah. You can keep looking for advice from others, but that’s all its going be. Just advice. You will hardly act on them. She says, how would you know. You said you don't have experience in this.

I could tell her about Ned or Vanessa. But I am not okay going to risk it. I am trying to cause their break up selfishly. I say, its normal, you know. She might have guessed I was talking about Vanessa. Regardless she didn't ask about that further. She raises the phone on her hand, what should I do. He can't move here. And I don't want to leave anymore. But we want to be together. I ask, your original plan was to leave. When you would done your part? She gave me sorrowful and guilty look. I guessed right. I'll be lying if I didn't know how that felt. They are for different reasons. I say, go to him. Talk to him. Figure out a solution.

She takes away her hand, how does that work. I meet him over the weekends, maybe planed visit during the holidays. No way its going to work. I say, then I am going to give the same answer I am gave a while ago. Either figure out a way, or just pull the band aide. Its not fair to you. Or to Robb for leading him on, keeping up with the false hope. She gives weak scoff, I don't think I can cut ties with him. We have been together for so long. I answer, not anymore. I am sorry, but to have a working relationship, you need to be in one. I can't fathom what kind of fantasy or dysfunctional relationship you two planned.

She remined dead silent at that, or maybe you didn't thought of it. That’s something you can finally talk about. I push the phone on her hand, get this out of your system. Go tomorrow. She scoffs, its not that easy. I can't just leave. I click my tongue, take a sick day. Or tell you need to take a personal day. Say you have lady problems. She punches me on my arm. I say, hey. That’s a valid reason. Or do you want to explain how you have a secrete human boyfriend with whom you don't know where you stand anymore.

She puts the phone down, I can't leave the island unauthorized. I chuckle, you do realize who you are talking to. She raises her eyebrows at me, seriously? I answer, oh yeah. I wasn't joking when Ruther asked me if I have a way out of the city. I can get out without anyone realizing. And back in the same way. She still thought I was messing with her, no way. That’s crazy. I ask, why is that. The Heraknus are going to leave tomorrow morning. Jess can handle your affairs for a day. And you can hold your search for the people behind the smuggling criminals, they aren't going anywhere. No can stop you, except yourself. She finally entertains the possibility and contemplates.

She shakes her head, no. It's selfish. What if I am needed here. I scoff, if the city can't function one day without you, then we have failed this place. It took a lot of convincing, but she finally was taking it seriously now. She asks, I can meet him tomorrow? I nod, pick a place and time you two want to meet. I will book your travel discreetly. But for his safety, you will have only 15 to 18 hours. Anything more than that and they might suspect he is missing. That should give you enough time to catch up.

She finally sees the possibility of this, you can do that. I am hurt she is asking me that, I have done much more difficult tasks in less time. Arranging a meet between two love birds, I can do that in my sleep. She suddenly goes in for a hug, thank you David. You are the best. I pat her back when I feel her relieved. She didn't know it, but this is what she needed. A push and someone to have her back. I pull back, there is a catch though. Robb can't risk his safety. Because its not just him. She whispers, Nine and Maiyer. They would be exposed if anyone found out about him. I say, I have to keep him, and therefore you, under surveillance.

That put a damper on her chipper mood. I say, as much I like to give you your privacy, its very risky to meet without some protection. I can ask the team to keep an eye on you from far. They won't hear you, but keep you in their eyeline. And you won't even know who they are. She says, that’s. After a lengthy pause, fair. I don't want to jeopardize others from my selfish behaviors. I nod, pick a place you guys are familiar. And I have a favor. She waits for me to ask. I give her a wicker smile, when you two lost souls meet, make sure you keep all your nasty business stays inside. You have a lot of catching up to do. But don't waste it on canoodling all the time.

That resulted in another punch to my shoulder with a icy stare from her. She blurts out, don't be such an ass after I just complimented you. I scoff, someone had to say. And make sure to use protection. She shook her head in disgust, I meant take a gun. She finally gives a nervous laugh. That brought her worries down a little. I offer her some solace, its going to be fine. She resolves herself, you are right. I can do this. No, we can do this. I need to go prepare a go bag. I nod, checklist is important. Passport, spare clothes, pajamas, and lingerie. She cackles, you are incorrigible. Before we leave, I face her. I ask, just don't regret whatever you decide. But do decide. She nods, I will and thanks for.

Then her face turns a little pale. I ask, what. She raises her eyes to point behind me. I turn my to see two people gawking through the gap of the door. I should be worried they snooped in, but Catherine was being nervous for both of us. Blake and Vanessa step inside with confused face. This is awkward. Catherine was feeling their gazes a bit too much. She slipped out between them without uttering a word in embarrassment. They both see her with puzzled expression. I bite my lip, what brings you here Blake. He turns back to me, ah, I was called in to deal with a problem. I connect the dots, for Saya. I see. Well, Catherine might be a little preoccupied. So you may want to handle this without her.

Vanessa gives me a hard stare. I thought I play it cool, but here intense gaze was piercing me hard. I ask, ahm, I didn't know people were snooping in. But just to be on the same page, what did you guys here. Blake answers, enough to know what happened. I got caught red handed. I blame this on my stupid shades. I pull it off and keep in my pocket. Vanessa asks with a flat tone, since when did you decide to play cupid. I don't need that kind of judgement from her. I reply with a snappy comment, since your boyfriend accused me of causing problems with you both. Someone has to make things right again.

That shut down her any emotion she wanted to throw at me. Blake asks, so she is going to meet him tomorrow. He sounded disappointed. Is there something on between them. Hope not, that would complicate things even more. I say, any way you can forget this. She barely got the courage to do this. Last thing she needs is you to stop her from leaving unauthorized. He snaps back to reality, I won't stop her. Sounds like she is figuring out stuff with Robb. Good for her. I hesitantly ask, and good for Robb too. He didn't respond to that, just gave a bewildered look. I ask, you okay. He answers back enthusiastically, of course. Just forgetting this conversation happened.

I ask, what conversation. I already forgot. He smirks, right. I got to. Yeah. I need to. Ahm. See you later. He leaves in hurry without finishing his sentence. Guess he is bothered by this a little too much. From the looks of it, Catherine was to. I ask Vanessa, you know anything about that. She was lost in her own thoughts to answer that. Then she asks, I came here earlier. Heard you talking about her family, so I left. What did you tell her about them. Got to hand it to her, she is consistent in her accusations. I say, I didn't tell her everything. Only the stuff that really matters. And she knows that too. Why do you ask.

I actually didn't need to. We both know who she was referring to. I say, before you start arguing with me again. You should settle things with your boyfriend. She is flustered, you talked to him? I laugh, more like he was accusing me. You two have the same penchant for blaming me for stuff I am not responsible for. Talk to him before he gets in my face again. She was cowering a little from my pushy attitude. I continue, I am going to tell you, what I told Catherine. If you are don't want to find a way to resolve this. Then don't keep leading the poor bastard, and just end it for freaks sake.

This made her eyes widen. She asks, you. She was stuttering a little. I guess I am being way to impudent with her. I pull back, sorry. That was uncalled for. But still, just talk to Ned. I decided to leave a dazed Vanessa and head out to meet Dunkin. Jeez, now its my turn to run away cowardly. Turns out I am no better than those two.

David (Chapter 109)

Friday, March 6, 2026 22:17

I rang the bell hoping they are at home. I didn't find them back at the office, and its too late for a date night. I hear a rustle inside and the door opens. Matt has a dumbfounded expression on his face. He blurts out, dude. I was hoping he be here with her. I reply, hey Matt. Can I come in. He pulls out of the shock and waves in, sure. He looks around behind me to check anyone else. I help him out as I enter through the door, its just me. Felt I needed to explain myself. He closes the door and we walk to the dinning room where he and Cass were having dinner. Cass got up from the table, putting away the fork she was eating with.

She cries, what are you doing here. I smile at the food, isn't it late for dinner. She is naturally confused at my sudden visit to her house. Matt says, I had to cover an evening shift today. I told her I'll order in late, but she insisted we eat together. I take an empty seat beside theirs. They had almost finished their dinner, so at least I didn't interrupt them too much. Cass remains silent, while Matt just stands beside me looking at her. I say, I wanted to apologies from my behavior the last time we met. I am sure you heard from my doctors and others, but I was out of my mind at that time. Matt asks, we know. You scared the freak out of us.

Cass breaks her confusion, I am angry with you David. You could have come to visit us anytime, but you came to us last. Didn't you. She takes back her seat along with Matt. She sighs, you know how embarrassing it is to be the last one to hear anything about you. I get her frustration. Its been happening more last few months, but too much in the last two weeks. Matt says, I am with here. We are kept too much out of the loop. And I don't mean just about your work. I nod, I don't know how else to explain it. I wasn't doing it intentionally. Cass was more mad than Matt, so I had to disclose everything from three days ago.

Matt says, whoa. You went on training marathon the whole day. That’s some dedication. I smirk, you think that fight with Heraknus was a fluke, it was hard work. And I was so exhausted later, I needed to rest. And I knew you guys were busy with work, so I couldn't come until tonight. Cass had her arms folded. She was unimpressed by brilliance. She was angry with something else too. Matt had some hesitation also still with him. I ask, so I am guessing this about me being a Shadow. Matt swipes his lips with tongue, you are damn right. How can you not tell us you were a freaking shadow. That’s blowing my mind even now.

I take a short breathe, because its was very personal. It wasn't a simple for me to reveal such a massive past. My shadow identity coupled with trauma was complicated to figure out. Cass asks, and now? I heard from many people that you have changed. Matt says, you looked like a different person yesterday. I surmise they didn't hear about my condition. I didn't want to use my Ketriya as an excuse, but it was a crucial part of my emotional and mental state. Neither of them had heard about Ketriya before, so it took a while to explain.

Another 20 minutes go by and their confusion went up. Cass says, what kind of messed up experimentation did MAR's do to you. Matt says, is this why Kuret also changed weirdly over the years. Damn man, that’s so cruel. I scoff, cruel and lucky. My physiology wouldn't be able to handle my completed Kuret. I didn't tell anyone about Drews theory about MAR's experimentation. That would only throw more chaos among people. Cass sighs, let me get this straight. Now that Ketriya is over, your personality has changed. I know its hard to explain. In children it’s a common and natural phenomenon. But in adult, well, no one is sure. Drew, my doctor is giving me routine checkup to see the overhaul changes. I actually have been doing some test on my own.

Matt asks, and. What's the verdict. I shrug, this isn't something I can measure very accurately. I can tell you some objective scores, but they are not really conclusive. This didn't made them any less hesitant, you both don't need to worry about the details. All you need to know, I was sick. And now I am not. Cass asks, I heard you have been flirting with any girl you see. Is that true. Or just part of you being fine. She underscores the last word with a sarcastic tone. Matt mocks me, I heard you were trying to flirt and fail spectacularly too. You are behaving in ways you are not used to.

I could physically feel a gut punch. Just how bad have my cheesy comments have been. I ask, do people have no appreciation for me. I am doing something new here. My frustration made them giggle. Cass says, you are out of practice. I could have corrected her saying its more like awkwardness, but its best to get her sympathy than digging a deeper pit for myself. I say, I promise to be more forthright with you both. But I can't promise it won't happen again. Things have changed a lot and will change even more once Citradel comes. We all have responsibilities. There will be times when we can't be free or available to meet more often.

I came here so I can make them understand some things are out of control. They didn't like it. But thankfully, they didn't deny our situation. I wish we could have made them high ranking officers. That would keep them close to us. I asked them again about it, but they said they wouldn't be able to make the cut. Cass sighs, I don't think I can handle logistics like Tina. Matt says, I am good where I am right now. After few rounds of discussion they finally accepted the hard reality. Cass sighs, fine. I get it. I hate it, but I guess its not your fault. But, she points her index to me, I am not forgiving you for not telling us you were a shadow. You could have told us anytime before your issues were acting up.

Matt agreed with her, yeah. That was not cool man. I have a million questions for you. He started to ramble about rumored mission like decimation of a political group, stopping a terrorist plot and something about a circus. I crack up at his attempt to gather all the possible things we might be responsible for. I say, unfortunately, I am not going to comment on any of them. Setting aside that they are in past, people hold conflicting feelings about it. I am not going to disclose that cause me and others problem. Matt lightly taps the table edge, that’s no fun. I don't think he appreciates how sensitive shadows missions were. We weren't a group of peacemakers.

Cass didn't seem disappointed like Matt, I don't care about the secrets. What I care is how you were chosen, who picked you and what more do you know about Terrisa. Guess she has been thinking a lot about her. I say, I don't know much about her. She was two generations before me, I only know her public reputation. In fact I only met her a grand total of once. Cass scoffs, you met a single time? But you know she was a Shadow. I don't understand. I say, I know its frustrating, but that’s I got. Though I am sure she referred you onto the ship. I explained how each Shadow member had given a privilege to choose a family member. But only if they were capable.

She raise her chin, so that’s how I was allowed to board in even when Sommers was already inside. She then turns gloomy learning the meaning of this. She wasn't chosen because of her innate skills, but it was due to someone else. I didn't want to burst her bubble, but I didn't want to hide it anymore. Matt and I assure her she didn't need to feel guilty. She says, I do feel it. I mean, what if there was someone more capable. Maybe one with previous Kurets that went extinct. Its all too common with the kids from the first ship. Matt says, I know how you feel Cass. He turns to me, please don't tell me that happened for me too.

I shake my head, sorry. I have no idea who referred your name. All I can say is, like others, you were chosen for your potential. That was the truth. Matt looks relieved to hear. He probably wouldn't have cared either way, but it was still a burden he didn't want to bear. Cass lowers her head to me, hold on. Did you get selected by someone else too. She connected the hidden dots. I nod, I was. Yes. By someone in the shadows. I know who they were, but I am going to refrain revealing their name. She sighs, your damn secrets. I suppose you won't tell how you got into Shadows too. I give her a small smile to her query.

She shakes her head annoyed. Matt says, I figured you would not tell. But still, this is still so crazy. And yet, its not. You took on three freaking Heraknus. There is a rumor you manipulated them before they even had a chance to retaliate. You were probably born for this. Blake and Marina told us how excited they were when you turned out be another survivor. I have been getting praise by a lot of people. I try my best not to get swayed by it too much. But after a certain point I just have to accept their glazing of me.

We discussed a little about how I told them and what I have been doing since then. I couldn't tell them everything, but I hinted that I have been brewing many hidden agendas. Cass says, that’s explains why you have been distant this year. You been plotting things in secret. Matt says, like that house of yours. I saw you using a tech after your tussle with Heraknus. Is it like that. I answer, it’s an application of it. A kind of a hybrid nano tech.

I told them as much I could. I wasn't hiding about it, buts the science is too advance for me to talk about. I only have a cursory knowledge, just enough to know the mechanism. Cass wasn't impressed by it unlike Matt. He even decided to open a bottle of beer excited to talk about anything with me. Cass is making it hard to win over her. Guess this is perfect time to show them. I say to her, I know you were going to be tough to appease. I didn't came here empty handed. I took out a piece of paper and laid it on the table. Matt puts the beer down, what is this. Cass asks, I don't think you can give me anything that will make me get over this.

I grin knowing that her attitude is going to change. I was more sure of it when Matt's chokes while drinking the beer. He coughs will giving me wide eyes. Cass yells, oi, you are spilling at my table. She grabs the paper and begins reading it. Matt wipes his jaws, dude. Is this a joke. I wave my palm at him, I don't have the courage to mess around with she is like this. It was Cass to freak out. She yells, how in the hell. I grabbed the beer bottle from Matt's hand and enjoy seeing their panicked expressions. Matt asks with a gaping mouth, I don't understand. We were no where on the short list.

Cass asks nervous, what did you do. I take a swipe off the bottle, it wasn't easy. Had to bribe, arg, no, give favor to the estate heads son's birthday. I have to come over to their party and give sort of show to them. Honestly, that is such a pain. All the while I had a devious smile on me. Matt asks, seriously. She agreed with just this. I puff out my chest, there are many benefits of being a meteoric celebrity. Just don't tell anyone I helped you jumped the line, that would cause Bianca problems. Cass puts down the deed to their new house over in section 2. She gets excited, this is real, right. I say, if you still don't believe it, go check it tomorrow. That house is yours.

I have trying to find a gift for them, hoping it buy me some grace. I already knew they were trying to buy a semi condo apartment in section 2. It was weird they be interested when its technically for 3 people. Plus its barely inside their budget. They must have had a reason. Regardless, I went over to the section 2's estate head and greased over to get it for them. Matt goes straight in for a hug, spilling the bear from my hand, holy shit. You are a god send. I laugh while patting his arm. Cass came rushing behind him and gave a bear squeeze, I don't believe you. This is. She grips me tighter.

They both still didn't think this was real, and went over to check on the network. Sure enough, they got a message from her telling the good news. Cass yells to Matt, we got it. Matt locks in his arm to hers and they went for kiss. He shouts, I had lost hope. This is really happening. They both embrace rejoicing over the sudden fortune. I wasn't expecting this big of a reaction. Why are they acting like they just won the largest lottery of their life. I ask curious, what am I missing here. Cass says, how did you know we wanted this. With a flat expression I waited for them to figure it out. Matt chuckles, duh. He pokes his shoulder. Even if I wasn't a shadow, I would have figured it out.

They both settle down from their excitement. Cass says, why do you think Matt and I haven't moved in together. I didn't need to think much about it, Mel? Matt says, she has been a pain in the ass to deal with. Whenever one of stay in the others house, it becomes a mess if she ever wakes up. I take another sip of the beer, hold up. I thought you take some sort of Kuritine pill to block her at night. Cass pouts a little, I do, but lately its loosing its effect. I think I have built up a tolerance for it. Matt says, this one time we were sleeping at my place, I woke up to a Mel working out in my living room with loud music. I ask, that doesn't seem too bad.

Matt freaks out a little, oh yeah. How about in the middle of making out she accidently comes out and begins to strangle me. And it wasn't even a erotic chocking, it was gut retching cutting off air strangling. Cass gets mad that he fessed up something so intimate. But she was actually angry about the accidental part, I am telling you, that was really a mistake. Why would I consciously use my Kuret. Matt yells, I will tell you why. You were scared of doing that, he peaks at me for just half a second, you know what. I wave my arms, all right. That’s enough. TMI. I couldn't even enjoy them bantering now. I ask, what does this have to do with getting that specific house.

Cass calms down, the point is, Mel is not going to let us live together in peace. And she is to belligerent to live in a cramped up place. Matt chips in, so we came up with an idea. He picks up the deed, this house has and extra room and bigger garage space. Now I see their plan. Cass says, we are going to offer Mel her own space. Matt says, completely fitted with sound proofing walls, a workout space and even her own bed. Their solution for Mel is to treat her like a roommate. I nod, this is actually brilliant. Thats why you wanted to purchase that place. Its even a little further away from neighbors. So no one will be disturbed too.

Cass says, its our ideal house. Yeah. Then then she become less excited. Matt asks, you worried if Mel is not going to accept it. Cass answers in a despondent tone, I have no clue. The last video message she gave, it was almost a threat that she will hurt you. Matt clacks his jaw, I told you. I am not worried about that. She is just bluffing. And if you ask me, she is embarrassed to live with me. Cass scoffs, would you please stop that. I have lived with her more than you, she is only tolerating you. Matt brings a sly smirk, lets ask her then. Cass gets confused, what. You want to do it now. No. She nervously looks at me and I froze with the bottle end on my lips.

I guess this is my cue, maybe I should go. Seems you have a lot of discussing ahead. I might just get in your way. I prepared to leave, but unexpectedly Cass stops me. She exclaims, wait. Now that I think about it. She won't

believe me or Matt. But if you are here, she will be more tenable. I really didn't want to mediate things with her alter ego. Matt was already onboard with this, yup. Plus she wouldn't go on a rampage since the last time you kicked Mel's ass. Yesterday Mel was so furious at you, but I could tell she is troubled also. Your presence might yield a peaceful resolution. Cass agreed with Matt and gave me a pleading eyes.

I really didn't like being put in this spot. I say, okay. But I will not be negotiating in any capacity. That's all on you Matt. I am only going to sit here and drink, I look at the empty bottle, let me get another bottle. No, I need something stronger. I rummaged in their kitchen and brought a Kuritine rum. I sigh, only you like this stuff Cass. She is annoyed at me, what. Don't judge me. I blast the bottle with my Kuret, hoping to have removed most of the Kuretine mixed in it. From the glimmer I say about 10% still remained. Well, this will have to be enough. I gesture them as I pour myself a glass.

Cass tells Matt, remember what we discussed. Matt grabs Cass's hand, a recurring schedule, zero property damage warning and money allowance. Cass adds, don't forget about her breaking any rules. And their consequences. They have been planning this for a while. I clear my throat as I drank the rum. I still felt the taste of Kuritine in it, however, it was just enough for me to ignore it. I need to remain less sober to see a tumultuous negotiation. They both kiss for good luck and then whisper to each other. The next second Cass summons her Kuret. Her hopeful expression turns to an aggressive one as Mel appears. She barks, ah, what is it. Why did you.

Her voice breaks when she turned to see me setting and partaking in some beverage in her own house. She takes a step forward to me, what the freak are you doing in my house. I already said I wasn't going to participate in this. Matt takes over, Mel. David is helping us out. He points to the deed on the table, we have a proposal for you. She ignores him and glares at me, I don't care. You, she points her index finger at me, lets go another round. I am not going do anything, except kick that smug face off of you. I think Matt misjudged her. She wasn't afraid of me, if anything she is even more hostile. She leans in and grabs my by the collar.

The drink spills for the second time on their table. I am getting annoyed at wasting their drinks. Mel screams, you listen to me. You smug, arrogant, freak. I am going to shove my foot far up your ass and enjoy watch you squirm in agony. I should be irritated, but I couldn't help laugh from her vain attempts to corner me. Matt grabs Mel by the shoulder and copy's her Kuret, Mel. You need to listen to me. She tries to shove him, but he held his ground. Mel eyes was so red with anger, I thought she might burst a vein. Her grip on my collar was tightening. Matt pleads for her to get off, but she wasn't having any of it.

I wanted to remain a neutral party here, but she is making it tough for me to remain impartial. I turn to Matt, I am going to try something, try to get through her will you. He nods vehemently. I grab hold her wrist my one arm and pull all my Kuret into my grip. The Kuret starts to vibrate and she suddenly barks at me, oh. You want to go now. I will gladly knock your teeth and feed it to you. I smile, aren't you a bag of sunshine. I kept vibrating my Kuret on her wrist hopping it hits the mark. She thought it was my acceptance to a fight. She releases one hand and prepares a fist in the air. Matt grabs her by the arm, Mel. You need to settle down.

She barks at him, go away. Cass pulled me out to talk to you, right. I won't do it until I stomp his ass. I am used to think her as a petulant war mongrel. But now, I think she is just a child throwing a tantrum. She clocks the pity smile I was showing in my face, you freaker. You think you better than me don't you. Don't get ahead of yourself. One good punch, I will knock that big mouth. Maybe after defeating three alphas and Heraknus together has made me a bit prideful. Perhaps her anger towards me is what Matt was talking about earlier.

I didn't want to be stuck like this forever, the three of us in a standoff. Fortunately, my Kuret side effect finally kicked in after multiple tries. Mel winces in pain, ouch. What. Her grip on my shirt loosens, while mine gets stronger. It was an crude attempt which I wasn't sure would work. But I am glad it did. I was cutting her Kuret off in her right arm. She crouches down when I twist her wrist. She writes in confused pain, what the freak are you doing to me. She has never experienced a focused pain like this. I see glimmers of her Kuret from her elbow. So that's the limit. I signal Matt to let go of her other arm. Matt gives a shocked wow.

I twist her wrist even further and make her slump on the ground. She tried to punch me in the legs with her freed arm. Just before she reaches me, I twist her whole elbow in an angle she couldn't get away from. She twists her hip as I stand up and I put a palm on her back, keeping her elbow extended up. She kept cursing at me, even while in agonizing pain. I lean in, you aren't used to being restrained like this aren't you. Your Kuret gives me unimaginable strength, where is it now. Her slew of grunting curses still escapes from her lips. I sigh, I turn Matt, I am sorry for this. Tell Cass I had no choice. Sometimes you need to show who is someone's master and who is a bitch.

I intentionally provoke her to catch her off guard. And she did by loosing her body to turn around. That small angle was all I needed. I applied pressure with my Kuret and break her arm by the elbow. She creams with pain and I let go of her. She stumbles down grabbing her other arm. Matt watches in shock and crouches down, David. What did you do that for. I dust of my shirt and tied to spat away from the drinks spilled on the edges. Then I sat back on my seat, she wasn't being corporative. She now knows what happens if she messes with me. I pour myself another glass, all the while Mel writhes on the floor. Matt looks confused and helpless glancing between us.

I gesture him to get a move on. After a lot of contemplating, he says, Mel. Don't do it. You saw it yourself, didn't you. He is not to be messed around. She wriggles and crawls up to the side wall. Even though she is struggling, she is not giving up. She takes support from the wall and leans on it sitting. The arm I broke was twisted in odd angle from the elbow down. I made sure it was a clean break so that there wouldn't be any big damage. I feel a little guilt doing this to Cass, but I hope she can forgive me. Mel was irritatingly stubborn to me. So I had to take a drastic action so she learns to fear me.

And it worked. The red glimmers coming off her was now turning to yellow. Anger mixed with hint of fear. And yet she kept up with a outward expression in defiance. She is nothing but stubborn. I casually resume my drinking. Matt pleads, just hear me out. She wasn't in any mood to listen, but the pain kept her mouth shut. Matt explains her the situation. I got their names bumped up the waiting list and now they can own the house. He began listing out all the benefits to her. A room for just her, no more of those blocker pills. She gets to come out every now and then. Even allowing her to buy her own stuff.

I am impressed by Matt and Cass's resolve to do so much for her. They are essentially giving her more than an identity now. Even in the pain, Matt had gotten through to her. She peeked at me several times while Matt explained to her. I nonchalantly partake in another glass of the rum. If it weren't for Mel's stubbornness, I would have be more amazed by the arrangement Matt laid out. About 10 minutes of Mel grunts, she finally spoke aloud, I don't believe you. I am sure this deed is fake and you are trying to trick me. I stepped in to assure her of this, you don't have to take my word for it. Tomorrow you can visit the place and see for yourself.

He eyes sharpen at me and then turns to Matt, even if that's true. You think I would be okay with this. Living like a prisoner. Matt rebukes her, not a prisoner. But a housemate. You will finally have your own stuff. She scoffs in pain, I don't need stuff. He smiles, that's a lie. I distinctly remember you wanting to wear the skirt. You said you didn't like the skimpy outfit Cass wears. Mel scoffs, its just a silly dress. So what. He answers, its not just that. You have your own favorite dish you like. A song you listen to. So I know you have things you like to have. And now you can keep it with you.

Using that as leverage he begin listing out all the things she liked. Some of them she really didn't care if she had, but some caught her ears. Her own person gym and a foosball table. I didn't know she was a fan of that human game. Matt askes me if I can one for them. I answer, I can get them three if they had the space for it. I threw in a jacuzzi too in their lawn. Of course, they would have to build it on their own, but I can help getting the materials and designs for it. That actually piqued her interest, more than she was letting it show on her grunt refusals.

After Matt finish up's the discussion with a ground rules, he explained the consequences part that Cass mentioned. If Mel ever did anything to break any stuff or take away time from Cass, they are prepared to lock her and Cass inside a basement cell. I cough from my drink when I listen their plan is to build some sort of cage beneath their basement. Matt was very quiet as he explained this part. Glimmers of disgust and fear came from him, but he muddled threw them. Mel spats, lie. You cannot keep me locked up. I can just. Matt cuts her off, this bar will be lined with Kuret blocking Kuritines. The moment you touch it, your Kuret will bounce back.

I see. If she had a Kuret to throw, she had a chance of breaking out. But a physical constraint is a bad compatibility for her. Mel warns him, then I will just go back to sleep and your precious Cass will remain locked up. Matt gives a weak smile, you forget. The cage does not block your Kuret. It just repels it. Cass can anytime pull her Kuret out again, and you will be back in the cage. I can't believe how far these two have planned it. This way, a vicious cycle of both Cass and Mell will keep happen, both of them being locked up. Even Mel is frightened by the prospect of it. She tried to call Matt's bluff, you wouldn't dare do that. You love her.

Matt says, I do. And I want to be with her. We both know this is a desperate play. Cass hates it as much as I do. You have no idea how cruel it is for her to not being able to share a life with me because of you. He then takes a breathe, I take that back. You have idea of what it's like to only live a part of your life. She can never experience Kuret like you, and you can't feel normalcy like her. But this is a comprise she agreed to. And if you agree to it, we can make this work. And as for as the jail thing. That's only if you break the rules. Otherwise you are free to do whatever you want. Cass has accepted this living arrangement if it meant you can restraint yourself when we are together. So, you can either both win, or both loose.

That is probably the most important thing they want from her. Restraining her reckless behaviors. They are employing a sort of a reword and punishment type of system. The kind you train dogs in military. I am going to keep that one to myself. Mel nostrils flairs up knowing she will not like being caged up like a house pet. But she also knows that she if she showed some consideration, then she get her own piece of her house. She won't just be called for battle. The pain in her arm and numbed down, her healing had kicked in a while ago. But it wasn't enough to mend the bones and tendons I broke.

She is quietly thinking about this. I guess, I should show her some compassion now. That will earn some points from her. I prepare a Kuret storm with both my hands. I have been meaning to use the designs Marina gave me. I wrap my Kuret in a spiral oval shape. Then another spiral ring overlapping the previous one but running in different angle for its spin. She was inspired by the centrifugal force of my Kuret vibrations and using some Kuret physics, the ambient Kuret is sucked inside. I am not very proficient with its control. But even with the sloppy and inefficient use, I could see glimmers of pure Kuret forming in the middle.

After a minute, it was barely stable, so I waste no time to use the insignia and turn it into the healing Kuret. The Kuret didn't come out as strong as usual, but it was enough to free her from pain. Her bones slowly mend back in shape and relief washes her from face. I disperse my Kuret and inspect her arm my glimmers. There is still some lingering streaks of red and white mixed in, your should be fine in couple of hours. I see signs for another rebellion. I step forward with a intimidating posture, unless you want another reminder of that pain, I suggest you tone down that temper of yours. I crack my neck and knuckles while sitting back on the chair.

That was enough to stop from any stupid ideas. She stands back up and flexes her arms a little. I kept a cold stare at her, prepared for any hostility from her. She turns back to Matt, I have demands. I didn't expect her to just lay down and roll over. She takes the seat beside mine and grabs the whole bottle. Matt sighs a relief knowing she is open to this. But I wonder what kind of conditions she will put on them now. She raises two fingers from her hand, first. I am not a child that needs allowance or something like that. I will buy or use whatever I want when I am awake. Matt says, that's not going to fly. We aren't going to have enough money to afford your lavish style.

She points the bottle to me, just use this shmuck. He is loaded, isn't he. Matt gets offended, we are not going to ask anyone for money. And David's already got us the house offer. Forget it. Mel drinks directly from the bottle and says, stop your whining. You are such a pathetic guy. She turns to me, what does Cass see's in him. I don't think she is noticing how much she is hurting the poor guys ego. I remained silent and let him deal with this. Matt grabs the middle chair with an annoyed look. He grabs the bottle away from her before she empties it in one gulp and places on the table.

She grunts, the freak you are doing. He spits out, teaching you moderation. You have to learn from now on. She makes a scowl and tried to grab the bottle again. But I grabbed it first, sorry. But I am not finished it with yet. She throws a stare down, but only gives me angry look in the end. She knows who holds her leash. Actually, I had enough drinks tonight. I just didn't want to give her the satisfaction. Matt says, there is a compromise I am prepared to do here. Its tough, but I can convince Cass to let do some side jobs so you can earn the extra money.

That is the most ridiculous and genius idea I have heard tonight. Letting an alter ego earn her own money. That is some mega brain move. Even Mel was not expecting such an answer. She spats, what. You expect me to work. You are out of your mind. Matt rebukes her, no. You are out of your mind if you think we are going to give our hard earned money to you. You always complain to Cass about not wanting to do or have things you don't have. This is your opportunity to have your own freedom. That was such a good point it made Mel question it even more. She thought hard about it, how am I going to get a job.

Matt says, getting one is very simple. Cass will make an arrangement and you take over her. We already have the Kuritine storage that will keep you awake just enough for an hour or two. You won't be able to keep your full strength up all the time, but that's something you already know how to do. And as an added bonus, you won't be able to cause too much trouble. His plan actually made sense. When Cass goes to sleep, Mel takes over. And vice versa. Currently, both their jobs is regular patrols and inspections of the city. So it isn't complicated for Cass or Mel to create a sort of calendar schedules.

The only down side is that this effectively reduces the pay for Cass. I am sure all of them are aware of this. But the upside is they get to live peacefully in the same house. Well, maybe not peacefully. Co-habituating is much appropriate. Mel made a lot of physical annoyance over manual labor. But the freedom to do whatever she wants later is very enticing. After a while she finally relents, fine. Baby sitting few hours a day is such a hassle. What a pain in the ass. She makes it clear she isn't going to like it one bit. But Matt didn't care for her attitude as long she agrees to it. Matt asks, great. What's the other condition.

She grins from ear to ear and lowers her gaze to him, you and her being all intimate is going to be frequent thing. Isn't it. Where is she going with it. Matt and I feel awkward listening about it, but he shakes his head very slowly to her. He says, yeah. Its our house. She chuckles, then I want to experience a physical relationship of my own. I can't let her be the only one who uses our body. My arm slip from the table's edge when I realize what she meant. Freak me, is she seriously implying what I think. Matt kicked away the chair and stood up, you bitch. She laughs so arrogantly amused by our appalled reaction at such a scandalize insulation.

I scoff, you have lost it completely. How much do you resent them to want something like this. She waves her hand to me, stay out it. You are just an eye sore to me. I say I have been relegated to her higher status in her mind if that’s all she thinks of me now. Matt says, tell me you are joking. You are not going to hook up with strangers. She shakes her head, you are so damn naïve. You think she would let me. Even I know she will never allow that to happen. I am not asking some other guy. She points her finger to him. Then it downed on us what is she really meant. The disgust I had was now overridden with a big wave of anxiety.

Matt had the worse reaction. His eye begins to twitch, while his body rigid. Mell continues, why is this such a big deal. I have needs too. If I am going to play roommate, I want to enjoy all of it. She sighs, you aren't my first pick. I rather pick someone like Blake or Danny. Or maybe that hot Derek guy. She turns to me, even you seem pretty decent. But hey, if I am going to be living with you. I might as well enjoy you. I am so lost for words by her outrageous proposal. But even then I had spared a thought whether to be offended that I was low in her list or be glad that I was in it. Or maybe just be disgusted her suggesting it, someone who is almost like a sister to me.

Matt was dumbfounded and couldn't form a single coherent sentence. He finally managed to ask, what the what. Mel says, you aren't half bad. Its a good deal for you. I bet Cass is too vanilla. Who knows, you would prefer a more wild one like me. And besides, you won't be cheating on her. We both are the same person in the end. So come on, wear your big man pants. I know this is very serious situation. But I couldn't resist from laughing. This is messed up, but also the most incredible thing I have ever witnessed.

I stand and walk to Matt placing my palm on both his shoulder, I don't know what you will decide. And I said I was going to remain impartial. But this is an opportunity you can't let go. That pulls him out his daze. He asks confused, you are freaking joking, right. I shake my head, do you know what this means. A menage a trois. His eyes still didn't clear from the haze, a throuple you idiot. And this is a special kind where you still technically in a single relationship. You are the one the most, if not the only luckiest guy in all of Medrone. Be a man and seize this dream of every guy. My enthusiasm broke his trance. He shoves my arms away while I continue to laugh aloud.

He gets annoyed, not funny David. I had to agree, but I couldn't help it. He turns to Mel in a stern voice, is this sort of way to get out of the deal. She stand up behind me and I gave them a bit of space, oh I wish it was that simple. Call it revenge for making me do this. Or a compromise. Whatever works for you. I don't get why its such a big deal. You get to enjoy both of us. She has never shy away from anything, but being bold about intimacy and having sex on such an angry voice has its own sort of charm. I couldn't stifle the guffaws from my mouth on her last comment.

I know I am only irritating Matt, but I seriously couldn't keep a straight face anymore. Mel is asking such a ludicrous demand. But is she though. I am actually very stupefied that they never thought of this before. Or maybe they did but never decided to speak or act on it. After a while I finally calm down while they both stared hard at each other. Obviously, emotionally and morally this is not acceptable. Mel and Cass have some body, but not the same personality. That alone would make a loved one cringe away. However, from a social point of view, this is still an option. Hell, many humans do it openly without having such a technical excuse.

Mel sighs, you are such a wimp. Can't even make a simple ass decision. Arg, you probably want to talk to her about it. Well, good luck loser. Before Matt could give any answer, Mel releases her Kuret and Cass wakes up. Suddenly she bends over to her side clutching her arm, what the hell. What happened to my arm. It hurts. Matt grabs her by her waist and helps her sit on their living room couch. I still have an amusing face on me. which she got confused juxtaposed with Matt's serious and anxious face. She asks, she made a mess didn't she. I answer her because Matt is still too lip locked right now.

She grunts with a slight pain when she moves her arm, damn her. She knows it was futile to attack you. Matt brings over a bag of ice and places it over her elbow. She says, thanks. Much better now. So what happened she was ready to listen. I held back from a laugh, but I am still grinning. Matt didn't find this one bit funny, and I feel for him. But what kind of friend I would be to not enjoy in his awkward misery and envious situation. Cass couldn't fathom why we were behaving so strangely. She asks confused, what did she say that's so damn funny. Then she turns to grim Matt, and why are so upset.

Matt gathers the courage to say, she, had some demands. Cass sighs, of course she does. I swear, if she were physically real, I would wrangle her my own hands. This is my cue to this absurdity, yeah. I am going to let you sort through this. I have done all I can do. Cass, don't get angry with Matt. She made a preposterous demand. And Matt, I have only one thing to say.

I walk out from their living room and open the door, you are one lucky bastard. I honestly envy you. But not the position you are in. Good luck. I left before Matt gets more annoyed than he already was.

Vanessa (Chapter 110)

Monday, March 9, 2026 19:23

Final check of the cruise is completed. Ruther gives me the update while I watch the Heraknus arrive in their cars. Once they park, I signal to Sommers who opens the barricade for the Heraknus to walk in. Blake stands beside me, so we good. I nod, that was the final check. We wait until the Heraknus arrive with Jess. I still reeling from yesterday when David met Catherine. She really didn't arrive today morning. Jess said she is taking a personal day, citing she is sick with Kuretine deficiency. Its not uncommon for people to have it, but its rare in omegas. I never had it even once. But with not many omegas present, she got away with that excuse.

I turn to ask Blake, Catherine really left the island. Blake become slightly annoyed from it, yeah. She messaged me before leaving. Somehow she evaded the border patrols and even the barrier. David really has a way undetected out of the city. When I told Marina, she flipped out. We both thought David was half bluffing. But the guy really has a way in and out of the city. The only good thing about this is that only he knows about it. I am confused about something, won't Catherine know about it too now. Blake scoffs, not unless she was unconscious while he took her. She messaged me after she woke up.

That crazy guy didn't even trust enough to share the route with anyone. Though I understand why he wants to keep it to himself. He would want a sure shot way to escape or bring people in. I ask, you think its good idea for Catherine to leave alone. Blake says, I know. I am concerned too. But she insisted to go alone. But she has been outside with Humans for years. She knows how to avoid detection. Plus, no one can really track her as she assumes different identities. Anyone going with her would get in her way. She didn't give me any good excuse.

It made sense why she was confident. I think many of us forgotten we used to live outside, hiding among the humans. We have become too complacent living for months in the city. But few people have been circumventing the humans much better than us. The most proficient one among us is her. And with the Hive threat at is minimum, she may not be any danger. All to meet her boyfriend. I mumble, admirable or foolish. Blake asks, what was that. I need fix my weird habit of a loose tongue. I shake my head, just thinking when she will be back. Blake says, don't know. From what she told me, I am guessing anytime between tonight and tomorrow morning.

David said something was off about him, but I am only noticing it now. I couldn't ask more once Rory and Melinda came into view. Melinda says, its been another pleasure to visit your city. Blake shakes off his weirdness and says, its our pleasure. Marina tells me you found a good place for your family. She makes a warm smile, I did. It checks out most of the stuff our kids wants. I heard since there will be seven people living together, Marina gave a villa blueprint and also gave the top choice in sector 1. Blake says, I am looking forward to be neighbors. Rory says, yeah. We figured its best to stick with you. I hear a lot of high profile people living in that sector.

Blake chuckles, it wasn't intentional. But it happened anyways. Sector 1 is becoming more lavish and expensive to live. He was subtly telling him they will have to pull their weight if they are able to afford it. Rory nods agreeing that they will have to put effort. Melinda says, that's true. Since you brought it up, I want to ask if you are willing to take Charles as a high ranking officer. Rory asks, and maybe few of us too. Blake didn't look fazed from this question, at the moment, Luther and I will only consider Charles. We would like to conduct a comprehensive check on the responsibilities and abilities he will be undertaking. No offense, but we have certain criteria's to consider.

Melinda says, I heard about it from June and the twins. They said there are other aspects than just being warriors. Blake answers, it would be a mistake if we only recruited people who can fight. We have many non fighters who have other remarkable skills. They both listen earnestly as he praised people others. Luther, Tina, Ruther and Deni. He explained a little about how when more people join, we would recruit more. Rory says, that's a good balance to have. Before the tournament, we heard you were a group of pure warriors. Blake says, that's a common misconception we hope people will learn.

Blake asks about Rory and his siblings. He chuckles, I am not sure about myself yet. But I know Tory wants to join your IDF. That leaves one more elder sibling. I ask about Gina. Melinda says, she is not certain. Though I can see her joining Catherine's team. She has a knack for calming down hot headed people. Sounds like the perfect fit for hers. She looks around, I heard Catherine is sick. Will she be fine. Blake says, nothing to worry about. I back him up, it happens to best of us. Rory says, that I understand completely. Hope she gets better. But what about David. Haven't seem him after yesterday. Blake sighs, I didn't want him to publicly gloat his victory.

He snarls, you mean not meet us, Heraknus. Blake and him have tense atmosphere. Rory breaks it up, I can't argue many of us hold conflicting feelings about him. Something feels different about him. Was his Kuret the only thing changed about him. His intuition was spot on. Blake and I just gave him our silence, expressing confusion and hoping he doesn't deep much further. The Heraknus behind us, boarding the boat, were still on edge from their humiliation. Their pride as legendary bloodline has been called into question by more and more people. Some claim they were just hyped up and at the critical time, screwed the pooch. Their words, not mine.

I still view them a force to be reckoned with. If only we could tell David is on league of his own. Now more than ever. Melinda says, lets not fret over what's done. David is taking on Charles, if he wasn't this powerful, he wouldn't survive Charles overdrive. She talks about it like it was from experience. Then it something clicks for me, Charles said the only people safe are his immediate blood relatives. Does that mean, not even you are. She finishes my sentence, safe? No. I am not. The first time I was shown, he didn't hesitate even a second to tear me apart. Though I understand it wasn't his fault, but I reprimanded him good. I will spare you the details, but there were a lot of begging for apologies from the alpha.

That made us snicker in amusement. However, it reminded us how messed up Charles overdrive is. To not even recognize her own wife. I ask Rory, this may sound strange, but humor me. Now that you have seen David up close, how well do you think he will fare against Charles. I felt a tinge of regret from Rory. But he remained composed to my doubt. He says, if you ask me this two weeks ago, I would treat it as a fantasy. But now. He turn to his step mother. She nods, we chatted a little bit about it as well. And I agree that David is still not at his level. I am fully aware how biased we sound. But that's how we feel.

Blake asks, that's troubling. Rory says, without giving up any clues, dad is an even bigger menace. Think of him as a wild animal that only knows to follow his raw instincts. David played mind games with us, but it won't work on someone who doesn't have much thoughts to spare. I don't deny David's power is not lacking. But against dad. He shrugs, he is still behind. He wasn't being arrogant about it. I think that was his honest opinion, despite the claims he made about David cheating. Blake says, I appreciate your candor. He then chuckles, tell him I look forward to seeing his full strength when we return.

With the conversation concluded, we said our goodbyes and parted ways. Melinda waves to us from the boat as the engines roar to life. We waited at the pier until they cross the border. Ruther messages me that they have crossed undetected into the ocean. After that we all resumed our daily tasks. Blake gave us an update about the construction while we head back to the officer building. Yesterday we had finally started the first batch of Kuritine enrichment. He invited all of us to check out the factory in section 5 whenever we can. It was an important milestone in our efforts to expand the city. This also meant there will be general disruptions to the public.

We held a meeting later where Luther showed a timeline of changes coming soon. Public transport will be stopped for few days as they will the first to get upgrades. This will impact the commute, so they are going to suggest people to take personal cars or carpool with others. The transportation improvement will drastically shorten the time and make it easier for people. A scientist from the Citradel came to the meeting as well. Ivan was gleaming with hope as he should us the designs he came up with after inspecting the city yesterday. He designs were ambitious, but possible over time.

Their focus will be on constructing state of the art houses and enmities on the peripheral houses. Once they are completed, there will be few weeks of usage monitoring and feedbacks. Armed with those beta testing data, they will revamp the inner existing houses and infrastructure. This was slightly deviated from the initial plan Luther and Blake laid out, but Ivan and his reasoned its not a good practice to use enrich untested Kuritine materials directly. This place is open with ambient Kuret denser than Citradel. So there will be issues popping up that they themselves don't know. To avoid delaying the progress, they planned for simultaneous projects so that they don't have to wait for one complete before other. They didn't have that option since they thought we didn't have enough raw materials.

Curtesy of David robbing Citradel, we have an abundance of material. Tina gave her report saying all the mines David seized have nearly dried up and the last of the shipments will arrive in next 4 days. She also mentioned Citradel have continued their effort to steal back some of the ores. Sabotaging trucks, ships and cargo planes. They tried any and all ways to block those shipments. But the latest figured shared by David estimates about 10% to 15% are lost in transit. Marina says that's just what we lost, but David's been self sabotaging the shipments there were intercepted. So technically, Citradel gotten less than 5% of the total mined ores and materials.

Ivan didn't like the wastage of resources from this conflict. Actually, its not just him alone. But many argued David's action were justified at the time. Blake put an end to people's opinion. He censured Ivan for being too idealistic and wanted him to be more pragmatic of the current political climate. He says, science is important no doubt. But we can't ignore other things going on. I think Ivan role was very simple in Citradel, or maybe he was unaware of the dealings outside his purview. But now that they are here, they have to better adapt to this city.

Once the meeting was over, Marina approaches Blake, do you have some time to talk about a concern. She came with the other Citradel high ranking officers. Blake and Luther stayed back and signaled me to join in as well. We take the conversation to his officer. Marina says, Blake. You remember when Melinda told there are new issues happening in Citradel. Blake nods, about that. Fortunately, someone reached out to us after we send out a message to other communities. I realizing he anticipated this and called me to see what I found. I say, an old contact reached out to me personally today morning. She told me about they surveilled the Citradel for a bit.

Marina asks, why. I shrug, I am not sure. Maybe they wanted to gauge what's happening in Citradel after being cornered by us. She heard from someone who heard the intel. So I can't guarantee this. Luther says, I saw read the transcripts. It doesn't look good for the citizens there. June asks concerned, please, just tell us what's going on. With a disappointed tone I answer, a riot happened some time ago. I don't know who instigated or what it was about. All I heard was the church and council were involved. Franks makes a disappointed face, shit. Its worse than I assumed. Chelsea yells, mother of Kuret. June remains shocked and speechless.

Blake says, I wanted to meet you all later, but since you all are here now. Lets check our options. Luther steps in, there are a lot of things to consider. But the priority is to get your loved ones out of Citradel. That made the four of them even more anxious. Marina says, isn't that what you guys have been wanting not to do. Extracting people from Citradel will cause major problems. Luther says, that was before. As bad is the situation, its given us an opportunity. I propose we send out a message to Citradel, asking if anyone needs our help or wants to leave Citradel, we would gladly help them. Frank asks, but the communications are down.

Chealse says, and even if they weren't, the council will not allow people to make their own decisions. Luther nods, I agree. But this will give us some sort of legitimacy. If people leave on their own accordance, we would be blamed. But if we offer our help first, we become favorable. By giving an option, we will be currying peoples trust. That was a brilliant plan from him. Its like those asylum thing I heard from some humans before. June says, isn't David's friend leaving tonight. We don't have the kind of time to do this. Blake nods, and that's why we aren't waiting for the communication of the message to pass over.

He bring his tablet to Marina, I imagine you want your friend to also leave. Marina nods, yeah. I haven't heard from her in a while, but I imagine she is in hot waters. Blake turns to others, we aren't going to wait for things to worse. What Luther told was for posterity. So that when people do notice few people are missing, its because they asked for our help. Which they did, but the timing order was different. Which I hope no will figure it out. Luther adds, that includes people here. Another reason I was involved in this discussion. Once these people come to our city, it will me our job to vet their story.

After contemplating for any potential downside I decided it was worth it. I answer, I can cover their entry protocols. Though, as I understand 3 of them will be special case? I was referring to David's contact and his family. Blake says, let me handle that. I feel David will be involving them without our support. That includes their entry. He is subtly implying about the hidden passage into the city. Its not hard to imagine they will come through that. And I heard that Catherine has already prepared new identities for them. I feel conflicted about people circumventing our security, but since others agree it's worth it for the guy who helped us many times. Even if indirectly.

I made up my mind, then it makes my work even more simpler. That approval washed relief on few people's face. Marina was reading the text on the tablet Blake had provided earlier. She scoffs, is this some sort of transportation checklist. Allergies, medical issues, claustrophobia, nyctophobia, zoophobia and a dozen more stuff. Blake smiles, yeah. I don't even know what half of them meant. David gave it to me a while ago for whenever we decide to go ahead. Write down anything important about the people you want to bring in. others gather around Marina as they scroll down the list.

Luther asks, any idea how we are going to tell the people that they have around 8 hours to leave Citradel. And what about their escape plan. Not even David can reach Citradel right now. Blake says, ever since Citradel went dark, we looked for a way to communicate. Since we don't need a two way communication, the task is easier. I ask, how are you going to do it. He raises his chin well pleased with himself, an old school method. They only have internet and people on lockdown. Unlike us, they can't erect a physical barrier. Humans can go in anytime they want. Everyone realize the simplicity of the plan. We all thought it would be convoluted, but sometimes the right answer is the obvious.

Luther says, won't they have rigorous check on humans coming in and out. He smiles, they do. And similar to David's escape plan, this will only work one time. We will deliver the message to one of the people. It will be their responsibility to inform others. I wish we had a better way, but in the time crunch, it's the best we can do. Marina had filled her friends details and given the tablet to June. She says, that's Jenna's role. I am sure she will let others know. Luther takes her address and other information. I ask Blake about the details of the messenger. It will be a gift delivery from a website that operates in Citradels town.

Naturally, everything that crosses goes through is inspected. But the message he is going to have it written on the card will be written in Greek and German. The people won't look twice to see innocuous message like that. There is a slight chance someone reads it with a translator, but I doubt anyone would care to be this thorough. I turn to Marina, I am guessing you were the one who came up with this plan. She nods, Jenna can read both those languages. And besides, she has a secret admirer for some time who's been sending her bouquets and chocolates few times in that language. I figure this would make it even less suspicious to the security guys.

I don't know who the person was, but she does. Marina makes a scowl and hint of disgust thinking about the person. Maybe she thought such overly brazen way to show affection was too gaudy. Regardless, this was a good cover. I ask, any chance she will not read it. A lot is riding on her. Marina slips out of the anxiety, trust me. She will. She is a sucker for those kinds of things. She will read it out of curiosity regardless the circumstances. Besides, I won't be surprised if the security itself will be lax due to the riots you speak of. She had a good point. They discussed a little more about how the Citradel officers had already informed their families about this a week before.

David was right to let them be informed of this possibility. June says her boyfriend had already packed up everything. He wasn't happy leaving some of his stuff behind, but June made him see reason. He could buy the stuff here anyways. Chelsea's girlfriend was a wild card. She says, I don't know if she will go with this. The last time I spoke, she said she couldn't leave her friends behind. I got so mad at her, she hung up on me. Her distraught eyes made us give some sympathies. Luther asks, anyway to convince her. Maybe pass a message along in the letter to Jenna. Chelsea thought about it for a moment, I can try. I won't forgive myself if something happens to her while I am here.

I gave her a bit of encouragement telling it will be fine. I reminded her, the situation has changed. She would surely see the benefit in leaving after seeing the riots. That gave her hope with a little light in her eyes. Frank says, I had a terrible thought. What if the riot was hidden from people. I mean, its unlikely that people didn't notice it. But its Citradel we are talking about. I didn't even knew there were fires that was intentionally lit to burn down our farm. Damn. None of us thought about it until now. I was so preoccupied about the riots itself, I never bothered to think it could have been swept under like the other incidents Blake revealed that day.

Blake and Luther dawn a distressed expression. Marina says, freak. That's possible. We haven't seen anything in the local Human news also. Right. So the council definitely kept it under wraps. Blake says, is there a way for them to confirm the riots. I recall the message I had received earlier, unfortunately I didn't get any details, like people or location. Not even any physical evidence like a photo or something. Luther brings his fingers to his chin, I didn't see either. But maybe there is another way. He drops his arm, Blake, do you know who David's contact is ? Blake gives a curious nod. He wasn't going to tell who they were though.

Luther asks, whoever they are, they must be well connected to inform David things other tried to hide. Why not have Jenna verify it from them. Surely an incident like this wouldn't have escaped their eyes and ears. Blake turns to Marina who provides a nervous nod, yeah. That could work. Actually, it will work in our favor. I am sure Jenna and others will know the severity of the situation and encourage to leave. Chelsea and June agreed to this immediately. Frank was skeptical, but he didn't object to this. Blake says, David's contact was always going to meet them during their escape. Meeting a bit earlier wouldn't be a big problem. Lets do that.

I had a thought, so he already knows that others are going to escape with his family. He answers, he does. David informed him of the possibility. This eases Franks anxiety. I guess he was having similar doubts. Soon everyone filled up the questionnaire on Blakes tablet. After glancing over them he says, is that all. We don't have time to change anything after I send it to David. Hour nods made it official. Luther says in a low tone, I guess we are officially breaking out people from Citradel now. It's a political nightmare, but its also a little bit interesting. I wonder what kind of escape route they have to question such weird safety checklist.

That made many of us also anxious. I think I saw question about if they were afraid of animals. Is David planning to bring them in a animal shelter program? Whatever it was, I am sure it was constructed in a way Citradel won't be able to detect. The meeting was over and people got to work. Marina and Blake worked on crafting the message with others input. Luther prepared to send out a help relief message. My role was going to be later, so I excused myself and went to IDF to prepare for their entry.

I needed to give an entry permit to the border team and Deni as well. I told her it was sensitive issue and she was not to tell anyone about it. To assure her that this was approved I explained, talk to Blake or Luther. They know what we just talked about. Deni lips morph into a relief smile, I will. I guess its about June and the others. Their concerns they told us a week ago. She guessed right, but I wasn't going to explain it to here where there are prying eyes. She understood it was a matter of urgency and not to be disclosed. She gestures an okay sign to me and leaves to prepare the orders.

With that bit of arrangement done, I resumed my work. I had the task of viewing the latest arrest reports and smuggled item confiscation. It was some sort of early century pot looking artifact. I knew now that I couldn't really judge its value based on appearance alone. So far we have collected 42 of these items and there are still two dozen people left on the disk. We had retrieved the whole list few days ago, but the people weren't dumb. They used aliases and fake addresses. Our focus has switched from decrypting the list to associating the alias with people. The saving grace is that we know what item was sold, so we Tessa's team has been able to investigate the items.

While I was listening to a video interrogation of our latest culprit, I heard a knock on my door. It was Ruther, he peaks in, hey Vanessa. Someone's here to meet you. That's strange, I don't have any appointment now. Its around 7:30 tight now, my schedule was clear. I ask, who is it. If possible, tell them to meet tomorrow. I am just about to wrap it and clock out. He hesitates for a second, its well, Ned. He wants to speak to you. I pause the video immediately and froze up for a second. What is he doing here. After nearly two weeks of deliberately ignoring me he is coming to me here. Ruther was probably being weirded out seeing that I was icing my boyfriend.

I clear my throat, tell him I am busy. It was a blatant lie which both of us know. But his nervousness didn't dissipate, actually, he was very adamant he needed to speak with you. He is already inside and waiting in the lobby. I didn't want to kick him out. He seems, I don't know how to say it, desperate probably. I can't believe this. No, actually I can. We have been ignoring each other for almost two weeks. And David told Ned confronted him. Its not a coincidence he approached me now. I felt my cheeks turning hot from my heart beat. I wasn't mentally prepared to face him. I know I had to eventually talk to him, but I have been procrastinating this very conversation.

I remained silent for so long that Ruther asks me for in a soft tone, ah, Vanessa. What should I say to him. I didn't have the courage to give him an answer. He says, maybe I should tell him you are busy. His attempt to cover for me jolted me out of my anxiety, no. Sorry. Let him in. He raises his voice back to normal, you sure. Because you kind of looked. I added abruptly, its fine. I was just wondering about something else. Give me a minute and then send him here. He stares at me for few seconds. I thought he attempt to decide against me, but he nods and leaves. I close my laptop and decided to switch seats to the couch. I don't know why I am so self conscious of him being here.

I waited in tense anticipation for his arrival. My mind went racing in all direction. It had to be David. He said something earlier, saying I should either fix our relationship or end it. I don't doubt that he said something very similar to him. I was lost in thoughts and didn't notice the door open. I restrained my thoughts and gather them to focus on this. Ned walk in with a concerned expression, Vanessa. That's all he said as he stands there gawking at me. I should say something, but seeing his face brought all the bitterness back from slumber. The times he coldly ignored me. Even when we were in the same room, he gave me indifferent look.

He saw the anger underneath my skin despite the stern expression I had. He gesture to the seat beside me. I didn't give any permission, but he was too awkward to keep standing like this. He didn't wait for my approval and took the seat. Suddenly my temper explodes, why did you come here. Of the all places. This is where I work. Have you no shame. He gives a hesitant look, I didn't have a choice. You avoid my messages, never reply and never let me visit at your home. Most of the times we both are too busy. I scoff, seriously. That's all you got. You could have met me other times, post meetings in officer building, lunch time or even at the training center. So don't give me such pathetic excuses.

He sighs, you are right. I am tired of avoiding this with excuses. But why are being angry about this. I didn't see you making any attempt. Did you like watching me suffer in solitude. I reached out to Siera immediately after the tournament. And few times after then too. I even tried to see at you home, where you kept dodging me. So don't be mad at me just because its easier to blame me. He infuriated me with his cold logic. But I already knew all that, what would be the point. You remember the meeting on the day Citradel council left. You dreadfully ignored me. Like I didn't even existed. Did you really believe that wasn't you hinting how you felt about me.

He got a little annoyed, I didn't want to behave like that. But you were getting on my nerves. You think only you have the right to be angry. That I can't be mad at you instead. That thought had occurred to me. But I didn't care. That attitude pissed me off so much, I didn't want to seem him. Didn't matter how long he persisted. He sighs, this is wrong. I didn't came here to make things worse. I ask, then what did you come here for. An apology. Sorry, you are mistaken. Whatever guilt I felt in my part, that's long gone. If you hadn't given me that attitude that day, maybe I would have listened to you.

He pushes his lips to show more anxiety, like I said. We both angry doesn't solve anything. We didn't make the right decisions. I know I didn't. I am not expecting you to admit that anyways. I know I was an ass, but don't deny you weren't being unreasonable. I was about to flip him off, but I held back when I recalled the conversation I had with Matt and Cass. I said I don't feel guilty about that anymore, but it was a half lie. It still bothers me. Same way it does when I think about how I defend my brother to David. He didn't say it outright, but he implied I wasn't being fair with him too.

Ned interpreted my hesitance to acceptance. He says, do you see that now. Don't you. I remained silent calming myself. I should be angry, but not like this. Not for the wrong reasons. He continues, I didn't come here for an apology. Nor did I come here to give one. I wish I say I was shocked, but his demeanor was apparent. He says in low tone, did you know I talked to David. I scoff, talked? He told me you confronted him in the middle of a crowd. He is surprised I already knew, I sort of did. And he told you about that. He shakes his head, something changed about him. I can't explain what or how.

I didn't want to explain anything to him. He says, I don't know what he told you. He told me something along the lines of resolve our issues or break it off. I was right, he did gave us like an ultimatum. I think I heard him telling the same thing to Catherine. I don't understand why he suddenly became so passionate about butting into our personal business. I have all sorts of conflicting emotions from his actions. Should I be glad he cares so much or be even more mad at him. Ned says, he called me out on my excuses. Like you did just now. And that's why I am here. I don't want to avoid this anymore. I don't like how it happened, but I am glad I did it.

I ask, if you are not here for an apology or ask for one. What are doing here. He takes a brief moment to settle something in his mind. He whispers, I want explain why I was angry with you in the first place. That's not something he needed to tell me, I know why. You were being an ass with me. You got offended too much just because I angered you. He snarls, no. I mean, yes. Here you go again. Do you still think I shouldn't have my own opinion. Even Catherine was betting on Charles. Why do you keep insisting I was being unfair to you. I bark, Catherine had a grudge towards David at the time. You didn't. All you had was statistics, that you used to demean me.

He lowers his angry voice, that's not completely true. I ask, which part. You waited just that moment to humiliate with the number of people against David. He says, I didn't mean that. But, just to clarify, I am still justified about that. You can't be angry at me alone. There are ton of people who didn't know David back then. He then closes his eyes for a second, I digress. I was angry about the bet. I have to come realize I was angry about something else entirely. My brows arch at the confusion. What realization is he talking about. He says, it was him. David. The way you instantly went to defend him, it ticked me off.

All the frustration and anger I held turn into bemusement. My fist that was so tense, become even tighter. He adds, it wasn't just that. You spent so much time with him in the flag capture game. Instead of me. And even before, you both spent years with each other. While I didn't share the past, except in your stories to each other. He makes a shameful face, I was. He lost his words. I hesitantly ask, jealous? Of him. Seriously? That made him annoyed, of course. Why wouldn't I be. You are two are so close lately. I heard people taking that you both are also fighting. I was sure he tried to make a move on you because of our fight. That's why I confronted him then.

I am so flabbergasted that my thoughts left my mouth stunned. I couldn't bring a single word to explain how utterly insane that was. I blurt out, why in the world would you believe that. He slumps on the chair, you already said it. I was jealous of him. He seems to know more about you than me. I already knew that, but I didn't know it would effect me so much. And back in the VIP room, I couldn't take it anymore. Its embarrassing that I was so insecure about you and him. You have to see how close you two are. Can you blame me for thinking that. This brew my emotions into a turmoil. I can't deny much of what he said. But I knew what to tell him.

I open my mouth, there is nothing between us. Now more than ever. He jerks ahead, meaning there was something before. That caught me of guard. Its my turn to be mortified now. I can't deny I am attracted to him. But I wouldn't act on it. Not when I was with Ned. Then it downed on me a thought so shameful I couldn't bring myself to even think about it. Ned says, I know you didn't cheat on me. Maybe it was silly of me to even believe that. But the guy is too impressive for me not to worry. I hate that he is become so strong lately. Want to know something bad. I was so envious of him, I was wishing he be defeated by the Heraknus trio.

He waves his arm in anger, but behold the great David. He pulls out another trick. And this is after he already pulled something so messed up as copying Kuret. Think how I feel when I saw he can do what I can do. I know its not the same, but still. He isn't even an alpha, and yet he is now trying to reach heights of overdrive users. Do you know what he is doing today. Working out in the training center. Even I think how strong he already is, it terrifies me how strong he will become later. He places his palms on his face, like trying to hide under it. He scoffs, who wouldn't be jealous of a guy like that who is so close to his girlfriend.

I could feel just how resentful he was from his guilt ridden expression. I never once thought he held such feelings towards him. I can't believe I never saw signs of this before. His confession left him pale and defeated. His hands slips from his face, that’s what I was angry with you. Not because of some silly bet. I thought we would resolve it without me ever revealing this. But then the guy pressured me into believing I should either fix things with you or break up to stop hurting both of us. I was so infuriated the way he said. But what he said wasn't wrong. I don't want us to end. So this is me, reaching out. Hoping you can understand the real issue with us.

My breathing felt so heavy, it was like I was scared of it. Partly, because the shameful secrete he told me. And because I was confused at my own feelings. Is that why I have been so angry at David. He betrayed me. No, it can't be. I am mad at him because he thinks my brother is not the person I think he was. But then I recall the conversation I had with Siera. That had opened a whole new perspective. But that’s all why I am angry at him. But then why does it hurt when Ned pointed it out aloud to me. Ned sees my convoluted expression, this is why I didn't want to tell you. Because I just mess things even more.

I couldn't refute that. Now it makes sense why he suddenly got angry at the VIP room and has been for so long. I can't tell how he handled was right. But how can I judge him when I am responsible my own horrible ways to avoid having this talk. I murmur to him, where does it leave us then. He closes the gap between us, I told you, it was my pride or ego getting in the way. But David told he didn't have anything to do between us. I am hoping we can move past this now. I know its not fair to ask you to be okay with this. I am asking you to understand me for feeling this way. I don't want to lose you. And at the risk of being arrogant, I am sure you don't want to either. So please. Lets not give into hatred and jealousy.

I am speechless. His earnest request to move past this was genuine. But I didn't have the answer he was asking. I tell him in a somber voice, maybe you knows what to do. But I don't. I understand what really happened. I didn't know you had such petty side. I am sort of glad you told me. But maybe that’s my fault for not noticing you were hurting this much. He scuffs beside me and grabs my hand. His hands felt warm to touch. Like I have been missing it. He shouts, no. This isn't on you. It's a guy thing. Or rather, its my thing. I told you I am not here to apologize, but if that what it takes. So be it. I am so sorry that I got angry at you. It wasn't about you at all.

I didn't exactly feel any relief hearing that from him. I thought him apologizing was what I needed the most. Hoping that would magically fix the problem. But nothing of that sort occurred. The only thing left was embarrassment and regret. I grip his hand, I know this sounds strange. But I need some time to think. He nods, its not strange. Its normal. Take your time. But please, don't break up with me. Not for this. Those moist eyes of his made me realize how much this was hurting him. The constant weight he was carrying all this time, something I didn't notice.

I gave him a nod. His gloomy face perked up like a child. I don't want to break the trust he was giving me by telling his selfish feelings. I don't want to throw away our relationship. Not for Ned. Not for anyone. But. What about David. That single thought made my heart ache.

David (Chapter 111)

Wednesday, March 11, 2026 20:17

Sweat is dripping from my entire body. For two days, I have been training ceaselessly. I have been doing only five things. Eat, shit, sleep, train and strategize. I have completely zoned out everything else. No more distractions. I heard what Rory told Blake yesterday. Normally, he would be biased since it was his dad. But he had a lot of time to think about it. If that's the conclusion he reached, then I am sure he had a reason to believe I was still lacking. The one reason he did gave away was correct. My usual tactics wouldn't work on a person who can't think clearly. They are the most dangerous kind of opponents. Spontaneous and strong.

I preparation, I have been following Blakes guidelines. Using Kuret do the work for me, instead of my muscles. I didn't have much choice with the impromptu Heraknus fight. That was an emergency. And it was clearly evident that I was no where ready to fight at that capacity. Not when it meant joint sprains and shoulder dislocations. So I back to basics, learning to control this form of Kuret. I have been performing basic target defense and attack with just my Kuret. So far I have gotten the hang of it. Using M to track my unconscious reflexive movements, I am slowly improving. I still flex out my limbs few time in practice. Can't be helped, it's a habit.

I also drew out a whole regiment with Blakes help. Another two days of Kuret control training and then comes Kuret assisted movement training. He has shared some thoughts on how to better control my Kuret while I move. Till now, I was focused on a balance of efficiency, precision and endurance. But now I need to add Kuret control. It will be hard to add it to the mix I have been learning for years. But I feel confident about this. Especially since my brain has been rewired. Apart for social behavior changes, the main changes are of course to how I handle my Kuret. Like Drew said, few days in and I have begin to feel better than ever.

Today was a satisfying day. I was able to form different physical shapes with my Kuret. Like how do it with my dome. I am beginning to think I don't need to exert that kind of strain anymore. The experience of how I used my Kuret in the middle of the match with Charles was helping me. A wall, a thin blade and spikes. I can still see vestiges of the exploding Kuret time to time. There is still so much to learn. The Kuret threads are grouping on me is also not yet stable. I feel its still slow, because I have to keep them running on my body all the time. It would be much easier if I could make them move without mental effort.

One step at a time. Am I sure it will became as natural as breathing. A quaint notion Blake said it to me while explaining his ideas. The sun is almost gone as I walk back to my house. With no public transportation, I had to walk all the way. My car is still in the garage. I could have it fixed, but I wanted to try some of the Kuret assisted sprint. Though I quickly realized I was getting ahead of myself. I ran for a while, but I didn't have any coordination and hit few poles and buildings as I ran. Few people that did saw me were shocked and amused at my failed attempts. For the time begin, I will borrow someone's car from tomorrow.

M chimes in after a while from my watch, boss. I have an update about our contact in Citradel. I halt and take shade under a tree. M relays the message through the ear piece. They have crossed the first checkpoint safely. That's excellent news. M says, however, my analysis shows there will be even a bigger delay for the next checkpoint. The increase in cargo containers will add more scrutiny. The contact organizing the transport says expect delays for at least a day. We can't help it. There are now eight involved in this extraction. But this should be good news for the Citradel officers who have been worried about their loved ones whole day yesterday.

I tell M, send a message to Marina, June, Chelsea and Frank detailing the routes and checkpoints. We should be getting a photo or video proof. Send those too. M says, reminder set. Thinking back, I never expected Citradel to be in such a chaos that I would have to extract Jack like this. Protests was one thing. But riots. And particularly one that involves the church. Between Ryes betrayal and this insurrection, there had to be a connection. Maybe there is none, but I had a nagging feeling that this isn't all about the religious devotion to the overdrive people. That's I have, a mild intrigue. I am a hemisphere away and far to busy to do anything about it.

My thoughts drifted to Catherine. She had an exhausted look on her face after I saw her boat coming from the horizon. When our two speedboats dock, I ask, so, how was it. She gave me a weak smile, you don't know. I shrug, I only got rudimentary reports, like location and timings. Didn't want to pry into both your lives. She nods, I appreciate that. Really. She picks her bag and hands it over to me while boarding my boat. I tried to see her glimmer, but most of it was just exhaustion. I am sure the continuous traveling and changing identities had to leave her burnt out.

I programmed the auto pilot on the boat to return back to the hideout it came from. While returning back to the island barrier, Catherine kept quiet and just looked far off into the ocean. I would be lying if I saw I wasn't eager to know what happened. But I didn't want to force her to answer me. 15 minutes before we reached the island border, she speaks up, I am sorry. Its just a lot happened. I am trying to figure out how best to explain. She had a despondent expression. So either they broke up or something else bad happened. I attempted to raise her spirits. The only way I know. I twist my neck to her, I have some idea. You spent half the day in some hotel room.

My grin gave away the nasty thoughts I had. She looks away flustered, hiding her face. That actually caught me by surprise. I was only joking, but did they really spend half the time having sex. She cries out, you don't have to be crass about it. I don't think there was any other way to see it. I turn my back to her and focused on navigating the water. A while later she stands beside me with a small sigh, we got carried away. I am not going to deny that. I only smiled without looking at her. She says, we haven't seen each other in months. And I don't know how long it will be next time. That line gave me a chilling pull in my guts.

Damn it. So they didn't break up. This was supposed to be the end of it. I was hoping she gave him a break up romp in the bed. My disappointment slipped through my amused façade. She says, you are upset. I reply, no. well, a little bit. I promised not to butt in. Didn't say anything about not having an opinion. But its your decision in the end. She says, I couldn't do it. I couldn't tell him that I didn't want to leave the island. I thought I would have the courage to tell him. He was so happy and I felt guilty taking it away in the same day. I remained silent, hoping to avoid saying anything I would regret. I knew how incredibly difficult it is to know something to be right, and yet act on it.

She continues, we love each other. It's enough for now. For now is okay, But what's comes next for them. I don't think she leave her responsibility to be with him. So they decided to just continue this. Meeting once in few months. How long can they keep it up. Until they can't? It took a lot of restraint for me to not judge them. I understand matters of love is irrational, but they are pushing the bounds of it. I ask, is Robb really fine with this. He gets to talk to you for a day only. And when you do meet, its under surveillance. She closes eyes hiding her wave of emotions. The glimmers revealed the truth though. Shame and anger.

She gathers her words, we spoke about that in length before we left the hotel. He had the same concerns. Not seeing each other is cruel. So, we have found a way to contact each other. An encrypted video link over the internet. Its not the best, but we can work it out. A very convoluted type of long distance relationship that has no end goal. That's their solution to fix their relationship. I almost told her this was a bad idea. But I closed my mouth before I said anything that would ruin me again. I say, all the communications are monitored in and out from the island. How are you going to talk to him.

She turns to me with suspicious eyes, I am hoping you can help with it. Can you ask Ruther to give me unrestricted access for that link? We are going to need it every alternate days. I gave a flat response, yeah. No can do. I did enough to fix my mistake. You know my feelings about it. I won't stop you. But I won't endorse it either. If you want that link to be active, you should talk to him yourself. She wasn't surprised by my reaction. Maybe she already knew I wasn't going to help her with this. She smiles, I know. Just had to ask.

She looks away to the ocean, you already did a lot. It was just a silly thought. I should take responsibility for my own decisions. I know it doesn't make any sense to you. But I can't just cut Robb out of my life. I want to hold on every second I have with him. She faces me again, what would you have done if you were in my position. She put a reversal question to me now. Honestly, I already knew what my answer was. But I am hesitant to give it her because I know she wouldn't like it. So I just stayed quiet hoping she lets it go. But she wasn't backing down, tell me. I want to know. She pleads with a soft voice. With a heavy sigh I reply, I would have ended it.

She stares at me for a while, gauging my reaction. She says, how can you say that without hesitation. I didn't want to sound like a know it all. But since she asked, I should tell her about it. I ask, how much do you know about Sophie Monroe. She answers after giving it some thought, isn't that the daughter of Robert Monroe, the guy who you. I step over her voice, killed. Yeah. That's her. Most of you believe that I was just close with Sophie because our target was Robert and his connection with the Hive. But it wasn't simple as that. Talking about Sophie brought up the memories I had with her.

I tried to focus on only the good things, but I would be delusional to not be guilty about the bad things. She nervously ask, wait. You mean, you and her. I gave a nod. At the time Catherine was infiltrating the Valley, so she knows about Liz and me. But not what happened in San Francisco. She asks, I don't believe it. How did I not know about that before. I wave my hand at her, it was a long time ago. And one of the worst mistakes I ever did. If you saw me back then, you would see a guy believing he could have it all. In the beginning Sophie was just a means to get close to her father, but I got infatuated with her. She asks, does anyone knows about this.

I scoff, you think I like advertising something like this. That I was once in love with her. I am sure Cass, Blake and Vanessa have some idea about it. But I hid from everyone. Catherine was amazed that I was more or less in the same situation as her. She asks, but how. She was a human you just met. Its embarrassing to talk about it with her, but I had to tell her why I did what I did. I reminisce about the time with Sophie, I was naïve. Without my memories and it had been about 18 months into my new life of war and death. I was holding on a single strand of normalcy. And by some twisted coincidence, it was her. And she is still the most unique and fascinating person I have ever met. Her personality was alluring to me and I couldn't stop myself from being interested in her.

Catherine gawks at me like I was telling her a made up story. She asks, what the hell. You never once told me you were this serious about her. She then leans forward, did you two ever? Her words trails off but I gathered what was implying. I shake my head, no. But we came very close to it once or twice. I didn't want to take advantage of her, more than we were already doing. Catherine asks disappointed, you mean you chickened out. She goads me intentionally, call me whatever you want. I was being foolish, thinking there was any future with her. Every time we get closer, I pull away before it became serious. I realized what a mess I was entangling her in.

She knew what happened in the end, so I didn't had to explain it to her. She asks, but it ended because you shot her father. I answer, that's not entirely right. Liz made me realize I was being delusional. Forget about us two being aliens to each other, I was going to destroy her life in ways she didn't know. I was putting her in danger just by being near her. So a few days before the day everything went to crap, I broke it off. She says, just like that. She didn't fought back. I remember the time she showed the hint of emotion. I had broken her heart so bad she actually felt it. I tell, she wasn't completely okay with it. But I know doesn't have any regret.

Catherine rebukes me hard, how can you say that. Guys are so dumb. I needed to explain some things to her for her to understand, I am not being facetious. Sophie isn't like your normal human being. I told you, she is very fascinating creature I have ever met. She didn't buy it, doesn't matter. I know she lost her father later, but at the time you didn't know that. You could have made it work still somehow. Or maybe you could have said some good fake excuse. Now it makes sense why she is after you. Its not just about her dad, its personnel. I wait for her to calm down. Once she did, I ask, are you done. She gave me angry face.

I say, first of all. Don't try to make this about you and Robb. I am telling you all this because I wanted to show that I made a hard choice. So I know how you feel, how agonizing it is when you make up your mind, but back away when you are in front of them. It was a mistake to get involved with her in the first place. Case in point, she joined FBI to kill me. So don't assume I did it because it wasn't hard for me. That made her back off me. I know she meant well, but I wasn't going to be guilted by her own personal drama. I continue, secondly, I didn't need to make any story for her. Not because I didn't care. Its because she doesn't.

That made Catherine confused, what. I explain, she is a highly intelligent functioning psychopath. A diagnosed one, not a metaphor for her behavior. She doesn't feel remorse or guilt. And certainly doesn't have normal feelings of love. So when I say the reasons don't matter, because she wouldn't care why I broke up with her. Catherine stood there with her jaws dropped. Coincidently we were near the border, so I turned off the engine. Now there was just the waves of the ocean and a discombobulated Catherine. She finally find's her voice, say that again. I sigh, you heard me. I am not going to repeat that.

I walk to her rucksack bag and begin wrapping it in a plastic sheet. She scurries behind me, the freaking hell. You were in love with a honest to god psychopath. Mother of Kuret. I face her annoyed, see. This is why I don't tell people. Imagine what would people think of her, or well, me. She is horrified to know the truth about Sophie and me. I think she is getting the wrong idea, she isn't like the one you have heard in TV. She is manipulative, selfish, but only to a point. She hasn't hurt anyone or anything. Well, I can't say for sure now. She is intelligent though. A rare type of person, so she understands basic morality. That's one of the things I liked about her.

I didn't even realize I was rambling and completely distracted from the main point. I reeled in the emotions swelling up in me. Catherine gazes at me anxious. I say, I went off topic. I would appreciate it if you don't tell anyone about her. In my mind I relayed, especially Vanessa. She gives a very small nod, ah. Okay. I can see it's a sore topic for you. But why tell to me that just to prove a point. I sigh as I take the bench beside the railing. She takes a spot beside mine. I take off my shades and close my eyes, resting my head on the grills.

I say, because I don't have anyone to talk to about this. As much as it pains to me, you are probably the only person I know who knows what I have gone through. A relationship between a Medrone and a Human. How many do you know there are like us. Or better yet, how many do you know of. She leans back understanding my point, that's true. Quite a troublesome pair we are. I blurt out, tell me about it. Since I got my memories, I have been hording secrets and feelings that was in a way making me sick. Drew say it was PTSD, or Ketriya, but who the hell knows. So I don't want to keep hiding, even from myself. That's why I am telling you this.

She asks, and what about now. Do you still lover her. I open my eyes and stare at the open clear blue sky. I say, tell me, if you break up with Robb, would you have been still in love with him. She gets silent at my question. I answer for her, its complicated. Right? Well, for me, I feel obligated to say its over. I used to love her. At least that's how I want it to be. Because there is zero probability that's happening again. Besides, I still have the memories of us together. All the social experiments we used to do. Or the running joke how she can't tell why people blink. I feel I am okay with loving her, in those memories. If that makes sense.

I used to feel a compulsion to hide embarrassing feelings. But now, I am at ease talking it aloud. At least to the right people. Catherine says, you know, I still am not used to be see you so open about stuff like this. Now she is just teasing me. I put the shades back on my eyes, so now you know. What I would have done in your shoes. Or more to the point, I have already done. She brings her arm against the railing, its not the same though. She had a good point, that's true. Robb knows and accepts who you are. But everything else is the same. He and you live in different world. Very different. To be clear, this is not me judging you or him. But its plain facts.

She becomes forlorn, you remember what you said few years ago. When you found about us two. I recall the time we were looking for the weapon Hive was hiding. She continues, that this will not last. It has an expiration date. I was so mad at you back then. But you were thinking about Sophie back then too. Weren't you. I answer, I was. That was wrong of me to force it on you both. But again, I am not making you do anything. Just expressing my concerns. In the end, you do what your heart tells you. No matter what others say. Even if that's me. She chuckles at my suggestion, if only that were so easy.

I hear M's beeping, all right. Its time. I stand up prepared for her to bring her back, I have done all I every say or do about this. Its your decision in the end. I just don't want to be blamed if things go wrong, deal. That's rude to mention, but I wanted to be very clear about that point. She stand beside me with a determined expression, I understand. Thank you for doing all this. And trust me, whatever happens from now on. Its not on you anymore. I am glad you told me about Sophie too. But trust that I have so many questions about her. I shake my head with a smile. I shouldn't have told her. She won't let go of my questionable past relationship.

I begin to gather the Kuret in my hands. She turns a little irritated, do we have to do this way. I am not going to tell anyone. I chuckle, I am not worried about that. I can't have you leave the island every time you get hungry. That joke earned my an jab at my shoulder. After that I took a unconscious Catherine back inside the island without anyone knowing. Once at the shore on sector 3, she went home to sleep in few hours while I went to training center. Where I have been entire day working on my Kuret control. I honestly don't know what's going to happen with her. I am concerned she will never be able to make a decision. Seeing her continue like this, stuck here without moving on, I rather she left the island. Even if that is completely selfish and unreasonable to others, at least she be happy in that case.

Just few meters before I reach my house, M says, boss. You have an unexpected visitor. I groan with annoyed shout. Since my show off with Heraknus, I have been continuously hounded by people. Some don't believe it really happened, and many didn't care. But few have become obsessed. At the beginning, it was enduring. But now its slowly turning creepy. I gave a five minute interview yesterday to tell people that I need to focus on my training and not to disturb me. Not that I expected it will shoo away everyone. But I expected some distance for the ones who kept creeping at my house. Blake offered officers to guard, but that would be too condescending.

I ask M, who is it. I raise my watch and a hologram comes out of the surveillance camera outside the house. There is a blue car waiting at some distance. I don't recognize it. M runs the GPS signature to identify who was it. Molly, a cashier from sector 5. Don't know who that is. M shows the car's been here for more than an hour. How persistent is Molly. When my house is in view, I side step from the cars view. Well, Molly, unfortunately I am too exhausted to meet you. I would use my Kuret to hide my presence, but that be overkill. Besides, I needed to make her see that I am not interested in taking anyone right now.

I quickly make my way through the driveway hoping she doesn't see me until I was in. But no such luck. I hear the car door opening and a person's footstep approaching me. I increased my pace like a burglar running to his own house. Molly comes running yelling, wait. David. Is that you. I just need five minutes. The voice made my legs slow down and my eyes wide. That familiar voice was unmistakable. I turn my neck to see Elina in a coat, running at me. I gulped hard seeing her frantic expression. I should have rushed inside my house. But my mind was racing to figure out why she is here.

Did someone tell her about me. Who. Blake, Nathan, Marina, Catherine, Tessa. Or maybe Vanessa. No, why would anyone do that. I erased my involvement with her and the criminals. Does she know that I was Mack too. Before I can figure out, she stood beside me. She says, sorry to barge in like this. But please. I am not here to freak you out. I just want to talk with you. Its important. I small air passes through my lips. She doesn't appear to know who Mack really was. I pull of my hoodie and take off my shades. She gets nervous staring at her. I should say something, she herself is getting anxious from my silence.

But what to should I do here. Do I tell her to leave me alone, or tell her to come tomorrow. But that's delaying the inevitable. And who knows, maybe she did came here just because she is a fan. A small wishful hope still lingered in my mind. I ask her, and you are? She hesitantly says with a deep eyes, I am Elina. Nice to meet you. I tested her a little. Well, so far so good. I gesture my hand towards the door. The tense atmosphere begins to dissipate as we step into my house.

I take off my jacket and put in on the hanger, you look troubled by something. I am not sure what you want from me. She reply's, again. I am sorry to interrupt you. I know you are very busy. But I had to meet you. I have not been keeping tabs on her, but the last I heard she was still on a semi house arrest. She doesn't leave her house except for daily necessities. Even that she had purchases in bulk last week and hunkered down. Since I already invited her, lets see how this plays out. I gesture her to the couch, can I get you anything. She replies as she takes a seat at my couch, thanks. I am good.

I answer, well I am thirsty. Care to wait for a minute. I need to take a protein shake and probably get changed. She nods her head and wriggles a little in her seat. I quickly walk away and prepare my drink in the kitchen. Once I turned on the machine, I left to change out of my sweaty clothes. This is not I imagined seeing Elina. Certainly not like this and not in my own home. While she waited patiently, I hurriedly cleaned myself and put on fresh clothes. By the time I arrived back out, the drink was done. With a bottle in hand, I sat next to her. She caught me off guard earlier, but I had settled my thoughts enough to make a poker face.

So, what can I do for you Elina. I take a sip from the bottle. She says, do you know about the incident at the water plant two weeks ago. I make a show of snapping my fingers, that's where I remember that name from. You are the one who got tangled up in that business. I put the bottle aside, it must have been harrowing experience for you. I heard you siblings were there too. She becomes upset as I mention their name, yes. Peter and Ryan. My baby brother was there while I nearly died. A regretful expression appears on my face, I heard. I am glad you survived though. And what about Ryan. How is he faring.

She takes a moment while she gives me a hard look. She is trying to see something from my reaction. What game is she playing here. Finally she says, he is better now. First few days he was so terrified he couldn't speak or do much of anything for days. He wouldn't let me out of his sight as well. Its taken some time and counselling to get him on his feet. I tell her, that's good to hear. He seems resilient. And you. You nearly died, must be difficult to get over something so dreadful. She nods, it was. I was being held at IDF for a while, so the shock hadn't gotten a hold on me. But when I went back home, and be alone, I had a crash out.

She is trying to best hide her fears, but I could see the faint glimmers of resentment. Yet she seems better now. At least physically. I waited for her to tell her reason to visit me. Didn't seem the right to ask her myself. Her fist tightens on her knees, I can't take it anymore. You were there at the warehouse, with us. People keep telling me everyone took out each other. But that detective, Roland. He kept asking me and Ryan about someone else there. The reason finally comes out. I kept my cool as she blatantly exposes me about my involvement.

I am curious why now. Its been weeks since the investigation. And fortunately Roland has no evidence. So she didn't get any new information from IDF. I ask her, why do you think that. She explains, few days ago. Me and Ryan were watching your fight with Heraknus. Which by the way was awesome. I was completely in awe how you beat them down. She hastily adds that as compliment. Even in the predicament I was in, I couldn't resist a smirk. Considering she was bad mouthing me, in front of me, as Mack. I say my image has drastically improved since then. Or maybe she is just saying that because she is here.

She says, after the match. You healed the Heraknus guy. My brother said he remembers seeing that thing happening at the warehouse too. Oh shit. I made a mental kick to myself. I was only showing off in front of Rory and others. Bloody hell. I can't believe after all that careful planning, I am busted because of my ego. Maybe I can cover this up, I am sure he is mistaken. I used Jonathans Kuret, that's true. Maybe your brother had seen that somewhere else. She isn't buying my lie, Ryan was sure he saw that. He remembered someone telling him to get me help.

She leans forward, and you know what. I think I remember seeing that Kuret too. I asked around, there no one from Jonathans house was at the warehouse. Not among the criminals or anyone in the officers nearby. Her glimmer was steady, meaning she was confident in herself. That's bad for me though. I take a drink a little bit of the shake to figure out how I can convince her. She gathers more courage, you were there. You were the one who saved me. The doctor said I was very lucky to be alive. But that's not the whole truth. You saved me and Ryan. I slowly gulp down all the rest of the drink hoping to buy some time.

Maybe I can tell her some clever lie. I swipe away the few drops of my lips, look. You seem like a nice girl. And I don't mean to be rude, but its just a misunderstand okay. You and your brother went something traumatic. That changes your perception. Believe me, I know all about that. Best to confuse her rather than outright reject her, you saw my interview. The one where I was accused by Ryes. I am well verse in all the matter of trauma. I am flattered you think I saved you. But you have one brother in jail, and one in house arrest. I don't think you are seeing things clearly too.

Unfortunately, none of my words reached her. She still had a headstrong expression, I am not here to cause any trouble for you. I just want to thank you. For saving me and my brother. You even let Peter get out of there. Even though he doesn't deserve it. She was hesitant in her actions, but now she is her usual self. I can still salvage this, but should I even do that. Haven't I lied to her a lot already. And if just let her believe this, maybe she won't dig deeper and find out other things. I look away for a moment.

I chuckled a little when it downs on me what a mistake that was to show my Kuret sphere in front cameras. Turns out that was enough of a confirmation to her. She turns bright, like she just figured out a big mystery. I wasn't going to make it easy for her, lets hypothetically say that I was there. Just minding my own business. Then I saw suspicious activity at the plant. I saw few warriors who were guarding a place which was supposed to be empty at night. I looked in and saw some in a pinch. So maybe I stepped in and took down their operation.

She took the hint with a big smile and nodded along. I continue, now, I could have done it without hiding my involvement. But lets just say there were other stuff going on behind the scenes. More than just petty criminals and smuggling operation. Perhaps its so sensitive that its best that no one knows that I was ever there. That finally gave away my meaning. Hey sharpens and mumbles, oh. So, its something more. I got it. Her voice returns to normal, thank you. I gave her gesture to say I don't need it. She leans away sighing with relief, to be completely honest. I wasn't sure why I come here. Maybe I thought it help me make sense of things. For my sake and Ryans.

That's so like her, putting her brothers before herself. Even Peter. She says, anyway. That's all I had to say. She looks around my living room, its actually not how I pictured you living by the way. I scoff, please. Tell me what you thought. She teases me, I heard rumors you are hiding some insane tech. I laugh at that, well, I am. Would you like to see some killer robots. She snickers, wow. Really. Well, maybe next time. I answer, bring Ryan too. I know you don't are not into nerdy stuff, but maybe Ryan would most definitely would be. Her cheery attitude turns into a little amusement.

Oh shit, that just slipped out without meaning too. Now that the tense air was cleared, I fell back into the my comfortable mode with her. I clear my throat, I mean. I am assuming any 9 year old would be interest in robots. She has a sudden realization, I didn't think of this before. You already researched us, don't you. Makes sense you would do that. Because of Peter. She was only half right, but props to her for connecting the dots. She seems

much better in spirits from the interrogation with Vanessa.

That made me recall how Vanessa was grilling Elina for my information. And then what she said to me later in IDF that I didn't care about Elina. That brought up a lot more guilt than I thought I could handle. Now that she is at my home, laughing and being her usual self. I can't help feeling that I am chickening out. Letting her believe that Mack is only some guy who is overly zealous friend. If things go back to normal, would I down that disguise from my bedroom and visit her again. Or maybe I won't see her again. I kept hearing Vanessa's words about not trusting anyone. Her warn voice had lost its smoothness after repeating those words to me so many times.

Elina gets uncomfortable at my sudden quietness. Her glimmers showed some agitation. She stands up, look at the time. I took a lot of your time. I should get back home. She mouths me, thanks you as she walks to the door. She says, and good luck for your fight with the Heraknus alpha. You have my full support. Her enthusiasm and sincerity in giving me that encouragement had the opposite effect. I now really felt I was betraying her. I sigh, damn you Vanessa. Filling my head with things. Elina thought I was saying something to her, she turns back before she opens the door, sorry. I didn't catch you.

I gather my resolve, I was saying you don't need to leave yet. We have a lot to catch up on. Her curiosity peaked, I am sorry. About what. I stand up from the couch, maybe talk about Mack. That name surprises her, wait. You know Mack. I thought about what kind of hint I can drop to her. I didn't like playing like this with her, but lets see if she can really recognize me. I say, sure. I know all about your friend with benefits. Her brows raises as she takes a step closer, how did you. I say, I am sorry you weren't able to buy that bracelet. No actually, if you play your card right. You can get out of that house arrest.

She gazes at me with complete shock. I add, maybe if you sell me all the 1879 Tennessee Whiskey you have left in your cellar, you can probably buy it. Now she begins to stutter a little, how. Did Mack tell you. She had to know what I have been saying. She is probably only resisting to say it now. I gently ask her, ever wonder I would not ask you out. Its not because I am hung up on a girl. No, that’s not true. She is a big reason. Now more than ever. But mostly because of what my life is.

She finally understands with small shriek yells, holy shit.

David (Chapter 112)

Friday, March 13, 2026 11:53

Elina is showing a complete reversal of her attitude from earlier. I sat back on my couch, while she is fuming at the other seat. I couldn't stop her from hurling all kinds of insults at me. Some of them I deserved. But calling me a leacher was uncalled for. The best way to let her settle down was to let her finish her ranting. She shouts at me, you are the worst kind of person I have ever met. I knew you were a messed up person who does whatever he thinks he can. But this, you crossed a line. Did you enjoy lying to me all this time. Using me for, what, selfish pleasure. Arg, this is so humiliating.

I think its been already 10 minutes since she expressed all her feelings. She barks, you have nothing to say for yourself. She crosses her arms while her veins turns red on her neck. I knew it would turn out like this. I was actually expecting her to be storm out of here already. Maybe there is hope she will understand me after all. She cries, have you gone deaf now. Say something dammit. I shouldn't infuriate her more, but I couldn't help commenting about her anger, just thinking that I have never seen you this angry before. Not even when Peter skipped on your 6 months opening anniversary of your bar. I smiled recalling how hot she seemed when she was angry at that time.

Its was obviously not the right time to reminisce about our history. She threw another slur at me, you freaker. You think this is a joke. You toyed with me for months. I don't care you saved my life. I hate your guts. You are the biggest liar I have ever met. Apparently, this was her limit. She didn't want to talk to me anymore. Not when I was purposefully not giving her any explanation. The problem is I am too embarrassed to talk as myself with her. I was playing a character with her, but not anymore. Its awkward to not having that façade anymore. Even though my current personality is very close to the way I appear with her.

She got up and headed straight for the door. Before she left I say, takes one to know one. She yells, what did you say. I clear my throat, I am saying you are a liar too. So don't get judgy with me. That freaked her out. She says, I don't know what you are talking about. Unlike you, I never lied about who I was. I nod, you didn't lie about that. You lied about something else. You have been ever since you got detained by the IDF. Her arms froze at the door knob. Even just looking at her back, I could tell she was a nervous wreck. She probably thought she would get away without anyone knowing about her tragic secret.

I tell her, if are willing to listen to me, I can help you get our of your house arrest. But that’s your choice. She immediately pushes the door open and runs away. I may have been a little too hasty with my provocation. But she will be back. I casually walk to the kitchen counter and begin preparing for my dinner. I contemplated what to tell her. I have been mocking her because I was scared for a bit. I should have a more serious conversation with her. That’s the first thing I would do when she returns.

30 minutes go by as I prepare my dinner. M told me that her car is still outside. So I know she is deliberating what I said. That's a good sign. She can hate me all she wants, but I know her. Once she realizes I am the only one who can help her get out of this mess. I felt a little pang of guilt using this tactic to make her listen to me. But my lie is nothing compared to hers. Another 10 minutes go by and finally I hear footsteps at my door. And it was serendipitous that I was about to finish grilling my fish fillet. She quietly peeks through the already ajar door. I didn't gesture her in until she hesitantly walks to the living room.

The pan was just done sizzling as she approaches me, what did you mean that you can help me. Hook, line and sinker. I thought it was quite a poetic coincidence as I plated the baked fish. I ask, join me for dinner. She gives a annoyed look, I am not hungry. I chuckle as I grab the cutleries, I can actually see you are. I saw her glimmer showing streaks of grey. She watches me in silence as I set the table. I even pulled out the whisky bottle that I actually got it from her one time. She instantly recognized it, isn't that the one I gave Mack. Ah, I mean you. I gestured it to her, you did. You said it should breathe for another few weeks. I thought its appropriate for now.

I hope she isn't too offended by this. While I took my seat, she stood dazed at me. I sigh, you don't have to eat. But I have a schedule to keep. That means taking calories at certain intervals. So you can just stand there, angry at me, or you could eat. I could see glimmers of her hunger increasing when she sees the fish I cooked. I say, its not Kuret mixed, but its still good. Have a bite at least. After I chewed on a bite from my plate and she finally broke. She says, this is not me forgiving you. I nod, I am not asking for it. You aren't the first women to be so mad at me. I internally had a laugh thinking what a repeating theme this is.

She awkwardly sits opposite to me and cuts a piece for her self. I peek at her eyes as they widen from the taste. She was anxious about it initially, but then she slowly gives in. The first bite is slow, but she takes another bite in a hurry. I say, yeah. Not bad right. I recently acquired a new taste for this particular type of marine food. I swivel my fork on a piece thinking how I used to not like this very much a week before. One of the side effects of Ketriya. Elina was no longer hiding her insatiable appetite. She dug in taking another piece with no more of that unnecessary humiliation of hunger. She must have cooked only limited things stuck at the house for a while.

I pour some of the whiskey for us. Its not really a complementing with fish, but Elina didn't mind as she ate and drink in quiet. Half way though I saw her glimmers settling down. I put my fork down, now you know I wasn't lying that I can cook. You remember, you kept teasing me that one time that I am always eating outside. She momentarily stops chewing with angry look. I sigh, I didn't lie about everything. Just my name and job. Everything else was completely true. She gulps, how can I believe that. I clarify, I may have spoofed up some things. But that’s harmless white lies.

She was right to be skeptical. I gave her an example, remember I told you once about Mary. My friend who was a childhood friend and is very extrovert. She recalls that conversation, you told she was kicked out of your team and threw a tantrum. You had to console her that it was just bad luck. I am glad she remembers our talks, well, that was Marina. I was talking about how sad she gotten after she lost against Blake. She coughs a little, what. Marina, as in the omega Marina. Its been quite some time seeing reactions like that. I laugh. She gets offended by it.

I wave at her, sorry. Since I am surrounded daily with her and other officers, I forget how normal people react when I mention Marina. If I recall, you once said you were rooting for Marina all along. She shakes off her confusion, I totally forget. You are on a personal level with all of the high ranking officers. She grumbly resumes eating her food. I continue, I can keep telling you things like that. About my friends, but I am sure that won't make you believe me. The point is, every conversation we had, no matter how convoluted, trivial, or serious, they were all real. Maybe they weren't the whole truth, but they were a version of events I can talk to you with.

She get annoyed at my logic, why me then. Of all the people in the city, why choose me to get drunk. I lean back putting away my fork, would you believe if I say that’s because you were gorgeous and charming. She throws daggers at me with her eyes. She scoffs, I though you weren't going to lie. I say, I am not. I put my elbows on the table and rest my head on my knuckles. I tell her, you are a captivating women. I think I see her blushing a little. That’s a good sign. I continue, I wasn't planning to take things this far, but it evolved more than I thought. I couldn't be myself with others, but you were easy to be with.

She wasn't buying that it was simple attraction. I add, trust me. Mack wasn't the only identity I was using while visiting places. Your rivals in sector 3, I go by Gary there. And another noodle shop in section 2, the owner knows me as Lucas. My life is too complicated, that even before getting fame, I had a checkered past. I can't really be myself around normal folks. Tell me, if I had walked in as myself the first time in your bar, what would you have done. That question made her perturbed a little. She says, I don't know. That was her honest thought. I say, but I know what would happened. I was only a participant in the tournament. A guy with strange Kuret with friends in high places. I would be getting silent judgement, curious questions and people prying into my past. I don't want to deal with those things when I came just to unwind.

She shows the first signs of understanding, I guess so. I continue, I already have a big target on my back with Humans. And while its not the same here, but its just as troubling. So I had to use disguises. Make a persona that I can use to talk to people. She says in a low tone, you mean like those human celebrities that hide their identities when in public. That’s a decent analogy. However she immediately puts it away, no. They don't go around getting involved in other people lives, lying to them this much. I answer, that was a mistake. Like I told you, you charmed me. I didn't want to stop visiting you.

I sigh, but I also know that I was digging myself further into a twisted lie. So I purposefully made our relationship strictly at your bar. You were right when you thought I was using money to keep things simple between us. Just not about the reasons. At this point I had to gulp down half of the glass so that I don't loose courage to speak my mind. I thought I could maintain my composure, but I am anxious. Naturally, this was too much for her. She remains silent trying to figure out if what I said was true or not. I put the glass down, I have another reason to go out of my way to talk to you like this. I won't be divulging that. Though, I can assure you it wasn't about you.

She gives me a suspicious look, what does that mean. I say, just use whatever trust I earned to know that it was for a good reason. She clearly didn't understand what I meant. That’s all I could tell her without mentioning my therapy. Thankfully, she left it alone as she continued to eat the rest of her food. Once finished I tell her, you think I am not being serious. You didn't need to worry about things like Hive wars or Echo espionages. Or even Medrone politics. I was so sure I made a mess by being in your life, but that’s not true anymore. Is it.

I am ready to dive into the heart of her despair. I had called her an even bigger liar than me. Now that I came clean with reasons, she couldn't use them against me. Whether the reasons were moral or not, just or not, they were mine. She knows that. Just like her reasons were hers and hers alone. Her demeanor shifts into a meek under my intense gaze. She is immobilized with fear. I feel pity for her, but I setup the conversation so that she cannot continue using the same excuse to blame for my behaviors. I tell her, the fact is I lied only about me. But you have been lying to me, to others and to IDF.

She asks, I don't know what you mean. She was desperate to hide her crimes. I never seen her nervous habit of pricking her nails before. Its weird that I find it interesting seeing different sides to her. But I restrained myself against pointing them out since she is under duress. I say, see. How hard is to open up to someone you care about. I subtly I asked if she still cared about me too. She didn't deny it. That actually gave me another boast of hope. I patiently waited for her to reveal it herself. But after a minute of intense silence I realized she needed some help.

I turn to the display on the side wall, M. Initiate Umbrella protocol. M replies, authorized personal detected. Requesting clarification. I answer back, approved. Just do it. The house begins to lockdown and Elina turns frantic, what's happening. She jerks at the noise of doors and window shutting down. I explain to her, something to give us complete privacy. Whatever we say now, cannot be recorded, intercepted or hacked. She glances at M's hologram, oh her. That’s one of the crazy tech you mentioned. Say hi to my personal AI. M says, good evening miss Elina. And then blinks away from her hologram form.

Elina asks, no will know about us. I shake my head. That helped her settle down a bit. After mustering courage she asks me in a grim tone, how did you find about it. I reveal, I noticed how weirdly Wayn was convinced you were the one who stole the drugs. At the treatment plant, I didn't put it together. But then later I visited him in jail. He was sure solely based on his intuition and thin evidence that the their shipment ledger was stolen by you. I had a nagging feeling of your involvement. So I saw your interrogations at the IDF. She turns her gaze down from me to the floor, the slow flow of guilt creeping at her face.

She is distraught by my every word, Vanessa gave you a doctored manifest of your shipment orders to see if you can remember anyone that seemed out of place. Find that shipment records that was different than the actual one and forged by Peter. You only remember one. But then I had a look at the list myself. And that’s when I realized you lied. Others may not know you. But you are meticulous with your records. Why do I think so. Because once Peter messed up placing a shipment order for rum instead of distilled rum, which you still remembered after a month of that blunder. Her shoulder drops down further as she was crushed by the weight of a hidden burden.

I remove my hands from the table, I thought it was just trauma. You simply couldn't get your mind focused on that. But that bar is more than just your work, its your life. You love your job. That’s why you are so good at it. You would never make a mistake of not recognizing your own orders and Peters feeble attempts to change it. Even when he is attempting to copy your handwriting. And even if it was flawless, you would should have been able to point out plenty of other suspicious shipments. And yet, you told them about only one. No, you made a show out of it. I wondered why you would try to hide it. Then I looked at your behavior timeline, from patient to victim. Then to consoling sister to a victimized brother. And when things were becoming too much, you started showing reluctance.

She pleads, please stop. Don't say it. It hurts to see her drowning in sorrow, but she has to face reality. I continue, IDF thought that was normal for you to process the event. No, its accurate to say that you sold that behavior to them. You played the best card you had with you, the victim card. Even used Ryan as an excuse. She slams the table with her fist, I never used him. She glares at me with murderous eyes. But contrary to her outburst, her glimmer were saying something else. She clenches her teeth, he has nothing to do with this. I nod, I agree. But that doesn't mean you won't use him to your advantage. And I am not judging you. You did what you could to get out of IDF.

Her fury simmers down with my honest thoughts, I would have never looked this closely. But I cared about you, so I gathered all the evidence and that concluded one thing. I lean in closer, tell me what is Elina. She remains frozen and trembling. I urge her more, you can say it. No one is listening. She is still resisting so much. I slam my own fist, sticking near the edge and toppling the bottle onto the ground. As it breaks on impacts, so does her thin resistance. She shouts, I admit it. Okay. I stole the ledger. I slam my fist again on the table, what else. She cries, no. I yell, what else Elina. Shall I expose you to others. Even Ryan will know what you did.

That broke her last vestiges of self restraint. She yells, it was me. I doctored the shipment records after Peter so that no one will ever find out the truth. Her most shameful and guilty lie comes out spilling. And the tears began rolling down her cheeks. She pushes away the table and dashes away to door. But when the protocol in effect, she had no where to run. She yells, let me out. I don't want to be here. Her cries echo's from the door. Her stifling snorts eating away at her as she tried to slam and kick open the door. I went a little extreme with her, but she had to let it out. She was not facing reality.

I approach her from behind and place my arm on her shoulder, its okay Elina. Its going to be fine. She shoves me away, stay away. You are going to tell everyone now. Aren't you. You want to throw away me in jail with Peter. I won't let you. She kept hitting and scratching away at the steel door. I forcefully grab her arm and pull her into a hug. She tried to wriggle out of my arms, but all she had was a tantrum with no strength left in her. She suddenly grabs my back and behind to cry on my neck.

After that emotional crash out, I let settle down back on the couch. I waited for her to let all her anger and frustration out with her tears. Meanwhile I took a broom to clear the broken bottle with spilled whiskey all over my dining room. I could have had ART clean that up, but the combat bots would only agitate Elina even more. I didn't want to waste the whiskey, but it got the job done. Loosened up Elina just enough so that she reveal her secretes. Normally, I would have a post dinner workout by now. But obviously, I have more pressing concerns right now. I sat beside a bellowing Elina. I grab her hand in mine and say, what do you need.

I figure I should ask her that first. She shook her head while she wipes away her tears. Her hair is a mess as she tugs on the ends with her fingers anxiously. Now that's something I have seen her do many times. I offered her a glass of water to settle down. She denied it, but I insisted. She relents and drinks it all in one go. When that didn't calm her down, I gave her another glass. That seemed to do the trick. Its been a while since I have seen a normal nervous breakdown. Not to be rude to her, but its actually refreshing to see a normal natural response. She says, thank you. Her attitude has drastically dropped down now that she has nothing else to hide.

I grab her shoulders to comfort her, like I told you. No will know this happened. No one heard you. She gives me meekly question, why are you helping me. I am a horrible person. A strands of tears flow from her eyes. I had to assure her that's not true, you did a horrible thing. You aren't one yourself. I can't imagine what you have been going through. But whatever be the reason, it was a mistake. That doesn't mean you are bad. She leans away, that doesn't makes it okay. I lied to everyone. To Ryan. To IDF. Even to Peter. He is in there because of me. I tighten my grip on her shoulder, he is in there because of himself. Don't forget that.

She closes her eyes as tears kept coming. I think I need a different way to let her process this. I ask, tell me how this happened. I don't know the details. When did you notice Peter has been lying to you about the shipments. That distracted her own guilt. She wipes away her tears, 6 months ago. I forced myself to hide the shock on my face. I wasn't expecting this. I thought it was only few weeks, not freaking months. She saw through my face the shock and judgement I had. She looks away resentful of her decisions.

This isn't boding well, sorry. She scoffs, no. You should be mad at me. You lied to me. But that's nothing compared to what I was doing. Being a secret helper to Peter and his smuggling operation the whole time. I need to stop her from spiraling down. So I began my own assumptions, you found out one day that your shipments were different on paper. Did you confront Peter about it. She pulls herself a little, at first I thought it was it was a simple mistake Peter made. I corrected it immediately so to avoid any penalties from spot inspections. But. She lost her words. I help her, it happened again. You started to notice a pattern. Why didn't you ask why he did it.

She replies, I thought he would give me some made up excuse. And what was I going to do, fire him. He is my brother. So I took it upon myself to check why he did that. I ask, did you know he was smuggling in stuff. Her eyes widen and face turns red, no. Absolutely not. I had no idea he was mixed up in all that until he brought me to the treatment plant that night. She had no reason to lie about it. I ask, so you just assumed it was something illegal but not this. Nod nods adamantly, whenever he change the shipment, a few days later he deposit in money in the counter. He claimed it was some side business he was doing. But after the fifth time I know it was related.

That's how she made the connection. She is clever enough to unravel Peter's business. But I am anxious about her reasons, so you saw he was bringing in money with every shipment. And despite having a good enough evidence for a potentially illegal activity, you decided not to turn him in. She finishes the words for me, I was sacred of what would happen to Peter. I didn't want him to go to jail, or get tanged with his other criminals. You have no idea how hard it was for me to make that decision. I needed a cure for Ryan, so that he wouldn't develop the same problem I have.

That's what Wyan said to me. That lends credence to her morality choice. She gets teary, I hate myself. Instead of doing the right thing, I took the easy way out. I say, I already told you. I am not judging you. I may not seem like it, but you are talking to a wanted criminal, hunted by many Human agencies. I am the last person you should worry about making the moral choices. My crimes are nothing compared to yours. I would in fact say they are harmless. That actually brought a unexpected smile to her. Glad that amused her enough to pull her out of her misery, even if it was only temporary. I ask, what happened then.

Her smile breaks away, after months of watching him, I learned a little about his business. I knew there were others, just didn't know who they were. He made many mistakes while covering up the shipments. That idiot thought it was okay to put down a 10 cubic creates into a 50 cubic one. Maybe it would not cause suspicion at the border security, but the inspectors would flag it down immediately. So I corrected them, making them more realistic. I raise my hand, hang on. Let me get this right. With every shipment, you would write down the amount you ordered, which you knew Peter will alter it and then you further edit it to make it even less suspicious. Is that right.

She gives a guilty nod. But I was actually impressed the hell out of this, that's incredible. You were letting him believe that he was cooking the books, when you are cooking his records. I am impressed. I should hire you to run my counterfeiting operations. She spats out, what. I say, never mind that. Setting aside the morality of the situation, what you did was a stroke of genius. You were even better at covering your own records than him. I chuckle imagining how Peter would feel about this if he ever find out. Elina is shocked at how chill I was with this. She says, this isn't something to be impressed with. I am a criminal. I say, if you are going to do something, be the best.

She says, you are crazy. I nod, many would agree with you. But don't deny it. You must have felt a little bit of pride from this. She shake her head, never. I click my tongue, no judgement. Remember. Just an impartial observation. I release her shoulder and grab her hand, you outsmarted him and even Wyan. My excitement finally broke through her emotional guilt. She gives me a proper smile now, you jackass. Fine. Yeah. I admit it, sometimes I felt a little proud of myself. I knew it. I wasn't sure of it, but she was this running for months. She had a carefully crafted system. No matter how guilty you feel, they still have some pride over their efforts.

She says, I can't believe you are happy about this. I say, well, you haven't met the real me. Just the me I showed. She scoffs, its not funny. Her glimmers shows she is better now. I was right to evaluate her state by taking out the emotions from her decisions. I ask, tell me how did you get your hands on the ledger. She looks away as another crime of hers got revealed, few days before the treatment plant, overheard Peter talking to someone in his room. He was talking about some ledger. I realized they had their own copy of the shipments ledger. And if anyone saw that and then compared it to the records I changed, they would know I was involved.

I understand what happened now, so you stole it. What was your plan exactly. You had to know they would know Peter lost it and blame you soon. She frowns, after living him for years on Earth, I know where he hides his stuff. I made it look like Peter misplaced it. I was so scared of getting caught, I didn't thought about the consequences. I hoped they would just blame Peter for being careless and start a new ledger. I had a lot of thoughts about this impulsive decision. But the most prevalent one was disappointment. She had a good thing going, but ruined it with a careless mistake. All too common with unexperienced criminals.

She says, I know I messed up. You don't look so glum. I am not a master criminal like you. Its like she read my mind. I smile, just a silly thought. Who knows, maybe that would have really happened. Won't they probably have a locater type Kuretine on that book. If they did, they would know where to look. She says, I bought a Kuritine safe that blocks everything. That same material as the menage a trois are planning to use in their basement. I say, the stuff that repels away the Kurets. Must have been expensive. She says, I bought it from Peter's own money. Serves him right for making me suffer through all this. She peeked my interest with this again.

I say, that's brutal and righteous. I assume all the rest of the money is gone however. She nods, IDF seized it. But they didn't notice that amount missing. I had to applaud her for this, if are good at covering your finances too. She didn't deny it, she looks away in a little bit of shame again. I scoff, if I had known what an excellent criminal you were, I would have asked you out much earlier. That brought out a laugh from her and shoves me hard in the guts. But she never lets goes of my hand. She slightly strokes my hand in hers.

I was being honest. But truth be told, I was behaving all this to sway her a little. So that she wouldn't suffer under the burden of guilt anymore. I ask, and where is the safe now. She says, I hide it in one of Peters old spots. Buried it in our neighbors lawn. I scoff, bloody hell. You aren't just a unexpectedly tidy thief, you are incredible actress. I met you that evening and I didn't even see a hint of deception. You appeared your usual self, acting like everything is perfectly normal. Down to the quips and the flirting with me. I must be loosing my touch. Of course I had other stuff going on with me, Ketriya, PTSD, and a mental block curtesy of Zakerine. But that's no excuse.

She sighs, please tell me you are not being serious. I am horrified at myself. You can't be impressed at me for doing so many disgusting things. I knew I couldn't ease her guilt in just a short time. But I try what I can, you only did a crime guilty by association. Not even the crime itself. Besides, you nearly died for your decisions. I think that's punishment enough. I hoped that would make her feel it balanced out her guilt. It was hard for to accept that. What a coincidence that one of the client stole the drugs around the same time she stole.

I'll admit that for a time, I believed there to be some sort of connection. But it looks like it was just freaky twist of fate and luck. I imagined the people who used their services wanted this to happen. They probably wanted all of them to be caught. What better way to hide your involvement. Use them, steal those drugs from them and then bust their operations. Now I believe it was two separate events intertwined that caused them to meet that night. I lean back thinking on how to deal with those people. I have been very busy lately to do anything about them. I sure hope that Catherine or Citradel officers have found some credible leads.

Elina voice zaps me out of my thoughts, what are you thinking. I answer, nothing you need to worry about. Lets figure out what we can do to get you out of this mess first. Her grip tightens on my hand, I am going to turn myself in. I had a nagging feeling she would say that. Now that she revealed her actions, her sins are eating her from the inside. I already told her that I can help her. But if she is not going to ask for it, there is no point in me forcing her. Instead I nod, that's the right thing to do. You don't have to worry about Ryan. I will help him out without him knowing. I'll make sure he is adopted by some family, instead of placed in the youth center.

That eventual future instantly shook her to her core. I continued, he wouldn't have to worry about money for a while. Soon your assets will be released and he will inherit them. But, given how close he is with both his sister and brother, he will not make it easier. And its understandable. Loosing fist Peter and now you. But you said counselling is helping him. I can personally vouch it does wonders. Maybe in a few years he will be fine. And he can still visit you both in prison in the meantime. I am sure everything will be fine without you.

The conscious provocation finally snapped her out of her guilt, you are the worst. She scoffs at me while trying to remove her hands. But I pull it back from her, why. I am just saying what will happen. I will help him out however much I can. That should be good enough for you, isn't that right. She gets furious at me. I ask, that's your plan, right. Clear your guilt because its too much. She yells, just stop. I get it already. I can't do that to him. She angrily turns to me, you win. Anyone tell you how obnoxious you are. I shrug, why. Did someone say something to you. I smirk at her even furious eyes.

She sighs, just tell me what your plan is. I waited her for to ask me something before I say anything else. She closes her eyes for a second and then says, you want me say it, don't you. I didn't give agree or deny that. She says, please. Help me. That was all I wanted to hear. But I feel I can ask for something more. So I pushed my luck and waited until she says it. After a while she realized what I wanted this time. She says, I don't forgive you for lying to me. I don't care how petty it makes me look. Dang it, I though I curried enough good will from her. She then softly says, but if you help me. I will think about it.

I saw a small glimmer of anxiety. This wasn't from nervousness, but from suspicion. Her quiet demeanor painted the rest of the picture. I had a laugh, clever. You plan to keep me on hook so I help you out. I guessed right when she tries to hide a smile from me. I wasn't expecting her to forgive me anyways. I say, you got a deal. I gather a little bit of nerve and clear the strands of hair away from her head. I was sure she would strike me away, but she buries her eyes on the ground embarrassed. I realize I was sending mixed signals now and stop it. I say, sorry. She says, its fine.

What was I even trying to achieve. Take advantage of her current vulnerable state. I slide a little away, letting go of her hand and creating a distance. I was doing this only to help her, not make things more complicated. Even though my mind and body were at conflicts, I can't do that to her. I clear my throat, well. Since you asked me so nicely, let me tell you what happens after. I will tell you the details only after you accept that part. A confusion washes over her, okay. As long as I get to stay with Ryan. I nod, as much as I want to let you go scott free. I can't. You may not have smuggled any items, but you definitely gained from it.

She could deny all that. She was enticed by the money. Even if it were for noble reasons. She didn't deny this accusation, and you went as far to cover up their crimes. You may not realize it, but if you had reported them to the officers, we could have avoided few things. I am not talking about you dying. I am talking about things set in motion due these criminals activities. She asks, I don't understand. I wasn't going to explain how it indirectly impacted the tournament or other crimes linked. I say, just trust me. If people know you had chance to stop it, do the right thing, they would tear you apart. Marina comes to my mind. Well, I knew she would eventually understand it, but she wouldn't like this happened at all.

Elina realizes the seriousness of her actions. The unintended consequences. I tell her, it was out of your control. So you are not completely guilty. But the fact remains, people were hurt because of this. With a meek nod she agrees. Now came the hard part, once we get back your life, you will need to make big changes. She asks, like what. I reply, for one thing, you are out of the liquor business completely. It be better if sell your bar. She blurts out, what. You want to give away my bar. I nod, yeah. I am sure if things settle back, you can run the bar again. But your name is hidden only to the public, but not to the officers. You will constantly live under their presence. Like how they do now.

The possibility of the future downs on her. I ask, and how long until people learn about your brother. What happens to you and Ryan when they hear Peter was involved. I am not trying to hurt you, but this only bring unnecessary hurdles and more pain. She says, if I give away the bar, they will leave me alone. I nod, yes. That’s the only way you get your life back. You can argue that I am being harsh, but you did commit a crime. You can't think there will be no consequences. Maybe you will not be held accountable by Blake or IDF. So I am doing it on my own discretion. Feel free to hate me, but that’s what's needs to happen.

The whole plan hinges on this. If she can accept to let go the bar she loves. I could probably find a way to keep the bar for her, but that would be wrong. She did a crime, no matter how much I approve. There has to be some punishment. Besides, she might not get caught. Or maybe she makes a another blunder and gets caught red handed. There are several other ways things can go wrong. Best I deal with it now before others find about it. I patiently wait for her answer. She has a hard time accepting this. Anyone would be feeling it when they are asked to give away something they love.

She makes up her mind after a while, I don't understand you. You say you don't judge me for my mistakes. But then ask for this. I get her confusion, that’s true. I have to live by rules or laws from others. I am not Human and I am not subjected to even Medrones. That means living in a certain way. I want to help you, but there had to be a balance. If you hadn't approached me today, I would have eventually visited you. It maybe was next week, or after my match with Charles. But I would have given you the same choice then. She says, you are weird. I can hardly deny that. My life is strange. She says, I don't want to leave that place. Its more home than my actual house.

She closes her eyes and leans her head on the couch, giving it up for a chance to get my life back. That's, her voice trembles a little. She gathers enough muster, fair I guess. I don’t like it, but its like you said. I won't ever feel less guilty if there are no consequence for my actions. She opens her eyes and straightens her back, fine. I said I do anything to stay with Ryan. If that means saying goodbye to the bar, so be it. She gives off a weak resolve, you sure. Because once we do this you can't go change you mind again. You have to sure of this. She nods more confidently now, I understand.

Her glimmer showed stronger determination. So for now I can accept it. Then I tell her my plan. It was fairly simple, except it involves Vanessa. It took a while convincing Elina of this. She had legitimate concerns, but it was imperative that we got Vanessa's help. She understood that she can't really get away with her crimes without some risks. Vanessa is partially the reason I fessed up my lies to Elina. I feel like she will understand if Elina explains herself.
☐She says, I still don't think she will help me. Her worries was obvious. From her perspective, the chief officer of IDF has no reason to help her and every reason to lock her in. I tell her, c
may be okay with your actions, but others do not share my sentiments. What happens when I am not there to help you. She asks, what does that mean. You said you will help me. I reply, I am saying you shouldn't rely solely on me. I am saying this for your sake. If you rely on just me, it will not make you independent. Eventually you would feel indebted to me, more than you should. I don't want you to feel that way.

My reasons resonated with her now. She blinks hard at me, that’s crazy. You seriously go this far. I smirk, If I am going to make things right with you, I want to make sure I do it the right way. That might have earned me some good grace when I see glimmers of relief on her. She says, you aren't how I pictured you would be. I say, I get that a lot too. But I am still the hot headed guy who thought I could fight off a Heraknus overdrive user. I recalled the words she told me. That made her gush with mortification. She says, I can't believe I bad mouthed you, in front of you.

Then another realization came, wait. Then you remember what I told about others too. I chuckle, I am envious you once said Blake is so dreamy and you would do anything to spend a night with him. I wonder what he would think about that proposition. And how enraged you were he lost instead of me. That garner such a eye of hate and shame that I thought she would throw something at me. She glares at me, not funny. I smile, lets stay on topic. One last piece of warning. I am in hot waters with Vanessa at the moment. So she might not be willing if you say this was my idea.

She settles down a bit, why. What did you do go her. I ask, why you do you assume its my fault. She says, a hunch. Or maybe its because you said I wasn't the only one who is angry with you. She caught remark for earlier. I say, don’t worry. She doesn't hate me. We are just having a hard time. Just trust me. Avoid mentioning my name. You don't know her. But I do. She isn't how you all make her out to be. She is a lot more compassionate than you think. And she has her own fair share of demons. She will try to resist, but I am sure you could convince her. Just stick to the plan.

Elina had no choice but to accept it. She says, and you. How will you do your part. I say, leave that to me. You only seen Mack at his lowest, feeling down and wanting a talk with you to avoid his problems. Maybe even flirt around, testing how much is there to learn about women these days. She scoffs, in that case you aren't ready. Your pick lines are to flat and not at all charming as you think it was. I lean in closer, is that right. But I swear it worked on you. Besides, I heard you like me. So I must have done something right. She says, I never said that. I reminded her of the interrogation with Vanessa. That turns her cheeks red.

Ah, I did it again. I keep falling back to the way I used to talk to her. I can't keep doing this. I resumed the rest of the plan to which she agreed. Our conversation went till 10 PM, that’s not good. She prepares to grab her coat, what's wrong. I say, I wasn't on planning on keeping you this late. You must have noticed many people tried to talk to me, yeah. She nods. I answer, and most of them women. She begrudgingly nods again. I say, well, they camp outside around this time. Hoping to meet me when I go for a run around this time. She turns her back to me and tries to peak through the shut window. Naturally she couldn't see through the barricade.

I showed her the outside cameras and just like the last few days, there were some people in the car hiding out. She says, shit. What do we do now. Do you have a back exit for me to leave. I had one. But aside from revealing its secret existence there is a problem. I mention, your car is outside. Can't just leave there whole night. I am amusing Molly is a friend of yours who lend it to you. She curses herself, I forgot about that. You said you kept your involvement hidden for a reason. It will be bad for if people saw me with you. I nod. I was suggest her a way, but she begin to unbutton her blouse. Then she ruffles up her hair. Even removes one sleave of her coat.

I take a step away surprised. For just a tiny second an insane thought crossed my mind. She says, stop gawking. Get me a black color shade and a hat. I hope you have a scarf do. While she roughs up her dress, I realized what she is planning. A sinister smile forms on my lips, are you sure about this. People will talk. Maybe even try to find you. She says, then stall them. Make sure no one follows me. I don't think you would be worried what people will think about this. How you let gullible women into your home but don't even let them stay the night. She flaps her hairs around a bit more. She smirks, a added bonus. People will know exactly what a type of sleazy guy you are.

I, on the other hand, am already enjoying how this will switch up my public image. I say, on the contrary, I love this idea.

Blake (Chapter 113)

Saturday, March 14, 2026 17:09

Come in, I said to a knock on my office door. I didn't realize its already 12 and I had a meeting right now. Marina and Catherine walk into the room. My nerves were acting up a little when I see Catherine. I heard she rejoined us yesterday after lunch. But I couldn't talk to her again. Looking closely at her, her aura is brighter now. I hesitate to imagine what happened with her romantic getaway with Robb. Its troubling me even now that she went to meet him. I desperately wanted to ask what happened. But I feel that would be getting into her personal life. Which I tried hard to avoid. When I met David earlier, he told me the gist of it.

Neither of us are actually okay with what Catherine decided. But he is right, if we try to separate them, it will only hurt her. I think there is only one way this ends, in heartbreak. David didn't really say that, but I know he agreed with me. For now we have to just wait and hope it doesn't turn into a disaster. But personally, I just don't want to see Catherine in a hopeless future. Love or not, she is an omega and she belongs here. Not with Humans. If only I have the nerve to make her realize of that. For now, I shake away those thoughts. We have a job to do.

I close my laptop as they take the chairs opposite to my table. Catherine says, hey Blake. Missed in the morning briefing. Heard you were not in office yet. I am a little annoyed because of the reason, that's David's fault. He kept me occupied with his training. Marina asks, didn't you had one yesterday. I sigh, he missed last night's session, so asked to have it in the morning. Catherine and Marina turn to each other and snicker. I could have asked what happened, but I already know the answer.

There are rumors that people saw a woman leaving his house last night. Some dark and blurry pics were taken of her driving away from his house. No one know who the woman is or if this rumor is really true. Based on the tweets, they imply they tried to hook up. But she ran away before spending the night with him. Setting aside the fact that David is not that type of guy, I don't think he would allow this to happen. Marina asks excited, did he tell you anything about that. I ask, you think we gossip about each others night life. He didn't say anything, I didn't ask. She scoffs, boring. I am going to meet him tonight. There a bazillion questions for him.

Catherine asks, you think he will tell you anything. Marina says, I will make him. For a while I have been tell him to meet someone. Get a more normal life, and start dating. I ask, you think this is an attempt at that. Marina scoffs, if this is true, he skipped all the steps. He can't just invite woman in for a casual hookup. Catherine says, I don't think this is true. The guy is too much of a wimp to be do be so bold. I add, maybe the old David. But can you honestly say that after witnessing a post Ketriya David. That sent Catherine into a thought, while Marina got even more hyped up, he is got a point. We don't know how much of exploring he is doing. You remember what he told us during the dinner at his place.

Catherine says, that was just about his new preference and lifestyle. Marina scoffs, yeah. That includes dating. I am going to grill him and ask who the poor women is entangled in all his craziness. Honestly, I don't think anything happened. When I met him at the training center, he was just as focused on training like usual. But I can't deny he be able to hide any relationship he has with the women. To be honest, I was a little disconnected while sparing with him. Its bothering me that he encouraged Catherine to meet Robb. I would be lying if I wanted him to stay out of people's lives. Especially hers.

They both were discussing who the girl might be. But I put an end to it, lets stop here. As much as everyone wants to know her, if David doesn't want anyone to find her, no will know. Both of them had to realize the futility of this. Marina says, doesn't mean I can't try. I chuckle, I am sure you will. Lets get on with the meeting though. Catherine called ahead to meet me and Marina earlier. So we both didn't have any idea what this was about. She only mentioned its about her investigation. I motion Catherine to begin. She places her tablet on my desk, as you know. I have been conducting my own investigation.

She refers to what we discussed in Davids car ride from Drews place. Marina says, I thought you weren't going to share the intel with us. Why the change of heart. She smiles, don't worry. I am not giving away everything. But this is a heads up so you guys aren't playing catch up. I am intrigued by her confidence. She turns to Marina, I know about your little Citradel meeting last week. I am guessing you tasked the new jonnies to investigate something. Marina remains lip locked. So did I. She says, so I was right. You are looking for something, maybe even someone. And you can't trust our cities officers.

Just how did she uncover that meeting. I was sure to keep it hidden. Marina signals me in Shadow sign language, someone slipped up. She had the same thought as I. None of the Citradel officers were assigned to her department. So someone poked around and Catherine saw them in a place they aren't normally there. If it was Marina, she wouldn't be caught. So its one of those three. I like to ask who it was, but that would mean admitting he were actually searching for a mole. Catherine says, don't worry. I am not going to say anything to anyone. I don't know what really happened, but if you Shadows believe it to be important. I won't butt in.

That was considerate of her. I can't tell by her aura if she is in a good mood because she met Robb or just being herself. And I hate that I have to even question her like this. Catherine continues, that was just something I wanted to mention. But tell Chelsea that she needs to be more discrete when talking to Rose. Chealse made a mistake meeting her instead of, literally like anyone else. So it was her. And on top of that she tried to asses Rose. That would definitely attract attention if Rose caught wind of Chelsea's intentions. I motion Marina, who nods agreeing to talk to her later.

Catherine adds, I know about the drugs and you are trying to find the people who stole them from Wyan. What I don't know how it relates to the internal investigation you have going on. She hadn't connected that particular thread for now. She continues, anyways. I figured I focus on who made that poison. Marina leans in, you know who it was. She says, not exactly. Did you investigate the two drugs. MCTL and Hetrox. I nod. We even searched for the third critical drug, Pesphinate. Marina and me tasked our Shadow recruits. So far nothing has panned out of it. Marina says, we looked up who has the technical knowledge to make that poison.

I explain more, we have a list of the people who may have the skills and even those who may have access to places to make it. R&D labs, hospitals, maybe their own private labs. The list is not long. But we can't eliminate without more evidence. So far, we can only keep them under surveillance hoping someone trips up. Marina says, we even are looking into their financials. But much to our dismay, nothing stands out. I am sure whoever made it, was traded with something else than money. I agreed with her. They know what that poison would do, I doubt they wouldn't take extreme precaution to hide their identity.

Catherine says, that maybe true. But you are missing something. This peeked our interest, you are only looking at people who declared their skills. I am sure you at least thought about someone hiding themselves under the cover of mundane jobs. Like how David found his therapist, Drew. She is highly skilled, but works as a glorified farmer. I reply, we discuss that possibility in length. But we have no way to figure who they are. Marina says, yeah. Like you said, they could be undercover. But we can't investigate at blind. We had to start somewhere. Catherine says, only if you didn't have additional intel.

So that's what this meeting is about. She has her own way of figuring out who made the drugs. She explains, Marina, did you know where I was day before yesterday. A strange thing to ask her. She turns to me, yeah. Blake was being cagey about it, but I heard from David what you were up to. I shrug, I heard nothing at the IDF lounge, as you know. I emphasis that to Catherine. She says, and thank you for not asking about that. But why did David tell you Marina. It was supposed to be a secret. Marina waves her fingers at her, please give me some credit. He knows what will happen if he doesn't keep me in the loop. And besides, now that this is in the open. We have a lot of Shadow dealings going on. Maybe more than what Blake knows.

Her blatant provocation at me isn't half as endearing she think she is being. I am sure she knows we both have secrets of our own and trying to gauge what they are. I say, lets just move on. Marina lets it slide with her attempts to pry. Catherine says, okay. So as I was saying, I was outside the island. I went to meet Robb, but I also had an objective. During the week, I made my own pool of suspects. And I had pulled background information on what they did while they were living among Humans. That evoked some excitement between the two of us listening to her idea. Marina says, that's really good idea.

I ask, you still have contacts outside. She says, not many. But Robb still had his contacts active. I didn't want him to involve in our business. I just wanted the names of his contacts who run down the photos of the suspects. From her words, it looks like Robb wouldn't stay out of our business. Yet another reason I disliked the idea of Catherine visiting her almost estranged boyfriend. I had to quell the nasty feelings I had to ask, and so did you get any potential suspects. Catherine says, the first list of suspect pool should arrive tomorrow. But I need you approval to authorize the transaction over the network.

That's where she needs our help. Marina tells, this is good. Between our short list of suspects, and then the ones you will have. We can cross reference it and get a viable lead. I had to agree with them. This is potential breakthrough. I say, if we know who made it. We find them, and find who they made it for. That's really good news. Catherine says, lets not get ahead of ourselves. I don't know about you, but I have a long list. And getting background information about their time in hiding is very difficult. Robb says, Home doesn't have 80% of their surveillance data. And branching out to other groups investigating our people is risky.

I guess where she is going, you want to involve David too. She says, he has probably the best network of people who can do it. I don't know how effective it will be for Medrone related targets. Marina says, worth a shot. But I had other issues with this plan, no. Involving Robb and Home is already pushing it. But involving unrelated Humans. I am drawing a line there. They both find my rejection sudden. So I lay it out properly, you realize we asking to investigate a huge portion of innocent people. Home is different, they are group of people who know about our existence, and Medrones are more or less aware of them. But letting other Humans know about us, that is cause for major trouble.

Marina says, shoot. I didn't think about others. You think if we let other people investigate they might find about Medrones. I answer, its not might. Most definitely. A comprehensive background check. Even if they decompartmentalize their intel, someone will see something they shouldn't have. An injury healed in weeks rather than months. Or not eating the same things as humans. We are putting a microscope on their lives. I understand the importance of finding the culprit. But we did this and if it ever came out we dug up people's privacy. I can't imaging the scandal we face.

Catherine sighs, that will be a disaster. Marina says, so no involving other party into our midst. But you know, there is some group there we can still involve. I ask, within David's criminal gang. How. She says, I don't know if you know, but David's put up a five Millon dollar bounty on Ryes. And those people know about us, or at least aware of our existence. Maybe its relatively safer to involve them. I shout, are you kidding me. He did what. Catherine asks when did he do that. Marina says, I think before he came back after his overseas trip last week.

I always wondered how less vocal he was about Ryes. He caused a lot of hurt to his, and our reputation. Actually, he did more of a physiological assault on David. I say, is that why he isn't doing anything major. Marina nods, its because he already made arrangements. You gotta love his precise and ruthless attack. By now I think even Citradel would be aware such a price is made on their former chancellor. You guys really didn't know. I scoff, I had no idea. Catherine says, news to me too. Marina smiles, guess I am special. She really likes to rub it in. I had a concern that's been there with me for a while, did he tell you what he plans to do with Ryes if he ever found him.

Marina shrugs, that's something even I am clueless. Before his radical treatment, I assumed it would be anywhere from interrogation to negotiation. But now, given his new proclivities to certain things. I don't have the slightest idea. Her concern was mine now. I hadn't thought of what he might do now. I don't believe he would do anything radical, now that he is free from his trauma. And yet I can't say he wouldn't have a grudge. Catherine asks, guys. Lets trust him. I know he had changed, but its still him. I guess she would know the most out of us. Marina says, yeah. Let me talk to him tonight when I meet him. Is that okay with you Blake.

I take a moment to think about the risks. If David has is own group of people who can investigate a important person as Ryes. I have to believe they are somewhat trustworthy to keep whatever information they find restrictive. I ask, yeah. You can ask if he can allow investigation of normal people. But let me talk to him before we hand him the list. I want to asses the risk with him. That's what we all agreed for now. Catherine says, just to remind you all, what I find, I follow. You do the same. I wasn't really happy with this disjoint investigation routes, but its proven to be effective. And most of all, it protects Catherine from being targeted.

We conclude the meeting with a few follow ups. Marina left for an early lunch so that she could get to the construction site. Catherine asks me a moment alone, I wanted to explain myself. She is probably referring to her visit with Robb. I wasn't really in the mood to listen to her gallivanting date. I say, like I said. I heard nothing. You don't have to explain anything to me. She doesn't let it go, I am so sorry. I know it seems like I ditched you without even asking for permission. I wanted to talk to you before I left. But my head was in different places at once. I just didn't want you to get angry with me.

Her aura showed she feels very guilty about it. I don't know how to assure her I wasn't angry. Because, truth be told. I did feel annoyed at her. But David and I promised to keep our opinions to minimum. I tell her, I was a surprised. Not mad though. Never. Just worried about you. That was true. When Vanessa I shouldn't have let her leave alone, I personally agreed with her. If only someone trustworthy was there, who could keep an eye on her. At one time I thought I should go myself. But that was just a silly thought. She says, its okay if you were though. I was selfish. I am not going to deny how wrong I was.

I tell, you got back safely. That's all that matters. But I hope next time, you at least tell me in advance. I would feel less anxious about your safety. She feels even more guilty on her impromptu departure. I couldn’t tell her how, but I was thinking of assigning a Shadow to tail her. To think a Shadow spy would be tailing someone of the family who had that Shadow role for centuries. The irony would be enough motivation for that individual for this challenge. She speaks in a low voice, I will. I promise. Hold on. That meant there will more times like this. Argh. I didn't realize it until she just said it. I was so worried for her, that I didn't get what that really meant.

That wrapped me different kind of emotion. Jealously. Just what does she see in that Human. Do they really expect that they can keep this facade. Catherine picks on my frustration. She says, you are upset. I can tell. I don't expect you to understand me. I sometimes think I don't even understand myself. I should tell her I wasn't angry at her. But then I would be lying. I rather keep my mouth shut than say something wrong. Catherine says, I won't let this get in the way of my job again. Believing I wasn't onboard of her, she starts to assure me with promises. I feel a little tricked. Does she really want me to accept this crazy arrangement.

Things took even a crazy turn when she told about setting up a personal link with Robb. I held out my annoyance so that she doesn't think I was getting in the way of her relationship. I should have said this is unacceptable. Its definitely some sort of violation. But instead I said, that’s good. A balance in life is important. I decided to go with a lame comment. Even she realized I was just trying to appear polite to her, I shouldn't have said that. Again, I am so sorry. I am going to try and limit it once or twice a week. I almost said not to do it all. Aside from the obvious dangers, why she want to torture herself like this. Is this long distance relationship going to work as she hopes.

I may have not been the most appreciate of her efforts. Because she soon ends the conversation and leaves. I actually felt a relief from not showing the irritation. I had a lot to say to her, but David pretty much covered everything we had to say to her. I need a distraction. I went to Tina's officer and ask for the latest update on the public transport upgrade. She shows a report of the progress, which was at 25 %. The same as yesterday night, which she pointed out specifically to me. I can't tell her I was just stopping by to get my mind off things. Then Luther joins in and gives reports on the other infrastructure.

After hearing the report I ask, when will they be ready with the demo houses and buildings. Luther looks at his notes, Ivan gave a timeline of 10 days. Maybe 8 even if they sort out their problem with enriching Kuretine with the foundations. Said something about the levels in the ground more than anticipated. Tina asks, is that bad. Luther says, on the contrary. They say it's actually good news. But they have to adjust for it perpetually. I say, the ambient Kuret is flowing gradually becoming stronger around the island. Luther nods, that’s what they said. They think the tournament influenced it. With so many Medrones fighting, it behaved like an epi center.

Tina says, I thought that was just a theory. People can't really influence the island. She turns to me, can we? I answer, those scientist think we do. Even I am skeptical about that. Lets leave that to the experts. But if this is happening sooner than we thought, we should prepare for it. I remember on Medrine that whenever we flip a new land, there are sometimes unexpected stuff. Like a deposit of Kuritine or wild Kuretine vegetation. I don't know how that manifest on Earth. Tina says, for real. Luther says, I am sure Ivan's team are aware of it too. But I will mention it next time we meet.

We cover the rest of the development progress. We have gotten off course with our projected timelines. It was to be expected with the delayed start. We are soon going to have to prepare more teams to work on the expansion plan. The we move on to last priority, security. Tina says, R & D received their first batch of drones today. David supposed to give a demo to Nathan and Frank tonight. Ruther is acting as liaison for IDF with them for immediate use by IDF. Luther asks me, how is he doing by the way. I hate to ask, but is his training going well? I felt a hint of suspicion from him. I guess even they heard about the gossip from people.

Tina laughs, he really has changed. I know people are saying that, but I really think he has turned over something. I have always seen him serious or secretive. But now, having women over his place. Someone's enjoying their fame. Luther says, its true what people say, being famous changes you. I would argue that David is simply taking advantage of this brief time of popularity. But I can't deny he is not shying away anymore. I answer, I couldn't get an answer from my last session with him. Regardless, of whether its true or not. He had to be enjoying the attention. Tina says, I heard some girls are hoping to lucky next. I just hope David doesn't get notoriety from this.

For the second time I am a slightly jealous. Many people are making their opinions of him. Some are still bad, but most of them are in positive light. And I hate this feeling even more. Because I personally know how dedicated he is to his training. I know this is probably a stunt to maintain an image for the people. But I still couldn't fell envious of him. He is juggling a lot of things on his hands, and yet finds time to somehow involve with others. Ah, I did it again. Made it about Catherine again. I need to learn to let it go. Catherine is happy, that should be all that matters to me.

We went for lunch after our discussion. There we met with IDF team. Ruther was every excited with tonight's demonstration. Sommers asks, how much longer for it to be operational. Any idea. Ruther replies, I am guessing about a week. We only got about 100 today. And we only start with 20 or so. That depends on it goes with Nathan. I ask, I will be there as well. I have a just a brief experience with that drones. I am curious to see them in action. Ruther says, you and Marina. She was the first one to sign up for checking it out. Like I had a way to stop her. A laughter erupted among us.

The topic naturally went over to the mysterious women leaving David's house. A lot of blatant speculation were made. June says David tried to score and failed. While Sommers said she probably just ran away in the middle after seeing the weird tech he has in his house. I don't know he learnt about the killer bots in his house. Actually, that is very possible. Deni says she heard David tried to stop the women, but was stalled by few others. They also asked me, much to my disdain. I had to explain again that he didn't tell me anything. We were just focused on our usual drill.

I wonder what Vanessa would think of all this. She has been very subdued lately. Distracted and confused. When I asked about it yesterday, she said, just dealing a lot of pressure at work. I can only hope that’s the case. Unless David told her the truth about her brother. I don't think he would do that, but that’s the only thing I believe would make her so crestfallen. Well, that and her problems with Robb. People still walking on egg shells around the sore topic. Even the new officers like June knows things are shaky between them. I can't handle another omega relationship problem. I just hope its not that and some other reason. Regardless, she is doing her job properly. At least that’s going on for her. No one is really complaining. Unlike some other omega who just abandoned us for a day. Ah, shit. I can't keep bringing her into every thought I have.

We spent the rest of the afternoon with our usual work. I worked through most of them. When the clock hit 6:00, I decided to finish the rest tomorrow. It was the demonstration time. It's at the R & D HQ. Luther decides to stay back. So only Tina and I went. On the way we met up with Catherine and Jess. Catherine and I remained awkward even after all her apologies. I wish we could go back the way we were. But it feels like a delicate wall has broken between us. And now all the nasty feelings I was avoiding is flooding in. Thankfully, I remained civil in the group. As we crossed the HQ gate, I spot Ivans team. We chatted a bit about the demo and its expectation. They were the most hyped people among the officers.

Soon Luther strolls out with Nathan and Frank from the building. Nathan says, evening everyone. We are just finishing up setting up the demo. I am going to ask you to move towards the eastside, the yard. We have setup a temporary viewing station. People hustle to the other side of the building and gather around a barricade. David was already there, working busy with the a group of lab geeks. They had dozens of monitors and machines setup. Frank explains to us that their software's are being programmed to be run on their own dedicate AI. I recall they have their own version of AI like M. Though theirs is more focus driven on Medrone technology.

Soon Marina also joined us, hey guys. Anything I missed. I gestured her to the people at the side of the building still working. She sighs, still not done yet. Lets checkout those puppies out. While we waited for their preparation, we were allowed to see the spherical drones on the ground. People seems unimpressed by the ball of steel at first. But I remember how crazy fast and versatile they were. Marina tells other, don't be fooled by its appears. Once we were entrapped by these drones. Though, if I wanted to, I could have crushed them away without breaking a sweat. She somehow boasts both the tech and herself.

She wasn't wrong though, they don't feel intimidating enough to be a big threat. Like David told us before, they are recon drones with limited fire power. Soon the rest of the IDF officers arrive. So we should be getting started soon. I caught Vanessa looking somehow even more distracted today. He aura is fluctuating a lot wilder. I hoped nothing serious happened so I approached her, Vanessa. Are you okay. You seem more anxious than before. She sighs, sorry. I just had an expected visitor a while ago. Its nothing you have to worry about. I ask, are you sure. I don't mean to pry, but I am a little worried about you. She says, I appreciate the concern. But seriously, its fine.

She then looks at the direction of David. She says, has he been here all this time. I nod, I heard since 4:00. Why, did he do something again. She scoffs, maybe. I don't understand what she means by that. I don't think he told her about her brother. I don't think he even talked to her recently. So maybe it was about something else. I had a hunch, so I ask her, do you know who that women was at his place yesterday. She turns a grim on that question. I think I need to back off now. Her aura felt unpredictable right now. As long as she not makes any scene with David, I don't want to get in middle of them. I have enough drama of my own to deal with.

Few minutes later, we get an announcement from Nathan, thank you all for waiting. We are ready. He gestures to Frank and David. He then points to the spheres on the ground, first of all. Let me be clear. This tech is technically classified as a fusion between Hive transfigurable material and Earth's micro technology. Those of you who want to know more of the technical details, feel free to ask as after this. As you know, we have been trying to reverse engineer Hive tech. We haven't had much succuss in that research. But thanks to a certain celebrity, we have a better chance. I am going to spare you all the details on he got Humans to work on this. Needless to say, its highly experimental.

All of the scientist had their eyes on the prize on the ground. Nathan continues talking about some high level functionalities. I followed most of them, but some were very technical. He spent quiet some time on the theoretical aspects. Naturally, his words was targeted at the scientists who were the best people to understand its potential. The last part was about repurposing with Kuretine tech. He underlines the unique challenge to achieve it, but also the incredible benefits when we do figure it out. Our warfare capability will drastically change. We lost a significant portion of Medrines science and tech, and on top of that, we have even less people with the right skills. This will balance the scale.

He concludes, what we need is firepower. Hive will be back, and this time we have to be ready for them. Lets hope this gets us better chance to fight them off. His passionate words amassed a lot of appreciations from the crowd. Many applauded, leaving the scientist excited more than ever. He gestures, so lets get started. David, its your stage. David swaps in Nathans place on the pavement. He says, hello everyone. Lets dive in to the highly anticipated part of the evening. And at any time, if you have questions, I will answer them to best of my knowledge. Marina didn't even hesitate with her question, who's the girl at your place. Everyone wants to know.

Leave it her to ask outrageous questions at such a time. But people found her hysterical and brief wave of laughs flow in the crowd. David's gives us a wide grin, well, Marina, I would tell, but for the life of me, I don't know what you are talking about. He is overtly stating he won't reveal who it was. That didn't discourage Marina even a bit. She just gives him a subtle nod signaling she will continue that later. David says, gross invasion of privacy aside, I like to point out few things about how I use these tech. As you already heard, the tech name is aptly labeled as ART. Though, unlike the name its not completely a reconfigurable matter.

A scientist asks, we inspected the designs earlier, some of there core parts are not transfigurable. David nods, yes. Unlike Hives pure programmable matter, we can't really achieve the same level. What it means that there are restrictions to the tech. There are ways to circumvent the issues, like designing the core parts to the objective you want. Case in point, these spheres that you see here. These are the lowest level my team could achieve. He gestures to Frank, who punches in on the computer. The spheres roar to life as they begin to levitate in the air. Out of the 10, three of them reveal a weird shaped gun. That’s what Marina and I back at the cliff.

The three sphere scurry off fast, circling around the crowd with speed. After showing its speed, the trio spheres speed off towards the model of a few dummy Medrones. They fire the guns, which turned out to be concentrated laser blasts. With precision and different angles, they tore through the iron molted dummies in just 6 shots. Then they hover around another dummy, to which they zap it with a thin electrified net, presumably for capturing target. For the last dummy, the spheres shift their weapons into a sort of sphere. With those pointed ends, just one sphere was enough to ram it through it, leaving behind a decapitated dummy from the middle.

The crowd applauds after witnessing their capabilities. David speaks up while the spheres swing back onto the ground, as you can see. They are fast, coordinated, and precise. But they have limited firepower, only enough to subdue smaller targets. Because, as impressive they are, they aren't strong enough for targets that can fight back. They so have excellent coordination capability. For that reason, they have a much better usefulness. Next three drone activate. Unlike the previous one, they immediately transform, one changes into a large bird. But not the Earth bird, it turned into a Medrone bird that had Kuritine features.

People gasp at its appearance. I can't remember what this bird was called, but I am sure they are extinct now. The bird flaps its wings and soars through the sky. The next one turns into a four legged Medrone dog. I remember this animal, Lymons. We had a flock of them at our homes. Excellent guard dogs. Like Earth dogs, they had a excellent sense of Kuret smells. The ART Lymon starts to run around the group. Marina crouches down and tried to pet it. But the Lymon snaps and bares its teeth to her. She jerks, hey. Its not at all friendly. But then it moves towards Deni, who it just snugs around her feet. She hesitantly tries to pet at its head, which it liked so much it starts to wag its tail.

Marina snaps, what. You have bug in the software. David laughs, maybe it just doesn’t like people who stuck their nose in other people's business. That made her give a infuriating chuckle. He says, you can customize your targets

threat capability and make them behave appropriately. That cocky guy must have programmed to do this specifically for her. The last drone turns into a fish, this one was a normal Earth fish. The fish suddenly flies off in the air and dips into a miniature pond at the edge of the yard. Sommers ask, a flying fish. That’s like some fantasy game or shit like that. The fish swims normally in the water. Nathan smirks, don't get fooled by their appearance.

Ivan says, that’s right. They may look like animals, but there machines. They don't have the biological features, but they mimic them to hide their propulsion thrusts. David nods, yup. The bird that flew, it can fly without moving its wings, no problem at all. But it will no doubt be unrealistic and stand out immediately. What you is see an reactive behaviors. These drones can be deployed in civilian population for day to day surveillance. These don't have a lick of combat capability. And unfortunately, can't be programmed to other species. You can maybe change their colors, texture, body frames, and certain extraneous features. However, their core skeleton remains the same.

A scientists asks, what is the blocking for a free transformation. David says, their engine drives. At the moment, Hive is only one who can somehow change their energy into matter, and then change back to energy. That is too advance for us. And for Humans, he scoffs, its close to science fiction. Maybe you can figure out a way to change with some Kuritine type energy. That sparked a few hushed conversation among the scientists. People broke into groups to inspect the three surveillance animals. While they appear to react like animals, they had sensors and cameras working all the time. The bird was able to capture pics of people on the ground from high above. The fish had a radar and sonar. The Lymon had thermal imaging and far off audio listening capabilities.

Nathan gives us explanation how they can be modified to detect Kurets too. But that’s a far off future development. Ivan was more interested about its current usefulness. Since they don't have any Medrine tech, they aren't influenced by Kuret or vice versa. So they are already perfect as it is for some of the objectives we want right now. Soon we come to last four remaining drones. David says, these aren't configured for contain or ground surveillance. These are completely for stealth. The drones didn't change their shape, instead they went invisible. Audible gasps can be heard from people. I was not expecting this to happen. Like many, I looked around to notice there whereabouts.

But not even a sound was heard. Suddenly Marina shouts, I got one. She had a charm opened on one hand and viewing through the surroundings with it. David says, I guess its not really effective against certain brunets. Marina stands tall and proud. David gestures, what about the others though. Marina looked around, but she didn't find the others. Meanwhile, Frank brought a laptop that was linked to the drone. It was a shot of us from high above, which slowly zooms in closer to the ground. Marina turns her charms to the sky, but she still couldn't find it. David says, they are near the edge of the barrier. And sure, given time you may be able to pin point their position.

Marina sighs, but I can't really do anything about it. Unless I do this, she throws a super fast thin blast towards a direction. Like a homing missile, it locked on to the nearest drone position. Its too far off to see, but I could see the aura of Marina's Kuret. Its hits something and dissipates at impact. Frank shows a footage from a different drone that showed the collision. Marina's Kuret didn't even hit the drone. The drone has a thin red laser grid surrounding itself. Ivan asks, there is some sort of protective field around it. David explains, it’s a magnetic field running along a laser grid. Marina says, I have to say its impressive. There is not even a scratch on it. David points to the drones above, of course if she had hit up close, it would be destroyed. Its strength lies in the distance. It can fly about to a mile and half outside a targets range.

David tells, Instead of zero combat capabilities, I designed for operational oversight. Nathan says, its actually a clever system. Instead of letting the other bots rely on self governance, these bots coordinate the ART tech. They are the brains of the system. They fly above us, in completely hidden from sight. And have a complete picture of the target. Frank hits a button and it shows a topological grid view of the HQ. Even circles around the people and the ART bots lying on the ground right now. Frank says, David had an idea to turn into a sort of an mini satellite for the island. Which is a daunting challenge, but very crucial.

Jess asks, this is good for security and all. But isn't it a bit too intrusive. What about privacy and sensitive things people don't want seen. Nathan agrees with her, naturally we need a balance of that. We haven't even begin the planning stage, but this was already an argument we have to address. Of course, by the time this tech is progressed enough to be deployed, we will have to have some rules. I nod, like surveilling only pubic areas. Nathan smirks, more like restricting homes, private institutions or businesses. With this tech, restricting much easier than focusing on selective targets. I guess he had a point.

Tessa asks, can they be utilized in the ocean too. Nathan turns to David for that question. David says, the accuracy drops by 30 %. But yeah, they are fully functional. Like Nathan said, they are the controlling mechanisms for any underwater ART marina bots. I have been using them personally for my. He halts for a moment, never mind that. Like Vanessa wanted, the border security will greatly benefit from this tech. Vanessa says, good. We are struggling to keep up the defense tight right now. The four bots descend back down and people inspect them much closer. I place my hand over the invisible field. David warns, careful. Better to use your Kuret.

Without my Kuret, I would definitely get hurt. I wrap my elbow with Kuret and field. The field glowed red against my blue Kuret. It tried to push me back, but I held enough power that I was able to dig though the barrier without much resistance. Marina followed suit and got through in faster than me. Tessa, Vanessa, June and Sommers. They got through as well. The rest couldn't. If they really tried to cut through, they could, but that would mean more Kuret or weapons. Suffice to say these drone had the strongest defense system. I ask, what about Hive. Are they effective against them.

I am sure others wondered the same. Because while this is impressive, its not effective until its against Hive. David smiles goes away, unfortunately, I can only tell you about simulation probability wins. There is no way to test it against real Hive forces. The only thing we can do is prepare for any and all type of eventualities. Nathan says, that’s the down side. We can test it all day, but never be sure about it against Hive. But, who knows. If they ever come down knocking at our doorstep in a small, isolated and testable condition. We might try it against them. He spoke like they were control subjects, which is highly unlikely to ever happen in reality.

After a bit of more technical talk, David gathers everyone, there are hundreds of vulnerabilities and issues. However, you can realize their benefits are high too. Nathan chips in, once we fit it with Kuretine tech, we will a version suited to our needs. The drones then drop dead with the rest of the them on the ground. Marina asks with enthusiasm, this is not everything. Is there. Get those killer robots out, already. I have been dying to see it again. Her excitement, reignited peoples curiosity.

David replies with a big smile, all right. Lets move on to the real fun part.

Vanessa (Chapter 114)

Sunday, March 15, 2026 11:59

Last few days I have been able to focus on much. I do my work diligently, but I can't seem to enjoy it like I used to. Every now and then my thoughts would inevitability fall back to Ned. His confession, the actual reason for the fight still makes me wonder how I missed it. Maybe I did know, but just assumed he was fine. During the flag capture game, he was a bit more agonistics to David. He said it was just because they were direct competitors that time. But maybe it was more than that. Honestly, I mad at myself for not seeing it. David and I have been getting closer together this year. Any guy would be jealous of his girlfriend be spending time with another guy.

He has to know there is nothing going on between us. But if I am being honest, I feel conflicted. Was it easier for me to be angry at Ned than to reconcile with him. All because of an unreasonable excuse I was making about not taking my side. I have been questioning a lot ever since Ned told me that. He told me he loves me. But I couldn't say it back. And he knows that. The guilt is eating me up. Why couldn't I tell him back. Why couldn't I just forgive him. It was never about him not trusting me. I selfishly believed it was about me. Just like what I have been doing with David.

Arg, this is giving me a headache. I drank water from the glass at my desk. The officers building right now are buzzing with people in the hallway. In 4 hours, there is going to be some a demo at R & D HQ. Not many are invited, but that didn't stop them from approaching me and get a pass. I put my foot down explaining its not a tech exposition. They will be shown when Blake and I are ready for it go public. If people knew that it was Human and Hive tech, it would create a long unending debate amongst people. Scientific progress vs the morality and pride. We don't have time for people to be nit picky about how we fight our wars.

Sommer tells, that’s the latest on the latest arrest. We recovered something called Goya from their house. Hidden inside a the basement wall. Its a painting of some war with a guy named Napolean. I groaned a little, I still have no idea what its about. Sommers says, me too. But Deni almost fainted when an officer accidently dropped it. So no doubt very valuable. Its not that I don't appreciate art, but I don't have the same passion as others. But I didn't need to know the history to understand its value. If its old, its vital to Human history. And its best for everyone if we treat it with the respect it deserves.

Sommers asks, David hasn't visited the IDF storage vault. When is he planning to see the artifacts. I scoff, knowing him. He probably has already seen it. I won't be surprised if he checked it after that dinner meeting. He laughs, you might be right about that. Tonight, we will see what this artifacts buys us. For many people who haven't seen David's tech, it’s the first time. I seen a glimpse of that back at his house. I didn't get a good look at it, but even I am intrigued by this. Sommers leaves for IDF while I stayed here to deal with some of my work.

An hour later I hear a knock at my door. I reply, I am busy. Come back after the break. I had a deadline to finish tonight and can't really accommodate others right now. There is another knock, followed by an officer saying, sorry chief. But there is someone here who wants to speak to you. Says its urgent. I think you know her, names Elina. Her name surprised me. What's she doing here. Didn't she have a routine check for tomorrow. But Sommers is in charge of that. I reply back, Sommers went back to IDF. Tell her to meet him there. He replies, got it. I thought that would be the end of it. But he comes back with another knock, she says she is here for you.

I don't have time for this. But if she is being persistent about it, it might be some kind of emergency. I tell him, tell her to meet me here in 30 minutes. I will be taking a break then. He leaves to convey my answer. He didn't approach me again, so I guess either she left or is waiting. Either way I wrapped up my work by then. I opened the door and see Elina sitting at the hallway end couch. She wore a blazer and jeans. She really waited for me. Must be really important. I gesture at her to come on in. She notices me and frantically walks in my office. She says, thank you Vanessa. I am so glad I could meet you.

I reply, hey Elina. She takes the chair opposite to mines. She seems troubled a little, almost anxious. I ask, is everything all right. That forces her to settle down a bit, yeah. I mean, no. Not really. Its been tough this two weeks. I can only imagine the duress she is under. I ask, and Ryan. Is he doing better. He nods, much better. The other day he finally talked to his friends. Though he couldn't tell why he was away. So he is still upset. I say, but I heard you are helping him lot. His is lucky to have a sister like you. She makes a nervous giggle, yeah. Lucky him. I couldn't put my finger on it, but she acting very suspicious.

I ask, so, what can I do for you. You have any new information for us. I guessed she would approach me directly only if she had something to offer. Instantly she begins to freak out. Nervously fidgeting with her hands, even a makes a very somber face. I lean in a little worried, did something happen. She isn't able to for any coherent words. She is really struggling to say something. The curiosity was eating me up. I had no choice for her to speak up. After what seemed like a heavy silent minute, she blurts out, ah, freak this. I can't do it. I thought I can do it. The lying has to stop. I ask, what are you talking about. What lies.

Then she told her biggest regret. With every word she said, my anger rose up. I can't believe I ever felt pity to her. She covered up her own crimes and has the gall to walk in here. Her face is buried in the ground all the while she explains her how she covered for Peter. I almost loose it when I hear she even stole the missing ledger. I kept my anger in check. But that didn't stop my words, you are a piece of work. Aren't you. I defended you. Gave others my recommendation that you were innocent. I even tried to release your assets, so you get can get your life back. I can't believe you were in on it from the beginning.

Her voice is breaking when she looks up, I am so sorry. I never imagined this would have happened. I would have never done it otherwise. I scoff, people rarely know what their actions leads to. Do you have any idea what you have done. You covered up a massive smuggling operation. You nearly died because of your own selfishness. I shake my head, you have no idea what you could have avoided if you had reported it in. Elina begins to lightly sob. I shout, don't even try to gain for any sympathies. I am fresh out. I feel like a fool for the all the times I believed her. Even when many believed she wasn't just the victim, I kept the hope she was innocent.

My fury boils on how naïve I was. Elina speaks, I can't apologies enough. I don’t know what happened because of me. He didn't tell me anything. But I understand that my actions have hurt others. I ask, him. Who? Peter. Or you partner in crime Wayn. She cuts me off, I have no connection to that freaker. Believe me. I said aloud, I don't believe anything you say now. How can I. You have been lying to everyone for months. I don't care for your personal reasons. Whether it was for Ryan or your ambitions. You made a mockery of me. I am done listening to you.

I got up, I am going to drag your ass to jail myself. You might run away. Elina breakdown horrified at my response. What did she expect I was going to do. Forgive her. She shouts, please. Before you do anything, give me a minute to explain. I heard enough, I don't care. I walk around the table and grab her by the arm. She panics and yell, please. I want to make things right with you. I beg you, just give a chance. If you don't think its enough, I will go with you. I deserve any punishment you give. More tears roll down her face. I want to believe this is not an act. But I didn't have a shred of trust in her. But there must be something she has of value that made her confess to me.

With an arduous effort, I let get of her arm. I tell her, you have 5 minutes. If I don't like what you have to say. I am taking your ass. She nods and blurts out everything she knows. I slump back in my chair as she cries and tells me what her plan was. No, theirs. David finally fessed up and told her how he has been semi stalking her. She wails explaining he wants to help her. She sniffs, he made a plan. A plan to leverage my freedom for the ledger. It was so good that I honestly thought I could do it. But. Looks away in shame, I couldn't go through with it. I thought I can. But not anymore, because you still believed I was innocent.

I should feel pity for her, getting wrapped up with David's scheme. But something is not sitting right with me. I ask, I don't understand you. You know who David is now. He might be a world class jerk, but he is a bonified genius. If he says he had a plan to get you out of trouble. Why in the hell did you throw it away. She faces me back again, because I can't look at myself anymore. David made me feel I could do it. And until now, I thought I could do it. But lies got in into this, and I can't keep lying anymore. That was her limit, huh. Or wait. Maybe this was what David planned all along. I ask her, this is all him. Isn't it. He manipulated you into confessing. And wants me to get forgive you. That is not happening.

Elina replies, no. He said that I shouldn't mention his name or the his plan. Just about leveraging the ledger. I scoff, you poor pathetic girl. He are playing right into his hands. For the first time Elina gets angry, stop it. Its not his fault. I am amazed how gullible she is. She says while wiping away her tears, I had a lot of time thinking about it. He didn't need to have to tell me anything. But he did. And you are right about him getting his way. But he promised me it wasn't about him. He even forced me to agree to few conditions. I wasn't buying any of it. But then I realized how overzealous I always am in prosecuting him.

I hate it, but I think I am just letting my frustration at him because of what Ned said to me. I take a beat and pull back my emotions. Maybe I should listen to her first. I ask her, what were his conditions. Turns out I really jumped the gun. I thought David was just using Elina, maybe even trying to win her over in some sort of sick sadistic way. But when Elina pulls out the deed to her shop, my anger subsided. I have seen enough of Elina's interrogation to know that the only thing beside her love for Ryan, is her bar. She says, I tainted something I love with selfish desire. I can't in good conscious work there anymore.

I had to be a tactic. A ploy to gain enough sympathy from me. Especially since I couldn't read the dead myself and confirm if its real. She slides it to me, you can check with others. I am giving it up. I even locked the bar. She fishes out a key from her jacket and puts it on top of the paper stack. This seems more and more real now. I pick up the key and its exactly the one we gave her back when we released her. I ask, are you serious about this. She nods, I am. Its the right thing to do. I don't know about that, but this decision is something she didn't make her own. David really put her up to this.

Then she told the other condition. Meeting me and confessing her involvement. I listen to her reasons in confusion. David thought if I ever heard that if he was involved, I wouldn't believe anything. What's even worse is that, he is right. I am questioning everything ever since she told it was their plan. She is trying to justifying her actions to me. She says, like he said, I don’t want to rely on just his methods. But couldn't go through with his plan. Maybe I really shouldn't have told you everything. But, like I said. I am done lying. I just want to sleep peacefully at night, without looking over my shoulder.

I ask her, even if that means you don't get to be with Ryan. Because that’s what you have done. You could have stick the plan. She says, I don't know what's right. I only know what's wrong. I want you to trust me. I just didn't want to do that with more lies. If that costs me Ryan. She takes a short breath, so be it. I am begging you to please forgive me. But I will not be angry at you if you decide to still arrest me. I don’t have the right. At this point I think she is telling me the truth. I have seen her playing the victim before. But this time, its different. It feels more real. In the back of my mind, I still think this a way to get me to pity her.

But she is going against David plan. That strangely makes me want to believe her more. Where does that leaves me. I should arrest her. But she is ready to give up her life she built here. And, like she pointed out. It was Karma that she nearly died because she covered up for the very people who nearly killed her. If David had never met her, she be dead because of her own fault. A poetic justice. Ah, this is so damn infuriating. She says, please. Give me another chance. Don't you have regrets that you wish you can be forgiven for. I have plenty, but I wonder what she knows. I ask, what did he say about me.

She shakes her head, he didn't tell me anything. Just that you are willing to at least understand me, if not forgive me. I don't understand him. First he tells his secret to her and then makes her confess to me. He could have told her about my own crimes. She could have appealed that I had made far worse mistakes. But he didn't reveal any of that. Just convinced her without it. Her snuffed cries still echo in my silent office. I stare at the key and paper stack, I don't know what to do with you. Maybe this does balance out what you did. But asking me cover up this is incredibly arrogant of you both. What if I said that I will take it to Blake or others to decide what happens to you.

She gives a disappointed smile, I already told you. I will be fine with whatever you want. She looks away, I thought I need to be there for Ryan no matter what. But I never thought what happened to him because of me. He could have died at the treatment plant. The only reason he was there because Peter brought us. Which I could have avoided from the beginning. Maybe Ryan will forgive me for being so selfish, but I will never. So I am prepared to do whatever I can to make this right. I really want to believe her. After listing to the fake plan of theirs, she did held some merit. She wasn't really involved in the crime, only hiding her brothers sketchy business.

I was ready to blame her for all the things Wyan did. However, now that I have calmed down. I don't think she is responsible for everything. She made a choice to protect her family, her life she built. I know what's that's like. And no has really died due to this. At least not that we know of. Can she really be blamed for it if there were any. Like she said to me just now, she isn't a warrior, just a girl who made a really stupid mistake. I sigh, I need to talk to him. I don't know what I will do. But I know that I won't do anything until I speak with him. Elina nods and turns grim, I understand. But, are you going to tell him I told the truth.

This is so weird. She is scared of me, and yet she scared of him knowing she didn't follow the plan. Did they get bond over this. Then it hits me, hold on. Last night there was a rumor of a girl leaving his place. Was that you. When I heard it this morning, I immediately scrapped it from my thought. David maybe be many things, but he is wimp when it comes to this. He had a chance with Sophie, and he didn't take it. But maybe after his Ketriya, he has changed too much. Elina yells, nothing happened between us. I just wanted to talk to thank him. And it turned out very differently. And by the time we decided to call it night, people were outside his place.

She really was there. There sudden closeness is alarmingly suspicious. That photo of hers was taken to look like she had sex. This brought up a whole new wave of emotions within me. Elina saw through me, I swear. Nothing happened. It was the only way I could think of to get away. I didn't want to do it, but I had no choice. And he was more than happy to make people believe it was true. I didn't realize it, but I was extremely furious at him for taking advantage of a vulnerable women. But maybe they didn't do anything. It took a while for me simmer down from the shock.

I tell her, just leave. Go home and stay there until I figure what to do with you. I have her an order which she can't disobey. I haven't made any decision, but I rather not have her tell people about David. Elina stands up with a pale face, okay. I won't leave my home. She turns her back to me and walks away completely drained of life. Before she leaves, she stops for second, I apologies for all trouble I have caused. With that goodbye she steps out through the door. This is mess I seriously didn't want or need right now. I open my phone and send a pic of the deed to Luther. Let me first confirm that this is a not a forgery.

I tried to resume my work, but Elina's pleas occupied my mind. She may have not done it out of malice or greed. But its impossible for me to take a decision. I wish I can include others to help me figure out what to do. I spent the next hour reviewing the interrogations from Elina, Peter, Ryan and Wyan. I had already done this before, but with this truth I am looking for any collusion between Elina and any other member of the smugglers. So far I didn't find any connection, nor did Roland's and Tessa's assessments suggested anything out of the ordinary. Its fair to say they don't have any direct dealings.

Just before I got ready to leave for the R & D demo, I got a message from Luther. I heard his analysis and confirmed that it was the original document with real signature. He asked why its with me. I didn't want to lie to him, so I replied back saying Elina contacted me to discuss something. I told him that I might have a way find the ledger. That was the extent to which I can reveal things to him. I put the deed and the key in my safe. It would have been much easier if that document was fake. While heading back, I met up with the rest of the IDF people. Everyone were eager to checkout the demonstration, while I was yet again distracted.

We arrived on time and most people had already arrived. When Blake asked me if I was okay, I was really tempted to tell him about Elina. But then I saw David and decided to play it off. It feels weird that he is causally working with Frank while also imploding other people lives. When the event started, I brought my focus on assessing the tech. I was secretly hoping David tanks the demo. It would be a satisfying revenge to see his inventions fail. I chided myself at that thought all the time. Just how much petty can I behave. The fact that tech were very impressive were making me irrationally frustrated. I had to reluctantly agree about their usefulness.

One the sphere drones demo was done, he brough out a new bot. This one was different than the one I saw at his house. He says, meet ART bots. Two bots came from out from under a tent. They had square heads, two camera eye sockets with hour long metal arms. Theor bottom were half leg, half wheels. This one had a bulky frame and more equipped with different weapons. David explains, these are secondary combat bots. Or I S bots for short. These combat abilities are superior to the drones. The bots weapons transform into different weapons, a sword, gun, shield, flamethrower, emp, rifles and even a freaking bazooka. Their artilleries are anything compatible, from normal human weapons to sophisticated bombs.

People were completely enthralled with the capability of these bots. I was impressed by the implosion blasts and electrified ropes. Even just one of them might give the run for a money against a normal Medrone. David says, again. Warriors can take them out. Though I not without some risks. To show his point, one bot throws one laser blast, that tore through the same dummy from begore in one go. Marina says, jeez. That’s what was pointed at us that time. She laughs thinking about the their encounter. Ivan asks, and they run on the same energy? Another scientist asks, how do you account for the increase in heat dissipation and intra surface area stability when you scale up the energy distribution. Ivan asks, is it linear or non-linear.

Neither Nathan or Frank had an answer. They turns to David. David squints his right eye like he is trying hard to answer the question. Marina laughs, sorry guys. Those are some difficult questions. Not even he knows. She goads at a focused David. David didn't even respond to her. He thinks about it for a few seconds and says, there is an internal component which convert the excess energy into eddy currents. Those are nullified by a laminated magnetic ring component. The surface is specially designed to act as a kinetic absorbing material, to dissipate the friction and heat when changing form. The same technology DARPA uses is their sonic jets.

That answer went above all our heads. But the scientists seem to have understood and ask follow up questions. Marins bites her lips realizing she made a fool of herself. Oddly I understood how she felt, let it go Marina. You won't win against a scientific wits with him. She scoffs, I just need to try harder to knock his ego down a bit. Knowing she was only doing to having fun with him actually made me even more mad. I feel similar to when I was trying to expose Mack to Elina. The same petty grudges from the time I haggled him for his ART tech. I should have leant to out grow such childish feelings.

But Marina did get her wishes in the end. There were some very complex questions that not even David could answer, I have no clue how the non configurable components handle the energy spikes from the nano bots. How about we do this, I can't share the research. But maybe you can send me your questions and they might answer them. I don't think they will give away their secretes. But who knows, they might give some hints. One guy was already taking notes and videos with her Kuretine recorder. She says, that’s sounds like a wonderful idea. I will compile a list for you.

That eased up the hard questions from him. Marina laughs and points to him when he turns exhausted. He says, someone is having fun. She smiles, you finally tripped up. He sighs, my bad. I should have read the research once more. I will be more ready if it happens next time. He wasn't even bothered by her criticism. This left Marina a little irked. Their banter caused people to laugh at the two of them. He says, how about you checkout their non combat purposes. Blake asks, they have other uses. He nods, they are secondary bots. I have been exploring different applications.

To show his point, one bot begins wheels over to the lab setup and picks out a computer. Its hands turn into fingers like a persons and starts dismantling the computer in front of us. It was quiet a spectacle to see the bots arms coordinate so skillfully and with complete accuracy. Each arm screws out the bolts independently and yet coordinated with blinding skill. The whole computer is dissembled in pieces in minutes. Nathan says, whoa. You never told they are capable of delicate work like this. Everyone gawks at the bot as it begins to resemble it again. The reverse took a bit longer. But when the computer boots up normally, it shows its success.

Frank says, such meticulous work, its quite an efficient worker. Ivan asks, so it can be programmed to learn anything. David says, not anything. That feat may look impressive, but it took months to optimize it. There are many limitations. Ivan says, this will help us with some of critical Kuritine enrichment. He whispers something to a person beside him. David says, maybe. That’s up to you. I have been using them has house bots. I scoff thinking he is using lethal machines for chores. Nathan yells, seriously. What the freak man. Using Farari as a lawn mower.

David says, please. I have my things I find tedious. When I am too tired, it can cook for me. People mock at him as rants about food being his major problem. Even I found it amusing how our problem isn't his and the reverse is true as well. He says, and besides. I have another use for them. Without any hesitation, he pulls out the jacket and his shirt. People, especially women, stare at his bare chest. I would be lying if I wasn't among them. He turns his back and points to a faded stitch near his lower back, there are no surgeons in the city. Imagine how difficult it is for me to get patched up in hard to reach places.

He could have just said that, instead of stripping. He was aware of this and still enjoying himself. I think he just wanted to show off just to take even bigger spot light. When he wears his shirt back, I swear I heard Deni groaning. Argh, this is messing me up in ways I don't want to think about. If that wasn't enough, he wanted to show its even more meticulous movements. With a live performance for a tattoo. He asks around, any volunteer. How about you Marina. She scoffs, please. My skin is a temple. Sommers steps in, I'll do it. I wanted to have one for some time. Ruther slaps him on his back, you finally got the nerve to do this.

Frank brings in a chair and they quickly setup an open tattoo parlor with a bot. Beside me, Catherine asks Blake, you should get one too. It would look really cool on you. He awkwardly looks away, no thanks. I am going to ask Frank some questions, if you don't mind. Normally I wouldn't think twice about this, but he was giving off a different vibe. And so was Catherine, who looked dejected watching Blakes back. I ask her, you okay. She replies, I really screwed up. I gaze back to Blake, what do you mean. She says, he is angry with me. I don't think he was, but she clearly believed that. She says, I left the island to meet Robb without talking to him about it first. I think he feels I betrayed him.

So its about her impromptu rendezvous with Robb that’s got him lit up. I ask, but we heard you that day. Why would be still mad about it. She sighs, because he probably thinks I will leave the island to be with Robb. I couldn't suppress the shock on my face, what. Is that true. She says, no. I wouldn't never do that. I hadn't asked her what happened with Robb because I believed it was none of my business. But I had to ask now, did you not break up with him. She face with a sad expression, did you also thought I would break up with him. I guess that answers my question. I really didn't want to intrude, but I had to say my peace.

I tell her, to be honest, I thought it was inevitable. Is there an end goal or a future where an omega can remain with a human. Now, if you weren't an omega, I wouldn't have any issue with it. I am not trying to upset you, but that’s the harsh reality. She replies, I know. Believe me, I have been going through it all every day. Knowing is one thing. But actually ending a relationship is completely different problem. My head tells me one thing, but my heart says another. She looks away to David, and you know the sad part. I was mad at David for trying to keeping us apart for no reason. When I was mad at myself for not doing it myself.

I get a sense she, like me and Ned, as been blaming others for their problems. I know all to well how that’s like. I ask, so you forgave him? She nods, yeah. I did. He went out of his way to help me out. Even if that didn't pan out they way he wanted, he respects my decision at least. I can't be mad about that. Then she faces Blake, he on the other hand is not even saying anything to me. At times he doesn't even acknowledge that fact that I left. That’s even worse. It makes sense why he be frustrated with her. She is not leaving but not breaking up with the human.

I sigh feeling a more sad from my own decision with Elina. I say, meanwhile, the person responsible for all this mess is enjoying himself. I point my head towards David who was admiring at the tattoo Sommers choose for himself. Catherine laughs, you know what. He really is the biggest jerk. We both shared a melancholy laughter. Once the tattoo session was over, Sommers was now the model to showcase the sophisticated design of a wolf over his shoulder. The bot had drawn in vivid details and almost no visible mistakes. Nathan is excited with a new prospect, if we have dozens of these bots, we can manufacture our Kuritine circuit chips and micro processors.

The scientists found the idea very appealing. Nathan drapes around them like they were best buddies now. Deni asks Sommers, why a wolf though. He smiles, when I was living in the tropical islands, there was a herd of wolfs living. Their pack leader was menacing and ferocious. I figure I channel some of that attitude. Its nice to seem him get over the slump he had for a while. Marina says, you know what they call the wolf leader, right. The alpha wolf. He gives an innocent smile, coincidence. Marina shoves him over his tattoo with a laugh. David says, now that you have the ancillary benefits of these bots. Lets move on the final ART bot I have.

People prepare themselves for the climax of the demonstration. Nathan scoffs, even we haven't seen them yet. Its all very suspense and exciting. Marina yells, finally. David says, I haven't been able to configure them yet. I will only show one for now. But in few days, I will deliver them to you. He raises his watch to his mouth, initiate the bot. There has been a boxed up crate for a while, sitting at the edge of the building. Now, a mechanical sounds come from it. The next second, the wooden box is torn out from the inside and the huge spider looking bot comes out from air. The bot jumps into the air and lands in front of all of us.

Its the same bot we face at his place when David lost his mind. People gasp in awe and shock at the 10 feet tall bot. Nathan shrieks, you weren't kidding that its not public friendly. Marina frantically inspects it while circling around it, hmm, not bad. Frank says, Its looks like an insect. David says, nature has been the inspiration for many human inventions. I found arachnids to be very dangerous species in the animal kingdom. They are versatile, fast and strong. The bots arm shift into weapons, but instead of single type, they all six arms are different. A noticeable upgrade from the single weapon change from those previous bots.

David says, these, killer bots, as Marina says, are not designed for surveillance, stealth or even coordinating other bots. They have only one function, neutralize the targets. Blake asks, they don't transform like the bots before. David says, actually. They do. I have currently configured to one specific structure. The bot begins to change its shape, the three arms morphing into one on each side, same with the six legs. Soon it begins to shape like a person, even the head has features of a person with big hair. But the height remains the same. The shape transform very close to a person now. If I had to compare, it looks like statue matching one those old cities in the Rome.

Tina says, whoa. Is that freaking Michealangelo? Wait. Are you fan of Renaissance. I had no idea she would be so passionate about something like this. But she was very vocal at the dinner meeting too. I don't think many people understood the reference, including me. David says, I do enjoy the usual debate between philosophy of art and science. But this design was picked by a scientist from Rome. She probably wanted this as a homage to her home, I think. But I am down to chat the medieval times with you Tina. Catch me at my home whenever you can. That made her blush a little. Given the rumors, he is obviously living up the hype.

Nathan says, enough flirting around. What's the point it turning into a statue. David smiles, the thing is, these bot, it can transform into anything. But unfortunately, it will be immobilized in that state. I think its something to with

the Hive automatons processors we reverse engineered from the wreckage. There is some issue with the nano configuring unit that renders it useless in its transformed state. The best we could do is program the transfiguration the way we want. Marina asks, I think I get it. You can't use them as statues or objects, but you can keep them hidden in plane sight. Or even transport them with suspicion.

David says, that’s absolutely right. Imagine installing them all over the island, out in open. It can be a stump of a tree, or a pillar of a building. Maybe even a rock under the ocean. With a flip of a switch, they will active whenever there is a threat. I have to say this is most outrageously impressive part of the demonstration. The potential of our security with this is incredible. Blake asks, that's an ingenious idea. How about the combat though. Marina says, yeah. Where is the killer in these killer robots. David says, thought you never ask. We need a volunteer to test them out, because a dummy is far too easy target.

Marina raises her hand nearly jumping, me. Me. David says, anyone?. He purposefully ignores her. Marina shouts, oh come on. I want to check it out. David looks around us, anyone not an omega who cannot crush it with a flick of her fingers. I laugh picturing Marina stomping it without a sweat. Marina puts her arms down, this is some bullshit. Blake says, I'll give it a try. He was the least person I thought would want to try. Even David felt a little anxious, anyone who is not a Terra who would most definitely not disintegrate it without touching it. Blake laughs it off, but gives off the impression he could probably do it.

Jess says, I'll do it. Any problem with a dual Kuret user. David eyes fell on her, we have our contestant. Nathan says, kick that bots ass, babe. Jess mocks him away in front of everyone. The bot changes back to its original shape. We clear out some space for her as David stands between them as a referee. Jess prepares her Kuret with confidence, now don't get mad if I accidently destroy it. David laughs as he signals. Jess prepares a javelin with her Kuret. The bot dashes across grass slithering on six legs towards her with its arms pointed at her. The arms turn into cannons and guns, firring hail of bullets. Jess defends herself with a Kuret of wall around her.

She throws the javelin at the bot, which defects it with a propulsion blasts of its own. Jess side steps from the path of the bot and hurls more Kuret spears at it. The bot continues to defend against the number Kuret attacks. Some of the Kuret go past its defense, but turns out it also had red laser shield overs its main body. The same that stopped Marina's attack. Damn, David wasn't kidding that this was his ultimate combat bots. Marina cheers on, awesome. Jess changed her strategy, instead of throwing spears, she changed to big attacks. She forms a large cannon barrel in front of her. The bot stops its advance, sensing the danger.

Jess fires a big cannon. The bots' weapons shift into bomber, throwing grenades into the air. Before the Kuret cannon reached the bot, it exploded in mid air from the grenades. The collision dusts up a strong wind around me. That Kuret attack from Jess was no joke. And yet it deflected it with precision. That is one hell of an attack. While Jess loads up for another Kuret cannon ball, the bot changes its strategy. One of it arms starts to spray camouflaging gas on the ground. Its trying to obscure Jess's vision. Jess wasn't going to let it happen and creates a Kuret sheet and begins fanning it over the gas.

There a large explosion inside the gas and the ground shook a little where it stood. I ask, did Jess attack it from the underneath it. Blake says, no. I didn't see her Kuret connect. When Jess cleans up the gas, the aftermath caught me by surprise. There is a dug up hole where the bot was standing. I immediately turn my eyes to my feet. I could feel slight vibrations off the earth. Catherine says, its underneath the ground. Jess stays cautious, anticipating for the moment it dugs its way out. One of the bots arm shot straight up behind and tried to grab her. She ducks away in a Kuret slide and swings her Kuret sword.

Even though the bots body is buried inside, it knew what was happening and transformed the arm into a sword of its own. They began to fiercely strike each other. She was only focused on that one arm. The other five came out, surrounding her with a different kind of weapon. This one threw electric bolts. I thought Jess was going to be caught in the middle. But turns out she was already a step ahead, she pushes down her one leg and Kuret walls rise from the ground into the air. The Kuret wall breaks the bolts. She jumps into the sky with a spring Kuret on her legs and lands gracefully at a distance. The bot's entire body finally digs it way out.

People are cheering on for Jess. Even though its supposed to be a demo for the bot. She gets our encouragement and channels a massive amount of Kuret around her. They wrap her like a fire as she charges at the bot. The bot raises its arms and combines at its six arms into a single weapon. The weapon has two long barrels with a gap in the middle. Marina yells, is that a freaking railgun. There a soft static noise coming from the inside of the barrels. The excitement from the collision among people is reaching new heights. Jess charges with even more Kuret as they close the distance.

However, before she could reach it. David lands from the air in between them. He puts his one Kuret wrapped arm on Jess's elbow raised for a punch. And with his other arm, he threw a bunch of black Kuret of ropes at the bot and pulled it to the sky. When the bot's weapons discharge, it throws a white pulsating blast into the air missing them both. The pulse was so fast, it become a speck in a few second disappearing in the sky. Jess's Kuret breaks into pieces at David's presence. He says, that's enough. But Jess was in the zone. The broken Kuret pieces were but back by her, come on. I am not done.

David lets out a bigger wave of Kuret than hers and disintegrates her Kuret. That snapped her back to her senses. The bot also freezes and goes into standby mode. Jess releases her Kuret and breathes hard for a bit, sorry. I got carried away. David smiles, no worries. He disperses his own Kuret letting go of her elbow. Nathan claps as he walks to Jess, that was awesome. Why you stop there David. She was just getting serious now. David sighs, I know that. She would have taken out the arms of the bot with that move. But she would also not walk away from that railgun unscathed. I thought it was enough to show the bots abilities.

He was right, either of them getting hurt would be bad. Jess asks David, that underground move. You used something similar in our match. Did you program it to do that. David says, yes and no. He faces us, Hive tech are proactive. That's something we can't achieve, so instead I focused on these being reactive and adaptive. The AI behind the bot analyzed our match followed similar strategies. With every move you make, it adapts and reacts differently. Jess says, impressive. Unfortunately, after experience my mistake, I wasn't going to be taken down the same way again. David smirks at her confident expression.

Marina asks, was that a railgun? She looks away to the direction the pulse beam went. He nods, it is. Unless you know its coming, you are at severe risk. Its fired at 0.1 speed of light. You can defend against it, but never escape it. Holy shit. At that speed, you won't be able to see it. Before you blink, you will be bombarded with a electromagnetic force. Jess gives a horrified laugh, so glad it didn't get me. Ivan and his team inspect the killer bot with awe expressions. Marina places her hand on David's shoulder, let me go as well.

He replies, you just want to show off. She scoffs, look who's talking. He says, well, this is my show and I say its done. That put a damper on Marina's mood. But she remained excited asking about other weapons it has. I realize I will not be able to talk to David tonight. I am a little anxious about it, but I need to talk to him soon. Feel like I have a lot to say to him now.

David (Chapter 115)

Monday, March 16, 2026 19:35

M says, boss, the cargo has reached the port. They will be here in the another 9 hours. I swipe off the towel from the table and wipe off the sweat. I say, that's great news. My high voice echo's in the empty room of the training center. I take the corner bench of the gym, exhausted from the workout. Jack and others will arrive today evening. I need to intercept the boat they are in and have Jack and his family come with me separately. I also need to collect their new identities from Catherine. The Citradel officers will meet the rest of their loved ones at the south port.

I have just finished the last session I planned for my Kuret control. I flex my hand pouring out Kuret and play around my hands. Now that we are entering the third week after the tournament, I need to really kick into high gear. In just another 2 weeks, I am going to face off a wild overdrive user. I have made several strategies, yet I am not ready to execute any of them. Especially my failsafe Kuret. Its proving extremely difficult to control its direction. When I showed it to Marina and Blake, I only achieved a small Kuret. Enough for them to realize I had an ultimate move in case things go bad. But making it work on bigger scale needs time.

Yesterday, after the demo, I had my third session with Marina. We have worked on the final schematics for my Kuret technique. She said its probably the best one out of all the attempts. Now its matter to practicing and adapting to under pressure of a fight. Blake is supposed to meet me now. But he is already 30 minutes late. I messaged him a while ago remind him, but I haven't gotten a reply. M didn't have anything new to report in the officers building. He has been a slightly distant for me and Catherine. I think he hold us responsible for her leaving the island to meet Robb.

Maybe I was too hasty in believing that I was not causing problem for anyone when I proposed this to Catherine. It would be natural for him to be worried about Catherine. I should perhaps ease him of the doubts he harbor. I thought at least he will be sticking with the schedule he planned. Did I unintentionally gave him the wrong impression and he is avoiding me. No, that would be silly. He has never been one to hold grudge for things like this. I just hope it's a coincidence and nothing else.

As I rack my brain for the reason, I heard the door to the gym open. It had to be him, I was being paranoid for no reason. I grab my bag and walk to him, hey dude. You had me worried. Why so. I halt as the person comes into view. It wasn't him. She says in a grim voice, hey. Blake couldn't make it, so I came instead. My eyes twitch at the surprise guest. What is Vanessa going here. She came in her sports bra and tights. Her hair tied up in a pony tail. She caught me off guard with her dress and appearance. I ask, what's going on.

She says, I told you. Blake couldn't make it. He has an emergency meeting with Ivan in sector 5. Something about ground readings different than projected levels. Sounded like he was needed there more. So he asked me fill in instead of him. I ask, that makes no sense. She says, I am telling the truth. He is there in sector. I speak over her, 5. Yeah, I heard you. I am not talking about that. Why would he send you. And why would you agree to it. She stays silent while I had to think what really happened. She is the last person Blake would choose to send in place of him. He knows she is mad at me. Hold on. Maybe Blake really holds some resentment and ambushed me with her. Or she came after hearing about Blake being busy and got him to agree to let her meet me. Either case, Blake needs to explain few things to me.

She still didn't give me any explanation. But I didn't need one anymore, sorry you wasted your morning. But I am good. I will doing training alone today. She blocks my path, why. You scared of me or something. I scoff, no. I just don't want to get dragged into another drama. I have been dealing with many things lately. I need to focus, and you being here. That's the opposite. She wasn't letting go of her stare. I don't have the mental capacity to argue with her again. Maybe I should defuse the situation before she starts blaming for something again. I gaze down at her tights, you look hot in that tights by the way.

I thought that would invoke some reaction out of her. But she remained stoic, like she was unfazed by my obvious attempts to flatter her. She crosses her arms and continues to throw a stare down at me. Okay, something is definitely is up with her. Her vigilance means she is no mood for small talks. Well, too bad for her I can match her wits. I ask, sorry. But my training is for Charles. That means sparing with certain type of opponents. And as much as I want to check out your moves, I can't make time for you. I try to slither through the door. But she places her arm on the door, blocking me again.

She says, you really are scared of me, aren't you. I wasn't before, but I am now. Her demeanor is border lining at intimidation. I could force my way out, but I doubt that will stop her persistence. I make my mind and decide to just wait her out. She is bound to crack and tell me why she is here. After a some time passed with us staring at each other in heavy silence, she finally speaks, you really don't know why I am here. The first thought comes to mind was about Wagner. Then what I told her about Ned. But its possible its about Elina too. It would be easy to point out reasons she aren't here to meet me.

Seeing my confused face she sighs, for freak sake. You two seriously need to get your story straight. I think its safe to say its about Elina now. Did Elina do something. The plan was to meet Vanessa after the exhibition match. At least that's what we agreed to. Could Elina have met her earlier than we agreed. She says, your girlfriend came to visit me yesterday. She had a lot to tell me. Oh crap. Elina screwed up. I need to get out of here. I didn't want to do it, but I have to force my way out. I gently shove her hand and step out. She yells, hey. I am talking to you.

I reply, and I am busy. If you want to talk, you need to deal with it. I guess this is how I am going to handle the burning gaze from her. I take the hallway that takes to the open ground where they have the tracks and other obstacle equipment's. Today was the start of my Kuret assisted movement training. Vanessa rushes behind me, where are you going. I answer, you know it all too well. Coincidently, I am heading to the place where she scored first place in the tournaments preliminary rounds. The sun was just the horizon as I step out. Its still colder out here, but its getting warmer. Gives me a good workout environment.

She looks around the place, reminiscing the events that took place here. She asks, Blake said you guys had a training regime of running today. Should have known it be here. I drop my bag and prepare myself mentally for a slew of blames and anger. I can't really avoid her, but I can keep myself preoccupied in the meanwhile. I begin limbering up as she gawks at me. She says, are you serious. We aren't going to talk about her. I muster a bit of courage and reply, I am not sure what you mean. She steps closer, drop the act. She told me the whole truth. How she covered Peter crimes, stole the ledger and how two planed to leverage it for her freedom.

My fingers slipped when I was stretching my legs on the ground. I made a scowl trying to understand why Elina told her everything. Didn't I already explained how delicately this had to be handled. And most importantly, keep my name out of this. I couldn't keep procrastinating with deflection anymore. I face her square, she spilled the beans big time huh. I didn't realize the she was carrying a bigger guilt. That's why I wanted that she talk to you after taking some more time. Let her emotions simmer down before trying to do anything. I sigh, I should have kept an eye on her. I thought giving her space was in her best interest. Shame on me.

I really felt disappointed in not keeping track of her. I knew she wouldn't expose my involvement, not that she had any actual proof. I was going to be in touch with her frequently. To help her deal with this. I never imagined she run off to talk to Vanessa the very next day. Vanessa asks, you shouldn't have done this. Do you know how I worse feel about it. I am in a moral dilemma here. I say, this is why I wanted to avoid Elina mentioning I put her up to this. If she had approached you, alone, you wouldn't be pressured so much. She scoffs, how can you believe that. She needs to be locked up. Like her brother. Like Wyan.

I ask her, then why haven't you already. If she came to with the complete truth, then you shouldn't have to wait. You don't need the ledger anyways. Its pointless to know about the shipments when we have the names, aliases and smuggled goods. That got her tongue and pained eyes look away from me. I say, our plan wasn't about lies. It was just to help her, with a leverage and a promise to keep her crimes a secret. Think for a second, if you had no idea I was helping her, maybe you would have taken pity on her and agreed to it. That's all I wanted.

She had to know I wasn't favoring Elina because I was selfishly making decisions for her. Vanessa asks, you told her to sell off her business. She already handed me the dead to her bar. But is that really true. How much did Elina planned this before meeting Vanessa. I say, its true. She was responsible for Marina getting poisoned. Even if it was unintentional and indirectly. She had to pay for her crimes. I just didn't want that to be jail. She blurts out, why didn't you tell her everything about me then. She could have easily leveraged her freedom using my past as a bargain.

I had a visceral reaction to her horrible line of thinking, why in the freaking hell would I ever do that. You think I would use such a dirty tactic against you. When you how Ryes used it against me. I shake my head in disgust, I can't believe you. I knew you hate me, but to even think I would hurt you back in such a way. That's unbelievable. You seem to think every action I make is against you. You know what, go head. Lock her up. I don't care anymore what you think of me anymore. Elina did a crime and she should be punished the way you want. That broke her hardened wall and she becomes frightened at my reaction.

I turn my back to her and wrap my Kuret around me. I didn't realize she had this much animosity for me. Maybe I really shouldn't have provoked Ned. I am guessing that backfired in the worst possible way. My anger is reflected in my poor Kuret control. I can't do this without a straight head. So I settle my thoughts first while swirling my Kuret around my legs. My concentration breaks when Vanessa says, I am sorry. I went too far. My Kuret broke apart as I yell, you think. Argh, I can't really concentrate with her anxious glimmers around me.

I face her back, if you are here for this, I suggest you go back. Elina has told you everything and I don't have anything else to contribute. You do whatever you want. She retorts, easy for you to say. She wasn't crying in front of you begging to forgive her. That actually put my mood in distraught. I reply, she broke down when I confronted her about it. So I don't have to imagine it, I was there. And I gave her a choice, to either surrender, like Peter. Or be the sister Ryan deserves. I am sorry you are in a position like this. But I suspect Elina said she has made her peace if you decide to turn her in. Isn't it your job to weigh your options impartially.

She silence told me I was right, maybe I shouldn't have revealed things to her. And I was going to leave it alone. But you know what kept me from doing it. I waited for her to think about it. I answer, you. You told me how I was keeping Elina in the dark. So I decided to not hold back anymore. So if anything, you are complicit in this. That stunned her speechless. I realized what utter nonsense I spewed. I chuckle, that came out wrong. But hey, you made me want to do the right thing. Even if it was hard. So blame me all you want for trying to help Elina, but don't accuse me for things between us.

This made an impact on her. I was aware how harsh I was being, but I that's how I really felt. And it actually helped my calm my nerves. I went to my bag and grabbed a bottle of water. The ranting had made my throat dry. Vanessa looks at me with sad eyes, you told her. Because of me? She was confused why I would listen to her like this. Guess I can't blame her when I haven't been honest like this before. I put the bottle down, yes. And I am glad I did. Perhaps Elina would have been okay without me confronting her. She would continue keeping her secret. But maybe not. Now I know it was too much for her. She would have eventually give in. Then she would really be in jail, no compromise. At least I gave her an option.

She asks, you care for her that much. Its awkward to talk to Vanessa of all people about this. But I can't shy away now. I say, yes. She is special to me. She doesn't know it, but she helped me deal with my PTSD. Vanessa asks in low tone, do you love her. I should have seen that question coming. I answer, its not like that. She asks, but she likes you. I sigh, she likes Mack. The fun, easy to hang with and bad at flirting guy. I can never make things personal with her based on lies. You remember Sophie. I won't do the same mistake again. Lately I have been thinking about her a lot, and how she react if she know the whole truth.

The following silence was awkward too. Vanessa breaks it, the old you wouldn't have never brought Sophie's name. I had to agree on that, true. I would think about it, but probably wouldn't say it aloud. She then unexpectedly smiles, guess so. She then sits on the bench. I contemplate what I should do now. I have been trying to get away from her, but that hasn't worked out well. She turns up to me, I spoke with Ned few days ago. Oh boy. We are jumping from one mine to another. Maybe she decided to let the matter of Elina rest for the time being.

She had a strangely confused expression now. I hesitate to ask, I am guessing it went good. Since her mood didn't worsen, I had to take a stab in the dark. I was hesitant to even see her glimmers to figure out her feelings. She says, not exactly. He told me you gave him a stern talking and basically told him to break up with me. I scoff, I didn't make him do anything. I only gave him a push he needed. Something you needed too it seems. She lowers her gaze, well, it worked. We talked through our issues. And I have a lot to think about. So it was neither good or bad. There is still a good chance they break up.

I don't know how I still want that when she continues to behave towards me like this. She asks, you don't want to know what happened. I almost said yes, but held my tongue with great restraint. I so want to know what did they

said, its none of my business. I don't want to get in the middle of yet another omega relationship problems. I barely dodged the previous one. Then I remember about Blake. I felt a little sadness, maybe not completely. But lesson learnt. I held back my real thoughts about her. How I was hoping they really do break up.

She says, thanks. I mean it. Despite everything going on between us, if you hadn't made Ned see reason. Or force my hand too. Neither of us would have had the courage to try. She becomes despondent, I was angry at you for many things. But if you hadn't made us face this, we were likely going to break up. I don't know what I would have done then. I couldn't blink for few seconds. Hold on. Did I really helped them find a way to patch things up. Oh hell no. The irony is making me cringe. Got damn it. I should have left things alone. Why did I go and gave them a choice. I should have just said they don't work.

What's worse, I see steady glimmers from her. Meaning she truly was a honest appreciation. I feign happiness, well, that’s ah, great. Why are you telling me all this. Seriously, I wish I never heard this. She says, I don't know. Maybe its because you are the only one I can talk to about it. Isn't that we used to do for a long time. Its strange to see her being so less aggressive. Like she is done hating me. I ask, I am confused. You came here to ask why I helped Elina and now about Ned. What am I missing here. She says, honestly, I am too. I don't want to be angry with you. Its exhausting and frankly childish.

This should feel like there is hope for reconciliation. But when did she feel this way. She says, I have been trying to get back at your lying about Wagner. You already know about that. But yesterday I realized I was making things worse. I saw someone behaving differently towards others. Once I saw how it looked from an outside perspective, it opened my eyes. I thought my issues were unique and only mine. I never expected to see them manifest in others in same ways. I should be really happy about this. But I wasn't, you mean Blake. Did he say something to you. She shakes her head, not it many words. But Catherine saw it too.

This is bad. I need to make things right with him. But how do I even do when it was about Catherine. Should I leave it to Catherine to handle. Is that irresponsible of me. I can't tell. Vanessa says, you look panicked. You should be. You might have sorted things with Catherine, but messed up with him. She didn't need to make me feel even worse about it. I say, you seem to be enjoying me being in trouble. She scoffs, I do. You made me suffer a lot. Serves you right for not thinking things through. Like how Elina caught you.

I am so conflicted right now. But the most important thing I want to know is how Vanessa feels about me. I wish I could just ask her outright about it. She looks to the sky, I have been thinking a lot about what you said to me that night when you told you were a shadow. She has jumped into yet another dangerous land mine. It feels like she is checking of things from a list and keeping me on my toes with this. She says, did you know I talked to your shadow friends about it. What they had to say about it. My silence gave her the answer, they believed you. Despite knowing what it means about my brother. I hated that for so long. And every time I think about I get mad.

Ah damn. Hear we go again. I stop her, if we are going to open that particular can of worms. I am have to going to ask you to not do this. I have had enough of Wagner to last a lifetime. She turns her face to me. I expected her to be angrier. But she remained surprisingly composed. But I wasn't going to take any chance. I tell her, talking to you has calmed me down. You always had that effect on me. So I am going to go for a lap. I didn't wait for her stop me. I prepared my Kuret and sprinted off the track. Given what just happened, my focus was all out of whack. Naturally, I sucked at my coordination. I tried to keep Vanessa out of my mind. But I couldn't help gazing at her every chance I get. How pathetic I am. I can't let feelings get in the way of this. I don't have much time left for the exhibition match.

With a stronger resolve, I brought my coordination back on track. I decided to do brisk walking first. Baby steps, as they say. The Kuret around my joints kept pushing me ahead at odd times. I recall how Blake had showed me last time the correct way to utilize Kuret. Instead of focusing on just one single movement, I need to keep my Kuret in use even when not I am not movement. That’s the key to consistent. That's why I needed to learn to control Kuret output. I need to change the force of my Kurets physical when I need and keep it low when I don't. I shouldn't stop it mid stride, otherwise I stumble down.

After some awkward few rounds, I begin to get a feel for what works for me. Its more exhausting than I expected. Blake said not to let the Kuret control me, but I have been making that same mistake and losing control. So every time I have to consciously lessen the impulse pushing me ahead. Two more laps and I was drenched in sweat. This is not working. Without Blake to point my mistakes, I have to review things later with M. I crouch down on my knees and breath hard. My legs feels so heavy. I only ran for 2.5 miles, but it feels like it was way longer than that.

I didn't hear Vanessa approaching me until she was beside me, that was interesting. I had it in my head that you were quick to pick up things. Like how you beat up three Heraknus with just one day of training. I chuckle, then I must be doing things right. I stand up straight, I don't know if people told you, but I wasn't luck. I work hard. She nods, I never doubted that. She then thinks for a second, maybe I can help you after all. You are struggling with Kuret movements. I used to have same problem. I can help you.

At any other circumstance I would have been overjoyed she is finally coming around. Maybe her hate for me is slowly going away. But that’s just wishful thinking. I am sure she is just being polite since I basically told her I wasn't interested taking to her about Wagner. She probably doesn't know how to breach the topic without one of us getting angry about it. I should answer her objectively here. I tell her, your Kuret is slightly different. Mine is meta physical while yours is fully. You thrust your entire body with wind and fire. Not quite the same with mine or Blakes.

She had to know the difference wouldn't help me learn from her. She says, I figured as much. Just thought to ask anyways. This presents a rare opportunity though. Maybe a way to ask her something I have been wanting to for a time. I ask, you can help me with something else. She questions my motives with her eyes. I explain, I am not very good with flying. And it turns out Blake is too good at it. He couldn't really see the struggles with that particular ability. She smiles with curiosity, you want me to teach you flying. I say, if you are going to keep hovering on me, I might as well use you. You are the fastest Medrone here after all

I don't know how she respond to that. But I didn't expect her to giggle. She says, that I am. But you didn't ask for my help last time, like others. So you must already have a way to learn it yourself. I nod, I did. But it be faster to learn it from you directly. I was sure she wouldn't agree to it. But she agrees completely surprising me, I can. I don't buy this at all. I wait for the catch, which he realized I guessed. She says, I will gladly help, if you do one thing for me. I say, shocker. You want something. You have started a trend you know. Even Frank and Chelsea gave me hints that I sort of owed them. I had no choice but to get their people out of Citradel.

I had no doubt she what she wanted. She says, I want to know about Wagner. I make a scowl at her, you know what. I changed my mind. I can do this myself. She steps closer, I am not going to get mad at you. I scoff, sorry. I don't believe you. You made pretty clear that you don't trust me. She looks away with a curious eyes, I didn't. But I am willing to try now. You said you were going to earn my trust back. So here I am, ready to listen. I am confused how that happened. I ask, weren't you just mad at me for involving Elina. And even trying to middle between you and Ned. She answers, you could have gotten Elina her freedom without involving me. But you didn't want Elina to be like you, taking things on by yourself. I respect that.

It was hard to ascertain her emotional state now. She has had weird mood swings before, but not like this. She says she understand my intent, but I don't know if she is really okay with it. She continues, and my issues with Ned. Turns out that had nothing to do with the bet. I noticed how she omitted the fact that I wasn't the cause of it. I feel I did play some role in their fight. Wonder what it was about. I ask, you think you ready to listen to me now. I don't think so. The mere mention of Wagner makes you want to rip off my head. Nothings changed about that. She faces with determined eyes, I won't do that again. At least, I will try to hear you out.

This had to be the biggest change in her. Her willingness to listen to me. I was hesitant to even believe this. Maybe she is faking it and just wants me to talk. So that she could just tell me how wrong I am. She says, I don't blame you for not believing me. But I had a lot of time to think. I have been trying to convince myself I don't need to know about him. I know my brother, and anyone else are either jealous of him or don't know him. I have idolized him all this time, so I can't really allow anyone badmouthing him. Maybe you don't had to tell me about him, but you shouldn't have lied about not knowing him.

This is what I told her a week before too. I am beginning to think she is ready now. Maybe time was the only thing needed for her to realize how unreasonable she has been all this time. But I wanted to make sure, something must have happened. Otherwise you wouldn't ask me directly. Someone said something to you. I began listing out who would be even possible to make her see reason. Vanessa remained suspiciously quiet. And that answered my question, Siera. The only person in the world you trust more than anyone. She relents, she told me a story about my brother. I cock my head sideways puzzled.

Seira shouldn't know about Wagner, she was nowhere near him to know personal things about him. I ask her, what did she say to you. Vanessa says, promise me that you will tell me the truth. If you can't, there be no point. The tables been reversed now. She is trying to use that as a leverage to talk about him. However, despite what she thought about me, it hadn't had the same effect on my anymore. I shake my head, If you would have told me this a week before, I would jumped at the chance. But now, I feel its just sad. She yells, what. How is that fair. I raise my hand to her, I am not talking about you. Its me. I have been holding on so anger and hate towards him. Its just pathetic. I no longer need to know his reasons.

Vanessa's shocked asked, what does that mean. I sigh, I can see how hard it was for you to trust me again. So I am not going to squander it again by arguing over him. I don't want to fight over who is right and wrong. I just want us to get along again. Memories are all that left of them. Who am I to say what's wrong. You should cherish him as you remembered him. She is stunned by my thoughts on the matter. Now that I don't have PTSD, I feel lighter around this topic. Its shocking how much control he had over me until now.

She says, you maybe be fine with it. I am not. I haven't been listing before. But I want to. So many people trust you, despite all the truths you kept from us. I thought you just manipulated them. No, I believed you did. Eventually I realized how stubborn I have been. She snarls, Siera has repeatedly told me how Shadow strategists are. To be honest with you, I have not been thinking of you like Blake or Marina. At least not completely. Its hard to see you in new light with our past. She actually made a good argument. It would take people lot of time to reconcile with this concept of me being in Shadows. And in her case it would take a lot more effort.

She says, the way you operate is still the same. So maybe that’s why its been hard to see how different you are now. But I am willing to believe you changed. That you were chosen in Shadows for a good reason. I can't really deny that anymore. Not after you decimated Heraknus or raged war against Citradel like it was nothing. It finally happened. I didn't realize, but this is what I needed to hear from her. It’s a burden, I never knew was present, that has been lifted off me. Its similar to the vision trance I was in. She hasn't been this honest to me in a while. But she is showing a modicum of admiration. The knot in my throat feels unravelling now.

Maybe she really means it now. Siera told her something and now that she accepted I am a Shadow, so what I say or do matters a great deal. She even tried to her slight embarrassment praising me like this. And yet I couldn't bring myself to reveal things about Wagner yet. There is a difference in learning things about the past and dealing them. I ask, I am inclined to tell you about him. That brought a little bit of appreciation on her face. I continue, however, I don't want us to fight when I say something you don't like. So this is what I will say to you now. Whatever you may feel about me, he is your family in the end. Hate him or love him, that will never change. Hold on to that connection, regardless of what others think.

I had to be absolutely sure she wouldn't argue over her ideals anymore. She gives me a hard stare and then nods, I can do that. I thought you were about to say to keep an open mind. I scoff, I already know its hard for you when it comes to him. Though I prefer you not hate me anymore. She says quietly, I don't think I ever truly hated you. Maybe slightly distrusted you. I scoff, just a bit? I recall all the stuff she has been saying to me, you first told you will never ever trust me again. That’s the first thing you said to me. Then you revenge bait Elina to potentially ruining the plan with the smugglers. Then you haggle me for the ART bots. And yet unknowingly sick your boyfriend on to me.

She says, hey. I didn't tell Ned anything. He was angry with me, heard the rumors about us and assumed it had to do with you. That’s was all him. I had a suspicion she said something to him. But maybe she didn't. Ned came up with that idea on his own. She says, I know how childish I have been. Believe me, I can see it now. I really believed you don't trust me enough. I ask, and now you don’t feel that way. She says, I am not sure what I believe now. I am hoping if you tell me about Wagner, I might figure it out. I risked a bit and saw her glimmers. It was flickering like crazy, but it wasn't from anger. It was from fear and anticipation. Not enough to be dishonest.

There was any chance of ending our feud, this is it. I have a hard time putting my next words. I feel like I am playing with dynamite, and it will explode when I least expect it. In the tense moment, she says, how about this. You love technicalities right. So lets have a bet. That intrigued me more than I cared. She knows me so well. If it were a game of sorts, I would be compelled to answer. She says, if I win, you tell me about my brother. And I mean every question. I ask, and when I win. I didn't even know what it was, but I was already imposing on her. She scoffs at my arrogance, I will give you flying lessons. So, how about it.

This sounds good, but I had another condition in mind, I don't need the lessons. But if I win, you give Elina a fair chance. That made her brows arch. I explain, I am not asking you to cover for her. Just look at her without any prejudice against me. If she can do that, I am very certain she will help Elina, or come up with some sort of compromise at the very least. She thinks about it and says, fair enough. She extends her hand to me, which I gladly take. I ask eagerly, what's the bet. She gestures me to follow her inside the training center.

I didn't know what she had in mind. Could be anything from the rolling targets to the war room. The way she lead was different than I anticipated. She lead me to the hall were we had martial arts training. I ask, huh? Why here. She says, you are training for Charles right. Hand to hand combat is key part of your training. I ask, if its about him, sure. But its between us. She nods while removing her shoes beside the central mat, you know one of my biggest regret is that I never got to fight you in the tournament. You were clearly the most sought after opponent. You remember how Marina, Blake and Derek were gunning for you in the semis. I wanted to be there too.

Does she plan to finally get her wish with this. She then begins stretching her limbs, I can't risk hurting you when you have such a big match coming up. So I thought the next best thing. She crouches down on her toes, we duke it on the mat, without our Kuret. It will be the standard three point hit above waist. No time limit, just bare hand fight. I laugh, I don't know if you notice, even without Kuret I have the upper edge. She straights up and raises her arms, you did. But now that you are training solely with your Kuret in two weeks, I am sure you have gotten rusty. I think that will give me the edge.

Whoa, I didn't expect her to be this clever. Truth be told, I did want a battle with Kuret. Even before the match with Charles, I had been focusing on my Kuret dome and sphere. I say its been a good month and half when I had to use bare knuckle fight. She says, don't tell me the badass Shadow guy is afraid of losing to me. Her cheap provocation wasn't good enough. But I be lying if wasn't excited from this. If she thinks I am at a disadvantage, she is wrong. While she limbers up, I remove my shoes and my shirt. She gets annoyed, what's with the sudden interest to always strip. I throw the shirt over my bag, why. Can't resist me already.

She smirks, please. You don't even crack the top 100 muscular guys. I reply, I don't need to. You getting distracted is enough for me. I caught her staring at me a tinge longer than she should. That made her annoyed a bit. I say, I am already in your head. You should have not challenged me where I am at my best.

Vanessa (Chapter 116)

Tuesday, March 17, 2026 17:37

I had only one goal in my mind when I going to meet David. Get him to apologies to me for involving Elina. When I asked him why he only did half measures to help Elina, he got mad at me. I wasn't prepared to see that side of him that still cared so much that he be angry at me for saying that. He came clean to Elina because of me. I wasn't sure if was being serious or just saying to prove a point. But then he outright said he was genuinely helping her because she is special to him. I felt compelled to ask if he loved her. I thought he was just playing with Elina, get into her pants by first exposing her and then helping her.

I don't know why, but I believed him that there is nothing going on between them. But that could change now. He even made me remember about Sophie, who was being lied to like Elina. I think he now understands how relationship are ruined. I couldn't believe that I had a part in him opening up to Elina. That left bitter taste in my mouth. The same nasty feeling I had earlier with Ned crept up to me. I still question myself that I wanted to stay angry at Ned to avoid focusing my own feelings towards David.

I am sure that I was making things too complicated for myself. I am so jealous that he isn't being distracted by the stuff going in our lives. Or maybe he is and still is so focused on his training. If nothing else, his determination is inspiring. After being so mad at him, I wanted to just be done with it. I have been so acting so boorish with him all this time. It made me even more upset, because it meant I was the only one who was making things worse. I was the only one obsessing over being angry at him. Just like Ned, I was being making an excuse with him so that I don't have to face him.

Aside my confusing feelings for David, I am beginning to think what if he is right about Wagner. I wanted to know what he knows about my brother. But first I told him about Ned. I thought about what Catherine said last night. She had forgiven him for being a jerk and even letting her decide what to do. It felt like he was doing the same for me too. I was actually touched by his effort to make me and Ned face our issues. I thought we were soon going to break up. I really appreciated him for helping me, even when all I ever did was complain to him. Its so immature of me to not have the courage to face Ned without David.

I feel like I am finally at a point where I can forgive him for lying to me. It took a lot of convincing that I am ready to talk about Wagner. The last time we spoke about him, he become angry. But since undergoing the treatment, he is more calm about it. He once told us that Wagner was a trigger for him. It doesn't seem like it was one anymore. So if he can get past his issues, maybe I can too. When he said how he didn't want us to take a step back, I was glad he was being serious about this. And I wanted to move ahead too. That’s why I want to tell him about Siera's story. I had a small hope he knew about it. But it doesn't look like that.

I thought something new about Wagner would make him want to know more. But turns out he is already made peace with his trauma. Considering how has been acting since the tournament, its safe to think he has completely new outlook to life now. Won't let anything tied him down again. I admired him even more. Ever since I learned he was a Shadow, I have been acknowledging him. Because I was trapped in my own feelings. Now I can see them much better. Its taking every once of courage to be honest with him. I had to convince him that I won't accuse him any longer.

I felt so damn embarrassed at my behavior as he lists down everything I ever did to him as a petty grudge. He even thought I made Ned confront him. I guess, in his mind I was out to get him in any way. We both have made a mess of each other, but only I kept digging much deeper. Maybe time was all I needed to clear my head. And that’s how I knew the best way to make him tell me about Wagner was through a match. He is a stickler for making things even. So I had a thought about what to do. I didn't expect him to give Elina a benefit of the doubt. She is really special to him. I feel oddly jealous of her. That fueled me even more for a win.

Now that we are preparing for the match, I feel a little bit excited. Its been so long I felt like this with him. I miss it. I am sure he does too, because he is grinning like a mad man as he cracks his arms and hip. He has gotten a weird taste for being shirtless. Not that I complain. But I had to keep up appearance that I wasn't bothered by it. We take our place in the middle of the large Mat. The lights turn on at the sides and so does the camera. He says, remind me, who came in the first in this preliminary round. He knows who it was. He says, didn't Cathrine take the spot from Sommers who took it from someone else. Oh that’s right, Polly. And who beat them all.

He is trying to get in my head. I know every tactic in his book. I say, that was with Kuret. Are you really going to run just your mouth at me. He chuckles as we begin circling each other. I was smiling along with him, fully aware how dangerous my opponent is. But he is way too cocky. It might do him some good to be cut down a peg or two. Then he said even more aggravating, I can take you blind and one arm tied behind my back. And that’s what he did. He pulls out a black thin long cloth from his pocket and wrapped it over his eyes. Then he locks his left to his back. Just how much confidence he has got to hold back so much. He says, now it seems like a fair fight.

He can't see, so how does he intent to fight me. But then I shake it off. He is lying. Its a trick, making me hesitate. I charge in the next moment, not giving him a moment of reprieve. I approach him with a left hook, which he dodges at the last moment crouching down. I go in for a knee kick to his chest, but he blocks it with his free arm. He tried to make a sweep cut my legs, I jump away and take a step back. I knew he was lying, why the charade. You can see through that flimsy cloth. He replies, who knows. Maybe that was just luck. I jump off for a high kick, which stops by grabbing my ankle and pulling me away to the side.

He nearly yanked me down before I kick his hands. I went in for a barrage of jabs and punches. But he dodges or blocks them at the last moment. I saw an opportunity, I lean down and go for a back kick to his chest. He defends himself, but it was just a second late. I landed a clean kick to his chest and he stumbles on his ass. He winces as pushes himself up, damn. I am rusty. I felt jubilant, point one. Did you thought it was going to be easy. We walk back to the center of the mat. I thought he remove his bindings or use another arm. But he didn't remove either of them, interesting. Feigning a punch while going for a high angled kick from below. Someone's been practicing.

I answer, you thought you were the only one doing training. Losing to Marina taught me what I was doing wrong. And you showed me how to not depend on Kuret alone. Every day, I have been working out without my Kuret. He says, that’s why you went with this game. You are branching out different styles. I shouldn't need to feel this, but it was good to be validated by him. I tell him, remove those silly restraints. Or you will be down before you figure out anything. He says, thanks for the warning. But I am good. I got nothing to worry about. Its a little intimidating how casual is he bring about this.

He switches up his movement this round and longues in with a mid kick. I saw it coming and dodge to my right. I circle around, twisting my knee for a kick to his left side. If he is seriously going to be stubborn about not using his left arm. Then I will not miss the chance. He cartwheels away just before I lightly grazed his waste. He says, whops. Almost got caught. I didn't wait for him to gain his balance and went if for a elbow slam on his back. That should been a point, but he brought up his right hand to behind and blocked my elbow. That caught me off guard. He goes in for a kick from side, to which I bring in my own leg and block it. I pull out my arm and go for a jab on his neck.

But somehow, even his back faced to me, he caught my wrist from behind. This wasn't even about seeing through the cloth. Does he have eyes behind his neck or something. That thought cost me a momentarily setback, which he capitalized on. He shoves me with is elbow to my chest and I get thrusted back. Wind passes through my lips as I stagger a little on my feet. He nonchalantly says, point one. I am annoyed at myself. I was prepared to not be caught off guard by anything he does. How in the hell did he saw the exact spot I was targeting him. For some reason he panics a little, ah, did I get you in your tits. My bad. I can't see where I throw my punches.

This deranged sleezbag. I blurt out, you dick. He did hit me in my boobs. Not that it should matter. The gall of him to point out something so needless. He smiles, don't take it the wrong way, but you gotten more hot recently. I actually felt my cheeks burning a little at how enthusiastically he said that. He sighs, how in the hell is Robb still made at you. I got curious, what does that mean. He says, you should mess with his head. Make him believe he is stupid. You should wear a swanky dress. Maybe a lace back dress or something. One that shows a little bit of cleavage. He will be on his knees, begging you let him back in. I promise you that.

I can't tell if he is blatantly flirting with me or trying to get a rise out of me. Maybe even both. I never thought he would go this far, objectify me and stir me up. And yet, I feel flushed and also a little bit of pride my efforts have been paying off. Shit. I am getting sucked in by his outrageous compliments. I need to hit him back, at least I have a boyfriend. Who do you have. I went for the jugular. He chuckles, touché. I make the first more again with a punch aimed at his head. Before he could block it, I pull back a little and go for a low kick to his knees. He dodges it barely by side stepping away. He goes in for a punch at my waist, I block it with my knee and push him back.

My fist nearly connected to his shoulder, but he grabbed my wrist few centimeters away from his skin. He gasps, getting closer. I go in for a kick to which he backs before getting struck in his groins. He shouts, hey. Not cool. I laugh, that’s me getting back for hitting me in my boobs. He raises his one arm up to defend himself, that was an accident. You think Ned will let me live after hugging you and then groping you. My anger rose as he made me remember that time. If I keep letting him taunt me, I won't get anywhere. I take a few breathes to settle my thoughts. I already tested that he is wasn't able to follow the first feint.

It still don't know if can see and or just following my movements by sound. As outrageous that sounds, it doesn't explain how he caught me from his back. I know he used to fighting without his eyes, but this is beyond what I imagined. Instead of going in fast, I make small movements around him now. He suddenly waves his arm at the place I was just a second ago. I smile realizing I got him now. He scoffs, why so quiet. Don't tell me you are busy ogling me. Sorry, I don't go after other guys girls. I wasn't going to react to his cocky behavior. I know what game he is playing at. He wants me to make a mistake.

Too bad. This teasing won't make me stumble anymore. I manage to get behind him. Should I try attacking from behind again. Even if can sense me approaching again, he can't defend his back every time. But wait, what if he is planning for that, luring me in. So I decided to wait for another opportunity when I am at his left side. Once aligned, I sprint at him. He notices me coming, but he is a second too late. I slide down and sweep his legs. I knock him down as I have tangled his knees. He falls hard on his back. I raise my foot and hammer down with my heel. He garbs my foot just barely an inch away from his face. I laugh, you should start using both arms now.

He shoves my leg away and tried to elbow me at my neck. I roll away and kick up back on my feet. He was still struggling to get up, so I went in for a high jump kick to his head. My leg came straight at his face and he gets knocked straight into the ground like a rock. I yell in joy, point two. How about that. He yells in pain, agh. Good one. He laughs with me now. He rubs the side of his face as he gets up, what the hell was that woman. I thought you weren't going to let me get hurt. I spat at him, oh bite me. You have been through much worse. He rotates his head around a bit to shake off the bell ring I gave him, you got in good. Shit.

I enjoyed seeing that haughty face was now filled with nervousness. He checks for any damage inside his mouth his tongue, no bleeding. That’s good. We come back to the center of the mat. I thought for sure he fight me seriously. But he still locked his left arm behind. I grew tried of his unfounded confidence. He still is mocking me with this shit. But back in my mind, I am being cautious. That might be another trap and he might use his hand suddenly. I need to keep my cool. He says, I have seen enough of your style. You keep changing stuff to keep me off balance. That’s a good strategy. But you missing other crucial stuff.

I am not going to give him any opening, so I stayed quiet as I approach him. He doesn't even raise his right hand to guard this time. As I walk around him like a cat he says, your attacks are too linear. You need variable acceleration, to further keep your opponent from guessing their next move. Yeah, keep talking shit. You think I would fall for any of it. He continues, and you aren't using your hips to give power to your punches. I know you have a fine ass, but you need more than just nice figure to generate the impulse for a kick. Now he is talking about my ass. A minute ago, I would be so furious. But this is all a game to him.

This time, I am going to attack from his back. The way he is moving he head around, he is anticipating a straightforward attack, like he just said. This time I will go for a two fold attack and he will have no chance of blocking both my fists. With nimble steps I rush in with both my arms pulled in for jabs. I basked in victory as he didn't see me coming and remained still. With all my strength, I go in for a double fist punch on his backside. I didn't notice he already crouch down on this knees. With swift movement, he twists while leaning down. A chill went down and I realize I have to get away. I am too vulnerable. It was too late though.

He thrusts himself up and grabs me by the neck with one arm. The force is so much that he yanks my feet off the ground for a few seconds. I struggle under his tight grip on my neck, but he doesn't let me go. With a slam, he shoves me down by the neck and hit the mat straight on my back. He pants hard few inches away from my face. The warmth radiating from his burning sweat. He leans in closer to my ear, point two. And please don't tell anyone I chocked you. People will get the wrong impression. He releases my neck and slowly pulls himself up. I lay dazed for a second on the mat. What just happened. He shakes his arms says, great stuff. He thrusts his hand to me.

I am so irritated by that humiliating beatdown, I get back up shoving his hand. He closes his fist away, did you really thought you had me. I fix my bra in silence. What was that. That precise movement, he knew where I was going to attack him from. And he also knew I was going in for a punch. If only I had gone in with a kick. How did he do that. He says, I know you don't know how I got you. You haven't studied much in this form of fighting. So nothing to

be ashamed about. I wasn't, but I was sure I had him. I was convinced of it. Its not like his movements were fast or unpredictable. It was precise and simple. A felt a pit in my stomach when I think about what he said.

It means he wasn't teasing me, he really did figure out what I can do. No, it was just a coincidence. Nothing more. He loves to play off them like it was skill. I know him the best. That's what he does the best. I made a plan for this last point. I am not going to overthink it, and just let him struggle under faster attacks. This time, we both kick off and go in for blows. He blocks my jabs, I block his kicks. When I go for a karate chop, he yet again grabs me by the wrist. This time I twist my hand over his and pull him down. He stumbles forward and I go in for his guts with a knee kick. He had no way to defend. But then I felt his weight falling on me, he went if for full body slam on me loosing my balance for a kick.

He falls on top of me, his bare chest on mine and misty breath on me. He had to gall to be amusing by this sudden closeness and smiles, again, not intentional. I yell, yeah, right. I force my hand out from his and go in for a elbow jab to his scandalous expression. He gets off of me and rolls to the side, before the jab connects. My skin still tingles from being in contact with him in close proximity. I can't believe how inappropriately he is trying to get under my skin. I grit my teeth and kick up once more. David flings back up and goes in to grab my neck. Not going to happen again. I go in for a high angled kick and he had to block it with his arm.

I take a few steps back from him. This is bad, he is completely reading my movements now. He really was analyzing my attacks initially. I feel so dumb thinking he was weak without his eyes and use of one arm. Even with all the inappropriate jokes and flattery, I was angry and enjoying this at the same time. I say, how far you have come god dammit. I still feel like was yesterday when I punched you out the first time we met. You were barely able to stand up against other humans, let alone a Medrone or Hive. Why do you get to be this strong. This is so freaking humiliating. I wasn't on planning to let off so much steam. But I couldn't keep it in any longer.

I thought he joke around again. But his smiles drops a little, don't remind me of how I used to be. That guy got his ass kicked by so many people. He straightens up, its not like you to be so down. You changed too. You are just being blinded by your brother a little much. My face flushes with blood. He continues, I know you know this already. You respect your brother so much, that you don't think anyone, including yourself, can be like him. I feel even more anger, because he called me out on my most shameful thoughts. I yell, shut it. I want to be stronger like him, why is that bad. He shakes his head, like I told you before. Its not about you admiring him.

I shout, I remember. You think I am lionizing so much that I can't get stronger than him. He raises his arm, yeah. You need to understand, like I had to accept, you only get stronger by looking inside. Not by others. You can be inspired by them, but true strength, the kind your brother had, comes from inside. I didn't expect him to give me a profound lecture here. Its like he has gotten enlightenment or something. I such in with anger, I already know that. Its so obvious, everyone knows that. He dodges my fist and steps away, knowing and accepting is two different things. Trust me, I had to learn this the hard way.

He then laughs, well. I am sure you will learn. Unlike me, you aren't haunted by trauma or weird things like adult Ketriya. So that's enough chit chat about that. He goes in for a jab at my chest. I thwart it away with my hand, yeah. I like it more when you were taking shit and making bad flirty comments. He laughs as he catches my elbow before I could go in for a punch, try to be considerate. I haven't dated anyone in a while. And the girl I used to go out with wasn't really into flirting. So as humiliating it is, I need to learn what works and what doesn't. I pull my elbows in anger, and you found me to be your study date.

He smiles, someone getting ahead of themselves. He goes in for a kick, which barely missed my waist. He continues, I try it on all women I see. Well, except for Marina. She would absolutely roast me if I ever tried hitting on her. I know he is leading me on. But I didn't think before asking, and Elina. You have her wrapped in your fingers. That was probably a little mean, but he was caught off guard my back hand chop jab to his chest. I thought this was it was over. Before it connects, he twists around and crouches down. Then he pulls the exact move I hit him with in the beginning. A high kick from a low angle. I bring both my arms up to block that kick.

I stagger back a little. That was close. The bastard was only faking it, he give me an opening on purpose. He says, wow. Nice save. I thought I won just then. He shakes his head, should have just gone in for a punch. I blurt out, you can see then. This was all a trick, you bastard. There is no way that was a coincidence. He still doesn't give up, that's for you to figure out. I am so mad at him for playing so many dirty tricks on me. Even more furious that I got fooled. I know I shouldn't do it, but my emotions got the better of me. I dashed on instinct. At the corner of my eye I saw him bringing out his left hand.

So he finally feels its time to use it. I jumped up high with a aim to smash down my fist on his face. He was strangely not reacting to me. Just standing still while he raises his arm. That is my chance. I lounged in mid air, flipping to his side and then twist my around to lean on the ground and then cartwheel on my hands. Even David didn't see that coming when I aimed for a kick to his chest. I also saw his own kick coming straight at my face. Smack, my kick lands on his chest and his kick on my face.

We both get knocked away and fall on the mat. My eyes widens realizing what just happened. David's laughter echo's in the empty hall, a double knockout. How anti climactic. But I wasn't humored with this at all. Before he hand the chance to get up, I got up and ran at him. He says, Vanessa. What. I didn't care about the shock on his face, I fall hard on his chest and thrust in my thigh on his neck, you freaker. You did that on purpose. Didn't you. He taps on my thigh as I continue to put pressure on him. His face turns red in pain. The smile all gone with coughs and struggles. He tries to get up, but I force him down from my entire body's strength.

He groans under me. I shout, why did you that. I saw you hesitating with using your left arm. You could have won there. Did you feel pity for me. Did I ask for it. My fury boils even harder now. With his oxygen cut off, he begins to furiously taps on my thighs, gesturing to tap up. More painful noises comes from this lips. After I while my anger finally settles down. I let him go and he shoves me away, gasping and coughing for air. I sat, resting my hands on my bent knees with rampant breathing. David literally crawls away and lies flat on his back. I ask, tell me why.

Once he gets his breath back, were you trying to kill me. He leans down towards me. I ask, why didn't you use her left hand. Did it feel good to toy with me. The frustration and humiliation is consuming my every thought. He sighs, I am not saying anything, until you calm the freak down. Even I have a limit of how much of your bushtit I find it endearing. That outburst from him made me realize I let my anger control me. I close my eyes and let the adrenaline flush away. I hear a cloth rummaging, he is removing his eye band. We sat in a bit of silence with just heavy breathing.

Once I gather my emotions I ask, what was that. He says, I just let you believed I was going to using my arm. I knew you be wary of that. You would mess up a little. What I didn't expect was your desperation and persistence. You got me good, so I made a desperate move on the spot myself. I open my eyes to see him setting with his arms leaning on the ground behind him. He says, I wasn't pitying you. It was a trick which you fell for. Well, not all the way anyways.

Dammit. Why did I assume that earlier. I feel so ashamed of my behaviors. Off course that was a trick. That's all he has been doing this whole time. I tighten my fist in anger, but you still lied about not seeing. He says, of course I did. Did you honestly thought I can do all that, without my Kuret. He throws me the cloth. I pull it over my eyes to asses it, and I could see through the gaps of the fabric. Not completely, but enough to make out my moves. I felt so violated right now. I knew in my gut that he was lying. But then how did he do that, how did you defend your back.

He smiles, the first one was calculated. I figured you wouldn't want to take the chance in case I wasn't lying. I was waiting for you to attack me there. I even angled my shoulder so that I would catch your blows. I scoff, for freak sake. You got lucky then. He says, you can believe that if you want. But I really got lucky the second time. That was pure instinct and luck. It happens to people when they are locked in. Not at all uncommon with experienced people. So I just went along with the act. Damn him. Its so easy for him to say after the fact. But doing this in the middle of a fight is incredible.

I was both impressed and furious at him. I ask, what was with not using the arm thing then. He stand back up on his feet, I knew that I was in for a rough time even before you told me you were working out without Kuret. It was obvious you had the advantage. I was just talking shit earlier. He laughs, I am surprised you bought that act. That cocky grin on his face. I wish I could just punch him one more time. He comes over to me and extend his arm. The last time I refused, but this time I accepted it. He helps me get up, how does one get an advantage when you are loosing.

I wasn't interest in playing this, so I just wait for him to explain. He says, one way is to give an obvious weakness or restraint. Even if you believe I was lying about it, you would consciously pay more attention to it. Even make assumptions or mistakes. Its much difficult to ignore it in middle of a fight. I figured it was something like that. I was keeping a eye out for his left arm more cautiously than the rest of him. He says, I have seen Chinese Buddhists, practitioner of martial arts, not using hands or legs to attack. They just use their head, shoulder or waist to attack. Compared to them, I am but a fledgling. Trying anticipating their attacks and defend against that.

I shake my head, god dammit. Even when I prepared myself from your mind games, I fell into it. This leaves a bitter taste in my mouth. David grabs his aching neck, yeah, you paid a little too much to me. But, you still got the better of me. I feel immediate regret, are you okay. He smirk, not really. You chocked me with your leg. Under other circumstance, I be enjoying it. The nerve of him joking when its obviously hurting him. I step forward and grab his jaw. There are light bruising and marks around his neck. I say, sorry. I wasn't thinking straight. He walks to his bag and pulls out a bottle. He shakes it and sprays white liquid over his neck.

He sighs in a little relief, you thought I was not giving you the respect you deserved. I apologies if I gave you that impression. I was just doing my usual stuff. I thought you be used it by now. I sigh, I thought I did too. But you really got under my skin when you spoke about Wagner. She swipes his sweat with the towel, should have guessed that. I wanted to know how'd you handle it when I talk about Wagner. I ask, you think getting a rise out of me was the right thing to do. In the middle of that? He replies, it was actually the best time. Keep you unbalanced and also know how to react.

I didn't like being tested like this. But honestly, I don't like how I reacted to this. I got agitated too much, and felt insecure over it all too easily. But I still want to know about Wagner, no matter what. I ask, what happens to the bet then. It ended in a draw, shall we go at it again. David makes an annoyed face when I suggested that, the way I see it. We have three options, have another match, or we both loose or we both win. I rather not do this again or be the looser. That's so like him to got for the win-win situation. I scoff, wouldn't you love that. He puts on his jacket, I am not sure about that. Based on that little outburst, there is a good chance you will go for neck again.

I retort irritated, that was a mistake. Don't think I would just loose it again. I can tell he is not convinced. Then he stands up, well, doesn't matter. You made me promise, so I will tell you what you want to know. I just need to better prepare myself. I am hesitant to ask what he meant by that. But I didn't want to know if he really thought I would hurt him again. He is waiting for me to make a decision for him. I didn't have a real problem giving Elina some more leeway. And yet I am conflicted how he feels about her. But that's not fair to her. So I decided my choice, fine. I'll do it. Its funny how it became a deal into a bet.

I had a very good hunch that David's plan was always to end in a draw. He is more worried about my behavior than the fact that he has to tell me about Wagner. But whatever doubts he had, he stuck to his promise. Since I had busy work today, we agreed to meet tonight. I ask, why do you want Siera too. Are you still worried about that. He slides his hands on his neck. He smirk, I would feel safer with a witness the next time you do that. I roll my eyes at him. He is blowing it way out of proportion. He adds, but I want to hear from her directly, because whatever she told you, it had an effect on you. I couldn't deny it didn't. Its taken a lot of time for me deal with it.

So we break for the rest of the day. He resumed his training, while I went back home, got a shower and went to officers building. I need to figure what I'll do with Elina. Because I regardless of how feel about it, I can't let her get her life back without some more guarantees that she won't do something like this ever again. I spent the day reviewing our tech teams initials plans for using the tech bots. I discussed this with Ruther that we should have the bots up and running by this weekend. The R&D can tinker with it all they want, but Ivan said some we can use immediately without big changes. I want to tighten up our security in the next two weeks before Heraknus arrive.

The meetings and then reviewing the latest stats of the arrests we made took the rest of the day. We run running out of people to capture. Tessa says, we have about 27 aliases. Sommers says, that is a lot of names we don't know about. But at least we know what they bought. Any chance we try to track them. Tessa shows her analysis, I spent past few days researching on these items. I think I figured out somethings. She points to a picture of a teapot in her tablet. I ask, what is that. She replies, its very old Japanese clay teapot called Kyusu. Technically its not a relic, but there are only a few dozen of this particular type of teapot. But what's more important is something else.

She slides away to a different slide, which had some text over it. While others read, she explains to me, they need to be polished with oil every few weeks so it doesn't wither away. I want to track the purchases and put

surveillance on those people. I am concerned about this, won't that list be long. She nods, we don’t have a choice. Just like this, there few more items that needs special care or maintenance. I'll like to assign teams to work on this. It's going to be very tedious, but its all we got for now. I suppose we don't much of a choice. Sommers went to IDF to delegate the tasks and form teams.

Around 6:00, me and June went to the beach in section 2. She says, when will they be here. I answer, should be about 10 minutes. Deni messaged me they crossed the barrier few minutes ago. She nods in anticipation as I park my car in the lot. Others were also gathering here. Frank and Chelsea came with Marina in her car. And soon Blake, Luther and Jess arrives as well. Blake tell everyone, I know you all are very keen to see them, but we can't be seen in public for much long. We need to keep this under wraps from the people. Got it. Everyone understood the sensitivity of the arrivals. They escaped from a hostile Citradel, so they will be under major scrutiny.

Jess says, I will take them to different safe houses, but it would be better if you don't go with them immediately. I know its not ideal, but we can't have people see them with you. Luther had already explained the plan to the four of them days before. So they all had time to agree to this, even if they didn't like it. June asks, when can they come with us. Luther turns to Blake. He says, at least three days. It would be very suspicious if people saw five people from Citradel just few days later they broke out. Three days would be enough time to make the narrative that they left after our invitation of rescue.

Three despondent expressions appear on their faces. Marina says, its okay guys. I am sure we can see them at least. Can't we. Luther says, off course. You guys can meet them when you are off work. But inform Jess or Catherine before. Because only they will know where your people will be living temporarily. I ask, I assuming its not the guest houses or the home stays we usually use. Jess replies, we are setting them up with regular family houses. More importantly people who we can trust to keep quiet about it. I wonder who these people were. But Jess only mentioned they weren't linked to any officers. And that Catherine personally vetted them.

Speaking for her, why isn't she here. When others went to the edge of the beach, I asked Blake about her. He explains, I asked her to come. But she said she had a personal prior arrangement. His mood sours as he told me. I get the distinct impression that he doesn't want to talk about it. Then he asks, and what about this morning. How did David feel about you ambushing him. I had so much to tell, but it was one giant mess. My eyes drop down as my mind plunder with mixed emotions. He interpreted as anger, don't tell me you are fighting again. Because I thought he be less antagonist then before.

I blurt out, no. I mean we did fight. He raised his brows, we sparred over a silly bet. Its nothing serious. We did argue a little. And like you said, he was more amenable than previous times. He asks, that’s good right. I couldn't really be happy about it. He adds, unless you don't feel it was. I say, I am just confused about it. He agreed to tell me about Wagner. And wants to meet tonight with Siera at my place. I couldn't tell him about Elina yet. He is curious about this, when he says tell you about him. What did he mean exactly. I wonder if Blake something more than he is letting on. A week ago when he asked about Wagner, I gave him an awful attitude.

I wish I could take it bad. All the times I have been so overly judgmental and aggressive about it. Feels so different now that I can't believe how rude I was last time. I tell him, he didn't any specifics. But he told that he will tell the things that matter. Like what he told to Catherine. Whatever that means. Blake smirks, sounds like he is still sticking to his usual half truths. I nod, at least he is being honest about it instead of hiding it. Blake replies, I guess that's a refreshing change. Then I remembered what I told David earlier, I may have accidently led him on that you were angry with him. Because he meddled with Catherine and her human partner.

He jerks at me with a hard stare, and why pray tell did you believe that. I answer, because of you were behaving yesterday with Catherine. And I did notice some resentment at David too. Wasn't hard to guess why. His eyes sharpen for a moment and then he looks away to the boat arriving on the beach. He sighs, I am not an idiot. I know he only did it to fix things with Catherine. He would do this for anyone he cares about. I don't blame him for that. He pauses a while, but I don't like it how this lead to. So what you may saw is not anger, but maybe annoyance. I sometimes feel he shouldn't have interfered. Which I know I said it was to help her, but it didn't exactly turn out the way we hoped for.

I am sure even he assumed they would break up. He says, knowing the guy, know doubt he feel guilty about it. I should talk to him about that next time. Its eerie how they understood things about each other so easily. Unlike woman, men really does have easier friendship. I felt a little better knowing it wasn't anger that was directed at David. A minute later the boats dock at the beach and five people step out. Marina and others rush to greet their loved ones. A scrawny looking guy with scuffled hair, lifts June in the air hugging tightly. Chelsea kisses her girlfriend. Frank and his foster parents lock in arms and shoulders. Marina and her friend fist bump than turn into a bear hug.

We waited for them to let them have this moment. After several minutes of excited faces and joyous reunions. They begin to walk inward to us officers. Blake greets each of them individually. I and the test meet them with warm appreciations. I tell, welcome everyone to our city. I am Vanessa, the chief of IDF. Junes partner Sam, the one who apparently was smitten by me goes in hard for my hand as I reached for a handshake. He yells, I am huge fan of yours. I couldn't but smile how he was enthusiastically smiled. June, like a jealous girlfriend, grabs his arm away, stop grinning you idiot. You are being rude to her.

I answer back, nah. Its all fine. Its good to know I still got it. My boyfriend says that to me all the time. That made him a little less excited, oh. You really do have a boyfriend. That’s ah, awesome. I could literally see his eyes wonder around awkwardly. June drags him away mumbling, I told you. And he is an officer that will kick your ass if you give him trouble. I remember she told me to bring Ned when I met him. Unfortunately, this will have to suffice for now. Despite that, he waves me bye with a wide smile.

The alpha twins parents were nice and cordial. They were however very exhausted from the trip. Jess says, it must have been terrible. I don't know what the travel arrangements were, but it must have been harrowing. The mom, Betty, says, it was a unlike anything I have experienced before since arriving on Earth. Lionel, says, we moved around a lot. In shipping containers, storage trucks and even in a flight cargo space. Candice, Chelsea's girl friend with darker complexion and short hairs, says, at one time we were in some sort of farm animal trailer filled with goats and sheep.

Just what kind of escape plan did David cook up. Then came Jeena, who was a little older than the rest of us. I don't know why, but I assumed she was Marina's age. She looked in her late thirties with blonde hair and piecing on her ear and nose. She says, but what's even crazier was that we got everything we needed. There was this guy, who asked us to call him magic. He was with us the whole time and just his moniker, would magically bring us whatever we needed. Frank asks, seriously. A guy named magic. Chelsea says, a fake name for sure. Candice says, yeah. He also had a mask on him all the time. But props to him, he kept us from falling apart all the way here.

I ask, when you say he got you stuff. Was it like normal supplies and stuff. Betty answers, oh yeah. We wanted a board game to pass the time and he got it in the next few hours. And this was when we were in a plane. The guy was truly a magician. Jenna says, you should have seen it Marina. I somehow got a spa massage when we were on road, travelling in what I think was a transportation truck. Marina yells, the freak. A massage as you being smuggled out of Citradel and into our city. Frank says, all while being incognito from the humans. Who the hell did David hire to for this.

It really sounds ludicrous. Lionel says, the travel was cramped and at times uncomfortable, but I can't complain about the impressive treatment we got. Betty, it certainly helped the arduous journey. Jenna says, we talked a lot about it. We complained at times, but we were risking a lot leaving Citradel. Marina smiles suspiciously, I need to know who this magic guy is. Sounds like an interesting guy. Jenna says, not a boyfriend material for you. He might be able to tolerate you, but you aren't his type. Marina scoffs, and how would you know. He smiles, because I asked him as a joke and he said he wasn't interested in dating an alien. They both snicker enjoying the banter.

I can see now how she is so close to Marina. She gives off a elder sister vibe to Marina. Candice says, I was hoping to see David. Thank him for getting us out of Citradel. It took a turn for the worse last few days. Jenna says, he must be with those three. Blake asks, I have been meaning to ask. Where did they go. Jenna explains, unlike us, David's guy was more careful than us. Marina says, that’s understandable. This was planned for him, his wife and their son in the beginning. Candice says, they wore scarfs and masks all the way to protect their identity. Betty says, we hardly spoke to them. But the wife wasn't really too happy with their infant child.

Marina warns her friend, you sure you didn't tell anyone who they were. Jenna scoffs, please. Not my first smuggling experience. Was she being facetious or serious. I really couldn't tell. Candice says, don't worry. Only Jenna knows who they were. The guy was actually decent and seems polite. But he said he was sorry while keeping his distance from us. Just then Blake gets a call and he excuses himself for a while. Marina asks, when did they sperate from you guys. Candice says, I think when we got on the boat. Jenna says, I think it was before we got off the truck. Can't be sure about it.

I had a thought, David probably doesn't want to take any chance with them and personally escort them in. Luther says, and how exactly does he plan to cross the barrier without notifying us. Deni still hasn't heard from them. Jess says, I don't think he will ask for permission. Luther scoffs, you think he will smuggle them in undetected. She stares at me for a second, I don't know. Maybe. But I have a feeling he has many tricks up his sleeve. Oh damn, she still has suspicions about David being a Shadow. I gave her my best confused poker face to avoid giving her any answer. She then gives a similar look to Marina. She gave a much more convincing expression that she doesn't know anything about that.

Jess begins explain the plan after June brings back Sam. They way he was panicking could be anything, a quick making out with June or berating him for being overly friendly with me. Luther relays the same talk again to them about hiding them in the city, it's temporary. And you will be able to visit at your discretion. Jenna says, I sort of already figured we will have to remain quiet for a while. Chelsea asks, we will see you guys very soon. June says, I assume are you moving them to different place every day. Having spent a week as an officer, she had gotten a good grasp of how we do this. Jess didn't confirm nor deny it. She just smiles letting us believe whatever we want.

They all follow Jess to her jeep, while Luther and I get their additional luggage's from the boat. Blake returns after a while and asks, Marina. I need to talk to you for a moment. Marina nods and waves bye to Jenna, what's up. I listen in, but they went to talk separately. Once others leave, I mention June to wait for a moment while Blake and Marina finish their talk. I didn't think it was any serious because Marina was laughing, but also being confused at times. June asks, did something happened. I shrug. After a while Marina suddenly creates a charm and takes off to the sky. But the weird thing is that she is heading out, into the ocean.

Blake approaches us, Vanessa. I need you to authorize an emergency exit protocol for Marina. I am concerned about the timing, where is she going. Blake sighs, its actually not an emergency. Its just the wife is not really cooperating and David is being cornered by her. I need Marina to help smooth things out.

David (Chapter 117)

Thursday, March 19, 2026 15:54

M says, they are two minutes out. At this distance, I could see the glimmers already. The waves rock my boat while its docked at a small collection of rocks. The same place I picked Catherine from few days ago. The speed approaches closer in the dim glow of the sun. Once they dock beside my boat, I could make out two figures in coats, one small baby and four luggage's behind them. It took a while to realize how much Jack has changed over the years. His hair was cut shorter now and I think he put on a little muscles too. He waves to me, are you sight for sore eyes man. We pat each other backs, its been a long time coming. Sorry it had to be this way in the end.

We lean away. A much warmer smiles appears on his face, shitty luck of mine. Can't catch a break. He offers his hands to his wife, who was carrying their son. They board down my boat. She removes her hoodie to reveal a blue streaked hair and few freckles on the checks. She appears completely drained of live. Carrying a baby with you in cramped spaces will do it that to you. But I saw her glimmers more flickering and greenish. She is being anxious and might have doubts about this. That's is to be expected. Jack introduces her, meet Alishia, the love of my life. And that bundle of joys is Kelton.

I bring out a bring smile looking at the sleeping baby in Alishia's arms. I turn to her, I am so glad to meet you. She gives me a very subtle nod while gripping her son a little closer to her chest. Is it just me or she is being weird. I chalk it up to the stress and the arduous journey. And besides, I think meeting me is making her even tense about it. I turn to Jack who felt the awkwardness. He licks his tongue, she is just tired. We all are. I can only imagine that. I go over their boat to fetch their bags. Jack asks me, let me give you a hand. I stop him, I got this.

I raise my hands and throw out my Kuret like giant claws. I didn't want to flaunt my prowess to them at the get go. But I figured they be less tense if they saw I am capable. Plus, it was a good test to see using my Kuret on something other than just weights. I grabbed the four bags with my Kuret and hurl them into my boat. It wasn't very graceful, but put every effort to not break any fragile item in their luggage's. I think I even felt the physical strain on my arms, even though it was supposed to be just a psychic connection to the meta physical Kuret. Guess I still have a long way to go for anything beyond carefully handled weights at the gym.

Jack says, impressive. It wasn't a fluke you won the tournament. I laugh as I start our boat back up. I instruct M to take the other boat into the underground cave. Alisha and Kelton took the bench at the back while Jack and I spoke at the wheel. I ask him, are they okay. He says, they will be fine. Four days stuck with strangers, who I can't reveal much about us. It wasn't really comfortable. I apologies to him about the extra people, this is wasn't the original plan. But I had to help out the warriors who joined us. He replies, it was a shock. Not going to lie. But Jenna explained to me it why it was important. And after spending enough time with them, I understood.

He told me how they kept their faces and identified a secret. No one knows him personally, but he didn't want to take any chance. Then he asks, I have been meaning to ask you for a long time. Where did you disappear. You were missing for almost a year after the valley. Next thing I heard you were fighting in war with Hive. I told him a shortened version. I didn't have the time nor the temperament to explain that I lost my earth memories. So I told him what I told most people. I was gravely injured and in a coma for months. Which wasn't technically a lie, but I was in one only for few weeks.

He says, I heard you died at the time. Never thought it was a something as base as a human coma. shitty luck man. I tell you, we both are got the raw end of it. I chuckle, but you found a family though. Can't be all that bad. He gives a weak smile while turning back to his family, that’s true. He then leans in, just between us. I wasn't looking forward to getting married, let alone a kid. I say, says every guy ever. He shakes his head, no. I am being serious. Between getting my revenge and spying, I always left it wasn't in the cards for me. I ask, what changed then.

His smile begins bigger, Alishia. Before I knew it, I was madly in love her. I knew she was the one for me. I turn back to check on those two. Somehow they were asleep. I ask, what does she know about you. His smile drops and becomes a little sad, you mean what I told about you. I nod, and why you had a league with me in the first place. He takes brief pause to think about his words. He reveals, I made a mistake and she found about some intel I was gathering. And we almost broke up back then. I am a little shocked to learn he got caught and kept it quiet about it all this time. Then I settle my confusion realizing she is here with him now, so they had to patch things up.

But could it be because of their son, did she get pregnant that time? He scoffs, if that happened then, trust me, we would be in a completely different situation. So it happened before they even got married. He says, she found about me few weeks after your civil war with Nathan. I was much more clueless on covering my tracks intel back then. Alishia was a clerk at the councils office were I was poking around. We hit off from there. Though I think she always suspects I was using her to get info out of the council. It made sense she believe that. I ask him, and did you.

He gave a suspicious answer, yes and no. I did peek at her work, but stopped when things got serious. But don't tell her that. I assure him, I got you. I am assuming she understood and maybe even forgave you. He snickers, understood, yes. Forgive, I don't think she will ever. I was deliberating a lot to tell her. But if I wanted her back, I had to reveal I was there for my brother and how keeping my end of the deal to get justice for him. This was the first time I heard him tell me the reason why he out for revenge. He gets curious a bit, I think I never told you this before.

I answer, not you didn't. I never realized you had a brother. He becomes upset rehashing something so painful, it happened when we both were in Valley. Way before you stirred up shit back then. My brother got wind of those experiments with human children and he got caught. Nathan ordered him to be imprisoned, but our stupid alpha forgot the give the medication to my brother. He had Asma and died in the prison. Pain and sorrow drenched on his face, in star contrast when he spoke about his wife and son. I console him, my condolence. I may have not known your brother, but it seemed he wanted to do the right thing unlike others. He nods appreciating my words.

He says, he was kinder person than me, that’s for sure. But the freaked up part is I didn't even know he died in the prison. That freaker, Lorance told me he gave a long mission to my brother, which I was gullible to believe. I only found out when you broke out from the prison and I saw his rusted stuff and a note left carving on the wall left before he died. I confronted Lorance, I even tried to kill him. But with Nathan backing him up, I wasn't ever going to get a chance. He then looks at me hope, I sought you out soon after that. You know the rest.

I imagined it was very personal and something like this. That’s why he was desperate for a way to get back at them. But it was my turn to be upset, I had a chance to kill Nathan and his sorry ass group of cohorts. But I couldn't do it. You have no idea how much I wanted, but in the end Jess and Freya were begging for me to spare him. I am sorry I couldn't keep up my bargain. He says in a grim voice, when I heard you spared them. I was furious. I waited for you to finish them, but I heard you disappeared. But you had foiled their operations and control. I even thought of doing it myself.

I ask, why didn't you. Lorance no longer had any backing anymore. He smiles, what do you think. I met Alisha when I snooping around info about Lorance. She didn't know it yet, but she saved me a life of misery. I felt like I had found a better purpose in my life. Eventually I gave up looking for revenge. So you don't have to apologies to me. In hindsight, it was probably for the best. Killing them won't bring back the people we lost. Didn't you also stop because you found something else to strive for. I was going slowly insane by talking to an imaginary Liz. So yeah, once I found some clarity, I did settle for hope rather than unnecessary killing.

He took my quiet as understanding, that being said. I rather not see Nathan or Lorance ever. I smile, you won't have to. Nathan is on a tight leash. He makes one wrong move and he knows I am going to kill him. And Lorance is no longer an alpha. In fact, apart from few people, we have stripped off their alphas to others. He eyes seems brighter hearing their situations, Lorance is no longer an alpha huh. Guess that answers why he didn't participate in the tournament. Must be pretty miserable not having that power anymore. That actually make me happy. He then laughs, but oh man. You have changed a lot. I cannot believe how casual you are about threatening a royal alpha. I remember you struggled against Jess that one time. You have only gotten a lot crazier since then.

I answer, a lot as changed since you saw me all those years ago. Blake is a terra and we got more overdrive users than ever. And so have you. When I met you, we were brought together with pain and suffering. And owing others who wronged us. I can't believe the guy, who only ever cared was to throw Lorance into meat grinder, fell in love with a women while on the said mission. He laughs, there are shitty luck. And then there is the stroke of luck never known. He then gets a little distracted, but there was a time when I thought we were done. When I told her the truth about everything. It took a while, but we made it work.

He shakes his head, and then she got pregnant. It was the best day of my life. Knowing I will be a father soon, I should have stopped the dangerous stuff like spying. It was difficult to decide since I didn't want to dishonor our deal. It was the second time in our life that we were close to giving up on us. I grab his shoulder, and you thank you for sticking with me. I can't imagine that was easy. It is surprising that she let you continuing sending me intel. He gives smirk, love man. It makes you do crazy things, even if the other person does things that questions you about everything. He didn't need to explain further. I have been lately aware of that more than ever.

I ask, how did she take it when you told about leaving Citradel. He turns a little anxious, you won't believe this. But she was the one who asked me to leave. That was a surprise since I have been believing he had been the one to convince her. He explains how she had access to councils work orders before anyone. Before the tournaments final, it was all business as usual. That changed with Heraknus reveals and their departure. She saw documents suggesting they were looking ways to replace Heraknus military power. That in it self wasn't a problem, but she saw others plans for seizing power. Like stealing weapons and research from humans.

I actually didn't think it was a bad plan. But it seems Alishia was not okay depending on humans and inviting unwanted troubles that comes from it. I can't really deny that problem since I dealt something like that with the people I deal with on regular basis. But since then, the doubts been spreading for a while. And it became a legitimate concern after the riots. When Jack found about it, she jumped at the chance to leave Citadel, thinking it wasn't a safe place to raise a child. Again, can't argue on that. Jack is grateful that she understood it was right time to jump ships.

I asked about Selena and what's her motives. He says, I personally thought she was about inspiring people. I don't know how serious is she about Blake and Marina, behaving as if they were god send. Though, I met plenty people who accepted it completely. And Alishia herself is follower of one of the religion the priest is leading. But instigating riots is a line even she doesn't believe in. I asked him about the conditions and the reasons it happened. He explains how he has collected all the communique around the church and council. He didn't have the time to figure out what happened and was more focused on covering their escape.

Thankfully he has all the data in a disk. He turns anxious, I made a promise to Alishia that I will hand it over only when we step into our new lives. I ask, leverage, huh. Even after I got all of you out of there. He gulps a little after a tense moment. I nod after giving it some though, clever girl. You are lucky to have her. He sighs a little, don't I know. I was actually very interested on what happened in Citradel. Because whatever happened, in the end it worked out in our favor. More than me, Blake and Luther are very concerned and they are in the correct position to figure out this mess. That intel is vital. Which he plans to hand over once they are satisfied about their new life.

Soon we reach near the barrier and I turn off the engine. Jack wakes up Alishia and I explained to them about this secret passage way. Immediately Alishia yells, no way in hell I am letting go of my son. She was so exhausted I saw orange glimmers from her. Now slowly turning into a hue to red, anger. I try to convince her, I am not asking you to. He will be perfectly safe with me. But she wasn't having any of it, no. I didn't travel with goats for me to let of him now. Doesn't matter how many ridiculous things like barbers or masseuse you give us. I honestly had no idea what she meant by that. Did that strange guy with the moniker magic really giving a royal treatment.

I shake off the thoughts about him, I promise you. He will be fine. I can be trusted. Jack agrees with me, Lis, we have trusted him this much already. Why not a trust him little bit more. She gives Jack an honest to god death stare with unblinking wide eyes, how can I trust him. He used you for his crazy revenge against the royal alpha. I don't care if he is strong. I won't trust anyone who manipulate others and gets away with murders. I am so lost how distrustful she is with me. With confusion, I face Jack, who just gives me an apologetic expression in return. I realize she has bought into Ryes nonsense. Jack would know the truth about Nathan, but not about other things.

It crossed my mind that things in Citradel wouldn't be like here. While I am rivered here, I most definitely am painted in a different picture there. I should confirm this before I continue on. With a condescending tone I ask, tell me this. Do you believe I cheated during the tournament, and even tried to poison Marina. She faces me back with anxious look. She tried to look tough for others sake, but her glimmer now has a shade of yellow, fear. She remains quiet, but I got the answer I needed by her glimmers. Jack was terrified of the situation too. He says, of course we don't think that’s true. Tell him Lis.

I make my stance rigid, well, what do you think of me. She speaks up in a soft voice now that I was intimidating her directly, I don't know. People tell you cheated. I ask, I don't care about others. I want you to tell me what you think. That got her more scared. She even clutches her son more tightly. Jack gets a little bit defensive now, lets not make this a thing. There are lots of different rumors going around. You are stealing from Citradel. So people aren't happy about it. I tell him, well I am not happy Ryes dig up private things about me and twisted them to fit into his own agenda of slandering me. So I like to know much of a liability I have become.

That made Jack even more tense. I am sure that my interview was seen by everyone in Citradel. I take a little offense that even after deriding myself, lying about everything, people still don't believe me. Alishia tried to show some resolve, you want the intel Jack has right. If that's gets us a safer place for Kelton, that's all I care about. Doesn't matter what is truth about you. I have witnessing the first hand brainwashing of the people of Citradel. I wasn't expecting to get a chance to see it for myself. But its fascinating to know how she really feels about me. Unlike Jack, who she loves and trust, she doesn't have the same faith as him. So there are more like her in Citradel.

Even when I am intimidating her on purpose, she doesn't crack and stays true to Kafar's or someone else's agenda. I didn't think two weeks of rumors and secret ploys were this effective on Citradel. Goes to show how lucky I was here. Especially with people like Cranston. While Jack tried to convince her I thought of a different approach. She says, I don't understand how you can trust him with our son. You are not his friend, only an asset. She isn't wrong. Ours has always been a professional relationship. Jack gives a suggestion, can you let us in with blindfolds instead.

Before I could open my mouth, Alishia says, no way. We snuck out Citradel like thief's, I won't do it again. Not when you and Kelton are my only concern. Aside from her obvious distrust, its admirable how much she loves them. I think its more or less because of the long journey she had to endure. Exhausted and on the run from Citradel with strangers. Anyone would be cranky. Though she has her own issues also. Anyways, I can't complain since I didn't know Jack had a family to begin with. What should I do now. I look around the empty ocean. She immediately yells, we are not going back. We have no where to go.

I tell her, calm down. No is making you go away. I just turn my back to them and gaze towards the island. Then I had an idea. I ask, since you don't trust me. What if can get someone you do trust. Jack asks, who? And we are in the middle of the ocean. I face them back, don't worry about that. Alishia asks confused, what are you talking about. I fish my phone from my pocket, if I get Blake here, would you trust him instead to take your son inside through the barrier while I bring you inside myself. They turn to each other with confusion. She asks, by Blake you mean the prince. I nod, and the leader of this island. A Shadow. And not to forget a terra. You think you can trust someone chosen by Kuret itself.

That got her thinking hard. They whispers somethings and then after a while she says meekly, maybe. Though she still held a lot of doubt. Actually I had another person in mind. Someone far more trustworthy to them. I just named Blake to see how she perceived him. I ask, what's wrong. You don't trust him because I am his friend. That seems a little unfair. Her eyes gives off a lot of anger, but she couldn't really say her feelings aloud. I wonder to what extend her distrust goes. Is to me or just people around me. I ask, what about Vanessa. You must have heard her. How she fought against Hive for years.

That got the ball rolling, I know her. She was the one who lost to Marina, didn't she. I nod, she is leading the security of this island. I can get her instead in case you don't think Blake is not good enough. She says in disbelieve, you know her. I laugh at her oblivious attitude. Though I understand it might not be a common knowledge as others. Even Jack apparently didn't know, wait. That Vanessa, the omega. You are friends with her. Actually, I am more than that. But I if talk about our convoluted shared history, we be stuck in the ocean for days. For the time being I explain, she is one my closest confidants.

Well, just today we might have patched things up again. But they didn't know that. Alishia didn't believe me though, why would she associate with you. Because of you people died at that warehouse. I know that she has been furious with you for years about that. That bit of information told me everything about the slanders and public misinformation spreading. Even Jack, who probably didn't think that was true, is still puzzled by this. So I have been surgically isolated from the rest of the people. Making them believe I don't have close connection to other influential people.

I begin to smirk thinking how ridiculous that effort was. Soon they are going to join us and know what kind of lies they have been told. But its very suspicious that they go this far, even after knowing they are loosing this struggle. Jack asks, what's so damn funny. I shake my head, nothing. I was just thinking what Catherine, June or Derek would say about it. I mean they all believe I am being framed by Ryes. That's just sad. As soon as I said those big names their attitude becomes tense. Alishia asks, lies . They are all omega's who are being tricked by you. They wouldn't stand for any injustice when they uncover of the real truth. They are just tolerating you for now.

Hot damn. Now we are really digging deep. The way she just quoted injustice meant she thinks of them as righteous and I was the preverbal snake in the garden guy. Oh man, Nathan is going to love this. So the narrative is being stretched out like I am the lesser devil that people have to deal with. I wonder if church is also involved somehow in this. So far I haven't heard what they preached about me. They definitely had some opinions of me. Maybe that intel holds that particular answer. Jack realizes how Alishia is making things worse, stop this Lis. We don't know the whole story. But she remains adamant, I don't need to know everything. I know enough.

What a pain. I doubt she would believe anything short of a Ryes confessing that he lied. This is turning out to be bigger problem than I anticipated. Its something I need to deal with before people arrive. For the time being I got what I needed, I am glad we talked. I have a good grasp on how I am seen in Citradel right now. I used a more calmer voice now. They both are bewildered how nonchalant I was. I wave my hand to her, don't worry. I don't hold any grudge against you. I mean, if I was living in a Citradel and I heard so many things about me. I would believe it too. Jack asks, ah, you aren't mad.

I chuckle, nope. Actually, I am surprised you found a wife is so brave. I am being a little facetious about how naïve she is being. Alishia was stunned by her sudden compliment, even thought she hurled only slanders at me. I explain, its obvious she cares about you and your son. And that's what's more important. Doesn't matter what you think of others, good or bad. You need to be all kinds of things to survive from now on. Stubbornness can be a very good thing when its for the right reasons. I can't be mad at her for believing what powerful people say. That's just normal crowd mentality. She is speechless, but her glimmers show she is less scared now.

I pull out my phone and dial in Blakes number. Once it connects I ask, Blake. Did I catch you at a wrong time. He says, ah, I just met with the rest of the people at the beach in section 2. Where are you calling from. I never seen this type of alert call before. Its not a priority alert message. I tell him, you remember the software patch I had installed in your phone. Well, among many things, it lets you connect from outside the barrier. He scoffs, what. Are you kidding me. Is this even safe to use. I assure him, don't panic. With the amount of encryption, overlays and around the world signal hops this connection has, only god can figure out where you are.

I exaggerate a little. Of course If you have a cutting edge, state of the art tracing equipment's, one can triangulate the location. Too bad I own most of them myself. And the ones I don't, they have to know my cell number first. Which changes every week. Blake takes a pause, well, I know you won't compromise the safety of the island. So this better be important. I say, it is. We hit a little snag. Turns out my friends wife is not really a fan of mine. Doesn't trust me enough. She gives me a hard look when I say that in front of her. Blake says, that's what we were concerned about people from Citradel. Isn't it.

I tell, I will tell you about that later. First, you should talk to her directly. She needs a little bit encouragement that she can trust us. You know who best fits this particular job for recent Citradel escapee's with trust issues. It didn't take much long to figure out what I meant, I see. Fortunately, she is right here with me. Let me talk to the wife then. I held my phone to her. She becomes anxious and panics at Jack. I tell, its for you. He wants to welcome you and regrets couldn't come himself. I add in a little white lie to help her along. Jack encourages her, its fine. I got Kelton. After giving me her classic death stare, she hands over the baby to him.

With a hesitant expression, she grabs the phone from my hand. He meekly says, hello. I decide to give them some space while I talk to M, I need to run another behavioral prediction algorithm. M asks, what are the parameters. I explain, there is a dataset of highly unstandardized data between two major institutions. I need you to create search protocols. First, about anything related to me or Ryes. Then use them to create the model. I need to know how much damage I am looking at. M asks, please clarify the required analysis, boss. I was not happy about detailing negative things about me. But I had to remain objective here.

I gave M all the specific answers I needed before Citradel moved here. After some time, Alisha approaches me. Her worries were not yet gone. But her white glimmer were much more now. So she is at least less worried now. She hands me her phone and walks away without saying anything. I put it against my ear, so how did it go. He sighs, she is one tough lady. Wouldn't budge no matter how I explain things like misinformation and propaganda. Had your friend also bought into all this bullshit. I honestly can't say for sure. I tell, maybe not like her. But its hard for him to side against his own wife on this. Blake says, that is a mess, but obvious I suppose.

He clears his thought, anyways. I told her I am going to send Marina. I assume you can help get her come to you. Because I don't want to issue a boat. Just sending her in and out inconspicuously is pushing it. I says, I already sent out an ART boat she can use. Just tell her to fly about 8 miles in northwest from your beach. The boat will be glowing with lights to mark it. And it won't appear in the border sensors. Blake replies, okay. I am going to ignore your blatant breach in our security. I laugh as he hangs up. I turn to others who were still nervous. Alishia is in state of panic, talking to Jack in hushed tones. I continue to give them their privacy.

We waited for another 20 minutes until I saw the same boat that dropped off them approaching from a different direction. They both hustle up to get ready. They both wore their face masks and Alishia added a scarf wrapped around herself. Soon Marina joins us, hey guys welcome to the island. They both nervously shook hands with a cheerful Marina. She turns to me, I heard you are giving them trouble. Is that true. I think she is trying to get on their good sides. But I wasn't going to let her dictate unilaterally, you know me, a troublemaker. Unlike you. I flash her a smile that made her even more relish in her fake glory.

She turns to others, don't worry. With me around, he can't cause any trouble. The nerve of her, and yet I could only smile at her. I need to keep her in line and not get carried away, 11th birthday. The courtyard. And what was the poor guys name. hmm. That made her turn her smile into a scowl, give it a rest will you. Forget about that. I was a only a kid back then. I shrug, and what a mischievous one at that. Do you want me to tell you what your Istra thought of it when she told me. She clenches her jaws, damn you mom, telling unnecessary things to other. Now it was my time to enjoy in her misery.

Jack and Alishia were gawking at us so confused. They obviously didn't know we both were childhood friends. Now that they have seen a hint of our true dynamics, I ask, Marina, she actually believes I poisoned you. What do you think about that. Marina shakes off her frustration and faces them, don't tell me you got sucked into the nonsense from Ryes. Or was that from Kafar. Argh. Jenna was just telling me what a mess Citradel is in. Alisha is a daze, perhaps stunned by being near Marina. Jack speaks up, ah. Sorry. But you too seem awfully close. Do you two know each other on Medrine.

Marina gives a wicked smile, know him? She then faces me, I was his first crush. I made a loud tongue click, you actually believe that, don't you. She says, I know it. I was in Shadows, and practically an alpha. I had guys crushing on me all over the university. I scoff realizing she is juxtaposing herself with Zakerine. I didn't like that how eerily close they were with their Kuret hierarchy and similar inclinations towards secrete organization. I wonder what would have happened if they had ever met together. I can't even imagine that dangerous fantasy. Marina laughs, anyways. Trust me, David is the last person that will hurt me.

Alishia blurts, but you are being tricked by him. Marina's smiles disappear, please. I am easily tricked in things like this. Who told you that anyways. We wait for Alishia to explain, but she remained speechless. Jack says, its what the council and Ryes are telling. Marina shakes her head, I thought they be smarter than this. She turns to me, any idea why they continue to spread lies? Aren't they soon going to move here. She had the same questions I have. I tell her, don't know it yet. Its hardly enough of a reason to stop people from leaving Citradel. Even if they don't believe me, they have to know there are more than enough trustworthy people here.

She says, like me. Right, that's why I am here. I nod while eyeing Alishia. Lets see if her perception changes in any way after seeing the warrior she has known for almost a decade. All I see are more pink and brown glimmers. So she is only surprised, but not necessarily cleared from suspicion. It isn't possible to see things differently just in a short time. She says, see. This is how he really is. You think he is stupid enough to make enemies of us. She is getting a little defense of me. While I appreciate the frustration she shows for me, I can't let them trust her less for now. I gesture Marina with my hands in Shadow language, this should be enough. She get the message and calms down.

After a pause she says, well, regardless. I am here, so what I can do to help. She waited for them to speak up. They turn to me, but I also remained quiet. If they going to ask something, they should do it themselves. Jack speaks up, right. So, she, has some doubts. He gets pocked lightly by Alishia's elbow to his guts, I mean we both have concern about our child's safety. Alishia pulls out the blanket over their baby. Marina gleams with joy, look at those chubby cheeks. I just want to bite them. She leans forward to see Kelton more closely, look at those eyelashes, she is beautiful. I realize what she is doing.

I laugh, yeah well, once he grows up, people can tell how Marina called him that. Marina acts nervous, oh shit. Sorry. I mean your son is very cute. Jack chuckles, thanks. Hold on, you didn't know about him. Jenna didn't tell you about us. Marina acts a little bit frustrated, I heard she promised to keep your identities a secret. Even from me. That really irks me out. Alishia asks, but she got a message from you. Marina points to me, that was from him. I just passed the message to Jenna. Aren't you guys keeping your identities hidden because you don't know whom to trust. That seems a little excessive. Though I now understand a little better after seeing the baby boy.

That changed their glimmers to more whites. Marina's white lie is working. She already knows who they were. This is charade to let them keep their secret and feel more trustworthy towards her. Like Marina said, they weren't sure of anything and took precautions regardless. I don't know if they really bought this or not, but at least they want to trust Marina. She then faces me, I can't believe you won't even trust them to keep the route a secret.

Didn't they know the escape route from Citradel. This isn't any different.

I smile, nice try. You just want to about the way yourself. That got her tongue and mumbles, jerk. I tell her, the difference is that I am still living here. I can't burn this route like we did for Citradel. She knows that, but she has been obstinately asking about it for a while now. She sighs, at least tell me how you guys escaped. You had others in a blindfold for majority of the escape, so they don't know. Jack turns his head to me. I nod and gesture him its fine. He says, in the south downtown of Yukon, there is a deli shop. It had a entrance to an underground defunct train tunnel. In about 4 miles, it opens near to the great bear lake. We took a boat to the other side and met a guy called magic, said he was coordinating our escape.

Marina thinks about this for a moment. Then she shakes her head, no way. I know the layout of Citradel in my sleep. Yokan had a very old tunnel system that got scrapped in the 19 hundreds. Sure, the tunnels are big enough for people to move around. But there are no tunnel running under south downtown. Alishia says, I thought too. But we came from there. Marina says, I wouldn't make a mistake to not map that entrance. She waits for me to explain, but I just gave her a smile, letting her come to the conclusion herself. She gasps a little, bloody shit. How did the tunnel seem? Was it rusted and chipped off. Alishia says, yeah. It was very old.

Jack says, but I remember something odd. I saw some new wirings up in the ceiling in the beginnings, which wasn't there after a while. Marina scoffs at me, you freaker. You dug the tunnel yourself. Didn't you. You constructed a new tunnel that connects to the old one. She has glimmers of maroon now. Equal parts impressed and annoyed. I tell her, guilty. The only way you can get into and out of a very secure place is not you use existing routes, but to create one. I was fortunate enough to find the smallest route, roughly 400 meters, to connect to the nearest tunnel. I got very lucky when found the route.

Marina clicks her tongue frustrated, how in the hell did you build one. And how did know one heard when such a massive tunnel was being dug underneath Citradel. I could tell her that this project took nearly an year to complete. I got a construction crew working on it just before the valley war. I had the crew enter Citradel as human city water level inspectors and map out the entire grid. Later, they would enter the tunnels at night and worked on digging it silently and very slowly. Since it had to be in secret, it was stretched to months. I had initially done this for myself, in case I ever needed to use it.

Since tournament ended in pretty much our win, that secret tunnel is not longer needed. I should feel bad for wasting a quarter million on that. But at least I got some use of it in the end. I couldn't see the two people's expression, but their glimmers showed trepidation. They realize their city architect had no idea of this route. It did felt a little good. I signal to her, this evens us for the tunnels you build secretly in our Island. She begins to laugh knowing she couldn't complain more. I think Alishia wouldn't feel comfortable around me anymore. But I setup the conversation making seem like Marina didn't know everything about me. So in turn, Alishia can trust her.

This gives her the courage to ask, Blake told you are willing to take to our son. She nods, If you guys allow it. I will bring him to you after we get him our routine medical protocols. That was news to me. Blake must told her to do that since Kelton isn't brought in normally. Marina explains to them about the mandatory shots, the one which I credited to Nathan in my interview. I don't think they would even believe if it was my team who found that vulnerability and synthesized a practical version for newborns as well. Alishia didn't like the idea of giving her son something weird. Marina made a compromise, they can come to the hospital and meet with the doctors administering the vaccines.

Jack asks, won't people asks questions why we came so late for Kelton shot. He is 15 months old. I explain, actually, it works in your favor. I lot of people after my interview are getting their kids vaccinated. Like you, not many trusted it before. But now, a lot of them don't want to take any chance. You can make up any story you want. Marina says, just say you guys are finally ready. That's what I hear many people giving as reason. Marina convinced them it was for Kelton's sake. Alishia took a lot of time to agree. They finally gave in after Marina gave another compromise, a charm over Kelton in which no one can touch her. Only Marina and blood relatives can touch Kelton.

It was a clever idea that gave her enough trust. Once she prepared the charm on Kelton, she tested it with us. Jack and Alishia could grab Kelton without any problem. But when I tried to, it zapped me. Actually, I can still cut through her charm with my Kuret, but that would be counter productive with Alishia here. She didn't realize that I can that that, so its better to not say. With a lot of negotiation, Marina grabs Kelton. Alishia kisses on Kelton head, mum and dad is going to be with you soon. So don't worry. Jack says, if he wakes up, just give him this. He hands Marina a small cube shaped Kuret toy, he loves this.

Marina carries the baby to her boat, he is in good hands. I will see you soon. And then her boats leaves towards the barrier. Even I think it's a bit extreme to do all this just because I didn't want to show anyone my route. But its very important to me to have an escape route. I hope I never have to use it, but I will be more comfortable with the option. When the boat disappears into the night, I give out instructions to M for the passage protocol. They both at my request wrap their bags with the plastic I provided.

Jack approaches me sidebar from Alishia, David. Thanks for listening to Alishia. I should have tried more to convince her. I reply, its all good. Like I said, she is fiercely loves you both. She didn't give in despite knowing who I am. That's admirable. He smiles, I continue to be amazed by her. He then peeks suspiciously to his back, checking out Alishia. Then raises his hand to me inconspicuously. I saw a glimmer of something small and intangible in his hand. I grab it without looking at it. It felt like a small drive. He whispers, I made a promise to Lis about the communique intel. But not about the intel on files of Citradel citizens.

I am stoked to finally get my hand on this incredible data. I hastily put away the drive in my pocket, are you sure you should be handing me something so sensitive. He replies, I am. I don't know what people say about you, what's true or not. But I believe you won't use this data for anything nefarious. And you got us out and giving us a new life here. Consider this my apology for Lis. She just doesn't know you like I do. He really is a man of his word. I had messaged him to bring all the data he could before leaving Citradel. This was the one the crucial intel that I thought he couldn't get it. I say, thanks for this. I had a thought, just out of curiosity, does it have data about Heraknus. I know you said before you didn't know about them. But you had to hack into some database to get this intel. So maybe its there now.

He laughs normally now, not worried about Lis hearing us now. He leaves without revealing anything and helps Lis finish up the preparation.